📖 Through the Bible in 12 Months

Purpose Church Sunday School Curriculum · Ages 4–17

A complete, ready-to-teach, 12-phase (12-month) Sunday school program that takes kids and teens through **all 66 books of the Bible, from Genesis to Revelation**, in the easiest words possible.

Every phase includes:

📖 **Bible in Easy Words**	Every book explained simply: what it's about, key people, key stories, and where Jesus shows up
👩‍🏫 **Teaching Instructions**	Teacher background, a 4-week plan, ready-to-read story scripts, and tips for each age group
📺 **YouTube Videos**	Weekly picks from **@SharefaithKids**, **@BibleJourneyTV** and **@bibleproject**
🎵 **Book Memory Song**	A cumulative song with hand motions so kids memorize every book in order
🔤 **Spelling & Reading**	Age-leveled spelling lists, syllable clapping, spelling bee words, and read-aloud practice
❓ **Word Trivia**	30+ questions per phase in Easy / Medium / Hard tiers, with answer keys
🎮 **Games**	Active games that drill book names, spelling and stories
🖍️ **Coloring**	Coloring page designs plus **printable** coloring sheets, tracing, word searches and flashcards
✂️ **Activities & Crafts**	Hands-on projects for each phase
💬 **Questions for Every Age**	Discussion questions for each age group, plus "Big Questions" for teens
🏅 **Review & Celebration**	Check-offs, Bible Passport stamps, badges and certificates
🏠 **Take-Home Family Page**	Verse, song, dinner-table questions and videos for home

📄 PDF Versions

Every guide in `00-start-here/` and every phase in `phases/` also has a **PDF copy right next to the `.md` file**, with the same name. Open the PDFs to read or print. To rebuild them after editing a `.md` file, run `node sunday-school-curriculum/tools/build_pdfs.js`.

🚀 Start Here

1. Read the **Program Overview** (vision, age groups, schedule, staffing).
2. Train volunteers with the **Teacher Training Guide** (how to teach each phase, run games, trivia and spelling).

3. Learn the **Books of the Bible Memory System** (all 66 books with pronunciation, syllables, spelling and memory tricks).
4. Set up your video playlists with the **YouTube Video Guide**.
5. Gather supplies with the **Supply List**, and send home the **Parent Welcome Letter**.
6. Each Sunday, plan with the **Weekly Session Template** and the month's phase guide.
7. Keep the **Game Library** handy (33 reusable games).

🗓️ The 12 Phases

Phase	Month	Title	Books	Total	Printables
1	Jan	In the Beginning	How the Bible works + Genesis	1	🖨️
2	Feb	Freedom & God's Good Rules	Exodus – Deuteronomy	5	🖨️
3	Mar	Into the Promised Land	Joshua, Judges, Ruth	8	🖨️
4	Apr	Kings & Kingdoms	1 Samuel – 2 Chronicles	14	🖨️
5	May	Coming Home & Being Brave	Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther	17	🖨️
6	Jun	Songs & Wise Words	Job – Song of Songs	22	🖨️
7	Jul	God's Big Messengers	Isaiah – Daniel	27	🖨️
8	Aug	Twelve Mighty Messengers	Hosea – Malachi	39	🖨️
9	Sep	Meet Jesus!	Matthew, Mark, Luke, John	43	🖨️
10	Oct	The Church Is Born	Acts	44	🖨️
11	Nov	Letters from Paul	Romans – Philemon	57	🖨️
12	Dec	Faith, Hope & Forever	Hebrews – Revelation + Bible Bowl & Graduation	66	🖨️

The program can start in any month. The months above assume a January start, so the graduation lands at Christmas.

👧🧒👦 Age Groups

Group	Ages	Focus
🐑 **Little Lambs**	4–6	Pictures, songs, hand motions, coloring, first letters
🧭 **Explorers**	7–10	Stories, trivia, reading and spelling the book names
🥾 **Trailblazers**	11–13	Maps, timelines, looking up verses, "why" questions
🕊️ **Ambassadors**	14–17	Big themes, apologetics, real-life application, leading younger kids

🖨️ Printables

Open **printables/index.html** in a web browser and print. Each phase has a book-name coloring page, a picture coloring page, a Little Lambs tracing sheet, a spelling practice sheet, a word search with answer key, a word scramble with answer key, and cut-out flashcards color-coded by Bible section. Also included: a **Bible Passport** and a **Graduation Certificate**.

To change words or verses, edit `printables/build_printables.py` and run:

```
python3 sunday-school-curriculum/printables/build_printables.py
```

📺 YouTube Channels

- **Sharefaith Kids**: https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids
- **Bible Journey TV**: https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV
- **BibleProject**: https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject

Always preview videos before class. See the YouTube Video Guide.

Program Overview: "Through the Bible in 12 Months"

A children's and youth Sunday school program for ages 4–17 Purpose Church Kids & Youth Ministry

1. Vision & Goals

> "Your word is a lamp for my feet, a light on my path." (Psalm 119:105, NIV)

Our goal is for every child, from age 4 to 17, to:

1. **Understand** the Bible's one big story, from Genesis to Revelation, in the simplest words possible.
2. **Memorize** all 66 books of the Bible, in order, by section.
3. **Spell and read** the name of every book (each age at its own level).
4. **Meet Jesus** on every page. The whole Bible points to Him.
5. **Love God's Word** because Sunday school is fun: games, coloring, songs, trivia, crafts and videos.

The One Big Story (teach this every phase)

The Bible is **one big story about God rescuing His people and making everything new**. We use five words, each with a hand motion, that kids repeat all year:

Word	Hand motion	Meaning
CREATION	Hands make a big circle (the world)	God made everything good.
FALL	Hands drop down fast	People chose sin and broke the world.
PROMISE	Pinky-promise with your own hands	God promised a Rescuer.
JESUS	Point to palms (nail marks)	Jesus came, died and rose again to save us.
FOREVER	Arms stretched up high	Jesus is coming back to make everything new.

2. The 12 Phases (One per Month)

The program runs 12 months. It can start in any month. If you start in January, use the "Suggested month" column.

Phase	Suggested month	Title	Books (count)	Running total	Bible section
1	January	In the Beginning	How the Bible works + Genesis (1)	1	Law
2	February	Freedom & God's Good Rules	Exodus–Deuteronomy (4)	5	Law ✅
3	March	Into the Promised Land	Joshua, Judges, Ruth (3)	8	History
4	April	Kings & Kingdoms	1 Samuel–2 Chronicles (6)	14	History
5	May	Coming Home & Being Brave	Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther (3)	17	History ✅
6	June	Songs & Wise Words	Job–Song of Songs (5)	22	Poetry & Wisdom ✅
7	July	God's Big Messengers	Isaiah–Daniel (5)	27	Major Prophets ✅
8	August	Twelve Mighty Messengers	Hosea–Malachi (12)	39	Minor Prophets ✅ **Old Testament complete!**
9	September	Meet Jesus!	Matthew, Mark, Luke, John (4)	43	Gospels ✅
10	October	The Church Is Born	Acts (1)	44	History (NT) ✅
11	November	Letters from Paul	Romans–Philemon (13)	57	Paul's Letters ✅
12	December	Faith, Hope & Forever	Hebrews–Revelation (9)	66	General Letters + Prophecy ✅ **Whole Bible!**

> **Tip:** Phase 12 lands in December in the suggested calendar, so the final "Bible Bowl" and graduation celebration can be part of your Christmas program.

3. Age Groups

Every lesson is written for one shared Bible story, taught at four levels. With a small church you can combine groups (see "Small Church Setup" below).

Group	Ages	Grades (approx.)	How they learn	What "mastery" looks like by year end
🐑 **Little Lambs**	4–6	Pre-K – K	Pictures, songs, hand motions, coloring, short stories, repeat-after-me	Sing the books song with motions; name the 10 sections; recognize the first letter of many books; tell 12 Bible stories in their own words

Group	Ages	Grades (approx.)	How they learn	What "mastery" looks like by year end
🧭 **Explorers**	7–10	1st – 4th	Stories, simple trivia, games, reading short verses, spelling	Say **and spell** all 66 books in order; find any book in their Bible; one-sentence summary of key books
🥾 **Trailblazers**	11–13	5th – 7th	"Why" questions, maps, timelines, looking up verses, teamwork	Say all 66 in order with sections; one-sentence summary of **every** book; place major people on a timeline
🕊️ **Ambassadors**	14–17	8th – 12th	Big themes, worldview and apologetics, real-life application, leading others	Everything above, plus explain how each section points to Jesus; lead a younger group's game or memory drill; give a 2-minute overview of the whole Bible

Ambassadors as helpers: Teens are invited to serve as "Junior Leaders" for one rotation (game, memory drill or craft) in a younger room at least once per month. This builds leadership and reinforces their own learning.

---

4. The Weekly Session (75 minutes)

Every Sunday follows the same rhythm, so kids know what to expect and volunteers can step in easily. A printable version is in weekly-session-template.md.

Time	Segment	What happens
0:00–0:10	🎵 **Welcome & Book Chant**	Greet kids by name, take attendance, sing the cumulative Books of the Bible song with motions
0:10–0:25	📖 **Bible Story / Lesson**	Object-lesson hook + story script (from the phase file)
0:25–0:35	📺 **Video**	One video from @SharefaithKids, @BibleJourneyTV or @bibleproject, chosen by age group
0:35–0:45	💬 **Small-Group Questions**	Age-specific discussion questions
0:45–0:55	🎮 **Game**	An active game that reinforces book names or the story
0:55–1:10	🖍️ **Activity / Coloring / Craft**	Coloring page, craft, word puzzle or trivia
1:10–1:15	✅ **Memory & Spelling Check + Prayer**	Quick check-offs, Bible Passport stickers, closing prayer

Shorter service? (45-minute version): Chant (5) → Story (10) → Video (8) → Questions (7) → Game *or* Craft (10) → Check + Prayer (5).

---

5. Monthly Rhythm (Inside Each Phase)

Week	Focus
Week 1	Introduce the phase: Big Idea, new books, new song verse, first story
Week 2	Story 2: add motions, spelling list goes home
Week 3	Story 3: trivia warm-up, spelling relay
Week 4	Story 4 + **End-of-Phase Review**: check-offs, Bible Passport stamp, phase badge
Week 5 (if the month has one)	**Review & Fun Sunday**: big review game, catch-up check-offs, celebration snack

6. Recognition System

- 🛂 **Bible Passport:** Each child gets a passport booklet (see printables). They earn a stamp or sticker for each phase completed.
- 🏅 **Phase Badges:** 12 badges, one per phase (described in each phase file). Use stickers, pins or iron-on patches on a lanyard or sash.
- ⭐ **Weekly Stars:** Stars for attendance, bringing a Bible, saying the memory verse, and spelling check-off.
- 🎓 **Year-End Graduation:** Certificates by level ("Bible Explorer," "66 Books Champion," etc.) at the Phase 12 celebration.

Fairness rule: Every child can earn every badge. Mastery is measured *against their own age level*, and teachers may adapt for learning differences. Effort counts.

7. Staffing

Role	Count	Responsibilities
Children's Ministry Director	1	Oversees program, schedules volunteers, orders supplies, communicates with parents
Lead Teacher (per room)	1 per age group	Teaches story, leads discussion
Assistant / Helper	1+ per room	Attendance, crafts, check-offs, bathroom escorts
Media Helper	1 (shared)	Queues videos, manages screens and sound
Junior Leaders (Ambassadors)	Rotating	Lead games and memory drills in younger rooms

Safety: Follow Purpose Church's child safety policy: background-checked adults, two-adult rule, check-in and check-out, allergy list posted in each room.

Small Church Setup

- **2 rooms:** Room A = Little Lambs + Explorers (ages 4–10); Room B = Trailblazers + Ambassadors (ages 11–17).
- **1 room:** Teach the story together, then split tables by age for questions and activities. Ambassadors lead the younger tables.

---

8. Recommended Bibles & Resources

Group	Recommended Bible
Little Lambs	A picture story Bible (e.g., *The Jesus Storybook Bible*, *The Beginner's Bible*) plus an NIrV for reading verses together
Explorers	NIrV (New International Reader's Version) or ICB
Trailblazers	NIV or NLT
Ambassadors	NIV, NLT, ESV or CSB, ideally a study Bible

Every phase file quotes memory verses from the NIV. Swap in your church's preferred translation if you like.

YouTube channels used all year: @SharefaithKids, @BibleJourneyTV and @bibleproject. See the YouTube Video Guide.

---

9. Folder Map

```
sunday-school-curriculum/
├── README.md                          ← start here
├── 00-start-here/
│   ├── program-overview.md            ← this file
│   ├── teacher-training-guide.md      ← how to teach, run games, trivia & spelling
│   ├── weekly-session-template.md     ← printable Sunday plan
│   ├── books-of-the-bible-memory-system.md  ← how kids memorize, spell & read all 66 books
│   ├── game-library.md                ← reusable games for any phase
│   ├── youtube-video-guide.md         ← how to use the 3 YouTube channels
│   ├── supply-list.md                 ← what to buy
│   └── parent-welcome-letter.md       ← send home on Day 1
├── phases/                            ← 12 monthly phase guides
└── printables/                        ← coloring sheets, word searches, flashcards,
passport
```

Teacher Training Guide

How to teach each phase, and how to run the games, trivia, spelling and memory work. Read this before your first Sunday. Plan on about 30 minutes, ideally with the other volunteers at a training lunch.

Part 1: Your Job in One Sentence

> **Help kids see that the Bible is one true story about God's love that leads to Jesus, and make it so fun they want to come back.**

You do not need to be a Bible scholar. Every phase file gives you background notes, a ready-to-read story script, questions and answers. Your job is to **prepare, love the kids, and keep it simple.**

Part 2: How to Prepare Each Phase (Monthly)

About two weeks before the month starts:

1. **Read the phase file** from top to bottom (about 45 minutes).
2. **Read the Bible books yourself.** At least read the passages for the four weekly stories. Bonus: watch the @bibleproject "Overview" video for each book in the phase. It is the fastest way to understand a book's big picture.
3. **Preview every video.** Use the search links in the phase file and pick the version you'll show. Write down the exact title and copy the link into your notes. Check that it fits your time slot and your kids.
4. **Make or print supplies.** Check the phase's games and crafts, and print the printables for the phase.
5. **Learn the song.** Practice the cumulative book song and motions until you can lead it without notes. Kids will copy your energy.
6. **Send the Take-Home Family Page** (the last section of every phase file) to parents in Week 1.

Each week (Saturday night or before class):

- Re-read that week's story script out loud once.
- Set up the room: chairs or carpet squares, video ready, game supplies, craft station.
- Pray for each child by name.

Part 3: How to Teach a Bible Story (Any Age)

The "HOOK → BOOK → LOOK → TOOK" method

Step	What you do	Time
HOOK	Grab attention with an object lesson, question or surprise (in every phase file)	2–3 min
BOOK	Tell the story from the Bible. **Hold your open Bible** so kids see it comes from God's Word, not a storybook you made up	8–10 min
LOOK	Look at what it means: "What does this show us about God? Where do we see Jesus?"	2–3 min
TOOK	What we "took" home: one action step for this week	1 min

Storytelling tips

- **Tell, don't read** (if you can). Learn the script well enough to look at kids' faces, and keep the open Bible in your hands.
- **Use your voice.** Whisper for secrets, go big for giants, slow down for important lines.
- **Use props.** A scarf for a robe, a flashlight for God's light, a rock for Goliath's stone.
- **Ask "What do you think happens next?"** It keeps kids leaning in.
- **Always end at Jesus.** Each phase file includes "where Jesus shows up" for every book.
- **Be truthful.** Simplify, but never change what the Bible says. If a story is hard (a flood, a battle, the cross), tell it gently and honestly, and focus on God's goodness and rescue.

Teaching by age group

Group	Do	Avoid
🐑 **Little Lambs (4–6)**	Short sentences. Repeat key lines ("God keeps His promises!"). Let them do motions and sound effects. Sit on their level. 5–7 minute story max.	Abstract words ("covenant," "redemption") without a picture. Long sitting. Scary details.
🧭 **Explorers (7–10)**	Let them read a verse aloud. Use "Who/What/Where" questions. Competition works well.	Talking down to them. Skipping the "why."
🥾 **Trailblazers (11–13)**	Give them Bibles to look things up. Use maps and timelines. Welcome hard questions.	Pat answers. Embarrassing anyone who reads slowly.
🕊️ **Ambassadors (14–17)**	Discuss, don't lecture. Connect to real life: school, friends, social media, doubt, purpose. Give them leadership.	Treating them like little kids. Ignoring doubt.

Handling hard questions

- **"I don't know, but let's find out together"** is a great answer. Write the question down and bring an answer next week.
- Point back to what we *do* know: God is good, God is loving, God keeps His promises, and Jesus is the Rescuer.

- For personal or sensitive issues (grief, abuse, family trouble), listen, comfort, and **tell the Children's Ministry Director the same day**, following church safety policy.

Part 4: How to Teach the Books of the Bible (Memory, Spelling, Reading)

The full system is in books-of-the-bible-memory-system.md. The short version:

The 5-Step Book Mastery Ladder

Every child climbs this ladder for each new book:

1. **HEAR IT:** The teacher says the book name clearly. Kids repeat it 3 times (whisper, normal, shout).
2. **SING IT:** Add it to the cumulative song with its hand motion.
3. **SEE IT:** Show the flashcard. Point to each syllable. Clap the syllables.
4. **SPELL IT:** Spell it aloud together, then alone (Explorers and up). Little Lambs name the first letter and its sound.
5. **FIND IT:** Find the book in a real Bible using the Table of Contents, then without it. Timed "Sword Drills" for older kids.

Daily memory routine (5 minutes, every Sunday)

1. **Sing** the cumulative song (all books learned so far).
2. **Section Shout:** Teacher calls a section ("LAW!"), kids shout the books in it.
3. **Missing Book:** Teacher says the list but skips one, and kids shout the missing book.
4. **Spell of the Week:** One book is spelled out loud as a group.

Spelling instruction

- **Clap the syllables:** "Deu-ter-on-o-my" = 5 claps. Spell one clap-chunk at a time.
- **Look-Say-Cover-Write-Check:** Look at the word, say it, cover it, write it, and check it. (Explorers and up.)
- **Tricky parts in a color:** Write the hard part in red: Le**v**iticus, Ecc**les**iastes, Phi**l**ippians, Thess**a**lonians.
- **Numbers:** Teach that "1 Samuel" is read "First Samuel," and the number is written as a numeral.
- **Little Lambs:** Focus on first letters and sounds ("Genesis starts with G, /g/ /g/ Genesis!"), letter tracing and finding the letter on the flashcard.

Reading instruction

- **Echo reading:** Teacher reads a line, kids echo.
- **Choral reading:** Everyone reads together.
- **Partner reading:** Older kid reads with a younger kid (great Ambassador job).
- **Never force** a struggling reader to read aloud alone. Offer "Do you want to read, or pick a friend to help?"

Part 5: How to Run Games

Full game instructions are in game-library.md, and each phase file has phase-specific games.

The Golden Rules of Games

1. **Explain in 30 seconds or less.** Demonstrate rather than describe.
2. **Everyone plays.** Avoid elimination games where kids sit out a long time. If someone is "out," give them a job (scorekeeper, judge, "question master").
3. **Learning first, winning second.** Every game must practice book names, verses or story facts.
4. **Safety:** Clear the space, no running near chairs, and soft balls only.
5. **End on a high.** Stop while kids still want more.
6. **Mixed teams.** Pair older with younger so everyone can contribute.

Teams & points

- Use the same 2–4 team names all year (e.g., Lions, Lambs, Eagles, Doves), or let kids name teams after Bible heroes.
- Keep a running **Phase Leaderboard** on a poster. Points can be traded for a team privilege (first in line for snack, choosing the game).

Part 6: How to Run Trivia

Each phase has 30+ trivia questions in three tiers.

Tier	Who	Point value
⭐ Easy	Little Lambs and Explorers	1 point
⭐⭐ Medium	Explorers and Trailblazers	2 points
⭐⭐⭐ Hard	Trailblazers and Ambassadors	3 points

Trivia formats

- **Classic Quiz Show:** Teams take turns. Teams may choose their tier, so a younger team can earn points too.
- **Buzzer Race:** Kids slap a table, ring a bell or squeeze a squeaky toy to answer.
- **Stand Up/Sit Down (True or False):** Stand for true, sit for false. Everyone plays.
- **Four Corners:** Label corners A/B/C/D, read a multiple-choice question, and kids run to their answer.
- **Trivia Ball:** Toss a beach ball with questions written on it, and the catcher answers whatever their thumb lands on.
- **Bible Bowl (Phase 12):** Year-end tournament. See Phase 12.

Tip for teachers: Read the question twice, give 10 seconds of think time, and celebrate wrong answers that show effort ("Great guess! It was actually...").

Part 7: How to Run a Spelling Bee

Use it at the end of each phase (Explorers and up) and in a big year-end bee.

1. **Word list:** From the phase's "Spelling & Reading" section. Give it to kids in Week 1.
2. **Format:** The speller stands and says the word, spells it, and says it again ("Genesis. G-E-N-E-S-I-S. Genesis.").
3. **They may ask:** for the word to be repeated, used in a sentence, or for the section it's in.
4. **Gentle rules for church:** A misspell earns a "second-chance ticket" once per bee, and spellers who are out join the "Judges' Panel" to help check spelling.
5. **Team Bee (for mixed ages):** Teams spell one letter each in a line, passing to the next person. Little Lambs can be the "first-letter starter."
6. **Prizes:** Everyone who participates earns a sticker, and the top spellers earn the phase's "Super Speller" star.

Part 8: How to Use the Videos

See the YouTube Video Guide. Key rules:

- **Always preview** the full video before class, including the end (to avoid autoplay surprises).
- **Use full screen with autoplay off.** Turn off autoplay and close comments and suggestions before class. Ads may play on YouTube. Consider downloading through an approved method or using YouTube Premium for classroom use, or show videos only after they're cued.
- **Watch with a purpose:** Give kids 1–2 "look-for" questions *before* the video ("Watch for what Moses held in his hand").
- **Pause to talk.** For BibleProject videos with younger kids, pause every 1–2 minutes and ask, "What did we just learn?"

Part 9: Classroom Management (Quick Tips)

- **Attention signal:** Teacher says "Bible!" and kids answer "Bible! Lamp unto my feet!" and freeze.
- **Clear 3 rules:** Listen when someone talks. Keep hands and feet to yourself. Be kind with words.
- **Catch kids being good:** Praise out loud, with specifics.
- **Movement every 10 minutes** for Little Lambs and Explorers (motions, stretch, "stand if...").
- **Have a "next thing" ready** for early finishers (word search, coloring, flashcards).
- **Know your kids:** Learn names in Week 1, and ask about their week.

Part 10: Volunteer Checklist

- [ ] I completed the church child-safety training and background check.
- [ ] I read the phase file for this month.
- [ ] I read the Bible passages myself.
- [ ] I previewed and queued the videos.
- [ ] I can lead the book song with motions.
- [ ] Supplies are printed and ready.
- [ ] The Take-Home Family Page went out.
- [ ] I prayed for my class.

Weekly Session Plan (Printable Template)

Copy this page for each Sunday. Fill it in from the phase file.

Date: _____ **Phase #:** ___ **Week #:** ___ **Room / Age group:** _____

Lead teacher: _____ **Helpers:** _____

Scripture: _____ **Lesson title:** _____

Key point (one sentence): _____

Memory verse: _____

⏱️ Time	Segment	My plan / notes	✅
0:00–0:10	🎵 **Welcome & Book Chant**: attendance, sing the cumulative books song with motions, Section Shout	Song verses to sing: _____	☐
0:10–0:25	📖 **Bible Story**: HOOK (object lesson) → BOOK (story script) → LOOK (what it means / Jesus) → TOOK (action step)	Object lesson supplies: _____	☐
0:25–0:35	📺 **Video**: "Look For" question first, then play, then 2 follow-up questions	Channel: _____ Title: _____ Link: _____	☐
0:35–0:45	💬 **Small-Group Questions** (from the phase file, for my age group)	Q1: _____ Q2: _____ Q3: _____	☐
0:45–0:55	🎮 **Game**	Game: _____ Supplies: _____	☐
0:55–1:10	🖍️ **Activity / Coloring / Craft / Puzzle**	Activity: _____ Early-finisher option: _____	☐
1:10–1:15	✅ **Memory & Spelling Check + Prayer**: check-offs, stickers, prayer	Spelling words: _____	☐

Before class checklist

- [ ] Room set up (chairs or carpet squares, tables, craft station)
- [ ] Video queued, autoplay off, sound tested
- [ ] Game supplies ready
- [ ] Printables copied (coloring page, puzzle, take-home page)
- [ ] Attendance sheet + allergy list posted
- [ ] Bible Passport stickers or stamps ready

After class notes

What went well: _____

What to change next time: _____

Kids who need follow-up (prayer, absent, questions): _____

Check-off progress (names):

Child	Said books	Spelled books	Memory verse	Passport stamp
	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐
	☐	☐	☐	☐

Books of the Bible Memory System

How every child memorizes, spells, reads, and finds all **66 books of the Bible** in 12 months.

1. The Big Picture: The Bible Is a Library

Teach this on Day 1 and repeat it every month:

> **The Bible is ONE book made of 66 little books, like a library on a shelf.** It has **2 big parts**: the **Old Testament** (39 books, before Jesus was born) and the **New Testament** (27 books, Jesus and His church). Trick to remember: **3 and 9 = 39. 3 × 9 = 27.** Together they make **66**!

The 10 "Shelves" (Sections) of the Bible Library

Each section has a color, which is used on the flashcards, the classroom "Bible Bookshelf" wall, and the printables.

#	Section	Books	Color	Hand sign	Kid meaning
1	**Law**	5	🟥 Red	Two flat hands like stone tablets	"God's rules and the beginning"
2	**History** (OT)	12	🟧 Orange	Point behind you ("long ago")	"What happened to God's people"
3	**Poetry & Wisdom**	5	🟨 Yellow	Hand on heart	"Songs and smart sayings"
4	**Major Prophets**	5	🟩 Green	Big megaphone hands	"God's BIG messengers (long books)"
5	**Minor Prophets**	12	🟦 Light Blue	Small megaphone (one hand)	"God's mini messengers (short books)"
6	**Gospels**	4	🟪 Purple	Arms make a cross	"Good News about Jesus"
7	**History** (NT): Acts	1	🟫 Brown	Hands blow like wind (the Holy Spirit)	"The church is born"
8	**Paul's Letters**	13	🔵 Dark Blue	Write on your palm	"Letters from Paul"
9	**General Letters**	8	⚪ Gray	Open an envelope	"Letters from other leaders"
10	**Prophecy**: Revelation	1	🟡 Gold	Crown on your head	"Jesus wins forever!"

Section count chant (clap on each number):

> "Law has **5**, History **12**, Poetry **5**, Prophets **5 and 12**! Gospels **4**, Acts is **1**, Paul wrote **13**, more letters **8**, Revelation **1**: Sixty-six and DONE!"

---

2. Master List of All 66 Books

Use this table to make flashcards, check spelling, and teach pronunciation. **Syllables** are separated with dots for clapping. The **"Phase"** column shows when each book is taught.

Old Testament (39)

#	Book	Say it	Syllables (clap)	Spell it	Section	Phase
1	Genesis	JEN-uh-sis	Gen·e·sis (3)	G-E-N-E-S-I-S	Law	1
2	Exodus	EK-suh-dus	Ex·o·dus (3)	E-X-O-D-U-S	Law	2
3	Leviticus	luh-VIT-ih-kus	Le·vit·i·cus (4)	L-E-V-I-T-I-C-U-S	Law	2
4	Numbers	NUM-burz	Num·bers (2)	N-U-M-B-E-R-S	Law	2
5	Deuteronomy	doo-tur-AH-nuh-mee	Deu·ter·on·o·my (5)	D-E-U-T-E-R-O-N-O-M-Y	Law	2
6	Joshua	JOSH-oo-uh	Josh·u·a (3)	J-O-S-H-U-A	History	3
7	Judges	JUJ-iz	Judg·es (2)	J-U-D-G-E-S	History	3
8	Ruth	ROOTH	Ruth (1)	R-U-T-H	History	3
9	1 Samuel	First SAM-yoo-ul	Sam·u·el (3)	1 S-A-M-U-E-L	History	4
10	2 Samuel	Second SAM-yoo-ul	Sam·u·el (3)	2 S-A-M-U-E-L	History	4
11	1 Kings	First KINGZ	Kings (1)	1 K-I-N-G-S	History	4
12	2 Kings	Second KINGZ	Kings (1)	2 K-I-N-G-S	History	4
13	1 Chronicles	First KRAH-nih-kulz	Chron·i·cles (3)	1 C-H-R-O-N-I-C-L-E-S	History	4
14	2 Chronicles	Second KRAH-nih-kulz	Chron·i·cles (3)	2 C-H-R-O-N-I-C-L-E-S	History	4
15	Ezra	EZ-ruh	Ez·ra (2)	E-Z-R-A	History	5
16	Nehemiah	nee-uh-MY-uh	Ne·he·mi·ah (4)	N-E-H-E-M-I-A-H	History	5
17	Esther	ES-tur	Es·ther (2)	E-S-T-H-E-R	History	5
18	Job	JOBE (rhymes with "robe")	Job (1)	J-O-B	Poetry	6
19	Psalms	SAHMZ (the P is silent!)	Psalms (1)	P-S-A-L-M-S	Poetry	6
20	Proverbs	PRAH-vurbz	Prov·erbs (2)	P-R-O-V-E-R-B-S	Poetry	6

#	Book	Say it	Syllables (clap)	Spell it	Section	Phase
21	Ecclesiastes	ih-klee-zee-AS-teez	Ec·cle·si·as·tes (5)	E-C-C-L-E-S-I-A-S-T-E-S	Poetry	6
22	Song of Songs	SONG uv SONGZ	Song of Songs (3)	S-O-N-G O-F S-O-N-G-S	Poetry	6
23	Isaiah	eye-ZAY-uh	I·sai·ah (3)	I-S-A-I-A-H	Major Prophets	7
24	Jeremiah	jair-uh-MY-uh	Jer·e·mi·ah (4)	J-E-R-E-M-I-A-H	Major Prophets	7
25	Lamentations	lam-un-TAY-shunz	Lam·en·ta·tions (4)	L-A-M-E-N-T-A-T-I-O-N-S	Major Prophets	7
26	Ezekiel	ih-ZEE-kee-ul	E·ze·ki·el (4)	E-Z-E-K-I-E-L	Major Prophets	7
27	Daniel	DAN-yul	Dan·iel (2)	D-A-N-I-E-L	Major Prophets	7
28	Hosea	ho-ZAY-uh	Ho·se·a (3)	H-O-S-E-A	Minor Prophets	8
29	Joel	JOE-ul	Jo·el (2)	J-O-E-L	Minor Prophets	8
30	Amos	AY-mus	A·mos (2)	A-M-O-S	Minor Prophets	8
31	Obadiah	oh-buh-DY-uh	O·ba·di·ah (4)	O-B-A-D-I-A-H	Minor Prophets	8
32	Jonah	JOE-nuh	Jo·nah (2)	J-O-N-A-H	Minor Prophets	8
33	Micah	MY-kuh	Mi·cah (2)	M-I-C-A-H	Minor Prophets	8
34	Nahum	NAY-hum	Na·hum (2)	N-A-H-U-M	Minor Prophets	8
35	Habakkuk	huh-BAK-uk	Ha·bak·kuk (3)	H-A-B-A-K-K-U-K	Minor Prophets	8
36	Zephaniah	zef-uh-NY-uh	Zeph·a·ni·ah (4)	Z-E-P-H-A-N-I-A-H	Minor Prophets	8
37	Haggai	HAG-eye	Hag·gai (2)	H-A-G-G-A-I	Minor Prophets	8
38	Zechariah	zek-uh-RY-uh	Zech·a·ri·ah (4)	Z-E-C-H-A-R-I-A-H	Minor Prophets	8
39	Malachi	MAL-uh-kye	Mal·a·chi (3)	M-A-L-A-C-H-I	Minor Prophets	8

New Testament (27)

#	Book	Say it	Syllables (clap)	Spell it	Section	Phase
40	Matthew	MATH-yoo	Mat·thew (2)	M-A-T-T-H-E-W	Gospels	9
41	Mark	MARK	Mark (1)	M-A-R-K	Gospels	9
42	Luke	LOOK	Luke (1)	L-U-K-E	Gospels	9
43	John	JAHN	John (1)	J-O-H-N	Gospels	9
44	Acts	AKTS	Acts (1)	A-C-T-S	History (NT)	10
45	Romans	ROE-munz	Ro·mans (2)	R-O-M-A-N-S	Paul's Letters	11
46	1 Corinthians	First kor-IN-thee-unz	Co·rin·thi·ans (4)	1 C-O-R-I-N-T-H-I-A-N-S	Paul's Letters	11
47	2 Corinthians	Second kor-IN-thee-unz	Co·rin·thi·ans (4)	2 C-O-R-I-N-T-H-I-A-N-S	Paul's Letters	11
48	Galatians	guh-LAY-shunz	Ga·la·tians (3)	G-A-L-A-T-I-A-N-S	Paul's Letters	11
49	Ephesians	ih-FEE-zhunz	E·phe·sians (3)	E-P-H-E-S-I-A-N-S	Paul's Letters	11
50	Philippians	fih-LIP-ee-unz	Phi·lip·pi·ans (4)	P-H-I-L-I-P-P-I-A-N-S	Paul's Letters	11
51	Colossians	kuh-LOSH-unz	Co·los·sians (3)	C-O-L-O-S-S-I-A-N-S	Paul's Letters	11
52	1 Thessalonians	First thess-uh-LOE-nee-unz	Thes·sa·lo·ni·ans (5)	1 T-H-E-S-S-A-L-O-N-I-A-N-S	Paul's Letters	11
53	2 Thessalonians	Second thess-uh-LOE-nee-unz	Thes·sa·lo·ni·ans (5)	2 T-H-E-S-S-A-L-O-N-I-A-N-S	Paul's Letters	11
54	1 Timothy	First TIM-uh-thee	Tim·o·thy (3)	1 T-I-M-O-T-H-Y	Paul's Letters	11
55	2 Timothy	Second TIM-uh-thee	Tim·o·thy (3)	2 T-I-M-O-T-H-Y	Paul's Letters	11
56	Titus	TY-tus	Ti·tus (2)	T-I-T-U-S	Paul's Letters	11
57	Philemon	fy-LEE-mun	Phi·le·mon (3)	P-H-I-L-E-M-O-N	Paul's Letters	11
58	Hebrews	HEE-brooz	He·brews (2)	H-E-B-R-E-W-S	General Letters	12
59	James	JAYMZ	James (1)	J-A-M-E-S	General Letters	12

#	Book	Say it	Syllables (clap)	Spell it	Section	Phase
60	1 Peter	First PEE-tur	Pe·ter (2)	1 P-E-T-E-R	General Letters	12
61	2 Peter	Second PEE-tur	Pe·ter (2)	2 P-E-T-E-R	General Letters	12
62	1 John	First JAHN	John (1)	1 J-O-H-N	General Letters	12
63	2 John	Second JAHN	John (1)	2 J-O-H-N	General Letters	12
64	3 John	Third JAHN	John (1)	3 J-O-H-N	General Letters	12
65	Jude	JOOD	Jude (1)	J-U-D-E	General Letters	12
66	Revelation	rev-uh-LAY-shun	Rev·e·la·tion (4)	R-E-V-E-L-A-T-I-O-N	Prophecy	12

> ⚠️ **Common spelling traps**
>
> - Reve**lation** has **no "s"** at the end. It is *not* "Revelations."
> - **Ps**alms has a silent **P**.
> - **Ecc**lesiastes has a double **C**.
> - Habak**k**uk has a double **K**.
> - Phi**lipp**ians has one **L** and a double **P**.
> - Thess**alon**ians has a double **S**, then **alon**.
> - Colo**ss**ians has a double **S**.
> - Deu**ter**onomy starts with "Deu," not "Du."
> - Song of Songs is also called **Song of Solomon** in some Bibles. Teach both names.

3. The Cumulative Song

Each phase file has its own song, set to a familiar tune, with hand motions. **Every phase song is already cumulative**: it reviews all the books from earlier phases and then adds the new ones. Sing the current phase's song at the start of each class. The hand motions stay the same all year, even when the tune changes, so kids keep the same motion for each book from January to December.

For a single song that covers all 66 books at once, many churches use a well-known "Books of the Bible" tune (several are free on YouTube). Search **@SharefaithKids** for "books of the Bible song," and preview it first. Use whichever version your church already knows. The phase verses still teach the motions and sections.

Section-by-section chant (no tune needed, use a steady clap)

> **LAW** (5): Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy! **HISTORY** (12): Joshua, Judges, Ruth, First and Second Samuel, First and Second Kings, First and Second Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther! **POETRY** (5): Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs! **MAJOR PROPHETS** (5): Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel! **MINOR PROPHETS** (12): Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi! **GOSPELS** (4): Matthew, Mark, Luke and John! **HISTORY** (1): Acts! **PAUL'S LETTERS** (13): Romans, First and Second Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, First and Second Thessalonians, First and Second Timothy, Titus, Philemon! **GENERAL LETTERS** (8): Hebrews, James, First and Second Peter, First, Second and Third John, Jude! **PROPHECY** (1): Revelation! **THE END, JESUS WINS!**

4. Memory Tricks & Mnemonics

Trick	Books	How it works
"Get Every Little Number Done"	Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy	First letters G-E-L-N-D
"Jesus Just Rescued"	Joshua, Judges, Ruth	J-J-R
Twins	1 & 2 Samuel, Kings, Chronicles	"Three sets of twins: Sam, King, Chronicle." Hold up 2 fingers, three times
"Every Nice Exit"	Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther	E-N-E (they all came home from exile)
"Joyful Praise Prepares Every Song"	Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs	J-P-P-E-S
"I Just Love Eating Donuts"	Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel	I-J-L-E-D
"Hosea Joel Amos, Obadiah Jonah Micah, Nahum Habakkuk Zephaniah, Haggai Zechariah Malachi"	Minor Prophets	Say them in 4 groups of 3, like a rhythm: *da-da-DA, da-da-DA*
"My Mom Likes Jesus"	Matthew, Mark, Luke, John	M-M-L-J
"Real Christians Can Go Every Place Carrying Ten Thousand Tiny Tracts To People"	Romans to Philemon	R-C-C-G-E-P-C-T-T-T-T-T-P, 13 words for 13 letters (Romans, 1 & 2 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, 1 & 2 Thessalonians, 1 & 2 Timothy, Titus, Philemon)

Trick	Books	How it works
"Gee, Eat Pie Cold"	Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians	G-E-P-C (the 4 middle letters; very popular!)
"He Just Prays, Prays; Just Just Just, Jesus Rules!"	Hebrews, James, 1–2 Peter, 1–3 John, Jude, Revelation	H-J-P-P-J-J-J-J-R

5. Classroom "Bible Bookshelf" Wall

Build a giant paper bookshelf on a wall with **10 shelves (one per section)**, each in its section color.

- Cut 66 "book spines" from colored cardstock (tall rectangles). Write one book name on each.
- When the class learns a book, a child **adds its spine to the shelf** in order.
- By December, the whole library is full: a visual celebration of the year!
- **Bonus:** Add a small picture symbol to each spine (from the phase file's "picture symbol").

6. Finding Books in a Real Bible ("Sword Drills")

> "For the word of God is alive and active. Sharper than any double-edged sword..." (Hebrews 4:12, NIV)

How to teach:

1. **Little Lambs:** Find the *middle* of the Bible (roughly Psalms). Find the *start* (Genesis) and the *big split* (Matthew).
2. **Explorers:** Use the Table of Contents, then try without it. Learn: "Old Testament is the front ¾, New Testament is the back ¼."
3. **Trailblazers & Ambassadors:** Timed Sword Drills.

Sword Drill rules:

1. "**Attention!**": Bibles closed, held at side.
2. "**Draw swords!**": Bibles held up flat, closed, hands on covers.
3. Leader calls a reference ("**Romans 8:28**") and repeats it.
4. "**CHARGE!**": Kids race to find it. First to find it **stands and reads it aloud**.
5. Points for the first three finders. Rotate so the same kid doesn't always win.

Book/chapter/verse: Teach "**John 3:16** = Book **John**, chapter **3** (the big number), verse **16** (the little number)."

7. Mastery Check-offs by Age Group

Use these at the end of each phase and in the final review. Record on the class chart and in each child's Bible Passport.

Level	🐑 Little Lambs	🧭 Explorers	🥾 Trailblazers	🕊️ Ambassadors
Say	Sing the song with the class	Say this phase's books alone	Say *all books so far* in order alone	Say all books so far in order + by section, alone, under 2 min by year end
Spell	Name the first letter of each new book	Spell this phase's books	Spell all books so far	Spell all books so far (written test)
Read	"Read" the flashcard picture and point to the word	Read the name on a flashcard	Read the book's key verse aloud	Read a passage and explain it
Find	Point to the Old or New Testament	Find the book using the Table of Contents	Find it in under 30 sec without the contents page	Win a Sword Drill round
Know	Tell one story from the phase	One-sentence summary per book	Summary + one key person per book	Explain how each book points to Jesus

8. Supporting Learners

- **Non-readers / early readers:** Use picture symbols, songs and motions, and "first-letter" spelling only.
- **Dyslexia or reading struggles:** Offer oral spelling, letter tiles or magnetic letters instead of writing, plus extra time. Never time them in front of others.
- **ADHD / high energy:** Pair memory work with movement (hopscotch spelling, toss-and-say).
- **English learners:** Pair with a buddy, use pictures, and celebrate the book names in their first language too.
- **Special needs:** Adapt the goal (e.g., recognize 5 books by picture) and celebrate progress. **Every child earns the badge for their personal best.**

Game Library: Reusable Games for Any Phase

These games work with **any phase**. Swap in that month's book names, verses, people or trivia. Each phase file also has its own story-specific games.

Key: 🐑 Little Lambs (4–6) · 🧭 Explorers (7–10) · 🥾 Trailblazers (11–13) · 🕊️ Ambassadors (14–17) · 🏃 Active · 🪑 Seated

---

A. Book-Name Memory Games

1. Bible Book Shuffle 🧭🥾🕊️ 🏃

- **Supplies:** One set of book-name flashcards per team (this phase's books, or all books so far)
- **How to play:** Shuffle each set. On "Go!" teams race to lay the cards out **in Bible order**. The first correct team wins.
- **Younger:** Use only 3–5 cards with picture symbols. **Older:** Use all books learned so far, or mix in two sets and make them separate OT from NT.
- **Learning goal:** Book order

2. Missing Book 🐑🧭🥾 🪑

- **Supplies:** Flashcards on the floor or a pocket chart
- **How to play:** Lay the cards in order. Kids close their eyes while the teacher removes one. "Open!" The first to name the missing book gets a point (or gets to be the next "remover").
- **Younger:** 3–4 cards. **Older:** Remove 2–3 at once.
- **Learning goal:** Order + recall

3. Book Hop (Hopscotch) 🐑🧭 🏃

- **Supplies:** Painter's tape squares on the floor, each with a book name
- **How to play:** Kids hop square to square, saying each book as they land. If a kid misses a book, they start again.
- **Learning goal:** Order + movement memory

4. Before & After 🧭🥾🕊️ 🪑

- **How to play:** The teacher names a book, and kids name the book **before** and **after** it. ("Ruth!" → "Judges and 1 Samuel!")
- **Learning goal:** Deep order mastery

5. Pass the Bible (Hot Potato) 🐑🧭🥾 🏃

- **Supplies:** A soft Bible-shaped pillow or ball, and music

- **How to play:** Pass the object while music plays. When the music stops, the holder says the next book in the list (or answers a trivia question).
- **Gentle version:** Nobody is out. The holder can "phone a friend."
- **Learning goal:** Recall under fun pressure

6. Section Sort (Four Corners) 🧭🥾🕊️ 🏃

- **Supplies:** Section signs taped in corners (e.g., Law / History / Poetry / Prophets)
- **How to play:** Call out a book name, and kids run to its section corner.
- **Learning goal:** Sections of the Bible

7. Book Name Bowling 🐑🧭 🏃

- **Supplies:** 10 plastic bottles labeled with book names and a soft ball
- **How to play:** Knock pins down, then say (or spell) the names on the fallen pins to score.
- **Learning goal:** Recognition + reading

8. Bible Book Line-Up 🧭🥾🕊️ 🏃

- **Supplies:** One book-name card per child (pinned to shirt or held)
- **How to play:** Without talking (gestures only!), kids line up in Bible order. Time them and try to beat the record each week.
- **Learning goal:** Order + teamwork

9. Sword Drill 🧭🥾🕊️ 🪑

- See the full rules in books-of-the-bible-memory-system.md.
- **Learning goal:** Finding books and verses quickly

B. Spelling Games

10. Spell It Out Relay 🧭🥾🕊️ 🏃

- **Supplies:** Whiteboard or paper on a wall, markers, two or more teams in lines
- **How to play:** The teacher calls a book. The first player runs and writes the **first letter**, runs back, and tags the next player, who writes the second letter, and so on. The first correct team scores.
- **Younger helpers:** Little Lambs on a team write the first letter (with help).
- **Learning goal:** Spelling

11. Letter Scramble Race 🧭🥾 🪑

- **Supplies:** Letter tiles or cut-up letter cards in envelopes (one envelope per book)
- **How to play:** Teams unscramble the letters to build the book name. The first correct team wins.
- **Learning goal:** Spelling + recognition

12. Human Spelling 🧭🥾🕊️ 🏃

- **Supplies:** Large letter cards, one per child
- **How to play:** Call a book name. The kids holding those letters run up and stand in the right order to spell it.
- **Learning goal:** Spelling + teamwork

13. Spelling Ball Toss 🧭🥾 🏃

- **Supplies:** Soft ball
- **How to play:** Kids stand in a circle. The teacher calls a book, and each catch adds one letter ("G" → toss → "E" → toss...). If someone misses a letter, restart the word.
- **Learning goal:** Spelling sequence

14. Letter Hunt 🐑 🏃

- **Supplies:** Big letter cards hidden around the room
- **How to play:** "Find the letter that starts GENESIS!" Kids hunt and bring back the G. Say the sound together.
- **Learning goal:** First letters and sounds (pre-readers)

15. Sky Writing 🐑🧭 🪑

- **How to play:** Everyone "writes" the book name in the air with a big finger while spelling it aloud. Then on a partner's back, then on their palm.
- **Learning goal:** Multisensory spelling

16. Hangman (Church Version: "Build the Ark") 🧭🥾🕊️ 🪑

- **How to play:** Classic letter guessing, but each wrong guess adds a piece to a boat drawing. Guess the book or word before the ark is finished.
- **Learning goal:** Spelling patterns

C. Trivia & Story Games

17. Bible Quiz Show 🧭🥾🕊️ 🪑

- **Supplies:** Trivia from the phase file, a bell or buzzer, a scoreboard
- **How to play:** Teams take turns choosing a tier (⭐ 1pt, ⭐⭐ 2pt, ⭐⭐⭐ 3pt). Correct answers score. Steals are allowed for half points.
- **Learning goal:** Story knowledge

18. True or False Stand-Up 🐑🧭🥾 🏃

- **How to play:** Read a statement. Kids **stand** for true and **sit** for false (or touch head / touch toes for little ones). Everyone plays every round.
- **Learning goal:** Facts

19. Who Am I? 🧭🥾🕊️ 🪑

- **How to play:** The teacher (or a kid) gives three clues about a Bible person, from hard to easy. Teams guess after each clue, and fewer clues means more points.
- **Example:** "I lived in a palace but was born a slave's son… I saw a burning bush… I led God's people out of Egypt." → **Moses**
- **Learning goal:** People of the Bible

20. Charades / Bible Pictionary 🧭🥾🕊️ 🏃

- **Supplies:** Slips with stories or people
- **How to play:** Act out or draw the story. The team guesses within 60 seconds.
- **Learning goal:** Story recall

21. Story Sequence Race 🐑🧭🥾 🪑

- **Supplies:** 4–6 picture cards (or sentence strips) of a story's events
- **How to play:** Teams put the story in order.
- **Learning goal:** Story order + retelling

22. Bible Jeopardy 🥾🕊️ 🪑

- **Supplies:** A grid on a whiteboard or slide: categories × 100–500 points
- **Categories:** "Books," "People," "Places," "Who Said It?," "Memory Verse," "Spell It"
- **Learning goal:** Mixed review (great for a Week 5 Review Sunday)

23. Bible Bingo 🐑🧭🥾 🪑

- **Supplies:** Bingo cards with book names (or picture symbols for little ones) and markers
- **How to play:** The caller reads a clue ("The book about the very beginning") and kids mark the answer.
- **Learning goal:** Matching books to summaries

24. Memory Verse Scramble 🧭🥾🕊️ 🪑

- **Supplies:** The verse written one word per card
- **How to play:** Teams race to put the verse in order, then say it together.
- **Learning goal:** Memorizing Scripture

25. Verse Pop 🐑🧭 🏃

- **Supplies:** Balloons with verse words inside on slips
- **How to play:** Pop the balloons, collect the words, and assemble the verse. (Check for latex allergies; use paper bags to "pop" instead if needed.)
- **Learning goal:** Verse memory

26. Snowball Questions 🧭🥾🕊️ 🏃

- **Supplies:** Scrap paper
- **How to play:** Kids write a question about the story, crumple it, and have a 30-second "snowball fight." Each kid picks one up and answers it.
- **Learning goal:** Kids create their own review (great for Trailblazers/Ambassadors)

D. Calm-Down Games (For End of Class)

27. Bible Book "I Spy" 🐑🧭 🪑

"I spy a book that starts with J and has a giant in it..." (1 Samuel, David & Goliath)

28. Whisper Down the Lane (Telephone) 🐑🧭🥾 🪑

Whisper the memory verse down the line, then see if it arrives correctly.

29. Thumbs Up, Bible Books 🧭🥾 🪑

Like "Heads Up, Seven Up," but the guesser must say a book name before guessing.

E. Teen Favorites (Ambassadors)

30. Bible Escape Room 🥾🕊️

Lock a box with a 3- or 4-digit combo. Clues come from Bible references (e.g., "How many books of Law?" = 5, "Chapter of the Love Chapter in 1 Corinthians" = 13). Takes 20–30 min, ideal for Week 5.

31. Speed Overview 🕊️

Each teen gets 60 seconds to explain a book (who, what, where Jesus shows up). Others vote on the clearest explanation.

32. Debate Corner 🕊️

Pose a question from the phase's "Big Questions." Two teams prepare 3 minutes and present, then the teacher summarizes the biblical answer.

33. Teach-Back 🕊️

Each teen prepares a 3-minute mini-lesson and delivers it to the Little Lambs or Explorers. This is the best way to learn!

YouTube Video Guide

Three YouTube channels are used throughout all 12 phases. Each phase file lists the videos for each week, with search terms and direct channel-search links.

Channel	Link	What it offers	Best for
📺 **Sharefaith Kids**	youtube.com/@SharefaithKids	Animated Bible stories, kids' lessons and songs	🐑 Little Lambs (4–6) and 🧭 Explorers (7–10)
📺 **Bible Journey TV**	youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV	Bible story videos that walk through the Bible narrative	🧭 Explorers (7–10) and 🥾 Trailblazers (11–13)
📺 **BibleProject**	youtube.com/@bibleproject	Animated **book overview** videos for all 66 books, plus theme videos	🥾 Trailblazers (11–13) and 🕊️ Ambassadors (14–17). Explorers can watch with pauses.

How Videos Fit Each Sunday

- **Time slot:** 10 minutes (0:25–0:35 in the weekly schedule).
- **Rotation:** Each week, each age group watches the channel that fits them best, as listed in the phase file. With combined rooms, show the younger-friendly video to everyone, and send the BibleProject video home for teens.
- **BibleProject book overviews:** BibleProject has an **"Overview"** video for every book of the Bible (longer books like Genesis, Exodus, Isaiah, Matthew, Luke and Acts are split into two parts). These are the backbone for Trailblazers and Ambassadors: show the overview in the first week a book is introduced.

How the Links Work

Video links can change, so instead of individual video links, the phase files give you **channel search links** like:

```
https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Genesis
https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Noah
https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Moses
```

Click the link to see that channel's videos on the topic, then **pick the one that best fits your class and time slot**. Write the exact title and link in your lesson notes (there's a space for this in the weekly session template).

> 💡 **Build a playlist:** At the start of each phase, the Media Helper creates a YouTube playlist (e.g., "Purpose Kids – Phase 3") with the chosen videos in order. This saves time on Sunday and gives

> parents one link to share at home.

Video Safety & Classroom Checklist

- [ ] **Preview the whole video** (including the end) before showing it.
- [ ] Turn **autoplay OFF** and hide comments and suggestions (use full screen).
- [ ] Be ready to skip ads, or queue the video past any ad before class starts.
- [ ] Check the volume and screen in the room before kids arrive.
- [ ] Give kids a **"Look For" question** before pressing play.
- [ ] Ask **2 follow-up questions** afterward (provided in every phase file).
- [ ] If a video contains anything that doesn't fit your church's teaching or your kids' ages, **skip it** and choose another.

Watching Tips by Age

Group	Tip
🐑 Little Lambs	Keep videos under 5–6 minutes. Sit close, and pause to ask "Who is that?" Do the motions during songs.
🧭 Explorers	Give them a "Look For" card with 2–3 things to spot. Pause once in the middle.
🥾 Trailblazers	Hand out a simple note sheet: *Who? What happened? What does it teach about God? Where's Jesus?*
🕊️ Ambassadors	Watch the full BibleProject overview, then discuss: *What surprised you? What's the main theme? How does this book fit the whole Bible story?*

Using the Videos at Home

Every phase's **Take-Home Family Page** lists the month's videos so families can re-watch them together. Encourage parents to watch the BibleProject overview *with* their teenager and talk about it.

Copyright Note

Show videos by streaming them from YouTube during class. Don't download, re-upload or edit them unless the creator's terms allow it. Some ministries offer church licenses or downloadable lesson packs on their own websites (Sharefaith Kids, for example, sells full curriculum materials), so check their sites for extras.

Supply List

One-Time Setup (Buy Once for the Year)

Every room

- [ ] Bibles for the age level (see program overview): at least one per child for Explorers and up
- [ ] Picture story Bible (Little Lambs)
- [ ] TV, projector or laptop with speakers, plus reliable Wi-Fi
- [ ] Whiteboard or easel pad with markers
- [ ] Pocket chart (for flashcards)
- [ ] Carpet squares or floor mats (Little Lambs and Explorers)
- [ ] Bell, buzzers or squeaky toys (trivia)
- [ ] Soft foam balls (2–3) and a beach ball
- [ ] Bean bags (4–6)
- [ ] Painter's tape (floor games; won't damage floors)
- [ ] Timer
- [ ] Bluetooth speaker for music
- [ ] Storage bins labeled by phase

Memory & recognition

- [ ] Cardstock in the 10 section colors: red, orange, yellow, green, light blue, purple, brown, dark blue, gray, gold (for flashcards and the Bible Bookshelf wall)
- [ ] Laminator + pouches (makes flashcards last all year)
- [ ] Bible Passport booklets: print from printables/bible-passport.html
- [ ] Stamp pad + stamps, or sticker sheets for passports
- [ ] 12 phase badges (stickers, pins or patches) × number of kids
- [ ] Lanyards or felt sashes to display badges (optional)
- [ ] Star stickers
- [ ] Certificate paper (for graduation)

Craft basics (restock monthly)

- [ ] Crayons, washable markers, colored pencils
- [ ] Glue sticks, white school glue
- [ ] Kid scissors (+ left-handed pairs)
- [ ] Construction paper, white printer paper, cardstock
- [ ] Paper plates, paper bags, craft sticks, cotton balls
- [ ] Pipe cleaners, pom-poms, yarn, googly eyes
- [ ] Stickers (assorted Bible or nature themes)
- [ ] Hole punch, stapler, tape

- [ ] Baby wipes and paper towels

Spelling

- [ ] Magnetic letters or letter tiles (2–3 sets)
- [ ] Small whiteboards + dry-erase markers (one per Explorer)
- [ ] Large letter cards A–Z (Human Spelling game)

Monthly Supplies

Each phase file lists exact supplies for its object lessons, games and crafts. At the start of each month:

1. Read the phase's **Weekly Lessons**, **Games** and **Activities & Crafts** sections.
2. Make a shopping list from them.
3. Print that phase's printables from `printables/phase-NN-printables.html` (open it in a browser and print).

Approximate Budget (per room, per year)

Item	Approx. cost
Bibles (10 kids)	60–150
Craft supplies	150–300
Games & equipment	50–100
Badges, stickers, passports, certificates	50–120
Snacks for celebrations	60–150
Total	**≈ 370–820**

(Costs vary. Ask the congregation to donate craft supplies and sponsor a phase.)

Parent Welcome Letter

(Copy onto church letterhead and send home on the first Sunday.)

Dear Parents and Families,

Welcome to **"Through the Bible in 12 Months,"** Purpose Church's new Sunday school program for kids and teens ages 4–17!

Over the next year, your child will travel through the **entire Bible, all 66 books, from Genesis to Revelation**, in 12 monthly "phases." Each month, they will:

- 📖 **Hear Bible stories** told in simple, clear words, always pointing to Jesus
- 🎵 **Learn a song with hand motions** that helps them memorize the books of the Bible in order
- 🔤 **Practice spelling and reading** the names of the books (each age at its own level)
- 📺 **Watch short videos** from trusted channels: Sharefaith Kids, Bible Journey TV and BibleProject
- 🎮 **Play games, color, do crafts and answer trivia**
- 💬 **Talk about real questions** about faith and life

Age Groups

Group	Ages
🐑 Little Lambs	4–6
🧭 Explorers	7–10
🥾 Trailblazers	11–13
🕊️ Ambassadors	14–17

How You Can Help at Home

1. **Read the Take-Home Family Page** we send each month. It has the memory verse, the song, dinner-table questions and the videos.
2. **Sing the books song in the car!** Kids learn fastest with repetition.
3. **Bring a Bible each Sunday** (Explorers and up). Ask us if you need one, because we have Bibles to give.
4. **Ask your child** to teach *you* what they learned.

Bible Passport & Badges

Every child gets a **Bible Passport**. They earn a stamp and a badge each month for learning that phase's books and verse, at their own age level. In December we'll celebrate with a **Bible Bowl** and **graduation ceremony**. Families are invited!

Our Year at a Glance

Month	Phase	Books
1	In the Beginning	Genesis
2	Freedom & God's Good Rules	Exodus – Deuteronomy
3	Into the Promised Land	Joshua – Ruth
4	Kings & Kingdoms	1 Samuel – 2 Chronicles
5	Coming Home & Being Brave	Ezra – Esther
6	Songs & Wise Words	Job – Song of Songs
7	God's Big Messengers	Isaiah – Daniel
8	Twelve Mighty Messengers	Hosea – Malachi
9	Meet Jesus!	Matthew – John
10	The Church Is Born	Acts
11	Letters from Paul	Romans – Philemon
12	Faith, Hope & Forever	Hebrews – Revelation

Thank you for partnering with us. We are praying for your child by name!

With joy,

Children's & Youth Ministry Director, Purpose Church

📞 _____ ✉️ _____

Please return this slip:

Child's name: _____ Age: ___ Allergies/medical notes: _____

Parent/guardian: _____ Phone: _____ Email: _____

☐ My child has their own Bible. ☐ My child needs a Bible. ☐ I'd like to volunteer (teaching, crafts, snacks, media).

Phase 1: In the Beginning

How God's Big Book works, and the first book in it, where everything starts.

At a Glance

Month	Month 1
Books covered	How the Bible works (the 66-book library) + Genesis (1 book)
Bible section(s)	Overview of the whole Bible; Law (book 1 of 5)
Big Idea	The Bible is God's one big true story in 66 books, and it starts with God making everything good and promising to fix what went wrong.
Memory Verse (all ages)	"In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth." (Genesis 1:1, NIV)
Week 1 bonus verse	"Your word is a lamp for my feet, a light on my path." (Psalm 119:105, NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"In the beginning God created." (Genesis 1:1)
Theme color	Sunrise gold and creation green
Phase symbol / badge	🌅 The **Creation Sunrise Badge**: an open Bible with a sunrise coming up out of its pages
Running total of books learned	1 of 66 (plus the shape of the whole library)

The Big Idea (in kid words)

The Bible is not just one book. It is a **library of 66 books**, and they all tell **one big true story** about God. The story starts in **Genesis**, where God made everything, and it was all *very good*. People chose to disobey God, and that broke the world. But right away God made a **promise**: He would send Someone to fix it. Then He kept His promises to Noah, Abraham, Isaac, Jacob and Joseph, and He keeps His promises to us too.

How this points to Jesus: In Genesis 3:15 God promises a child who will crush the snake's head. That child is **Jesus**. God told Abraham that "all peoples on earth will be blessed through you" (Genesis 12:3), and Jesus came from Abraham's family to bless the whole world. Abraham's son Isaac carried wood up a hill, but God gave a ram in his place. Later God gave His own Son, Jesus, as *the* Lamb. Joseph was hurt by his brothers and then saved their lives. Jesus was hurt by the people He came to save, and He forgives and saves us. The whole Bible library is about Him (Luke 24:27).

The Books in Easy Words

Before We Start: The Bible Is a Library 📚

Fact	Kid words
66 books	The Bible is like a bookshelf with 66 books on it.
2 Testaments	The **Old Testament** (39 books) was written *before* Jesus was born. The **New Testament** (27 books) was written *after* Jesus came. "Testament" means a promise or agreement.
Many writers, one Author	About 40 people wrote over about 1,500 years, but God guided all of them (2 Timothy 3:16, "God-breathed").
3 languages	Hebrew (most of the Old Testament), a little Aramaic, and Greek (the New Testament).
Chapters & verses	Big numbers are **chapters**, small numbers are **verses**. They were added hundreds of years later to help us find things. They're like the street name and house number on a map.
10 sections	Like a library has shelves for different kinds of books, the Bible has sections (see the chart below).

The 10 shelves of the Bible library (we learn all of them this year):

Shelf	# of books	Kid words	Phase(s)
Law	5	God's beginning story and His good rules	1–2
History	12	God's people in the Promised Land, kings, exile, coming home	3–5
Poetry / Wisdom	5	Songs, prayers and wise sayings	6
Major Prophets	5	Long messages from God's big messengers	7
Minor Prophets	12	Shorter messages (not less important!)	8
Gospels	4	The life of Jesus	9
History (Acts)	1	The church begins	10
Paul's Letters	13	Letters from Paul to churches and friends	11
General Letters	8	Letters from other leaders	12
Prophecy (Revelation)	1	God's forever ending	12

How to read a Bible address: `John 3:16` = book **John**, chapter **3**, verse **16**. The colon (:) means "verse." A dash means "through": `Genesis 1:1-3` = Genesis chapter 1, verses 1 through 3.

The Table of Contents trick: Every Bible has a "Contents" page near the front. It lists every book in order with a page number. If you can't find a book, flip to Contents, find the book's name, look at its page number, and turn there. *Smart Bible readers use the Contents page. It's not cheating!*

More finding tips:

- Open your Bible right in the middle and you'll usually land in **Psalms**.

- The Old Testament is the first big part (about three-quarters of the pages). The New Testament starts at **Matthew**, about three-quarters of the way in.
- Some books have numbers in front, like **1 John**. Say it "First John." It's different from **John**!
- A few books have only one chapter (Obadiah, Philemon, 2 John, 3 John, Jude), so you may see just a verse number, like "Jude 24."

Book 1: Genesis

How to say it	JEN-uh-sis
How to spell it	Gen-e-sis: **G-E-N-E-S-I-S** (3 claps)
Section	Law (book 1 of 5), Old Testament book 1 of 39, Bible book 1 of 66
Traditional author	Moses
Chapters	50
One-sentence kid summary	God made everything good, people broke it by disobeying, and God promised to fix it through one special family.
In one word	**BEGINNINGS** (the name "Genesis" means "beginning" or "origin")
Key people	God, Adam and Eve, Cain and Abel, Noah, Abraham and Sarah, Isaac and Rebekah, Jacob (Israel) and Esau, Joseph and his 11 brothers
Key stories	Creation (1–2); the first sin (3); Cain and Abel (4); Noah's ark and the rainbow (6–9); the Tower of Babel (11); God calls Abram (12); God's promise of stars (15); Isaac is born (21); Abraham and Isaac on the mountain (22); Jacob and Esau (25, 27); Jacob's ladder dream (28); Jacob wrestles God and becomes "Israel" (32); Joseph's coat and dreams (37); Joseph in prison and in the palace (39–41); Joseph forgives his brothers (45, 50)
Where Jesus shows up	The promised Snake-Crusher (3:15); the blessing to all nations through Abraham (12:3); "God himself will provide the lamb" (22:8); the ladder between heaven and earth (28:12, and Jesus says He is that ladder in John 1:51); Joseph, the rejected brother who saves his family (50:20); the King from Judah's family (49:10)
Hand motion / picture	🌅 **Sunrise hands:** start with palms together like a closed book, open them like a book, then sweep both arms up and out like the sun rising. *"In the beginning!"*

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher (plain adult language)

Week 1, the Bible as a whole. Many children (and adults!) have never been shown how a Bible is put together. They think of it as one long book, so it feels huge and confusing. Your goal this week is confidence. A 6-year-old who knows "big number = chapter, little number = verse" and that the Contents page is a friend has a skill they'll use for life. Bring **several physical Bibles** (ideally the same edition so page numbers match). If your church has pew Bibles, use those.

Key facts you should know:

- Protestant Bibles have 66 books: 39 Old Testament (OT) and 27 New Testament (NT). Catholic and Orthodox Bibles include some additional books (the Apocrypha / Deuterocanonical books). If a child has one of those Bibles, say kindly, "Your Bible has a few extra books; we'll learn the 66 that all Christians share."
- The books are grouped by *type*, not always by the order they were written. That's why the Contents page and the sections chart help.
- Chapter divisions were added around AD 1200 (credited to Stephen Langton), and verse numbers in the 1500s (Robert Estienne for the NT). They're helpful tools, not part of the original writing. That's why we read whole stories, not just single verses.
- Main idea: the Bible has many human authors but one divine Author (2 Timothy 3:16; 2 Peter 1:21), and one central storyline that leads to Jesus (Luke 24:27, 44).

Weeks 2–4, Genesis. Genesis has two big halves:

1. **Chapters 1–11, the beginnings of the world:** creation, the fall, the spread of sin (Cain, the flood, Babel). Key truth: God is the good Creator; people are made in His image; sin breaks everything; God judges sin but also shows grace (clothing Adam and Eve, saving Noah's family, the rainbow covenant).
2. **Chapters 12–50, the beginnings of God's rescue family:** Abraham, Isaac, Jacob and Joseph. God promises Abraham land, descendants and blessing, and that through his family *all nations* will be blessed (12:1–3). The rest of the Bible is the story of God keeping that promise, finally in Jesus (Galatians 3:8, 16).

Genesis ends with Jacob's family (about 70 people, Genesis 46:27) living in Egypt. That sets up Exodus next month.

Key truths to emphasize

1. **God made everything, and He made it good.** (Genesis 1:31)
2. **Every person is made in God's image**, so every person matters. (Genesis 1:27)
3. **Sin is choosing our way instead of God's way**, and it breaks things. (Genesis 3)
4. **God keeps His promises**, even when it takes a long time. (Genesis 15, 21)
5. **God can bring good out of bad.** (Genesis 50:20)
6. **The whole Bible points to Jesus**, the promised rescuer. (Genesis 3:15; 12:3)

Timeline and map notes

- **Timeline:** Creation → Fall → Flood → Babel → Abraham (traditionally dated around 2000 BC) → Isaac → Jacob → Joseph in Egypt (around 1900–1800 BC by traditional dating). Draw a long rope or ribbon across the room and clip pictures to it. Keep it up all year and add each phase's people.
- **Map:** Abram's journey goes from **Ur** (in modern Iraq) to **Harran** (modern Turkey), then down to **Canaan** (modern Israel). Joseph is taken to **Egypt**. Show older kids the "fertile crescent" curve on a map.

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers / Ambassadors (11–17)
The flood (people died)	Focus on God keeping Noah's family and the animals safe and the rainbow promise. "People were being very, very mean, and God had to stop the hurting." No pictures of drowning.	Be honest that the flood was God's judgment on violence (6:11), but God gave time and a way to be saved (the ark).	Discuss justice and mercy; 1 Peter 3:20 and 2 Peter 2:5 (Noah as a "preacher of righteousness"). Compare the ark to Jesus as our safe place.
Abraham and Isaac (Genesis 22)	Tell it gently: "God told Abraham to give Isaac back to Him. Abraham trusted God, and God gave a ram instead. God never wanted Isaac hurt."	Emphasize God *stopped* Abraham and *provided*. God does not want child sacrifice (other nations did that; God forbids it in Leviticus 18:21).	Talk about it as a test of trust and a picture of God giving His own Son (John 3:16; Romans 8:32).
Cain and Abel (murder)	"Cain was angry and hurt his brother very badly. God was sad."	Name it honestly: Cain killed Abel. Talk about anger (4:7).	Discuss sin "crouching at the door" and choosing to master it.
Joseph's brothers / Potiphar's wife	"His brothers were jealous and sold him. A lady told a lie about him."	Same, plus jealousy and lying as sins that hurt families.	You can explain she tried to get Joseph to do wrong and he ran away (39:12); talk about running from temptation (2 Timothy 2:22).
Sodom, Lot's daughters, Dinah, Judah and Tamar	Skip.	Skip or summarize: "Some people in Genesis made very bad choices; the Bible tells the truth about them."	Mention that the Bible is honest about its heroes' failures; handle specifics only if asked, and privately if needed.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

- **"Who made God?"** Nobody. God has always been. He never had a beginning, and He'll never have an end. Everything else needs a maker; God is the Maker. (Psalm 90:2)
- **"Were dinosaurs on the ark?"** The Bible doesn't say the word "dinosaur." It says God made all the land animals (Genesis 1:24–25). Christians have different ideas about the details, but we all agree God made every creature, even the giant ones!
- **"How long were the days of creation?"** Christians who love the Bible hold different views on this. What everyone agrees on is the big truth: God made it all, on purpose, and it was good. *(Teacher: don't take sides with kids; point them to their parents and pastor for more.)*
- **"Why did God put the tree there if He knew they'd eat from it?"** God wanted Adam and Eve to love and trust Him for real. Real love means there's a real choice.
- **"Is the snake the devil?"** Yes. Revelation 12:9 calls Satan "that ancient serpent."
- **"Why didn't everyone just get on the ark?"** They didn't believe Noah or didn't want to stop doing wrong. God waited patiently (1 Peter 3:20).

- **"Why does the Bible tell bad things that people did?"** Because it's true, and it shows that everyone needs God, even heroes.
- **"Why are there two Testaments?"** The Old Testament is God's promises *before* Jesus, and the New Testament is how God kept them *in* Jesus.
- **"Did God write the Bible with His own hand?"** God used people to write it. He guided them by His Spirit so that what they wrote is what He wanted said (2 Peter 1:21).

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson title	Key point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
1	Psalm 119:105; 2 Timothy 3:16; Luke 24:27	**God's Big Library**	The Bible is 66 books, two testaments and one story about Jesus, and I can find my way around it.	SharefaithKids "books of the Bible"; BibleJourneyTV "Bible"; BibleProject "What Is the Bible?"	Old or New? Run!; Draw Your Swords (Bible Address Race)	Bible Bookshelf Craft; "My First Bible Address" card
2	Genesis 1–3	**God Made It Good**	God made everything good and made people in His image. Sin broke it, but God promised a Rescuer.	SharefaithKids "Creation"; BibleJourneyTV "Creation"; BibleProject "Overview: Genesis 1-11"	Creation Day Scramble	Creation Wheel
3	Genesis 6–9; 12:1–3; 15:5–6; 21:1–7; 22:1–14	**God Keeps His Promises**	God kept Noah safe and kept His promise to Abraham. God always keeps His word.	SharefaithKids "Noah's ark" / "Abraham"; BibleJourneyTV "Noah"; BibleProject "The Covenants"	Two by Two Animal Match; Count the Stars Toss	Rainbow Promise Mobile; Abraham's Star Jar
4	Genesis 37; 39–45; 50:15–21	**God Turns Bad into Good**	Joseph was treated badly, but God was with him and used it to save many lives.	SharefaithKids "Joseph"; BibleJourneyTV "Joseph"; BibleProject "Overview: Genesis 12-50"	Joseph's Coat Color Relay	Joseph's Coat Collage
5 (optional)	Review all of Genesis + Bible library	**Review & Fun Sunday**	I know how the Bible works and I know the story of Genesis!	Re-watch the class favorite	Genesis Game Show; Sword Drill Championship	Passport stamping + badge ceremony

---

Weekly Lessons

Week 1: God's Big Library 📚

Scripture: Psalm 119:105; 2 Timothy 3:16–17; Luke 24:27

Lesson goal: Kids will know that the Bible is a library of 66 books in two testaments, that it is God's true Word, and how to find a book, chapter and verse (including the Table of Contents trick).

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Mystery Box Library"

- *Supplies:* A box or bag holding 4–6 different kinds of books (picture book, cookbook, history book, songbook, letters/cards, a map book), plus one Bible. A small flashlight.
- *Do:* Pull out each book. "What kind of book is this? A cookbook tells you how to cook. A songbook has songs." Then hold up the Bible. "This one is special. It's not *one* book. It's like ALL of these kinds of books together: history, songs, letters, wise sayings, even a book about the future. It's a whole **library**!" Turn off the lights and switch on the flashlight: "The Bible says God's Word is a lamp for my feet and a light on my path. It helps us see the way to go."

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Have you ever been to a library? A library has LOTS of books on shelves. Some shelves have story books. Some have songbooks. Some have letters people wrote.
>
> Guess what? The Bible is like a library! It looks like one book, but inside are **66 books**. Let's say it together: *sixty-six!*
>
> A long, long time ago, God picked about 40 different people to write down His words. Some were shepherds. Some were kings. One was a doctor, and some were fishermen. They lived in different places and at different times, over 1,500 years! But God's Holy Spirit helped every one of them write exactly what God wanted. The Bible says all of it is "God-breathed." That means it's God's own words to us.
>
> The Bible library has two big rooms. The first room is the **Old Testament**. It has **39 books**. They were written *before* Jesus was born. They tell how God made the world and how He chose a family and made promises. Again and again He said, "Someday I will send a Rescuer!"
>
> The second room is the **New Testament**. It has **27 books**. They were written *after* Jesus came. They tell how Jesus was born, how He lived, died on the cross, and came back to life, and how His friends told the whole world.
>
> Thirty-nine plus twenty-seven makes... sixty-six!
>
> Here's something amazing. After Jesus rose again, He walked with two friends. He explained to them what the *whole* Bible said about Himself, starting with the very first books (Luke 24:27). So the whole library, all 66 books, is really **one big story**, and Jesus is the hero.

> Now, how do you find something in a library this big? God's people added little numbers to help. The **big numbers** are **chapters**, and the **little numbers** are **verses**. When you see "Genesis 1:1," it means: the book of Genesis, chapter 1, verse 1. That's the very first verse in the whole Bible!
>
> And if you ever get lost, there's a secret helper at the front of your Bible called the **Table of Contents**. It's like the library map. It tells you what page every book starts on.
>
> The Bible is like a flashlight in the dark. It shows us who God is and how to follow Him. Let's learn to use it!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on three things: "The Bible is God's book," "66 books," and "Old before Jesus, New after Jesus." Let each child hold a Bible and find the *front* (Genesis) and the *back* (Revelation). Practice "big number, little number" by pointing on a page.
- **Explorers:** Teach them to read a reference out loud ("John three sixteen") and find it with the Contents page. Give each a "Bible address" card to find. Celebrate every find.
- **Trailblazers:** Introduce all 10 library sections. Let them race to find the first book of each section. Introduce the three original languages and the idea that chapters and verses were added later.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss *how we got the Bible* (many authors, one Author, inspiration). Have them pair with Little Lambs to help them find Genesis 1:1 and Psalm 119:105.

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) How many books are in the Bible? (66) (2) Who wrote the Bible? (God, using people) (3) Does the Old Testament come before or after Jesus? (Before)
- *Explorers:* (1) What does "John 3:16" mean? (2) Where can you look if you can't find a book? (3) Why do you think God gave us a Bible instead of just a feeling?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) If 40 people wrote over 1,500 years, how is it still one story? (2) Which section of the library are you most curious about, and why? (3) What does "God-breathed" mean for how we treat the Bible?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Jesus said the Scriptures "testify about me" (John 5:39). What difference does that make in how you read the Old Testament? (2) Why is it risky to read just one verse without the chapter around it? (3) How would you explain "the Bible is true" to a friend who thinks it's just old stories?

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "books of the Bible" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=books+of+the+Bible` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Bible" (look for an intro or "how the Bible" video) | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Bible` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors (Explorers with pauses) | "What Is the Bible?" (series intro) or "The Story of the Bible" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=What+Is+the+Bible` |

Teacher: preview every video first and pick the one that fits your group's time and maturity. Follow-up questions: (1) What is one thing the video said about the Bible that you didn't know? (2) What is the Bible's big story about?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Old or New? Run!* and *Draw Your Swords (Bible Address Race)*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Bible Bookshelf Craft* and the *"My First Bible Address" card*. See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** "66 books, 39 Old, 27 New." Bonus verse Psalm 119:105. Spell **B-I-B-L-E**; Explorers and up spell **T-E-S-T-A-M-E-N-T**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, thank You for giving us the Bible, Your true words. Help us learn it, love it, and follow it like a light on our path. In Jesus' name, amen.

Week 2: God Made It Good 🌍

Scripture: Genesis 1:1–2:3; 2:7–25; 3:1–24 (key verses 1:1, 1:27, 1:31, 3:15)

Lesson goal: Kids will know that God created everything good, that people are made in His image, that sin broke God's good world, and that God immediately promised a Rescuer (Jesus).

Opening hook / object lesson: "Made from Nothing?"

- *Supplies:* An empty table, a lump of play dough, a cookie (or picture of one), a mirror.
- *Do:* "I'm going to make a cookie from *nothing*." Wave your hands over the empty table. Nothing happens! "I can't. Even a baker needs flour and eggs. But God made the whole universe from nothing, just by speaking!" Then pull out the mirror and let kids look: "God made you in His *image*. That means you're made to show what God is like, a bit like a mirror shows a reflection."

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> In the beginning, before there was anything, there was God. No sun, no ground, no animals, no people. Just God.
>
> Then God spoke. **Day 1:** "Let there be light!" And there was light. **Day 2:** God made the sky above and the waters below. **Day 3:** God gathered the waters so dry land appeared, and He made plants, trees and flowers grow. **Day 4:** God put the sun, moon and stars in the sky. **Day 5:** God filled the water with fish and the sky with birds. **Day 6:** God made animals, big and small. Then God made something extra special: **people**. He made the first man, Adam, from the dust of the ground and breathed life into him. Then He made the first woman, Eve. God made them **in His own image**, to know Him, love Him and take care of His world.
>
> God looked at everything He had made, and it was **very good**. **Day 7:** God rested, not because He was tired, but because His work was finished and He enjoyed it.
>
> Adam and Eve lived in a beautiful garden called **Eden**. God gave them every good tree for food. There was only one rule: "Don't eat from the tree of the knowledge of good and evil."

> One day a sneaky snake (who was really God's enemy, Satan) said to Eve, "Did God *really* say that? You won't die. You'll be like God!" Eve looked at the fruit. She ate it, and she gave some to Adam, and he ate too.
>
> Right away, everything changed. They felt ashamed and hid from God. When God came walking in the garden, He called, "Where are you?" They had disobeyed. That's called **sin**. Sin broke the good world. Now there would be pain, sadness, hard work and death. And they had to leave the garden.
>
> But even then, God made a **promise**. He told the snake that one day a child would be born from the woman's family who would **crush the snake's head** (Genesis 3:15). God also made clothes from animal skins for Adam and Eve. He still loved them.
>
> That promised child is **Jesus**! He came to defeat Satan, take away sin, and one day make the whole world very good again.

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Use 7 picture cards (one per day) and a motion for each day. Repeat: "God made it. It was good!" For the fall: "They didn't listen to God. That's sin. But God promised Jesus!"
- **Explorers:** Have them put the 7 days in order. Emphasize "image of God" (everyone matters) and Genesis 3:15 as the first promise of Jesus.
- **Trailblazers:** Look at the pattern of days 1–3 (spaces: light/dark, sky/sea, land) and days 4–6 (fillers: sun and moon, birds and fish, animals and people). Look at how the snake twisted God's words (3:1 compared with 2:16–17).
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss what "image of God" means for human dignity (racism, disability, the unborn, the elderly). Compare Adam's failure in a garden with Jesus' faithfulness in the wilderness and in Gethsemane.

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Who made the world? (2) What did God say about everything He made? ("Very good!") (3) What did God promise? (Jesus)
- *Explorers:* (1) What did God make on Day 6? (2) What did the snake say that wasn't true? (3) What did God do to show He still loved Adam and Eve?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why did Adam and Eve hide? What do people "hide" behind today? (2) How did the snake twist God's words? How can we spot lies like that? (3) How does Genesis 3:15 point to the cross?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) If every person bears God's image, how should that change how we treat people we disagree with? (2) Sin brought shame and blame (3:12–13). Where do you see that today? (3) Why is it good news that God came looking for Adam and Eve ("Where are you?")?

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Creation" or "Adam and Eve" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Creation` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Creation" or "Garden of Eden" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Creation` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Genesis 1-11"; theme video "Image of God" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Genesis` |

Preview first. Follow-up questions: (1) What does it mean that God made people in His image? (2) In the video, what went wrong in the garden, and what did God promise?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Creation Day Scramble*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Creation Wheel*. See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Genesis 1:1 (Little Lambs: "In the beginning God created."). Spell **G-E-N-E-S-I-S** with claps: Gen (clap) - e (clap) - sis (clap).

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> God, You made the sky, the sea, the animals, and me! Thank You that You still love us even when we sin, and thank You for sending Jesus to make things right. Amen.

Week 3: God Keeps His Promises 🌈⭐

Scripture: Genesis 6:5–9:17 (Noah); 11:1–9 (Babel, briefly); 12:1–3; 15:5–6; 21:1–7; 22:1–14 (Abraham)

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that God saved Noah's family and promised never to flood the whole earth again (rainbow), and that God promised Abraham a huge family that would bless the world, and He kept His promise.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Pinky Promise"

- *Supplies:* A flashlight and a glass prism or a CD (to make a rainbow), or a picture of a rainbow; a handful of glitter stars or a star-patterned sheet.
- *Do:* Ask, "Has anyone ever broken a promise to you? How did it feel?" Then shine the light through the prism to make a rainbow on the wall. "Every rainbow is God's reminder that He keeps His promises. God has never broken a promise, not even one!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> After Adam and Eve left the garden, more and more people were born. But sin spread too. People became very violent and mean. It made God's heart sad.
>
> But one man, **Noah**, loved God and walked with Him. God told Noah, "Build a giant boat called an **ark**." It was as long as one and a half football fields! Noah worked for years. God told him to bring his family (his wife, his three sons and their wives, 8 people in all) and pairs of every kind of animal, two by two, plus seven pairs of some kinds.
>
> Then the rain came. It rained for **40 days and 40 nights**. The water covered everything, but the ark floated safely, because God shut the door and kept them safe inside.
>
> After many months, Noah sent out a dove. It came back with an **olive leaf**! Land was drying! When they finally came out, Noah thanked God. And God put a **rainbow** in the sky and said, "This is the sign of My promise: I will never again destroy the whole earth with a flood."

> Many years later, God spoke to a man named **Abram**. "Leave your home and go to a land I will show you. I will make you into a great nation, and **all peoples on earth will be blessed through you**." Abram didn't know where he was going, but he trusted God and went!
>
> There was one problem. Abram and his wife Sarai were old, and they had no children. One night God took Abram outside. "Look up at the sky and count the stars, if you can. That's how many people will be in your family!" Abram believed God. God later changed their names to **Abraham** ("father of many") and **Sarah**.
>
> They waited and waited. Abraham was **100 years old** and Sarah was 90 when God gave them a baby boy named **Isaac**, which means "he laughs." Sarah laughed with joy!
>
> Later God tested Abraham: "Take Isaac up the mountain and give him back to me." It was very hard, but Abraham trusted God. Isaac asked, "Where is the lamb?" Abraham said, "**God himself will provide the lamb.**" And at the top, God stopped Abraham and gave a ram, stuck in a bush, instead. Isaac was safe!
>
> Long, long after, God provided *the* Lamb: **Jesus**, born in Abraham's family. Through Jesus, the whole world can be blessed. God keeps His promises!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Make animal sounds as the animals board the ark; count "two by two." Big takeaway: "God keeps His promises!" (Say it every time you show the rainbow.) Tell the Isaac story very gently (see Sensitive Content).
- **Explorers:** Ask them to count promises: to Noah (rainbow) and to Abraham (land, family, blessing). Have them find Genesis 12:3 in their own Bibles using the Contents page.
- **Trailblazers:** Trace Abram's journey on a map (Ur → Harran → Canaan). Read Genesis 15:6 and Romans 4:3: Abraham was made right with God by *trusting* Him.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss "covenant" (a binding promise-relationship). Compare Genesis 22 with John 3:16 and Romans 8:32. Ask: what's harder, obeying or waiting?

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Who built the ark? (Noah) (2) What did God put in the sky? (A rainbow) (3) What baby did God give Abraham and Sarah? (Isaac)
- *Explorers:* (1) Why was Noah different from the other people? (2) What did God tell Abraham to count? (3) How long did Abraham and Sarah wait for Isaac? What's something you've had to wait for?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Hebrews 11:8 says Abraham went "even though he did not know where he was going." What makes that kind of trust possible? (2) How is the ark like Jesus? (3) Why do you think God made Abraham wait so long?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) What does Genesis 15:6 teach about faith and being right with God? (2) Genesis 22 is a hard chapter. How does it help us understand what God did for us at the cross? (3) The Tower of Babel was people trying to "make a name for ourselves" (11:4); God instead promises to make Abram's name great (12:2). What's the difference?

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Noah's ark" or "Abraham" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Noah` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Noah" or "Abraham" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Noah` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | Theme video "The Covenants"; or the second half of "Overview: Genesis 1-11" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Covenants` |

Preview first. Follow-up questions: (1) What promise did God make in the video? (2) How did God keep it?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Two by Two Animal Match* and *Count the Stars Toss*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Rainbow Promise Mobile* (younger) or *Abraham's Star Jar* (older). See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Keep reviewing Genesis 1:1. Spell **N-O-A-H** and **A-B-R-A-H-A-M** (Explorers+). Trailblazers: **C-O-V-E-N-A-N-T**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Faithful God, You always keep Your promises. When we have to wait, help us trust You like Abraham did. Thank You for Jesus, the Lamb You provided for us. Amen.

Week 4: God Turns Bad into Good 🧥

Scripture: Genesis 25:19–34 and 28:10–22 (Jacob, briefly); 37; 39–45; 50:15–21 (key verse 50:20)

Lesson goal: Kids will learn how God was with Joseph through hard times and used even the wrong things people did to save many lives, and how Joseph forgave.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Messy Becomes Beautiful"

- *Supplies:* A piece of paper with random scribbles and splotches on it, prepared in advance so that, with a few added lines, the scribbles become a picture (for example a butterfly or a flower). Markers.
- *Do:* Show the messy page: "What a mess! Is this good for anything?" Then quickly add a few lines to turn the mess into a picture. "Sometimes our lives feel messy. But God can take messy, even mean things that happen, and make something good. That's Joseph's story."

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Abraham's son Isaac had twin boys, **Esau** and **Jacob**. Jacob tricked his brother and had to run away, but God still met him. One night Jacob dreamed of a **stairway to heaven** with angels going up and down, and God promised to be with him. Later God gave Jacob a new name: **Israel**. Jacob had **12 sons**!

> Jacob loved his son **Joseph** most and gave him a beautiful, fancy **robe**, a coat of many colors. Joseph also had dreams: his brothers' bundles of grain bowed down to his! His brothers got jealous. Very jealous.
>
> One day, when Joseph went to check on them in the fields, they grabbed him, took his robe, and threw him into a dry well. Then they **sold him** to traders going to Egypt for 20 pieces of silver! They dipped his coat in goat's blood and told their dad, "A wild animal must have gotten him." Jacob cried and cried.
>
> In Egypt, Joseph became a servant in the house of a man named Potiphar. Joseph worked hard, and **the LORD was with Joseph**. But Potiphar's wife told a lie about Joseph, and he was thrown into **prison**, even though he did nothing wrong. Still, **the LORD was with Joseph**.
>
> In prison, God helped Joseph explain dreams. One day **Pharaoh**, the king of Egypt, had two strange dreams: seven fat cows eaten by seven skinny cows, and seven good heads of grain swallowed by seven thin ones. Nobody knew what they meant. But Joseph said, "God will tell you: seven years of lots of food are coming, and then seven years of famine (no food)." Pharaoh put Joseph in charge of all of Egypt! Joseph was 30 years old.
>
> When the famine came, Joseph's brothers traveled to Egypt to buy food, and they bowed down to him, just like the dream! They didn't recognize him. Joseph tested them to see if they had changed. Then he cried and said, "I am Joseph!" They were scared. But Joseph **forgave** them. He hugged them and brought the whole family to Egypt.
>
> Joseph told them, "You meant to hurt me, but **God meant it for good**, to save many lives."
>
> Jesus is like Joseph, only even greater. He was rejected and hurt by people He loved. But God used His death on the cross to save many, many lives, and Jesus forgives everyone who comes to Him.

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Use a colorful scarf or robe as a prop. Repeat the refrain: "But God was with Joseph!" each time something bad happens. Kids can shout it with you.
- **Explorers:** Make a "Bad → God → Good" chart: sold → God was with him → became a leader; jailed → God gave wisdom → saved Egypt. Practice forgiveness role-plays.
- **Trailblazers:** Track Joseph's age (17 when sold, 37:2; 30 before Pharaoh, 41:46). Discuss how God's plan protected the family line that leads to Jesus (49:10).
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Genesis 50:20 and Romans 8:28. Does "God meant it for good" make evil okay? (No. The brothers were still guilty; God is greater than their evil.) Talk about forgiveness versus pretending nothing happened.

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What special gift did Joseph's dad give him? (A colorful coat) (2) Was God with Joseph in the prison? (Yes!) (3) What did Joseph do when he saw his brothers? (He forgave them)

- *Explorers:* (1) Why were Joseph's brothers jealous? (2) How did God help Joseph in prison? (3) Is it easy or hard to forgive someone? Why?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Joseph tested his brothers before revealing himself. Why? (2) Which character do you relate to most: Jacob, Joseph or the brothers? Why? (3) How does Joseph's story show God working when no one could see Him?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Romans 8:28 and Genesis 50:20 are often quoted. What do they promise, and what don't they promise? (2) What can we learn from Joseph about integrity when no one is watching (Genesis 39)? (3) How is Joseph a "preview" of Jesus? List at least three parallels.

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Joseph" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Joseph` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Joseph" or "Jacob" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Joseph` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Genesis 12-50" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Genesis+12-50` |

Preview first. Follow-up questions: (1) What bad things happened to Joseph, and what good did God bring? (2) What does Joseph teach us about forgiving?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Joseph's Coat Color Relay*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Joseph's Coat Collage*. See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Say Genesis 1:1 from memory (all groups) and spell **G-E-N-E-S-I-S** without help. Explorers+: spell **J-O-S-E-P-H**, **J-A-C-O-B**, **I-S-A-A-C**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, thank You that You are always with us, even on bad days. Help us forgive like Joseph did, and like Jesus forgives us. We trust You to bring good out of hard things. Amen.

Week 5 (optional): Review & Fun Sunday 🎉

Use the **End-of-Phase Review & Celebration** plan below: Genesis Game Show, Sword Drill Championship, oral check-offs, Bible Passport stamps and badges.

Book Memory Song & Motions 🎵

This is the **first** song of the year. Every later phase adds new verses to it, so teach it well!

Part A: "The Bible Library Song" (tune: *Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star*)

> 🎵 **Sixty-six books, one big story,** *(hold up 6 fingers, then 6 again; spread arms wide)* **All about God and all His glory!** *(point up, then wiggle fingers down like sparkles)* **Thirty-nine are in the Old,**

> *(thumb points back over shoulder = "before Jesus")* **Twenty-seven New, we're told.** *(thumb points forward = "after Jesus")* **Sixty-six books, one big story, All about God and all His glory!**

Part B: "Genesis Is Book Number One" (same tune)

> 🎵 **Genesis is book number one,** *(hold up 1 finger)* **That's where God's big story's begun!** *(Sunrise hands: open the "book," sweep arms up like the sun)* **G-E-N-E-S-I-S,** *(draw each letter in the air, or clap 7 times)* **God made it all, and it was blessed!** *(arms in a big circle = the world)* **Genesis is book number one, First of the LAW, and we've begun!** *(fist pump on "LAW!")*

Part C: "Find It Fast" chant (call and response, steady clap)

> **Teacher:** Big number? **Kids:** CHAPTER! **Teacher:** Little number? **Kids:** VERSE! **Teacher:** Lost your place? **Kids:** Contents FIRST! **Teacher:** Old Testament? **Kids:** BEFORE Jesus! **Teacher:** New Testament? **Kids:** AFTER Jesus! **Teacher:** How many books? **Kids:** SIXTY-SIX!

Hand motion for Genesis

🌅 **Sunrise hands:** palms pressed together (a closed book) → open them like a book → sweep both arms up and out in a big arc like the sun rising. Say: *"Genesis: in the beginning!"*

Section Shout

> **Teacher:** "What's the first section of the Bible library?" **Kids:** "**LAW!** Five books of LAW! Book one: **GENESIS!**" *(hold up 5 fingers, then 1)*

(Next month we'll fill in the other four books of the Law.)

Cumulative recall drill (end of every class)

1. Sing Part A together.
2. Teacher holds up a Bible: "How many books?" (66) "Old?" (39) "New?" (27)
3. "First book?" (Genesis, with the motion) "Spell it!" (G-E-N-E-S-I-S)
4. "What section?" (LAW!)
5. "Genesis 1:1, say it!" (Little Lambs: "In the beginning God created.")
6. Speed round: point at a child and call "Chapter or verse?" while pointing at a big or small number in an open Bible.

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Use only Part A and the first two lines of Part B. Lots of motion, little words. Praise loudly!
- **Explorers:** Learn all three parts. Let volunteers lead the "Find It Fast" chant.
- **Trailblazers:** Add a challenge: say the 10 library section names in order (Law, History, Poetry, Major Prophets, Minor Prophets, Gospels, Acts, Paul's Letters, General Letters, Revelation).
- **Ambassadors:** Learn the song well enough to lead it with the Little Lambs. Challenge: say the number of books in each section (5-12-5-5-12 / 4-1-13-8-1).

Spelling & Reading 🔤

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letters and sounds)	Explorers (book names and story words)	Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocab)	Ambassadors (book names + harder vocab)
G is for **G**enesis and **G**od	GENESIS	GENESIS	GENESIS
B is for **B**ible	BIBLE	TESTAMENT	TESTAMENT
N is for **N**oah	NOAH	CHAPTER	CREATION
A is for **A**dam and **A**braham	ADAM	**Vocab:** CREATION, COVENANT, IMAGE, FAMINE, ARK	**Vocab:** COVENANT, SCRIPTURE, INSPIRATION, PATRIARCH, REDEMPTION
J is for **J**oseph and **J**esus	EVE		
Sound it out: *G-e-n* "Gen"	JOSEPH		
Trace: G-O-D	ABRAHAM		
	VERSE		

Ambassadors vocab with definitions:

- **Covenant:** a binding promise-relationship God makes with people (with Noah in Genesis 9, with Abraham in Genesis 15 and 17).
- **Scripture:** the written Word of God; the 66 books of the Bible.
- **Inspiration:** God guiding the human writers so what they wrote is His Word ("God-breathed," 2 Timothy 3:16).
- **Patriarch:** a "founding father" of God's people: Abraham, Isaac and Jacob.
- **Redemption:** being bought back or rescued; what God does for His people, ultimately through Jesus.

The syllable-clap method 👋

1. Say the word slowly: "Gen... e... sis."
2. Clap once for each part: **Gen** (clap) **e** (clap) **sis** (clap) = 3 claps.
3. Spell each clap-part: "Gen" = G-E-N, "e" = E, "sis" = S-I-S.
4. Put it together: G-E-N-E-S-I-S!
5. Try it on: Ab-ra-ham (3), Jo-seph (2), Tes-ta-ment (3), Cov-e-nant (3), Cre-a-tion (3).

"Spell It Out" relay

- **Setup:** Two or more teams in lines. At the far wall, put a pile of large letter cards for each team (or magnetic letters on a whiteboard).
- **Play:** The teacher calls a word ("GENESIS!"). The first child runs, grabs the first letter, runs back, and tags the next child, who gets the second letter, and so on. The team lines up its letters in order on the floor.
- **Win:** First team to spell it correctly, *and say the word and its section together* ("GENESIS, LAW!"), gets a point.
- **Little Lambs:** Find just the first letter ("Find the G!"). **Ambassadors:** Spell vocab words backwards for a challenge.

Mini spelling bee word list (with sentences)

Word	Use it in a sentence
Genesis	*Genesis* is the first book of the Bible.
Bible	The *Bible* has 66 books.
Testament	The Old *Testament* was written before Jesus was born.
chapter	Genesis has 50 *chapters*.
verse	Genesis 1:1 is the first *verse* in the Bible.
creation	God made everything in the *creation* story.
Abraham	God promised *Abraham* a family as many as the stars.
Isaac	*Isaac* means "he laughs."
Jacob	God changed *Jacob's* name to Israel.
Joseph	*Joseph* forgave his brothers.
rainbow	The *rainbow* reminds us of God's promise.
covenant	God made a *covenant* with Noah.
famine	There was a seven-year *famine* in Egypt.
Egypt	Joseph's family moved to *Egypt*.
patriarch	Abraham was the first *patriarch*.

Read-aloud practice passage (Genesis 1:1–5, NIV)

Have Explorers and older take turns reading one sentence each. Little Lambs repeat after a leader, one phrase at a time.

> "In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth. Now the earth was formless and empty, darkness was over the surface of the deep, and the Spirit of God was hovering over the waters. And God said, 'Let there be light,' and there was light. God saw that the light was good, and he separated the light from the darkness. God called the light 'day,' and the darkness he called 'night.' And there was evening, and there was morning — the first day."

Reading tip: Point out the repeated phrases ("And God said," "God saw that it was good," "there was evening, and there was morning"). Repeated words are clues to what's important!

Word Trivia ❓

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. How many books are in the Bible?
2. What is the first book of the Bible?
3. Who made the world?
4. **True or False:** The Old Testament was written before Jesus was born.
5. What did God make on the very first day?
6. Who built the ark?
7. What did God put in the sky as a promise?
8. Who were the first man and woman?
9. **Fill in the blank:** "In the _____ God created the heavens and the earth."
10. What special gift did Jacob give Joseph?
11. What did God call everything He made? (Two words)
12. **Who said it?** "Where are you?" (Genesis 3:9)

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

13. How many books are in the Old Testament? In the New Testament?
14. In "John 3:16," what does the 3 stand for? The 16?
15. Where in your Bible can you look to find what page a book starts on?
16. How many days did it rain on Noah's ark?
17. What bird brought Noah an olive leaf?
18. What did God tell Abraham to try to count?
19. How old was Abraham when Isaac was born?
20. **Who said it?** "God himself will provide the lamb." (Genesis 22:8)
21. **True or False:** Joseph's brothers sold him for 20 pieces of silver.
22. What new name did God give Jacob?

23. **Which book?** The story of the Tower of Babel is found in which book?

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

24. What does the word "Genesis" mean?
25. Name the 10 sections of the Bible library in order.
26. Which verse is called the "first gospel" (the first promise of a Savior)?
27. **Fill in the blank:** "You intended to harm me, but God intended it for _____." (Genesis 50:20)
28. What three things did God promise Abraham in Genesis 12?
29. **True or False:** Chapter and verse numbers were in the Bible when it was first written.
30. What three languages was the Bible originally written in?
31. How many chapters are in Genesis?
32. **Who said it?** "Am I my brother's keeper?" (Genesis 4:9)
33. According to Genesis 15:6, why did God count Abram as righteous?
34. How old was Joseph when he entered Pharaoh's service?
35. Who is the traditional author of Genesis?

🔑 Answer Key

1. 66 · 2. Genesis · 3. God · 4. True · 5. Light · 6. Noah · 7. A rainbow · 8. Adam and Eve · 9. beginning · 10. A beautiful, colorful robe (coat) · 11. "Very good" · 12. God
2. 39 Old, 27 New · 14. 3 = chapter, 16 = verse · 15. The Table of Contents · 16. 40 days and 40 nights · 17. A dove · 18. The stars · 19. 100 · 20. Abraham · 21. True (Genesis 37:28) · 22. Israel · 23. Genesis (chapter 11)
3. "Beginning" or "origin" · 25. Law, History, Poetry/Wisdom, Major Prophets, Minor Prophets, Gospels, History (Acts), Paul's Letters, General Letters, Prophecy (Revelation) · 26. Genesis 3:15 · 27. good · 28. Land, a great nation (many descendants), blessing to all peoples on earth through him · 29. False (they were added much later) · 30. Hebrew, Aramaic, Greek · 31. 50 · 32. Cain · 33. Because he believed (trusted) the LORD · 34. 30 (Genesis 41:46) · 35. Moses

---

Games 🎮

(More games and variations: `../00-start-here/game-library.md`)

1. Old or New? Run!

- **Best for:** All ages (great for Week 1).
- **Supplies:** Two big signs: "OLD TESTAMENT (39) — Before Jesus" and "NEW TESTAMENT (27) — After Jesus." Tape them on opposite walls.
- **Setup:** Kids stand in the middle of the room.
- **How to play:** Call out a book name or a person ("Genesis!", "Matthew!", "Noah!", "Jesus' birth!", "Psalms!", "Revelation!"). Kids run to the correct wall. For younger kids, use people and events; for older, use book names only.
- **How to win:** Last one to the right wall (or anyone at the wrong wall) does a silly job (5 jumping jacks) and rejoins. Everyone keeps playing.

- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* only "Before Jesus or After Jesus?" with pictures. *Ambassadors:* add a third wall: "Which section?" (they must shout the section).
- **Learning goal:** The two testaments; early familiarity with book names.

2. Draw Your Swords (Bible Address Race)

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors (Little Lambs with a buddy).
- **Supplies:** A Bible for every child (same edition if possible), a list of references.
- **Setup:** Kids stand in a line holding Bibles closed at their sides. ("The word of God is... sharper than any double-edged sword," Hebrews 4:12.)
- **How to play:** Leader: "**Attention!**" (Bibles at side.) "**Draw swords!**" (Bible held flat in front, closed.) Leader reads a reference twice: "Genesis 1:1." "**Charge!**" Kids race to find it. The first to put a finger on the verse steps forward and reads it aloud.
- **How to win:** Points for each first find; everyone who finds it gets a cheer.
- **Week 1 references:** Genesis 1:1; Psalm 119:105; John 3:16; Genesis 12:3; Matthew 1:1; Revelation 22:21; 2 Timothy 3:16. **Weeks 2–4:** Genesis 1:27; 1:31; 3:15; 9:13; 15:6; 22:8; 37:3; 50:20.
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* "Find Genesis!" (front of the Bible) or "Find the big number 1!" *Ambassadors:* no Contents page allowed, or one point off for each peek.
- **Learning goal:** Finding book, chapter and verse; the Table of Contents trick.

3. Creation Day Scramble

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers.
- **Supplies:** 7 picture signs (Day 1 light, 2 sky and water, 3 land and plants, 4 sun, moon and stars, 5 fish and birds, 6 animals and people, 7 rest), taped around the room.
- **Setup:** Kids start in the center.
- **How to play:** Call "Day 4!" and kids run to the sun/moon/stars sign and act it out (twinkle fingers). Call "Something God made!" ("Fish!") and they run to the right day. "Day 7!" means everyone lies down and rests, and the first person to giggle is the next caller.
- **How to win:** No losers; just fun. For older kids, last one to the correct sign answers a trivia question.
- **Adaptation:** *Older kids:* call the reverse ("What day were the birds?") or call two items fast. *Ambassadors:* explain the days 1–3 / days 4–6 "spaces and fillers" pattern.
- **Learning goal:** The order and goodness of creation.

4. Two by Two Animal Match

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers.
- **Supplies:** Pairs of animal picture cards (one card per child; make sure every card has a match).
- **Setup:** Give each child a card face down. Don't let them show anyone!
- **How to play:** "Go!" Kids make their animal's sound or motion (no words) to find their partner. When a pair finds each other, they link arms and walk "two by two" into the "ark" (a taped rectangle or blanket area).
- **How to win:** When everyone's in, the teacher "shuts the door" ("God shut them in," Genesis 7:16) and everyone shouts "God keeps His promises!"
- **Adaptation:** *Older kids:* use harder animals (sloth, platypus) or add a timer.

- **Learning goal:** Noah's story; God keeping Noah's family safe.

5. Count the Stars Toss

- **Best for:** All ages.
- **Supplies:** A dark blanket or poster board with paper stars taped on (each star has a number of points, 1–5); beanbags or crumpled paper balls.
- **Setup:** Lay the "night sky" on the floor. Line kids up behind a tape line.
- **How to play:** Each child tosses a beanbag. If it lands on a star, they answer a trivia question (matching the star's difficulty) to earn its points.
- **How to win:** The team with the most points wins, but the twist at the end is: "Did anybody count ALL the stars in the real sky? No! God's promise to Abraham was bigger than we can count!"
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* just count out loud together the stars they hit. *Ambassadors:* questions from the ⭐⭐⭐ list.
- **Learning goal:** God's promise to Abraham; trivia review.

6. Joseph's Coat Color Relay

- **Best for:** All ages.
- **Supplies:** Strips of colored paper or fabric (many colors), a large paper "coat" outline for each team, tape or glue sticks; a list of review questions.
- **Setup:** Teams line up; coats on the far wall; color strips in a basket by the teacher.
- **How to play:** Teacher asks the first child in line a question. If correct, they take one color strip, run, and tape it on their team's coat. Then the next child goes.
- **How to win:** First team to cover their coat (for example 10 strips) wins, and then shouts Genesis 50:20 together.
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* name a color to get a strip ("Red!"). *Older kids:* questions about Joseph's life in order, and they must also say the age (17 / 30).
- **Learning goal:** Joseph's story and God's goodness.

7. Library Shelf Sort (bonus for Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

- **Best for:** Trailblazers, Ambassadors (Explorers in teams).
- **Supplies:** 66 index cards, each with one book name; 10 "shelf" signs on the floor (section names).
- **Setup:** Shuffle the cards and split them among teams.
- **How to play:** Teams race to place every card under the correct section sign, in order.
- **How to win:** Fastest correct shelf (check against the Contents page) wins.
- **Adaptation:** *Explorers:* just Old Testament or New Testament piles.
- **Learning goal:** A preview of the whole library structure for the year.

Coloring Pages 🖍️

> Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-01-printables.html`

Page 1: The Bible Library Bookshelf (Week 1)

- **Scene:** A tall wooden bookshelf with two big doors labeled "OLD TESTAMENT — 39" and "NEW TESTAMENT — 27." Small book spines on the shelves; the first spine says "GENESIS." A smiling child holds a flashlight shining on the shelf.
- **Caption:** *"Your word is a lamp for my feet, a light on my path." Psalm 119:105*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Which room is before Jesus? Which is after? Can you find Genesis on the shelf? What do you want to learn from the Bible this year?"

Page 2: Seven Days of Creation (Week 2)

- **Scene:** A circle divided into 7 pie slices: (1) light and dark, (2) sky and water, (3) land, trees and flowers, (4) sun, moon and stars, (5) fish and birds, (6) animals and two people, (7) a peaceful scene with "REST."
- **Caption:** *"God saw all that he had made, and it was very good." Genesis 1:31*
- **Coloring conversation:** "What's your favorite thing God made? Why do you think God made so many colors? You're made in God's image. What's one way you can show God's kindness?"

Page 3: Noah's Ark and the Rainbow (Week 3)

- **Scene:** The ark resting on a mountain; animals walking out two by two (elephants, giraffes, lions, sheep); Noah's family waving; a dove with an olive leaf; a big rainbow overhead.
- **Caption:** *"I have set my rainbow in the clouds." Genesis 9:13*
- **Coloring conversation:** "What does a rainbow remind us of? What's a promise God has made to you? (He'll never leave you, Hebrews 13:5.)"

Page 4: Abraham Under the Stars (Week 3)

- **Scene:** Abraham as an old man standing outside a tent at night, looking up at a sky FULL of stars; Sarah peeks out of the tent. Leave lots of stars for kids to color or add with glitter.
- **Caption:** *"Look up at the sky and count the stars." Genesis 15:5*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Can you count all the stars? God's family is that big, and you can be part of it through Jesus!"

Page 5: Joseph's Colorful Coat (Week 4)

- **Scene:** Young Joseph holding out his arms to show a long robe with big stripes and patches; in the background a pyramid and a little picture of grain bundles bowing.
- **Caption:** *"God intended it for good." Genesis 50:20*

- **Coloring conversation:** "Use a different color for every stripe! When something bad happens, who is with you? Who can you forgive this week?"

Page 6: GENESIS Bubble Letters (book-name page)

- **Scene:** Big outline letters "G-E-N-E-S-I-S" across the page with a sunrise behind them; small pictures tucked into each letter: G = garden, E = Eve, N = Noah, E = earth, S = stars, I = Isaac, S = sun. Below: "Book 1 of 66 · LAW · Old Testament."
- **Caption:** *"In the beginning God created." Genesis 1:1*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Can you spell it out loud as you color each letter? What section is Genesis in?"

Activities & Crafts ✂️

1. Bible Bookshelf Craft (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** 66 thin craft sticks or paper strips per child (or a printed bookshelf sheet with 66 "spines"), a 9×12 sheet of cardstock, glue, markers. Two colors of sticks (for example 39 brown and 27 blue) is ideal.
- **Steps:** (1) Draw a bookshelf outline on the cardstock. (2) Glue the 39 "Old" sticks on the top shelves and the 27 "New" sticks on the bottom shelves. (3) Write "GENESIS" on the very first stick. (4) Title it "My Bible Library."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* pre-glued shelf; they add 5 sticks and color "GENESIS." *Explorers:* count and glue all 66. *Trailblazers / Ambassadors:* color-code by the 10 sections and write each section name.
- **What it teaches:** The Bible is a library of 66 books in two testaments. Keep the bookshelf at home and color in each book as it's learned this year!

2. "My First Bible Address" Card and Bible Tabs (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Index cards, markers, stickers; for older kids, small sticky tabs or washi tape.
- **Steps:** (1) On the front, write "Genesis 1:1" big. On the back, draw arrows: "Book → Chapter → Verse." (2) Older kids put a tab on the first page of Genesis, Psalms, Matthew and Revelation in their own Bible as "landmarks," and on the Contents page.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* sticker on the Genesis page of a class Bible. *Ambassadors:* help younger kids place tabs.
- **What it teaches:** How to read and find a Bible reference; using the Contents page.

3. Creation Wheel (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Two paper plates per child, a brass paper fastener, scissors, crayons. Pre-divide one plate into 7 sections.
- **Steps:** (1) On the bottom plate, draw or glue a picture for each day of creation in its section. (2) Cut a pie-slice "window" out of the top plate and write "Genesis 1" on it. (3) Fasten the plates together in the center. (4) Spin to show each day.

- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* use stickers and pre-printed pictures. *Trailblazers:* write each day's verse reference. *Ambassadors:* label the "spaces" (days 1–3) and "fillers" (days 4–6).
- **What it teaches:** God created in an orderly, good way.

4. Rainbow Promise Mobile (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** A paper plate cut in half (cloud/arch), crepe paper streamers or ribbons in rainbow colors, cotton balls, glue, a hole punch and string.
- **Steps:** (1) Color the half-plate in rainbow stripes or glue cotton "clouds" on it. (2) Glue streamers hanging down. (3) Write on it: "God keeps His promises! Genesis 9:13." (4) Punch a hole and add string for hanging.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* glue cotton balls and pre-cut streamers. *Older kids:* write a different promise of God on each streamer (Hebrews 13:5; John 14:3; 1 John 1:9; Joshua 1:9).
- **What it teaches:** God is faithful to His promises.

5. Abraham's Star Jar (Week 3, older groups)

- **Supplies:** Clear plastic cups or small jars, small paper stars or star stickers, glitter (optional), markers.
- **Steps:** (1) On some stars, write names of people in your family, church or friends who follow Jesus. (2) Fill the jar. (3) Label: "As many as the stars! Genesis 15:5." (4) Discuss: everyone who trusts Jesus is part of Abraham's family (Galatians 3:7).
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* decorate a star with their own name: "I'm in God's family!" *Ambassadors:* write names of people they're praying will come to know Jesus.
- **What it teaches:** God kept His promise to Abraham and is still growing His family.

6. Joseph's Coat Collage (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Coat outline on cardstock, tissue paper or fabric scraps of many colors, glue sticks, markers.
- **Steps:** (1) Glue colorful scraps all over the coat. (2) On the back, write "But God was with Joseph!" or Genesis 50:20. (3) Older kids: write a hard thing on one side of a scrap and "God can bring good" on the other.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* large pre-cut pieces. *Ambassadors:* make a "Joseph and Jesus" comparison chart on the back.
- **What it teaches:** God is with us in hard times; forgiveness.

7. Genesis Story Timeline Rope (whole month, class project)

- **Supplies:** A long rope or ribbon, clothespins, picture cards (Creation, Adam and Eve, Noah, Babel, Abraham, Isaac, Jacob, Joseph, Egypt).
- **Steps:** Each week, kids clip the new pictures in order. Leave the rope up all year so each phase extends it.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* "What comes next?" *Trailblazers / Ambassadors:* add approximate dates and map locations.
- **What it teaches:** Genesis is the start of one big story that continues through all 66 books.

Word Puzzles 🧩

Word Scramble

Unscramble each word.

#	Scrambled	Hint
1	SNEESGI	First book of the Bible
2	LEIBB	God's book
3	ATTMESENT	Old or New _____
4	RECTHAP	The big number
5	SERVE	The little number
6	HONA	Built the ark
7	WOBNRIA	Sign of God's promise
8	MAHABAR	Father of many
9	CASIA	His name means "he laughs"
10	BOCAJ	Renamed Israel
11	PHOSEJ	Had a colorful coat
12	NEVOTANC	A binding promise
13	TOCREANI	God making everything
14	DENE	The first garden

🔑 **Answers:** 1. GENESIS · 2. BIBLE · 3. TESTAMENT · 4. CHAPTER · 5. VERSE · 6. NOAH · 7. RAINBOW · 8. ABRAHAM · 9. ISAAC · 10. JACOB · 11. JOSEPH · 12. COVENANT · 13. CREATION · 14. EDEN

Fill-in-the-Blank Story

Word bank: 66, beginning, good, rainbow, stars, Isaac, coat, forgave, Contents, Jesus

> The Bible is a library of **(1)** books. If I can't find a book, I look at the **(2)** page. The first book, Genesis, starts with "In the **(3)** God created the heavens and the earth." God looked at everything and said it was very **(4)**. After the flood, God put a **(5)** in the sky. God told Abraham to count the **(6)**. Abraham and Sarah had a baby named **(7)**. Jacob gave Joseph a colorful **(8)**. Joseph's brothers were mean to him, but Joseph **(9)** them. The whole Bible points to **(10)**!

🔑 **Answers:** 1. 66 · 2. Contents · 3. beginning · 4. good · 5. rainbow · 6. stars · 7. Isaac · 8. coat · 9. forgave · 10. Jesus

Match It! (draw a line from the person or thing to its picture or summary)

Person / thing	Picture / summary
1. Genesis	A. 🌈 Built a big boat and saw God's promise in the sky
2. Adam and Eve	B. ⭐ Trusted God and was promised a family like the stars
3. Noah	C. 🧥 Sold by his brothers, saved many lives
4. Abraham	D. 🌅 The book of beginnings, #1 of 66
5. Joseph	E. 🍎 First people; lived in the garden of Eden
6. Old Testament	F. 🪜 Dreamed of a stairway to heaven
7. Jacob	G. 📜 39 books written before Jesus

🔑 **Answers:** 1-D · 2-E · 3-A · 4-B · 5-C · 6-G · 7-F

Questions for Every Age 💭

Little Lambs (4–6)

1. Who made you?
2. What is your favorite thing God made?
3. Is the Bible God's book? (Yes!)
4. What color is your favorite in the rainbow? What does the rainbow remind us of?
5. Was God with Joseph when he was sad? Is God with you when you're sad?

Explorers (7–10)

1. Why do you think God wants us to read the whole Bible, not just parts?
2. What does it mean to be made in God's image?
3. Adam and Eve hid from God after they sinned. What should we do when we sin? (Run *to* God, 1 John 1:9.)
4. Which promise of God do you want to remember this week?
5. Is there someone you need to forgive, like Joseph did?

Trailblazers (11–13)

1. How can 66 books written by about 40 people be one story? What holds it together?
2. Genesis shows good people doing bad things (Abraham lying, Jacob tricking). Why might God include those stories?
3. Where do you see the effects of sin in the world? Where do you see glimpses of God's goodness?
4. Abraham waited 25 years for God's promise (Genesis 12:4; 21:5). What's hardest about waiting on God?

5. Joseph stayed faithful when no one was watching. What does integrity look like for you at school or online?

Ambassadors (14–17)

1. If you believed every person is made in God's image, what would change in how you talk about people?
2. How does knowing the Bible's overall storyline change how you read a single verse?
3. Genesis 3 says sin brought shame and blame. How does Jesus deal with both?
4. Genesis 50:20: can you name a hard time in your life where you later saw God at work?
5. What's one way you can help a younger kid love the Bible this month?

🧠 Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics / worldview)

1. **"Doesn't science disprove Genesis?"** *Suggested answer:* Genesis mainly answers *who* made the world and *why* (God, on purpose, for His glory and our good). Science studies *how* the physical world works. Many scientists have been Christians. Christians hold different views on the age of the earth and how to read the days, but they agree that God is Creator, that humans are uniquely made in His image, and that the world is not an accident. The order and fine-tuning of the universe actually fit very well with a Creator (Romans 1:20; Psalm 19:1).
2. **"How can a loving God send a flood?"** *Suggested answer:* A loving God can't be indifferent to evil. Genesis 6:11 says the earth was "full of violence." A good judge stops harm. God was also patient (1 Peter 3:20), gave a way of rescue (the ark), and then promised never to do it again (Genesis 9). The flood shows that sin is serious and that God provides a way to be saved, which points to Jesus.
3. **"Why should I trust that the Bible is God's Word and not just old human writings?"** *Suggested answer:* Look at its unity (one story from 40 authors over 1,500 years), its historical reliability (thousands of ancient manuscripts, archaeology that confirms many places and people), its fulfilled prophecies pointing to Jesus, and above all Jesus Himself, who treated the Old Testament as God's Word (Matthew 5:17–18) and rose from the dead to show He was who He said. The Bible also proves itself in changed lives.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration 🎉

Review game plan (last Sunday of the month, 75 minutes)

Time	Activity
10 min	Welcome + sing the full Phase 1 song (Parts A–C) with motions
15 min	**Genesis Game Show:** teams answer trivia (⭐ for Little Lambs, ⭐⭐ for Explorers, ⭐⭐⭐ for older) to "build" a giant paper rainbow on the wall, one color per correct answer
10 min	**Sword Drill Championship:** class finals of Draw Your Swords (Little Lambs do "Find Genesis!")

Time	Activity
10 min	**Timeline Rope Race:** teams put Genesis picture cards in order
15 min	**Oral check-offs** (see checklist) while other kids color Page 6
10 min	**Passport stamping & badge ceremony**
5 min	Closing prayer and Take-Home Family Page

Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs (4–6) ☐ Say "The Bible has 66 books" ☐ Name the first book (Genesis) and show the sunrise motion ☐ Say the section name: "LAW" ☐ Say "In the beginning God created." ☐ Name 3 people from Genesis (for example Adam, Noah, Joseph)

Explorers (7–10) ☐ Say 66 / 39 / 27 ☐ Say AND spell G-E-N-E-S-I-S ☐ Explain chapter versus verse ☐ Find Genesis 1:1 using the Contents page ☐ Say Genesis 1:1 from memory ☐ Name 4 Genesis stories in order

Trailblazers (11–13) ☐ All Explorer items ☐ Name the 10 library sections in order ☐ Give a one-sentence summary of Genesis ☐ Find 3 references in under 30 seconds each ☐ Explain how Genesis 3:15 points to Jesus

Ambassadors (14–17) ☐ All Trailblazer items ☐ Say how many books are in each section ☐ Teach a Little Lamb how to find Genesis 1:1 (with the leader watching) ☐ Explain the two halves of Genesis (1–11 and 12–50) ☐ Share one way Genesis points to Jesus

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp page 1 of each child's Bible Passport with a **sunrise** stamp (or sticker) labeled: **"Phase 1 ✔ Genesis + The Bible Library · 1 of 66."** Kids who complete their check-off get the stamp; anyone still working can finish next week. Grace, not pressure!

🏅 Phase badge: The Creation Sunrise Badge

A round gold-and-green badge: an open Bible at the bottom with a bright sunrise coming up out of its pages, a small rainbow arching over the top, and the words "IN THE BEGINNING · GENESIS 1:1." Make it from cardstock with a ribbon, a sticker, or an iron-on patch for a sash.

📜 Certificate wording

> **Purpose Church Sunday School Certificate of Completion: Phase 1, "In the Beginning"** This certifies that _____ has explored God's Big Library (66 books, 39 Old Testament, 27 New Testament), learned how to find any book, chapter and verse, and discovered the book of **GENESIS**, where God made everything good and promised a Rescuer. *"In the beginning God*

> *created the heavens and the earth." Genesis 1:1* Books learned: **1 of 66** · Teacher: _____ · Date: _____

Take-Home Family Page 🏠

Dear Parents and Caregivers,

This month your child began a year-long journey through the whole Bible! First we learned how the Bible works: it's a **library of 66 books** (39 Old Testament, 27 New Testament), and we read a reference like "John 3:16" as book, chapter and verse. We also learned the **Table of Contents trick** for finding any book. Then we explored **Genesis**, the book of beginnings: creation, the first sin and God's first promise of a Savior, Noah, Abraham's family, and Joseph. Please help your child practice at home. A few minutes a week makes a big difference!

📖 **Memory verse:** "In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth." (Genesis 1:1, NIV) **Little Lambs:** "In the beginning God created." **Bonus verse:** "Your word is a lamp for my feet, a light on my path." (Psalm 119:105)

🎵 **Our song (tune: *Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star*):**

> Sixty-six books, one big story, / All about God and all His glory! / Thirty-nine are in the Old, / Twenty-seven New, we're told. / Sixty-six books, one big story, / All about God and all His glory! Genesis is book number one, / That's where God's big story's begun! / G-E-N-E-S-I-S, / God made it all, and it was blessed! / Genesis is book number one, / First of the LAW, and we've begun!

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions:**

1. What's your favorite thing God made? Why?
2. Which promise from God in Genesis do you like best (the rainbow, the stars, the Rescuer)?
3. Joseph forgave his brothers. Is there someone our family needs to forgive?

👨‍👩‍👧 **Family activity: "Family Sword Drill."** Grab every Bible in your house. Call out a reference (Genesis 1:1, Genesis 9:13, Psalm 119:105, John 3:16) and race to find it using the Contents page. Then go outside on a clear night and try to count the stars, and talk about God's promise to Abraham.

📺 **Videos to watch at home** (search these channels on YouTube):

- **@SharefaithKids:** search "Creation," "Noah," "Joseph": `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Creation`
- **@BibleJourneyTV:** search "Joseph": `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Joseph`
- **@bibleproject:** "Overview: Genesis 1-11" and "Overview: Genesis 12-50": `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Genesis`

Next month: Phase 2, "Freedom & God's Good Rules." We'll learn Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers and Deuteronomy, which completes the 5 books of the Law!

For more on the year, see `../00-start-here/program-overview.md` and `../00-start-here/books-of-the-bible-memory-system.md`.

Phase 2: Freedom & God's Good Rules

God sets His people free, gives them good rules, lives among them, and teaches them to love Him with all their heart.

At a Glance

Month	Month 2
Books covered	Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy (4 books)
Bible section(s)	Law (books 2–5 of 5). This **completes the Law!**
Big Idea	God rescues His people from slavery, gives them good rules because He loves them, lives with them, and calls them to love Him with their whole heart.
Memory Verse (all ages)	"Love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength." (Deuteronomy 6:5, NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"Love the LORD your God." (Deuteronomy 6:5)
Theme color	Passover red and desert tan
Phase symbol / badge	🌊 The **Red Sea Crosser Badge**: two walls of blue water with a dry path between them and two stone tablets at the end
Running total of books learned	5 of 66 (Law section complete: 5 of 5)

The Big Idea (in kid words)

God's people were slaves in Egypt, and God **set them free**! He did amazing miracles, opened a path through the sea, and fed them with bread from heaven. Then God gave them **good rules** (the Ten Commandments), not to spoil their fun, but to show them how to love God and love people. God even came to **live with them** in a special tent. Even when they grumbled and disobeyed, God stayed faithful. Before they went into the Promised Land, Moses told them: **"Love the LORD your God with all your heart!"**

How this points to Jesus: On the first Passover, the blood of a lamb protected God's people. Jesus is "our Passover lamb" (1 Corinthians 5:7), and His blood saves us. God brought His people out of slavery to Egypt; Jesus frees us from slavery to sin (John 8:36). The manna was bread from heaven; Jesus said, "I am the bread of life" (John 6:35). The tabernacle was God living with His people; Jesus "made his dwelling among us" (John 1:14). The bronze snake on a pole saved people who looked at it; Jesus was lifted up on the cross so that everyone who believes in Him may have eternal life (John 3:14–15). Moses promised that God would raise up "a prophet like me" (Deuteronomy 18:15), and that prophet is Jesus (Acts 3:22). Nobody can keep God's rules perfectly, except Jesus, who kept them for us.

The Books in Easy Words

Review: Book 1, Genesis 🌅

Gen-e-sis (G-E-N-E-S-I-S) · Law · "God made everything good, people broke it, God promised to fix it." · Motion: sunrise hands.

Book 2: Exodus

How to say it	EKS-uh-dus
How to spell it	Ex-o-dus: **E-X-O-D-U-S** (3 claps)
Section	Law (book 2 of 5)
Traditional author	Moses
Chapters	40
One-sentence kid summary	God rescued His people from slavery in Egypt, gave them His good rules on Mount Sinai, and came to live with them in a special tent.
In one word	**RESCUE** ("Exodus" means "going out" or "exit")
Key people	Moses, Aaron (Moses' brother), Miriam (Moses' sister), Pharaoh, Jethro (Moses' father-in-law), Joshua, the Israelites
Key stories	Baby Moses in a basket (2); the burning bush and God's name "I AM" (3); the 10 plagues (7–12); the first Passover (12); crossing the Red Sea (14); Moses' and Miriam's song (15); manna and quail (16); water from the rock (17); the Ten Commandments (19–20); the golden calf (32); the tabernacle filled with God's glory (40)
Where Jesus shows up	The Passover lamb (12; 1 Corinthians 5:7); manna, the bread from heaven (16; John 6:35); "I AM" (3:14; Jesus says "before Abraham was born, I am!" in John 8:58); the tabernacle (John 1:14); Moses as a rescuer and go-between for the people
Hand motion / picture	🚪 **Exit walk:** "walk" two fingers across your other palm and out the "door" (off the edge of your hand), like God's people walking out of Egypt.

Book 3: Leviticus

How to say it	luh-VIT-ih-kus
How to spell it	Le-vit-i-cus: **L-E-V-I-T-I-C-U-S** (4 claps)
Section	Law (book 3 of 5)
Traditional author	Moses
Chapters	27
One-sentence kid summary	God is holy (perfectly good and pure), and He showed His people how to come close to Him through priests, sacrifices and holy living.

In one word	**HOLY** (named after the tribe of **Levi**, the priests' tribe)
Key people	Moses, Aaron the high priest, Aaron's sons (including Nadab and Abihu), the priests and Levites
Key stories / teachings	Five kinds of offerings (1–7); priests begin their work (8–9); what's clean and unclean (11–15); the **Day of Atonement**, with one goat offered and the "scapegoat" sent away carrying sins (16); "Be holy because I, the LORD your God, am holy" (19:2); "Love your neighbor as yourself" (19:18); the yearly feasts (23); the Year of Jubilee (25)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus is our perfect sacrifice, once for all (Hebrews 10:10–14); Jesus is our great High Priest (Hebrews 4:14); like the scapegoat, He carries our sins away; Jesus called "love your neighbor as yourself" one of the two greatest commandments (Matthew 22:39)
Hand motion / picture	🙏 **Holy hands:** fold hands to pray, then raise them up high: "Be holy!"

Book 4: Numbers

How to say it	NUM-burz
How to spell it	Num-bers: **N-U-M-B-E-R-S** (2 claps)
Section	Law (book 4 of 5)
Traditional author	Moses
Chapters	36
One-sentence kid summary	God's people were counted and traveled through the wilderness, but because they didn't trust God they wandered for 40 years, and God still took care of them.
In one word	**WILDERNESS** (it's called "Numbers" because the people are counted twice; its Hebrew name means "In the Wilderness")
Key people	Moses, Aaron, Miriam, Joshua and Caleb, the 12 spies, Korah, Balaam (and his talking donkey!)
Key stories	The people counted (1, 26); the priestly blessing, "The LORD bless you and keep you" (6:24–26); the cloud and fire leading the way (9); 12 spies, 2 brave and 10 afraid (13–14); 40 years of wandering (14); Aaron's staff buds (17); water from the rock, and Moses disobeys (20); the **bronze snake** (21); Balaam's donkey talks (22)
Where Jesus shows up	The bronze snake lifted up (21:8–9; John 3:14–15); water from the rock ("that rock was Christ," 1 Corinthians 10:4); manna again (11); Balaam's prophecy: "A star will come out of Jacob" (24:17)
Hand motion / picture	🔢 **Counting fingers:** count "1, 2, 3, 4" on your fingers, then make your hand "wander" in a zig-zag.

Book 5: Deuteronomy

How to say it	doo-tuh-RON-uh-mee

How to spell it	Deu-ter-on-o-my: **D-E-U-T-E-R-O-N-O-M-Y** (5 claps)
Section	Law (book 5 of 5), the last book of the Law!
Traditional author	Moses (the last chapter, about Moses' death, was likely added by Joshua or another faithful writer)
Chapters	34
One-sentence kid summary	Before he died, Moses reminded God's people of everything God had done and taught them to love God with all their heart and obey Him in the new land.
In one word	**REMEMBER** ("Deuteronomy" means "second law," because Moses repeats God's law to a new generation)
Key people	Moses, Joshua, the new generation of Israelites
Key stories / teachings	Moses retells the journey (1–4); the Ten Commandments again (5); the **Shema**: "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one. Love the LORD your God..." (6:4–9); "Man does not live on bread alone" (8:3); "A prophet like me" (18:15); blessings and curses (27–28); "Choose life" (30:19); "Be strong and courageous... he will never leave you" (31:6); Joshua is chosen as the new leader (31); Moses sees the Promised Land from Mount Nebo and dies at 120 (34)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus is the "prophet like me" (18:15; Acts 3:22); Jesus quoted Deuteronomy three times when tempted by the devil (Matthew 4: Deuteronomy 8:3, 6:16, 6:13); Jesus called Deuteronomy 6:5 the greatest commandment (Matthew 22:37–38)
Hand motion / picture	✌️🧠 **Second law, remember:** hold up two fingers ("second"), then tap your head ("remember!") and put your hand on your heart ("love God!").

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher (plain adult language)

These four books continue straight on from Genesis. At the end of Genesis, Jacob's family (about 70 people) lives in Egypt. About 400 years later (Exodus 12:40 says 430 years), they've grown into a large nation, but a new Pharaoh has made them slaves.

- **Exodus** has two halves: **rescue** (chapters 1–18: Moses, plagues, Passover, Red Sea, wilderness) and **relationship** (19–40: God makes a covenant at Mount Sinai, gives the law, and comes to dwell in the tabernacle). The order matters: God rescues *first*, then gives the law. The law is not "how to earn God's love," it's "how to live as people God has already saved." Notice the first words of the Ten Commandments: "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of Egypt..." (Exodus 20:2).
- **Leviticus** answers a question raised at the end of Exodus: Moses couldn't even enter the tabernacle because of God's glory (Exodus 40:35). How can a holy God live among sinful people? Leviticus gives the answer through sacrifices (sin is serious; it costs a life, Leviticus 17:11), priests (go-betweens), and holiness in daily life. Chapter 16 (the Day of Atonement) is the heart of the book. Hebrews 9–10 explains how Jesus fulfills all of this.

- **Numbers** covers about 40 years in the wilderness. The first generation refused to enter the land after the spies' report (13–14), so they wandered until a new generation grew up. Themes: grumbling and unbelief versus God's patient faithfulness. Even Moses failed (20:12).
- **Deuteronomy** is Moses' farewell sermons on the plains of Moab, just before Israel enters Canaan. It calls a new generation to remember, love and obey. It's quoted often in the New Testament, especially by Jesus.

The Ten Commandments (kid version). *Note: Christian traditions number them slightly differently; this is the common Protestant numbering.*

1. Love God most: have no other gods. 2. Don't make idols to worship. 3. Use God's name with respect. 4. Keep the Sabbath day holy (rest and worship). 5. Honor your father and mother. 6. Don't murder. 7. Keep marriage promises (don't commit adultery). 8. Don't steal. 9. Don't lie about others. 10. Don't covet (be content with what you have).

Jesus summed them up as **love God** (1–4) and **love your neighbor** (5–10) (Matthew 22:37–40, quoting Deuteronomy 6:5 and Leviticus 19:18).

The ten plagues (in order): (1) water to blood, (2) frogs, (3) gnats, (4) flies, (5) livestock die, (6) boils, (7) hail, (8) locusts, (9) darkness, (10) death of the firstborn. Each showed God's power over Egypt's false gods (Exodus 12:12).

Key truths to emphasize

1. **God hears and rescues** His people (Exodus 2:24; 3:7).
2. **God's rules are good gifts** that show us how to love Him and others (Deuteronomy 10:13, "for your own good").
3. **God is holy**, and sin is serious, but God provides a way to come close (Leviticus 16–17).
4. **Grumbling and unbelief** are dangerous; trusting God brings blessing (Numbers 14).
5. **Love God with everything** and remember what He's done (Deuteronomy 6:4–9).
6. **Jesus is the true Passover Lamb, Bread of Life, perfect Sacrifice and greater Prophet.**

Timeline and map notes

- **Timeline:** Joseph's family in Egypt → about 400 years → slavery → Moses born → Moses flees to Midian (age 40, Acts 7:23) → burning bush → Exodus from Egypt (Moses about 80, Exodus 7:7). Traditional dating puts the exodus around 1446 BC (some scholars prefer around 1260 BC) → Mount Sinai (about 1 year) → 40 years wandering → Moses dies at 120 (Deuteronomy 34:7).
- **Map:** Egypt (Goshen in the Nile delta) → across the "Red Sea" (Hebrew *Yam Suph*, "Sea of Reeds"; exact location debated) → the Sinai wilderness → Mount Sinai (also called Horeb) → Kadesh Barnea (where the spies were sent from) → around Edom → the plains of Moab across the Jordan River from Jericho → Mount Nebo. Add these to your class timeline rope and wall map.

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers / Ambassadors (11–17)
Pharaoh's order to kill baby boys (Exodus 1)	"The mean king wanted to hurt the baby boys, but Moses' mommy hid him and God kept him safe."	Be honest but brief; highlight the brave midwives Shiphrah and Puah (1:15–21).	Discuss courage to disobey wicked commands; God's protection of His plan.
The 10th plague (firstborn deaths)	"The last sign was very sad for Egypt. But God's people put lamb's blood on their doors and were safe." Avoid graphic detail.	Explain Pharaoh's repeated refusals; God gave many chances. Emphasize the Passover lamb.	Discuss God's justice (Egypt had killed Israel's babies), Pharaoh's hard heart, and how the Passover points to the cross.
Egyptian army drowning	"The water came back and the army couldn't chase them anymore."	Honest summary; God fought for His people (14:14).	Discuss judgment and deliverance together; read the song in Exodus 15.
Golden calf consequences (32:27–28), Korah (Numbers 16), Nadab and Abihu (Leviticus 10)	Skip the deaths: "God's people did wrong, and Moses prayed for them."	Mention that sin had serious consequences, without detail.	Discuss God's holiness and why He takes worship seriously; Moses as intercessor (32:30–32).
Leviticus rules (skin diseases, bodily discharges, sexual laws)	Skip.	Summarize: "God gave rules about staying clean and healthy, and about being holy in every part of life."	Explain categories: some laws were for Israel's worship and identity (fulfilled in Jesus, Mark 7:19; Hebrews 8–10), while the moral heart (love God, love neighbor) continues. Keep specifics general.
Animal sacrifices	"People gave God a lamb to say sorry. Jesus is God's Lamb who takes away sin."	Explain simply that sin costs something; Jesus paid it all.	Discuss substitution and Hebrews 10:4, 10.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

- **"Why did God make Pharaoh's heart hard?"** Pharaoh hardened his own heart first, again and again (Exodus 8:15, 32). Eventually God confirmed the choice Pharaoh kept making. God gave him many chances.
- **"Do we still have to keep all the rules in Leviticus?"** Jesus fulfilled the sacrifices and the special worship rules (Hebrews 10:1, 10). But the heart of God's law, loving God and loving others, is still how we live, with the Holy Spirit's help.
- **"Why did people have to kill animals?"** To show that sin is really serious and causes death. Those sacrifices were like arrows pointing to Jesus, the final sacrifice. Now no more are needed!

- **"Why couldn't Moses go into the Promised Land?"** Moses disobeyed God by striking the rock instead of speaking to it, and he took credit (Numbers 20:8–12). God still let him see the land, and later Moses stood in the Promised Land with Jesus at the Transfiguration (Matthew 17:3)!
- **"Was the manna real food?"** Yes! It tasted like wafers made with honey (Exodus 16:31). God fed them every day for 40 years.
- **"Why did the people make a golden calf?"** They got impatient waiting for Moses and wanted a god they could see. People still do that with money, phones or popularity.
- **"Can a donkey really talk?"** God made the donkey speak (Numbers 22:28). The God who made donkeys can do that!
- **"Are the Ten Commandments still for us?"** Yes. They show us God's good way and show us we need Jesus because we break them. Jesus helps us obey from the heart.

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson title	Key point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
1	Exodus 1–15	**God Sets His People Free**	God heard His people's cry and rescued them from slavery, and the Passover lamb points to Jesus.	SharefaithKids "Moses"; BibleJourneyTV "Moses" / "Exodus"; BibleProject "Overview: Exodus 1-18"	Red Sea Crossing; Plague Pop-Up	Baby Moses Basket; Passover Door
2	Exodus 16–40	**God's Good Rules and God's Tent**	God feeds His people, gives good rules because He loves them, and comes to live with them.	SharefaithKids "Ten Commandments"; BibleJourneyTV "Ten Commandments"; BibleProject "Overview: Exodus 19-40" / "The Law"	Manna Gather; Ten Commandment Tower	Stone Tablets; Shoebox Tabernacle

Week	Passage	Lesson title	Key point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
3	Leviticus 16; 19:2, 18; Numbers 13–14; 21:4–9	**Holy God, Wandering People**	God is holy and gives a way to be forgiven; when we trust Him like Joshua and Caleb, we can be brave.	SharefaithKids "12 spies"; BibleJourneyTV "spies" / "wilderness"; BibleProject "Overview: Leviticus", "Overview: Numbers", "Holiness"	Spy Hunt for Grapes; Look and Live Tag	Giant Grape Cluster; Bronze Snake on a Pole
4	Deuteronomy 6:4–9; 30:19–20; 31:6–8; 34	**Remember and Love God**	Love God with all your heart and remember what He has done.	SharefaithKids "Moses"; BibleJourneyTV "Moses"; BibleProject "Overview: Deuteronomy"	Law Line-Up Relay	Heart-Door Scroll (Deuteronomy 6:9)
5 (optional)	Review Genesis–Deuteronomy	**Review & Fun Sunday**	I know all 5 books of the Law!	Class favorite	Law Game Show; Red Sea Relay Finals	Passport stamping + badge ceremony

Weekly Lessons

Week 1: God Sets His People Free 🔥🌊

Scripture: Exodus 1:8–2:10; 3:1–15; 7–12 (summary); 12:1–13; 14:10–31

Lesson goal: Kids will know that God saw His people's suffering, called Moses, defeated Pharaoh with ten plagues, saved His people through the Passover lamb, and opened the Red Sea, and that Jesus is our Passover Lamb who sets us free from sin.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Chains Off!"

- *Supplies:* A paper chain (or yarn loops) loosely around a volunteer's wrists; a red paper door frame taped around the classroom door.
- *Do:* "Imagine you had to work all day, every day, and never got to go home or play. That's what it was like for God's people in Egypt. They were slaves." Have the class shout "Let my people go!" and the volunteer breaks the paper chain. "God did that for His people, and Jesus does that for us when it comes to sin!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

Remember Joseph's family that moved to Egypt? Many, many years later, the family had grown HUGE, like the stars God promised Abraham! But a new Pharaoh (king) was afraid of them. He made them **slaves**, making bricks in the hot sun. He even ordered that the baby boys be thrown into the Nile River.

One mom hid her baby boy. When he got too big to hide, she made a basket, covered it with tar so it would float, and set it in the tall grass by the river. His big sister **Miriam** watched. Pharaoh's daughter found the baby, felt sorry for him, and adopted him! She named him **Moses**, which sounds like "drawn out of the water."

Moses grew up in the palace, but one day he ran away to the desert and became a shepherd. When he was 80 years old, he saw a **bush on fire, but it didn't burn up!** God spoke from the bush: "Moses! Take off your sandals, because this is holy ground. I have seen my people's misery. I've heard them crying. Go to Pharaoh and bring my people out!"

Moses said, "Who am I? And who should I say sent me?" God said, "**I AM WHO I AM.** Tell them I AM sent you." God promised to go with Moses, and Moses' brother **Aaron** went too.

Moses told Pharaoh, "**Let my people go!**" Pharaoh said NO. So God sent **ten plagues**: the river turned to blood, then came frogs, gnats, flies, sick animals, boils, hail, locusts and darkness. Every time, Pharaoh said no.

Then God told His people to get ready for the tenth and last plague. Each family took a perfect **lamb** and put its blood on the sides and top of their doorframe. That night, death came to the oldest son in every house in Egypt, but **passed over** every house with the lamb's blood. That's why it's called **Passover**. Finally, Pharaoh said, "GO!"

God led His people with a tall cloud by day and fire by night. But Pharaoh changed his mind and chased them with chariots! The people were trapped at the **Red Sea**. Moses said, "Don't be afraid! The LORD will fight for you." Moses raised his staff, and God sent a strong wind that **split the sea**, with walls of water on both sides! God's people walked through on **dry ground**. When Pharaoh's army followed, the waters came back down.

On the other side, Moses and Miriam sang and danced: "The LORD is my strength and my song!"

Jesus is our Passover Lamb. When we trust Him, His blood covers our sin and God's judgment passes over us. Jesus sets us free!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Act it out: crouch to hide baby Moses, say "Let my people go!", count plagues on fingers, then walk between two teachers holding up blue sheets ("walls of water"). Big takeaway: "God rescues!"
- **Explorers:** Have them list the 10 plagues in order with motions (see the Plague Pop-Up game). Read Exodus 12:13 in their Bibles: "When I see the blood, I will pass over you."
- **Trailblazers:** Discuss God's name "I AM" (Exodus 3:14) and Jesus' "I am" statements in John. Map the route out of Egypt. Ask why God rescued *before* giving the law.

- **Ambassadors:** Study 1 Corinthians 5:7 and John 1:29 alongside Exodus 12. Discuss Pharaoh's hardened heart and what it teaches about repeatedly saying no to God.

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Where did Moses' mom put baby Moses? (In a basket) (2) What did God talk from? (A burning bush) (3) What did God do to the sea? (Split it / opened a path)
- *Explorers:* (1) What did the families put on their doors? Why? (2) How many plagues were there? Name three. (3) When the people were trapped, what did Moses say? ("Don't be afraid; the LORD will fight for you.")
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Moses felt like he wasn't good enough ("Who am I?"). How did God answer? (2) Why do you think Pharaoh kept saying no? (3) How is the Passover lamb like Jesus?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) What does the name "I AM" tell us about God? (2) The plagues judged Egypt's false gods (12:12). What "gods" do people trust in today? (3) In what ways can someone be "free" on the outside but still a slave on the inside (John 8:34–36)?

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Moses" or "Passover" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Moses` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Moses" or "Exodus" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Moses` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Exodus 1-18" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Exodus` |

Teacher: preview every video first. Follow-up questions: (1) What did God do to rescue His people? (2) How does the Passover help us understand what Jesus did?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Red Sea Crossing* and *Plague Pop-Up*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Baby Moses Basket* (younger) or *Passover Door* (all). See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Introduce Deuteronomy 6:5 (Little Lambs: "Love the LORD your God."). Spell **E-X-O-D-U-S**; Trailblazers: **P-A-S-S-O-V-E-R**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> God, You heard Your people crying, and You set them free. Thank You that Jesus is our Passover Lamb who sets us free from sin. Help us not be afraid, because You fight for us. Amen.

Week 2: God's Good Rules and God's Tent ⛰️📜

Scripture: Exodus 16:1–31; 17:1–7; 19:16–20:17; 32:1–20; 40:34–38

Lesson goal: Kids will know that God provided food and water in the wilderness, gave the Ten Commandments as good gifts, forgave His people after the golden calf, and came to live among them in the tabernacle.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Rules for Our Good"

- *Supplies:* A board game with its rule sheet, or a picture of a playground with a fence near a busy road.
- *Do:* "What would happen if we played this game with no rules?" (Chaos! Fights!) "What's the fence by the road for?" (To keep kids safe.) "God's rules are like the fence. They're not there to stop our fun. They're there because God loves us and wants us safe and happy with Him."

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> After crossing the Red Sea, God's people walked into the desert. Soon they started **grumbling**: "We're hungry! We had more food in Egypt!" But God was kind. He said, "I will rain down bread from heaven." The next morning the ground was covered with thin white flakes. The people said, "**Manna?**" which means "What is it?" It tasted like wafers made with honey. Every morning God sent manna, enough for each day, and on the sixth day enough for two days so they could rest on the Sabbath. God also sent quail (birds) for meat and water out of a rock!
>
> Then they came to **Mount Sinai**. The mountain shook! There was thunder, lightning, smoke, and a trumpet blast that got louder and louder. God came down on the mountain and spoke to His people. God said, "I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of Egypt." *(I rescued you, so here's how to live as My people.)*
>
> Then God gave **Ten Commandments**:
>
> 1. Love God most. 2. Don't make idols. 3. Respect God's name. 4. Keep the Sabbath holy. 5. Honor your parents. 6. Don't murder. 7. Keep marriage promises. 8. Don't steal. 9. Don't lie. 10. Don't want what belongs to others.
>
> God wrote them on **two stone tablets**. Moses stayed on the mountain with God for 40 days and 40 nights.
>
> But down at the bottom, the people got tired of waiting. They asked Aaron to make them a god. Aaron melted their gold earrings and made a **golden calf**, and they bowed down to it! When Moses came down and saw it, he was so upset that he threw down the tablets and they broke. The people had broken God's first two rules already.
>
> But Moses prayed for the people, and God **forgave** them. God gave the commandments on new tablets. God told Moses, "I am compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, abounding in love."
>
> Then God said, "Build Me a special tent, a **tabernacle**, so I can live among you." Everyone brought gifts. When it was finished, a cloud covered the tent and **God's glory filled it**. God was living right in the middle of His people!
>
> Years later, God came to live with people in an even closer way. Jesus was born and "made his dwelling among us" (John 1:14). And nobody kept God's rules perfectly, except Jesus. He kept them for us and died for every time we've broken them.

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Teach five easy rule motions: love God (point up), tell the truth (finger to lips, then open hand), don't take (hands behind back), honor parents (bow), rest (pillow hands). Toss white cotton-ball "manna."
- **Explorers:** Learn the Ten Commandments with finger numbers. Talk about which ones are about loving God (1–4) and which are about loving others (5–10).
- **Trailblazers:** Discuss why the law came *after* rescue. Compare the golden calf to modern idols. Look at Exodus 34:6–7, God's description of Himself.
- **Ambassadors:** Read Matthew 5:21–28 (Jesus on the heart behind the commands) and Galatians 3:24 (the law leads us to Christ). Discuss: if no one can keep the law perfectly, why did God give it?

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What food did God send from heaven? (Manna) (2) Where did God give His rules? (On a mountain) (3) Who lived in the special tent? (God!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What does "manna" mean? (2) Which commandment do you think is hardest for kids? Why? (3) Why did the people make a golden calf?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) The people grumbled even after amazing miracles. Why do we forget God's goodness so fast? (2) How are God's rules "for our good"? Give an example. (3) What did Moses do after the golden calf, and what does that show about him?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) What's an "idol" in today's world? How can a good thing become a god? (2) How does Jesus' summary (love God, love neighbor) help us understand all ten? (3) The tabernacle was God's way of living among His people. Where does God live now (1 Corinthians 3:16)?

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Ten Commandments" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Ten+Commandments` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Ten Commandments" or "manna" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Ten+Commandments` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Exodus 19-40"; theme video "The Law" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Exodus+19-40` |

Preview first. Follow-up questions: (1) Why did God give His people rules? (2) What did the tabernacle show about God?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Manna Gather* and *Ten Commandment Tower*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Stone Tablets* (all) and *Shoebox Tabernacle* (older). See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Deuteronomy 6:5 first half. Review Genesis and Exodus. Spell **M-A-N-N-A**, **S-I-N-A-I**; Trailblazers: **T-A-B-E-R-N-A-C-L-E**, **C-O-M-M-A-N-D-M-E-N-T**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Thank You, God, for giving us good rules because You love us. Forgive us when we break them,

> and thank You that Jesus kept them for us. Help us love You most and love others well. Amen.

Week 3: Holy God, Wandering People 🐐🍇🐍

Scripture: Leviticus 16:1–22 (Day of Atonement); 19:2, 18; Numbers 13:1–14:35; 21:4–9

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that God is holy and provided a way for sins to be forgiven (sacrifice and the Day of Atonement), and that the people's lack of trust led to 40 years of wandering while Joshua and Caleb trusted God, and that Jesus is our perfect sacrifice, lifted up like the bronze snake.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Clean Hands"

- *Supplies:* A clear glass of clean water and a few drops of iodine (from a pharmacy), plus a crushed vitamin C tablet. Vitamin C turns iodine-tinted water clear again. *(Do a test run first, and keep the iodine away from little hands.)* Simpler option: a white T-shirt with a ketchup stain and a stain-remover pen.
- *Do:* "God is holy. That means He is perfectly pure, like this clean water. Our sin is like this iodine. Just a few drops change everything!" Add the iodine. "Can the water get clean by itself? No. But God provides a way." (Stir in the vitamin C until the water clears, or use the stain-remover.) "In Leviticus, God gave sacrifices to cover sin. Now Jesus makes us clean all the way!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> God's people were camped around the tabernacle, God's special tent. But there was a problem. God is **holy**, perfectly good, pure and bright, and people are sinful. How could they come near God?
>
> In the book of **Leviticus**, God gave the answer. He chose Aaron and his sons to be **priests**, helpers who went between God and the people. When people sinned, they brought an animal, like a lamb or a goat, as a **sacrifice**. It showed that sin is very serious, but God would forgive.
>
> Once a year was a super-important day called the **Day of Atonement**. The high priest took two goats. One goat was offered to God for the people's sins. Then the high priest put his hands on the head of the second goat and confessed all the people's sins over it. That goat, the **scapegoat**, was sent far away into the wilderness, as if carrying their sins away! God also told His people, "**Be holy, because I am holy**," and "**Love your neighbor as yourself.**"
>
> Then it was time to travel to the Promised Land. In the book of **Numbers**, Moses sent **12 spies** to check out the land of Canaan. They came back carrying a bunch of grapes so big that two men had to carry it on a pole! "The land is amazing!" they said. "But... the people there are giants. We felt like grasshoppers!" Ten spies said, "We can't do it."
>
> But two spies, **Joshua** and **Caleb**, said, "The land is very good! If the LORD is pleased with us, He will lead us in. Don't be afraid!" Sadly, the people listened to the ten scared spies. They cried and even wanted to go back to Egypt.

> Because they didn't trust God, God said that grown-up generation would wander in the wilderness for **40 years**, until their children were ready. Only Joshua and Caleb from that generation would enter the land.
>
> Even in the wilderness, God took care of them. But once, the people grumbled again and poisonous snakes came into the camp. People were getting bitten! God told Moses, "Make a snake out of bronze and put it up on a pole. Anyone who is bitten can **look at it and live**." And everyone who looked, lived!
>
> Jesus said, "Just as Moses lifted up the snake in the wilderness, so the Son of Man must be lifted up, that everyone who believes may have eternal life" (John 3:14–15). When we look to Jesus on the cross and trust Him, we are saved. Jesus is our perfect sacrifice; He carries our sins away forever!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on two pictures: big grapes (Joshua and Caleb were brave: "God is with us!") and the snake on the pole ("Look and live!"). Have them practice brave voices: "Don't be afraid! God is with us!"
- **Explorers:** Act out the spy report: 10 kids crouch like grasshoppers; 2 stand tall. Read Numbers 14:9 together. Explain the scapegoat with a "sins" sticky-note on a toy goat that gets carried out of the room.
- **Trailblazers:** Compare the Day of Atonement with Hebrews 9:11–14 and 10:11–14. Discuss: why did fear spread so quickly among the people? Look at the 40 days of spying versus the 40 years of wandering (Numbers 14:34).
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss holiness: not just "rules" but being set apart for God in every area. Read Leviticus 19 and notice how practical it is (care for the poor, honesty, the deaf and blind, foreigners). Discuss trusting God when "giants" are real.

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What fruit did the spies bring back? (Grapes!) (2) Which two spies were brave? (Joshua and Caleb) (3) What did people do to get better from snake bites? (Look at the snake on the pole)
- *Explorers:* (1) What does "holy" mean? (2) Why were 10 spies afraid? (3) How is the snake on the pole like Jesus?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) What was the scapegoat a picture of? (2) What "giants" (big scary problems) do kids face today? What would Joshua and Caleb say? (3) Why did God make the people wait 40 years?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Leviticus 19:18 says "love your neighbor as yourself." Why is it significant that this command sits in a book full of holiness laws? (2) How does Hebrews describe Jesus as better than the high priests? (3) Grumbling is a big theme in Numbers. Why does God take grumbling so seriously?

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "12 spies" or "Joshua and Caleb" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=spies` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers,

Trailblazers | "spies" or "wilderness" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=spies` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Leviticus" and "Overview: Numbers"; theme videos "Holiness" and "Sacrifice and Atonement" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Leviticus` and `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Numbers` |

Preview first. With limited time, show Leviticus one week and Numbers in the review week. Follow-up questions: (1) What does it mean that God is holy? (2) What did Joshua and Caleb believe that the other spies didn't?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Spy Hunt for Grapes* and *Look and Live Tag*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Giant Grape Cluster* and *Bronze Snake on a Pole*. See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Deuteronomy 6:5 whole verse (Explorers+). Spell **L-E-V-I-T-I-C-U-S** (syllable-clap: Le-vit-i-cus) and **N-U-M-B-E-R-S**. Trailblazers: **H-O-L-Y**, **S-A-C-R-I-F-I-C-E**, **A-T-O-N-E-M-E-N-T**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Holy God, You are perfectly good, and we need You to make us clean. Thank You that Jesus was lifted up on the cross so we can look to Him and live. Make us brave like Joshua and Caleb, trusting You with our giants. Amen.

Week 4: Remember and Love God ❤️

Scripture: Deuteronomy 6:4–9; 8:2–3; 30:19–20; 31:6–8; 34:1–12

Lesson goal: Kids will learn Moses' final message: love God with all your heart, remember what He has done, teach it to your children, and choose life, and that God was faithful to Moses to the very end.

Opening hook / object lesson: "String on Your Finger"

- *Supplies:* Yarn pieces to tie around each child's finger; sticky notes.
- *Do:* "What do people do to remember important things?" (Sticky notes, alarms, a string on a finger.) Tie a yarn on each finger. "Before Moses died, he said: Don't forget God! Remember all He did! Write His words on your doorframes, talk about them at home, when you walk and when you go to bed."

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> After 40 years in the wilderness, God's people were finally camped right next to the Promised Land, just across the Jordan River. The old, grumbling generation was gone. Their children were grown up now, ready to go in.
>
> Moses was 120 years old. He knew he wouldn't go into the land with them. So he gathered everyone together and gave them some of the most important speeches in the whole Bible. That's

> the book of **Deuteronomy**, which means "second law," because Moses repeated God's law to the new generation.
>
> Moses said: "**Remember!** Remember how God brought you out of Egypt. Remember how He fed you with manna for 40 years. Your clothes didn't even wear out! God was teaching you that people don't live on bread alone, but on every word that comes from the mouth of the LORD."
>
> Then Moses said the most important words of all: "**Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one. Love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength.**" God's people call this the **Shema** (shuh-MAH), which means "Hear!"
>
> "Keep God's words in your hearts," Moses said. "Teach them to your children. Talk about them when you sit at home, when you walk along the road, when you lie down and when you get up. Write them on the doorframes of your houses!"
>
> Moses told them, "I have set before you life and death. Now **choose life**, so that you and your children may live, and that you may love the LORD your God and listen to Him."
>
> Then Moses called **Joshua** in front of everyone. "Be strong and courageous! The LORD Himself goes before you and will be with you. He will **never leave you**." Joshua would be the new leader.
>
> Finally, God took Moses up to the top of **Mount Nebo**. From there, God showed him the whole Promised Land, the land He had promised to Abraham, Isaac and Jacob. Then Moses died, and God Himself buried him. The Bible says there was never another prophet like Moses, who knew the LORD face to face.
>
> But God had promised a greater Prophet who would come someday. When Jesus was asked, "What is the greatest commandment?" He answered with Moses' words: "Love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind." Jesus loved God perfectly, for us, and He helps us love God too.

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Teach "Love the LORD your God" with motions: point up (LORD), hands on heart (love), arms around self (all of me!). Practice "Remember!" by tapping heads.
- **Explorers:** Memorize the whole Shema (Deuteronomy 6:4–5). Make a list of "things God has done for my family" to remember.
- **Trailblazers:** Look up Jesus' three temptation answers in Matthew 4 and find each in Deuteronomy (8:3; 6:16; 6:13). Discuss what it means to "choose life."
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss "heart, soul, strength" (all of you). How do Christians "write God's words on doorframes" today? Plan how they will help pass faith to younger kids (they're doing it this year!).

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Who should we love most? (God!) (2) How old was Moses? (120, very old!) (3) Who was the new leader after Moses? (Joshua)

- *Explorers:* (1) What does "Deuteronomy" mean? (2) Where did Moses tell people to talk about God's words? (3) What's one thing God has done for you that you want to remember?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why did Moses repeat the law to the new generation? (2) Why did Jesus use Deuteronomy against the devil? What does that teach us? (3) What does it look like to love God with your strength?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Deuteronomy says God's commands are "not too difficult" and "very near you" (30:11–14). Paul applies this to the gospel in Romans 10:6–10. What's the connection? (2) What would a home look like where God's words are talked about "when you walk along the road"? (3) Moses didn't get to enter the land, but he was faithful. How do you define success?

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Moses" or "greatest commandment" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=greatest+commandment` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Moses" or "Deuteronomy" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Moses` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Deuteronomy"; Shema-related word study "Love" or "Shema" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Deuteronomy` |

Preview first. Follow-up questions: (1) What was Moses' most important message? (2) How can our family "remember" God every day?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Law Line-Up Relay*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Heart-Door Scroll*. See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Say Deuteronomy 6:5 from memory. Spell **D-E-U-T-E-R-O-N-O-M-Y** (syllable-clap: Deu-ter-on-o-my). Say all 5 books of the Law in order!

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Lord our God, we want to love You with all our heart, soul and strength. Help us remember everything You've done for us. Thank You for Jesus, who loved You perfectly and loves us forever. Amen.

Week 5 (optional): Review & Fun Sunday 🎉

Use the **End-of-Phase Review & Celebration** plan below.

Book Memory Song & Motions 🎵

This phase's song **adds on** to Phase 1. Always start from the beginning!

Part A (review from Phase 1): "The Bible Library Song" (tune: *Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star*)

> 🎵 Sixty-six books, one big story, / All about God and all His glory! / Thirty-nine are in the Old, / Twenty-seven New, we're told. / Sixty-six books, one big story, / All about God and all His glory!

Part B (NEW): "The Law Song" (tune: *Ten Little Fingers*, the "one little, two little, three little..." counting tune)

> 🎵 **Gen-e-sis, Ex-o-dus, Le-vit-i-cus,** *(sunrise hands → exit walk → holy hands)* **Num-bers and Deu-ter-on-o-my,** *(counting fingers → two fingers, tap head, hand on heart)* **God gave His Word to Mo-ses,** *(two hands flat like stone tablets, lifted up)* **Five books of the LAW!** *(hold up 5 fingers and stomp on "LAW!")*

Verse 2 (spelling verse, same tune, slower):

> 🎵 **E-X-O-D-U-S, Exodus!** *(exit walk)* **L-E-V-I-T-I-C-U-S!** *(holy hands)* **N-U-M-B-E-R-S, Numbers,** *(counting fingers)* **D-E-U-T, Deuteronomy!** *(two fingers, head, heart)*

(Verse 2 lets kids practice the start of "Deuteronomy" in rhythm; spell the whole word, D-E-U-T-E-R-O-N-O-M-Y, in the clap drill below.)

Verse 3 (story verse, same tune):

> 🎵 **Out of Egypt, through the sea,** *(exit walk, then part the waters with both hands)* **God gave rules for you and me,** *(tablets)* **Wandered forty years, then heard:** *(zig-zag hand, cup ear)* **"Love God with all your heart!"** *(hands on heart)*

Hand motions for each book

Book	Motion	Say
Genesis	🌅 Sunrise hands: open your "book" hands, sweep arms up like the sun	"Beginning!"
Exodus	🚪 Two fingers walk across your palm and out the "door"	"Exit! Rescue!"
Leviticus	🙏 Fold hands, then raise them high	"Be holy!"
Numbers	🔢 Count 1-2-3-4 on fingers, then zig-zag your hand	"Count and wander!"
Deuteronomy	✌️🧠❤️ Two fingers up, tap your head, hand on your heart	"Second law: remember, love God!"

Section Shout

> **Teacher:** "What's the first section of the Bible?" **Kids:** "**LAW!**" *(stomp)* **Teacher:** "How many books?" **Kids:** "**FIVE!**" *(hold up 5 fingers)* **Teacher:** "Name them!" **Kids:** "**Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy!** Five books of LAW! (Some people call it the **Pentateuch**, *PEN-tuh-took*, 'five scrolls'!)" *(Older kids add the last line.)*

Cumulative recall drill

1. Sing Part A, then Part B (verse 1).
2. **Fist count:** the teacher holds up a fist and raises one finger at a time; kids say the next book on each finger.
3. **What's missing?** Say the five books but skip one ("Genesis, Exodus, ___, Numbers, Deuteronomy"). Kids shout the missing book.
4. **Backward challenge (Explorers+):** Deuteronomy, Numbers, Leviticus, Exodus, Genesis!
5. **One-word round:** teacher says the book, kids say its one word (Genesis: Beginnings, Exodus: Rescue, Leviticus: Holy, Numbers: Wilderness, Deuteronomy: Remember).
6. Bible facts from Phase 1: 66 / 39 / 27; big number = chapter, little number = verse.

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Aim for the motions plus the words Genesis, Exodus, Numbers. Leviticus and Deuteronomy can be "sing along." Celebrate any attempt!
- **Explorers:** Say all 5 in order and spell Exodus and Numbers on their own; Leviticus and Deuteronomy with the clap method.
- **Trailblazers:** Say all 5 forwards and backwards plus the one word for each; learn "Pentateuch."
- **Ambassadors:** Lead the song for the younger classes. Learn the Shema (Deuteronomy 6:4–5) by heart.

Spelling & Reading 🔤

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letters and sounds)	Explorers (book names and story words)	Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocab)	Ambassadors (book names + harder vocab)
E is for **E**xodus and **E**gypt	GENESIS	GENESIS	GENESIS
L is for **L**eviticus and **L**amb	EXODUS	EXODUS	EXODUS
N is for **N**umbers	LEVITICUS	LEVITICUS	LEVITICUS

Little Lambs (letters and sounds)	Explorers (book names and story words)	Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocab)	Ambassadors (book names + harder vocab)
D is for **D**euteronomy	NUMBERS	NUMBERS	NUMBERS
M is for **M**oses and **M**anna	DEUTERONOMY	DEUTERONOMY	DEUTERONOMY
Sound it out: *Ex-o-dus*	MOSES	**Vocab:** PASSOVER, PLAGUE, TABERNACLE, HOLY, WILDERNESS	**Vocab:** PENTATEUCH, ATONEMENT, COVENANT, SACRIFICE, SHEMA
Trace: L-A-W	MANNA, SINAI		

Ambassadors vocab with definitions:

- **Pentateuch** (PEN-tuh-took): Greek for "five scrolls"; the first five books of the Bible (also called the Torah, Hebrew for "instruction" or "law").
- **Atonement:** making things right between God and people by dealing with sin; the Day of Atonement (Leviticus 16) points to Jesus' death.
- **Covenant:** a binding promise-relationship; at Sinai, God made a covenant with Israel (Exodus 19:5–6; 24:7–8).
- **Sacrifice:** an offering given to God; in Leviticus, an animal's life given in place of the sinner's (17:11). Jesus is the final sacrifice (Hebrews 10:12).
- **Shema** (shuh-MAH): Hebrew for "Hear!"; Deuteronomy 6:4–5, the central confession of Israel's faith.

The syllable-clap method 👏

Word	Claps	Parts → letters
Exodus	3	Ex (E-X) · o (O) · dus (D-U-S)
Leviticus	4	Le (L-E) · vit (V-I-T) · i (I) · cus (C-U-S)
Numbers	2	Num (N-U-M) · bers (B-E-R-S)
Deuteronomy	5	Deu (D-E-U) · ter (T-E-R) · on (O-N) · o (O) · my (M-Y)
Tabernacle	4	Tab (T-A-B) · er (E-R) · nac (N-A-C) · le (L-E)

Tip for Deuteronomy: "**Deu**-ter" starts with **D-E-U** (not D-O-O!). Remember "**DEU**ce = two," as in second law.

"Spell It Out" relay

- Same setup as Phase 1 (teams, letter cards at the far wall).
- **Phase 2 twist, "Red Sea Relay":** lay two long blue streamers on the floor as "walls of water." Kids must run *between* them to grab letters. Touching the "water" means going back to the start!

- **Words:** EXODUS, NUMBERS, MOSES, MANNA (Explorers); LEVITICUS, DEUTERONOMY, PASSOVER (Trailblazers); PENTATEUCH, ATONEMENT (Ambassadors).
- **Little Lambs:** find the first letter of each Law book: G, E, L, N, D.

Mini spelling bee word list (with sentences)

Word	Use it in a sentence
Exodus	In *Exodus*, God rescued His people from Egypt.
Leviticus	*Leviticus* teaches that God is holy.
Numbers	The book of *Numbers* tells about 40 years in the wilderness.
Deuteronomy	*Deuteronomy* is the fifth book of the Law.
Moses	God spoke to *Moses* from a burning bush.
Pharaoh	*Pharaoh* would not let God's people go.
plague	The first *plague* turned the Nile into blood.
Passover	At *Passover*, the lamb's blood was on the doorframes.
manna	God fed His people *manna* every morning.
Sinai	God gave the Ten Commandments on Mount *Sinai*.
tabernacle	God's glory filled the *tabernacle*.
wilderness	They wandered in the *wilderness* for 40 years.
sacrifice	Jesus is the perfect *sacrifice* for our sins.
atonement	The high priest went into the Most Holy Place on the Day of *Atonement*.
Pentateuch	The *Pentateuch* is the first five books of the Bible.

Read-aloud practice passage (Deuteronomy 6:4–9, NIV)

> "Hear, O Israel: The LORD our God, the LORD is one. Love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength. These commandments that I give you today are to be on your hearts. Impress them on your children. Talk about them when you sit at home and when you walk along the road, when you lie down and when you get up. Tie them as symbols on your hands and bind them on your foreheads. Write them on the doorframes of your houses and on your gates."

Reading tips: "LORD" in capital letters stands for God's personal name (Yahweh, "I AM"; see Exodus 3:14–15). "Impress" here means "press deeply into," like making a footprint in wet sand. Have kids read it in four voices (girls, boys, teachers, everyone) line by line.

Word Trivia ❓

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. Where did baby Moses' mother put him?
2. What did God speak from to call Moses?
3. **Who said it?** "Let my people go!"
4. What did God do to the Red Sea?
5. What food did God send from heaven?
6. How many commandments did God give?
7. **True or False:** The golden calf was a good idea.
8. What did the spies carry back on a pole?
9. Which two spies were brave?
10. **Fill in the blank:** "Love the LORD your _____."
11. How many books are in the Law?
12. Who was Moses' brother?

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

13. Name the 5 books of the Law in order.
14. What does "manna" mean?
15. What did the Israelites put on their doorframes at the first Passover?
16. On what mountain did God give the Ten Commandments?
17. **Which book?** The Day of Atonement and the scapegoat are found in which book?
18. How many years did God's people wander in the wilderness?
19. What did Moses make so that bitten people could look and live?
20. **Who said it?** "Who am I that I should go to Pharaoh?"
21. **True or False:** Moses entered the Promised Land.
22. What does "Exodus" mean?
23. Who became the leader after Moses?

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

24. What name did God give for Himself at the burning bush?
25. Name the 10 plagues in order.
26. What does "Deuteronomy" mean, and why does it have that name?
27. **Fill in the blank:** "Be _____ because I, the LORD your God, am _____." (Leviticus 19:2)
28. Which verses from Deuteronomy did Jesus quote when He was tempted in the wilderness?
29. What does "Shema" mean?
30. **Who said it?** "We should go up and take possession of the land, for we can certainly do it." (Numbers 13:30)
31. On what mountain did Moses die, and how old was he?
32. **Which book?** "The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face shine on you..." is found in which book?
33. Why wasn't Moses allowed to enter the Promised Land?

34. What does "Pentateuch" mean?
35. Which New Testament verse calls Jesus "our Passover lamb"?

🔑 Answer Key

1. In a basket in the tall reeds of the Nile River · 2. A burning bush · 3. Moses (and Aaron) to Pharaoh · 4. Split it / made a dry path through it · 5. Manna · 6. Ten · 7. False · 8. A huge cluster of grapes · 9. Joshua and Caleb · 10. God · 11. Five · 12. Aaron
2. Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy · 14. "What is it?" · 15. A lamb's blood · 16. Mount Sinai · 17. Leviticus (chapter 16) · 18. 40 · 19. A bronze snake on a pole · 20. Moses (Exodus 3:11) · 21. False (he saw it from Mount Nebo) · 22. "Going out" / "exit" · 23. Joshua
3. "I AM WHO I AM" (Exodus 3:14) · 25. Blood, frogs, gnats, flies, livestock, boils, hail, locusts, darkness, death of the firstborn · 26. "Second law"; Moses repeated the law to a new generation · 27. holy / holy · 28. Deuteronomy 8:3, 6:16, 6:13 · 29. "Hear!" · 30. Caleb · 31. Mount Nebo; 120 years old · 32. Numbers (6:24–26) · 33. He disobeyed by striking the rock instead of speaking to it, and didn't honor God as holy (Numbers 20:8–12) · 34. "Five scrolls" · 35. 1 Corinthians 5:7

Games 🎮

(More games and variations: `../00-start-here/game-library.md`)

1. Red Sea Crossing

- **Best for:** All ages.
- **Supplies:** Two long blue sheets, tablecloths or streamers (the "walls of water"); two adult or Ambassador helpers; a "Pharaoh" (a teacher wearing a paper crown).
- **Setup:** "Egypt" at one end of the room, "dry land" at the other, the sea in the middle. Helpers hold the sheets low across the middle (the sea is "closed").
- **How to play:** Ask a review question. When it's answered correctly, the helpers lift the sheets up to make walls ("God opened the sea!"), and all the kids run through to dry land before "Pharaoh" can tag them. When kids are across, the helpers drop the walls. Repeat back the other way.
- **How to win:** Kids who make it across safely shout "The LORD will fight for you!" (Exodus 14:14). Tagged kids become Pharaoh's helpers until the next round.
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* no tagging, just walk through as the "walls" rise, and sing. *Older kids:* they must name a Law book in order before the walls open.
- **Learning goal:** The Red Sea rescue; trusting God.

2. Plague Pop-Up

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers (Little Lambs with a leader).
- **Supplies:** 10 picture cards (one per plague).
- **Setup:** Teach a motion for each plague: (1) blood: wiggle red fingers like a river; (2) frogs: hop; (3) gnats: scratch; (4) flies: buzz and swat; (5) livestock: moo and fall over; (6) boils: "ouch!" on your arms; (7) hail: hands bounce down from the sky; (8) locusts: munch munch; (9) darkness:

cover your eyes; (10) firstborn: everyone kneels quietly, and then a leader holds up a red "lamb's blood" door sign and all stand: "Passed over!"

- **How to play:** Kids sit on the floor. The leader flips a card or calls a number. Kids "pop up" and do the motion. Speed up as you go. For a challenge round, call numbers out of order.
- **How to win:** Last one to do the correct motion sits out one round as the "plague caller."
- **Adaptation:** *Older kids:* say each plague in order without cards. *Ambassadors:* match each plague to the Egyptian god it challenged (for example the Nile god Hapi, the frog goddess Heqet, the sun god Ra).
- **Learning goal:** The 10 plagues in order; God's power over false gods.

3. Manna Gather

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers.
- **Supplies:** Lots of cotton balls or white pom-poms (or packing peanuts) scattered across the floor; a small cup per child.
- **Setup:** Scatter the "manna" before kids enter the room (or while they cover their eyes: "It's nighttime!").
- **How to play:** "Morning!" Kids gather manna, but each child can gather only enough to fill their cup once (Exodus 16:16–18). Next round: "It's day six! Gather two cups!" Then: "Sabbath! Rest!" Everyone lies down; no gathering allowed.
- **How to win:** Everyone who obeyed the rules gets a real snack (such as honey graham crackers or vanilla wafers, "like wafers made with honey"). *Check allergies first!*
- **Adaptation:** *Older kids:* hide a few "rotten" (brown) pom-poms; anyone who grabbed more than a cup must take those too (16:20).
- **Learning goal:** God provides daily; trust and obedience.

4. Ten Commandment Tower

- **Best for:** All ages.
- **Supplies:** 10 plastic or paper cups per team, numbered 1–10 (or labeled with the commandments for older kids), a ball for knocking towers down at the end.
- **Setup:** Teams line up at a table.
- **How to play:** Each child in turn says one commandment (or one Law book, for younger kids) and adds a cup to the tower (base of 4, then 3, 2, 1). When the tower is complete, the team says all ten together.
- **How to win:** First team with a complete pyramid and all ten said correctly. Bonus fun: the leader rolls a ball to knock the tower down: "The golden calf broke God's law, but God forgave and gave the commands again!" Rebuild.
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* stack cups while saying "Love God! Love people!" *Ambassadors:* sort into "love God" (1–4) and "love neighbor" (5–10) towers.
- **Learning goal:** Learning the Ten Commandments; God's law is good.

5. Spy Hunt for Grapes

- **Best for:** All ages.

- **Supplies:** 30–40 purple paper "grapes" hidden around the room; about 10 green paper "giant" cards hidden too; two paper towel tubes taped into a "pole."
- **Setup:** Split the class into "tribes" of up to 12 spies each.
- **How to play:** Spies search for grapes. Each grape found = 1 point. If you find a "giant" card, you must shout "God is with us! Don't be afraid!" (Numbers 14:9) to keep the card for 3 bonus points. If you just hide it again, it's no points.
- **How to win:** The tribe with the most points, carried back together on their "pole," wins.
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* find grapes, no giants. *Older kids:* each grape has a trivia question on the back that must be answered to score.
- **Learning goal:** Joshua and Caleb's faith; courage in God.

6. Look and Live Tag

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers.
- **Supplies:** A pool noodle or broom with a pipe-cleaner "bronze snake" on top; 2–3 "snake" taggers (with green armbands).
- **Setup:** Open space. One leader stands still holding the pole as "Moses."
- **How to play:** Snakes tag players. A tagged player freezes and holds their arm like it's "bitten." To unfreeze, they must turn and **look** at the bronze snake pole while saying "Look and live!" (Numbers 21:8). Moses may move the pole around so frozen kids have to find it.
- **How to win:** After 2 minutes, count frozen players. Rotate taggers. End by reading John 3:14–15.
- **Adaptation:** *Ambassadors:* run the game for younger kids and give the gospel connection at the end.
- **Learning goal:** The bronze snake and how it points to Jesus on the cross.

7. Law Line-Up Relay

- **Best for:** All ages.
- **Supplies:** For each team, 5 large cards: GENESIS, EXODUS, LEVITICUS, NUMBERS, DEUTERONOMY (shuffled), at the far wall.
- **Setup:** Teams of 5 (or groups that rotate).
- **How to play:** On "Go!" each runner brings back one card. Once all 5 are back, the team lines up **in order** holding the cards and sings Part B of the song.
- **How to win:** First team in correct order wins. Second round: line up *backwards*. Third round: cards show the one-word summaries (Beginnings, Rescue, Holy, Wilderness, Remember) instead of names.
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* cards have the book picture (sunrise, door, praying hands, numbers, heart); a teacher helps line up. *Ambassadors:* add the 3 Phase 3 books as a sneak peek.
- **Learning goal:** The 5 books of the Law in order.

Coloring Pages 🖍️

> Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-02-`

```
printables.html
```

Page 1: The Burning Bush (Week 1)

- **Scene:** Moses kneeling barefoot (sandals beside him) before a bush with bright flames, the bush still green; sheep grazing nearby; a mountain behind.
- **Caption:** *"I AM WHO I AM." Exodus 3:14*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Why did Moses take off his sandals? What colors will you use for the fire? God called Moses even though he felt afraid. What might God call you to do?"

Page 2: Crossing the Red Sea (Week 1)

- **Scene:** Two tall walls of water with fish visible inside; a dry path down the middle with families, children, sheep and carts walking; Moses at the front holding his staff up; a pillar of cloud/fire behind them.
- **Caption:** *"The LORD will fight for you; you need only to be still." Exodus 14:14*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Can you draw some fish in the walls? How do you think the people felt walking through? When do you need God to fight for you?"

Page 3: Mount Sinai and the Two Tablets (Week 2)

- **Scene:** A big mountain with smoke and lightning at the top; Moses coming down holding two stone tablets with Roman numerals I–X; the camp of tents at the bottom.
- **Caption:** *"I am the LORD your God, who brought you out of Egypt." Exodus 20:2*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Which commandment is about honoring parents? Why did God remind them that He rescued them first?"

Page 4: The Tabernacle with the Cloud (Week 2)

- **Scene:** The rectangular courtyard with curtains, the bronze altar, and the tent in the center; a cloud resting on top of the tent; the tribes' tents arranged around it.
- **Caption:** *"The glory of the LORD filled the tabernacle." Exodus 40:34*
- **Coloring conversation:** "God wanted to live with His people! Where does God live now if you trust Jesus? (In your heart, by His Holy Spirit.)"

Page 5: Joshua and Caleb with the Giant Grapes (Week 3)

- **Scene:** Two men carrying a pole on their shoulders with an enormous cluster of grapes hanging in the middle; a beautiful green land behind them; in the distance a big walled city.
- **Caption:** *"The LORD is with us. Do not be afraid." Numbers 14:9*
- **Coloring conversation:** "What would you color the grapes? What's something big and scary that you can trust God with?"

Page 6: The Bronze Snake / Moses on Mount Nebo (Week 3–4)

- **Scene (left half):** A bronze snake wrapped around a tall pole, people looking up at it. **(Right half):** Old Moses on a mountaintop with his staff, looking out over a valley, a river and a city in the distance (the Promised Land).
- **Caption:** *"Love the LORD your God with all your heart." Deuteronomy 6:5*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Who did the snake on the pole point to? What did Moses get to see before he died? How can you love God with all your heart this week?"

Page 7: Five Books of the LAW (book-name page)

- **Scene:** Five scrolls standing side by side, each with a bubble-letter label: GENESIS (sunrise), EXODUS (an open door with waves), LEVITICUS (praying hands), NUMBERS (1-2-3 and a tent), DEUTERONOMY (a heart). Banner across the top: "THE LAW · 5 of 5 · Old Testament."
- **Caption:** *"Five books of the Law!"*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Can you say all five as you color? Which one is the hardest to spell?"

Activities & Crafts ✂️

1. Baby Moses Basket (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Small paper bowls or cupcake liners (brown), brown yarn or paper strips, a clothespin or a small paper "baby" wrapped in a fabric scrap, green paper strips (reeds), blue paper plates (river), glue.
- **Steps:** (1) Glue brown strips around the bowl to look woven. (2) Put the baby inside. (3) Glue the basket on the blue plate and add green reeds around it. (4) Write "God kept Moses safe. Exodus 2."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* pre-made baskets, add the baby and reeds. *Older kids:* actually weave paper strips; write a prayer for someone who needs God's protection.
- **What it teaches:** God protects and has a plan even in scary times.

2. Passover Door (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Construction paper (brown for a door), red paper strips or red paint with sponge brushes, a lamb sticker or cotton-ball lamb, markers.
- **Steps:** (1) Fold the brown paper so the "door" opens. (2) Glue red strips along the top and both sides (the doorframe). (3) Inside, write: "When I see the blood, I will pass over you. Exodus 12:13" and on the inside back: "Jesus is our Passover Lamb! 1 Corinthians 5:7." (4) Add the lamb.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* red stickers or paint; teacher writes the words. *Ambassadors:* write a short explanation of how the Passover points to the cross.
- **What it teaches:** The Passover lamb and Jesus, the Lamb of God.

3. Stone Tablets (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Gray cardstock cut into two rounded tablets per child (or air-dry clay), markers, brass fastener or tape to join them.
- **Steps:** (1) Number the tablets I–V and VI–X. (2) Write or draw each commandment in kid words. (3) Join the tablets. (4) On the back write "Love God (1–4) · Love people (5–10). Matthew 22:37–39."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* draw a heart (love God) on one and a smiley face (love people) on the other. *Explorers:* write kid-word commandments. *Older:* write the reference for each (Exodus 20:3–17).
- **What it teaches:** The Ten Commandments and Jesus' summary of them.

4. Shoebox Tabernacle (Week 2, Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

- **Supplies:** Shoebox (lid off) or a box base, white fabric or paper for the courtyard curtains, a small box for the tent, gold paper for the ark, a bottle cap for the bronze basin, a small cube for the altar, cotton for the cloud, glue, and Exodus 25–27 for reference.
- **Steps:** (1) Line the box with white "curtains" (courtyard). (2) Place the altar and basin near the entrance. (3) Put the tent at the back with a curtain dividing the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place. (4) Put the gold ark inside the Most Holy Place. (5) Top with a cotton cloud.
- **Age adaptations:** *Explorers:* the leader builds it as a class with kids adding pieces. *Ambassadors:* explain each piece's link to Jesus (altar = sacrifice; basin = cleansing; lampstand = light of the world; bread = bread of life; curtain torn when Jesus died, Matthew 27:51).
- **What it teaches:** God wants to live with His people; the way to God is through Jesus.

5. Giant Grape Cluster (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Purple circles (or purple balloons, or bubble wrap painted purple), a green leaf and a paper "pole" (a straw or craft stick), glue.
- **Steps:** (1) Glue purple circles in a big triangle cluster. (2) Glue the stem and leaf at the top. (3) Tape the cluster hanging from a stick. (4) Write "The LORD is with us. Do not be afraid. Numbers 14:9."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* dot purple paint with a cork or finger. *Older:* write a "giant" (a fear) on one grape and a promise of God on another.
- **What it teaches:** Courage that comes from trusting God.

6. Bronze Snake on a Pole (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Brown or gold pipe cleaners, a craft stick or straw, googly eyes (optional), a small card.
- **Steps:** (1) Wrap the pipe cleaner around the stick in a coil. (2) Bend the top into a snake head and add eyes. (3) Attach a card: "Look and live! Numbers 21:8 · Look to Jesus! John 3:14–15."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* pre-made coil; they add the eyes and color the card. *Ambassadors:* explain the connection to a younger buddy.
- **What it teaches:** Salvation comes by looking to Jesus in faith.

7. Heart-Door Scroll (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Paper strips (about 3 × 8 inches), two drinking straws or chopsticks, ribbon, markers; a small decorated paper "door" frame.
- **Steps:** (1) Write Deuteronomy 6:5 on the paper strip (Little Lambs: "Love the LORD your God" traced). (2) Tape a straw to each end and roll it into a scroll. (3) Tie with ribbon. (4) Decorate the paper door and tape the scroll to its frame, "Write them on the doorframes" (6:9). Take it home to hang by the bedroom door.
- **Age adaptations:** *Older kids:* write the whole Shema (6:4–5) in their best handwriting; add a list of "Times our family will talk about God" (meals, car rides, bedtime).
- **What it teaches:** Loving God with all your heart and remembering His Word every day.

Word Puzzles 🧩

Word Scramble

#	Scrambled	Hint
1	SUDOXE	Book 2, the rescue book
2	CSUITIVEL	Book 3, the holy book
3	SNUBERM	Book 4, counting and wandering
4	YMONOREUTED	Book 5, "second law"
5	SEMOS	Spoke to God at a burning bush
6	VOSERPAS	The lamb's blood on the door
7	NAMAN	"What is it?" bread
8	NIASI	Mountain of the Ten Commandments
9	CLEABENTAR	God's special tent
10	BELACA	Brave spy (not Joshua)
11	GAPLUE	One of ten signs in Egypt
12	LYOH	"Be ___, because I am ___"
13	SNEDILWERS	Where they wandered for 40 years
14	HOAPHRA	King of Egypt

🔑 **Answers:** 1. EXODUS · 2. LEVITICUS · 3. NUMBERS · 4. DEUTERONOMY · 5. MOSES · 6. PASSOVER · 7. MANNA · 8. SINAI · 9. TABERNACLE · 10. CALEB · 11. PLAGUE · 12. HOLY · 13. WILDERNESS · 14. PHARAOH

Fill-in-the-Blank Story

Word bank: basket, bush, ten, lamb, sea, manna, commandments, tent, grapes, forty, heart, Jesus

> Baby Moses floated in a **(1)** on the Nile River. When he grew up, God spoke to him from a burning **(2)**. God sent **(3)** plagues on Egypt. At the first Passover, each family put the blood of a **(4)** on their door. God opened the Red **(5)** and His people walked through on dry ground. In the desert God fed them **(6)**. On Mount Sinai, God gave the Ten **(7)**. God lived among His people in a special **(8)** called the tabernacle. The spies brought back giant **(9)**, but the people were afraid, so they wandered for **(10)** years. Moses said, "Love the LORD your God with all your **(11)**." All of this points to **(12)**, our Passover Lamb!

🔑 **Answers:** 1. basket · 2. bush · 3. ten · 4. lamb · 5. sea · 6. manna · 7. commandments · 8. tent · 9. grapes · 10. forty · 11. heart · 12. Jesus

Match the Book to Its Picture / Summary

Book	Picture / summary
1. Genesis	A. ❤️ Moses' last speeches: "Remember and love God!"
2. Exodus	B. 🙏 Priests, sacrifices and "Be holy"
3. Leviticus	C. 🌅 Creation, Noah, Abraham, Joseph
4. Numbers	D. 🚪🌊 Out of Egypt, through the sea, Ten Commandments
5. Deuteronomy	E. 🔢🍇 Counting the people, 12 spies, 40 years wandering

🔑 **Answers:** 1-C · 2-D · 3-B · 4-E · 5-A

Questions for Every Age 💭

Little Lambs (4–6)

1. Who kept baby Moses safe?
2. How did God help His people when they were trapped at the sea?
3. What food did God give them?
4. What's one of God's good rules?
5. Who do we love most? (God!)

Explorers (7–10)

1. When have you felt like you were "trapped," and how can you trust God then?
2. Why are God's rules good for us?
3. What's something you grumble about? What could you thank God for instead?
4. How was Joshua and Caleb's report different from the other spies'?
5. What's one way your family can "talk about God" during the week?

Trailblazers (11–13)

1. Why do you think God rescued His people *before* giving them the law?
2. What modern things can become "golden calves" for people your age?
3. What does it mean for you to be "holy" at school, at home and online?
4. The people quickly forgot God's miracles. What helps you remember what God has done?
5. Which "I am" statement of Jesus (John 6:35; 8:12; 10:11; 11:25; 14:6) connects with something from Exodus?

Ambassadors (14–17)

1. How does the Passover help you explain the cross to a friend?
2. If no one can keep the law perfectly, what is it for? (See Romans 3:20; Galatians 3:24.)
3. What's the difference between obeying God to *earn* His love and obeying *because* He loves you?
4. How can you be a "Joshua or Caleb" voice among your friends when others are afraid?
5. What would it mean for you to love God with all your heart, soul and strength this week?

🧠 Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics / worldview)

1. **"Did the exodus really happen? There's no evidence."** *Suggested answer:* Ancient Egypt rarely recorded its defeats, and nomads living in tents in a desert leave very little archaeological trace. Still, there's evidence of Semitic peoples living in the Nile delta, Egyptian records of slaves making bricks, and the Merneptah Stele (around 1208 BC), which mentions "Israel" already in Canaan. Most importantly, Israel's whole identity, its festivals (Passover) and its laws all rest on this event; nations don't usually invent a humiliating slave origin. And Jesus treated it as history (John 6:49).
2. **"Aren't the Old Testament laws harsh and outdated?"** *Suggested answer:* Many laws were for ancient Israel as a nation and for its temple worship, and Jesus fulfilled those (Matthew 5:17; Hebrews 8:13). Compared with other ancient law codes, Israel's laws were often more humane: protecting foreigners, the poor, widows, orphans and even animals (Leviticus 19:9–10, 33–34; Deuteronomy 24:17–22; 25:4). The heart of the law, loving God and loving neighbor, is never outdated.
3. **"Why would God need blood sacrifices? That seems primitive."** *Suggested answer:* Sacrifice shows how serious sin is: it brings death (Romans 6:23). God isn't bloodthirsty; He is just and loving. He provided a substitute so sinners could live (Leviticus 17:11). Animal sacrifices could never fully remove sin (Hebrews 10:4); they pointed ahead to the day God Himself, in Jesus, would give His own life for us. The cross shows both how serious sin is and how great God's love is.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration 🎉

Review game plan (last Sunday of the month, 75 minutes)

Time	Activity
10 min	Welcome + sing Parts A and B with motions; Section Shout
15 min	**Law Game Show:** teams answer trivia; each correct answer moves their team's paper Israelite one step across a floor map from "Egypt" to the "Promised Land"
10 min	**Red Sea Relay Finals** (Spell It Out relay between blue streamers)
10 min	**Law Line-Up Championship:** forwards, backwards, and by one-word summary
15 min	**Oral check-offs** while others color Page 7
10 min	**Passport stamping & badge ceremony**
5 min	Closing: everyone says Deuteronomy 6:5 together; prayer; Take-Home Family Page

Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs (4–6) ☐ Say the section name: "LAW" ☐ Name 3 of the 5 Law books (with motions) ☐ Say "Love the LORD your God." ☐ Tell one thing God did for Moses or His people (basket, bush, sea, manna) ☐ Review: "The Bible has 66 books"

Explorers (7–10) ☐ Say all 5 Law books in order ☐ Spell Genesis, Exodus and Numbers from memory; Leviticus and Deuteronomy with the clap method ☐ Say Deuteronomy 6:5 ☐ Name 5 of the 10 plagues ☐ Find Exodus 20:3 using the Contents page

Trailblazers (11–13) ☐ Say all books learned so far (Genesis–Deuteronomy) in order, forwards and backwards ☐ Give a one-sentence summary of each ☐ Spell all 5 ☐ Say Deuteronomy 6:5 ☐ Explain how the Passover and the bronze snake point to Jesus

Ambassadors (14–17) ☐ All Trailblazer items ☐ Say the Shema (Deuteronomy 6:4–5) ☐ Teach one Law book (summary + motion) to a younger child ☐ Explain the difference between being saved *by* the law and living *in response to* God's rescue ☐ Name the 10 library sections and their book counts

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp Phase 2 in each child's Bible Passport with a **parted-sea** stamp (or sticker) labeled: **"Phase 2 ✔ The LAW Complete! Exodus · Leviticus · Numbers · Deuteronomy · 5 of 66."** Add a gold star sticker for completing an entire section (Law: 5 of 5).

🏅 Phase badge: The Red Sea Crosser Badge

A red-bordered shield: two curling blue walls of water on each side with a tan path running up the middle, ending at two small gray stone tablets with "I–X." Banner at the bottom: "THE LAW · 5 BOOKS." Make it from cardstock and ribbon, or as a sticker or patch for the sash.

📜 Certificate wording

> **Purpose Church Sunday School Certificate of Completion: Phase 2, "Freedom & God's Good Rules"** This certifies that _____ has crossed the Red Sea with Moses and learned **Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers and Deuteronomy**, completing all **5 books of the LAW!** *"Love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength." Deuteronomy 6:5* Books learned: **5 of 66** · Sections complete: **Law** ✔ · Teacher: _____ · Date: _____

Take-Home Family Page 🏠

Dear Parents and Caregivers,

This month we finished the first section of the Bible, the **Law** (Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy)! Your child learned how God **rescued** His people from Egypt (Passover, the Red Sea), gave them **good rules** (the Ten Commandments), lived among them in the **tabernacle**, cared for them through 40 years in the wilderness, and called them to **love Him with all their heart**. Most importantly, we saw how all of this points to Jesus, our Passover Lamb, the Bread of Life, and the One lifted up so we can look to Him and live.

📖 **Memory verse:** "Love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength." (Deuteronomy 6:5, NIV) **Little Lambs:** "Love the LORD your God."

🎵 **Our song, "The Law Song" (tune: *Ten Little Fingers*):**

> Gen-e-sis, Ex-o-dus, Le-vit-i-cus, / Num-bers and Deu-ter-on-o-my, / God gave His Word to Mo-ses, / Five books of the LAW! *(Sing the Phase 1 "Bible Library Song" first to the tune of "Twinkle, Twinkle": "Sixty-six books, one big story...")*

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions:**

1. If you were walking through the Red Sea, what would you say to God?
2. Which of the Ten Commandments is hardest for our family? How can we help each other?
3. What's something God has done for our family that we should always remember?

👨‍👩‍👧 **Family activity: "Doorframe Verse."** Deuteronomy 6:9 says to write God's words "on the doorframes of your houses." Together, write Deuteronomy 6:5 on a card and tape it beside your front

door or fridge. Every time someone walks by this week, say it together! Bonus: have a "manna breakfast" (honey toast or wafers) and talk about how God provides for your family every day.

📺 **Videos to watch at home** (search these channels on YouTube):

- **@SharefaithKids:** search "Moses," "Ten Commandments": `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Moses`
- **@BibleJourneyTV:** search "Moses": `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Moses`
- **@bibleproject:** "Overview: Exodus 1-18," "Overview: Exodus 19-40," "Overview: Leviticus," "Overview: Numbers," "Overview: Deuteronomy": `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Exodus`

Next month: Phase 3, "Into the Promised Land." We'll learn Joshua, Judges and Ruth and start the History section!

For more on the year, see `../00-start-here/program-overview.md` and `../00-start-here/books-of-the-bible-memory-system.md`.

Phase 3: Into the Promised Land

God's people cross the Jordan, see the walls of Jericho fall, cry out for rescuers again and again, and meet a loyal friend named Ruth who becomes part of Jesus' family.

At a Glance

Month	Month 3
Books covered	Joshua, Judges, Ruth (3 books)
Bible section(s)	History (books 1–3 of 12)
Big Idea	God keeps His promise and brings His people into the land. When they follow Him there is victory, when they wander there is trouble, and through it all God is working to bring a true King and Redeemer: Jesus.
Memory Verse (all ages)	"Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God will be with you wherever you go." (Joshua 1:9, NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"Be strong and courageous." (Joshua 1:9)
Theme color	Trumpet brass and harvest-wheat gold
Phase symbol / badge	🎺 The **Jericho Trumpet Badge**: a ram's horn trumpet over a tumbled wall, with a bundle of wheat for Ruth
Running total of books learned	8 of 66 (Law 5 of 5 ✔ · History 3 of 12)

The Big Idea (in kid words)

After 40 years in the wilderness, God's people finally walk into the **Promised Land**! God tells their new leader, **Joshua**, "Be strong and courageous. I am with you." God stops a river and knocks down the walls of **Jericho**. But after Joshua dies, the people forget God again and again. Each time they get into trouble, they cry out, and God sends a rescuer called a **judge**. In the middle of those messy days, a young widow named **Ruth** shows loyal love, and God gives her a family. Her great-grandson is **King David**!

How this points to Jesus: The name **Joshua** means "**the LORD saves**," and it's the same name as **Jesus** in Hebrew (*Yeshua*). Joshua led God's people into the Promised Land; Jesus leads us into God's forever home. **Rahab** was saved by trusting God and hanging a **scarlet (red) cord** in her window, and she became part of Jesus' family tree (Matthew 1:5)! The judges were rescuers who weren't perfect and couldn't fix people's hearts, so the people needed a perfect Savior and King. **Boaz** was Ruth's "guardian-redeemer," a relative who paid the price to rescue her family. Jesus is our **Redeemer** who paid for us with His life. Ruth's baby was born in **Bethlehem's** family line, the same town where Jesus would be born.

The Books in Easy Words

Review: The 5 Books of the Law 📜

Genesis (beginnings 🌅), Exodus (rescue 🚪), Leviticus (holy 🙏), Numbers (wilderness 🔢), Deuteronomy (remember ❤️). **Section complete!**

Book 6: Joshua

How to say it	JOSH-oo-uh
How to spell it	Josh-u-a: **J-O-S-H-U-A** (3 claps)
Section	History (book 1 of 12)
Traditional author	Joshua (with a few later additions, such as the account of his death)
Chapters	24
One-sentence kid summary	God helped Joshua lead His people across the Jordan River into the Promised Land, knocked down Jericho's walls, and kept every promise He made.
In one word	**CONQUER** (or **PROMISE-KEEPER**)
Key people	Joshua, Rahab, the two spies, Caleb, Achan, the Gibeonites, the priests carrying the ark
Key stories	"Be strong and courageous" (1); Rahab hides the spies and hangs a scarlet cord (2); the Jordan River stops so the people cross on dry ground, and 12 memorial stones (3–4); the commander of the LORD's army (5:13–15); the walls of Jericho fall (6); Achan's hidden sin and the battle of Ai (7–8); the Gibeonites' trick (9); the sun stands still (10); Caleb, 85 years old, asks for his mountain (14); the land is divided among the tribes (13–21); "Not one of all the LORD's good promises... failed" (21:45); "As for me and my household, we will serve the LORD" (24:15)
Where Jesus shows up	Joshua's name = Jesus' name ("the LORD saves"); Rahab in Jesus' family line (Matthew 1:5) and a hero of faith (Hebrews 11:31); the scarlet cord as a sign of rescue, like the Passover blood; the "rest" in the land points to the greater rest Jesus gives (Hebrews 4:8–10)
Hand motion / picture	🎺 **March and blow:** march in place while holding your fists to your mouth like a trumpet: "Toot-toot! Walls fall down!"

Book 7: Judges

How to say it	JUJ-iz
How to spell it	Judg-es: **J-U-D-G-E-S** (2 claps). *Tip: "judge" + "s." Don't forget the silent D before the G!*
Section	History (book 2 of 12)
Traditional author	Samuel (according to Jewish tradition)
Chapters	21

One-sentence kid summary	After Joshua died, God's people kept forgetting God and getting into trouble, so God sent 12 rescuers called judges to save them again and again.
In one word	**CYCLE** (sin → suffer → shout → Savior → silence, then again)
Key people	The 12 judges: Othniel, Ehud (a left-handed hero), Shamgar, **Deborah** (with Barak), **Gideon**, Tola, Jair, Jephthah, Ibzan, Elon, Abdon, **Samson**; also Jael, Delilah, and enemy kings and armies (Canaanites, Midianites, Philistines)
Key stories	The cycle begins (2:10–19); Ehud defeats a cruel king (3); Deborah the judge and prophet leads Barak to victory (4–5); Gideon, the "mighty warrior" hiding in a winepress, the fleece, and the 300 men with trumpets, jars and torches (6–7); Samson, the strongman with a Nazirite vow, the lion, Delilah, and the temple pillars (13–16); "In those days Israel had no king; everyone did as they saw fit" (21:25)
Where Jesus shows up	Every judge was a flawed savior, showing we need a *perfect* Savior; the book ends longing for a good King, and Jesus is that King; Samson's greatest victory came when he gave up his life, a faint picture of Jesus defeating the enemy through His death; God's Spirit coming on the judges points to the Holy Spirit Jesus gives
Hand motion / picture	🔨 **Gavel:** pound one fist gently on your other palm like a judge's hammer, then draw a circle in the air (the cycle).

Book 8: Ruth

How to say it	ROOTH
How to spell it	Ruth: **R-U-T-H** (1 clap)
Section	History (book 3 of 12)
Traditional author	Unknown (Jewish tradition says Samuel)
Chapters	4
One-sentence kid summary	Ruth stayed loyal to her mother-in-law Naomi and to God, and kind Boaz became her family's redeemer, and their great-grandson was King David.
In one word	**LOYALTY** (the Hebrew word *hesed*: loyal, faithful, never-giving-up love)
Key people	Naomi, Elimelech, Mahlon and Kilion (Naomi's sons), Orpah, Ruth (from the nation of Moab), Boaz, Obed (Ruth's baby)
Key stories	A famine; Naomi's family moves to Moab and her husband and sons die (1); "Where you go I will go… your God my God" (1:16); Naomi returns to Bethlehem bitter ("Call me Mara," 1:20); Ruth gleans (gathers leftover grain) in Boaz's field, and Boaz is kind to her (2); Ruth asks Boaz to be her family's guardian-redeemer (3); Boaz redeems the family land and marries Ruth, sealed with a sandal at the city gate (4); baby Obed is born, the grandfather of David (4:17)
Where Jesus shows up	Boaz the guardian-redeemer points to Jesus our Redeemer (Galatians 4:4–5; 1 Peter 1:18–19); Ruth, a foreigner, welcomed into God's family shows the gospel is for all nations; Ruth is in Jesus' family tree (Matthew 1:5); the story happens in **Bethlehem**, Jesus' birthplace

Hand motion / picture	🌾 **Gather and hug:** scoop up pretend grain from the ground with both hands, then hug yourself ("loyal love!").

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher (plain adult language)

Where we are in the story. At the end of Deuteronomy, Moses has died and Israel is camped east of the Jordan River, across from Jericho. These three books cover about 300–350 years in the land, from the conquest (traditionally around 1400 BC) to just before the time of Samuel and the kings.

- **Joshua** shows God's faithfulness to His promise to Abraham (Genesis 15:18–21). Key themes: courage that comes from God's presence (1:5–9), the importance of complete obedience (Achan, ch. 7), God fighting for Israel (Jericho, ch. 6; Gibeon, ch. 10), and covenant renewal (ch. 24). The conquest was a divine judgment on Canaanite nations for centuries of evil, including child sacrifice (see Genesis 15:16; Deuteronomy 9:4–5; 12:31), and God had waited over 400 years. Note also that individuals who turned to God, such as Rahab and the Gibeonites, were spared.
- **Judges** is a downward spiral. The "cycle" repeats seven times: Israel **sins** (worships idols), God lets them **suffer** under enemies, they **shout** (cry out) to God, God sends a **savior** (a judge), and there is **silence** (peace) until the judge dies. Each time it gets worse, and even the judges get worse (Gideon begins well and ends making an idol, 8:27; Samson is impulsive and self-centered). The refrain, "In those days Israel had no king; everyone did as they saw fit" (17:6; 21:25), prepares for the coming of kings in Samuel, and ultimately points to the need for Jesus. Judges 17–21 are very dark chapters; we do not teach them to children.
- **Ruth** is set "in the days when the judges ruled" (1:1), but it's a bright, beautiful contrast: ordinary people showing **hesed** (loyal covenant love) in everyday life. Ruth is a Moabite (a nation usually at odds with Israel), yet she chooses Israel's God. Boaz acts as a **guardian-redeemer** (Hebrew *go'el*), a close relative who had the right and duty to buy back family land and care for a widow's family (Leviticus 25:25; Deuteronomy 25:5–6). The book ends with a genealogy leading to **David**, showing that God was quietly preparing a king, and ultimately the Messiah.

Key truths to emphasize

1. **God keeps every promise.** (Joshua 21:45; 23:14)
2. **God's presence gives courage.** (Joshua 1:9)
3. **Obedience matters; hidden sin hurts everyone.** (Joshua 7)
4. **Choose today whom you will serve.** (Joshua 24:15)
5. **When we forget God, life goes in circles of trouble, but God hears when we cry out.** (Judges 2:18)
6. **God uses unlikely people** (a left-handed man, a woman judge, a fearful farmer, a foreign widow).
7. **We need a perfect Savior and King: Jesus.** (Judges 21:25)
8. **God works through ordinary kindness and loyalty.** (Ruth 2:12; 3:10)

Timeline and map notes

- **Timeline:** Moses dies → Joshua crosses the Jordan (traditionally around 1406 BC) → conquest (about 7 years; see Caleb's age in Joshua 14:7–10) → land divided → Joshua dies at 110 → the judges (about 300 years) → Ruth (during the judges, about three generations before David) → Samuel (next month!).
- **Map:** Draw the Jordan River (from the Sea of Galilee down to the Dead Sea). Mark **Jericho** (just west of the Jordan), **Ai**, **Gibeon**, **Shiloh** (where the tabernacle stood), **Hebron** (Caleb's land), **Bethlehem** (Ruth and Boaz) and **Moab** (east of the Dead Sea). Show the 12 tribal areas with colored paper. Older kids: note the Philistines on the coast (Samson's enemies, and Goliath's people later).

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers / Ambassadors (11–17)
Battles and the conquest (Jericho, Ai)	Focus on the miracle: "God made the walls fall down!" Skip what happened to the people inside, except "Rahab's family was safe!"	Honest but brief: there were battles, and God was judging nations that had done very evil things for a long time. Highlight Rahab's rescue.	Discuss the hard question openly (see Big Question 1). Read Genesis 15:16, Deuteronomy 9:4–5 and Joshua 5:13–14 ("Neither… I am commander of the army of the LORD").
Rahab's background	"Rahab didn't know God yet, but she chose to trust Him."	"Rahab had been living a sinful life, but God forgave and saved her."	You may say she was a prostitute (Joshua 2:1; Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25); emphasize grace: God welcomes anyone who turns to Him.
Achan (Joshua 7:24–26)	Skip the punishment: "Achan hid things God said not to take, and it hurt everyone."	"Achan's sin had very serious consequences."	Discuss the seriousness of sin within God's covenant community, and contrast it with grace in Christ.
Ehud and Eglon, Jael and Sisera (Judges 3–4)	Skip.	Say only: "God used Ehud and Jael to defeat cruel enemy leaders."	You may read the passages; discuss why the Bible records violence honestly without approving everything.
Jephthah's vow (Judges 11)	Skip.	Skip.	Optional for Ambassadors: a tragic example of a foolish vow and of how far Israel had drifted (God forbids child sacrifice, Deuteronomy 12:31).

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers / Ambassadors (11–17)
Samson and Delilah	"Samson was very strong because God gave him strength. He made bad choices, but at the end he prayed and God helped him one last time."	Describe his poor choices (wanting his own way). Skip romance details.	Discuss how a gifted person can waste gifts, and God's grace even at the end (Hebrews 11:32).
Judges 19–21	Skip.	Skip.	Skip in class. If asked, acknowledge "the end of Judges shows how terrible things become when everyone does what they want," and talk privately or with parents.
Ruth at the threshing floor (Ruth 3)	"Ruth asked Boaz to take care of her family."	Same; explain it was a respectful custom for asking a guardian-redeemer for help.	Explain the customs (spreading the corner of a garment = a request for protection and marriage, compare Ezekiel 16:8); Boaz acts with integrity (3:11–14).
Death and grief (Naomi's husband and sons die)	"Naomi was very sad because her family died. But God took care of her."	Discuss grief honestly; it's okay to be sad and to tell God.	Talk about Naomi's honest lament (1:20–21) and how God was working when she couldn't see it.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

- **"How did the walls of Jericho fall down?"** God did it! The people obeyed by marching and shouting, but God's power knocked down the walls (Hebrews 11:30: "By faith the walls of Jericho fell").
- **"Did the sun really stand still?"** The Bible says God answered Joshua's prayer and made the day longer (Joshua 10:12–14). We don't know exactly *how*, but God made the sun and can do anything with it.
- **"Why did God let His people be beaten by enemies in Judges?"** Like a loving parent, God let them feel the hurt of their choices so they'd turn back to Him. And every time they cried out, He rescued them.
- **"Was Samson's strength in his hair?"** His strength came from God. His long hair was a sign of his special promise (a Nazirite vow) to belong to God. When he broke that promise completely, God's strength left him (Judges 16:17–20).
- **"Why did Gideon only get 300 men?"** So everyone would know that *God* won the battle, not the army (Judges 7:2).
- **"Can girls be leaders like Deborah?"** Deborah was a prophet and judge whom God used to lead Israel (Judges 4:4). God used her courage and faith in a powerful way. *(Teacher: different churches apply this to church leadership in different ways. Keep the focus on God using Deborah's faith and courage.)*

- **"What's a redeemer?"** Someone who pays a price to buy something or someone back. Boaz bought back Naomi's family land and took care of Ruth. Jesus paid for us with His life to bring us back to God.
- **"Why is Ruth's story in the Bible if it's not about battles?"** Because God cares about ordinary people and everyday kindness, and because Ruth's family leads to King David and to Jesus!

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson title	Key point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
1	Joshua 1–6	**Be Strong and Courageous**	God is with us wherever we go, so we can be brave, and God can knock down any wall.	SharefaithKids "Jericho"; BibleJourneyTV "Joshua"; BibleProject "Overview: Joshua"	Jericho Walls; Crossing the Jordan	Jericho Trumpet; Rahab's Scarlet Cord Window
2	Joshua 7; 14:6–15; 21:43–45; 24:14–28	**Choose Whom You Will Serve**	God keeps every promise, so we choose to follow Him fully.	SharefaithKids "Joshua"; BibleJourneyTV "Joshua"; BibleProject "Overview: Joshua" (second half) / "The Covenants"	Rahab's Rescue Rope; Twelve Stones Stepping Race	Memorial Stones; "As for Me and My House" Door Hanger
3	Judges 2:10–19; 4–7; 13–16 (selected)	**Rescuers in Messy Times**	When we forget God, we go in circles of trouble, but God hears and rescues, and Jesus is the perfect Rescuer.	SharefaithKids "Gideon" / "Samson"; BibleJourneyTV "Gideon"; BibleProject "Overview: Judges"	Gideon's Shrinking Army; Torch & Trumpet Night Tag	Gideon's Jar & Torch; Judges Cycle Wheel
4	Ruth 1–4	**Loyal Love and a Redeemer**	God shows loyal love through ordinary people, and Jesus is our Redeemer.	SharefaithKids "Ruth"; BibleJourneyTV "Ruth"; BibleProject "Overview: Ruth"	Ruth's Gleaning Grab	Wheat Sheaf Craft; Ruth-to-Jesus Family Tree
5 (optional)	Review Genesis–Ruth	**Review & Fun Sunday**	I know 8 books: the Law and the start of History!	Class favorite	Promised Land Game Show; History Shelf Hop	Passport stamping + badge ceremony

---

Weekly Lessons

Week 1: Be Strong and Courageous 🎺

Scripture: Joshua 1:1–9; 2:1–21; 3:1–4:9; 6:1–25

Lesson goal: Kids will know that God told Joshua to be strong and courageous because God was with him, that Rahab trusted God and was saved, that God stopped the Jordan River, and that God made the walls of Jericho fall.

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Wall"

- *Supplies:* 15–20 empty cardboard boxes or plastic cups, stacked into a "wall"; a toy trumpet or a kazoo.
- *Do:* Build the wall before class. "Imagine you had to get into a city with walls this tall and thick, as tall as a house! Could you push it down by yourself?" Let a volunteer try to "think" it down. "No? What if I told you that God told His people to just walk around it and shout?" Blow the kazoo and have everyone shout; secretly have a helper knock it down. "When God is with us, nothing is too big for Him!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Moses had died, and God's people were waiting by the **Jordan River**. On the other side was the land God had promised to Abraham hundreds of years before! God chose **Joshua** to be the new leader. Joshua might have felt a little scared. Moses was a hard act to follow!
>
> But God told Joshua, "**Be strong and courageous! Do not be afraid. Do not be discouraged. For the LORD your God will be with you wherever you go.**"
>
> Joshua sent two spies to look at the big city of **Jericho**. A woman named **Rahab** lived in a house built into the city wall. She hadn't followed God before, but she had heard how God opened the Red Sea. She said, "I know the LORD has given you this land. Your God is God in heaven above and on the earth below!" She hid the spies on her roof under stalks of flax. Then she let them down by a rope out her window. The spies told her, "Tie this **scarlet (red) cord** in your window, and everyone in your house will be safe."
>
> Next, God's people had to cross the Jordan River, and it was flooding! God said, "Have the priests carry the ark of the covenant into the water." As soon as their feet touched the river, the water stopped flowing and piled up far upstream! All the people crossed on **dry ground**, just like at the Red Sea! Joshua had 12 men take 12 stones from the riverbed to make a pile, so that when children asked, "What do these stones mean?" their parents could say, "God stopped the river for us!"
>
> Then came Jericho. Its gates were shut tight. God gave Joshua a very strange plan: "March around the city once a day for six days. Have seven priests blow trumpets made of rams' horns. On the seventh day, march around **seven times**. When you hear a long trumpet blast, everyone **SHOUT**!"

> So they did. Day 1, around once. Day 2, around once. All the way to Day 6. On Day 7, they marched around… 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7 times! The trumpets blew, the people gave a great shout, and **the walls came tumbling down!**
>
> And Rahab? Her family was safe because of the red cord in the window. She came to live with God's people, and many years later, she became the great-great-…-grandmother of **Jesus**!
>
> Joshua's name means "the LORD saves." Jesus has the very same name! Jesus is with us wherever we go, so we can be strong and courageous too.

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** March around the room 7 times while counting, then shout and "fall down" like the walls. Repeat often: "Be strong and courageous! God is with me!" with a flexed-arm "strong" motion.
- **Explorers:** Act out the spies and Rahab (a red ribbon in a "window"). Count the marches together. Have them find Joshua 1:9 with the Contents page.
- **Trailblazers:** Compare the Jordan crossing to the Red Sea (Joshua 4:23). Talk about Rahab's faith (Hebrews 11:31; James 2:25). Look at the commander of the LORD's army (5:13–15): God isn't on "our side"; we must be on His.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss what courage looks like for a Christian teen today. Talk about memorials: what "12 stones" could help them remember what God has done in their lives?

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Who was the new leader after Moses? (Joshua) (2) What color was Rahab's cord? (Red!) (3) What happened when the people shouted? (The walls fell down!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What did God promise Joshua? (2) Why did Rahab help the spies? (3) Why do you think God gave such a strange plan for Jericho?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why did God tell Joshua *three times* to be strong and courageous (1:6, 7, 9)? (2) What do the 12 stones teach about remembering God's faithfulness? (3) What does Rahab's story teach about who God welcomes?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Where does real courage come from, according to Joshua 1:9? (2) The commander said he wasn't for Israel or its enemies (5:13–14). What does that mean for how we see "our side" today? (3) Rahab was saved by faith before she'd done anything "good." How does that connect to the gospel?

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Jericho" or "Joshua" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Jericho` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Joshua" or "Jericho" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Joshua` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Joshua" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Joshua` |

Teacher: preview every video first. Some Joshua videos include battle scenes; choose what fits your group. Follow-up questions: (1) How did God show He was with Joshua? (2) What do you need courage for this week?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Jericho Walls* and *Crossing the Jordan*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Jericho Trumpet* and *Rahab's Scarlet Cord Window*. See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Joshua 1:9 (Little Lambs: "Be strong and courageous."). Spell **J-O-S-H-U-A**. Trailblazers: **J-E-R-I-C-H-O**, **C-O-U-R-A-G-E-O-U-S**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, thank You that You are with us wherever we go. When we feel scared, help us be strong and courageous. Thank You for Jesus, whose name means "the LORD saves." Amen.

Week 2: Choose Whom You Will Serve 🪨🏠

Scripture: Joshua 7:1–26 (summarized); 14:6–15; 21:43–45; 24:14–28

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that hidden sin hurts everyone (Achan), that faithful Caleb kept trusting God into old age, that God kept every promise, and that Joshua challenged everyone to choose to serve the LORD.

Opening hook / object lesson: "One Rotten Apple"

- *Supplies:* A bowl of fresh apples (or pictures) and one bruised or rotten apple hidden underneath; two signs: "God's way" and "My way."
- *Do:* Lift out the good apples, then reveal the rotten one at the bottom. "What happens if you leave one rotten apple in the bowl? It can spoil the others! In Joshua, one man hid something he shouldn't have, and it hurt everyone." Then hold up the two signs. "Every day, we choose: God's way or my way. Joshua made his choice. Let's find out what it was!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> After Jericho, God had given one rule: "Don't take any of the treasure for yourselves. It belongs to the LORD." But a man named **Achan** saw a beautiful robe, some silver and a bar of gold. He thought, "Nobody will know." He took them and **hid** them under his tent.
>
> Next, Israel went to fight a little town called **Ai**, and they lost! Joshua fell on his face before God. "Why, LORD?" God said, "Someone has disobeyed and hidden what they took." Achan finally confessed, "It's true. I saw, I wanted, I took, I hid." Achan's sin was very serious, and it hurt the whole nation. After it was dealt with, God gave Israel victory. Sin we hide never stays hidden from God.
>
> Years went by, and God's people took more and more of the land. One day an old man came to Joshua. It was **Caleb**, one of the two brave spies from 45 years before! Caleb said, "I'm **85 years old**, but I'm still as strong as I was the day Moses sent me! Give me that hill country God promised me. The LORD will help me!" And Joshua gave Caleb the city of **Hebron**. Caleb trusted God his whole life long.

> Then the land was divided among the **12 tribes** of Israel, like a big family sharing a giant gift. The Bible says, "**Not one of all the LORD's good promises to Israel failed; every one was fulfilled.**" Remember God's promise to Abraham? A land, a big family, a blessing. God kept it!
>
> When Joshua was very old, he gathered all the people. He reminded them of everything God had done, from Abraham to Egypt to the Red Sea to Jericho. Then he said, "Now choose for yourselves this day whom you will serve. You can follow the false gods, or the LORD. **But as for me and my household, we will serve the LORD.**"
>
> The people shouted, "We will serve the LORD!" Joshua set up a big stone under a tree as a reminder of their promise. Then Joshua died at 110 years old.
>
> Every day, we choose too. Jesus said, "Follow me." When we choose Jesus, He forgives our hidden sins when we confess them, and He helps us follow Him all our lives, like Caleb did.

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Use the two signs: kids point to "God's way" or "My way" as you describe kid choices (sharing, hitting, obeying, telling the truth). Repeat: "I will serve the LORD!"
- **Explorers:** Discuss Achan's four steps: "I saw, I wanted, I took, I hid" (7:21). Compare them with Eve in Genesis 3:6. Talk about how to stop sin at step 1 or 2. Celebrate Caleb's lifelong faith.
- **Trailblazers:** Read Joshua 21:43–45 and list the promises God kept. Discuss what "serving the LORD" looks like at home ("me and my household").
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss hidden sin and confession (1 John 1:9; Proverbs 28:13). Discuss Joshua 24:15 as a personal decision: faith can't be inherited from parents; each person must choose.

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What did Achan do with the things he took? (Hid them) (2) How old was Caleb? (85, still strong!) (3) What did Joshua say his family would do? ("Serve the LORD!")
- *Explorers:* (1) Why was it wrong for Achan to take the treasure? (2) What made Caleb so brave, even when he was old? (3) What's one way your family can serve the LORD?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why does hidden sin affect other people? (2) What do the words "not one promise failed" tell you about God? (3) Why did Joshua make the people *choose* instead of just telling them what to do?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) What is the difference between hiding sin and confessing it? What happens with each? (2) Caleb "followed the LORD wholeheartedly" (14:8, 14). What would wholehearted faith look like for you? (3) Is it possible to grow up in a Christian family and still need to make your own choice? Explain.

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Joshua" or "Achan" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Joshua` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Joshua" or "Caleb" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Caleb` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Joshua" (focus on the second half) or theme video "The Covenants" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Covenants` |

Preview first. Follow-up questions: (1) What promises did God keep in the book of Joshua? (2) What choice did Joshua ask the people to make?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Rahab's Rescue Rope* and *Twelve Stones Stepping Race*. See Games.

🧨 **Activity of the week:** *Memorial Stones* and *"As for Me and My House" Door Hanger*. See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Joshua 1:9 (whole verse for Explorers+). Bonus for older groups: Joshua 24:15b. Spell **C-A-L-E-B**, **R-A-H-A-B**; Trailblazers: **P-R-O-M-I-S-E**, **S-E-R-V-E**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Faithful God, You have never broken one promise. Help us confess our sins instead of hiding them, and help us choose every day: "We will serve the LORD!" Amen.

Week 3: Rescuers in Messy Times 🔥🦁

Scripture: Judges 2:10–19 (the cycle); 4:1–16 (Deborah); 6:11–16, 36–40; 7:1–22 (Gideon); 13:1–5, 24–25; 16:4–30 (Samson, selected); 21:25

Lesson goal: Kids will learn the Judges "cycle" (sin, suffer, shout, Savior, silence), meet Deborah, Gideon and Samson, and understand that people needed a perfect Savior and King, Jesus.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Round and Round"

- *Supplies:* A toy car or ball and a circular track (or tape a circle on the floor); five signs around the circle: SIN, SUFFER, SHOUT, SAVIOR, SILENCE (peace).
- *Do:* Walk (or roll the car) around the circle, stopping at each sign. "God's people forgot Him (SIN). Enemies were mean to them (SUFFER). They cried to God (SHOUT). God sent a rescuer (SAVIOR). There was peace for a while (SILENCE)... and then they forgot God AGAIN!" Keep going around faster. "Round and round and round! That's the book of Judges. They needed someone to break the circle!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> After Joshua died, a new generation grew up who didn't know the LORD or what He had done. They started worshiping fake gods called idols. So God let enemy nations come and bully them. Then the people cried out, "Help us, LORD!" And God, who is so kind, sent a rescuer called a **judge**. A judge was a leader God used to save His people. Then there was peace... until the people forgot God again. This happened over and over, like going in circles!
>
> One judge was a woman named **Deborah**. She was a prophet who sat under a palm tree, and people came to her for help. A cruel enemy general named **Sisera** had 900 iron chariots! Deborah told a man named **Barak**, "God says go fight, and He will win the battle for you." Barak said, "I'll only go if you go with me." So Deborah went! The LORD threw Sisera's army into a panic, the

Kishon River swept the enemy away (Judges 4:15; 5:21), and Sisera's army ran. Afterward, Deborah sang a song of praise to God.

Later, God's people were being robbed by the **Midianites**. A young man named **Gideon** was hiding in a winepress, secretly threshing wheat. An angel of the LORD appeared and said, "**The LORD is with you, mighty warrior!**" Gideon looked around: "Who, me?" He was afraid. He asked God for signs: he put a sheep's fleece on the ground. One morning it was wet while the ground was dry, and the next morning it was dry while the ground was wet! God was patient with Gideon.

Gideon gathered 32,000 men. But God said, "**Too many!** People will brag that they won by themselves." God sent most of them home until only **300** were left! God gave them a strange battle plan: each man held a **trumpet**, and a **torch hidden inside a clay jar**. In the middle of the night, they surrounded the enemy camp. Gideon gave the signal. CRASH went the jars! The torches blazed! The trumpets blared! They shouted, "**A sword for the LORD and for Gideon!**" The enemy was so confused they ran away. God won the battle!

Then there was **Samson**. Before he was born, an angel told his parents that he would belong to God in a special way. He must never cut his hair. God gave Samson amazing strength: he tore apart a lion with his bare hands! But Samson often did whatever *he* wanted. He fell in love with a woman named **Delilah**, who worked for the enemy **Philistines**. She kept begging him to tell her the secret of his strength. Finally he told her, and while he slept, his hair was cut. The Philistines captured him and made him their prisoner. But Samson prayed one last time, "Lord, remember me. Give me strength just once more." God answered, and Samson pushed down the pillars of the enemy temple, defeating more enemies in his death than in his life.

The book of Judges ends with sad words: "**In those days Israel had no king; everyone did as they saw fit**," meaning everyone did whatever they wanted. They needed a good King. And God was already planning one: first King David, and then the best King of all, **Jesus**, the perfect Rescuer who changes our hearts and breaks the circle of sin for good!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on Gideon. Give each child a paper cup "jar" with a paper flame inside and a cardboard-tube trumpet. Practice the shout: "For the LORD!" Big idea: "God helps us even when we feel small!"
- **Explorers:** Walk the cycle circle together, naming each step. Meet the three main judges with motions: Deborah (palm-tree arms), Gideon (trumpet and torch), Samson (strong arms).
- **Trailblazers:** Read Judges 2:10–19 and identify the cycle. Discuss: each judge had weaknesses. What does that show about our need for Jesus? Mention the other judges briefly (Othniel, Ehud, Shamgar, Tola, Jair, Jephthah, Ibzan, Elon, Abdon).
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Judges 2:10, "another generation grew up who knew neither the LORD nor what he had done." How does faith get passed (or lost) between generations? Read Judges 21:25 and connect it to today's "do whatever feels right" culture.

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What did God's people do when they got in trouble? (Cried out to God) (2) How many men did Gideon have at the end? (300) (3) Who gave Samson his strength? (God!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What does a judge do in this book? (2) Why did God send most of Gideon's army home? (3) What was one good thing and one bad thing about Samson?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Name the five steps of the cycle. Have you ever been in a "cycle" with a bad habit? (2) Why was Gideon called "mighty warrior" when he was hiding? What does God see in us? (3) Why couldn't any judge fix the people for good?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Judges 2:10 describes a generation that didn't know God. What can your generation do differently? (2) "Everyone did as they saw fit." What happens to a society when that becomes the rule? (3) How is Jesus a better Savior than every judge?

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Gideon" or "Samson" or "Deborah" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Gideon` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Gideon" or "Judges" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Gideon` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Judges" | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Judges` |

Preview first. Judges videos can show battle scenes; choose carefully for younger groups. Follow-up questions: (1) What was the "cycle" the people kept repeating? (2) Why did they need a better King?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Gideon's Shrinking Army* and *Torch & Trumpet Night Tag*. See Games.

🧨 **Activity of the week:** *Gideon's Jar & Torch* (younger) and *Judges Cycle Wheel* (older). See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Joshua 1:9 review. Spell **J-U-D-G-E-S** (remember the D!). Explorers: **G-I-D-E-O-N**, **S-A-M-S-O-N**, **D-E-B-O-R-A-H**. Trailblazers: **J-U-D-G-E**, **C-Y-C-L-E**, **D-E-L-I-V-E-R-E-R**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, thank You that You hear us when we cry out to You. When we feel small like Gideon, remind us that You are with us. Thank You for Jesus, the perfect Rescuer and King who never fails. Amen.

Week 4: Loyal Love and a Redeemer 🌾

Scripture: Ruth 1:1–22; 2:1–23; 3:1–13 (summarized); 4:1–22

Lesson goal: Kids will learn how Ruth showed loyal love to Naomi and trusted God, how Boaz showed kindness and became their guardian-redeemer, and how their family led to King David and to Jesus, our Redeemer.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Stick Like Glue"

- *Supplies:* Two paper hearts, glue stick, a small bag of wheat stalks or uncooked rice/cereal; a "price tag."
- *Do:* Glue the two hearts together, then try to pull them apart (they tear!). "Some friends stick together no matter what. Ruth was a friend like that." Then show a price tag on a toy: "If I lost this and someone else had it, I could *buy it back*. That's called **redeeming**. In Ruth's story, someone redeems a whole family!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> During the days of the judges, there was a famine in Israel. There was no food! So a man named Elimelech, his wife **Naomi**, and their two sons left **Bethlehem** and moved to the country of **Moab**.
>
> While they were there, Elimelech died. The two sons married Moabite women named **Orpah** and **Ruth**. Then, very sadly, both sons died too. Naomi was left with no husband and no sons, just her two daughters-in-law.
>
> Naomi heard that God had given food back to Israel, so she decided to go home. She told Orpah and Ruth, "Go back to your mothers' homes." Orpah kissed her goodbye. But Ruth hugged Naomi tight and said, "**Where you go I will go, and where you stay I will stay. Your people will be my people and your God my God.**" Ruth chose to stay with Naomi, and to follow Naomi's God, the LORD.
>
> When they got to Bethlehem, Naomi was so sad she said, "Don't call me Naomi (which means *pleasant*). Call me **Mara** (which means *bitter*)." It was the start of the barley harvest.
>
> To get food, Ruth went to **glean**: walking behind the harvesters and picking up the leftover grain they dropped. God's law said farmers should leave some for poor people and foreigners. Ruth "happened" to go to the field of a kind man named **Boaz**, who was a relative of Naomi's husband! Boaz greeted his workers, "The LORD be with you!" He saw Ruth and said, "I've heard how kind you've been to Naomi. May the LORD, under whose wings you've come to find safety, reward you!" He told his workers to drop extra grain on purpose for her, and he gave her lunch.
>
> Naomi was amazed. "Boaz is one of our family's **guardian-redeemers**!" A guardian-redeemer was a close relative who could buy back a family's land and take care of a widow's family so the family name wouldn't be lost.
>
> Ruth asked Boaz to be their redeemer, and Boaz said yes! But there was one closer relative who had the first chance. So Boaz went to the town gate and asked him in front of the leaders. The man said, "I can't do it." He took off his sandal and gave it to Boaz. That's how people sealed a deal back then!
>
> So Boaz **redeemed** Naomi's family land and married Ruth. God gave them a baby boy named **Obed**. Naomi held him and wasn't bitter anymore. The women said, "Praise the LORD!" Obed grew up and became the father of **Jesse**, and Jesse was the father of... **King David**!

> And many years later, from that same family, in that same town of Bethlehem, **Jesus** was born. Jesus is our **Redeemer**. He paid the price, His own life, to bring us back into God's family. And just like Ruth, anyone from any nation can come and find safety under God's wings.

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Scatter paper "grain" on the floor. Kids gather it like Ruth, while a "Boaz" helper secretly drops extra. Repeat the motion and words: "Where you go, I will go!" (point and walk) and "Boaz was kind!" (hug).
- **Explorers:** Act out the story in 4 scenes (one per chapter) with simple costumes, including the sandal at the gate! Talk about how Ruth "happened" to find Boaz's field (2:3) and how God was guiding her.
- **Trailblazers:** Teach the word *hesed* (loyal love) and find it in Ruth 1:8; 2:20; 3:10. Draw the family tree from Ruth and Boaz to David (4:17–22), then show Matthew 1:5–6.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss how Ruth, a Moabite, is welcomed into Israel (compare Deuteronomy 23:3 and how grace goes beyond expectations). Discuss God's "hidden" work: He's never mentioned doing a miracle in Ruth, yet He's guiding everything.

💬 **Discussion questions:**

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Who did Ruth stay with? (Naomi) (2) What did Ruth pick up in the field? (Grain / wheat) (3) Who was kind to Ruth? (Boaz)
- *Explorers:* (1) What did Ruth promise Naomi? (2) How did Boaz show kindness? (3) Ruth's great-grandson became a famous king. Who was he?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) What does "redeemer" mean? How is Jesus our Redeemer? (2) Ruth "happened" to come to Boaz's field. Do you think it was an accident? (3) How did Naomi change from the beginning to the end of the story?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) What does Ruth's story teach about loyalty in friendships and family? (2) How does God work in ordinary life when there are no big miracles? Where have you seen that? (3) Why is it significant that a foreigner from Moab is in the family line of Jesus?

📺 **Video for the week:** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs, Explorers | "Ruth" | `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Ruth` | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers, Trailblazers | "Ruth" or "Ruth and Boaz" | `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Ruth` | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers, Ambassadors | "Overview: Ruth"; theme video "Messiah" (optional) | `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Ruth` |

Preview first. Follow-up questions: (1) How did Ruth show loyal love? (2) How is Boaz like Jesus?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Ruth's Gleaning Grab*. See Games.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Wheat Sheaf Craft* and *Ruth-to-Jesus Family Tree*. See Activities.

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Say Joshua 1:9 from memory. Spell **R-U-T-H**, **N-A-O-M-I**, **B-O-A-Z**. Trailblazers / Ambassadors: **R-E-D-E-E-M-E-R**, **B-E-T-H-L-E-H-E-M**, **L-O-Y-A-L-T-Y**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, thank You for Your loyal love that never lets us go. Help us be kind and loyal friends like Ruth and Boaz. Thank You for Jesus, our Redeemer, who brings us into Your family. Amen.

Week 5 (optional): Review & Fun Sunday 🎉

Use the **End-of-Phase Review & Celebration** plan below.

Book Memory Song & Motions 🎵

This song **builds on** Phases 1 and 2. Always sing from the beginning: Library → Law → History!

Part A (review from Phase 1): "The Bible Library Song" (tune: *Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star*)

> 🎵 Sixty-six books, one big story, / All about God and all His glory! / Thirty-nine are in the Old, / Twenty-seven New, we're told. / Sixty-six books, one big story, / All about God and all His glory!

Part B (review from Phase 2): "The Law Song" (tune: *Ten Little Fingers*)

> 🎵 Gen-e-sis, Ex-o-dus, Le-vit-i-cus, / Num-bers and Deu-ter-on-o-my, / God gave His Word to Mo-ses, / Five books of the LAW!

Part C (NEW): "History Starts Here" (tune: *London Bridge Is Falling Down*)

Verse 1, the books:

> 🎵 **Josh-u-a, Judg-es, then comes Ruth,** *(march and trumpet → gavel → gather and hug)* **Then comes Ruth, then comes Ruth;** *(gather and hug, twice)* **Josh-u-a, Judg-es, then comes Ruth:** *(repeat motions)* **His-to-ry starts here!** *(point down at the floor on "here!")*

Verse 2, Joshua:

> 🎵 **Jericho walls came falling down,** *(hands high like a wall, then let them tumble down)* **Falling down, falling down; "Be strong and brave, God's always 'round!"** *(flex arms, then point up)* **Joshua one-nine!** *(hold up 1 finger, then 9 fingers)*

Verse 3, Judges:

> 🎵 **Round and round the people went,** *(draw a big circle in the air)* **People went, people went; They cried to God and judges were sent:** *(hands cupped at mouth, then gavel)* **Gideon, Deborah, Samson!** *(trumpet, palm-tree arms, strong arms)*

Verse 4, Ruth:

> 🎵 **"Where you go, I'll go," said Ruth,** *(point forward, walk fingers)* **Said to Naomi, loyal and true;** *(hug yourself)* **Boaz redeemed her (Jesus does too!),** *(arms wide, then point up)* **Great-grandma of David!** *(make a crown on your head)*

The "Eight Books" chant (steady clap)

> **Five books of LAW** *(clap-clap-clap)*: Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy! **Three books of HISTORY** *(stomp-stomp-stomp)*: Joshua, Judges, Ruth! **Five plus three is EIGHT!** *(hold up 5 fingers + 3 fingers)*: **EIGHT of SIXTY-SIX!**

Hand motions for all 8 books

#	Book	Motion	One word
1	Genesis	🌅 Sunrise hands	Beginnings
2	Exodus	🚪 Fingers walk out the door	Rescue
3	Leviticus	🙏 Fold hands, raise high	Holy
4	Numbers	🔢 Count, then zig-zag	Wilderness
5	Deuteronomy	✌️🧠❤️ Two fingers, tap head, hand on heart	Remember
6	Joshua	🎺 March in place with a fist trumpet	Conquer
7	Judges	🔨 Fist on palm, then a circle in the air	Cycle
8	Ruth	🌾 Scoop grain, then hug yourself	Loyalty

Section Shout

> **Teacher:** "What's the FIRST section?" **Kids:** "**LAW!** Five books!" *(5 fingers)* **Teacher:** "What's the SECOND section?" **Kids:** "**HISTORY!** Twelve books!" *(10 fingers + 2)* **Teacher:** "How many History books do we know?" **Kids:** "**THREE!** Joshua, Judges, Ruth!" **Teacher:** "How many more to go?" **Kids:** "**NINE** more next time!"

Cumulative recall drill

1. Sing Parts A, B and C (verse 1) straight through with motions.
2. **Motion-only round:** the teacher does only the motions, silently; kids call out the book names.
3. **Book-before / book-after:** "What comes after Deuteronomy?" (Joshua) "What comes before Ruth?" (Judges)
4. **Section sort:** call a book; kids shout "LAW!" or "HISTORY!"
5. **One-word round** for all 8 books.
6. **Bible facts** from Phase 1: 66 / 39 / 27; chapter versus verse; the Contents trick.
7. **Sword drill:** Joshua 1:9; Judges 21:25; Ruth 1:16.

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Aim to say "Joshua, Judges, Ruth" with motions, and "LAW" and "HISTORY" as section names. The London Bridge tune is easy for them!
- **Explorers:** Say all 8 books in order and spell Joshua, Judges and Ruth. Lead the "Eight Books" chant.
- **Trailblazers:** Say all 8 forwards and backwards with one-word summaries. Add the 12 judges as a bonus chant.
- **Ambassadors:** Lead Parts A–C for the younger kids. Challenge: name all 12 History books in order as a preview (Joshua, Judges, Ruth, 1 & 2 Samuel, 1 & 2 Kings, 1 & 2 Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther).

Spelling & Reading 🔤

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letters and sounds)	Explorers (book names and story words)	Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocab)	Ambassadors (book names + harder vocab)
J is for **J**oshua, **J**udges and **J**ericho	JOSHUA	All 8: GENESIS → RUTH	All 8: GENESIS → RUTH
R is for **R**uth and **R**ahab	JUDGES	**Vocab:** COURAGEOUS, JERICHO, JUDGE, REDEEMER, GLEAN	**Vocab:** CONQUEST, DELIVERER, NAZIRITE, HESED, GUARDIAN-REDEEMER
G is for **G**ideon	RUTH		
B is for **B**oaz	GIDEON		
Sound it out: *R-u-th* "Ruth"	SAMSON		
Trace: R-U-T-H	RAHAB, CALEB, NAOMI		

Little Lambs (letters and sounds)	Explorers (book names and story words)	Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocab)	Ambassadors (book names + harder vocab)
Clap it: Josh-u-a (3)	JERICHO		

Ambassadors vocab with definitions:

- **Conquest:** taking control of a land by force; in Joshua, God giving Canaan to Israel as He promised and judging the Canaanites' long-standing evil.
- **Deliverer:** one who rescues; the Bible's word for what a judge did (Judges 3:9, 15). Jesus is the ultimate Deliverer (1 Thessalonians 1:10).
- **Nazirite:** a person set apart to God by a special vow: no haircuts, no wine or grapes, no touching dead bodies (Numbers 6). Samson was one from birth (Judges 13:5).
- **Hesed** (HEH-sed): Hebrew for loyal, covenant, never-giving-up love; shown by Ruth, Boaz and, most of all, God.
- **Guardian-redeemer** (Hebrew *go'el*): a close relative responsible for buying back family land or people and protecting the family line (Leviticus 25:25; Ruth 3:9).

The syllable-clap method 👏

Word	Claps	Parts → letters
Joshua	3	Josh (J-O-S-H) · u (U) · a (A)
Judges	2	Judg (J-U-D-G) · es (E-S)
Ruth	1	Ruth (R-U-T-H)
Jericho	3	Jer (J-E-R) · i (I) · cho (C-H-O)
Gideon	3	Gid (G-I-D) · e (E) · on (O-N)
Redeemer	3	Re (R-E) · deem (D-E-E-M) · er (E-R)

Tips: **Judges** has a sneaky silent **D**: "jud-ges." **Joshua** ends with **U-A**, not "-ua" sounding like "wah." **Ruth** rhymes with "truth," and Ruth told Naomi the truth about being loyal!

"Spell It Out" relay, Jericho style

- **Setup:** Teams; letter cards for each word are taped on cardboard boxes stacked into a "wall" at the far end.
- **Play:** Runners march (no running!) to the wall, take one letter card from a box, and march back. When a team's word is complete and in order, they blow paper trumpets and shout the word. Then they get to knock down their wall!
- **Words:** JOSHUA, JUDGES, RUTH, RAHAB (Explorers); JERICHO, GIDEON, REDEEMER (Trailblazers); NAZIRITE, CONQUEST, DELIVERER (Ambassadors).
- **Little Lambs:** Find the letters J, J, R (the first letters of the three new books) and the letters of R-U-T-H.

Mini spelling bee word list (with sentences)

Word	Use it in a sentence
Joshua	*Joshua* led God's people into the Promised Land.
Judges	The book of *Judges* shows God sending rescuers again and again.
Ruth	*Ruth* said, "Your God will be my God."
Jericho	The walls of *Jericho* fell down flat.
Rahab	*Rahab* hung a scarlet cord in her window.
Caleb	*Caleb* was still strong at 85 years old.
Gideon	*Gideon* had only 300 men, but God won the battle.
Deborah	*Deborah* was a judge and a prophet.
Samson	God gave *Samson* great strength.
Naomi	*Naomi* came home to Bethlehem.
Boaz	*Boaz* was kind to Ruth.
courageous	God told Joshua, "Be strong and *courageous*."
redeemer	Jesus is our *Redeemer*.
Bethlehem	Ruth and Boaz lived in *Bethlehem*.
Nazirite	Samson was a *Nazirite*, set apart for God.

Read-aloud practice passage (Ruth 1:16–17, NIV)

> "But Ruth replied, 'Don't urge me to leave you or to turn back from you. Where you go I will go, and where you stay I will stay. Your people will be my people and your God my God. Where you die I will die, and there I will be buried. May the LORD deal with me, be it ever so severely, if even death separates you and me.'"

Reading tips: Read it like Ruth, with a strong, loyal voice. Notice the pairs: go / go, stay / stay, people / people, God / God. Have kids read it in pairs, one reading "Where you go," the other answering "I will go." Second passage (Explorers+): Joshua 1:9, read three times, getting louder each time like the Jericho shout!

Word Trivia ❓

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. Who became the leader of God's people after Moses?
2. What color was the cord Rahab hung in her window?

3. What fell down when the people shouted?
4. **Fill in the blank:** "Be strong and _____."
5. What river did God's people cross on dry ground?
6. How many times did they march around Jericho on the seventh day?
7. Who was very strong because God gave him strength?
8. **True or False:** Gideon had a really big army when he won the battle.
9. Who said, "Where you go I will go"?
10. What did Ruth gather in Boaz's field?
11. Who was Ruth's mother-in-law?
12. Which famous king was Ruth's great-grandson?

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

13. Name the 8 books we've learned so far, in order.
14. What does the name "Joshua" mean?
15. How many stones were taken out of the Jordan River?
16. **Who said it?** "As for me and my household, we will serve the LORD."
17. **Which book?** Gideon and Samson are found in which book?
18. How many men were left in Gideon's army?
19. What did Gideon's men carry into the battle?
20. **True or False:** Deborah was a judge and a prophet.
21. Who hid two spies on her roof?
22. How old was Caleb when he asked for his mountain?
23. What did the closer relative give Boaz to seal the deal?

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

24. What are the five steps of the Judges cycle?
25. Name at least six of the 12 judges.
26. **Fill in the blank:** "In those days Israel had no _____; everyone did as they saw _____." (Judges 21:25)
27. What did Achan take and hide?
28. What does "guardian-redeemer" mean?
29. What special vow did Samson have from birth, and what was its sign?
30. **Who said it?** "The LORD is with you, mighty warrior." (Judges 6:12)
31. Which two women from these books are listed in Jesus' family tree in Matthew 1?
32. **Fill in the blank:** "Not one of all the LORD's good _____ to Israel failed; every one was _____." (Joshua 21:45)
33. What does the Hebrew word *hesed* mean?
34. What was the name of Ruth's son, and who was his grandson?
35. What happened to the Jordan River when the priests' feet touched the water?

🔑 Answer Key

1. Joshua · 2. Red (scarlet) · 3. The walls of Jericho · 4. courageous · 5. The Jordan River · 6. Seven · 7. Samson · 8. False (only 300 men) · 9. Ruth · 10. Grain (barley and wheat) · 11. Naomi · 12. King

David
2. Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, Joshua, Judges, Ruth · 14. "The LORD saves" · 15. Twelve · 16. Joshua (Joshua 24:15) · 17. Judges · 18. 300 · 19. Trumpets, and torches inside clay jars · 20. True (Judges 4:4) · 21. Rahab · 22. 85 · 23. His sandal
3. Sin, Suffer, Shout (cry out), Savior (a judge is sent), Silence (peace), and then repeat · 25. Othniel, Ehud, Shamgar, Deborah, Gideon, Tola, Jair, Jephthah, Ibzan, Elon, Abdon, Samson · 26. king / fit · 27. A beautiful robe, 200 shekels of silver and a bar of gold (Joshua 7:21) · 28. A close relative who buys back family land or people and protects the family · 29. The Nazirite vow; never cutting his hair · 30. The angel of the LORD · 31. Rahab and Ruth (Matthew 1:5) · 32. promises / fulfilled · 33. Loyal, faithful, covenant love · 34. Obed; David (Obed → Jesse → David) · 35. It stopped flowing and piled up upstream so the people crossed on dry ground (Joshua 3:15–17)

Games 🎮

(More games and variations: `../00-start-here/game-library.md`)

1. Jericho Walls

- **Best for:** All ages.
- **Supplies:** 20+ cardboard boxes or plastic cups for a "wall"; paper trumpets or kazoos; a "trumpet" signal (a whistle or a real trumpet sound on a phone).
- **Setup:** Build the wall in the center of the room. Kids line up behind a "priest" (an Ambassador holding a toy "ark," such as a decorated box on two poles).
- **How to play:** Kids march around the wall in silence (Joshua 6:10) as you count "Day 1, Day 2..." up to Day 6 (one lap each). On Day 7 they march 7 laps. On the long trumpet blast, everyone shouts, and a helper knocks the wall down. Then rebuild, and on the second round, each lap requires a kid to say one book name in order (Genesis through Ruth, then start again).
- **How to win:** It's a celebration game: everyone wins when the wall falls! Optional: time the second round to beat your record.
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* fewer laps (Day 7 = 3 laps) and lots of shouting. *Ambassadors:* they lead, and each lap they must quote a promise of God.
- **Learning goal:** The Jericho story; obedience and faith; book-name review.

2. Crossing the Jordan

- **Best for:** All ages.
- **Supplies:** Blue tarp or blue paper "river"; 12 paper "stones" (gray paper plates) each with a review question on the back.
- **Setup:** Lay the river across the room; place the 12 stones inside it as stepping stones.
- **How to play:** Teams take turns. To step on a stone, a player picks it up, answers its question, and if correct, places it on the far bank to build the "memorial pile." Wrong answers: the stone stays, and the next player tries.
- **How to win:** When all 12 stones are on the far bank, the whole class has "crossed" and shouts "God stopped the river!" For competition, use two rivers and race.

- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* questions are pictures ("Who is this?") or "Say a book name." *Ambassadors:* questions from the ⭐⭐⭐ list.
- **Learning goal:** The Jordan crossing; remembering God's faithfulness.

3. Rahab's Rescue Rope

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers (Little Lambs as "family members").
- **Supplies:** A long red ribbon or rope; a "window" (a hula hoop held up, or a doorway).
- **Setup:** One child is Rahab, holding the red cord in the "window." Two players are "spies." Several "soldiers of Jericho" are taggers.
- **How to play:** The spies must reach Rahab's window without being tagged. If they make it, Rahab "lets them down" (they walk through the hoop). Then Rahab's family members (the rest of the kids) must also reach the red cord. Anyone touching the red cord is safe and can't be tagged.
- **How to win:** Once everyone's holding the red cord, read Joshua 6:25: "Joshua spared Rahab... and all who belonged to her."
- **Adaptation:** *Older kids:* players must say a book name or Bible fact before they can grab the cord.
- **Learning goal:** Rahab's faith and rescue; salvation for all who trust.

4. Twelve Stones Stepping Race

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors.
- **Supplies:** For each team, 12 paper "stones," each labeled with one of the 12 tribes of Israel or, for younger kids, with book names in order.
- **Setup:** Teams line up; stones piled at the start.
- **How to play:** The first player places a stone a step ahead and steps on it; each next player places the next stone in order (Genesis, Exodus... or the tribes: Reuben, Simeon, Judah, Issachar, Zebulun, Benjamin, Dan, Naphtali, Gad, Asher, Ephraim, Manasseh). Players may only move on stones. The whole team must cross the "river" using the stone path.
- **How to win:** First team across with stones in the correct order.
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* stepping-stone path with pictures, no order needed. *Ambassadors:* tribes in the order of Joshua 13–19, or the 12 sons of Jacob.
- **Learning goal:** Teamwork; book order; the 12 tribes.

5. Gideon's Shrinking Army

- **Best for:** All ages.
- **Supplies:** None (optional: paper cups of water for the "drinking test").
- **Setup:** All kids stand in an open space as "Gideon's army." A leader is "Gideon."
- **How to play:** Like "Simon Says," but Gideon says "**God says...**" Round 1: "Anyone afraid, go home!" (Judges 7:3; everyone who giggles goes to the side.) Then quick commands: "God says march!", "God says blow your trumpet!", "Shout!" (Without "God says," anyone who moves sits out.) Keep going until only a few are left: "Now there are just enough for God to win the battle!"
- **How to win:** The last few players lead the final victory shout: "**A sword for the LORD and for Gideon!**" Then explain: "God made the army small so everyone would know *He* won."

- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* simple commands and quick restarts. *Older kids:* commands include Bible facts ("God says hop if Gideon was a judge!").
- **Learning goal:** Listening to God; God's strength in our weakness (2 Corinthians 12:9).

6. Torch & Trumpet Night Tag

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors.
- **Supplies:** Flashlights (torches) hidden in paper bags or under cups (jars); a room that can be darkened safely; glow sticks for "Midianites."
- **Setup:** Turn the lights down (not fully dark; keep it safe). "Midianites" wearing glow sticks hide around the room. Gideon's team of "300" holds covered flashlights.
- **How to play:** On "Now!", the team lifts their cups (revealing the light), shouts "For the LORD and for Gideon!" and "tags" Midianites with flashlight beams. Tagged Midianites must sit down.
- **How to win:** Gideon's team wins when all Midianites are tagged; then switch roles.
- **Adaptation:** *Ambassadors:* run it for younger kids, with careful supervision. Keep lights partly on for anxious kids.
- **Learning goal:** The Gideon story; God gives victory.

7. Ruth's Gleaning Grab

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers (older kids as "Boaz's workers").
- **Supplies:** Yellow paper strips or pipe cleaners ("barley"), a few gold-colored strips (bonus "extra from Boaz"), a basket per child.
- **Setup:** "Harvesters" (older kids or helpers) walk across the "field," dropping barley strips. "Ruths" follow behind.
- **How to play:** Ruths may only pick up what's dropped *behind* the harvesters. Boaz (a teacher) secretly tells harvesters to "drop extra on purpose" (Ruth 2:16): gold strips.
- **How to win:** At the end, everyone counts their barley. Gold strips are worth 5. Everyone shares their gleanings so that all baskets are equal: "Boaz was kind and generous!"
- **Adaptation:** *Older kids:* each gold strip has a trivia question; answer it to keep the 5 points.
- **Learning goal:** Ruth's story; kindness and generosity to those in need.

8. History Shelf Hop (review game)

- **Best for:** All ages.
- **Supplies:** Painter's tape for a hopscotch grid of 8 squares, labeled with the 8 books in order (Law squares one color, History squares another).
- **How to play:** Kids hop through saying each book as they land. On the way back, they say the one-word summary. A tossed beanbag marks a square; when you land there, do that book's motion.
- **How to win:** Complete the hop with no mistakes for a sticker. Add more squares each phase!
- **Adaptation:** *Little Lambs:* hop with a buddy who says the names with them. *Ambassadors:* say the book's key person on every square.
- **Learning goal:** Cumulative book order (8 of 66).

Coloring Pages 🖍️

> Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-03-printables.html`

Page 1: The Walls of Jericho Fall (Week 1)

- **Scene:** Big stone walls tumbling down with bricks flying (no people hurt); seven priests in robes blowing long, curly ram's-horn trumpets; Joshua in front with arms raised; one section of the wall still standing with a window and a red cord hanging out (Rahab's house!).
- **Caption:** *"Be strong and courageous." Joshua 1:9*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Can you find Rahab's window? What color is the cord? Why did the walls fall down? What's a 'wall' (a big problem) you need God's help with?"

Page 2: Crossing the Jordan and the 12 Stones (Week 1)

- **Scene:** Priests standing in a dry riverbed holding the gold ark of the covenant on poles; water piled up in the distance; families crossing; 12 men each carrying a big stone on their shoulder.
- **Caption:** *"What do these stones mean?" Joshua 4:6*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Count the stones! What does your family 'remember' about God's goodness?"

Page 3: "As for Me and My House" (Week 2)

- **Scene:** A house with an open door, a family (parents, kids, grandparents, a pet) standing together in front; a big stone under a tree beside them; old Caleb waving from a hill in the background.
- **Caption:** *"As for me and my household, we will serve the LORD." Joshua 24:15*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Draw your own family members in the doorway! What's one way your family serves God?"

Page 4: Gideon's 300 (Week 3)

- **Scene:** Nighttime on a hill; men holding ram's-horn trumpets in one hand and broken clay jars with bright torches in the other; the enemy camp of tents below in confusion; a moon and stars.
- **Caption:** *"The LORD is with you, mighty warrior." Judges 6:12*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Use bright colors for the torches! God called scared Gideon 'mighty warrior.' What do you think God sees in you?"

Page 5: Deborah under the Palm Tree / Samson (Week 3, optional)

- **Scene (left):** Deborah sitting under a big palm tree helping people who came to her. **(Right):** Strong Samson pushing two temple pillars apart.
- **Caption:** *"They cried out to the LORD, and he raised up for them a deliverer." Judges 3:9*

- **Coloring conversation:** "Who gave Deborah wisdom and Samson strength? Who is our perfect Deliverer?"

Page 6: Ruth Gleaning in Boaz's Field (Week 4)

- **Scene:** Golden fields of grain; workers harvesting with sickles; Ruth with a basket picking up stalks; Boaz, kind and smiling, pointing workers to drop extra; Naomi in the distance near Bethlehem's walls.
- **Caption:** *"Where you go I will go... your God my God." Ruth 1:16*
- **Coloring conversation:** "How did Ruth show loyal love? Who can you be a loyal friend to this week?"

Page 7: History Begins! (book-name page)

- **Scene:** A bookshelf with the 5 Law books already "colored in" (filled with stripes), then three new books in bubble letters: JOSHUA (trumpet and walls), JUDGES (gavel and circle arrow), RUTH (wheat sheaf and heart). Banner: "8 of 66 · LAW ✔ · HISTORY 3 of 12."
- **Caption:** *"Joshua, Judges, then comes Ruth!"*
- **Coloring conversation:** "Can you name all eight books on the shelf? How many History books are left to learn? (9!)"

Activities & Crafts ✂️

1. Jericho Trumpet (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Paper-towel tubes or rolled paper cones, gold or brown paint/markers, curling ribbon, stickers, tape.
- **Steps:** (1) Roll a sheet of paper into a cone (or use a tube) and tape it. (2) Decorate it like a ram's horn with stripes. (3) Add ribbons coming out of the wide end. (4) Write "Be strong and courageous! Joshua 1:9" along the side.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* pre-rolled tubes; stickers and crayons. *Older kids:* draw seven marks on it (seven trumpets, seven days, seven laps) and write the book names Genesis–Ruth around the horn.
- **What it teaches:** Faith and obedience in the Jericho story; courage in God's presence.

2. Rahab's Scarlet Cord Window (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Brown cardstock (the wall), a window cut-out (fold-open shutters), red yarn, glue, markers.
- **Steps:** (1) Draw bricks on the cardstock. (2) Cut a window with shutters that open. (3) Inside the window, draw Rahab's family. (4) Glue red yarn hanging out of the window. (5) Write "Rahab trusted God and was saved. Hebrews 11:31."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* pre-cut windows; glue on the yarn and draw faces. *Ambassadors:* add a note connecting the red cord, the Passover blood and Jesus' blood.
- **What it teaches:** Salvation by faith; God welcomes anyone who trusts Him.

3. Memorial Stones (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Smooth rocks (one or more per child), acrylic paint pens or markers, sealer spray (optional, done by an adult).
- **Steps:** (1) On one rock, write or draw something God has done for you or your family (Little Lambs: a heart or a smiley). (2) On the back, write "Joshua 4:7." (3) Older kids make 12 small stones, one for each "God did it!" memory.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* paint with fingers or dot markers; the teacher writes. *Ambassadors:* write a testimony sentence to share with the class.
- **What it teaches:** Remembering and telling God's faithfulness to the next generation.

4. "As for Me and My House" Door Hanger (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Door-hanger shapes cut from cardstock (or paper plates with a hole), markers, stickers, ribbon.
- **Steps:** (1) Write Joshua 24:15b: "As for me and my household, we will serve the LORD." (2) Draw your family. (3) On the back, list 3 ways your family can serve God this week (pray at dinner, help a neighbor, give to someone in need).
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* the teacher pre-writes; kids decorate and add a family picture. *Older kids:* use calligraphy or bubble lettering.
- **What it teaches:** Choosing to serve God as an individual and a family.

5. Gideon's Jar & Torch (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Paper or plastic cups (the "jars"), yellow, orange and red tissue paper, craft sticks, tape; optional battery tea lights.
- **Steps:** (1) Glue tissue "flames" onto a craft stick (or use a tea light). (2) Decorate the outside of the cup like a clay jar. (3) Hide the torch inside the cup. (4) Write on the cup: "The LORD is with you, mighty warrior! Judges 6:12." (5) Practice the reveal: lift the cup, shout "For the LORD!"
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* pre-made flames. *Ambassadors:* connect it to 2 Corinthians 4:6–7 ("treasure in jars of clay"): God's light shines through ordinary people.
- **What it teaches:** God uses small and weak people for His glory.

6. Judges Cycle Wheel (Week 3, Explorers and older)

- **Supplies:** Two paper plates, a brass fastener, markers.
- **Steps:** (1) Divide the bottom plate into 5 sections: SIN (an idol), SUFFER (a sad face), SHOUT (hands up), SAVIOR (a judge), SILENCE / peace (a dove). (2) Cut a window in the top plate. (3) Fasten together and spin to show the cycle. (4) On the top plate write: "Jesus breaks the cycle! Judges 21:25 → John 8:36."
- **Age adaptations:** *Explorers:* pre-labeled sections, they draw pictures. *Ambassadors:* add the names of the judges around the edge in order.
- **What it teaches:** The pattern of Judges and our need for Jesus.

7. Wheat Sheaf Craft (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Yellow construction paper strips, brown yarn or ribbon, glue, cardstock backing; optional real wheat stalks (from a craft store).
- **Steps:** (1) Fringe-cut the yellow strips at the top for grain heads. (2) Bundle them and tie them in the middle with yarn. (3) Glue the sheaf to cardstock and write "Ruth 1:16" and "God provides through kind people."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* glue pre-cut strips. *Older kids:* write the name of someone they can be kind to this week, like Boaz.
- **What it teaches:** Loyal love, kindness and God's provision.

8. Ruth-to-Jesus Family Tree (Week 4, Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

- **Supplies:** Large paper, markers, Bibles open to Ruth 4:13–22 and Matthew 1:1–6, 16.
- **Steps:** (1) Draw a tree. (2) At the roots, write Abraham. (3) Up the trunk: Judah… Salmon + **Rahab** → Boaz + **Ruth** → Obed → Jesse → **David**. (4) At the top of the tree, write **Jesus** (Matthew 1:16). (5) Mark Rahab and Ruth with hearts: two women from outside Israel, welcomed by grace!
- **Age adaptations:** *Explorers:* fill in a pre-drawn tree with name stickers.
- **What it teaches:** God's big plan to bring Jesus; His grace for all nations.

Word Puzzles 🧩

Word Scramble

#	Scrambled	Hint
1	HUSAJO	Book 6, leader after Moses
2	SEDGUJ	Book 7, the "cycle" book
3	HURT	Book 8, loyal love
4	CHOJIRE	City whose walls fell
5	BAHAR	Hung a scarlet cord
6	BACLE	Strong at 85
7	DONIGE	Had 300 men
8	HADROBE	Judge under a palm tree
9	MASNOS	Strongest judge
10	MIANO	Ruth's mother-in-law
11	ZOBA	Kind guardian-redeemer
12	DRAJON	River that stopped flowing
13	MEDEERER	One who buys back
14	SOURCEGUAO	"Be strong and _____"

🔑 **Answers:** 1. JOSHUA · 2. JUDGES · 3. RUTH · 4. JERICHO · 5. RAHAB · 6. CALEB · 7. GIDEON · 8. DEBORAH · 9. SAMSON · 10. NAOMI · 11. BOAZ · 12. JORDAN · 13. REDEEMER · 14. COURAGEOUS

Fill-in-the-Blank Story

Word bank: courageous, Jordan, red, seven, serve, judges, 300, Samson, Naomi, Boaz, David, Jesus

> God told Joshua, "Be strong and **(1)**." God stopped the **(2)** River so the people could cross. Rahab hung a **(3)** cord in her window. On the seventh day, the people marched around Jericho **(4)** times, and the walls fell! Joshua said, "As for me and my household, we will **(5)** the LORD." After Joshua died, God sent rescuers called **(6)**. Gideon won a battle with only **(7)** men. God gave **(8)** great strength. Ruth stayed with her mother-in-law, **(9)**. A kind man named **(10)** became Ruth's redeemer. Their great-grandson was King **(11)**. And from their family came **(12)**, our Redeemer!

🔑 **Answers:** 1. courageous · 2. Jordan · 3. red · 4. seven · 5. serve · 6. judges · 7. 300 · 8. Samson · 9. Naomi · 10. Boaz · 11. David · 12. Jesus

Match the Book to Its Picture / Summary

Book	Picture / summary
1. Deuteronomy	A. 🌾 A loyal widow, a kind redeemer, a baby in David's family
2. Joshua	B. 🔨🔄 Round and round: sin, suffer, shout, Savior, silence
3. Judges	C. ❤️ Moses' farewell: "Love the LORD your God"
4. Ruth	D. 🎺 Walls fall down, the river stops, "Be strong and courageous"
5. Genesis	E. 🌅 Creation, the flood, Abraham, Joseph
6. Exodus	F. 🚪🌊 Plagues, Passover, the Red Sea, the Ten Commandments

🔑 **Answers:** 1-C · 2-D · 3-B · 4-A · 5-E · 6-F

Questions for Every Age 💭

Little Lambs (4–6)

1. When do you feel scared? Who is always with you?
2. What did God do to the walls of Jericho?
3. How did Gideon's tiny army win?
4. How was Ruth a good friend?
5. How can you be kind like Boaz this week?

Explorers (7–10)

1. What does it mean to be "strong and courageous" at school?
2. Achan hid what he took. Why is it better to tell the truth when we do wrong?
3. What's a "cycle" you sometimes get stuck in (like losing your temper)? How can God help?
4. God used a scared farmer (Gideon). What does that tell you about how God can use you?
5. Who in your life is loyal like Ruth? How can you thank them?

Trailblazers (11–13)

1. Joshua 1:9 says God is with you "wherever you go." Where do you most need to remember that?
2. Caleb followed God wholeheartedly for 45+ years. What helps someone stay faithful for a lifetime?
3. Why do you think every judge had flaws? What does that teach about human heroes?
4. "Everyone did as they saw fit" (Judges 21:25). Where do you see that attitude today?
5. In Ruth, God never does a big miracle, yet He's working everywhere. How might God be working quietly in your life?

Ambassadors (14–17)

1. Joshua 24:15 is a personal choice. Have you made that choice for yourself? What would it look like to say it out loud?
2. How does Rahab's story challenge the idea that some people are "too far gone" for God?
3. What lessons from Samson's life apply to gifted, talented people today?
4. Judges 2:10 describes a generation that didn't know God. What can you do to help younger kids know Him? (You're doing it now!)
5. How is Jesus a better Joshua, a better Judge and a better Boaz?

🧠 Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics / worldview)

1. **"How could a loving God command the destruction of the Canaanites?"** *Suggested answer:* This is a hard question, and it's okay to wrestle with it. Some things to consider: (a) It was **judgment** for centuries of serious evil, including child sacrifice (Deuteronomy 12:31; 18:9–12), after God had waited over 400 years (Genesis 15:16). (b) It was **limited** to a specific time and place, not a permanent command for God's people to fight anyone. (c) God **judged Israel too** when it did the same evil (2 Kings 17). (d) **Mercy was available:** Rahab and the Gibeonites turned to God and were spared. (e) Ancient war reports often used exaggerated, sweeping language ("left no survivors"), and later passages show Canaanites still living there (Judges 1). (f) Ultimately, the cross shows God taking judgment on Himself so that people from every nation, including Canaanites, can be saved. Christians are never called to "holy war"; Jesus says to love our enemies (Matthew 5:44).
2. **"Is the Bible just a book of moral heroes? Many of these people are pretty bad."** *Suggested answer:* The Bible isn't mainly about heroes to copy; it's about a God who rescues flawed people. Gideon doubted and later made an idol; Samson was selfish; Israel kept forgetting God. The Bible is brutally honest about its people, which is one reason to trust it. Myths usually make their

heroes look good. The real hero of every story is God, and every flawed rescuer points to Jesus, the only perfect Savior.

3. **"Why does it matter that Rahab and Ruth are in Jesus' family tree?"** *Suggested answer:* Both were outsiders. Rahab was a Canaanite with a sinful past and Ruth was a Moabite, from nations considered enemies of Israel. Their inclusion shows that God's plan was always for "all peoples on earth" (Genesis 12:3), that grace isn't earned by background or record, and that Jesus came for everyone. It also shows that the Bible's genealogy isn't a cleaned-up royal record; it's honest, and full of grace.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration 🎉

Review game plan (last Sunday of the month, 75 minutes)

Time	Activity
10 min	Welcome + sing Parts A, B and C with motions; "Eight Books" chant; Section Shout
15 min	**Promised Land Game Show:** teams answer trivia; each correct answer earns a paper stone to build their "memorial pile." The tallest pile wins
10 min	**Jericho Walls Finale:** march 7 laps saying all 8 books (one book per lap, plus a final shout of all 8)
10 min	**History Shelf Hop** relay (8-square hopscotch)
15 min	**Oral check-offs** while others color Page 7 or finish the Family Tree
10 min	**Passport stamping & badge ceremony**: blow paper trumpets as each name is called!
5 min	Everyone says Joshua 1:9 together; prayer; Take-Home Family Page

Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs (4–6) ☐ Say the section names "LAW" and "HISTORY" ☐ Say "Joshua, Judges, Ruth" with motions ☐ Say "Be strong and courageous." ☐ Tell one story (Jericho, Gideon or Ruth) in one sentence ☐ Review: "The Bible has 66 books; Genesis is first"

Explorers (7–10) ☐ Say all 8 books in order ☐ Spell Joshua, Judges and Ruth ☐ Say Joshua 1:9 ☐ Name 3 judges ☐ Find Joshua 1:9 and Ruth 1:16 using the Contents page

Trailblazers (11–13) ☐ Say all 8 books forwards and backwards with a one-word summary for each ☐ Spell all 8 books ☐ Say Joshua 1:9 ☐ Explain the Judges cycle ☐ Explain how Boaz points to Jesus

Ambassadors (14–17) ☐ All Trailblazer items ☐ Name the 10 library sections and their book counts ☐ Teach one of this month's books (summary + motion + key verse) to a younger child ☐ Give a thoughtful answer to one Big Question ☐ Draw the family line from Rahab and Ruth to David to Jesus

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp Phase 3 in each child's Bible Passport with a **trumpet** stamp (or sticker) labeled: **"Phase 3 ✔ Into the Promised Land · Joshua · Judges · Ruth · 8 of 66."** Kids who finish can also color the first 3 spines of the History shelf on their Bible Bookshelf craft from Phase 1.

🏅 Phase badge: The Jericho Trumpet Badge

A brass-gold circle: a curved ram's-horn trumpet across the middle, a few tumbling bricks below it, and a small golden wheat sheaf (for Ruth) in the corner, with a thin red cord (for Rahab) wrapped around the edge. Banner: "BE STRONG & COURAGEOUS · JOSHUA 1:9." Make it from cardstock with ribbon, or as a sticker or patch for the sash.

📜 Certificate wording

> **Purpose Church Sunday School Certificate of Completion: Phase 3, "Into the Promised Land"**
> This certifies that _____ has marched around Jericho with Joshua, met the judges, and gleaned with Ruth, learning **Joshua, Judges and Ruth**, the first three books of **HISTORY!** *"Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God will be with you wherever you go." Joshua 1:9* Books learned: **8 of 66** · Sections: **Law ✔** · **History 3 of 12** · Teacher: _____ · Date: _____

Take-Home Family Page 🏠

Dear Parents and Caregivers,

This month we began the **History** section of the Bible with **Joshua, Judges and Ruth**. Your child learned how God brought His people into the Promised Land (the Jordan River crossing, the walls of Jericho, and brave Rahab with her scarlet cord), how Joshua challenged everyone to "choose... whom you will serve," how God sent judges like Deborah, Gideon and Samson whenever His people cried out, and how Ruth's loyal love and Boaz's kindness led to King David and, eventually, to Jesus, our Redeemer. Your child now knows **8 of the 66 books!**

📖 **Memory verse:** "Have I not commanded you? Be strong and courageous. Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God will be with you wherever you go." (Joshua 1:9, NIV) **Little Lambs:** "Be strong and courageous."

🎵 **Our song (sing all three parts in a row!):**

> *Twinkle tune:* Sixty-six books, one big story, / All about God and all His glory! ... *Ten Little Fingers tune:* Gen-e-sis, Ex-o-dus, Le-vit-i-cus, / Num-bers and Deu-ter-on-o-my, / God gave His Word to Mo-ses, / Five books of the LAW! *London Bridge tune:* Josh-u-a, Judg-es, then comes Ruth, / Then comes Ruth, then comes Ruth; / Josh-u-a, Judg-es, then comes Ruth: / His-to-ry starts here!

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions:**

1. What is something that makes you feel scared? How does Joshua 1:9 help?
2. What would "As for me and my household, we will serve the LORD" look like in our family this week?
3. Who has been a loyal friend to you, like Ruth was to Naomi?

👨‍👩‍👧 **Family activity: "Family Memorial Stones."** Joshua set up stones so families would remember what God had done. Find a few rocks together. On each one, write or draw something God has done for your family (a prayer answered, a new baby, a safe move, a friend). Put them in a bowl on your table. When someone asks, "What do these stones mean?" (Joshua 4:6), tell the story!

📺 **Videos to watch at home** (search these channels on YouTube):

- **@SharefaithKids:** search "Jericho," "Gideon," "Ruth": `https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Jericho`
- **@BibleJourneyTV:** search "Joshua," "Ruth": `https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Ruth`
- **@bibleproject:** "Overview: Joshua," "Overview: Judges," "Overview: Ruth": `https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Joshua`

Next month: Phase 4, "Kings & Kingdoms." We'll learn 1 and 2 Samuel, 1 and 2 Kings, and 1 and 2 Chronicles: Samuel, Saul, David and Goliath, Solomon, Elijah, and more!

For more on the year, see `../00-start-here/program-overview.md` and `../00-start-here/books-of-the-bible-memory-system.md`.

Phase 4: Kings & Kingdoms

Israel asks for a king, and God shows that He is the true King, and that the best King of all is still coming.

At a Glance	
Month	Month 4
Books covered	1 Samuel, 2 Samuel, 1 Kings, 2 Kings, 1 Chronicles, 2 Chronicles (**6 books**)
Bible section(s)	History (books 9–14 of the Bible; books 4–9 of the 12 History books)
Big Idea	God looks at the heart. Kings come and go, but God's promise of a forever King never fails.
Memory Verse (all ages)	"People look at the outward appearance, but the LORD looks at the heart." (1 Samuel 16:7, NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"The LORD looks at the heart." (1 Samuel 16:7)
Theme color	Royal purple (with gold trim)
Phase symbol / badge	A gold crown with a small red heart in the middle (the "Heart Crown" badge)
Running total of books learned	**14 of 66** (Law 5 + History 9 of 12)

The Big Idea (in kid words)

God's people said, "We want a king like everybody else!" God gave them kings. Some kings loved God and some did not. God does not pick people because they are tall, strong or good-looking. He looks at the heart. God made a promise to King David: "Someone from your family will be King forever."

How this points to Jesus: Jesus is that forever King! He was born in Bethlehem, King David's hometown, and He is called the "Son of David" (Matthew 1:1). Every king in these books messed up somehow, even the good ones. Jesus is the perfect King who never does wrong, who fought the biggest giant (sin and death) for us, and whose kingdom will never end (Luke 1:32–33).

The Books in Easy Words

> Teacher tip: Say the numbers out loud as words: "**First** Samuel," "**Second** Kings." Show the number with your fingers (1 finger, then 2 fingers). Explain that these were once one long book each, split into two scrolls because they were too long to fit on one.

1. 1 Samuel

- **How to say it:** "FIRST SAM-yoo-ul"
- **How to spell it:** Sam-u-el, S-A-M-U-E-L (with the number 1 in front)
- **Section:** History
- **Traditional author:** Samuel wrote the early part. The prophets Nathan and Gad probably added more (1 Chronicles 29:29). We don't know who put the book together in its final form.
- **One-sentence kid summary:** God gives Israel a prophet named Samuel, then their first king, Saul, who stops obeying, so God chooses a shepherd boy named David whose heart loves God.
- **In one word:** *Chosen*
- **Key people:** Hannah, Eli, Samuel, Saul, David, Jonathan, Goliath
- **Key stories:** Hannah prays for a baby (ch. 1); God calls young Samuel in the night (ch. 3); Israel asks for a king (ch. 8); Saul becomes king (ch. 9–10); David is anointed (ch. 16); David and Goliath (ch. 17); David and Jonathan's friendship (ch. 18–20); David spares Saul's life (ch. 24, 26)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** David is anointed with oil. "Messiah" and "Christ" both mean "Anointed One." Like David, Jesus was chosen by God and faced the giant enemy for His people. Hannah's song (ch. 2) sounds a lot like Mary's song (Luke 1:46–55).
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 👂 Cup a hand behind your ear, because Samuel said "Speak, for your servant is listening" (1 Samuel 3:10). Picture: a sling and five smooth stones.

2. 2 Samuel

- **How to say it:** "SEC-und SAM-yoo-ul"
- **How to spell it:** Sam-u-el, S-A-M-U-E-L (with the number 2 in front)
- **Section:** History
- **Traditional author:** Not named. Tradition says Nathan and Gad, prophets in David's court, recorded these events.
- **One-sentence kid summary:** David becomes king, God promises him a forever kingdom, David sins badly and is sorry, and his family has big troubles.
- **In one word:** *Promise*
- **Key people:** David, Mephibosheth, Bathsheba, Nathan the prophet, Absalom, Joab
- **Key stories:** David becomes king of Judah, then of all Israel (ch. 2, 5); David captures Jerusalem (ch. 5); David dances as the ark comes to Jerusalem (ch. 6); God's forever promise to David (ch. 7); kindness to Mephibosheth, who could not walk (ch. 9); David's sin and Nathan's story of the lamb (ch. 11–12); Absalom rebels against his father (ch. 15–18)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** 2 Samuel 7:16, "Your throne will be established forever." Jesus is the Son of David who sits on that forever throne. The way David brought Mephibosheth to eat at the king's table is a picture of how Jesus welcomes us.
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 🤝 Make a pinky promise with a friend for God's promise to David. Picture: a throne with a "forever" sign (∞).

3. 1 Kings

- **How to say it:** "FIRST KINGZ"
- **How to spell it:** Kings, K-I-N-G-S (with the number 1 in front)
- **Section:** History

- **Traditional author:** Not named. Jewish tradition says the prophet Jeremiah. The writer used older royal records ("the book of the annals of the kings").
- **One-sentence kid summary:** Wise King Solomon builds God's temple, then the kingdom splits in two, and the brave prophet Elijah shows that the LORD is the only true God.
- **In one word:** *Divided*
- **Key people:** Solomon, the Queen of Sheba, Rehoboam, Jeroboam, Ahab, Jezebel, Elijah, the widow of Zarephath
- **Key stories:** Solomon asks God for wisdom (ch. 3); the two mothers and the baby (ch. 3); Solomon builds the temple (ch. 6–8); the Queen of Sheba visits (ch. 10); Solomon's heart turns away (ch. 11); the kingdom splits into Israel (north) and Judah (south) (ch. 12); ravens feed Elijah (ch. 17); fire from heaven on Mount Carmel (ch. 18); God speaks in a gentle whisper (ch. 19)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** Jesus said, "Now something greater than Solomon is here" (Matthew 12:42). Jesus is the true Temple, the place where God lives with people (John 2:19–21). Elijah raised a widow's son (ch. 17), and Jesus raised a widow's son too (Luke 7:11–17).
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 👑✂️ Put a "crown" on your head with both hands, then make a scissors motion to "split" the kingdom. Picture: a crown split down the middle.

4. 2 Kings

- **How to say it:** "SEC-und KINGZ"
- **How to spell it:** Kings, K-I-N-G-S (with the number 2 in front)
- **Section:** History
- **Traditional author:** Not named. Jewish tradition says Jeremiah, the same writer as 1 Kings.
- **One-sentence kid summary:** Elisha does amazing miracles, most of the kings stop following God, and both kingdoms are finally taken away to faraway lands, just as God warned.
- **In one word:** *Warning*
- **Key people:** Elijah, Elisha, Naaman, the Shunammite woman, Joash (boy king at 7), Hezekiah, Josiah (boy king at 8)
- **Key stories:** Elijah goes to heaven in a whirlwind (ch. 2); the widow's oil keeps pouring (ch. 4); Elisha raises the Shunammite boy (ch. 4); Naaman is healed after dipping 7 times in the Jordan (ch. 5); the floating axe head (ch. 6); chariots of fire around Elisha (ch. 6); Israel falls to Assyria (ch. 17); Hezekiah prays (ch. 18–20); Josiah finds God's lost Book (ch. 22–23); Jerusalem falls to Babylon (ch. 25)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** Elisha fed 100 men with 20 loaves and had leftovers (2 Kings 4:42–44). Jesus fed 5,000 with five loaves! Jesus Himself talked about Naaman (Luke 4:27). The book ends with a king of David's family still alive in Babylon (25:27–30), so God's promise is not dead.
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 🌪️ Spin your finger in the air like a whirlwind (Elijah goes up!). Picture: a chariot of fire.

5. 1 Chronicles

- **How to say it:** "FIRST KRON-ih-kulz"
- **How to spell it:** Chron-i-cles, C-H-R-O-N-I-C-L-E-S (with the number 1 in front). Tip: the "Ch" sounds like "K"!
- **Section:** History
- **Traditional author:** Jewish tradition says Ezra the priest-scribe. Often just called "the Chronicler."

- **One-sentence kid summary:** A family-tree book that starts with Adam and retells King David's story, showing how David got everything ready for God's temple.
- **In one word:** *Remember*
- **Key people:** Adam (first name in the book!), Jabez, David, the Levites (worship leaders), Solomon
- **Key stories:** Long family trees from Adam to the return from exile (ch. 1–9); the prayer of Jabez (4:9–10); David brings the ark to Jerusalem with music and joy (ch. 13, 15–16); God's promise to David (ch. 17); David collects supplies and makes plans for the temple (ch. 22, 28–29)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** The family trees lead to David's family, and Matthew 1 continues that same family tree all the way to Jesus! God's promise in 1 Chronicles 17:12–14 ("I will establish his throne forever") is fulfilled in Jesus.
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 📜 Pretend to unroll a long scroll (a long family tree!). Picture: a tree with names on its branches.

6. 2 Chronicles

- **How to say it:** "SEC-und KRON-ih-kulz"
- **How to spell it:** Chron-i-cles, C-H-R-O-N-I-C-L-E-S (with the number 2 in front)
- **Section:** History
- **Traditional author:** Jewish tradition says Ezra (the Chronicler)
- **One-sentence kid summary:** The story of Solomon's temple and the kings of Judah, and how God always forgave when His people humbled themselves and prayed.
- **In one word:** *Return*
- **Key people:** Solomon, Jehoshaphat, Joash, Hezekiah, Josiah, Cyrus king of Persia
- **Key stories:** Solomon dedicates the temple and fire falls from heaven (ch. 5–7); "If my people... will humble themselves and pray" (7:14); Jehoshaphat's choir marches in front of the army, "the battle is not yours, but God's" (ch. 20); Hezekiah's big Passover party (ch. 30); Josiah's reforms (ch. 34–35); Babylon destroys the temple (ch. 36); King Cyrus says, "Go home and rebuild!" (36:22–23)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** The temple was where God met His people. Jesus is "God with us" (Matthew 1:23). In the Hebrew Bible, 2 Chronicles is the very last book, and it ends by looking forward to going home, which Jesus makes possible forever.
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 🙏 Fold your hands in prayer and bow (2 Chronicles 7:14). Picture: Solomon's temple with fire on top.

> **The "twin books" trick:** All three pairs are twins. **Samuel** = the prophet who anointed the first kings. **Kings** = the kings after David. **Chronicles** = the replay (re-telling) with a focus on worship and the temple. Kids can remember: "**S**am, **K**ings, **C**hron: **S**tart, **K**eep going, **C**atch up!"

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher

These six books cover about 500 years, from roughly 1100 BC (the last judge, Samuel) to 586 BC (Jerusalem destroyed by Babylon) and, in the last two verses of 2 Chronicles, 538 BC (Cyrus lets the Jews go home).

- **1–2 Samuel** describe the change from judges to kings. In 1 Samuel 8 the people ask for a king "such as all the other nations have." God warns them through Samuel, then gives them Saul. Saul looks the part (tall, handsome), but he disobeys (ch. 13, 15). God sends Samuel to anoint David, the youngest of Jesse's sons (ch. 16). Much of 1 Samuel is about David running from a jealous Saul. In 2 Samuel, David becomes king (about 1010 BC), makes Jerusalem the capital, and receives God's covenant promise (2 Samuel 7), which is one of the most important chapters in the Old Testament. David then sins with Bathsheba and arranges the death of her husband Uriah (ch. 11). He repents when the prophet Nathan confronts him (ch. 12; see Psalm 51), but serious consequences follow in his family.
- **1–2 Kings** begin with Solomon (about 970–930 BC), who builds the temple and is famous for wisdom, but whose many foreign wives turn his heart to idols (1 Kings 11). After his death the kingdom divides (about 930 BC): **Israel** in the north (10 tribes, capital eventually Samaria) and **Judah** in the south (capital Jerusalem, kings from David's line). Every northern king is described as doing evil. Judah has a mix of good and bad kings. Prophets like **Elijah** and **Elisha** confront kings and call people back to God. Israel falls to **Assyria** in 722 BC (2 Kings 17). Judah falls to **Babylon**, and Jerusalem and the temple are destroyed in 586 BC (2 Kings 25).
- **1–2 Chronicles** were written later, after the exile, to people who had come back home. They retell the same history but focus on David's family, the temple, worship, and the pattern that when people humble themselves and seek God, He restores them. The Chronicler leaves out many of David's and Solomon's failures, not to hide them (they were already in Samuel–Kings) but to encourage a discouraged people with God's faithfulness.

Key truths to emphasize

1. **God is the true King.** Even when Israel wanted a human king, God was still in charge (1 Samuel 8:7; 12:12).
2. **God looks at the heart** (1 Samuel 16:7). Obedience matters more than looks, size, or impressive sacrifices (1 Samuel 15:22).
3. **God keeps His promises.** The promise to David (2 Samuel 7) stays alive even when the kingdom falls.
4. **Sin has consequences, but God forgives the humble** (2 Samuel 12; 2 Chronicles 7:14).
5. **Jesus is the forever King from David's family**, better than Saul, David or Solomon.

Timeline and map notes

- Draw a simple timeline on a long strip of butcher paper and add to it each week: `Samuel (judge/prophet) → Saul (1st king) → David → Solomon → SPLIT (930 BC) → Israel falls (722 BC) / Judah falls (586 BC) → Cyrus: go home! (538 BC)`

- Map: Show Bethlehem (David's hometown), the Valley of Elah (David and Goliath), Jerusalem (City of David, temple), Mount Carmel (Elijah), the Jordan River (Naaman), Samaria (northern capital), Assyria (Nineveh) to the northeast, and Babylon to the east.
- Show the split with two colors: blue for Israel (north), purple for Judah (south). The southern kingdom was called Judah after the tribe of Judah, and that is where the word "Jew" comes from.

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
Goliath's death	"David won, and the giant fell down."	"David's stone hit Goliath and he fell. God gave David the win."	Read 1 Samuel 17 as written. Discuss why the battle mattered.	Discuss ancient warfare and representative combat (one champion fights for the whole army).
David & Bathsheba	"David did something very wrong. He said sorry to God, and God forgave him."	"David took another man's wife and caused that man to die. God sent Nathan to tell him the truth. David was truly sorry (Psalm 51)."	Same as Explorers, with Nathan's parable read aloud (2 Samuel 12:1–7).	Discuss abuse of power, honesty about heroes, repentance vs. consequences.
Wars & kings killed	Skip details.	"There were many battles. Some kings were very bad."	Brief facts as they come up.	Discuss God's judgment and patience (He warned for centuries).
Jezebel, Baal worship	"Some people prayed to fake gods."	"Baal was a fake god. God showed He is the real God."	Explain Baal worship and why Elijah's challenge mattered.	Note that 1 Kings 18:40 records the prophets of Baal being killed; discuss covenant law and why Christians don't take up swords for God today (John 18:36).
The fall of Jerusalem	"Because the people kept doing wrong, they had to move far away. God still loved them."	"God warned many times. Babylon came and took them away. God promised they would come home."	Connect to Jeremiah and Daniel (coming in Phase 7).	Discuss exile as a theme (BibleProject "Exile" video).

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

- **"Was Goliath really a giant?"** The Bible says he was over 9 feet tall (1 Samuel 17:4) in most Hebrew copies. Either way he was huge, and David was a boy. The point is: God is bigger.
- **"Why did God let them have a king if it was a bad idea?"** The problem wasn't having a king. God had planned a king (Deuteronomy 17:14–20). The problem was that they wanted a king *instead* of trusting God. God gave them what they asked for and still worked it into His plan.
- **"Why did God choose David if David did bad things later?"** God doesn't choose perfect people (there aren't any!). David's heart kept coming back to God. When he sinned, he admitted it and asked for forgiveness.

- **"Is Elijah still alive?"** Elijah was taken to heaven without dying (2 Kings 2:11). He appeared with Moses when Jesus was transfigured (Matthew 17:3), so he is alive with God.
- **"Why are there two books with the same name?"** They were one long book that got split into two scrolls. Ask: "Have you ever had a book with Part 1 and Part 2?"
- **"Why does Chronicles repeat Kings?"** It's like watching the replay of a game from a different camera angle. It shows us new things.

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
1	1 Samuel 3; 8–10; 16	God Looks at the Heart	God calls Samuel and picks David because of his heart.	SharefaithKids "Samuel"; BibleJourneyTV "Samuel"; BibleProject "Overview: 1 Samuel"	Crown Grab	Heart Crown craft
2	1 Samuel 17; 2 Samuel 5, 7, 9	Giant Faith & a Forever Promise	God fights for us and keeps His forever promise.	SharefaithKids "David and Goliath"; BibleJourneyTV "David and Goliath"; BibleProject "Overview: 2 Samuel"	Giant Toss	Five Smooth Stones verse stones
3	1 Kings 3; 8; 12; 18	Wise King, Split Kingdom, Fire from Heaven	Ask God for wisdom; the LORD is the only true God.	SharefaithKids "Elijah"; BibleJourneyTV "Elijah Mount Carmel"; BibleProject "Overview: 1-2 Kings"	Kingdom Split Tag	Elijah's 12-Stone Altar
4	2 Kings 2; 5; 22–23; 2 Chronicles 7:14; 36:22–23	Prophets, Boy Kings & God's Replay Book	God keeps working and keeps His promises, even when kings fail.	SharefaithKids "Naaman"; BibleJourneyTV "Elisha"; BibleProject "Overview: Chronicles"	Seven Dips Relay	King Timeline Scroll
5 (optional)	Review of all six books	Royal Review Day	Jesus is the forever King.	Rewatch favorite clip	Throne Swap + Royal Bible Bowl	Royal Feast & badge ceremony

---

Weekly Lessons

Week 1: God Looks at the Heart

Scripture: 1 Samuel 3:1–10; 8:4–7; 10:23–24; 16:1–13

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that God speaks, that Israel asked for a king, and that God chooses people by looking at their hearts, not their outsides.

Opening hook / object lesson (5 min) *Supplies:* Two boxes. One is beautifully gift-wrapped with a bow but has trash inside (crumpled paper, a banana peel in a bag). The other is a plain brown paper bag with something wonderful inside (a wrapped treat for each child, or a shiny toy crown).

1. Hold up both. Ask, "Which one do you want?" (Most pick the pretty box.)
2. Open the pretty box: trash! Open the plain bag: treasure!
3. Say: "The outside didn't tell us what was inside. Today we'll learn that God doesn't look at the outside. He looks at the heart."

📖 **Story script (read aloud)**

> A long time ago, a woman named Hannah prayed and prayed for a baby. God answered her prayer, and she named her son **Samuel**. When Samuel was still a boy, he went to live at God's house to help the old priest, Eli.
>
> One night, Samuel was lying down when he heard a voice: "Samuel!" He jumped up and ran to Eli. "Here I am!" But Eli said, "I didn't call you. Go back to bed." This happened again... and again! Three times! Then Eli understood. "It's God calling you. Next time, say, 'Speak, LORD, for your servant is listening.'" So Samuel did. And God talked to Samuel. Samuel grew up to be God's prophet, a person who tells people God's messages.
>
> When Samuel was old, the people came to him and said, "Give us a king, like all the other nations have!" That made Samuel sad. God told him, "They are not turning away from you. They are turning away from Me as their King." But God let them have a king.
>
> The first king was **Saul**. Saul was tall, taller than everyone, and handsome. He *looked* like a king! But Saul did not obey God. He did things his own way.
>
> So God sent Samuel to Bethlehem, to a man named Jesse who had eight sons. The oldest son walked in. He was tall and strong. Samuel thought, "This must be the one!" But God said, "**People look at the outward appearance, but the LORD looks at the heart.**" One by one, seven sons walked by. God said no to each one.
>
> "Do you have any more sons?" Samuel asked. "Well, there's the youngest," said Jesse. "He's out taking care of the sheep." They sent for him. In came a young shepherd boy named **David**. God said, "This is the one!" Samuel poured oil on David's head to show that God had chosen him to be the next king.
>
> David wasn't the biggest or the oldest. But his heart loved God. And God was looking at his heart. God sees your heart too, and He loves you.

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Act out Samuel "sleeping" and jumping up three times. Have kids say "Here I am!" each time. Use a bottle of (water) "oil" to pretend-anoint a doll or stuffed sheep.
- **Explorers:** Count Jesse's sons on fingers (7 walk by + David = 8). Have kids find 1 Samuel in their Bibles (right after Ruth).
- **Trailblazers:** Read 1 Samuel 8:10–18 (what a king would take) and 1 Samuel 15:22 ("to obey is better than sacrifice"). Ask why Saul's outward religion wasn't enough.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss 1 Samuel 8:7: how does wanting to "be like everyone else" still pull at us? Have them lead the object lesson for Little Lambs.

💬 **Discussion questions**

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Who called Samuel in the night? (God) 2) What job did David have? (Shepherd) 3) What does God look at? (Our heart)
- *Explorers:* 1) How many times did God call Samuel before he answered? (3, then a 4th time he answered) 2) Why did God not choose David's oldest brother? 3) What is a way you can "listen" to God this week?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) What was wrong with the people's reason for wanting a king (8:5, 20)? 2) Compare Saul and David: what did each look like on the outside and inside? 3) What do people today judge others by on the outside?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) What does "anointed" mean, and how does it connect to the titles "Messiah" and "Christ"? 2) Saul offered sacrifices but disobeyed. How can church activity hide a heart problem? 3) If God looks at the heart, how should that change the way you post online or choose friends?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Samuel" / "God calls Samuel" / "David anointed" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Samuel | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Samuel" / "King Saul" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Samuel | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors (Explorers with pauses) | Likely title: "Overview: 1 Samuel" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=1+Samuel |

Follow-up questions: 1) What did the video show about why Israel wanted a king? 2) What did you notice about how God chose David?

> Preview every video first. Choose the clip that fits your time (about 10 minutes); show only part of a longer video if needed.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Crown Grab* (see Games). Use the 14 book names learned so far.

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Heart Crown craft* (see Activities & Crafts).

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Spell S-A-M-U-E-L. Learn "First Samuel, Second Samuel" with 1 and 2 fingers. Little Lambs: "The LORD looks at the heart" with motions (point up, point to eyes, hands make a heart).

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> Dear God, thank You that You see my heart. Help me listen to You like Samuel did. Make my heart love You like David's. In Jesus' name, amen.

Week 2: Giant Faith & a Forever Promise

Scripture: 1 Samuel 17; 2 Samuel 5:1–5; 7:12–16; 9:1–13

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that David trusted God to fight Goliath, that God promised David a forever King, and that David showed kindness like God does.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* A tape measure, painter's tape, and a picture of a person.

1. Before class, put a strip of tape on the wall at 9 feet 9 inches (about 3 meters), close to the ceiling. (Most Hebrew copies of 1 Samuel 17:4 say "six cubits and a span," about 9 feet 9 inches.)
2. Have kids stand against the wall to compare. Ask, "Would you want to fight someone this tall?"
3. Say: "One boy did, and he wasn't scared, because he knew God was bigger."

📖 **Story script**

> The army of Israel was camped on one hill. The Philistine army was camped on the other. In the valley between them stood a giant named **Goliath**. He was super tall, he wore heavy armor, and he carried a spear as thick as a fence post. Every morning and every evening for forty days, he shouted, "Send someone to fight me!" All of Israel's soldiers, even King Saul, were scared.
>
> One day, David, the young shepherd, came to bring food to his big brothers. He heard Goliath shouting. "Who is this man who makes fun of the army of the living God?" David asked. "I will fight him!"
>
> King Saul said, "You're just a boy!" But David said, "When I watched my sheep, God helped me fight a lion and a bear. God will help me fight this giant too."
>
> Saul gave David his armor, but it was too big and heavy. So David took it off. He took his shepherd's staff, his sling, and five smooth stones from a stream.
>
> Goliath laughed at him. But David shouted, "You come against me with a sword and spear, but I come against you in the name of the LORD! The battle is the LORD's!" David ran toward Goliath, put a stone in his sling, swung it around, and let it fly. *Thunk!* The stone hit Goliath's forehead, and the giant fell face down on the ground. God gave Israel the victory!
>
> Years later, David became king. God made David an amazing promise: "Someone from your family will be King forever. His kingdom will never end."
>
> King David remembered his best friend Jonathan, who had died. "Is anyone left from Jonathan's family that I can be kind to?" Someone told him about Jonathan's son, **Mephibosheth** (meff-IB-oh-sheth), whose feet had been hurt so he couldn't walk. Mephibosheth was afraid, but David said, "Don't be afraid. You will eat at my table like one of my sons, always."

> Many years later, the forever King came from David's family. His name is **Jesus**! He beat the biggest giants, sin and death, and He invites us to eat at His table forever.

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Let them stomp like Goliath and then "fall down." Give each child five "smooth stones" (cotton balls) to toss into a basket.
- **Explorers:** Have them find 1 and 2 Samuel and notice the chapters (1 Samuel 17 is a long chapter: 58 verses!). Practice spelling "Goliath."
- **Trailblazers:** Read 2 Samuel 7:12–16 aloud and then Luke 1:32–33. Have them list the matching words (throne, kingdom, forever).
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss "the battle is the LORD's" (1 Samuel 17:47). Is this a promise that we'll win every fight? (No. It means God's purposes win, and we trust Him.) Talk briefly about David's later sin with Bathsheba and Psalm 51: heroes in the Bible are real people who need grace.

💬 **Discussion questions**

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Who was the giant? (Goliath) 2) How many stones did David pick up? (5) 3) Who helped David? (God)
- *Explorers:* 1) Why didn't David wear Saul's armor? 2) What did God promise David? 3) How was David kind to Mephibosheth?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) What "practice" had David had trusting God before Goliath? 2) What "giants" do kids your age face? 3) How does Mephibosheth's story show us grace?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Why is 2 Samuel 7 called the "Davidic covenant," and why does the whole Bible care about it? 2) David is the hero against Goliath, but in a sense we are more like the scared soldiers and Jesus is like David. What does that change? 3) How do you hold together that David was "a man after God's own heart" and also a man who sinned badly?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "David and Goliath" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=David+and+Goliath | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "David and Goliath" / "King David" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=David+and+Goliath | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | Likely title: "Overview: 2 Samuel"; bonus theme video "The Messiah" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=2+Samuel |

Follow-up questions: 1) What gave David courage? 2) What did God promise David's family?

> Preview every video first. BibleProject's 2 Samuel overview mentions David's sin with Bathsheba; it is handled with care but decide which groups should watch.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Giant Toss* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Five Smooth Stones* verse stones (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Review 1 and 2 Samuel. Explorers spell G-O-L-I-A-T-H and D-A-V-I-D. Recite the whole memory verse with motions.

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> God, You are bigger than any giant. Help me be brave and trust You. Thank You for Jesus, the forever King. Amen.

Week 3: Wise King, Split Kingdom, Fire from Heaven

Scripture: 1 Kings 3:5–15; 8:10–11; 12:16–20; 18:20–39

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Solomon asked for wisdom and built the temple, that the kingdom split in two, and that God showed Elijah and everyone that He alone is the true God.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* A paper crown, scissors, and a "wish" card.

1. Ask: "If God said, 'Ask for anything you want,' what would you ask for?" Let kids answer (toys, pets, money...).
2. Say: "God really said this to King Solomon! Let's see what he asked for."
3. Later in the lesson, cut the paper crown in half to show the kingdom splitting.

📖 **Story script**

> After King David died, his son **Solomon** became king. One night God came to Solomon in a dream and said, "Ask for whatever you want me to give you."
>
> Solomon could have asked for riches or a long life. Instead, he said, "I'm young and I don't know how to lead all these people. Please give me a wise heart so I can tell right from wrong." God was so pleased! He said, "I will give you wisdom, and I will also give you riches and honor."
>
> Solomon built a beautiful **temple** for God in Jerusalem, made of stone, cedar wood and gold. When it was finished, God's glory filled it like a bright cloud! But later, when Solomon was old, he married many wives who prayed to fake gods, and his heart turned away from the LORD.
>
> After Solomon died, the kingdom split in two, like this crown. *(Cut the crown.)* Ten tribes in the north were called **Israel**. Two tribes in the south were called **Judah**. Many of the kings who came after did evil.
>
> One of the worst was King **Ahab**, and his wife **Jezebel**. They led people to pray to a fake god named **Baal**. So God sent a brave prophet named **Elijah**. Elijah said, "Let's have a contest on Mount Carmel! The 450 prophets of Baal will build an altar, and I will build an altar. Whoever answers with fire is the real God!"
>
> The prophets of Baal danced and shouted from morning until noon. "Baal, answer us!" Nothing happened. Elijah teased them, "Shout louder! Maybe he's asleep!" They shouted all afternoon. Still

> nothing.
>
> Then Elijah built an altar with 12 stones. He dug a ditch around it. Then he said, "Pour water on it!" They poured big jars of water, three times, until the wood was soaked and the ditch was full. Elijah prayed a simple prayer: "LORD, show everyone that You are God."
>
> **WHOOSH!** Fire fell from heaven! It burned up the sacrifice, the wood, the stones, and even licked up the water in the ditch! All the people fell on their faces and shouted, "**The LORD — He is God! The LORD — He is God!**"
>
> Fake gods can't hear us. But the real God hears even a short, simple prayer, and He answers.

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Have the "Baal prophets" (teachers) jump and shout while nothing happens, then everyone shouts "WHOOSH!" and waves orange/red streamers for the fire. Chant "The LORD, He is God!"
- **Explorers:** Hold up 12 fingers (with a friend) for the 12 stones = 12 tribes. Discuss why Elijah poured water on the altar.
- **Trailblazers:** Map the split kingdom: north = Israel (capital Samaria), south = Judah (capital Jerusalem). Read 1 Kings 18:21: "How long will you waver between two opinions?"
- **Ambassadors:** Compare Solomon's request (1 Kings 3) with James 1:5. Discuss: how can someone so wise make such foolish choices (1 Kings 11:4)? Wisdom must be lived, not just known.

💬 **Discussion questions**

- *Little Lambs:* 1) What did Solomon ask God for? (Wisdom / to be wise) 2) What fell from heaven? (Fire) 3) Who is the real God? (The LORD)
- *Explorers:* 1) Why was asking for wisdom a good choice? 2) What were the two kingdoms called? 3) Why did Baal not answer?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why did the kingdom split (1 Kings 11:9–13; 12:13–16)? 2) What did the 12 stones stand for? 3) What are "fake gods" people chase today?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) What does "wavering between two opinions" look like for a teen today? 2) Elijah's prayer was short; the Baal prophets' was long and loud. What does that say about prayer? 3) How is Jesus "greater than Solomon" (Matthew 12:42)?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Elijah" / "Elijah and the prophets of Baal" / "Solomon" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Elijah | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Elijah Mount Carmel" / "Solomon" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Elijah | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | Likely title: "Overview: 1-2 Kings" (one video covers both books) | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Kings |

Follow-up questions: 1) What happened after Solomon died? 2) What did the people shout when the fire fell?

> Preview every video first.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Kingdom Split Tag* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Elijah's 12-Stone Altar* (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Spell K-I-N-G-S. Say "First Kings, Second Kings" with the crown motion. Add these to the song.

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> LORD, You are the one true God! Please give me a wise heart like You gave Solomon. Help me follow only You. Amen.

Week 4: Prophets, Boy Kings & God's Replay Book

Scripture: 2 Kings 2:11; 5:1–15; 22:1–2, 8–13; 25:8–11; 1 Chronicles 17:11–14; 2 Chronicles 7:14; 36:22–23

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that God worked through Elisha, used boy kings who loved Him, warned His people, and kept His promise even when they were taken away. They'll learn that Chronicles is the "replay" of the story.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* A dusty old book (or a Bible wrapped in an old towel and hidden in a box), a damp cloth.

1. Before class, hide the "lost book" somewhere in the room.
2. Say, "Someone lost a very important book! Can you find it?" Let kids search.
3. When found, say: "A long time ago, God's people lost God's Book, inside God's own temple! An 8-year-old king was ruling when they found it. Let's hear what happened."

📖 **Story script**

> Before Elijah went to heaven, he had a helper named **Elisha**. One day, as they walked, a chariot of fire with horses of fire came between them, and Elijah went up to heaven in a whirlwind! Elisha became God's next prophet.
>
> In the land of Aram lived a strong army captain named **Naaman**. But Naaman had a terrible skin disease called leprosy. A young girl from Israel, who had been taken captive and worked in his house, said, "I wish my master would see the prophet in Israel. He would heal him!"
>
> So Naaman rode to Elisha's house with horses, chariots and gifts. Elisha didn't even come outside! He sent a message: "Go wash seven times in the Jordan River, and you'll be healed." Naaman was angry. "That muddy river? We have better rivers at home!" But his servants said, "If he asked you to do something hard, you would do it. Why not this easy thing?"

> So Naaman went down into the Jordan. One dip... two... three... four... five... six... **seven!** His skin became clean and soft like a little boy's. Naaman said, "Now I know there is no God in all the world except in Israel!"
>
> Sadly, most of the kings didn't listen to God. God sent prophet after prophet to warn them: "Turn back to Me!" But they wouldn't.
>
> Some kings did love God. **Josiah** became king when he was only **8 years old**! When he grew up, workers fixing the temple found a dusty scroll: God's Book of the Law! It had been lost. When Josiah heard it read, he tore his robes because his people had not obeyed God. Josiah cleaned out all the idols and led the people to worship God again.
>
> But after Josiah, the people turned away again. At last, the army of **Babylon** came. They burned the temple and took the people far away. It was very sad.
>
> But God was not done! Years later, someone wrote **Chronicles** to remind the people of their whole story, starting with Adam! It reminded them: "When God's people humble themselves and pray, God hears and forgives." The very end of Chronicles says that King Cyrus told God's people: "**Go home and rebuild!**" God always keeps His promises. And the forever King, Jesus, was still coming!

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Count Naaman's seven dips together while a child "dips" (squats down and pops up). Celebrate on number 7!
- **Explorers:** Point out that Josiah was about their age when he became king. Read 2 Chronicles 34:3 ("while he was still young, he began to seek the God of his father David").
- **Trailblazers:** Build the timeline: Israel falls (722 BC), Judah falls (586 BC), Cyrus decree (538 BC). Explain Chronicles as a "replay" written after the exile.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss 2 Chronicles 7:14 in context (spoken to Israel at the temple dedication). How do Christians apply it today without treating it as a promise about a modern nation? (Principle: God responds to humble repentance; 1 John 1:9.)

💬 **Discussion questions**

- *Little Lambs:* 1) How many times did Naaman dip in the river? (7) 2) How old was King Josiah? (8) 3) What did they find in the temple? (God's Book)
- *Explorers:* 1) Why was Naaman angry at first? 2) Who helped Naaman learn about Elisha? (A young servant girl) 3) What did Josiah do after hearing God's Word?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why did God let Babylon take His people away (2 Kings 17:13–14)? 2) Why do you think God's Book got "lost"? Can that happen to us? 3) What's the difference between Kings and Chronicles?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Jesus mentioned Naaman in Luke 4:27. Why did that upset the crowd? (God's grace reaches outsiders.) 2) How does the end of 2 Kings (25:27–30) keep hope alive? 3) If Chronicles retells history to encourage people, how should we tell our own stories of failure and grace?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Naaman" / "Elisha" / "Josiah" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Naaman | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Elisha" / "Naaman" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Elisha | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | Likely title: "Overview: Chronicles"; bonus theme video "Exile" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Chronicles |

Follow-up questions: 1) What happened to Naaman when he obeyed? 2) Why is Chronicles like a "replay"?

> Preview every video first.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Seven Dips Relay* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *King Timeline Scroll* (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Spell C-H-R-O-N-I-C-L-E-S ("Ch" says K!). Say all six books in order. Explorers and older: say all 14 books so far.

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> God, thank You for Your Book, the Bible. Help me never lose it, but read it and obey it like King Josiah. Thank You for keeping every promise. Amen.

Week 5 (optional): Royal Review Day

See **End-of-Phase Review & Celebration** below for the full plan. Kids wear crowns, play review games, recite the books, and receive the Heart Crown badge.

Book Memory Song & Motions

🎵 "The Kings and Kingdoms Song" (tune: *Yankee Doodle*)

This song is cumulative. Verse 1 is the 5 books of Law. Verse 2 adds Joshua, Judges and Ruth (learned in Phase 3) plus this month's six books, for 14 books in all.

Verse 1: The Law (books 1–5)

> Genesis and Exodus, Leviticus and Numbers, Deuteronomy makes five, The Law books, God's great wonders!

Shout: "FIVE BOOKS OF LAW!" *(hold up five fingers)*

Verse 2: History so far (books 6–14), sung to the chorus tune "Yankee Doodle, keep it up…"

> Joshua, Judges, Ruth, and then First, Second Samuel, First and Second Kings, and then First, Second Chronicles!

Tag line (spoken in rhythm):

> "Saul and David, Solomon, a kingdom split in two… But God's forever King is coming: Jesus, it's You!"

Shout: "NINE BOOKS OF HISTORY SO FAR!" *(hold up nine fingers)* **Big finish:** "FOURTEEN BOOKS! WE KNOW FOURTEEN!" *(all fingers twice, plus four)*

> Next month (Phase 5) adds Ezra, Nehemiah and Esther to finish all 12 History books.

Hand motions for each book

Book	Motion
Genesis	Sunrise hands: palms together like a closed book, open them, sweep arms up like the sun rising
Exodus	Exit walk: walk two fingers across your palm and out the "door"
Leviticus	Holy hands: fold hands to pray, then raise them high
Numbers	Count 1-2-3-4 on fingers, then zig-zag your hand (wandering)
Deuteronomy	Two fingers up ("second"), tap head ("remember"), hand on heart
Joshua	March in place with fist-trumpet at mouth ("Walls fall down!")
Judges	Pound a gavel on your palm, then draw a circle (the cycle)
Ruth	Scoop up pretend grain, then hug yourself (loyal love)
1 Samuel	1 finger up, then cup hand behind ear (listening)
2 Samuel	2 fingers up, then swing a pretend sling
1 Kings	1 finger up, then place a crown on your head
2 Kings	2 fingers up, then spin a finger like a whirlwind
1 Chronicles	1 finger up, then unroll a scroll
2 Chronicles	2 fingers up, then fold hands in prayer

📣 Section Shout

Leader: "What do we call the first five books?" Kids: "**The LAW!**" Leader: "What do we call Joshua through Chronicles?" Kids: "**HISTORY!**" Leader: "Who is the forever King?" Kids: "**JESUS!**"

Cumulative recall drill (2–3 minutes each week)

1. **Echo round:** Leader says a book, kids echo it with the motion.
2. **Motion only:** Leader does the motion silently; kids shout the book name.
3. **Missing book:** Leader says the list but skips one; first kid to name the missing book earns a "jewel" sticker for their crown.
4. **Pass the crown:** Kids sit in a circle passing a paper crown. Each child who holds it says the next book in order (Genesis → 2 Chronicles, then start over).
5. **Speed round (Trailblazers/Ambassadors):** Stopwatch: how fast can you say all 14 books? Record class best on the board.

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on the motions and the words "Samuel, Kings, Chronicles." They don't need to say all 14 alone. Hold up 1 and 2 fingers. Celebrate every attempt.
- **Explorers:** Aim to say all 14 in order. Use the song every week. Pair them with an Ambassador "coach."
- **Trailblazers:** Say all 14 without the song, and know which section each book belongs to. Challenge: say them backwards!
- **Ambassadors:** Lead the song and motions for younger groups. Know one key story for each of the six new books.

Spelling & Reading

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letter recognition and first sounds) | Word | First letter | Sound it out | |---|---|---| | Samuel | S | "Sss" like a snake 🐍 | | Kings | K | "K" like a kite | | David | D | "D" like a drum | | crown | C | "K" sound | | God | G | "G" like a goat | | heart | H | "H" like a happy breath |

Activity: Show big letter cards S, K, C, D. Ask "Which letter starts Samuel?" Kids trace the letters in the air or in a tray of sand/salt.

Explorers (book names)

1. Samuel (S-A-M-U-E-L)
2. Kings (K-I-N-G-S)
3. Chronicles (C-H-R-O-N-I-C-L-E-S)
4. David, Goliath, Solomon (bonus names) Practice writing "1 Samuel, 2 Samuel, 1 Kings, 2 Kings, 1 Chronicles, 2 Chronicles."

Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocab words)

- All six book names, plus Joshua, Judges, Ruth
- **prophet:** a person who brings God's message
- **anoint:** to pour oil on someone to show God has chosen them

- **temple:** God's house in Jerusalem, built by Solomon
- **kingdom:** a land and people ruled by a king
- **covenant:** a serious, binding promise between God and people

Ambassadors (book names + harder vocab with definitions)

- All 14 book names in order, spelled correctly
- **monarchy:** government by a king or queen
- **dynasty:** a line of rulers from the same family (the "house of David")
- **idolatry:** worshiping anything other than the true God
- **repentance:** turning away from sin and back to God
- **exile:** being forced to live away from your homeland
- **messiah:** Hebrew for "anointed one"; in Greek, "Christ"
- **chronicle:** a written record of events in time order (from the Greek *chronos*, "time")

Syllable-clap method

Clap once per syllable as you say the word, then spell it:

- Sam-u-el (3 claps) → S-A-M-U-E-L
- Kings (1 clap) → K-I-N-G-S
- Chron-i-cles (3 claps) → C-H-R-O-N-I-C-L-E-S
- Go-li-ath (3 claps) → G-O-L-I-A-T-H
- Sol-o-mon (3 claps) → S-O-L-O-M-O-N
- E-li-jah (3 claps) → E-L-I-J-A-H
- E-li-sha (3 claps) → E-L-I-S-H-A

Tip: "Elijah" and "Elisha" only differ at the end: **J-A-H** vs **S-H-A**. Remember: **J** comes before **S** in the alphabet, and Elijah came before Elisha. Elisha has the **S** for "**S**econd prophet."

"Spell It Out" relay

1. Split into teams of 4–6. Each team lines up behind a starting line.
2. Across the room, place a pile of letter cards for each team (enough letters to spell SAMUEL, KINGS and CHRONICLES).
3. Leader calls a book: "Chronicles!" The first runner grabs the first letter (C), runs back, and tags the next runner, who gets the next letter (H), and so on.
4. The team lays the letters in order on the floor. First team to spell the word correctly and shout it wins the round.
5. *Younger:* Use only first letters, or let them carry a whole word card. *Older:* add the number (a "1" or "2" card) and spell names like GOLIATH and NAAMAN.

Mini spelling bee word list

Word	Use it in a sentence
Samuel	Samuel heard God calling him in the night.

Word	Use it in a sentence
Kings	The books of Kings tell about the kings of Israel and Judah.
Chronicles	Chronicles starts with a family tree from Adam.
David	David was a shepherd boy who became king.
Goliath	Goliath was a giant from the city of Gath.
Solomon	Solomon asked God for wisdom.
Elijah	Elijah prayed, and fire fell from heaven.
Elisha	Elisha told Naaman to wash seven times.
temple	Solomon built a temple for God in Jerusalem.
prophet	A prophet tells people God's message.
Jerusalem	David made Jerusalem his capital city.
Naaman	Naaman was healed in the Jordan River.

Read-aloud practice passage

Have readers take turns reading one sentence each (simple version based on 1 Samuel 16:6–7, 11–13):

> When they came, Samuel saw Eliab. He thought, "Surely this is the one the LORD has chosen." But the LORD said to Samuel, "Do not look at how tall he is. People look at the outside. But the LORD looks at the heart." Then Samuel asked Jesse, "Are these all the sons you have?" Jesse said, "There is still the youngest. He is taking care of the sheep." So they brought David. The LORD said, "Rise and anoint him. This is the one." So Samuel poured oil on David's head.

Word Trivia

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. Who called Samuel in the night?
2. What animal did David take care of?
3. What was the name of the giant David fought?
4. How many stones did David pick up?
5. What did Solomon ask God for?
6. What did Solomon build for God?
7. What fell from heaven when Elijah prayed?
8. What birds brought food to Elijah?
9. How many times did Naaman dip in the river?
10. **True or False:** God looks at how tall we are.
11. **Fill in the blank:** "The LORD looks at the ____."
12. Who is the forever King from David's family?

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

13. Who was Israel's first king?
14. What was the name of Samuel's mother?
15. **Who said it?** "Speak, for your servant is listening."
16. Who was David's best friend (Saul's son)?
17. **Which book?** David and Goliath are found in ____.
18. What city did David make his capital?
19. **True or False:** The kingdom split into two kingdoms after Solomon died.
20. What were the two kingdoms called?
21. On what mountain did Elijah face the prophets of Baal?
22. **Who said it?** "The LORD — he is God!"
23. In what river did Naaman wash?
24. How did Elijah go to heaven?
25. **Which book?** The prayer of Jabez is in ____.

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

26. How many prophets of Baal were on Mount Carmel?
27. **Who said it?** "You come against me with sword and spear and javelin, but I come against you in the name of the LORD Almighty."
28. What prophet told David a story about a poor man's lamb?
29. What was the name of Jonathan's son who couldn't walk, to whom David showed kindness?
30. **Fill in the blank:** "If my people, who are called by my name, will ____ themselves and pray..." (2 Chronicles 7:14)
31. Which empire conquered the northern kingdom of Israel in 722 BC?
32. Which empire destroyed Jerusalem and the temple in 586 BC?
33. How old was Josiah when he became king?
34. **Which book?** God's promise that David's throne will be established forever is in 2 Samuel chapter ____.
35. Which Persian king's decree ends 2 Chronicles?
36. **True or False:** Chronicles was written before Samuel and Kings.
37. What did Elisha ask Elijah for before Elijah was taken up?
38. Who was the first king of the northern kingdom after the split?

Answer Key

1. God 2. Sheep 3. Goliath 4. Five 5. Wisdom (a wise heart) 6. A temple 7. Fire 8. Ravens 9. Seven 10. False, He looks at the heart 11. heart 12. Jesus
2. Saul 14. Hannah 15. Samuel (1 Samuel 3:10) 16. Jonathan 17. 1 Samuel (ch. 17) 18. Jerusalem 19. True 20. Israel (north) and Judah (south) 21. Mount Carmel 22. The people of Israel (1 Kings 18:39) 23. The Jordan River 24. In a whirlwind, with a chariot and horses of fire (2 Kings 2:11) 25. 1 Chronicles (4:9–10)
3. 450 (plus 400 prophets of Asherah were invited, 1 Kings 18:19) 27. David, to Goliath (1 Samuel 17:45) 28. Nathan (2 Samuel 12) 29. Mephibosheth (2 Samuel 9) 30. humble 31. Assyria 32. Babylon 33. Eight (2 Kings 22:1) 34. 7 (2 Samuel 7:16) 35. Cyrus 36. False. Chronicles was written

after the exile, later than Samuel and Kings. 37. A double portion of his spirit (2 Kings 2:9) 38. Jeroboam (1 Kings 12:20)

Games

> More game ideas and general rules: see `../00-start-here/game-library.md`.

🎮 1. Crown Grab

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers (Little Lambs with help)
- **Supplies:** One paper or plastic crown, masking tape
- **Setup:** Two teams line up facing each other about 20 feet apart. Each player on both teams is secretly given a book name (Genesis through 2 Chronicles, 14 books), so each team has one player per book (repeat books for big teams). The crown sits in the middle.
- **How to play:** The leader calls a clue, such as "the book where David fights Goliath" or "the book after Ruth." The two players holding "1 Samuel" race to grab the crown and bring it back without being tagged by the other.
- **How to win:** One point for bringing the crown back safely; one point to the tagger if they tag. First team to 10.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Just call out the book name and hold up a picture. *Older:* Give clues from summaries ("the book that ends with Cyrus's decree").
- **Learning goal:** Book order and book contents.

🎮 2. Giant Toss

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** A large poster of Goliath (draw on butcher paper, about 6–9 feet tall, taped to a wall), 5 beanbags or soft balls ("smooth stones"), sticky notes with the 14 book names stuck on different parts of the giant
- **Setup:** Mark a throwing line about 8–12 feet away (closer for Little Lambs).
- **How to play:** Each child gets 5 "stones." When a throw hits a sticky note, the child reads the book name aloud and says the book that comes *next*. Hitting Goliath's forehead (a special star) = shout the memory verse for a bonus.
- **How to win:** Teams earn 1 point per correct "next book" and 3 points for the forehead verse. Highest team score wins, but remind kids: "The battle is the LORD's!"
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Any hit counts; teacher reads the name and kids repeat. *Older:* Must say the next TWO books, or give the section and one fact.
- **Learning goal:** Book order and the memory verse.

🎮 3. Kingdom Split Tag

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors

- **Supplies:** Two colors of pinnies or armbands (blue = Israel, purple = Judah), cones to divide the room
- **Setup:** Divide the play area in half: north (Israel) and south (Judah). Put 10 "tribe" players on the north side and 2 or 3 on the south (or a proportion of your class: more in the north).
- **How to play:** The leader calls out a king or prophet fact. If the fact is about the north (Israel: Jeroboam, Ahab, Elijah, Samaria), southern players can tag northern players. If it's about the south (Judah: Rehoboam, Hezekiah, Josiah, Jerusalem, temple), northern players can tag southern players. Tagged players freeze and must answer a book-order question to be "freed."
- **How to win:** No winner: play several rounds and see who can stay unfrozen longest. Or the team with the fewest frozen at the end.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Simple "Red light, green light" with "Good king!" (walk) and "Bad king!" (freeze). *Older:* Use harder facts ("first king of the north," "capital of Israel").
- **Learning goal:** Understanding the divided kingdom, kings and prophets.

🎮 4. Seven Dips Relay

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** A blue tarp or blue paper strip ("the Jordan River"), 7 index cards per team with one of the 14 book names (mix them), a cone for each team
- **Setup:** Teams line up. Across the room is the "Jordan River."
- **How to play:** Each runner runs to the river, does a "dip" (a squat) while saying the next book in order on their turn (Runner 1: "Genesis," Runner 2: "Exodus"...), and runs back. The team must get to 7 dips, then 14 (all books), in correct order. If someone says the wrong book, the team says "Try again, Naaman!" and that runner dips again.
- **How to win:** First team to complete all 14 books in order and shout "I'm clean!" wins.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Just count to 7 dips together. *Older:* Go backwards from 2 Chronicles to Genesis.
- **Learning goal:** Book order; the Naaman story (obeying God fully).

🎮 5. Throne Swap (book-name musical chairs, no one is "out")

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers
- **Supplies:** Chairs in a circle (one per child), a book-name card taped to each chair, music
- **Setup:** Chairs face outward with book cards on the seats.
- **How to play:** Play music (try a worship song or the Yankee Doodle book song). When the music stops, everyone sits in a "throne." The leader picks a child to read (or say, with help) the book on their seat and do its motion. Everyone stays in. Remove no chairs.
- **How to win:** Everyone wins a "jewel" sticker when the whole group gets through all 14 books.
- **Adaptations:** *Older:* Remove one chair each round; the child without a chair must say all books on the seats in order to rejoin.
- **Learning goal:** Recognizing and reading book names.

🎮 6. Fire or Fizzle? (true/false run)

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Two signs: "FIRE! 🔥 (True)" on one wall and "FIZZLE 💧 (False)" on the opposite wall

- **How to play:** Leader reads a statement ("Solomon asked for riches" / "Josiah was 8 when he became king"). Kids run to the wall they think is right. Explain each answer.
- **How to win:** Kids on the correct side get a point; play to 10.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Use very simple statements and picture cues. *Older:* Use the Hard trivia.
- **Learning goal:** Story facts and review.

Coloring Pages

> 🖍️ Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-04-printables.html`

Page 1 (Week 1): "Speak, LORD, I'm Listening"

- **Scene:** A boy (Samuel) sitting up on a simple mat in a lamp-lit room, with a small clay oil lamp glowing. One hand is behind his ear. Through a doorway you can see the old priest Eli sleeping. Soft lines of light come from above.
- **Caption:** "Speak, for your servant is listening." (1 Samuel 3:10)
- **Conversation prompts:** How do you think Samuel felt when he heard his name? How does God speak to us today? (Through the Bible, through prayer, through people who love Him.)

Page 2 (Week 2): "The Battle Is the LORD's"

- **Scene:** Young David in a simple tunic, swinging a sling over his head, a shepherd's bag at his waist and a stream with smooth stones at his feet. In the background, huge Goliath (shown from the waist up, big helmet and spear) towers over the hill. Scared soldiers peek from behind rocks.
- **Caption:** "The LORD looks at the heart." (1 Samuel 16:7)
- **Conversation prompts:** What is something that feels like a "giant" to you? Who can help you be brave?

Page 3 (Week 3): "The LORD, He Is God!"

- **Scene:** Elijah with arms raised beside an altar of 12 large stones surrounded by a water-filled ditch. Big flames come down from the sky onto the altar. People on the mountainside fall to their knees.
- **Caption:** "The LORD — he is God!" (1 Kings 18:39)
- **Conversation prompts:** Why did Elijah pour water on the altar? What would you have shouted if you were there?

Page 4 (Week 4): "Seven Dips"

- **Scene:** Naaman in the Jordan River, coming up from the water with a big smile. Number bubbles 1 through 7 float in the air above him. His horses and chariot wait on the riverbank with servants cheering.

- **Caption:** "Now I know that there is no God in all the world except in Israel." (2 Kings 5:15)
- **Conversation prompts:** Was it hard for Naaman to obey? What is something God asks you to do that might be hard?

Page 5 (Week 4 bonus): "Boy King Josiah"

- **Scene:** An 8-year-old king with a too-big crown, sitting on a throne, holding an unrolled scroll. A priest stands beside him pointing at the words.
- **Caption:** "While he was still young, he began to seek the God of his father David." (2 Chronicles 34:3)
- **Conversation prompts:** What can kids do for God? How can you "seek God" this week?

Page 6 (Book-name page): "Six Royal Books"

- **Scene:** Six crowns in two rows of three. Each crown has a book name in bubble letters: 1 SAMUEL, 2 SAMUEL, 1 KINGS, 2 KINGS, 1 CHRONICLES, 2 CHRONICLES. Under each is a tiny symbol (ear, sling, split crown, whirlwind, scroll, praying hands). A big banner across the top reads "HISTORY."
- **Caption:** "Jesus is the forever King!"
- **Conversation prompts:** Which crown is your favorite book? Can you say all six in order while you color?

Activities & Crafts

✂️ 1. Heart Crown craft (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Purple or gold cardstock crown strips (about 4" × 24"), red foam or paper hearts, sticky "jewels," glue sticks, stapler, markers
- **Steps:**
    1. Cut points along the top edge of the strip (precut for Little Lambs).
    2. Write "The LORD looks at the heart" on the front band.
    3. Glue a big red heart in the center.
    4. Decorate with jewels: one jewel for each book they can say.
    5. Staple to fit each child's head.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* precut crowns; teacher writes the verse; kids decorate. *Explorers:* write the six new book names on the points. *Trailblazers:* write a "heart quality" on each point (honest, kind, brave, obedient…). *Ambassadors:* make crowns for the Little Lambs and help them.
- **What it teaches:** God chooses based on the heart; kids belong to the King.

✂️ 2. Five Smooth Stones (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Smooth river rocks (from a craft store) or gray paper "stones," paint pens or permanent markers, a small fabric bag or paper lunch bag
- **Steps:**
    1. Give each child five stones.

2. Write one word or phrase of the memory verse on each stone: "People look... outward appearance... but the LORD... looks at... the heart."
3. Mix them up and practice putting them in order.
4. Put them in a "shepherd's bag" to take home.

- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* write the 5 words "The / LORD / looks / at / heart" or draw a heart, eye, crown, sheep and sling. *Older groups:* on the back of each stone, write one of this month's books (1 Samuel through 1 Chronicles), and on the bag write a "giant" they want to trust God with (privately, if they prefer).
- **What it teaches:** Memorizing the verse; trusting God with our "giants."

✂️ 3. Elijah's 12-Stone Altar (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** 12 small boxes, blocks or stacked paper cups per team; red, orange and yellow tissue paper; a blue paper "ditch" ring; a small cup of water (optional, outside)
- **Steps:**
  1. Label the 12 stones with the 12 tribes, or with the first 12 books of the Bible (Genesis → 2 Kings)!
  2. Build an altar.
  3. Place the blue ring around it as the ditch.
  4. Crumple tissue "fire" and toss it on top when everyone shouts, "The LORD — He is God!"
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* big soft blocks, count to 12 together. *Explorers:* use the first 12 book names and build in order. *Trailblazers/Ambassadors:* label with the 12 tribes (Reuben, Simeon, Levi, Judah, Dan, Naphtali, Gad, Asher, Issachar, Zebulun, Joseph, Benjamin) and discuss why Elijah used 12 even though the kingdom was split (he reminded them they were one people of God).
- **What it teaches:** God alone is God; God answers prayer; book order.

✂️ 4. King Timeline Scroll (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Long strips of paper (adding-machine tape or butcher paper cut 4" wide, about 4 feet long), two dowels or paper towel tubes, crayons, tape, simple picture cards (Samuel, Saul, David, Solomon, split crown, Elijah, Elisha, Josiah, Babylon, Cyrus)
- **Steps:**
  1. Draw a line across the strip.
  2. Glue or draw the picture cards in order along the line.
  3. Label the dates (older groups): 1050 BC Saul; 1010 David; 970 Solomon; 930 split; 722 Israel falls; 586 Judah falls; 538 Cyrus.
  4. Tape each end to a tube and roll it up like a "chronicle" scroll.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* 4 pictures only (Samuel, David, Solomon, Elijah). *Explorers:* all pictures, no dates. *Trailblazers:* add dates and which book tells each part. *Ambassadors:* add the prophets of each period (Elijah, Elisha, Isaiah, Jeremiah), linking to Phase 7.
- **What it teaches:** The order of Israel's history; Chronicles as a "record in time."

✂️ 5. Mephibosheth's Table Place Mat

- **Supplies:** 11" × 17" construction paper, markers, laminator or clear contact paper

- **Steps:**
  1. Draw a long royal table with a seat that says "Reserved for ____ (your name)."
  2. Write: "Jesus invites me to His table."
  3. Decorate with food, crowns and the six book names around the border.
  4. Laminate to use at home.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* sticker food and name written by a teacher. *Older:* add 2 Samuel 9:7, "I will surely show you kindness."
- **What it teaches:** Grace: the King brings us to His table though we don't deserve it.

✂️ 6. Naaman Seven-Dip Flip Book

- **Supplies:** 8 small paper squares stapled together, crayons
- **Steps:** Page 1: Naaman with spots. Pages 2–7: numbers 1–6 with fewer spots each time. Page 8: "7!" Naaman clean and smiling with the words "God healed me!"
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* use precut pages and dot stickers to peel off. *Older:* add the lesson "Obey God all the way."
- **What it teaches:** Obedience and God's power to heal.

Word Puzzles

Word scramble

Unscramble these words from this month's stories. | # | Scrambled | Hint | |---|---|---| | 1 | LEUMAS | A prophet who heard God at night | | 2 | VIDAD | Shepherd boy who became king | | 3 | THAILOG | A giant | | 4 | MONOLOS | The wise king | | 5 | JHALIE | Prophet on Mount Carmel | | 6 | SAHILE | Prophet who helped Naaman | | 7 | GINKS | 1 and 2 ____ | | 8 | ELCHORNICS | 1 and 2 ____ | | 9 | PELMET | God's house in Jerusalem | | 10 | WRONC | A king wears it | | 11 | THEPORP | Person who tells God's message | | 12 | MAANAN | Captain healed in the Jordan | | 13 | HISAJO | Boy king who found God's Book | | 14 | HAHNNA | Samuel's mother |

Answer key: 1. SAMUEL 2. DAVID 3. GOLIATH 4. SOLOMON 5. ELIJAH 6. ELISHA 7. KINGS 8. CHRONICLES 9. TEMPLE 10. CROWN 11. PROPHET 12. NAAMAN 13. JOSIAH 14. HANNAH

Fill-in-the-blank story

Word bank: *heart, Goliath, stones, wisdom, temple, fire, seven, forever, Jesus, Book*

> God sent Samuel to choose a new king. God said, "The LORD looks at the _____." He chose David, a shepherd boy. David trusted God and fought the giant _____ with a sling and five smooth _____. God promised David that his family would have a King _____. David's son Solomon asked God for _____ and built a beautiful _____. Later, Elijah prayed, and _____ fell from heaven. Naaman dipped _____ times in the Jordan River and was healed. Boy King Josiah found God's lost _____ in the temple. All these stories point to the forever King, _____!

Answer key: heart, Goliath, stones, forever, wisdom, temple, fire, seven, Book, Jesus

Match the book to its picture / summary

Draw a line from the book to its matching picture and summary. | Book | | Picture & summary | |---|---|---| | 1. 1 Samuel | | A. 🌪️ Elijah goes up in a whirlwind; Naaman is healed; the kingdoms fall. | | 2. 2 Samuel | | B. 🙏 Solomon's temple; "If my people… pray"; Cyrus says go home. | | 3. 1 Kings | | C. 👂 Samuel listens; Saul is first king; David beats Goliath. | | 4. 2 Kings | | D. 📜 A family tree from Adam; David prepares for the temple. | | 5. 1 Chronicles | | E. 🤝 David is king; God promises a forever throne; kindness to Mephibosheth. | | 6. 2 Chronicles | | F. ✂️👑 Solomon's wisdom; the kingdom splits; fire on Mount Carmel. |

Answer key: 1-C, 2-E, 3-F, 4-A, 5-D, 6-B

Questions for Every Age

Little Lambs (ages 4–6)

1. What does God look at? (Our heart)
2. Who can help you be brave like David?
3. What can you ask God for, like Solomon? (To help you be wise and good)
4. Can God hear you when you pray? (Yes!)
5. Who is the best King of all? (Jesus)

Explorers (ages 7–10)

1. What is one way you can listen to God this week?
2. What's a "giant" (something scary or hard) you can trust God with?
3. How can you show kindness like David showed Mephibosheth?
4. If God offered you anything, what would you ask for? Why?
5. Josiah was young when he started following God. What is one thing you can do for God right now?

Trailblazers (ages 11–13)

1. Why do people judge by outward appearance? Where do you see that at school?
2. What are some "fake gods" people trust instead of the real God?
3. Saul looked good but disobeyed. What's the difference between looking religious and loving God?
4. Why do you think so many kings turned away from God even after seeing miracles?
5. How does knowing Jesus is the forever King help when leaders let you down?

Ambassadors (ages 14–17)

1. David was "a man after God's own heart" (Acts 13:22) yet sinned terribly. What does that teach you about God's grace and about our heroes?
2. Solomon had wisdom but didn't use it at the end. Where are you tempted to know the right thing and not do it?
3. The people wanted to be "like all the other nations." In what ways do Christian teens feel pressure to fit in?
4. How does 2 Samuel 7 shape the way you read the New Testament (e.g., Matthew 1:1; Luke 1:32–33; Romans 1:3)?
5. Elijah later felt alone and wanted to give up (1 Kings 19). What did God do for him, and what does that teach about discouragement?

Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics / worldview)

1. **"Is there any evidence King David existed?"** *Suggested answer:* Yes. The Tel Dan Stele, found in northern Israel in 1993–94 and dated to the 800s BC, mentions the "House of David," meaning a dynasty named after David. This is outside the Bible and written by an enemy king. Many other names from Kings (such as Omri, Ahab, Jehu, Hezekiah and Sennacherib) also appear in Assyrian and Moabite records. Archaeology doesn't "prove" faith, but it shows the Bible is rooted in real history.
2. **"Why does the Bible show its heroes' sins so plainly?"** *Suggested answer:* Ancient royal records usually bragged and hid failures. The Bible tells the truth about Saul, David and Solomon, which is one sign that it is honest history and not propaganda. It also makes the main point clear: no human king can save us. We need a perfect King, Jesus.
3. **"If God is in control, why did He let His people be conquered?"** *Suggested answer:* God warned His people for hundreds of years through prophets (2 Kings 17:13–14). The exile was both a consequence of their choices and a discipline meant to bring them back. Even in exile, God preserved David's line (2 Kings 25:27–30) and later brought them home (2 Chronicles 36:22–23). God's judgment and mercy work together, and both point to the cross, where Jesus took the judgment so we could have mercy.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration

Royal Review Day plan (last Sunday of the month, 75 minutes)

Time	What happens
0–10 min	**Royal Welcome:** Kids put on their Heart Crowns. Play the Kings & Kingdoms song with motions. Ambassadors act as "royal heralds" who greet each child with "Welcome to the King's court!"
10–25 min	**Story Replay ("Chronicles Theater"):** Four stations, one per week's story. Small groups rotate every 3–4 minutes and act out a 1-minute scene (Samuel listening, David and Goliath, Elijah's fire, Naaman's dips).

Time	What happens
25–35 min	**Favorite Video Rewatch:** Let the kids vote on the best clip from the month.
35–50 min	**Royal Bible Bowl:** Teams answer trivia from the Word Trivia list. Use buzzers (or bells). Little Lambs answer picture questions with help.
50–60 min	**Game:** Giant Toss or Throne Swap (kids' choice)
60–70 min	**Oral check-off + Royal Feast:** While kids enjoy a snack ("Mephibosheth's table": grapes, crackers, cheese, "crown" cookies), teachers do individual check-offs. *(Check allergies first.)*
70–75 min	**Badge Ceremony & Prayer:** Stamp Bible Passports, award Heart Crown badges, pray.

Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs (ages 4–6)

- ☐ Says "History" when asked what kind of books these are
- ☐ Names 3 of this month's books (e.g., Samuel, Kings, Chronicles), with or without numbers
- ☐ Says the short verse: "The LORD looks at the heart."
- ☐ Tells one thing about David, Elijah or Naaman

Explorers (ages 7–10)

- ☐ Says all 6 books of this phase in order
- ☐ Spells SAMUEL, KINGS and CHRONICLES correctly
- ☐ Says the books from Genesis to 2 Chronicles (14) with the song
- ☐ Says the full memory verse (1 Samuel 16:7)

Trailblazers (ages 11–13)

- ☐ Says all 14 books so far in order without the song
- ☐ Gives a one-sentence summary of each of the 6 new books
- ☐ Identifies the two sections (Law, History)
- ☐ Says the memory verse with reference

Ambassadors (ages 14–17)

- ☐ Says all 14 books in order and can name the section of each
- ☐ Explains the Davidic covenant (2 Samuel 7) and how it points to Jesus
- ☐ Teaches one of the six books to a younger child (2 minutes: name, motion, one story)
- ☐ Says the memory verse with reference

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp the "Kings & Kingdoms" page of each child's Bible Passport. Stamp design: a purple crown with "1 SAM – 2 CHRON" around the edge. Kids who complete the check-off get a gold star next to the stamp.

🏅 Badge description: The Heart Crown Badge

A round purple badge with a gold crown in the center and a small red heart on the front of the crown. Around the edge: "KINGS & KINGDOMS • 14 OF 66." (Use a sticker, a pin-back button, or an iron-on patch for a sash.)

📜 Certificate wording

> **Royal Court Certificate** This certifies that _____ has completed **Phase 4: Kings & Kingdoms** at Purpose Church Sunday School. You have learned the books of **1 Samuel, 2 Samuel, 1 Kings, 2 Kings, 1 Chronicles and 2 Chronicles** and now know **14 of the 66 books** of the Bible! *"People look at the outward appearance, but the LORD looks at the heart." (1 Samuel 16:7)* Remember: Jesus is the forever King, and He looks at your heart with love. Teacher: _____ Date: _____

Take-Home Family Page

> ✂️ *Copy this page and send it home on the first Sunday of the month.*

Dear Parents and Caregivers, This month your child is learning **Phase 4: Kings & Kingdoms**, six History books of the Bible: **1 Samuel, 2 Samuel, 1 Kings, 2 Kings, 1 Chronicles and 2 Chronicles.** We'll meet Samuel, King Saul, David and Goliath, wise King Solomon, the prophet Elijah, Naaman, and boy King Josiah. The big idea: **God looks at the heart, and He keeps His promise of a forever King, Jesus.** Your child now knows **14 of the 66 books** of the Bible!

📖 **Memory Verse:** "People look at the outward appearance, but the LORD looks at the heart." (1 Samuel 16:7, NIV) **Little Lambs:** "The LORD looks at the heart."

🎵 **Our Song (tune: *Yankee Doodle*)**

> Genesis and Exodus, Leviticus and Numbers, Deuteronomy makes five, the Law books, God's great wonders! Joshua, Judges, Ruth, and then First, Second Samuel, First and Second Kings, and then First, Second Chronicles!

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions**

1. What is something people notice about the outside, and what is something only God sees on the inside?
2. If God said, "Ask for anything," what would you ask for? What did Solomon ask for?
3. What "giant" is our family facing right now, and how can we trust God with it together?

🏠 **Family activity: "Heart Look" game** Over dinner, each person says one thing they love about another family member's *heart* (kindness, helpfulness, honesty), not their looks or skills. Then read 1 Samuel 16:7 together and pray for each other.

📺 **Videos to watch at home (search on YouTube; parents, please preview)**

- @SharefaithKids: search "David and Goliath" → https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=David+and+Goliath
- @BibleJourneyTV: search "Elijah" → https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Elijah
- @bibleproject: "Overview: 1 Samuel," "Overview: 2 Samuel," "Overview: 1-2 Kings," "Overview: Chronicles" → https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Samuel

Thank you for partnering with us! For more about the program, see `../00-start-here/program-overview.md`.

Phase 5: Coming Home & Being Brave

God brings His people home, helps them rebuild, and makes ordinary people brave "for such a time as this."

At a Glance	
Month	Month 5
Books covered	Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther (**3 books**)
Bible section(s)	History (books 15–17 of the Bible; books 10–12 of the 12 History books). **This phase completes the History section!**
Big Idea	God keeps His promise to bring His people home, and He gives His people courage, joy and strength to do His work, even when He seems hidden.
Memory Verse (all ages)	"Do not grieve, for the joy of the LORD is your strength." (Nehemiah 8:10, NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"The joy of the LORD is your strength." (Nehemiah 8:10)
Bonus phrase (all ages)	"...for such a time as this." (Esther 4:14)
Theme color	Brick orange / sandstone (with royal blue for Esther)
Phase symbol / badge	A brick wall with a small gold crown on top (the "Brave Builder" badge)
Running total of books learned	**17 of 66** (Law 5 + History 12 of 12 ✔)

The Big Idea (in kid words)

God's people had to live far away in Babylon for a long time because they kept turning away from Him. But God promised, "I will bring you home." And He did! A priest named Ezra helped them rebuild God's house and learn God's Word. A man named Nehemiah helped them rebuild the city walls. And far away, a brave queen named Esther spoke up to save God's people. God was working the whole time, even when people couldn't see Him.

How this points to Jesus: God kept His people safe and brought them home because He had a plan: the Savior, Jesus, would be born from this family (Zerubbabel, the leader in Ezra, is in Jesus' family tree in Matthew 1:12–13). Nehemiah left a palace to rebuild a broken city; Jesus left heaven to rebuild broken people. Esther risked her life to save her people; Jesus *gave* His life to save us. And Jesus is the one who brings us *home* to God forever (John 14:2–3).

The Books in Easy Words

15. Ezra

- **How to say it:** "EZ-ruh"
- **How to spell it:** Ez-ra, E-Z-R-A (only 4 letters! One of the shortest book names)
- **Section:** History
- **Traditional author:** Ezra the priest and scribe (parts are written as "I," in Ezra's own voice, ch. 7–9). In the Hebrew Bible, Ezra and Nehemiah were one book.
- **One-sentence kid summary:** God's people come home from Babylon, rebuild God's temple, and Ezra teaches them God's Word.
- **In one word:** *Rebuild*
- **Key people:** King Cyrus of Persia, Zerubbabel (the leader), Jeshua the priest, the prophets Haggai and Zechariah, King Darius, Ezra
- **Key stories:** Cyrus says, "Go home and rebuild!" (ch. 1); about 50,000 people make the long trip home (ch. 2); the temple foundation is laid: some shout for joy and some cry (ch. 3); enemies stop the work (ch. 4); the prophets cheer the people on, and the temple is finished (ch. 5–6); Ezra comes to teach God's Law (ch. 7); the people pray and fast for a safe journey (ch. 8); the people confess their sins (ch. 9–10)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** Zerubbabel, the leader who rebuilt the temple, is Jesus' great-great-(many greats)-grandfather (Matthew 1:12–13). Jesus later said *He* is the true temple, the place where God and people meet (John 2:19–21).
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 🧱 Stack one fist on top of the other, like laying bricks for the temple. Picture: a temple with scaffolding.

16. Nehemiah

- **How to say it:** "nee-uh-MY-uh"
- **How to spell it:** Ne-he-mi-ah, N-E-H-E-M-I-A-H (4 syllables: "Knee-he-MY-ah")
- **Section:** History
- **Traditional author:** Nehemiah (much of it is his own "I" journal). Tradition says Ezra may have put it together.
- **One-sentence kid summary:** Nehemiah prays, leaves the king's palace, and leads God's people to rebuild Jerusalem's broken walls in just 52 days, even while enemies make fun of them.
- **In one word:** *Walls*
- **Key people:** Nehemiah (the king's cupbearer), King Artaxerxes, Sanballat and Tobiah (the bullies), Ezra, the Levites
- **Key stories:** Nehemiah hears the walls are broken and prays (ch. 1); a quick prayer before talking to the king (ch. 2:4); a secret night ride to inspect the walls (ch. 2); every family builds a section (ch. 3); enemies mock them: "Even a fox would knock it down!" (ch. 4); half build, half guard, with a tool in one hand and a weapon in the other (ch. 4); "I am doing a great work and cannot come down!" (ch. 6); the wall is finished in 52 days (6:15); Ezra reads God's Law and the people celebrate: "The joy of the LORD is your strength!" (ch. 8); a huge parade on the walls (ch. 12)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** Nehemiah gave up comfort to come and rebuild what was broken; Jesus gave up heaven to come and make us new (Philippians 2:6–8). In Nehemiah 8, the people

were sad when they heard God's Law, but were told to celebrate. Jesus brings joy to people who know they've done wrong (Luke 15:7).
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 🛡️🔨 One hand "hammers," the other hand holds up a shield. Picture: a city wall with a gate.

17. Esther

- **How to say it:** "ES-ter"
- **How to spell it:** Es-ther, E-S-T-H-E-R (the "th" sounds like "t")
- **Section:** History
- **Traditional author:** Unknown. Some Jewish tradition says Mordecai or the "Men of the Great Assembly."
- **One-sentence kid summary:** A young Jewish woman named Esther becomes queen of Persia and bravely risks her life to save God's people from a wicked man's plan.
- **In one word:** *Courage*
- **Key people:** King Xerxes (also called Ahasuerus), Queen Vashti, Esther (her Hebrew name was Hadassah), Mordecai (Esther's older cousin who raised her), Haman (the villain)
- **Key stories:** Queen Vashti refuses the king (ch. 1); Esther is chosen as the new queen (ch. 2); Mordecai saves the king's life (ch. 2); Mordecai won't bow to Haman, and Haman plots to destroy all the Jews (ch. 3); "Who knows but that you have come to your royal position for such a time as this?" (ch. 4); Esther goes to the king uninvited, and he holds out his golden scepter (ch. 5); the king can't sleep, and Haman has to honor Mordecai (ch. 6); Esther tells the king about Haman's plan (ch. 7); the Jews are allowed to defend themselves (ch. 8–9); the party of Purim begins (ch. 9)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** Esther stood between the king and her people to save them. Jesus stands between God and us (1 Timothy 2:5). Esther said, "If I perish, I perish" (4:16); Jesus didn't just risk death, He died and rose again to save us. God kept the Jewish people alive, so Jesus could be born from them as promised.
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 👑🗣️ Put a crown on your head, then cup your hands around your mouth to "speak up." Picture: a golden scepter.

> **Fun fact for kids:** The name "God" never appears in the book of Esther! But God is working on every page: the right person in the right place, a king who couldn't sleep, a plan that flips upside down. We call this **God's hidden hand**.

> **Timeline twist for teachers:** In our Bibles the order is Ezra → Nehemiah → Esther, but the events of Esther actually happened *between* Ezra chapter 6 and Ezra chapter 7. (See the timeline below.)

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher

Last month ended with the fall of Jerusalem to Babylon in 586 BC and a promise at the end of 2 Chronicles. This month picks up that thread. In 539 BC, the Persian king **Cyrus** conquered Babylon. In 538 BC he issued a decree allowing exiled peoples, including the Jews, to return home and rebuild their temples (Ezra 1:1–4; compare Isaiah 44:28, written long before, which names Cyrus!). Jeremiah had predicted the exile would last about 70 years (Jeremiah 29:10).

- **Ezra 1–6 (538–516 BC):** About 50,000 people (Ezra 2:64–65: 42,360 plus servants and singers) return under **Zerubbabel** (a descendant of King David) and **Jeshua** the high priest. They rebuild the altar and lay the temple foundation (ch. 3). The older people who had seen Solomon's glorious temple wept, while younger people shouted for joy (3:12–13). Opposition from neighboring peoples stops the work for about 16 years (ch. 4). The prophets **Haggai** and **Zechariah** (Phase 8!) encourage the people to restart (5:1), and King **Darius** confirms Cyrus's decree. The temple is completed in 516/515 BC (6:15).
- **Esther (about 483–473 BC):** Set in Susa, the Persian capital, during the reign of **Xerxes I** (Hebrew: Ahasuerus), many Jews still live across the Persian Empire. Haman, an official, plots genocide against the Jews; Esther, a Jewish orphan who has become queen, intercedes. The feast of **Purim** ("lots," from the *pur* Haman cast to choose the date) still celebrates this deliverance.
- **Ezra 7–10 (458 BC):** Ezra, a priest and scribe, comes with a second group. "Ezra had devoted himself to the study and observance of the Law of the LORD, and to teaching" (Ezra 7:10). He leads the people to confess unfaithfulness, especially marriages to people who worshiped other gods (ch. 9–10).
- **Nehemiah (445–about 430 BC):** Nehemiah, cupbearer (a trusted official who tasted the king's wine) to King **Artaxerxes I**, hears that Jerusalem's walls are still in ruins. A city without walls was unsafe and disgraced. He prays, gets the king's permission, and leads the people to rebuild the walls in 52 days despite opposition from Sanballat, Tobiah and Geshem (6:15). Ezra then reads the Law to the gathered people (ch. 8), who respond with weeping, then joy, then confession and covenant renewal (ch. 9–10). Nehemiah serves as governor and fights for justice for the poor (ch. 5) and faithfulness (ch. 13).

Key truths to emphasize

1. **God keeps His promises**, even after a long wait (70 years!).
2. **Prayer comes first.** Nehemiah prayed for months (ch. 1) and in a split second (2:4). Ezra's group fasted and prayed (Ezra 8:21–23). Esther asked everyone to fast (Esther 4:16).
3. **God's Word brings joy and change** (Nehemiah 8).
4. **God is at work even when He seems hidden** (Esther).
5. **God puts people in the right place for a reason**: "for such a time as this."
6. **Everyone has a part** in God's work (Nehemiah 3: families, goldsmiths, perfume-makers and daughters all built!).

Timeline (put this on the wall)

```
586 BC  Jerusalem destroyed (end of 2 Kings / 2 Chronicles)
538 BC  Cyrus's decree: "Go home!" (Ezra 1)
536 BC  Temple foundation laid (Ezra 3)
520 BC  Haggai & Zechariah preach; work restarts (Ezra 5)
516 BC  Temple finished (Ezra 6)
483–473 BC  Esther becomes queen; Haman's plot; Purim (Esther)
458 BC  Ezra arrives in Jerusalem (Ezra 7)
445 BC  Nehemiah rebuilds the walls in 52 days (Nehemiah 1–6)
~430 BC Malachi, the last Old Testament prophet (Phase 8)
```

Map notes

- **Babylon** (in modern Iraq) → **Jerusalem**: about 900 miles along the Fertile Crescent route. Ezra's trip took about four months (Ezra 7:8–9).
- **Susa** (also called Shushan, in modern Iran) was the Persian winter capital where Esther lived and where Nehemiah served the king (Nehemiah 1:1).
- The Persian Empire under Xerxes had 127 provinces "from India to Cush" (Esther 1:1), roughly from modern Pakistan to Sudan. Show how huge that is on a world map!

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
Haman's plan to kill the Jews	"A mean man named Haman wanted to hurt God's people."	"Haman made a law to destroy all the Jews. Esther helped stop it."	Read Esther 3 as written.	Connect to later antisemitism and the Holocaust; discuss why hatred of a whole people is evil.
Haman's death	"Haman's evil plan came back on him."	"Haman was punished on the same pole he built for Mordecai."	Read Esther 7:9–10.	Discuss justice and the reversal theme (Proverbs 26:27).
How Esther became queen	"The king picked Esther to be queen."	"The king looked for a new queen, and Esther was chosen."	Honestly: young women were brought to the palace, and Esther didn't get much choice. God was with her in a hard situation.	Discuss power, consent and the ancient Persian court. God works through broken situations without approving of them.
Fighting in Esther 9	Skip.	"The Jews were allowed to protect themselves, and they won."	The second law let Jews defend themselves against attackers (8:11).	Discuss self-defense vs. revenge; note they "did not lay their hands on the plunder" (9:10, 15–16).

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
Ezra 9–10 (sending away foreign wives)	Skip.	Skip, or "the people said sorry to God for not obeying His rules."	"They had married people who worshiped false gods, which God had told them not to do."	See Big Question 3 below.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

- **"Why did God's people have to leave home in the first place?"** God warned them for many years to stop worshiping idols and treating people badly. They wouldn't listen, so God let Babylon take them away. But He never stopped loving them, and He brought them back.
- **"Why did old people cry when the temple foundation was laid?"** They remembered how big and beautiful Solomon's temple had been, and this one looked smaller (Ezra 3:12; Haggai 2:3). Some cried for sadness, and some for joy. Both were loud!
- **"Why didn't Mordecai just bow to Haman?"** The Bible doesn't say exactly. Many think it was because Haman wanted honor that only belongs to God, or because Haman came from an old enemy people of Israel (the Agagites; compare 1 Samuel 15). Mordecai would not give in, even when it was dangerous.
- **"Why couldn't Esther just go talk to her husband?"** Persian law said anyone who went to the king without being called could be killed, unless the king held out his gold scepter (Esther 4:11). Esther hadn't been called for 30 days.
- **"Where is God in Esther if His name isn't there?"** Look for the "coincidences": Esther became queen at just the right time, Mordecai heard about the plot, the king couldn't sleep on just the right night. That's God's hidden hand.
- **"What's Purim?"** A Jewish holiday (in February or March) celebrating how God saved His people in Esther's day. People read Esther aloud and make noise every time Haman's name is read!

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
1	Ezra 1; 3; 6:14–16; 7:10	Going Home to Build God's House	God keeps His promises and brings His people home.	SharefaithKids "Ezra"; BibleJourneyTV "Return from exile"; BibleProject "Overview: Ezra-Nehemiah"	Wall Builders Relay	Foundation Stone Shout-and-Cry craft
2	Nehemiah 1–2; 4; 6:15; 8:1–12	Pray, Plan, Build!	Pray first; God gives strength and joy to do His work.	SharefaithKids "Nehemiah"; BibleJourneyTV "Nehemiah"; BibleProject "Overview: Ezra-Nehemiah"	Build and Guard	Book Wall craft

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
3	Esther 1–4	For Such a Time as This	God puts us in the right place to do the right thing.	SharefaithKids "Esther"; BibleJourneyTV "Esther"; BibleProject "Overview: Esther"	The King's Scepter	Esther's crown & scepter
4	Esther 5–10	God's Hidden Hand	God is working even when we can't see Him.	SharefaithKids "Queen Esther"; BibleJourneyTV "Esther and Haman"; BibleProject theme "Exile"	Purim Noise-Maker Bible Bowl	Purim noisemaker (gragger)
5 (optional)	Nehemiah 12:27–43	The Wall Party! (Review & Fun Sunday)	Celebrate: all 12 History books complete!	Rewatch favorite	All games + "Who Am I?"	Wall dedication parade & badges

Weekly Lessons

Week 1: Going Home to Build God's House

Scripture: Ezra 1:1–5; 3:10–13; 6:14–16; 7:10

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that God kept His promise to bring His people home from Babylon, and that they rebuilt God's temple with joy (and some tears), even when it was hard.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* A suitcase or backpack packed with a few items (a toothbrush, a stuffed animal, a Bible, a snack), a "WELCOME HOME" sign.

1. Walk in with the suitcase. "I've been gone for a long, long time... 70 years! What would you pack if you were going home after 70 years?"
2. Pull out the items one by one and talk about them.
3. Hold up the WELCOME HOME sign: "Today God's people finally get to go HOME!"

📖 **Story script**

> Remember how God's people were taken far away to Babylon? They had to live there for a long, long time, about 70 years! Kids grew up and became grandparents. Many people missed home. They sang sad songs and wondered, "Will we ever go back?"
>
> But God had made a promise through the prophet Jeremiah: "After seventy years, I will bring you home." And God *always* keeps His promises.
>
> A new king named **Cyrus** took over Babylon. One day, God stirred Cyrus's heart, and Cyrus made an announcement: "The LORD, the God of heaven, has told me to build a house for Him in

> Jerusalem. Any of God's people may go home and help rebuild it!" He even gave them back the gold and silver cups and bowls that Babylon had taken from God's temple!
>
> So about 50,000 people packed up and made the long journey home, led by a man named **Zerubbabel**. When they got there, Jerusalem was a mess: broken stones, burned wood and weeds everywhere. But they got to work!
>
> First they built an altar to worship God. Then they laid the **foundation**, the bottom part, of a new temple. When it was done, the priests blew trumpets and everyone sang, "God is good! His love lasts forever!" Lots of people shouted for joy. But some of the old people cried. They remembered how beautiful the first temple had been. The shouting and crying were so loud, people could hear it far away!
>
> Then trouble came. Enemies didn't want the temple built. They wrote letters to the king and scared the workers, and the work stopped for a long time. But God sent two prophets, **Haggai** and **Zechariah**, who said, "Get back to work! God is with you!" And they did. Finally the temple was finished, and the people had a big party.
>
> Years later, a man named **Ezra** came to Jerusalem. Ezra loved God's Word. He studied it, he obeyed it, and he taught it to everyone. God wants us to do the same: read it, live it, and share it!

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Practice the "shout and cry" moment. Half the class shouts "Hooray!" and half pretends to cry "Boo-hoo!" Then everyone together: "God is good!"
- **Explorers:** Have kids find Ezra in their Bibles (right after 2 Chronicles). Read the last verse of 2 Chronicles and the first verse of Ezra side by side: they're almost the same!
- **Trailblazers:** Read Isaiah 44:28, which names Cyrus more than a century before he became king. Discuss God's control of history.
- **Ambassadors:** Read Ezra 7:10 and discuss the order: *study → do → teach*. Which one do they tend to skip? Have them plan how to "teach" a Little Lamb something from God's Word this month.

💬 Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Where did God's people go home to? (Jerusalem) 2) What did they build? (God's house / temple) 3) Does God keep His promises? (Yes!)
- *Explorers:* 1) How long were God's people away? (About 70 years) 2) Why did some people cry when the foundation was laid? 3) What did Ezra love to do?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why did the work on the temple stop? 2) What got it started again? 3) Have you ever started something for God and then quit? What helps you keep going?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) How is it possible that a pagan king (Cyrus) carried out God's plan? (Proverbs 21:1) 2) What's the difference between knowing the Bible and devoting yourself to it (Ezra 7:10)? 3) The old people grieved what was lost while the young celebrated what was new. How can churches honor both?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Ezra" / "rebuilding the temple" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Ezra | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "return from exile" / "Ezra" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Ezra | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors (Explorers with pauses) | Likely title: "Overview: Ezra-Nehemiah" (one video covers both books) | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Ezra+Nehemiah |

Follow-up questions: 1) Who let God's people go home? 2) What did the people build first?

> Preview every video first. Search results change over time, so pick the best clip for your group and time slot.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Wall Builders Relay* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Foundation Stone* craft (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** E-Z-R-A (only 4 letters!). Little Lambs: "E is for Ezra." Learn the first half of the verse: "Do not grieve..." and the meaning of "grieve" (to be very sad).

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> Dear God, thank You for always keeping Your promises. Thank You that You bring Your people home. Help me love Your Word like Ezra did. In Jesus' name, amen.

Week 2: Pray, Plan, Build!

Scripture: Nehemiah 1:1–4; 2:1–8; 4:1–6, 15–20; 6:15–16; 8:1–12

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Nehemiah prayed first, worked hard, and didn't give up when enemies made fun of him, and that God's Word gives us joy and strength.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* 20–30 empty boxes, paper cups or blocks; one "bully" helper (a teen or teacher, coached beforehand).

1. Ask kids to build a wall across the front of the room.
2. While they build, the "bully" (gently, with a smile) teases: "That's a silly wall! A fox could knock it down!" (Nehemiah 4:3)
3. Ask: "How did that feel? Did you want to quit?" Then: "A man named Nehemiah had people say exactly that! Let's see what he did."

📖 **Story script**

Far away in the palace of the king of Persia worked a man named **Nehemiah**. He was the king's **cupbearer**. That means he tasted the king's drinks to make sure nobody had put poison in them! The king trusted him a lot.

One day, Nehemiah's brother came with bad news: "The walls of Jerusalem are broken down, and the gates have been burned. God's people are in trouble and feel ashamed." In those days, a city without walls wasn't safe. Nehemiah sat down and cried. Then for many days he did something very important: he **prayed**. "God, You promised to bring Your people back. Please help me when I talk to the king."

One day the king asked, "Why are you so sad?" Nehemiah was scared, but he shot up a quick prayer to God, right there! Then he said, "My city is broken. Please let me go rebuild it." And the king said **yes**! He even gave Nehemiah letters and wood for the job.

In Jerusalem, Nehemiah rode around the broken walls at night on his animal to see the damage. Then he told the people, "Let's rebuild the wall!" Everyone got to work: priests, goldsmiths, perfume makers, even daughters. Each family built the part of the wall near their house.

But some bullies, **Sanballat** and **Tobiah**, laughed: "What are those weak people doing? If even a fox climbed on that wall, it would fall down!" Later they planned to attack. Did Nehemiah quit? No! He prayed, and he made a plan: half the people built and half stood guard. The builders worked with a tool in one hand and a weapon nearby. Nehemiah said, "Don't be afraid! Remember the Lord, who is great and awesome!"

The enemies tried to trick Nehemiah into coming down to meet them. He said, "**I am doing a great work, and I can't come down!**" And in just **52 days**, the wall was finished! Even the enemies knew God had helped them.

Then all the people gathered, and Ezra stood on a tall wooden stage and read God's Law from morning until noon. The people cried because they realized they hadn't obeyed God. But Nehemiah said, "Don't be sad today! Go have a feast and share with others. **The joy of the LORD is your strength!**"

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Practice a "quick prayer": "Help me, God!" Have them "build" with big blocks while singing "Build the walls of Jerusalem" (see song). Count to 52 together in tens if possible.
- **Explorers:** Act out the "fox" scene. Teach the response, "I'm doing a great work and can't come down!" and use it whenever someone tries to distract them during class.
- **Trailblazers:** Track Nehemiah's prayers: 1:4–11; 2:4; 4:4–5; 4:9; 6:9; 13:14. What kinds of prayers are they (long, short, for help, for strength)?
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss leadership: Nehemiah prayed, researched (night inspection), cast vision, organized, protected, and refused distraction. How could they lead a project at school or church this way?

💬 Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) What did Nehemiah do first when he heard bad news? (Prayed) 2) What did they build? (A wall) 3) Say the verse: "The joy of the LORD is your strength!"
- *Explorers:* 1) What was Nehemiah's job? (Cupbearer) 2) How many days did it take to build the wall? (52) 3) What did Nehemiah do when people made fun of them?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why do you think Nehemiah prayed for months before talking to the king? 2) What "distractions" try to stop you from doing what God wants? 3) Why did the people cry when Ezra read God's Law, and why were they told to celebrate?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Nehemiah prayed *and* posted guards (4:9). How do faith and practical planning fit together? 2) Nehemiah 3 lists dozens of workers by name. What does that say about how God sees ordinary contributions? 3) What does "the joy of the LORD is your strength" mean? Is it about feeling happy all the time?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Nehemiah" / "Nehemiah builds the wall" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Nehemiah | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Nehemiah" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Nehemiah | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | Likely title: "Overview: Ezra-Nehemiah" (watch the second half, about Nehemiah) | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Ezra+Nehemiah |

Follow-up questions: 1) How did Nehemiah handle the people who opposed him? 2) What happened when Ezra read the Law?

> Preview every video first.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Build and Guard* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Book Wall* craft (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** N-E-H-E-M-I-A-H using the syllable clap (Ne-he-mi-ah). Learn the whole memory verse with motions: "Do not grieve" (shake head, rub eyes), "for the joy" (big smile, hands up), "of the LORD" (point up), "is your strength!" (flex arms).

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> God, when I'm sad or scared, help me pray first like Nehemiah. Thank You that Your joy makes me strong. Help me not quit doing good things. Amen.

Week 3: For Such a Time as This

Scripture: Esther 2:5–7, 17, 21–23; 3:1–11; 4:1–17

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that God placed Esther in the palace at just the right time, and that being brave means doing the right thing even when you're scared.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* A puzzle with one piece missing (hide the missing piece in your pocket).

1. Let a small group quickly put the puzzle together (or show a nearly finished one).
2. "Oh no, one piece is missing! Can the puzzle be finished without it?"
3. Pull the piece out of your pocket and snap it in. "Every piece has the right place. Today we'll meet a young woman God put in exactly the right place at exactly the right time."

📖 **Story script**

> While some of God's people had gone home to Jerusalem, many still lived far away in the huge kingdom of Persia. The king, **Xerxes**, lived in a giant palace in the city of Susa.
>
> One day, the king's queen, Vashti, refused to come when he called her, and the king became very angry. He decided to find a new queen. Many young women were brought to the palace. One of them was a Jewish girl named **Esther**. Esther's parents had died, so her older cousin **Mordecai** had raised her like his own daughter. Mordecai told her, "Don't tell anyone you're Jewish yet."
>
> The king liked Esther more than anyone else, so he put the royal crown on her head. Esther became **queen**!
>
> Meanwhile, Mordecai overheard two guards planning to hurt the king. He told Esther, Esther told the king, and the king was saved. Someone wrote it down in the king's record book... and then everyone forgot about it. (Remember that! It's important later.)
>
> Then the king made a proud man named **Haman** the most important leader in the land. Everyone had to bow down to Haman. But Mordecai would not bow. Haman was so angry that he decided to get rid of not just Mordecai but *all* of the Jewish people! He threw dice called "pur" to pick a day, and he tricked the king into signing a law: on that day, all the Jews would be destroyed.
>
> When Mordecai heard, he tore his clothes and cried loudly. He sent a message to Esther: "You must go to the king and beg for your people!"
>
> But Esther was afraid. "Anyone who goes to see the king without being invited can be killed, unless the king holds out his golden scepter. And he hasn't called me for 30 days!"
>
> Mordecai sent back a message: "Don't think you'll be safe just because you live in the palace. If you stay quiet, God will save His people another way. **But who knows? Maybe you became queen for such a time as this.**"
>
> Esther thought about it. Then she said, "Gather all the Jews and fast (go without food) and pray for me for three days. My servants and I will do the same. Then I'll go to the king, even though it's against the law. **And if I die, I die.**"
>
> That's real courage. Being brave doesn't mean you're not scared. It means you trust God and do what's right *even when* you're scared.

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Practice "brave voices." Kids stand tall and say, "God helps me be brave!" Let them each wear a crown when they say it.
- **Explorers:** Freeze-frame the story at Mordecai's message. Ask, "What would you do if you were Esther?" Then reveal her answer.
- **Trailblazers:** Discuss: God's name isn't in Esther. List the "coincidences" so far (Esther chosen, Mordecai hears the plot, it's written down). Keep the list going next week.
- **Ambassadors:** Read Esther 4:13–14 slowly. What does "relief and deliverance... will arise from another place" teach about God's sovereignty and our responsibility? Where might *they* be placed "for such a time as this" (school, team, job, friend group)?

💬 **Discussion questions**

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Who became queen? (Esther) 2) Who raised Esther? (Mordecai) 3) Who helps us be brave? (God)
- *Explorers:* 1) Why wouldn't Mordecai bow to Haman? 2) Why was Esther scared to go see the king? 3) What did Esther ask everyone to do before she went? (Fast and pray for three days)
- *Trailblazers:* 1) What does "for such a time as this" mean? 2) Is being brave the same as not being scared? 3) When is it hard for you to speak up for someone?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Esther kept her identity secret at first. When is it wise to wait, and when must you speak up? 2) Mordecai says God will save His people even if Esther doesn't act. Then why does her choice matter? 3) Who in your world needs someone to speak up for them?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Esther" / "Queen Esther" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Esther | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Esther" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Esther | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | Likely title: "Overview: Esther" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Esther |

Follow-up questions: 1) What was Haman's evil plan? 2) What did Esther decide to do?

> Preview every video first. Some Esther videos skip how Esther became queen; others show it in more detail. Choose what fits your age group.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *The King's Scepter* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Esther's Crown & Scepter* (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** E-S-T-H-E-R. Notice: "Ezra" and "Esther" both start with E! Practice the bonus phrase "for such a time as this" with a clock motion (point to wrist).

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> God, thank You that You put me right where I am for a reason. When I'm scared, help me be brave like Esther and do what is right. In Jesus' name, amen.

Week 4: God's Hidden Hand

Scripture: Esther 5:1–8; 6:1–11; 7:1–10; 8:3–8; 9:20–22

Lesson goal: Kids will learn how God turned Haman's evil plan upside down and saved His people, showing that God is always working, even when we can't see Him.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* A glove puppet or a hand inside a glove; a sheet or blanket.

1. Hold up an empty glove. "Can this glove move on its own?" (No.)
2. Put your hand inside and make it wave, point and grab. "Now it can! You can't see my hand, but it's there, making everything happen."
3. Cover your arm with the blanket and keep moving the glove. "In Esther, God is like the hand in the glove. You can't see Him, but He's making things happen."

📖 **Story script**

> After three days of fasting and praying, Queen Esther put on her royal robes and walked into the king's hall. Her heart was pounding. The king looked up... and held out his **golden scepter**! Esther was safe! She touched the tip of it.
>
> "What do you want, Queen Esther? I'll give you up to half my kingdom!" Esther said, "Please come to a dinner I've made for you, and bring Haman." At the dinner she said, "Come back tomorrow for another dinner, and then I'll tell you."
>
> Haman left feeling proud, until he saw Mordecai, who still wouldn't bow. Haman was so mad that he had a tall pole built, 75 feet high, to hang Mordecai on.
>
> But that very night, **the king couldn't sleep**. (Was that an accident? No! God's hidden hand!) So the king asked a servant to read him the boring record book. The servant read about how Mordecai had saved the king's life. "What reward did Mordecai get?" asked the king. "Nothing," said the servant.
>
> Just then, Haman walked in, coming to ask the king to get rid of Mordecai. The king asked him, "What should I do for a man I really want to honor?" Haman thought, "He must mean ME!" So he said, "Dress him in the king's robe, put him on the king's horse, and have someone lead him through the city shouting, 'This is what is done for the man the king delights to honor!'"
>
> The king said, "Great idea! Go do all that... for **Mordecai**!" So Haman had to lead Mordecai through the streets, shouting about how great Mordecai was! Haman's plan was turning upside down!
>
> At the second dinner, Esther finally spoke up: "Please, my king, spare my life and my people's lives! Someone has planned to destroy us all." "Who would dare do that?" shouted the king. Esther pointed. "This wicked **Haman**!" The king was furious, and Haman was punished on the very pole he had built for Mordecai.
>
> The king couldn't undo his old law, but he made a new law that let the Jews protect themselves. God's people were saved! They celebrated with food, gifts and gifts for the poor. They called the

> party **Purim**, and Jewish people still celebrate it today.
>
> God's name isn't written in the book of Esther even once. But look at all the ways He was working! And He's working in your life too, even when you can't see Him.

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Every time you say "Haman," kids shake a noisemaker or stomp (a Purim tradition!). Every time you say "Esther" or "Mordecai," they cheer "Hooray!"
- **Explorers:** Make an "Upside Down" chart: what Haman planned vs. what really happened (he wanted honor → he honored Mordecai; he built a pole for Mordecai → he was punished on it; he planned destruction for the Jews → they were saved).
- **Trailblazers:** Finish the "coincidences" list from last week (the king can't sleep, the reading falls on Mordecai's deed, Haman walks in at that moment). Discuss providence: God working through ordinary events.
- **Ambassadors:** Compare the reversal in Esther with the cross: what looked like the enemy's victory became God's greatest victory (Colossians 2:15; Genesis 50:20 as a parallel).

💬 **Discussion questions**

- *Little Lambs:* 1) What did the king hold out to Esther? (A golden scepter) 2) Who couldn't sleep? (The king) 3) Did God save His people? (Yes!)
- *Explorers:* 1) What did Haman think when the king asked about honoring someone? 2) How did Haman's plan turn upside down? 3) What is Purim?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) List three "coincidences" in Esther. Were they really accidents? 2) Why didn't Esther just tell the king at the first dinner? 3) Where have you seen God's "hidden hand" in your life?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) How does Esther show both God's sovereignty and human courage at work together? 2) Pride ruined Haman. How does pride show up in teens' lives? 3) Why might God choose to work "hidden" sometimes instead of with obvious miracles?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Queen Esther saves her people" / "Esther" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Queen+Esther | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Esther and Haman" / "Esther" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Esther+and+Haman | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | Theme video, likely title: "Exile"; or rewatch "Overview: Esther" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Exile |

Follow-up questions: 1) How was God working even though His name isn't in the book? 2) How did the people celebrate?

> Preview every video first.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Purim Noise-Maker Bible Bowl* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Purim noisemaker (gragger)* (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Spell all three: E-Z-R-A, N-E-H-E-M-I-A-H, E-S-T-H-E-R. Say all 12 History books in order. Explorers and older: all 17 books.

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> God, even when I can't see You, You are working. Thank You for taking care of me. Help me trust You and be brave. Amen.

Week 5 (optional): The Wall Party! (Review & Fun Sunday)

Based on Nehemiah 12:27–43, when two big choirs marched on top of the finished wall and "the sound of rejoicing in Jerusalem could be heard far away." Celebrate finishing all 12 History books! Full plan under **End-of-Phase Review & Celebration**.

Book Memory Song & Motions

🎵 "Building the Books" (tune: *London Bridge Is Falling Down*)

This song is cumulative: all 17 books from Genesis to Esther. (Our new verse is Verse 3.)

Verse 1: The Law (books 1–5)

> Genesis and Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers too, Deuteronomy makes five: Books of Law!

Shout: "FIVE BOOKS OF LAW!" *(five fingers up)*

Verse 2: History, part 1 (books 6–14)

> Joshua, Judges, and then Ruth, Samuel, Samuel, Kings and Kings and Chronicles, Chronicles!

(Hold up 1 finger, then 2 fingers each time Samuel, Kings and Chronicles is sung, for "First" and "Second.")

Verse 3: History, part 2 (books 15–17), NEW!

> Ezra, Nehemiah too, Esther too, Esther too, Twelve books of History, through! Seventeen books!

Shout: "TWELVE BOOKS OF HISTORY... DONE!" *(clap 12 times fast)* **Big finish:** "SEVENTEEN BOOKS! WE KNOW SEVENTEEN!"

Fun bonus verse (story verse, same tune):

> Build the walls of Jerusalem, Jerusalem, Jerusalem, Build the walls of Jerusalem, In fifty-two days!
>
> Esther spoke up to the king, To the king, to the king, Esther spoke up to the king: Such a time as this!

Hand motions for each book

Book	Motion
Genesis	Sunrise hands: palms together like a closed book, open them, sweep arms up like the sun rising
Exodus	Exit walk: walk two fingers across your palm and out the "door"
Leviticus	Holy hands: fold hands to pray, then raise them high
Numbers	Count 1-2-3-4 on fingers, then zig-zag your hand (wandering)
Deuteronomy	Two fingers up ("second"), tap head ("remember"), hand on heart
Joshua	March in place with fist-trumpet at mouth ("Walls fall down!")
Judges	Pound a gavel on your palm, then draw a circle (the cycle)
Ruth	Scoop up pretend grain, then hug yourself (loyal love)
1 & 2 Samuel	1/2 fingers, cup ear (listening)
1 & 2 Kings	1/2 fingers, crown on head
1 & 2 Chronicles	1/2 fingers, unroll a scroll
Ezra	Stack fists like bricks (rebuilding the temple)
Nehemiah	Hammer with one hand, shield up with the other
Esther	Crown on head, then cup hands around mouth (speak up!)

📣 Section Shout

Leader: "Five books of..." Kids: "**LAW!**" Leader: "Twelve books of..." Kids: "**HISTORY!**" Leader: "How many books do we know?" Kids: "**SEVENTEEN!**" Leader: "What's next month?" Kids: "**POETRY!**" (preview of Phase 6)

Cumulative recall drill

1. **Brick by brick:** Each child holds a "brick" (a box or card) labeled with one of the 17 books. Kids line up in order to build a wall across the room. Time it! Can you beat last week's time?
2. **Knock out a brick:** While eyes are closed, the leader removes one "brick." Kids open their eyes and name the missing book.
3. **Echo and motion:** Leader says/does a book; kids echo. Speed up each round.

4. **History split:** Kids name the 12 History books in three groups of four: (Joshua, Judges, Ruth, 1 Samuel) (2 Samuel, 1 Kings, 2 Kings, 1 Chronicles) (2 Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther).
5. **Backwards challenge (Trailblazers/Ambassadors):** Esther to Genesis!

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on Verse 3 with motions and the word "Esther." Celebrate knowing the "E" names: Ezra and Esther.
- **Explorers:** Aim for all 17 with the song. Use the "History split" (groups of four) to break it down.
- **Trailblazers:** All 17 without the song; name the section of each; know how many books are in each section (5 Law, 12 History).
- **Ambassadors:** Lead the song. Learn the actual time order (Ezra 1–6 → Esther → Ezra 7–10 → Nehemiah) and explain it to Trailblazers.

Spelling & Reading

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letter recognition, first sounds) | Word | First letter | Sound it out | |---|---|---| | Ezra | E | "Eh" like an egg 🥚 | | Esther | E | "Eh," same letter as Ezra! | | Nehemiah | N | "Nnn" like a nose 👃 | | wall | W | "Wuh" like a wagon | | joy | J | "J" like jump! | | king | K | "K" like a kite |

Activity: Hide big letter cards (E, E, N) around the room. Kids find them and "build" a wall by taping them up in order: E (Ezra), N (Nehemiah), E (Esther).

Explorers (book names)

1. Ezra (E-Z-R-A)
2. Nehemiah (N-E-H-E-M-I-A-H)
3. Esther (E-S-T-H-E-R) Bonus: Mordecai, Haman, Persia. Practice writing all 12 History books.

Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocab words)

- Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther (plus all 12 History books)
- **exile:** being forced to live away from your home country
- **temple:** God's house in Jerusalem
- **scribe:** a person who copies and teaches God's Law
- **cupbearer:** a trusted helper who tasted the king's drinks
- **scepter:** a rod a king holds to show his power

Ambassadors (book names + harder vocab with definitions)

- All 17 book names in order, spelled correctly
- **restoration:** bringing something back to how it should be
- **providence:** God's wise care and control of everything, even ordinary events
- **intercede:** to go to someone with power on behalf of someone else
- **decree:** an official order from a ruler

- **fast / fasting:** going without food for a time to focus on prayer
- **Purim:** the Jewish festival celebrating God's rescue in Esther ("lots")
- **diaspora:** Jewish people living outside the land of Israel (literally "scattering")

Syllable-clap method

- Ez-ra (2 claps) → E-Z-R-A
- Ne-he-mi-ah (4 claps) → N-E-H-E-M-I-A-H
- Es-ther (2 claps) → E-S-T-H-E-R
- Mor-de-cai (3 claps) → M-O-R-D-E-C-A-I
- Ha-man (2 claps) → H-A-M-A-N
- Je-ru-sa-lem (4 claps) → J-E-R-U-S-A-L-E-M

Tip for Nehemiah: "**Nehe**-**MIAH**": "Knee, hey! My, ah!" Or spot the pattern: **N-E-H-E** has two E's after N and H; **M-I-A-H** ends like "Jeremiah" and "Isaiah" (coming in Phase 7)!

"Spell It Out" relay: Wall Edition

1. Teams line up. At the far end of the room are cardboard "bricks" (boxes or cards), each with one letter.
2. Leader calls "Nehemiah!" Runner 1 brings back N, runner 2 brings back E, and so on.
3. Teams stack the letter bricks into a wall in the right order.
4. First team to spell the word correctly and shout "The joy of the LORD is our strength!" wins.
5. *Younger:* Each runner brings one whole book-name card to build the History wall in order. *Older:* Spell all three books back-to-back with one set of letters (you'll need to reuse letters: plan carefully!).

Mini spelling bee word list

Word	Use it in a sentence
Ezra	Ezra loved to study and teach God's Word.
Nehemiah	Nehemiah prayed before he spoke to the king.
Esther	Esther bravely went to see the king.
Mordecai	Mordecai raised Esther like a daughter.
Haman	Haman's evil plan turned upside down.
Persia	Esther was queen of Persia.
Jerusalem	The people rebuilt the walls of Jerusalem.
temple	The people rebuilt God's temple.
scepter	The king held out his golden scepter.
wall	The wall was finished in 52 days.
joy	The joy of the LORD is your strength.
courage	Esther showed courage when she was afraid.

Read-aloud practice passage

Readers take turns, one sentence each (simple version based on Nehemiah 8:1–3, 5–6, 10):

> All the people came together in the square by the Water Gate. They asked Ezra to bring out the Book of the Law. Ezra stood on a high wooden stage. He opened the book, and all the people stood up. Ezra praised the LORD, the great God. The people lifted their hands and said, "Amen! Amen!" Ezra read from early morning until noon. The people listened carefully. Then Nehemiah said, "Go and enjoy good food and sweet drinks. Share with people who have nothing. This day is holy to our Lord. Do not be sad, for the joy of the LORD is your strength."

Word Trivia

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. Which king let God's people go home? (Hint: starts with C)
2. What did the people rebuild in Ezra?
3. What did Nehemiah rebuild?
4. What did Nehemiah do first when he heard bad news?
5. Who became queen of Persia?
6. Who raised Esther?
7. What did the king hold out to Esther so she would be safe?
8. **True or False:** Nehemiah gave up when people made fun of him.
9. **Fill in the blank:** "The joy of the LORD is your _____."
10. **Fill in the blank:** "...for such a time as _____."
11. Who wouldn't bow to Haman?
12. **True or False:** God helped His people even when they couldn't see Him.

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

13. About how many years were God's people in exile? (Jeremiah 29:10)
14. How many days did it take to rebuild the wall?
15. What was Nehemiah's job in the king's palace?
16. **Who said it?** "I am carrying on a great project and cannot go down."
17. What did the bullies say would knock down the wall?
18. **Which book?** "The joy of the LORD is your strength" is in ___.
19. What did Haman throw to pick a day? (It gave the holiday its name.)
20. What is the name of the Jewish holiday that celebrates Esther's story?
21. **Who said it?** "If I perish, I perish."
22. What happened the night the king couldn't sleep?
23. **True or False:** The name "God" appears many times in the book of Esther.
24. What were the names of the two prophets who encouraged the temple builders?
25. **Which book?** Ezra reads God's Law from a high wooden platform in ___ chapter 8.

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

26. Which prophet named Cyrus over 100 years before Cyrus became king?
27. Who led the first group home and is in Jesus' family tree?
28. **Who said it?** "Who knows but that you have come to your royal position for such a time as this?"
29. What was Esther's Hebrew name?
30. Why did some old men weep when the temple foundation was laid?
31. Name the two main enemies who opposed Nehemiah.
32. What was the Persian capital where Esther lived?
33. **Fill in the blank:** "Ezra had devoted himself to the _____ and _____ of the Law of the LORD, and to _____ its decrees and laws in Israel." (Ezra 7:10)
34. **True or False:** The events of Esther happened after Nehemiah rebuilt the walls.
35. How did the builders in Nehemiah 4 protect themselves while they worked?
36. Which king did Nehemiah serve?
37. Why couldn't the king simply cancel Haman's law?
38. In the Hebrew Bible, which two of this month's books were counted as one book?

Answer Key

1. Cyrus 2. The temple (God's house) 3. The walls of Jerusalem 4. Prayed (and cried and fasted) 5. Esther 6. Mordecai, her cousin 7. His golden scepter 8. False 9. strength 10. this 11. Mordecai 12. True
2. 70 years 14. 52 days (Nehemiah 6:15) 15. Cupbearer 16. Nehemiah (6:3) 17. A fox (4:3) 18. Nehemiah (8:10) 19. The pur (a lot, like dice) 20. Purim 21. Esther (4:16) 22. A servant read the royal records, and the king learned Mordecai had saved his life (ch. 6) 23. False. God's name is never mentioned. 24. Haggai and Zechariah (Ezra 5:1) 25. Nehemiah
3. Isaiah (44:28; 45:1) 27. Zerubbabel (Matthew 1:12–13) 28. Mordecai (Esther 4:14) 29. Hadassah (2:7) 30. They remembered the glory of Solomon's first temple (Ezra 3:12) 31. Sanballat and Tobiah (also Geshem) 32. Susa 33. study, observance, teaching 34. False. Esther (about 483–473 BC) happened before Nehemiah (445 BC). 35. Half worked and half stood guard; builders kept weapons with them (4:16–18) 36. Artaxerxes 37. A law sealed with the king's ring could not be revoked under Persian law (Esther 8:8), so a new law was written to let the Jews defend themselves. 38. Ezra and Nehemiah

---

Games

> More game ideas and general rules: see `../00-start-here/game-library.md`.

🎮 1. Wall Builders Relay

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** 17 empty boxes (cereal boxes, shoe boxes) or large plastic cups per team, each labeled with a book name (Genesis → Esther); a start line

- **Setup:** Mix each team's 17 "bricks" in a pile at the far end of the room.
- **How to play:** One runner at a time runs to the pile, finds the next book in order (first Genesis, then Exodus...), brings it back and adds it to the team's wall. Bricks must be stacked or lined up in order.
- **How to win:** First team to build its wall correctly, from Genesis to Esther, and shout "Seventeen books!" wins.
- **Adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Use only Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther (with pictures) or just build a wall with any blocks while singing. *Ambassadors:* Wall must be built in two layers: Law on the bottom, History on top.
- **Learning goal:** Book order from Genesis to Esther.

🎮 2. Build and Guard (Nehemiah 4)

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors
- **Supplies:** Soft foam balls ("enemy arrows"), blocks or cups for building, pool noodles or cardboard "shields," pinnies for two teams
- **Setup:** Team A ("Jerusalem") has a building zone in the middle. Half are builders and half are guards with shields. Team B ("Sanballat's crew") stands outside a marked line and throws soft balls *only at the wall*, never at people.
- **How to play:** Builders try to build a wall of cups as tall as possible in 90 seconds while guards block balls with shields. When the leader blows a whistle or trumpet ("When you hear the trumpet, join us there!" Nehemiah 4:20), everyone on Team A must run to the leader and shout the memory verse before returning. Switch roles.
- **How to win:** The team with the tallest standing wall at the end of its round wins.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Teachers are the "enemies" and toss balls gently. *Older:* Each cup must be labeled with a book in order to count.
- **Learning goal:** Teamwork, perseverance, the memory verse, and the story of Nehemiah 4.

🎮 3. The King's Scepter

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers
- **Supplies:** A "golden scepter" (wrapping paper tube covered in gold paper with a ball on top), a "throne" chair
- **Setup:** One player (or teacher) is King Xerxes on the throne at one end. Everyone else is "Esther" at the other end.
- **How to play:** Like "Mother, May I?" Players ask, "King, may I take three steps?" The king says, "Only if you can tell me the book after Ruth!" (or any review question). Correct answer: king holds out the scepter, and the player takes the steps. Wrong answer: player stays (with a hint for next time). Players who reach the throne and touch the tip of the scepter (Esther 5:2) become the next king.
- **How to win:** First to touch the scepter.
- **Adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Questions like "What did Nehemiah build?" or "Say the verse." *Older:* Spelling questions ("Spell Nehemiah").
- **Learning goal:** Review of books and story facts.

🎮 4. Purim Noise-Maker Bible Bowl

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Noisemakers (from the craft), a trivia list (see Word Trivia), a scoreboard
- **Setup:** Divide into teams. Explain the Purim tradition: when Haman's name is read, everyone makes noise to "blot out" his name.
- **How to play:** Ask trivia questions. Teams shake their noisemakers to "buzz in." BUT if the leader says "Haman" anywhere in a question, everyone must make noise and shout "Boo!" before the team can answer. Any team that forgets to boo loses its turn.
- **How to win:** Most points after 15–20 questions.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Use Easy questions and picture cards; teacher reads. *Older:* Use Hard questions and require the book and chapter.
- **Learning goal:** Story review; learning about Purim.

🎮 5. Trumpet Gather

- **Best for:** All ages (great active game)
- **Supplies:** A kazoo, whistle or toy trumpet; three signs on three walls: "EZRA," "NEHEMIAH," "ESTHER"
- **How to play:** Kids walk around the room "building" (pretend hammering). The leader blows the trumpet and calls out a fact: "Rebuilt the walls!" Kids run to the right book sign (Nehemiah). Other facts: "Golden scepter" (Esther), "Cyrus's decree" (Ezra), "52 days" (Nehemiah), "Temple foundation" (Ezra), "Mordecai" (Esther), "Joy of the LORD is your strength" (Nehemiah).
- **How to win:** Kids at the wrong wall join the "builders' crew" (they help the leader check others next round). Last kids standing win.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Use pictures on the walls (temple, wall, crown). *Older:* Add the History books from previous phases on more walls (Samuel, Kings, Chronicles).
- **Learning goal:** Matching facts to books.

🎮 6. Upside-Down Day (Esther reversal game)

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers
- **Supplies:** None
- **How to play:** Leader calls out commands, and kids do the *opposite* ("Sit down!" → stand up; "Be quiet!" → cheer; "Frown!" → smile). Whoever does the command instead of the opposite must say one book of the Bible in order to stay in. Between rounds, explain one "reversal" from Esther (Haman wanted honor but had to honor Mordecai; the day planned for destruction became a day of celebration, Esther 9:1).
- **How to win:** Last players still "in." (Players who say a book correctly stay in, so most kids stay in!)
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Play slowly with only 3 commands. *Older:* Speed it up and require books in order.
- **Learning goal:** God turns things around; book order.

Coloring Pages

> 🖍️ Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-05-printables.html`

Page 1 (Week 1): "Shout for Joy!"

- **Scene:** A crowd of people around a temple foundation of big stones. Priests in robes blow long trumpets. Children and young people jump and cheer with hands raised; a few older people with gray beards wipe tears. Scaffolding and building tools lie nearby.
- **Caption:** "He is good; his love toward Israel endures forever." (Ezra 3:11)
- **Conversation prompts:** Why were some people crying and some shouting? What makes you want to shout for joy to God?

Page 2 (Week 2): "We Will Build!"

- **Scene:** A tall stone wall of Jerusalem half-built, with workers laying bricks. One worker holds a trowel in one hand and a shield on his arm. Nehemiah stands on the wall pointing and encouraging. Tiny fox peeking from behind a rock (for fun!). A trumpet player stands ready.
- **Caption:** "The joy of the LORD is your strength." (Nehemiah 8:10)
- **Conversation prompts:** Find the fox! What did the bullies say about it? What is a "great work" God wants you to do?

Page 3 (Week 3): "For Such a Time as This"

- **Scene:** Queen Esther in royal robes and crown, kneeling in prayer in a palace room with tall columns and hanging curtains. Through a window you can see the city of Susa. A large clock or hourglass decorates the corner as a symbol of "time."
- **Caption:** "Who knows but that you have come to your royal position for such a time as this?" (Esther 4:14)
- **Conversation prompts:** How do you think Esther felt? Where has God put you "for such a time as this"?

Page 4 (Week 4): "The Golden Scepter"

- **Scene:** King Xerxes on a big throne holding out a long golden scepter toward Queen Esther, who reaches to touch its tip. Guards stand at the sides. Behind a curtain, a hand-in-glove shape (God's "hidden hand") subtly appears in the pattern of the drapes for older kids to find.
- **Caption:** "God's hidden hand is always working."
- **Conversation prompts:** Can you find the hidden hand in the picture? Where do you think God is working in your life even when you can't see Him?

Page 5 (Book-name page): "The History Wall Is Complete!"

- **Scene:** A big brick wall made of 12 large bricks, each with one History book name in bubble letters: JOSHUA, JUDGES, RUTH, 1 SAMUEL, 2 SAMUEL, 1 KINGS, 2 KINGS, 1 CHRONICLES, 2 CHRONICLES, EZRA, NEHEMIAH, ESTHER. The three newest bricks (Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther) are on top with tiny pictures (temple, trowel, crown). A banner overhead: "12 BOOKS OF HISTORY."
- **Caption:** "17 of 66 books: Law ✔ History ✔"
- **Conversation prompts:** Can you read all 12 bricks in order? Which History book is your favorite story?

Activities & Crafts

✂️ 1. Foundation Stone (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Gray construction paper "stones" (or real flat rocks), markers, a large poster board labeled "God's House"
- **Steps:**
  1. Each child writes their name and one thing they're thankful God has done on a paper stone.
  2. Glue all the stones together at the bottom of the poster to make a "foundation."
  3. On the top, write "He is good; his love endures forever!" (Ezra 3:11).
  4. As a group, do the "shout and cry" moment: shout "God is good!"
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Draw a picture instead of writing; teacher writes the name. *Explorers:* Write the 12 History books on 12 foundation stones in order. *Trailblazers/Ambassadors:* Write a promise God kept in their life or in the Bible.
- **What it teaches:** God keeps His promises; worship and thankfulness.

✂️ 2. Book Wall (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Red/brown rectangle paper bricks (about 2" × 4", 17 per child), a long strip of paper (4" × 36") as the base, glue sticks, markers
- **Steps:**
  1. Write one book name on each brick (Genesis → Esther).
  2. Glue the bricks in order to build a wall: 5 Law bricks on the bottom row (a different color), 12 History bricks above.
  3. Draw a gate in the middle and write "The joy of the LORD is your strength!" above the gate.
  4. Bonus: draw a tiny fox at the bottom!
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-printed bricks; they glue and color. Focus on the three new names. *Explorers:* Write names themselves. *Trailblazers:* Add one word for each book's summary. *Ambassadors:* Make an extra-large class version for the classroom wall, to be added to each month.
- **What it teaches:** Book order and sections; Nehemiah's story.

✂️ 3. Esther's Crown & Scepter (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Gold cardstock crowns, paper towel tubes or dowels, gold paper/foil, a styrofoam ball or crumpled foil ball, sticky jewels, glue, tape
- **Steps:**
    1. Decorate a crown. On the band write "For such a time as this."
    2. Wrap the tube in gold paper and attach the foil ball on top to make a scepter.
    3. On a ribbon tied to the scepter, write "God helps me be brave."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Precut and pre-wrapped; they add jewels. *Explorers/Trailblazers:* Write on the crown points places God has put them (school, team, family). *Ambassadors:* Make sets for Little Lambs and act as "kings" for The King's Scepter game.
- **What it teaches:** God places us where He wants us; courage.

✂️ 4. Purim Noisemaker (Gragger) (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Small clean plastic bottles with lids (or two paper plates stapled together), dried beans or rice, tape, stickers, markers, ribbon
- **Steps:**
    1. Fill the bottle or plates with a spoonful of beans.
    2. Seal tightly with tape (hot glue by a teacher for bottles).
    3. Decorate with the words "God saves!" and a crown.
    4. Use it during the story and the Bible Bowl whenever Haman's name is said.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Paper plate version (safer); teacher seals. *Older:* Write the "upside down" reversals around the plate.
- **Safety:** Small beans can be a choking hazard. Seal well and supervise Little Lambs.
- **What it teaches:** Celebrating God's rescue; Purim tradition; God turns evil plans around.

✂️ 5. Nehemiah's "Arrow Prayer" Cards

- **Supplies:** Index cards cut into arrow shapes, markers, a hole punch, a key ring
- **Steps:**
    1. Explain the "arrow prayer": the quick prayer Nehemiah prayed before answering the king (Nehemiah 2:4).
    2. On each arrow, write a short prayer: "Help me, God!" "Give me courage." "Thank You, Jesus!" "Show me what to say." "Make me brave."
    3. Punch holes and put them on a key ring to clip on a backpack.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* One arrow with "Help me, God!" and a picture. *Ambassadors:* Write longer prayers modeled on Nehemiah 1:5–11.
- **What it teaches:** We can pray anywhere, anytime, even quick prayers.

✂️ 6. Booth of Joy (Nehemiah 8:14–17)

- **Supplies:** A table or chairs, a sheet, green paper leaves, tape, paper fruit
- **Steps:**
    1. Explain that after Ezra read the Law, the people built little shelters out of branches to celebrate the Festival of Booths (Tabernacles). It was the happiest they'd been in a long

time (8:17).
2. Build a class "booth" over a table with a sheet and leaves.
3. Kids write or draw things that bring them joy from God on paper fruit and hang them.
4. Read the memory verse inside the booth during snack time.

- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Decorate leaves. *Older:* Look up Leviticus 23:42–43 to learn why they built booths (remembering the wilderness journey).
- **What it teaches:** God's Word leads to joy; remembering God's faithfulness.

Word Puzzles

Word scramble

#	Scrambled	Hint
1	ZARE	Book 15; a priest who taught God's Word
2	HAIMEHEN	Book 16; he rebuilt the walls
3	HETRSE	Book 17; a brave queen
4	ACIDORME	Esther's cousin
5	MANHA	The villain
6	SURYC	Persian king who said "Go home!"
7	LAWL	Built in 52 days
8	PELTEM	God's house
9	REPTECS	The king held it out
10	RIMUP	Jewish holiday of celebration
11	YJO	"The ___ of the LORD is your strength"
12	HENGSTRT	"...is your ___"
13	SPAIRE	Esther's kingdom
14	RAPEYR	Nehemiah did this first

Answer key: 1. EZRA 2. NEHEMIAH 3. ESTHER 4. MORDECAI 5. HAMAN 6. CYRUS 7. WALL 8. TEMPLE 9. SCEPTER 10. PURIM 11. JOY 12. STRENGTH 13. PERSIA 14. PRAYER

Fill-in-the-blank story

Word bank: *home, Cyrus, temple, Ezra, prayed, wall, 52, strength, queen, scepter, Haman, hidden*

> After 70 years in Babylon, God kept His promise to bring His people _____. King _____ said they could go back. They rebuilt God's _____. A priest named _____ taught them God's Word. Nehemiah heard that Jerusalem was broken, so he _____. Then he led the people to rebuild the _____ in just _____ days! Ezra read God's Law, and Nehemiah said, "The joy of the LORD is your _____." Far

> away in Persia, Esther became _____. When wicked _____ planned to destroy the Jews, Esther went to the king, and he held out his golden _____. God's name isn't in the book of Esther, but His _____ hand was working all along!

Answer key: home, Cyrus, temple, Ezra, prayed, wall, 52, strength, queen, Haman, scepter, hidden

Match the book to its picture / summary

Book		Picture & summary
1. Ezra		A. 👑 A brave queen speaks up to the king to save her people.
2. Nehemiah		B. 🧱 God's people come home and rebuild God's temple; a priest teaches God's Word.
3. Esther		C. 🛡️🔨 A cupbearer prays and leads the people to rebuild the city walls in 52 days.
4. 2 Chronicles		D. 👂 A boy hears God calling in the night.
5. 1 Samuel		E. 🙏 Solomon's temple, kings of Judah, and Cyrus says "Go home!"

Answer key: 1-B, 2-C, 3-A, 4-E, 5-D

Questions for Every Age

Little Lambs (ages 4–6)

1. Does God keep His promises? (Yes!)
2. What can you do when you're sad or scared? (Pray!)
3. Who helps you be brave? (God)
4. What makes you happy about God?
5. Can God see you even when you can't see Him? (Yes!)

Explorers (ages 7–10)

1. What's a promise from God that you're glad He keeps?
2. When people make fun of you for doing what's right, what can you do?
3. What's a "great work" you can do for God this week (at home, at school)?
4. When is a time you had to be brave?
5. How can you help someone who is being treated unfairly, like Esther did?

Trailblazers (ages 11–13)

1. Nehemiah prayed both long prayers and quick "arrow prayers." Which kind do you pray more? Why?
2. Why do you think God's Word made the people cry, and then celebrate?
3. Mordecai refused to bow. What are some things Christians today shouldn't "bow down" to?
4. Can you look back and see a time God was working in your life even when you didn't notice?

5. Where has God placed you "for such a time as this"?

Ambassadors (ages 14–17)

1. Esther and Nehemiah both lived and worked in a non-believing government. What can Christians learn from them about being faithful in secular places?
2. Nehemiah faced mockery, threats and distraction. Which of these is hardest for you, and how can you respond?
3. Ezra "devoted himself" to God's Word. What would that look like in your actual weekly schedule?
4. The people grieved over sin and then were told to celebrate (Nehemiah 8:9–10). How do repentance and joy fit together in the Christian life?
5. How does the theme of "coming home" in Ezra–Nehemiah point to what Jesus does for us (Luke 15; John 14:1–3)?

Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics / worldview)

1. **"Why is Esther in the Bible if it doesn't mention God?"** *Suggested answer:* Esther shows that God is at work even when He seems absent, in the "coincidences" of daily life. That's true for most of our lives too; we rarely see fire from heaven. The book also shows God's faithfulness to His covenant people, preserving the line through whom Jesus would come. The absence of God's name may be a deliberate literary choice, inviting readers to look for His hand.
2. **"Is there historical evidence for these books?"** *Suggested answer:* Yes, a good amount. The **Cyrus Cylinder** (now in the British Museum) records Cyrus's policy of letting conquered peoples return home and restore their temples, which fits Ezra 1. **Xerxes** (Ahasuerus) is well known from Greek historians like Herodotus, and his palace at Susa has been excavated. Documents found at Elephantine in Egypt mention **Sanballat** as governor of Samaria. Archaeologists have also found remains of walls in Jerusalem that some date to Nehemiah's time. Some scholars connect a Persian-era tablet naming an official called "Marduka" to Mordecai, though that's debated.
3. **"Wasn't it wrong (or racist) for Ezra to tell people to send away foreign wives?"** *Suggested answer:* The issue was not ethnicity but faith. The Old Testament welcomed foreigners who turned to the LORD (Ruth the Moabite and Rahab of Jericho are both in Jesus' family tree!). Ezra 9:1–2 explains that these marriages joined Israel to the "detestable practices" of nations that worshiped other gods, the very thing that had led to exile. It was a painful emergency measure in a specific covenant situation. The New Testament gives different instructions to Christians: believers should marry believers (2 Corinthians 6:14), but a Christian already married to an unbeliever should *not* leave them (1 Corinthians 7:12–14). This passage shows how seriously God's people took faithfulness after the exile.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration

The Wall Party plan (last Sunday, 75 minutes; Nehemiah 12:27–43)

Time	What happens
0–10 min	**Wall Dedication Parade:** Divide into two "choirs" (like Nehemiah 12:31, 38). Each choir marches around the room (or outside) in opposite directions on a tape "wall," singing "Building the Books" with motions, and meets in the middle. Shake noisemakers!
10–25 min	**Story Stations:** Four corners: (1) Ezra: build a block temple; (2) Nehemiah: build-and-guard mini challenge; (3) Esther: act out the scepter scene; (4) Purim: retell the "upside down" story. Rotate every 3–4 minutes.
25–35 min	**Favorite Video Rewatch** (kids vote)
35–50 min	**Who Am I?** Kids take turns acting as Cyrus, Zerubbabel, Ezra, Nehemiah, Sanballat, Esther, Mordecai, Haman or King Xerxes. Others guess from clues ("I tasted the king's drinks!"). Then play the **Purim Noise-Maker Bible Bowl**.
50–60 min	**Wall Builders Relay: Championship Round** (all 17 books)
60–70 min	**Joy Feast & Check-offs:** "Go and enjoy choice food and sweet drinks, and send some to those who have nothing" (Nehemiah 8:10). Serve a snack and pack a few extra snack bags for a local food pantry or for kids who are absent. Teachers do oral check-offs. *(Check allergies.)*
70–75 min	**Passport Stamps, Badges & Prayer**

Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs (ages 4–6)

- ☐ Says "History" for this kind of book
- ☐ Names Ezra, Nehemiah and Esther (with motions)
- ☐ Says the short verse: "The joy of the LORD is your strength."
- ☐ Tells one thing: Nehemiah built a wall / Esther was a brave queen

Explorers (ages 7–10)

- ☐ Says all 3 books of this phase in order
- ☐ Spells EZRA, NEHEMIAH and ESTHER correctly
- ☐ Says all 17 books from Genesis to Esther (with the song is OK)
- ☐ Says the memory verse (Nehemiah 8:10)

Trailblazers (ages 11–13)

- ☐ Says all 17 books in order without the song
- ☐ Gives a one-sentence summary of Ezra, Nehemiah and Esther

- [ ] Names the two sections so far and how many books are in each (Law 5, History 12)
- [ ] Says the memory verse with reference and explains "for such a time as this"

Ambassadors (ages 14–17)

- [ ] Says all 17 books in order and names each section
- [ ] Explains the real time order of events (Ezra 1–6 → Esther → Ezra 7–10 → Nehemiah)
- [ ] Teaches one of the three books to a younger child (name, motion, one story, one way it points to Jesus)
- [ ] Says the memory verse with reference

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp the "Coming Home & Being Brave" page. Stamp design: a brick wall with a small crown on top and "EZRA • NEH • ESTHER" around the edge. Add a special **"HISTORY COMPLETE!"** sticker, since kids have now finished two whole sections of the Bible library.

🏅 Badge description: The Brave Builder Badge

A shield-shaped badge in brick orange. In the center, a small stone wall with a gold crown sitting on top. A banner at the bottom reads "17 OF 66 • HISTORY ✔." (Sticker, button or sash patch.)

📜 Certificate wording

> **Brave Builder Certificate** This certifies that _____ has completed **Phase 5: Coming Home & Being Brave** at Purpose Church Sunday School. You have learned the books of **Ezra, Nehemiah and Esther** and have completed **all 12 books of History**. You now know **17 of the 66 books** of the Bible! *"Do not grieve, for the joy of the LORD is your strength." (Nehemiah 8:10)* God has placed you right where you are "for such a time as this." Teacher: _____ Date: _____

Take-Home Family Page

> ✂️ *Copy this page and send it home on the first Sunday of the month.*

Dear Parents and Caregivers, This month your child is learning **Phase 5: Coming Home & Being Brave**, the last three History books: **Ezra, Nehemiah and Esther.** We'll see God bring His people home from Babylon, rebuild the temple (Ezra) and the walls of Jerusalem in 52 days (Nehemiah), and use a brave young queen to save her people (Esther). The big idea: **God keeps His promises and gives His people courage and joy, even when He seems hidden.** With this phase, your child completes the entire History section and knows **17 of the 66 books** of the Bible!

📖 **Memory Verse:** "Do not grieve, for the joy of the LORD is your strength." (Nehemiah 8:10, NIV) **Little Lambs:** "The joy of the LORD is your strength." **Bonus phrase:** "...for such a time as this." (Esther 4:14)

🎵 **Our Song (tune: *London Bridge Is Falling Down*)**

> Genesis and Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers too, Deuteronomy makes five: Books of Law! Joshua, Judges, and then Ruth, Samuel, Samuel, Kings and Kings and Chronicles, Chronicles! Ezra, Nehemiah too, Esther too, Esther too, Twelve books of History, through! Seventeen books!

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions**

1. Nehemiah prayed before he did anything. What is something our family should pray about this week?
2. When is it hard to be brave like Esther? Has anyone in our family had to be brave recently?
3. Where did you see God's "hidden hand" working this week?

🏠 **Family activity: "Hidden Hand Journal"** Put a jar or notebook on the kitchen table. All month, whenever someone notices something good God did ("I found my lost shoe after I prayed," "Grandma's surgery went well," "I made a new friend"), write it down. At the end of the month, read them all together and thank God for His hidden hand.

📺 **Videos to watch at home (search on YouTube; parents, please preview)**

- @SharefaithKids: search "Esther" → https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Esther
- @BibleJourneyTV: search "Nehemiah" → https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Nehemiah
- @bibleproject: "Overview: Ezra-Nehemiah" and "Overview: Esther" → https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Esther

Thank you for partnering with us! For more about the program, see `../00-start-here/program-overview.md`.

Phase 6: Songs & Wise Words

The Bible's poetry books teach us how to talk to God, sing to God, trust God when life hurts, and live wisely every day.

At a Glance	
Month	Month 6
Books covered	Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs (**5 books**)
Bible section(s)	Poetry / Wisdom (books 18–22 of the Bible). **This phase completes the Poetry/Wisdom section!**
Big Idea	God gave us songs and wise words so we can talk to Him honestly, praise Him joyfully, and follow His way, which is the wise way.
Memory Verse (all ages)	"Your word is a lamp for my feet, a light on my path." (Psalm 119:105, NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"Your word is a lamp for my feet." (Psalm 119:105)
Bonus verse (Trailblazers & Ambassadors)	"Trust in the LORD with all your heart and lean not on your own understanding." (Proverbs 3:5)
Theme color	Lamplight gold (with deep teal)
Phase symbol / badge	A harp with a glowing oil lamp beside it (the "Lamp & Harp" badge)
Running total of books learned	**22 of 66** (Law 5 + History 12 + Poetry 5 ✔)

> 🎉 **Fun fact:** We now know **22** books. Psalm 119 (where our memory verse comes from) has **22** sections, one for each letter of the Hebrew alphabet!

The Big Idea (in kid words)

The Bible has a whole shelf of poetry books: songs, prayers and wise sayings. Job shows us we can trust God even when life hurts. Psalms gives us songs to sing to God when we're happy, sad, scared or sorry. Proverbs teaches us how to make wise choices. Ecclesiastes reminds us that only God makes life really matter. And Song of Songs shows that God made love and marriage good.

How this points to Jesus: Jesus is the "wisdom of God" (1 Corinthians 1:24). Jesus sang the Psalms and even prayed Psalm 22 on the cross: "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" Jesus is the Good Shepherd of Psalm 23 (John 10:11). Job cried out for a "Redeemer" (Job 19:25) and someone to stand between him and God (Job 9:33); Jesus is that Redeemer. Jesus is "greater than Solomon" (Matthew 12:42), and He gives us life that is full and not meaningless (John 10:10). The Bible calls Jesus the Bridegroom who loves His people, the church (Ephesians 5:25).

The Books in Easy Words

> Teacher tip: Hold up the Bible and open it right in the middle. You'll usually land in Psalms! The Poetry books sit in the middle of the Bible, like a heart in the middle of a body.

18. Job

- **How to say it:** "JOHB" (rhymes with "robe," not like a "job" you go to)
- **How to spell it:** Job, J-O-B (one syllable, just 3 letters!)
- **Section:** Poetry / Wisdom
- **Traditional author:** Unknown. Some Jewish tradition says Moses. The story is set very long ago, probably around the time of Abraham.
- **One-sentence kid summary:** Job was a good man who lost almost everything, asked God hard questions, and learned that God is great and wise and can be trusted even when we don't understand.
- **In one word:** *Trust*
- **Key people:** Job, his wife, Satan ("the accuser"), Job's three friends Eliphaz, Bildad and Zophar, a younger man named Elihu, God
- **Key stories:** Job is blameless and loves God (ch. 1); Satan says Job only loves God because God gives him good things (ch. 1–2); Job loses his animals, servants, children and health, but says "The LORD gave and the LORD has taken away; may the name of the LORD be praised" (1:21); his friends sit with him silently for 7 days, then wrongly say he must have sinned (ch. 2–31); "I know that my redeemer lives" (19:25); God speaks from a storm: "Where were you when I laid the earth's foundation?" (ch. 38–41); God restores Job and gives him twice as much as before (ch. 42)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** Job wished for someone to stand between him and God (9:33) and believed in a living Redeemer (19:25). Jesus is that Redeemer! Jesus, too, was completely innocent and suffered terribly, and God brought Him through to glory.
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 🙌 Hands open upward, then folded over your heart ("I'll trust You, God"). Picture: a man sitting on the ground looking up at a storm cloud.

19. Psalms

- **How to say it:** "SAHMZ" (the P is silent! It's a sneaky letter)
- **How to spell it:** Psalms, P-S-A-L-M-S (one syllable; starts with a silent P!)
- **Section:** Poetry / Wisdom
- **Traditional author:** Many writers. King David wrote about half (73 psalms have his name). Others were written by Asaph, the sons of Korah, Solomon (Psalms 72 and 127), Moses (Psalm 90), and others. Many are unnamed.
- **One-sentence kid summary:** Psalms is God's songbook: 150 songs and prayers that teach us to talk to God about everything, happy, sad, scared, sorry and thankful.
- **In one word:** *Praise*
- **Key people:** David, Asaph, the sons of Korah, Moses, Solomon

- **Key stories / famous psalms:** Psalm 1 (the happy person is like a tree by water); Psalm 8 (how big God is, how special we are); Psalm 23 ("The LORD is my shepherd"); Psalm 46 ("Be still, and know that I am God"); Psalm 51 (David says sorry); Psalm 100 ("Shout for joy to the LORD"); Psalm 117 (the shortest chapter in the Bible, only 2 verses!); Psalm 119 (the longest chapter, 176 verses, all about God's Word); Psalm 139 ("I am fearfully and wonderfully made"); Psalm 150 ("Let everything that has breath praise the LORD")
- **Where Jesus shows up:** Jesus is the Good Shepherd (Psalm 23; John 10:11). On the cross He prayed Psalm 22:1 ("My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?") and Psalm 31:5 ("Into your hands I commit my spirit"). Psalm 118:22 says the rejected stone becomes the cornerstone, and Jesus said that was about Him (Matthew 21:42). The New Testament quotes the Psalms more than almost any other Old Testament book!
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 🎵 Strum a pretend harp (David played the harp). Picture: a harp with music notes.

20. Proverbs

- **How to say it:** "PRAH-vurbz"
- **How to spell it:** Prov-erbs, P-R-O-V-E-R-B-S (2 syllables)
- **Section:** Poetry / Wisdom
- **Traditional author:** Mostly King Solomon (1:1), who wrote 3,000 proverbs (1 Kings 4:32). Also "sayings of the wise" (22:17), Agur (ch. 30) and King Lemuel (ch. 31). Some were collected by King Hezekiah's men (25:1).
- **One-sentence kid summary:** Proverbs is a book of short, wise sayings that teach us how to make good choices with our words, friends, work, money and hearts.
- **In one word:** *Wisdom*
- **Key people:** Solomon, a father teaching his son, "Lady Wisdom" and "Lady Folly" (two characters who call out to people), the noble woman of chapter 31
- **Key sayings:** "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge" (1:7); "Trust in the LORD with all your heart" (3:5–6); "Above all else, guard your heart" (4:23); "Go to the ant, you sluggard" (6:6); "A gentle answer turns away wrath" (15:1); "A friend loves at all times" (17:17); "Walk with the wise and become wise" (13:20); "a wife of noble character" (ch. 31)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** Jesus is the wisdom of God (1 Corinthians 1:24, 30); "in him are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" (Colossians 2:3). Proverbs 8 describes Wisdom being with God at creation, and the New Testament says Jesus was with God at creation (John 1:1–3).
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 🧠 Tap your head with one finger ("think wise!"). Picture: an ant carrying food.

> **Fun tip:** Proverbs has **31 chapters**, and most months have about 31 days. Read the chapter that matches today's date!

21. Ecclesiastes

- **How to say it:** "ih-KLEE-zee-AS-teez"

- **How to spell it:** Ec-cle-si-as-tes, E-C-C-L-E-S-I-A-S-T-E-S (5 syllables; the hardest book name yet!)
- **Section:** Poetry / Wisdom
- **Traditional author:** "The Teacher" (Hebrew *Qoheleth*), "son of David, king in Jerusalem" (1:1). Traditionally Solomon.
- **One-sentence kid summary:** A wise teacher tries everything (money, fun, work, learning) and finds that nothing "under the sun" makes life last or matter, except loving God and obeying Him.
- **In one word:** *Meaning*
- **Key people:** The Teacher (Solomon)
- **Key sayings:** "Meaningless! Meaningless!... Everything is meaningless" (1:2; the Hebrew word means "vapor" or "breath," like the cloud you make on a cold day); "There is a time for everything" (3:1–8); "He has made everything beautiful in its time. He has also set eternity in the human heart" (3:11); "Two are better than one" and "a cord of three strands is not quickly broken" (4:9–12); "Remember your Creator in the days of your youth" (12:1); "Fear God and keep his commandments" (12:13)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** Ecclesiastes asks, "What lasts?" Jesus answers: "I have come that they may have life, and have it to the full" (John 10:10). Ecclesiastes says wise words are "given by one shepherd" (12:11), and Jesus is the Good Shepherd. Because Jesus rose from the dead, our work for Him is "not in vain" (1 Corinthians 15:58).
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** 💨 Blow a puff of air into your hand, then point up to God ("Life is a breath, so remember God!"). Picture: a puff of steam beside a clock.

22. Song of Songs

- **How to say it:** "SONG uv SONGZ" (also called **Song of Solomon** in some Bibles)
- **How to spell it:** Song of Songs, S-O-N-G O-F S-O-N-G-S (3 words!)
- **Section:** Poetry / Wisdom
- **Traditional author:** Solomon (1:1, "Solomon's Song of Songs")
- **One-sentence kid summary:** A beautiful love poem about a bride and groom who love each other very much, showing that God made love and marriage good.
- **In one word:** *Love*
- **Key people:** The bride (a young woman), the groom (connected with King Solomon), the bride's friends ("daughters of Jerusalem")
- **Key sayings:** "Solomon's Song of Songs" means "the best song of all" (1:1); "Catch for us the foxes, the little foxes that ruin the vineyards" (2:15); "Love is as strong as death" (8:6); "Many waters cannot quench love; rivers cannot sweep it away" (8:7)
- **Where Jesus shows up:** The Bible often describes God's love for His people like a groom's love for his bride (Isaiah 62:5; Hosea 2). Jesus is called the Bridegroom (Mark 2:19–20), and the church is His bride (Ephesians 5:25–32; Revelation 19:7). Jesus' love is truly "stronger than death," because He beat death!
- **Hand motion / picture symbol:** ❤️ Make a heart with your hands, then sing a "la-la" note. Picture: a heart with a flower.

> **Remember the shape of the Poetry shelf:** **J**ob, **P**salms, **P**roverbs, **E**cclesiastes, **S**ong. Kid phrase:

> "**J**esus **P**uts **P**eace in **E**very **S**ong!"

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher

The five books from Job to Song of Songs are often called the **Poetry** or **Wisdom** books. Unlike the History books, they don't move the story along in time. Instead, they show how God's people pray, worship, think and live. Most of the content is Hebrew poetry.

- **Hebrew poetry rhymes ideas, not sounds.** This is called *parallelism*. One line says something, and the next line repeats it, builds on it, or contrasts it. Example: "Your word is a lamp for my feet, / a light on my path" (same idea twice). "A gentle answer turns away wrath, / but a harsh word stirs up anger" (contrast). Teach this to Trailblazers and Ambassadors; it unlocks the whole section.
- **Job** wrestles with the question "Why do good people suffer?" The opening (ch. 1–2) is a prose story. The middle (ch. 3–37) is a long poetic debate in which Job's friends insist that suffering is always punishment for sin. Job insists he is innocent and demands an answer from God. In chapters 38–41, God speaks "out of the storm," not explaining Job's suffering but revealing His power and wisdom in creation. Job humbles himself (42:1–6). God says the friends were wrong and Job spoke rightly (42:7), and He restores Job (42:10–17). Key lesson: suffering is not always punishment, and God is trustworthy even when unexplained.
- **Psalms** is a collection of 150 songs and prayers, written over about 1,000 years (Moses to after the exile), divided into five "books" (1–41, 42–72, 73–89, 90–106, 107–150), each ending with a short praise (a "doxology"). Main types: *praise* (Ps 100, 150), *thanksgiving* (Ps 107), *lament*, or honest complaint/sadness (Ps 13, 42, 88), *repentance* (Ps 51), *trust* (Ps 23, 46), *wisdom* (Ps 1, 119) and *royal/messianic* psalms about the king (Ps 2, 110). The laments are important: they teach kids they can bring sadness and anger to God.
- **Proverbs** contains short sayings about everyday life. Proverbs are general principles, not guaranteed promises (e.g., 22:6 describes how things usually go, not a contract). The foundation is "the fear of the LORD" (1:7), meaning deep reverence, awe and trust that leads to obedience, not terror.
- **Ecclesiastes** is honest about life's frustrations. The key word, *hevel* (translated "meaningless" in the NIV, "vanity" in the KJV), literally means "vapor" or "breath," something real but fleeting that can't be grasped. The phrase "under the sun" (used about 29 times) means "life seen only from an earthly view, without God." The conclusion is to enjoy God's gifts, remember your Creator, and fear God (12:1, 13–14).
- **Song of Songs** is love poetry celebrating romantic love between a husband and wife. Christians have read it in two complementary ways: (1) a celebration of God's good gift of married love, and (2) a picture of God's love for His people / Christ's love for the church. For children, emphasize that God made love, that marriage is His good idea, and that His love for us is stronger than anything.

Key truths to emphasize

1. **We can talk to God about anything.** The Psalms include happy, sad, angry and scared prayers.
2. **God is worthy of praise** all the time (Psalm 150; Job 1:21).
3. **Wisdom starts with God** (Proverbs 1:7). Smart isn't the same as wise.
4. **God can be trusted even when we don't understand** (Job; Proverbs 3:5).
5. **Life finds its meaning in God** (Ecclesiastes 12:13).
6. **God's love is strong and faithful** (Song of Songs 8:6–7; Psalm 136: "His love endures forever," 26 times!).
7. **God's Word guides us** like a lamp in the dark (Psalm 119:105).

Timeline and map notes

- These books don't follow a timeline, but you can place them:
  - **Job:** setting probably around the time of the patriarchs (about 2000 BC); land of **Uz** (likely east of Israel, toward Edom/Arabia).
  - **Psalms:** from Moses (about 1400 BC) through David (1000 BC) to after the exile (about 500 BC). Most were written for worship in Jerusalem.
  - **Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs:** connected with Solomon (970–930 BC), in Jerusalem. (Remember him from Phase 4!)
- Show kids on last month's timeline where David and Solomon were, and draw a harp and a lamp there.
- A simple illustration: an ancient oil lamp gave only enough light for the next step or two, not the whole road. That's what Psalm 119:105 means: God's Word shows us the next step.

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
Job's children die (Job 1:18–19)	"Job lost almost everything, even people he loved. He was very, very sad. But he still trusted God."	"A great wind knocked down the house and Job's children died. Job was heartbroken, but he still worshiped God."	Read 1:13–22. Discuss grief and trust.	Discuss the problem of evil (see Big Questions). Be sensitive: some teens have lost loved ones.
Satan in Job	"There is an enemy called Satan, but God is much stronger and is always in charge."	"Satan accused Job. God set limits on what Satan could do (1:12; 2:6)."	Discuss that Satan is real but limited and under God's authority.	Discuss the heavenly court scene as a window into spiritual reality; avoid speculation.

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
Sad and angry Psalms	"We can tell God when we're sad."	"Some psalms are sad. God wants us to be honest."	Read Psalm 13: complaint → trust → praise.	Discuss imprecatory psalms (e.g., 137:9, 109) as honest cries for justice that leave vengeance to God (Romans 12:19).
Song of Songs	"God made moms and dads love each other." Don't read the text aloud.	"A love song about a husband and wife. God made marriage." Read only 8:6–7.	Explain it's romantic poetry for married love. Read 2:15; 8:6–7.	Discuss God's design for love, sexuality within marriage, waiting (2:7, "Do not arouse or awaken love until it so desires"), and Christ's love for the church. Consider a same-gender small-group setting.
Ecclesiastes' "meaningless"	Skip the word; say "Only God makes things last."	"Without God, things don't last. With God, life matters!"	Discuss "under the sun."	Discuss nihilism vs. Christian hope; link to 1 Corinthians 15:58.
Grief / loss (any week)	Be gentle; let kids share.	Pray for those who are hurting.	Let them share if they want.	Offer a follow-up with a pastor or parent if a teen shares serious grief or depression.

> **Care note:** Job and the lament Psalms may stir up feelings for kids who have lost a parent, grandparent or pet, or whose families are going through hard times. Watch faces, keep tissues handy, and follow up with parents if a child seems distressed. If a child shares something that suggests they are unsafe, follow your church's child-safety reporting procedures.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

- **"Why do bad things happen to good people?"** We don't always know why. The world is broken because of sin, and there is an enemy who wants to hurt us. But Job shows that God is still good, still in control, and still with us. In the end, God will make everything right. Jesus Himself suffered, so He knows how we feel.
- **"Did God make bad things happen to Job?"** God allowed Satan to test Job, but He set limits (Job 1:12; 2:6). Satan caused the harm. God was still in charge, and He brought good out of it.
- **"Why is the P in Psalms silent?"** The word comes from Greek *psalmos*, meaning a song played on a stringed instrument. In Greek, the P was pronounced, but in English we dropped the sound and kept the letter.
- **"Did David really write the Psalms?"** He wrote many of them (about 73 have his name). Others were written by other worship leaders.
- **"Do proverbs always come true?"** They are wise guidelines about how life usually works when we follow God's way. They aren't magic promises, but they're always wise.
- **"Why does Ecclesiastes say everything is meaningless?"** The Teacher is showing what life is like *without* God: like trying to catch a puff of air. At the end he says that what really matters is loving and obeying God.

- **"Why is a love song in the Bible?"** God invented love! He made marriage, and He's happy when husbands and wives love each other. It also helps us see how much God loves us.

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
1	Job 1:1–3, 13–22; 2:11–13; 38:1–7; 42:10–17	When Life Hurts, God Is Still Good	We can trust God even when we don't understand.	SharefaithKids "Job"; BibleJourneyTV "Job"; BibleProject "Overview: Job"	Storm and Stars Freeze	"Where Were You?" star chart
2	Psalms 23; 100; 150; 119:105	God's Songbook	We can talk and sing to God about everything.	SharefaithKids "Psalm 23"; BibleJourneyTV "David the shepherd"; BibleProject "Overview: Psalms"	Shepherd and Sheep Tag	Psalm 150 instruments
3	Proverbs 1:7; 3:5–6; 6:6–8; 15:1; 17:17	Wise Choices	Wisdom starts with trusting and obeying God.	SharefaithKids "Wisdom" / "Proverbs"; BibleJourneyTV "Solomon's wisdom"; BibleProject "Overview: Proverbs"	Wise or Foolish Four Corners	Ant Hill wisdom craft
4	Ecclesiastes 3:1–8, 11; 4:9–12; 12:1, 13; Song of Songs 8:6–7	What Really Matters & God's Strong Love	Only God makes life last; God's love is stronger than anything.	SharefaithKids "God's love"; BibleJourneyTV "Solomon"; BibleProject "Overview: Ecclesiastes" & "Overview: Song of Songs"	A Time for Everything Charades	Three-Strand Cord bracelet
5 (optional)	Psalm 150	Praise Party! (Review & Fun Sunday)	Celebrate 22 books and three full sections!	Rewatch favorite	Harp Hot Potato + Poetry Bible Bowl	Praise parade & badges

---

Weekly Lessons

Week 1: When Life Hurts, God Is Still Good

Scripture: Job 1:1–3, 13–22; 2:7–13; 19:25; 38:1–7; 42:1–6, 10–17

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Job trusted God even when he lost almost everything, that God is great and wise beyond our understanding, and that we can trust Him when life hurts.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* A piece of embroidery or cross-stitch (or a woven potholder), turned to the messy back side first.

1. Show the back side: tangled, knotted threads. "What do you think this is? Does it look like a mess?"
2. Turn it over to reveal the beautiful picture.
3. Say: "Sometimes our lives look like the messy side. We can't see what God is doing. But God sees the whole picture. Today we'll meet a man named Job who learned to trust God even when everything looked like a mess."

📖 **Story script**

> In the land of Uz lived a man named **Job** (say "JOHB"). Job loved God and always tried to do what was right. God had blessed him with seven sons and three daughters, and thousands of sheep, camels, oxen and donkeys. He was the greatest man in all the East!
>
> One day, Satan, God's enemy, came before God. God said, "Have you noticed My servant Job? There's no one on earth like him." Satan sneered, "Of course Job loves You. You give him everything! Take it away, and he'll turn against You." God said, "You may test him, but you may not touch Job himself."
>
> Then terrible news came, one messenger after another. "Robbers stole your oxen and donkeys!" "Fire fell and burned up your sheep!" "Raiders took your camels!" And the worst news: "A great wind knocked down the house where your children were, and they all died."
>
> Job was so sad that he tore his robe and fell to the ground. But then he did something amazing: he **worshiped**. He said, "**The LORD gave, and the LORD has taken away. May the name of the LORD be praised.**"
>
> Then Job got sick with painful sores all over his body. Three friends came to visit. At first they were good friends: they sat with him quietly for seven days. But then they started talking: "Job, you must have done something really bad for this to happen!" But that wasn't true.
>
> Job was hurting, and he asked God lots of hard questions: "Why, God? Why is this happening?" Even then, Job said, "**I know that my Redeemer lives!**"
>
> Finally, God answered Job from a big storm. But God didn't explain *why*. Instead, God asked Job questions: "Where were you when I made the earth? Have you ever told the sun to rise in the morning? Can you count the stars? Do you feed the lions? Do you tell the eagle where to fly?"
>
> Job realized: "God, You are so great and so wise! You know things I could never understand. I trust You." God told Job's friends they had been wrong. Then God blessed Job again with twice as many animals as before, and seven more sons and three more daughters. Job lived a long, happy life.

> When life hurts, we might not know why. But we can always know **Who**: God, who is great, who is good, and who loves us. Our Redeemer, Jesus, lives!

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on two things: Job was sad, and Job still trusted God. Teach a simple response: when something sad happens, we can say, "I trust You, God." Use a stuffed sheep and camel to show what Job had.
- **Explorers:** Act out God's questions from Job 38–39. Kids take turns asking "Can you...?" questions about nature ("Can you make it snow?"). Answer together: "No, but God can!"
- **Trailblazers:** Discuss why Job's friends were wrong (they assumed all suffering is punishment). Compare John 9:1–3 (the man born blind).
- **Ambassadors:** Read Job 42:7. God says Job spoke rightly, even though Job complained loudly. What does that teach about honesty with God? Discuss how to be a good friend to someone who is suffering (Job 2:13: just be there).

💬 **Discussion questions**

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Was Job happy or sad when bad things happened? (Sad) 2) Did Job still love God? (Yes!) 3) What can you say to God when you're sad? ("I trust You, God.")
- *Explorers:* 1) What did Job say after losing everything? 2) What did Job's friends get wrong? 3) What questions did God ask Job?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why do you think God didn't tell Job *why* he suffered? 2) Is it okay to ask God "why"? 3) How can you be a good friend to someone who's going through something hard?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Satan claimed Job only loved God for His gifts. Do you love God for who He is or for what He gives? 2) What's the difference between honest questions and turning away from God? 3) How does Jesus' suffering help us trust God in ours?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Job" / "the story of Job" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Job | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Job" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Job | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors (Explorers with pauses) | Likely title: "Overview: Job" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Job |

Follow-up questions: 1) What did the video say about why Job suffered? 2) What did God show Job when He spoke from the storm?

> Preview every video first. Searching "Job" may bring up unrelated results ("job" as work), so look for the Bible story titles.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Storm and Stars Freeze* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *"Where Were You?" Star Chart* (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** J-O-B (the shortest book name in the Bible!). Remember: it's "JOHB." Start the memory verse: "Your word is a lamp for my feet..."

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> God, sometimes life is hard and I don't understand. Thank You that You are great and good. Help me trust You like Job did. Thank You that Jesus, my Redeemer, lives! Amen.

Week 2: God's Songbook

Scripture: Psalm 23; Psalm 100; Psalm 150; Psalm 13 (optional for older); Psalm 119:105

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Psalms is the Bible's songbook, that David the shepherd wrote many psalms, and that we can talk and sing to God about everything.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* A shoebox "feelings box" with four emoji faces taped on the sides (happy, sad, scared, sorry), a music player or instrument.

1. Roll the box like a big die. Whatever face lands on top, ask a child, "When do you feel this way?"
2. After a few rolls, say: "Did you know there are songs in the Bible for *every one* of these feelings? The book of Psalms is God's songbook!"
3. Play or sing a short worship song.

📖 **Story script**

> Do you remember David, the shepherd boy who fought Goliath and became king? Long before he was king, David spent many days and nights out in the fields taking care of his sheep. He found green grass for them to eat and quiet water for them to drink. When a lion or bear came, he protected them. When a sheep got lost, he went looking for it.
>
> Out in the fields, David played his harp and made up songs to God. One day he thought, "God takes care of me the way I take care of my sheep!" And he wrote a song:
>
> "**The LORD is my shepherd, I lack nothing.** He makes me lie down in green pastures, he leads me beside quiet waters... Even though I walk through the darkest valley, I will fear no evil, for you are with me."
>
> David wrote many songs. When he was happy, he wrote happy songs: "Shout for joy to the LORD, all the earth!" When he was scared and enemies were chasing him, he wrote songs asking God for help. When he did something wrong, he wrote a song telling God he was sorry and asking for a clean heart (Psalm 51). Sometimes he even wrote sad songs: "How long, LORD? Will you forget me forever?" (Psalm 13). But even his sad songs usually end with trusting God: "But I trust in your unfailing love."
>
> Other people wrote psalms too: Moses, Solomon, and temple singers called the sons of Korah and Asaph. Altogether, there are **150 psalms**. God's people sang them in the temple, and Jesus sang

> them too!
>
> The very last psalm, Psalm 150, is a big praise party. "Praise God with trumpets! Praise Him with harps! Praise Him with tambourines and dancing! Praise Him with clashing cymbals!" And the very last verse says: "**Let everything that has breath praise the LORD!**"
>
> Do you have breath? *(Everyone breathe in and out!)* Then you can praise the LORD! Whether you're happy, sad, scared or sorry, you can always talk and sing to God. He's listening.

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Teach Psalm 23:1 with motions: "The LORD (point up) is my shepherd (hold a pretend staff), I lack nothing (shake head, hands out)." End with a noisy Psalm 150 praise parade with shakers.
- **Explorers:** Find Psalm 23, Psalm 117 (shortest) and Psalm 119 (longest) in their Bibles. Count the verses of each. Explain that in Psalms, each chapter is a whole song.
- **Trailblazers:** Teach parallelism. Read Psalm 119:105 and Psalm 19:1 and find how the second line repeats the first. Then read Psalm 13 and trace the movement: complaint (vv. 1–2) → request (vv. 3–4) → trust and praise (vv. 5–6).
- **Ambassadors:** Have them write their own short psalm (4–8 lines) following the lament pattern (complaint → request → trust → praise) about something real in their lives. Invite volunteers to read them aloud.

💬 **Discussion questions**

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Who is our shepherd? (God / Jesus) 2) What instrument did David play? (Harp) 3) Can you praise God? (Yes! Everything that has breath!)
- *Explorers:* 1) How many psalms are there? (150) 2) How is God like a shepherd? 3) What feeling would you write a song to God about?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why do you think God put sad songs in the Bible? 2) What's the "darkest valley" in Psalm 23, and how does God help there? 3) What does Psalm 119:105 mean when it calls God's Word a lamp?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Jesus prayed Psalm 22:1 on the cross. Read Psalm 22. What else in it sounds like the crucifixion? 2) Why might honest lament be a sign of faith rather than lack of faith? 3) How could you use the Psalms in your own prayer life this week?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Psalm 23" / "The Lord is my shepherd" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Psalm+23 | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "David the shepherd" / "Psalms" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Psalms | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | Likely title: "Overview: Psalms" (also called "Book of Psalms"); bonus: their "Psalms" series | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Psalms |

Follow-up questions: 1) What kinds of feelings show up in the Psalms? 2) How is Jesus connected to the Psalms?

> Preview every video first.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Shepherd and Sheep Tag* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Psalm 150 Instruments* (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** P-S-A-L-M-S. Watch out for the silent P! Practice the whole memory verse with motions: "Your word" (open hands like a book) "is a lamp" (hold up a pretend lamp) "for my feet" (point to feet) "a light" (wiggle fingers like rays) "on my path" (hand moves forward like a road).

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> Dear Jesus, You are my Good Shepherd. Thank You that I can talk to You when I'm happy, sad, scared or sorry. I want to praise You with everything I have! Amen.

Week 3: Wise Choices

Scripture: Proverbs 1:7; 3:5–6; 4:23; 6:6–8; 13:20; 15:1; 17:17; also 1 Kings 3:9, 12 and 4:29–34 (review)

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Proverbs teaches us how to make wise choices, and that true wisdom starts with trusting and obeying God.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* Two cups of water and two plants/flowers (or pictures), one bag of trail mix with a few "yucky" items mixed in (e.g., paper clips, clearly not edible, in a sealed bag for demo only).

1. Say: "I have a snack. It's mostly yummy... but there are a few things in here that would hurt you. Would you eat it without looking?" (No!)
2. "Making choices is like picking through this bag. We need wisdom to know what's good and what's harmful."
3. "Smart means you know a lot. **Wise** means you know what's right and you *do* it. Today we'll learn about the book of wise choices: Proverbs."

📖 **Story script**

> Remember King Solomon? When God said, "Ask for anything," Solomon asked for wisdom. God made Solomon the wisest man in the world. People came from far away just to hear him. The Bible says Solomon spoke 3,000 proverbs!
>
> A **proverb** is a short, wise saying that's easy to remember. Many of Solomon's proverbs, and some from other wise people, are collected in the book of **Proverbs**. It's like a dad giving his kids advice: "My son, listen to me. This is how to live a good life."

> The very first big lesson is this: "**The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge.**" That doesn't mean being scared of God like a monster. It means knowing how great and holy God is, loving Him, trusting Him, and wanting to obey Him. That's where wisdom starts!
>
> Proverbs has wise words about lots of things:
>
> About **trusting God**: "Trust in the LORD with all your heart and lean not on your own understanding." That means: trust God more than your own ideas.
>
> About **working hard**: "Go to the ant, you sluggard!" A sluggard is a lazy person. Ants don't have a boss telling them what to do, but they work hard all summer gathering food for winter. Be like the ant!
>
> About **words**: "A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger." If someone yells at you and you yell back, it gets worse. But if you answer gently, the anger can calm down.
>
> About **friends**: "Walk with the wise and become wise." The friends you spend time with will shape who you become. And "A friend loves at all times."
>
> Proverbs also tells us about two ladies who call out to everyone passing by. One is **Lady Wisdom**. She says, "Come to me! Learn my ways and live!" The other is **Lady Folly** (foolishness). She says, "Come to me! Do whatever you want!" But her way leads to trouble. Every day, we choose whose voice to follow.
>
> The Bible says that Jesus is the true wisdom of God. When we follow Jesus, we're following the wisest way there is!

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Play "Wise or Not?" with thumbs up/down: "Sharing your toys?" 👍 "Hitting your brother?" 👎 "Saying sorry?" 👍 Show a real ant farm or ant pictures.
- **Explorers:** Give each child a Proverbs "fortune cookie" (a folded paper with one proverb). They read it and explain it in their own words.
- **Trailblazers:** Discuss Proverbs 13:20 and peer pressure. Have them identify one proverb about words, one about friends, one about work and one about money (e.g., 22:7 or 11:24–25).
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Proverbs as principles vs. promises (compare 26:4 and 26:5, which seem to say opposite things; wisdom means knowing which applies when). Introduce the idea of starting a "Proverb a day" habit (31 chapters).

💬 **Discussion questions**

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Who was the wisest king? (Solomon) 2) What little bug works hard? (The ant) 3) Is it wise to obey God? (Yes!)
- *Explorers:* 1) What's the difference between "smart" and "wise"? 2) What does "a gentle answer turns away wrath" mean? Give an example. 3) Why does it matter who your friends are?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) What does "the fear of the LORD" mean? 2) What does "lean not on your own understanding" look like in a real decision? 3) Where do you hear "Lady Folly's" voice in your life (ads, shows, friends)?

- *Ambassadors:* 1) Solomon knew all this wisdom and still made foolish choices (1 Kings 11). What does that teach us? 2) How does Jesus fulfill or embody Proverbs 8's picture of Wisdom? 3) Choose one proverb to practice all week. How will you do it?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "wisdom" / "Proverbs" / "Solomon asks for wisdom" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Proverbs | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Solomon's wisdom" / "Solomon" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Solomon | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | Likely title: "Overview: Proverbs"; bonus: "Wisdom Series" or "The Book of Proverbs" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Proverbs |

Follow-up questions: 1) What is wisdom? 2) Who are the two "ladies" in Proverbs, and what do they want?

> Preview every video first.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Wise or Foolish Four Corners* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Ant Hill Wisdom craft* (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** P-R-O-V-E-R-B-S (Prov-erbs). Notice: Psalms and Proverbs both start with P! Little Lambs: "P, P, Psalms and Proverbs!" Trailblazers and Ambassadors: learn the bonus verse, Proverbs 3:5.

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> God, please make me wise. Help me trust You with all my heart, choose good friends, use kind words, and work hard. Thank You that Jesus shows me the wise way. Amen.

Week 4: What Really Matters & God's Strong Love

Scripture: Ecclesiastes 1:2; 3:1–8, 11; 4:9–12; 12:1, 13; Song of Songs 2:15; 8:6–7

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Ecclesiastes teaches that only God gives life real meaning, and that Song of Songs celebrates love as God's good gift, pointing to God's love that is stronger than anything.

Opening hook / object lesson *Supplies:* A bottle of bubbles, a small mirror (or a cold window), and a rope made of three strands.

1. Blow bubbles. Let kids try to catch them. "What happens when you catch a bubble?" (It pops!)
2. Breathe on a mirror: see the fog? Watch it disappear. "The book of Ecclesiastes says that lots of things in life are like this: like a puff of breath. Here for a moment, then gone."
3. Hold up the three-strand rope. "But some things are strong and last. Let's find out what."

📖 Story script

> King Solomon was the richest, wisest king who ever lived. When he got older, he did an experiment. He wanted to find out: *What makes life really matter?*
>
> First he tried **learning**. He studied everything! But he said, "The more I know, the more I realize how much I don't know."
>
> Then he tried **fun**: parties, music, laughing. But when the party was over, he felt empty.
>
> Then he tried **building and getting stuff**: huge houses, gardens, pools, gold and silver, more than anyone. But he thought, "When I die, someone else will get all this."
>
> Then he tried **hard work**. But he said, "I work and work, and then I'm gone, and the work doesn't last forever either."
>
> He said, "**Meaningless! Meaningless!**" The word he used means a puff of breath or a bubble. Everything "under the sun," everything in life without God, is like trying to catch a bubble. Pop!
>
> But Solomon also noticed some beautiful things. He said, "**There is a time for everything**: a time to be born and a time to die, a time to cry and a time to laugh, a time to be sad and a time to dance." God made everything beautiful in its time. And God put a longing for *forever* in our hearts, because we were made for Him.
>
> He noticed that friends matter: "Two are better than one. If one falls down, the other can help him up." And "a cord of three strands is not quickly broken." When you have God with you and your friends, you're strong together.
>
> At the end of his experiment, Solomon wrote his answer. Are you ready? "**Remember your Creator in the days of your youth.**" That means while you're young, like you! And: "**Fear God and keep his commandments.**" That's what really matters. Knowing God makes life full of meaning!
>
> Solomon also wrote a song called the **Song of Songs**, which means "the best song." It's a love song about a bride and a groom who love each other very much. It reminds us that God made love and marriage, and it's good. The song says, "**Love is as strong as death. Many waters cannot put out love.**" You can't stop real love with a whole ocean!
>
> And do you know whose love is the strongest of all? **Jesus'** love. His love was stronger than death, because He died for us and rose again! Nothing can wash away His love for you.

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Blow bubbles: "Toys are fun, but they don't last forever. God's love lasts forever!" Show a heart and a "squirt bottle" of water: "Water can't wash away God's love!" Keep Song of Songs to "God made moms and dads to love each other, and God loves us most of all."
- **Explorers:** Make a "time for everything" list: kids add their own pairs ("a time to play and a time to clean up," "a time for school and a time for summer").

- **Trailblazers:** Discuss the phrase "under the sun." What does life look like if there's no God? How does knowing God change that? Do the three-strand rope demonstration: try to break one strand, then three twisted together.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Ecclesiastes and culture: where do teens look for meaning (achievement, popularity, followers, pleasure)? For Song of Songs, discuss God's good design for love and marriage, and the repeated warning, "Do not arouse or awaken love until it so desires" (2:7; 3:5; 8:4). Consider splitting into small groups led by mature leaders.

💬 **Discussion questions**

- *Little Lambs:* 1) What happens to a bubble? (It pops!) 2) Whose love lasts forever? (God's / Jesus') 3) Who made love? (God)
- *Explorers:* 1) What did Solomon try to make life matter? 2) What's something that's "a time to..." for you? 3) What did Solomon say really matters at the end?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why do things like money and fun leave people feeling empty? 2) What does "God set eternity in the human heart" (3:11) mean? 3) Who are the "strands" in your cord of three?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Can someone have everything and still feel empty? Why? 2) How does the resurrection of Jesus answer the "meaningless" problem (1 Corinthians 15:58)? 3) What does Song of Songs teach about how God sees love and marriage? How is this different from what culture says?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "God's love" / "a time for everything" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=God%27s+love | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Solomon" / "Ecclesiastes" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Ecclesiastes | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | Likely titles: "Overview: Ecclesiastes" and "Overview: Song of Songs" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Ecclesiastes |

Follow-up questions: 1) What does "meaningless" (hevel) really mean? 2) What does the Bible say is the strongest love?

> Preview every video first, especially "Overview: Song of Songs," which discusses romance and marriage tastefully but is best for Ambassadors (and Trailblazers at your discretion). Use only the Ecclesiastes video for younger groups.

🎮 **Game of the week:** *A Time for Everything Charades* (see Games)

✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Three-Strand Cord Bracelet* (see Activities & Crafts)

🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** E-C-C-L-E-S-I-A-S-T-E-S. Clap it: Ec-cle-si-as-tes (5 claps). And S-O-N-G O-F S-O-N-G-S. Say all 5 Poetry books, then all 22 books!

🙏 **Closing prayer**

> God, toys and stuff don't last, but You last forever. Help me remember You while I'm young. Thank You for Your love that is stronger than anything. In Jesus' name, amen.

Week 5 (optional): Praise Party! (Review & Fun Sunday)

Based on Psalm 150: "Let everything that has breath praise the LORD." Celebrate three complete sections (Law, History, Poetry)! Full plan under **End-of-Phase Review & Celebration**.

Book Memory Song & Motions

🎵 "Twenty-Two Books" (tune: *Jesus Loves Me*)

This song is cumulative: all 22 books from Genesis to Song of Songs. The new Poetry books are the chorus!

Verse 1: The Law (books 1–5)

> Genesis and Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers too, Deuteronomy makes five, These are Law books, give me five! *(high five!)*

Verse 2: History, part 1 (books 6–14)

> Joshua, Judges, Ruth, and then Samuel and Samuel, Kings and Kings and Chronicles, Chronicles, and on we go!

(Hold up 1 finger, then 2 fingers for the "First" and "Second" books.)

Verse 3: History, part 2 (books 15–17)

> Ezra, Nehemiah too, Esther: History is through! Twelve books tell what God has done, Now the poetry's begun!

Chorus: Poetry (books 18–22), NEW! *(tune of "Yes, Jesus loves me...")*

> Job and Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs makes five: Twenty-two books we know!

Shouts: "FIVE BOOKS OF LAW! TWELVE BOOKS OF HISTORY! FIVE BOOKS OF POETRY!" *(5 fingers, clap 12 times, 5 fingers)* **Big finish:** "TWENTY-TWO! WE KNOW TWENTY-TWO!"

> **Singing tip:** "Ecclesiastes" fits the melody of "Yes, Jesus loves me" exactly when you sing it "Ec-cle-si-as-tes" (5 notes). Practice that line slowly first!

Bonus "Lamp" verse (a sing-along paraphrase of the memory verse, same tune):

> Your word is a lamp for my feet, A light upon my path so sweet. When it's dark I will not fear, For Your Word shows me the way here.

(Always finish by saying the real verse word for word: Psalm 119:105.)

Hand motions for each book

Book	Motion
Genesis	Sunrise hands: palms together like a closed book, open them, sweep arms up like the sun rising
Exodus	Exit walk: walk two fingers across your palm and out the "door"
Leviticus	Holy hands: fold hands to pray, then raise them high
Numbers	Count 1-2-3-4 on fingers, then zig-zag your hand (wandering)
Deuteronomy	Two fingers up ("second"), tap head ("remember"), hand on heart
Joshua	March in place with fist-trumpet at mouth ("Walls fall down!")
Judges	Pound a gavel on your palm, then draw a circle (the cycle)
Ruth	Scoop up pretend grain, then hug yourself (loyal love)
1 & 2 Samuel	1/2 fingers, cup your ear
1 & 2 Kings	1/2 fingers, crown on head
1 & 2 Chronicles	1/2 fingers, unroll a scroll
Ezra	Stack fists (bricks)
Nehemiah	Hammer and shield
Esther	Crown, then "speak up" hands
Job	Open hands up, then fold over heart (trust)
Psalms	Strum a harp
Proverbs	Tap your head (think wise!)
Ecclesiastes	Blow a puff into your hand, then point up
Song of Songs	Make a heart with your hands

📣 Section Shout

Leader: "In the beginning there's the..." Kids: "**LAW!**" (5 fingers) Leader: "Then comes..." Kids: "**HISTORY!**" (clap 12) Leader: "In the middle, the heart of the Bible..." Kids: "**POETRY!**" (make a heart) Leader: "How many?" Kids: "**TWENTY-TWO!**"

Cumulative recall drill

1. **Lamp Light Line-Up:** Turn the lights down. The leader shines a flashlight on one child at a time; that child says the next book in order (Genesis → Song of Songs). Keep going around the circle until all 22 are said. Then start again faster.
2. **Section Sort:** Hand out 22 book cards. Kids run to three areas of the room labeled LAW, HISTORY and POETRY, then line up in order inside their section.
3. **Silent Song:** Do only the motions to the whole song while kids shout the book names.
4. **Missing Note:** The leader sings the song but hums one book; kids name the missing book.
5. **Countdown (Trailblazers/Ambassadors):** Say the 22 books backwards: Song of Songs → Genesis.

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Learn the chorus and motions for the five Poetry books. Celebrate when they can say "Job, Psalms, Proverbs" (the easier three). Ecclesiastes can simply be "Ecclesi-ASTES!" with a puff of air.
- **Explorers:** Aim for all 22 with the song. Use Section Sort to help them see the three shelves.
- **Trailblazers:** All 22 without the song; say how many books are in each section (5-12-5).
- **Ambassadors:** Lead the song for the younger groups; know one famous verse from each Poetry book.

Spelling & Reading

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letter recognition, first sounds) | Word | First letter | Sound it out | |---|---|---| | Job | J | "J" like jump (and J-O-B is only 3 letters, so try spelling it!) | | Psalms | P | Silent P! It sounds like "S" 🤫 | | Proverbs | P | "P" like popcorn 🍿 | | Song | S | "Sss" like a snake | | lamp | L | "L" like a lollipop | | sheep | S | "Sh" like "shh!" |

Activity: Little Lambs spell J-O-B with big letter cards, their first whole book name! Play "Silent P": the leader says words that start with P, and when they hear "Psalms," kids put a finger to their lips: "Shh!"

Explorers (book names)

1. Job (J-O-B)
2. Psalms (P-S-A-L-M-S)
3. Proverbs (P-R-O-V-E-R-B-S)

4. Ecclesiastes (E-C-C-L-E-S-I-A-S-T-E-S)
5. Song of Songs (S-O-N-G O-F S-O-N-G-S) Bonus: shepherd, harp, wisdom.

Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocab words)

- All 5 Poetry book names (and all 22 books)
- **psalm:** a song or prayer to God
- **proverb:** a short, wise saying
- **wisdom:** knowing what is right and good, and doing it
- **praise:** telling God how great He is
- **redeemer:** someone who rescues or buys back another person

Ambassadors (book names + harder vocab with definitions)

- All 22 book names in order, spelled correctly
- **parallelism:** the way Hebrew poetry repeats or contrasts ideas in pairs of lines
- **lament:** a prayer or song of sadness or complaint brought to God
- **reverence:** deep respect and awe (as in "the fear of the LORD")
- **sovereignty:** God's complete authority and control over everything
- **hevel:** Hebrew word in Ecclesiastes meaning "vapor" or "breath" (NIV "meaningless")
- **acrostic:** a poem where each section starts with the next letter of the alphabet (Psalm 119)
- **doxology:** a short burst of praise to God (the end of each of the 5 books of Psalms)

Syllable-clap method

- Job (1 clap) → J-O-B
- Psalms (1 clap) → P-S-A-L-M-S ("P is silent but still there!")
- Prov-erbs (2 claps) → P-R-O-V-E-R-B-S
- Ec-cle-si-as-tes (5 claps) → E-C-C-L-E-S-I-A-S-T-E-S
- Song of Songs (3 claps) → S-O-N-G / O-F / S-O-N-G-S
- Shep-herd (2 claps) → S-H-E-P-H-E-R-D
- Wis-dom (2 claps) → W-I-S-D-O-M

Ecclesiastes spelling trick: Break it into 3 chunks: **ECCLE** + **SIAS** + **TES**. Or think: "**E**ach **C**hild **C**an **L**earn **E**cclesiastes" for the first five letters E-C-C-L-E, then "SI-AS-TES." Note the double **C** near the start: "Ec-cle."

"Spell It Out" relay: Harp Strings Edition

1. Stretch a long string or yarn "harp string" across the room at kid height for each team, with clothespins on it.
2. At the far end, put letter cards in a pile for each team.
3. Leader calls a book ("Proverbs!"). Runners take turns grabbing the next letter and clipping it onto the string in order.
4. First team to spell it correctly "plays" their harp (everyone strums the air and sings "Praise the LORD!").

5. *Younger:* Spell JOB only, or use whole book-name cards to clip the 5 Poetry books in order. *Older:* Spell ECCLESIASTES (12 letters!) as the championship round.

Mini spelling bee word list

Word	Use it in a sentence
Job	Job trusted God even when he lost everything.
Psalms	The book of Psalms has 150 songs.
Proverbs	Proverbs teaches us how to make wise choices.
Ecclesiastes	Ecclesiastes says there is a time for everything.
Song of Songs	Song of Songs is a love poem in the Bible.
shepherd	The LORD is my shepherd.
harp	David played the harp for King Saul.
wisdom	Solomon asked God for wisdom.
praise	Let everything that has breath praise the LORD.
lamp	God's Word is a lamp for my feet.
redeemer	Job said, "I know that my redeemer lives."
meaningless	Without God, life feels meaningless.

Read-aloud practice passage

Readers take turns, one line each (Psalm 23, NIV):

> The LORD is my shepherd, I lack nothing. He makes me lie down in green pastures, he leads me beside quiet waters, he refreshes my soul. He guides me along the right paths for his name's sake. Even though I walk through the darkest valley, I will fear no evil, for you are with me; your rod and your staff, they comfort me. You prepare a table before me in the presence of my enemies. You anoint my head with oil; my cup overflows. Surely your goodness and love will follow me all the days of my life, and I will dwell in the house of the LORD forever.

Little Lambs: echo each line after the reader. *Explorers:* read a line each. *Trailblazers & Ambassadors:* read it in two groups, like a choir, and notice the parallel lines.

Word Trivia

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. Who is "my shepherd" in Psalm 23?
2. What instrument did David play?

3. Which tiny bug does Proverbs say works hard?
4. Who was the wisest king?
5. How many books of Poetry are there?
6. **True or False:** Job stopped loving God when bad things happened.
7. **Fill in the blank:** "Your word is a _____ for my feet."
8. **Fill in the blank:** "Let everything that has _____ praise the LORD."
9. Which book is God's songbook?
10. **True or False:** God made love and marriage.
11. Which Poetry book name has only 3 letters?
12. What is silent in the word "Psalms"?

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

13. How many psalms are in the book of Psalms?
14. **Who said it?** "The LORD gave and the LORD has taken away; may the name of the LORD be praised."
15. **Which book?** "There is a time for everything."
16. **Which book?** "Trust in the LORD with all your heart."
17. How many days did Job's friends sit with him without saying anything?
18. What is the shortest psalm (and shortest chapter in the Bible)?
19. What is the longest psalm (and longest chapter in the Bible)?
20. **Fill in the blank:** "A gentle answer turns away _____."
21. **True or False:** David wrote all 150 psalms.
22. How did God speak to Job at the end of the book?
23. **Which book?** "Many waters cannot quench love."
24. How many chapters does Proverbs have?
25. **Fill in the blank:** "Remember your _____ in the days of your youth."

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

26. **Who said it?** "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (two answers)
27. Name Job's three friends.
28. **Fill in the blank:** "The fear of the LORD is the _____ of knowledge." (Proverbs 1:7)
29. What does the Hebrew word *hevel* (NIV "meaningless") literally mean?
30. **Who said it?** "Where were you when I laid the earth's foundation?"
31. In what land did Job live?
32. Which psalm is credited to Moses?
33. How many proverbs did Solomon speak according to 1 Kings 4:32?
34. What is "parallelism" in Hebrew poetry?
35. **True or False:** Proverbs are guaranteed promises that always happen exactly as written.
36. Psalm 119 is an acrostic with 22 sections. What is each section based on?
37. Into how many "books" (smaller collections) is the book of Psalms divided?
38. Who wrote Proverbs 31 (according to verse 1)?
39. **Who said it?** "I know that my redeemer lives, and that in the end he will stand on the earth."

Answer Key

1. The LORD (God) 2. The harp (lyre) 3. The ant (Proverbs 6:6) 4. Solomon 5. Five 6. False 7. lamp 8. breath (Psalm 150:6) 9. Psalms 10. True 11. Job 12. The P
2. 150 14. Job (1:21) 15. Ecclesiastes (3:1) 16. Proverbs (3:5) 17. Seven days and seven nights (2:13) 18. Psalm 117 (2 verses) 19. Psalm 119 (176 verses) 20. wrath (anger) (15:1) 21. False. David wrote about 73; others were by Asaph, the sons of Korah, Solomon, Moses and unnamed writers. 22. Out of a storm / whirlwind (38:1) 23. Song of Songs (8:7) 24. 31 25. Creator (Ecclesiastes 12:1)
3. David wrote it (Psalm 22:1), and Jesus prayed it on the cross (Matthew 27:46) 27. Eliphaz, Bildad and Zophar 28. beginning 29. Vapor, breath or mist 30. God (Job 38:4) 31. Uz (Job 1:1) 32. Psalm 90 33. 3,000 34. Pairs of lines that repeat, build on, or contrast the same idea 35. False. They are wise principles about how life generally works. 36. The 22 letters of the Hebrew alphabet (each section's verses start with the same letter) 37. Five (1–41, 42–72, 73–89, 90–106, 107–150) 38. King Lemuel (taught by his mother) 39. Job (19:25)

Games

> More game ideas and general rules: see `../00-start-here/game-library.md`.

🎮 1. Storm and Stars Freeze (Week 1)

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Music (or a drum), a flashlight, picture cards of animals and nature from Job 38–39 (lion, eagle, horse, ostrich, mountain goat, stars, snow, rain, sea)
- **Setup:** Open space. Dim the lights a little for "storm" mood if appropriate (keep it fun, not scary).
- **How to play:** Kids move around the room while music plays (the "storm"). When it stops, everyone freezes. The leader flashes a picture card and asks, "Can YOU make a ___?" ("Can you tell the eagle where to fly?") Everyone shouts, "No, but GOD can!" Then the leader asks one book-order question to a frozen child ("What comes after Esther?"). If the child is right, they become the next "storm leader."
- **How to win:** Everyone wins when all 22 books have been named in order through the rounds.
- **Adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Just the "Can you...?" part with animal pictures and motions (roar like a lion, fly like an eagle). *Older:* Require them to say the section the book is in, too.
- **Learning goal:** God's greatness from Job 38–39; book order review.

🎮 2. Shepherd and Sheep Tag (Week 2)

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers, Trailblazers
- **Supplies:** A "shepherd's staff" (pool noodle or cardboard tube), a "sheepfold" area marked with tape or cones, one or two "wolf" headbands
- **Setup:** Mark a safe sheepfold at one end. One teacher or older kid is the Shepherd; one or two kids are Wolves.

- **How to play:** Sheep (most kids) "graze" in the open field. When the Shepherd calls, "The LORD is my shepherd!", sheep run toward the sheepfold. Wolves try to tag sheep before they get there. The Shepherd can "protect" any sheep by touching them with the staff (they're safe). Tagged sheep must say one Poetry book (or the next book after one the Wolf names) to return to the flock, because "He restores my soul!"
- **How to win:** No one is ever out; the goal is to get the whole flock home. Switch roles often.
- **Adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Wolves walk on tiptoe; teachers help. *Ambassadors:* Act as shepherds and help the youngest sheep.
- **Learning goal:** Psalm 23; Jesus as the Good Shepherd; book review.

🎮 3. Wise or Foolish Four Corners (Week 3)

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors (Little Lambs with two corners: "Wise" and "Not Wise")
- **Supplies:** Four signs: "WISE 👍," "FOOLISH 👎," "PROVERBS SAYS..." and "WHICH BOOK?"
- **How to play:** Leader reads a situation or statement. Kids run to the corner they think fits:
  - Situations ("Your friend yells at you. You answer gently.") → WISE or FOOLISH
  - "Proverbs says... go to the ___!" → kids at the PROVERBS SAYS corner shout the answer
  - "Which book says 'The LORD is my shepherd'?" → kids at WHICH BOOK? shout the answer
    The leader announces which corner was right for each question. Kids in the right corner get a point.
- **How to win:** Kids track their own points; the top three get to choose the next game.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Only use WISE and FOOLISH corners with very simple choices. *Older:* Use real proverbs and ask kids to explain.
- **Learning goal:** Applying Proverbs; matching verses to books.

🎮 4. Ant Relay (Week 3)

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** A bowl of dried beans, cotton balls or cereal ("food") at one end; an empty cup ("anthill") for each team at the other end; spoons
- **How to play:** Like the hard-working ant (Proverbs 6:6–8), each runner carries one "food" piece on a spoon to their anthill. Before dropping it in, they must say the next book of the Bible in order (team keeps going from Genesis).
- **How to win:** First team to collect 22 pieces (one for each book, in order) wins and shouts, "Go to the ant and be wise!"
- **Adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Carry with hands, not spoons; teacher says the book and they repeat. *Older:* Carry two pieces at once and say two books.
- **Learning goal:** Book order; Proverbs' lesson about hard work.

🎮 5. A Time for Everything Charades (Week 4)

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Cards with Ecclesiastes 3 pairs ("a time to cry / a time to laugh," "a time to plant / a time to pull up," "a time to be quiet / a time to speak," "a time to tear / a time to mend," "a time to dance") plus book-name cards for the 5 Poetry books

- **How to play:** One child acts out a card while their team guesses. If it's an Ecclesiastes pair, they act out both halves. If it's a book card, they use the book's hand motion and the team must guess the book.
- **How to win:** Points for each correct guess within 30 seconds.
- **Adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Teacher acts; kids guess "Cry! Laugh!" *Ambassadors:* Act out a famous verse from each Poetry book.
- **Learning goal:** Ecclesiastes 3; Poetry book motions.

🎮 6. Harp Hot Potato (any week / review)

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers
- **Supplies:** A toy instrument or homemade shaker (the "harp"), music
- **How to play:** Kids sit in a circle passing the "harp" while music plays. When the music stops, the child holding it says one book of the Bible (Little Lambs: any book or a Poetry book; Explorers: the next book in order). Then the whole class "plays" their pretend harps and sings the chorus of the book song.
- **How to win:** Everyone wins when the class gets through all 22 books.
- **Adaptations:** *Older:* The holder must say a verse or fact from the book they name.
- **Learning goal:** Book recall; joyful praise.

🎮 7. Lamp to My Feet Path (memory verse game)

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors
- **Supplies:** Flashlights, a blindfold, paper "stepping stones" each with one word of Psalm 119:105 (10–12 stones)
- **Setup:** Lay the stepping stones out in a winding path in a dimmed room.
- **How to play:** One child is blindfolded (or walks with eyes closed). A partner holds a flashlight and gives directions only by reading the words on the stones as they step on each one ("Your... word... is... a... lamp..."). The walker repeats each word. Swap roles.
- **How to win:** Teams that finish the path and can say the whole verse without help earn a "lamp" sticker.
- **Adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* No blindfold; just hop stone to stone saying the short verse with a teacher holding a flashlight.
- **Learning goal:** Memorizing Psalm 119:105 and understanding it (God's Word shows the next step).

Coloring Pages

> 🖍️ Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-06-printables.html`

Page 1 (Week 1): "Where Were You?"

- **Scene:** Job, a bearded man in simple clothes, sitting on the ground and looking up in wonder. Above him, a dramatic storm cloud opens to a starry sky. Around the edges: a lion, an eagle, a horse, an ostrich, a mountain goat and ocean waves (the animals and wonders God describes in Job 38–39).
- **Caption:** "I know that my redeemer lives." (Job 19:25)
- **Conversation prompts:** Which of God's creations in the picture is your favorite? How does looking at God's creation help us trust Him?

Page 2 (Week 2): "The LORD Is My Shepherd"

- **Scene:** Young David sitting on a rock playing his harp, with sheep lying in green grass and a quiet stream nearby. A shepherd's staff leans on the rock. Music notes float across the page with little words: happy, sad, sorry, thank You.
- **Caption:** "The LORD is my shepherd, I lack nothing." (Psalm 23:1)
- **Conversation prompts:** How does a shepherd take care of sheep? How does Jesus take care of you?

Page 3 (Week 2 bonus): "Praise Party!"

- **Scene:** Kids of different ages and backgrounds marching in a parade with trumpets, harps, tambourines, cymbals and ribbons, with big letters "PRAISE THE LORD!" across the top.
- **Caption:** "Let everything that has breath praise the LORD." (Psalm 150:6)
- **Conversation prompts:** What instrument would you play for God? What's one thing you want to praise God for?

Page 4 (Week 3): "Go to the Ant"

- **Scene:** A cheerful line of ants carrying crumbs into an anthill under a big sunflower. A boy and girl crouch down watching with a magnifying glass. A scroll at the bottom reads "WISDOM."
- **Caption:** "Trust in the LORD with all your heart." (Proverbs 3:5)
- **Conversation prompts:** What can we learn from ants? What's one wise choice you can make this week?

Page 5 (Week 4): "A Time for Everything"

- **Scene:** A big circle divided into four seasons (spring flowers, summer sun, fall leaves, winter snow), with a clock in the center. Around the outside, small pictures: a baby, a laughing face, a crying face, a seed being planted, kids dancing. At the bottom, a three-strand rope tied in a bow.
- **Caption:** "Remember your Creator in the days of your youth." (Ecclesiastes 12:1)
- **Conversation prompts:** What season is your favorite? What's "a time to ____" in your life right now?

Page 6 (Book-name page): "The Poetry Shelf"

- **Scene:** A bookshelf with five books standing up, each with a symbol on the spine: JOB (storm cloud), PSALMS (harp), PROVERBS (ant), ECCLESIASTES (puff of breath and clock), SONG OF SONGS (heart). A glowing oil lamp sits on top of the shelf. A banner reads "5 BOOKS OF POETRY • 22 OF 66."
- **Caption:** "Your word is a lamp for my feet, a light on my path." (Psalm 119:105)
- **Conversation prompts:** Can you read all five book names? Which Poetry book would you like to read at home first?

Activities & Crafts

✂️ 1. "Where Were You?" Star Chart (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Black or dark blue construction paper, star stickers or white/yellow gel pens, white crayon
- **Steps:**
  1. Read Job 38:4–7 and 38:31–33 (God asks about the stars and constellations).
  2. Kids cover their paper with as many stars as they can.
  3. At the bottom, write: "God made every star, and He takes care of me."
  4. Older kids can try to count their stars, then talk about how God "determines the number of the stars and calls them each by name" (Psalm 147:4).
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Stickers only; teacher writes. *Explorers:* Make the Big Dipper or Orion (Job 9:9 mentions Orion and the Pleiades!). *Trailblazers/Ambassadors:* Write one of God's questions from Job 38 and an answer of trust.
- **What it teaches:** God is great and wise; we can trust Him like Job.

✂️ 2. Psalm 150 Instruments (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** *Shakers:* paper plates, dried beans, stapler, ribbons. *Harps:* small sturdy boxes (tissue boxes or shoe box lids), rubber bands of different thicknesses. *Tambourines:* paper plates, jingle bells, pipe cleaners. Markers and stickers.
- **Steps:**
  1. Let each child choose an instrument to make.
  2. Write "Praise the LORD! Psalm 150" on it.
  3. Decorate it.
  4. End class with a Psalm 150 praise parade around the room or church.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Paper plate shakers (sealed well by a teacher). *Explorers:* Rubber-band harps; experiment with how thicker bands make lower sounds. *Older:* Write their own praise lines on the instrument.
- **Safety:** Seal beans well; supervise Little Lambs with small parts.
- **What it teaches:** Psalms is God's songbook; praise God with everything.

✂️ 3. Ant Hill Wisdom Craft (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Brown paper bags or brown paper cones (the anthill), black pom-poms or thumbprints with black ink pads, googly eyes (optional), pipe cleaners, small paper strips
- **Steps:**
  1. Make ants: three black pom-poms glued in a row (or three thumbprints), plus pipe cleaner or drawn legs.
  2. Write one proverb on each paper strip ("A friend loves at all times," "A gentle answer turns away wrath," "Go to the ant and be wise," "Trust in the LORD with all your heart").
  3. Glue each strip so the ant is "carrying" it into the anthill.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Thumbprint ants with one strip: "Be wise!" *Older:* Each child writes a proverb in their own words and how they'll apply it.
- **What it teaches:** Proverbs gives wise words for daily life; working hard and making good choices.

✂️ 4. Lamp for My Feet (memory verse craft, any week)

- **Supplies:** Air-dry clay (or paper cutouts of an oil lamp), a battery tea light, paint or markers, a paper footprint cutout for each child
- **Steps:**
  1. Shape a small ancient-style oil lamp from clay (a pinched bowl with a spout), or cut one from yellow paper.
  2. Place a battery tea light inside (or draw a flame).
  3. Trace the child's foot on paper and write Psalm 119:105 on the footprint.
  4. Display the lamp on the footprint.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Paper version; short verse. *Older:* Clay version; write the full verse and reference.
- **What it teaches:** God's Word guides our next step, like a lamp in the dark.

✂️ 5. Three-Strand Cord Bracelet (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Embroidery floss or yarn in three colors (gold for God, plus two other colors for "me" and "a friend"), tape
- **Steps:**
  1. Cut three strands about 12" long and knot them together at one end.
  2. Tape the knot to the table.
  3. Braid the three strands.
  4. Knot the end and tie it around a wrist.
  5. Talk about Ecclesiastes 4:12: "A cord of three strands is not quickly broken."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Teacher pre-braids or helps; kids pick colors. Try breaking one strand, then the braid! *Ambassadors:* Make extra bracelets and give them to a younger friend with a note of encouragement.
- **What it teaches:** Friendship with God at the center; we're stronger together.

✂️ 6. Seasons Wheel (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Two paper plates per child, a brad fastener, markers, scissors
- **Steps:**
  1. Divide the bottom plate into four sections and draw a pair from Ecclesiastes 3 in each ("a time to plant / a time to harvest," "a time to cry / a time to laugh," "a time to be quiet / a time to speak," "a time to mourn / a time to dance").
  2. Cut a quarter "window" out of the top plate and write on it "God makes everything beautiful in its time" (3:11).
  3. Attach the plates with a brad so the top plate turns.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Use four seasons (spring, summer, fall, winter) with stickers. *Older:* Add a personal "time" they're in right now.
- **What it teaches:** God is in charge of every season of life.

✂️ 7. My Own Psalm (Trailblazers & Ambassadors)

- **Supplies:** Nice paper or journals, pens, colored pencils
- **Steps:**
  1. Choose a type of psalm: praise, thanks, sorry, or a lament (sad song).
  2. Write 4–8 lines, using parallelism (say each idea twice in different words).
  3. Decorate the border.
  4. Optional: share with the group or give to a family member.
- **What it teaches:** We can talk honestly with God; how Hebrew poetry works.

Word Puzzles

Word scramble

#	Scrambled	Hint
1	BOJ	He trusted God when life hurt
2	SLAMPS	God's songbook
3	BERPROVS	Book of wise sayings
4	SEASILECCTES	"A time for everything"
5	GNOS	___ of Songs
6	DERPHEHS	"The LORD is my ___"
7	PRAH	David's instrument
8	MODWIS	What Solomon asked for
9	PALM	"Your word is a ___ for my feet"
10	THILG	"...a ___ on my path"
11	ESARIP	"Let everything that has breath ___ the LORD"

#	Scrambled	Hint
12	TAN	A small, hard-working bug
13	EERDEMER	"I know that my ___ lives"
14	VOLE	Stronger than death

Answer key: 1. JOB 2. PSALMS 3. PROVERBS 4. ECCLESIASTES 5. SONG 6. SHEPHERD 7. HARP 8. WISDOM 9. LAMP 10. LIGHT 11. PRAISE 12. ANT 13. REDEEMER 14. LOVE

Fill-in-the-blank story

Word bank: *Job, trust, Psalms, shepherd, 150, Proverbs, ant, Ecclesiastes, Creator, love, lamp, Jesus*

> The Poetry books sit in the middle of the Bible. First comes _____, a man who lost almost everything but still chose to _____ God. Next is _____, God's songbook with _____ songs. David wrote, "The LORD is my _____." Then comes _____, full of wise sayings like "Go to the _____ and be wise!" In _____, Solomon said, "Remember your _____ in the days of your youth." Song of Songs shows that God made _____. All these books tell us God's Word is a _____ for our feet, and they point us to _____, the Good Shepherd and the wisdom of God!

Answer key: Job, trust, Psalms, 150, shepherd, Proverbs, ant, Ecclesiastes, Creator, love, lamp, Jesus

Match the book to its picture / summary

Book		Picture & summary
1. Job		A. 🎵 God's songbook: 150 songs and prayers for every feeling.
2. Psalms		B. ❤️ A love poem showing God made love and marriage good.
3. Proverbs		C. ⛈️ A man suffers, asks hard questions, and learns to trust God.
4. Ecclesiastes		D. 🐜 Short wise sayings about words, friends, work and trusting God.
5. Song of Songs		E. 💨 Life without God is like a puff of breath; remember your Creator!
6. Nehemiah (review)		F. 🧱 A cupbearer rebuilds Jerusalem's walls in 52 days.

Answer key: 1-C, 2-A, 3-D, 4-E, 5-B, 6-F

Questions for Every Age

Little Lambs (ages 4–6)

1. When you feel sad, who can you talk to? (God!)
2. What song can you sing to God?
3. How does Jesus take care of you like a shepherd?

4. What is one wise choice you can make today? (Share, obey, be kind)
5. Who loves you more than anyone? (God / Jesus)

Explorers (ages 7–10)

1. What is something hard in your life that you can trust God with?
2. Which feeling (happy, sad, scared, sorry) do you most want to talk to God about this week?
3. What's a proverb you can practice at school?
4. What are some things that don't last forever? What lasts forever?
5. How can you show God's love to someone this week?

Trailblazers (ages 11–13)

1. Why is it okay (and even good) to be honest with God about how you feel?
2. Job's friends gave bad advice. How can you be a good friend when someone is hurting?
3. Who are the "wise" people you walk with (Proverbs 13:20)? Who might be pulling you toward folly?
4. Where do people your age look for meaning and happiness? Does it last?
5. How does God's Word act like a lamp in your life? Give a real example.

Ambassadors (ages 14–17)

1. When you're suffering or watching someone suffer, what helps you hold on to faith? What doesn't help?
2. Pick a psalm that matches how you're feeling right now. What does it teach you to say to God?
3. Which area of your life most needs Proverbs' wisdom right now: words, friends, work, money, or relationships?
4. Ecclesiastes says God "set eternity in the human heart." How do you see that longing in yourself and in your friends?
5. What does the Bible's view of love and marriage (Song of Songs; Genesis 2; Ephesians 5) say to a culture that often treats love as just a feeling?

Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics / worldview)

1. **"If God is good and all-powerful, why is there suffering?"** *Suggested answer:* This is called "the problem of evil," and Job wrestles with it honestly. Christianity's answer has several parts: (1) God created a good world, but human sin broke it (Genesis 3; Romans 8:20–22); (2) real love requires real freedom, which makes evil possible; (3) God can bring good out of suffering, even if we can't see it now (Romans 8:28; Genesis 50:20); (4) our view is limited, as God showed Job (Job 38–42); (5) most importantly, God didn't stay distant from suffering. In Jesus, He entered it, suffered with us and for us, and rose to defeat death. One day He will wipe away every tear (Revelation 21:4). We may not know every "why," but we can know the "Who."
2. **"Is the Bible against feelings? Aren't Christians supposed to be happy all the time?"** *Suggested answer:* No! About a third of the Psalms are laments: sad, angry, confused prayers. Jesus wept (John 11:35) and was "overwhelmed with sorrow" (Matthew 26:38). The Bible teaches us to bring

every feeling to God, not hide it. Christian joy (Nehemiah 8:10) isn't pretending to be happy; it's trust that God is with us and will make things right, even in tears.

3. **"Isn't 'the fear of the LORD' an unhealthy way to relate to God?"** *Suggested answer:* Biblical "fear of the LORD" is not terror of a cruel God. It's the awe and reverence you'd feel standing at the edge of the Grand Canyon, combined with trust and love that make you want to obey. It's the right response to how great and holy God really is. Through Jesus, we can approach this awesome God as our loving Father (Romans 8:15; Hebrews 4:16). Awe and closeness go together, and that's actually the healthiest relationship possible.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration

Praise Party plan (last Sunday, 75 minutes; Psalm 150)

Time	What happens
0–10 min	**Praise Parade:** Kids bring their Psalm 150 instruments and march around the room (or through the church hallway, with permission) singing "Twenty-Two Books" with motions. Ambassadors lead the parade.
10–25 min	**Poetry Shelf Stations:** Five stations, one per book: (1) Job: Storm and Stars "Can you…?" questions; (2) Psalms: Write or illustrate a one-line praise; (3) Proverbs: Ant Relay mini round; (4) Ecclesiastes: Time-for-everything charades; (5) Song of Songs: Make a "God's love" heart card for a family member. Rotate every 3 minutes.
25–35 min	**Favorite Video Rewatch** (kids vote)
35–50 min	**Poetry Bible Bowl:** Teams compete with the Word Trivia questions. Use instruments as "buzzers."
50–60 min	**Lamp Light Line-Up:** Dim the lights, and use flashlights for the all-22-books recall drill.
60–70 min	**Honey & Wisdom Snack + Check-offs:** "How sweet are your words to my taste, sweeter than honey to my mouth!" (Psalm 119:103). Serve honey graham crackers or honey sticks *(check allergies first)*. Teachers do individual check-offs.
70–75 min	**Passport Stamps, Badges & Prayer:** Close with everyone reading Psalm 150:6 together.

Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs (ages 4–6)

- [ ] Says "Poetry" for this kind of book
- [ ] Names 3 Poetry books (e.g., Job, Psalms, Proverbs) with motions
- [ ] Says the short verse: "Your word is a lamp for my feet."
- [ ] Spells J-O-B (with or without letter cards)

Explorers (ages 7–10)

- [ ] Says all 5 Poetry books in order
- [ ] Spells JOB, PSALMS, PROVERBS and SONG OF SONGS correctly (bonus: ECCLESIASTES)
- [ ] Says all 22 books from Genesis to Song of Songs (with the song is OK)
- [ ] Says the memory verse (Psalm 119:105)

Trailblazers (ages 11–13)

- [ ] Says all 22 books in order without the song
- [ ] Gives a one-sentence summary of each Poetry book
- [ ] Names the three sections so far with the number of books in each (5-12-5)
- [ ] Says the memory verse and the bonus verse (Proverbs 3:5) with references

Ambassadors (ages 14–17)

- [ ] Says all 22 books in order and names each section
- [ ] Explains Hebrew parallelism with an example
- [ ] Teaches one Poetry book to a younger child (name, motion, famous verse, how it points to Jesus)
- [ ] Says the memory verse and bonus verse with references

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp the "Songs & Wise Words" page. Stamp design: a harp next to a glowing oil lamp with "JOB • PSALMS • PROVERBS • ECCL • SONG" around the edge. Add a **"POETRY COMPLETE!"** sticker. Kids have now finished three whole sections of the Bible library and the entire first third of the Bible (22 of 66 books).

🏅 Badge description: The Lamp & Harp Badge

A round lamplight-gold badge with a teal border. In the center, a small harp with a glowing oil lamp beside it and three tiny music notes. Around the edge: "SONGS & WISE WORDS • 22 OF 66 • POETRY ✔." (Sticker, button or sash patch.)

📜 Certificate wording

> **Songs & Wisdom Certificate** This certifies that _____ has completed **Phase 6: Songs & Wise Words** at Purpose Church Sunday School. You have learned the books of **Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes and Song of Songs** and completed **all 5 books of Poetry**. You now know **22 of the 66 books** of the Bible: one-third of the whole library! *"Your word is a lamp for my feet, a light on my path." (Psalm 119:105)* Keep singing to God, keep choosing wisdom, and remember: Jesus is your Good Shepherd. Teacher: _____ Date: _____

Take-Home Family Page

> ✂️ *Copy this page and send it home on the first Sunday of the month.*

Dear Parents and Caregivers, This month your child is learning **Phase 6: Songs & Wise Words**, the five Poetry books of the Bible: **Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes and Song of Songs.** We'll learn that we can trust God when life hurts (Job), talk and sing to God about everything (Psalms), make wise choices (Proverbs), find real meaning in God (Ecclesiastes), and celebrate God's gift of love (Song of Songs, taught in an age-appropriate way). The big idea: **God's Word is a lamp that guides us, and Jesus is our Good Shepherd and the wisdom of God.** Your child now knows **22 of the 66 books** of the Bible!

📖 **Memory Verse:** "Your word is a lamp for my feet, a light on my path." (Psalm 119:105, NIV) **Little Lambs:** "Your word is a lamp for my feet." **Bonus (older kids):** "Trust in the LORD with all your heart and lean not on your own understanding." (Proverbs 3:5)

🎵 **Our Song (tune: *Jesus Loves Me*)**

> Genesis and Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers too, Deuteronomy makes five, these are Law books, give me five! Joshua, Judges, Ruth, and then Samuel and Samuel, Kings and Kings and Chronicles, Chronicles, and on we go! Ezra, Nehemiah too, Esther: History is through! Twelve books tell what God has done, now the poetry's begun! *Chorus:* Job and Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs makes five: Twenty-two books we know!

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions**

1. If you wrote a song to God today, would it be a happy song, a sad song, a sorry song or a thank-you song? Why?
2. What's one wise choice and one foolish choice someone could make at school this week?
3. What are some things that don't last, and what lasts forever?

🏠 **Family activity: "Proverb of the Day"** Proverbs has 31 chapters. Each day this month, read a few verses from the chapter that matches the date (e.g., on the 15th, read from Proverbs 15). Let each family member pick one favorite verse and write it on a sticky note on the fridge. At the end of the week, see who can remember the most! For younger children, read Psalm 23 together at bedtime each night until they can say verse 1 by heart.

📺 **Videos to watch at home (search on YouTube; parents, please preview)**

- @SharefaithKids: search "Psalm 23" → https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Psalm+23
- @BibleJourneyTV: search "Job" → https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Job
- @bibleproject: "Overview: Job," "Overview: Psalms," "Overview: Proverbs," "Overview: Ecclesiastes" → https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Proverbs *(BibleProject's*

"Overview: Song of Songs" is recommended for teens; parents, please preview.)

Thank you for partnering with us! For more about the program, see `../00-start-here/program-overview.md`.

Phase 7: God's Big Messengers

The Major Prophets: Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel & Daniel. God speaks, God warns, God comforts, and God promises a coming King.

At a Glance

Month	Month 7
Books covered	Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel (**5 books**)
Bible section(s)	Major Prophets (Old Testament)
Big Idea	God sent messengers to tell His people the truth: turn back to Me, I still love you, and a Rescuer-King is coming.
Memory Verse (all ages)	"The grass withers and the flowers fall, but the word of our God endures forever." (Isaiah 40:8, NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"The word of our God endures forever." (Isaiah 40:8)
Theme color	Royal Purple (for the King the prophets pointed to)
Phase symbol / badge	📯 The Megaphone (a messenger's horn), "God's Big Messenger" badge
Running total of books learned	**27 of 66** (Law 5 + History 12 + Poetry/Wisdom 5 + Major Prophets 5)

> Cross-links: Program Overview · Teacher Training Guide · Books of the Bible Memory System · Game Library · YouTube Video Guide · Phase 7 Printables

The Big Idea (in kid words)

A **prophet** is a messenger. God gave prophets a message, and they told it to the people. God's people kept running away from Him and doing wrong things. So God sent His big messengers to say, "Come back! I love you!" They also told a secret about the future: **a Rescuer-King is coming!**

How this points to Jesus: The prophets were like people standing on a tall tower, pointing far down the road and shouting, "Here He comes!" Isaiah said a baby would be born who would be called "Mighty God" and "Prince of Peace." Jeremiah said God would make a new promise and write His ways on our hearts. Ezekiel said God would be our Good Shepherd. Daniel saw a "Son of Man" who would rule forever. Every one of those promises came true in **Jesus**. Jesus even called Himself the "Son of Man" from Daniel's vision!

The Books in Easy Words

> **Why "Major"?** These five books are called "Major" Prophets because they are **long** (big books), not because these prophets were more important than the "Minor" (shorter) Prophets we will learn next month. Lamentations is short, but it sits with Jeremiah because Jeremiah is its traditional author.

1. Isaiah 📜

How to say it	eye-ZAY-uh
How to spell it	I-sai-ah — **I-S-A-I-A-H** (tip: "I SAID A HOT dog... no, I-S-A-I-A-H!" There's an "I" at the start and an "I-A" in the middle.)
Section	Major Prophets (book 1 of 5)
Traditional author	The prophet Isaiah, son of Amoz (Isaiah 1:1), around 740–680 B.C. in Jerusalem
One-sentence kid summary	Isaiah told God's people to stop doing wrong and promised that God would send a special Child, a Servant-King, to save them.
In one word	**Savior** (Isaiah's name means "The LORD saves")
Key people	Isaiah, King Uzziah, King Ahaz, King Hezekiah, the seraphim (angel-like creatures), the Assyrian king Sennacherib
Key stories	Isaiah sees God on His throne and a coal touches his lips: "Here am I. Send me!" (ch. 6); the sign of Immanuel (ch. 7); "For to us a child is born" (ch. 9); God rescues Jerusalem from the Assyrian army (ch. 36–37); "Comfort, comfort my people" and soaring on wings like eagles (ch. 40); the Suffering Servant (ch. 53); a new heaven and new earth (ch. 65–66)
Where Jesus shows up	Immanuel, "God with us" (7:14 → Matthew 1:23); "Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace" (9:6); the Servant "pierced for our transgressions" (53:5) → the cross; Jesus read Isaiah 61 in His hometown synagogue and said, "Today this scripture is fulfilled" (Luke 4:16–21).
Hand motion / symbol	🔥 **Hot coal on the lips**: touch two fingers to your lips, then point up and shout "Send me!"

> Fun fact: Isaiah has **66 chapters**, the same number as the books in the whole Bible. Some teachers call it "the Bible in miniature." (It's a fun coincidence, not a secret code!)

2. Jeremiah 🏺

How to say it	jair-uh-MY-uh
How to spell it	Jer-e-mi-ah — **J-E-R-E-M-I-A-H**
Section	Major Prophets (book 2 of 5)

Traditional author	The prophet Jeremiah (with his helper and scribe Baruch, Jeremiah 36:4), around 627–580 B.C.
One-sentence kid summary	Jeremiah, the "weeping prophet," warned Jerusalem for 40 years that it would fall if the people did not turn back to God, and he was right, but God also promised a brand-new covenant.
In one word	**Warning** (and **New Promise**)
Key people	Jeremiah, Baruch the scribe, King Josiah, King Jehoiakim, King Zedekiah, Ebed-Melek (who rescued Jeremiah), King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon
Key stories	God calls young Jeremiah: "Do not say, 'I am too young'" (ch. 1); the potter and the clay (ch. 18); a letter to the exiles: "For I know the plans I have for you" (29:11); the new covenant (31:31–34); the king cuts up and burns Jeremiah's scroll (ch. 36); Jeremiah is lowered into a muddy cistern and rescued (ch. 38); Jerusalem falls to Babylon (ch. 39 & 52)
Where Jesus shows up	The **new covenant** (31:31–34). At the Last Supper, Jesus said, "This cup is the new covenant in my blood" (Luke 22:20). Jeremiah also promised a "righteous Branch" from David's family (23:5).
Hand motion / symbol	🏺 **Potter's hands**: cup your hands and "shape clay" in a circle.

3. Lamentations 😢

How to say it	lam-en-TAY-shuns
How to spell it	Lam-en-ta-tions — **L-A-M-E-N-T-A-T-I-O-N-S** (tip: it has "LAMENT" + "ATIONS". A lament is a sad song.)
Section	Major Prophets (book 3 of 5)
Traditional author	Jeremiah (tradition; the book itself doesn't name its author), written soon after Jerusalem fell in 586 B.C.
One-sentence kid summary	Lamentations is five sad poems crying over broken Jerusalem, but right in the middle it says God's love is new every morning.
In one word	**Tears** (with hope in the middle)
Key people	The poet (Jeremiah), the people of Jerusalem (pictured as "Daughter Zion")
Key stories	There's no action story. It's poetry. Four of the five poems are ABC poems (acrostics) using the Hebrew alphabet. The hope-filled center: "Because of the LORD's great love we are not consumed, for his compassions never fail. They are new every morning; great is your faithfulness." (3:22–23)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus also wept over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41). God's never-failing love in 3:22–23 is shown most fully at the cross. Jesus is the "Man of Sorrows" who carried our sadness.
Hand motion / symbol	😢→🌅 **Tears to sunrise**: trace tears down your cheeks with your fingers, then sweep your arms up like the sun rising ("New every morning!").

4. Ezekiel 🦴

How to say it	ih-ZEE-kee-ul
How to spell it	E-ze-ki-el — **E-Z-E-K-I-E-L** (tip: "E-Z" like "easy" + "KIEL." Two E's around the Z, then "K-I-E-L.")
Section	Major Prophets (book 4 of 5)
Traditional author	Ezekiel, a priest who was taken to Babylon as a captive in 597 B.C. (Ezekiel 1:1–3)
One-sentence kid summary	Ezekiel saw amazing visions of God's glory while far away in Babylon, and God showed him that He could even bring dry bones back to life.
In one word	**Glory** (and **New Life**)
Key people	Ezekiel, the four living creatures, the exiles by the Kebar River
Key stories	The vision of God's glory with wheels within wheels (ch. 1); Ezekiel eats a scroll that tastes like honey (ch. 3); the watchman on the wall (ch. 3 & 33); God's glory leaves the temple (ch. 10); God the Good Shepherd (ch. 34); a new heart (36:26); the Valley of Dry Bones (ch. 37); a river flowing from a new temple (ch. 47); the city's new name: "THE LORD IS THERE" (48:35)
Where Jesus shows up	"I myself will search for my sheep" (34:11) → Jesus: "I am the good shepherd" (John 10:11). New heart and Spirit (36:26–27) → the Holy Spirit given through Jesus. The river of life (47) → Jesus offers "living water" (John 7:37–38).
Hand motion / symbol	🦴 **Dry bones wake up**: flop like a floppy skeleton, then stand up straight and tall!

5. Daniel 🦁

How to say it	DAN-yul
How to spell it	Dan-iel — **D-A-N-I-E-L**
Section	Major Prophets (book 5 of 5)
Traditional author	Daniel, a young man from Judah taken to Babylon in 605 B.C., who served kings for about 70 years
One-sentence kid summary	Daniel and his friends stayed faithful to God in Babylon, and God protected them in a blazing furnace and a den of lions and showed Daniel that His kingdom will last forever.
In one word	**Faithful**
Key people	Daniel (Babylonian name Belteshazzar), Shadrach, Meshach & Abednego (Hebrew names Hananiah, Mishael & Azariah), King Nebuchadnezzar, King Belshazzar, King Darius, the angel Gabriel
Key stories	Vegetables and water for 10 days (ch. 1); the king's dream of a giant statue (ch. 2); the blazing furnace, and a fourth man in the fire (ch. 3); proud Nebuchadnezzar eats grass like a cow (ch. 4); the handwriting on the wall (ch. 5); the lions' den (ch. 6); the vision of the "son of man" coming with the clouds (ch. 7)

Where Jesus shows up	The "son of man" given an everlasting kingdom (7:13–14). Jesus called Himself "the Son of Man" more than any other name, and quoted Daniel 7 at His trial (Mark 14:62). The rock "not cut by human hands" that becomes a mountain (2:34–35, 44) pictures God's never-ending kingdom.
Hand motion / symbol	🦁 **Lion's mouth shut**: open your hands like a roaring lion's jaws, then clap them shut!

Section summary: The Major Prophets (5)

#	Book	One word	Motion
1	Isaiah	Savior	Coal on lips → "Send me!"
2	Jeremiah	Warning / New Promise	Shape the clay
3	Lamentations	Tears	Tears → sunrise
4	Ezekiel	Glory / New Life	Floppy bones → stand tall
5	Daniel	Faithful	Lion jaws snap shut

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher

What is a prophet? In the Bible, a prophet is a person God chose to speak His words to His people. People often think "prophet" means "someone who predicts the future." Prophets sometimes did that, but mostly they were *covenant messengers*. They reminded Israel of the covenant (the binding promise-relationship) God made at Mount Sinai (Phase 2). Their message usually had three parts:

1. **"You have broken the covenant."** Idolatry (worshiping false gods), injustice to the poor, empty religion.
2. **"Judgment is coming if you don't turn back."** For Israel this meant invasion and exile (being carried away from the land).
3. **"But God will not give up on you."** After judgment comes restoration, a new covenant, and a coming King from David's family (the Messiah).

Where these books fit on the timeline. The Major Prophets fit inside the stories you taught in Phases 4 and 5 (Kings, Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah):

Approx. date (B.C.)	Event	Prophet(s) speaking
740	King Uzziah dies; Isaiah's call (Isaiah 6)	Isaiah
722	Assyria conquers the northern kingdom (Israel)	Isaiah (and Hosea, Amos, Micah next month)
701	Assyria's King Sennacherib surrounds Jerusalem; God rescues the city (Isaiah 36–37; 2 Kings 18–19)	Isaiah

Approx. date (B.C.)	Event	Prophet(s) speaking
627	Jeremiah is called as a young man	Jeremiah
605	First captives taken to Babylon, including Daniel and his friends	Jeremiah, Daniel
597	Second deportation, including Ezekiel and King Jehoiachin	Jeremiah, Ezekiel
586	Babylon destroys Jerusalem and the temple	Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel
539	Persia (King Cyrus) conquers Babylon; Daniel in the lions' den happens around this time under "Darius the Mede"	Daniel
538	Cyrus lets the Jews go home (Ezra 1); Isaiah had named Cyrus ahead of time (Isaiah 44:28–45:1)	—

Map notes. Draw (or print) a simple "arc" map: **Jerusalem** (Judah) on the left, **Nineveh** (Assyria) at the top, **Babylon** on the right along the Euphrates River. The trip from Jerusalem to Babylon was not straight across the desert. Travelers went north and around through the "Fertile Crescent," about 900 miles, which took roughly four months on foot (compare Ezra 7:9). Ezekiel lived by the **Kebar River** (a canal near Babylon). Daniel lived in the city of Babylon, and later served in the Persian government.

Key truths to emphasize

- **God speaks.** He is not silent. He tells His people the truth even when it's hard to hear (Isaiah 40:8: His word lasts forever).
- **Sin has real consequences**, but **God's love is bigger** than our sin (Lamentations 3:22–23).
- **God keeps His promises.** The prophets' predictions came true: Jerusalem fell (as warned), the people came home (as promised), and the Messiah came (as promised).
- **God is with His people even in hard places.** In Babylon, God was with Ezekiel by the river and with Daniel in the lions' den.
- **Faithfulness matters**, even when you're young (Jeremiah, Daniel and his friends were teenagers or young adults).
- **Jesus is the King the prophets were waiting for.**

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
Destruction of Jerusalem / war	"A strong army came and broke the city. The people had to move far away."	Explain the army, the broken walls and temple, and the long walk to Babylon.	Discuss *why* (2 Kings 24–25, 2 Chronicles 36:15–16: God warned for a long time).	Discuss judgment and mercy together; God's patience; exile as discipline, not abandonment.
Lions & the furnace	Focus on God's protection; "the lions' mouths were shut."	Tell the whole story; it's exciting.	Discuss Daniel 3:18 "even if he does not": faith that trusts God no matter what.	Discuss martyrdom honestly: God doesn't always rescue from death, but He always keeps us (Hebrews 11:32–38).

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
The accusers thrown to the lions (Dan. 6:24)	Skip.	Simply: "The bad men who tricked the king were punished."	Mention it briefly; it was the Persian king's decision.	Discuss ancient justice vs. God's justice.
Lamentations' graphic famine imagery (e.g., 4:10)	Skip.	Skip.	"The city was starving. It was terrible."	May read with discussion, if appropriate for your group.
Ezekiel's adult imagery (chs. 16 & 23)	Skip.	Skip.	Skip.	Summarize only: "God compares His people's idolatry to an unfaithful marriage."
Ezekiel's wife's death (24:15–18)	Skip.	Skip.	Optional: God's prophet obeyed even in deep grief.	Optional discussion on grief and obedience.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

1. **"Are prophets still around today?"** God still speaks today, mostly through the Bible, His Word. The Old Testament prophets had a special job that was finished when Jesus came (Hebrews 1:1–2: "In the past God spoke... through the prophets... but in these last days he has spoken to us by his Son").
2. **"Why didn't the people listen?"** Their hearts had grown hard. They liked their idols and doing things their own way. We can be the same, so we ask God for a soft heart (Ezekiel 36:26).
3. **"Was the fourth man in the furnace Jesus?"** The Bible doesn't tell us for sure. The king said he looked like "a son of the gods" (Daniel 3:25). Many Christians believe it was an angel or even a special appearance of God's Son before He was born as a baby. What we know for sure is that God was with them in the fire.
4. **"Did Daniel get hurt by the lions?"** No! "No wound was found on him, because he had trusted in his God" (Daniel 6:23).
5. **"Could dry bones really come alive?"** Ezekiel 37 was a vision, a picture God showed Ezekiel to teach that He can bring His people back to life after the exile. But God *really does* raise the dead. He raised Jesus, and He will raise everyone who trusts in Jesus one day!
6. **"Why is it called Lamentations?"** A "lament" is a sad song or a cry to God. It's okay to tell God when you're sad. He wants to hear it.
7. **"How did Isaiah know about Jesus 700 years early?"** God knows everything, even the future, and He told Isaiah. That's one reason we can trust the Bible.
8. **"Why did Daniel eat only vegetables?"** He didn't want to break God's food laws or be "defiled" by the king's food (Daniel 1:8). He wanted to obey God even in small things, and he was polite and wise about it.

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
1	Isaiah 6:1–8; 9:6–7; 53:4–6	"Here Am I, Send Me!"	God calls messengers, and Isaiah pointed to Jesus the Savior.	BibleProject "Overview: Isaiah 1-39"; Sharefaith Kids "Isaiah"; Bible Journey "Isaiah"	Prophet Says (Messenger Relay)	Megaphone Craft
2	Jeremiah 1:4–10; 18:1–6; 38:1–13; Lamentations 3:22–23	"Clay in the Potter's Hands"	God shapes us, warns us, and His love is new every morning.	BibleProject "Overview: Jeremiah" & "Overview: Lamentations"; Sharefaith Kids "Jeremiah"; Bible Journey "Jeremiah"	Potter's Shape-Up	Clay/Play-Dough Pots
3	Ezekiel 1:1, 26–28; 37:1–14	"Dry Bones, Live!"	God can bring new life to anything, even dry bones.	BibleProject "Overview: Ezekiel 1-33" & "Ezekiel 34-48"; Sharefaith Kids "Ezekiel Dry Bones"; Bible Journey "Ezekiel"	Dry Bones Freeze Tag	Q-tip Skeleton Craft
4	Daniel 1; 3; 6	"Brave in Babylon"	Stay faithful to God. He is with us in the fire and in the lions' den.	BibleProject "Overview: Daniel"; Sharefaith Kids "Daniel and the Lions' Den"; Bible Journey "Daniel"	Lions' Den Sneak	Lion Paper-Plate Masks
5 *(optional)*	Review all 5 books	"Messenger Mania Review Sunday"	God's word lasts forever, and it all points to Jesus.	Favorite clip review + BibleProject "Messiah"	Major Prophet Mega-Relay	Passport Stamp & Badge Ceremony

Weekly Lessons

Week 1: "Here Am I, Send Me!" (Isaiah)

Scripture: Isaiah 6:1–8; Isaiah 9:6–7; Isaiah 53:4–6

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that a prophet is God's messenger, that Isaiah said "Send me!" to God, and that Isaiah pointed to Jesus, the Child who would be born and the Servant who would die for our sins.

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Sealed Message"

- *Supplies:* An envelope marked "TOP SECRET MESSAGE FROM THE KING," a paper inside reading "A CHILD IS COMING. HIS NAME WILL BE MIGHTY GOD, PRINCE OF PEACE," a toy crown, a party horn or rolled-up paper megaphone.
- *Do:* Hold up the envelope. "I have a message from the King! But a message isn't any good if nobody tells it. I need a messenger!" Pick a volunteer, give them the megaphone and have them read the message loudly. Say: "God has messages too. The people He picked to tell His messages are called **prophets**. Today we meet one of God's biggest messengers: Isaiah!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> A long, long time ago, in the city of Jerusalem, there lived a man named Isaiah. The king of the land, King Uzziah, had just died. People were worried. "Who will take care of us now?"
>
> Then one day, God gave Isaiah a vision, like a dream while he was awake. Isaiah saw the Lord sitting on a throne, high and lifted up! God's royal robe was so long that it filled the whole temple. Above Him flew amazing creatures called seraphim. Each one had six wings. With two wings they covered their faces, with two they covered their feet, and with two they flew. They called out to each other, "Holy, holy, holy is the LORD Almighty; the whole earth is full of his glory!" The doorposts shook, and the temple filled with smoke!
>
> Isaiah was scared. "Oh no!" he cried. "I'm not good enough to be here! I have said wrong things with my lips, and so have my people!"
>
> Then one of the seraphim flew to the altar, picked up a burning hot coal with tongs, and flew to Isaiah. He touched the coal to Isaiah's lips and said, "Your guilt is taken away and your sin is forgiven."
>
> Then Isaiah heard God's voice: "Whom shall I send? And who will go for us?"
>
> Isaiah didn't wait. He said, "Here am I. Send me!"
>
> So God made Isaiah His messenger. Some of the messages were hard: "Stop doing wrong. Stop praying to fake gods. Help the poor!" But some of Isaiah's messages were the most wonderful news ever. God told Isaiah about Someone who was coming:
>
> "For to us a child is born, to us a son is given... And he will be called Wonderful Counselor, Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace."
>
> God also told Isaiah that this special Person would be a Servant who would suffer for other people's sins: "He was pierced for our transgressions... and by his wounds we are healed."
>
> Who was Isaiah talking about? Seven hundred years later, a baby was born in Bethlehem. His name was **Jesus**. He grew up and died on the cross for our sins, and He rose again! Isaiah's message came true, because God's word lasts forever.
>
> And guess what? God is still asking, "Whom shall I send?" You can tell people about Jesus too. You can say, "Here am I. Send me!"

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Act it out: flap "six wings" (arms, hands over face, hands over feet), shout "Holy, holy, holy!", touch lips gently, then raise hands: "Send me!" Keep the main idea: *A prophet tells God's message.*
- **Explorers:** Have kids find Isaiah in their Bibles (just after Song of Songs, the first Major Prophet). Count the seraphim's wings together. Emphasize Isaiah 9:6 names.
- **Trailblazers:** Compare Isaiah 7:14 with Matthew 1:22–23 and Isaiah 53:5 with 1 Peter 2:24. Ask: "How could Isaiah write this 700 years early?"
- **Ambassadors:** Read Isaiah 53 in full. Discuss "substitution" (Jesus taking our place). Have them prepare a 2-minute "send me" testimony to share with a younger group.

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What did the angels with six wings say? ("Holy, holy, holy!") (2) What did Isaiah say to God? ("Send me!") (3) Who is the special baby Isaiah talked about? (Jesus!)
- *Explorers:* (1) Why was Isaiah scared when he saw God? (2) What did the hot coal mean? (Forgiveness, his sin was taken away.) (3) Name one of the four names in Isaiah 9:6.
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why do you think Isaiah had to be forgiven *before* he was sent? (2) What does "holy" mean? (Set apart, totally pure, different from everything else.) (3) Which part of Isaiah 53 sounds most like the cross?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Isaiah was willing before he knew how hard the job would be (6:9–13). What does that teach about following God? (2) How is Isaiah 53 one of the strongest evidences that the Bible points to Jesus? (3) Where is God "sending" you this year (school, team, family)?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Isaiah" (or "Isaiah's Vision" / "Here I Am Send Me")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Isaiah
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Isaiah"	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Isaiah
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors (Explorers with pauses)	"Overview: Isaiah 1-39" (and part 2: "Overview: Isaiah 40-66")	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Isaiah

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) What did the video show about why God sent Isaiah? (2) What promise about the future did you hear?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Prophet Says (Messenger Relay)*, see Games #1.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Megaphone Craft*, see Activities #1. Coloring Page 1: "Isaiah's Vision."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Introduce the Memory Verse (Isaiah 40:8) and the section name **Major Prophets**. Spell **I-S-A-I-A-H**. Review the 22 books from previous phases with the cumulative chant.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, You are holy, holy, holy! Thank You for forgiving our sins through Jesus. Here we are. Send us to tell others about You. Amen.

Week 2: "Clay in the Potter's Hands" (Jeremiah & Lamentations)

Scripture: Jeremiah 1:4–10; 18:1–6; 38:1–13; Lamentations 3:22–23

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that God can use young people, that God shapes us like a potter shapes clay, that Jeremiah kept telling the truth even when it was hard, and that God's love is new every morning.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Squish and Start Over"

- *Supplies:* A lump of clay or play-dough, a small bowl you made ahead of time from the same color, a lopsided "messed-up" pot.
- *Do:* Show the lopsided pot. "Oops! This pot didn't turn out right. Should I throw it away?" Squish it back into a ball and begin reshaping it. "A potter doesn't throw the clay away. He starts again and makes something good! That's exactly what God showed the prophet Jeremiah."

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Jeremiah was a young man, maybe even a teenager, when God spoke to him. God said, "Before I formed you in the womb I knew you... I appointed you as a prophet to the nations."
>
> Jeremiah gulped. "But Lord, I don't know how to speak. I am too young!"
>
> God said, "Do not say, 'I am too young.' You must go to everyone I send you to and say whatever I command you. Do not be afraid, for I am with you." Then God reached out and touched Jeremiah's mouth and said, "I have put my words in your mouth."
>
> One day God said, "Jeremiah, go down to the potter's house." So Jeremiah went. He watched the potter spin his wheel round and round, shaping a lump of wet clay into a pot. But the pot got messed up in the potter's hands! So the potter squished it down and made it into a different pot, one that was just right.
>
> God said, "Like clay in the hand of the potter, so are you in my hand." God's people had gotten "messed up." They were worshiping fake gods and being unkind to the poor. But God was willing to reshape them, if they would turn back to Him.
>
> Jeremiah preached for forty years. Most people didn't want to listen. Some even laughed at him. Once, some leaders were so angry that they lowered Jeremiah with ropes into a deep, muddy well

called a cistern. There was no water, only mud, and Jeremiah sank down into it!

But a kind man named Ebed-Melek went to the king and begged for help. The king let him rescue Jeremiah. Ebed-Melek took thirty men, plus some old rags and worn-out clothes, and let them down on ropes. "Put these rags under your arms so the ropes won't hurt," he said. Then they pulled Jeremiah up out of the mud!

Sadly, the people still didn't listen. Just as Jeremiah warned, the Babylonian army came and broke down the walls of Jerusalem and burned the beautiful temple. Many people were taken far away.

Jeremiah was so sad that he cried. That's why he's called the "weeping prophet." The book of **Lamentations** is full of sad songs about the broken city. But right in the middle of all that sadness, there is a bright, shining hope:

"Because of the LORD's great love we are not consumed, for his compassions never fail. They are new every morning; great is your faithfulness."

Even when everything goes wrong, God's love is still there, fresh and new every single morning. And God promised Jeremiah that one day He would make a **new covenant**, a new promise, and write His ways on people's hearts. Jesus came to make that new promise come true!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Give every child a small ball of play-dough to squish and reshape while you tell the story. Main idea: *God loves me and makes me new.* Do the "sunrise" motion for "new every morning."
- **Explorers:** Find Jeremiah and Lamentations in the Bible (right after Isaiah). Act out the cistern rescue with a jump rope and a "rag" (dish towel).
- **Trailblazers:** Read Jeremiah 31:31–34 and Luke 22:20. Discuss what makes the new covenant "new" (forgiveness and God's law written on hearts). Look at Jeremiah 29:11 *in context* (it was written to exiles who would wait 70 years; 29:10).
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss being faithful when you're not "successful." Jeremiah had few converts but obeyed for 40 years. How do we measure faithfulness? Look at the acrostic structure of Lamentations (chapter 3 has 66 verses: 3 for each of the 22 Hebrew letters).

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What did the potter make? (A pot!) (2) Where did the bad men put Jeremiah? (In a muddy hole!) (3) When is God's love new? (Every morning!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What excuse did Jeremiah give God? ("I am too young.") (2) What did God mean when He said we are like clay? (3) How did Ebed-Melek show kindness?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why do you think the people refused to listen to Jeremiah? (2) What does Jeremiah 29:11 mean when you read verse 10 too? (3) How is the "new covenant" connected to the Lord's Supper?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Is it okay to lament (complain honestly) to God? What does Lamentations teach? (2) What's the difference between being *shaped* by God and being *crushed* by circumstances? (3) Where do you need to speak truth even if no one listens?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Jeremiah" (or "Potter and the Clay")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Jeremiah
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Jeremiah"	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Jeremiah
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Jeremiah" and "Overview: Lamentations"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Jeremiah

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) Why was Jeremiah called the "weeping prophet"? (2) What hope did God give, even after Jerusalem fell?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Potter's Shape-Up*, see Games #2.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Clay Pots with a Promise*, see Activities #2. Coloring Page 2: "Jeremiah at the Potter's House."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **J-E-R-E-M-I-A-H** and **L-A-M-E-N-T-A-T-I-O-N-S** (clap the syllables: Lam-en-ta-tions = 4 claps). Say the Major Prophets so far: Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, You are the Potter and we are the clay. Shape us to be like Jesus. Thank You that Your love is new every morning. Amen.

Week 3: "Dry Bones, Live!" (Ezekiel)

Scripture: Ezekiel 1:1, 26–28; Ezekiel 37:1–14 (optional: 36:26)

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that God was with His people even far away in Babylon, that God showed Ezekiel His dazzling glory, and that God can bring new life to things that seem completely dead, like dry bones (and like our hearts).

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Wilted Plant"

- *Supplies:* A badly wilted (droopy, not dead) potted plant, a cup of water. (Do this 2–3 hours before class: a wilted plant watered at the start of class will often perk up by the end. Check on it at closing!) Also a plastic Halloween skeleton or a picture of a skeleton.
- *Do:* "This plant looks pretty dead. Can it come back to life?" Water it and set it aside. "Let's see at the end of class!" Then hold up the skeleton: "But what about THIS? Can a skeleton come back to life? Today God shows a prophet something amazing."

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Ezekiel was a priest. He was supposed to serve God at the temple in Jerusalem. But when he was a young man, the Babylonian army took him and many others far away to the land of Babylon. There was no temple there. Ezekiel lived by a river called the Kebar River, and he probably thought, "God is far away in Jerusalem. Is He even here with us?"
>
> Then one day, the sky opened up! Ezekiel saw a giant storm cloud flashing with fire. Inside were four amazing living creatures with wings, and next to them were wheels, sparkling wheels with wheels inside them, covered with eyes, moving in every direction! And above them all, on a throne like sapphire, sat Someone who glowed like fire, with a rainbow all around Him. It was the glory of the LORD!
>
> Ezekiel fell flat on his face. God was not stuck in Jerusalem. God was right there with His people in Babylon!
>
> Years later, God gave Ezekiel another vision. God's Spirit carried Ezekiel to a valley, and the whole valley was full of bones. Not just a few bones, but piles and piles of very, very dry bones.
>
> God asked, "Son of man, can these bones live?"
>
> Ezekiel said, "Sovereign LORD, you alone know."
>
> God said, "Prophesy to these bones and say to them, 'Dry bones, hear the word of the LORD!'"
>
> So Ezekiel preached to the bones. And then: *rattle, rattle, clack, clack!* The bones came together, bone to bone! Foot bones connected to leg bones, leg bones to hip bones! Then muscles and skin covered them. But they were still lying there with no breath.
>
> God said, "Prophesy to the breath!" Ezekiel did, and breath came into them. They came to life and stood up on their feet, a huge army!
>
> God explained, "These bones are my people. They feel dried up and hopeless. But I will open their graves and bring them back to their land. I will put my Spirit in you and you will live!"
>
> God also promised, "I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit in you."
>
> Kids, without God, our hearts are like dry bones: no life, no hope. But Jesus came to give us new life! When we trust Jesus, God gives us the Holy Spirit and a brand-new heart. And one day Jesus will raise His people from the dead for real, forever!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Play "Dry Bones": everyone lies down "floppy." As you say "Toe bone! Leg bone! Knee bone!", they wiggle each part, then "BREATH!" and everyone jumps up. Main idea: *God gives life.*
- **Explorers:** Sing or chant the "toe bone connected to the foot bone" pattern (traditional spiritual "Dem Bones" is public domain). Find Ezekiel 37 in the Bible together.

- **Trailblazers:** Compare Ezekiel 10 (God's glory leaves the temple) with John 1:14 ("The Word became flesh and made his dwelling among us. We have seen his glory"). Discuss how Jesus is God's glory returning.
- **Ambassadors:** Read Ezekiel 36:25–27 and John 3:5 (Jesus to Nicodemus: "born of water and the Spirit"). Jesus expected Nicodemus, a teacher, to know Ezekiel! Discuss what spiritual "new birth" means.

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What was in the valley? (Bones!) (2) What did God give the bones? (Breath / life!) (3) Who gives us new life? (Jesus!)
- *Explorers:* (1) Where did Ezekiel live? (Babylon, by the Kebar River.) (2) What did God tell Ezekiel to say to the bones? (3) What does God promise to give us in Ezekiel 36:26?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why was it important for Ezekiel to see God's glory *in Babylon*? (2) What did the dry bones stand for? (God's discouraged people in exile.) (3) How is Jesus the "breath of life" for us?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) What's the difference between "fixing ourselves up" and receiving a new heart? (2) How does Ezekiel 37 point toward the resurrection? (3) Ezekiel was called a "watchman" (ch. 33). Who are you responsible to warn and encourage?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Ezekiel Dry Bones"	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Ezekiel+Dry+Bones
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Ezekiel"	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Ezekiel
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Ezekiel 1-33" and "Overview: Ezekiel 34-48"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Ezekiel

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) What did the vision of God's glory teach Ezekiel? (2) What does the valley of dry bones tell us about God's power?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Dry Bones Freeze Tag*, see Games #3.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Q-tip Skeleton* (Explorers+), *Paper Bone Puzzle* (Little Lambs), see Activities #3. Coloring Page 3: "The Valley of Dry Bones."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **E-Z-E-K-I-E-L** ("E-Z" sounds like "easy!"). Say all four Major Prophets so far. Check the wilted plant at the end of class!

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, You can make dry bones live! Please give us new hearts and fill us with Your Spirit.

> Thank You for Jesus, who gives us life forever. Amen.

Week 4: "Brave in Babylon" (Daniel)

Scripture: Daniel 1:8–17; Daniel 3:13–28; Daniel 6:1–23 (optional: 7:13–14)

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Daniel and his friends obeyed God even in a land that didn't follow God, that God was with them in the blazing furnace and the lions' den, and that God's kingdom (Jesus' kingdom) lasts forever.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Stand Up Straight"

- *Supplies:* A tall paper "statue" (or a cardboard box tower) labeled "BOW DOWN!", a battery tea-light or orange tissue paper "fire," a stuffed lion.
- *Do:* Tell everyone: "When I hit this bell (or clap), everyone must bow down to the box!" Clap once and let everyone bow. Then whisper to one pre-chosen helper to stay standing. Clap again. Point at the helper: "Hey! Why aren't YOU bowing?" Helper says (rehearsed): "I only worship the one true God!" Say: "Today we meet some brave young people who wouldn't bow down even when a king commanded it."

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> When Daniel was a teenager, the army of Babylon took him away from his home in Jerusalem. He and his friends, Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego, were brought to the palace of the mighty King Nebuchadnezzar to be trained as royal helpers.
>
> The king offered them his fancy food, but Daniel decided he would not do anything that might break God's laws. He politely asked, "Please test us for ten days. Give us only vegetables to eat and water to drink." After ten days, Daniel and his friends looked healthier and stronger than everyone else! God gave them wisdom, and Daniel could even understand dreams.
>
> Later, King Nebuchadnezzar built a giant golden statue, ninety feet tall! He commanded, "When the music plays, everyone must bow down and worship this statue. Anyone who doesn't will be thrown into a blazing furnace!"
>
> The music played. *Toot! Twang! Boom!* Everyone bowed down... except Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego. They stood tall!
>
> The king was furious. But the three friends said, "Our God is able to save us. But even if He does not, we will never bow to your statue." The king made the furnace seven times hotter and had them thrown in!
>
> Then the king jumped up. "Didn't we throw three men into the fire? Look! I see **four** men walking around in the fire, unharmed!" God was with them in the flames! When they came out, not one hair was burned, and they didn't even smell like smoke!

> Many years later, Daniel was an old man working for a new king named Darius. Daniel did such a good job that some jealous leaders wanted to get rid of him. They tricked the king into making a law: "For thirty days, nobody can pray to anyone except the king. Anyone who does will be thrown into the lions' den!"
>
> Did Daniel stop praying? No! He went home, opened his windows toward Jerusalem, and got down on his knees and prayed three times a day, just like always.
>
> The jealous men caught him. The king was very sad, because he liked Daniel, but he had to keep his law. Daniel was thrown into a den of hungry lions, and a stone was placed over the opening.
>
> The king couldn't sleep all night. Early in the morning he ran to the den and called out, "Daniel! Has your God been able to rescue you?"
>
> And from inside the den came Daniel's voice: "My God sent his angel, and he shut the mouths of the lions. They have not hurt me!"
>
> Daniel later had a vision of "one like a son of man" coming with the clouds of heaven, and God gave Him a kingdom that would never end. Who is that? Jesus! Jesus called Himself "the Son of Man." Kings come and go, but Jesus' kingdom lasts forever!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Use the stuffed lion. Let kids "roar," then clap hands over the lion's mouth: "God shut the lions' mouths!" Main idea: *God is with me when I'm scared.*
- **Explorers:** Count the four men in the fire using fingers. Find Daniel in the Bible (the last Major Prophet). Discuss: "What are things kids might be pressured to 'bow down' to?"
- **Trailblazers:** Look at Daniel 2 (the statue of four metals = four kingdoms) and 7:13–14. Talk about how Daniel predicted a series of empires (Babylon, Medo-Persia, Greece, Rome) followed by God's everlasting kingdom.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss "even if he does not" (3:18): faith that isn't based on getting the outcome we want. Discuss how to live as a faithful Christian in a culture that doesn't share your faith (Daniel served the government well but would not compromise worship).

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Who was in the lions' den? (Daniel!) (2) How many men were in the fire? (Four!) (3) Is God with you when you are scared? (Yes!)
- *Explorers:* (1) Why did Daniel eat vegetables? (2) What did the three friends say to the king? (3) How many times a day did Daniel pray?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Daniel kept praying even though it was against the law. When should we obey God rather than people? (Acts 5:29) (2) What do you think the "fourth man" teaches us about God? (3) Why do you think Jesus called Himself the Son of Man?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) How did Daniel stay faithful *and* respectful to pagan kings? (2) What "statues" does our culture ask us to bow to today (popularity, money, image)? (3) What does "even if he does not" faith look like when prayers aren't answered the way we hoped?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Daniel and the Lions' Den" / "Fiery Furnace"	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Daniel
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Daniel"	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Daniel
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Daniel" (bonus theme video: "Son of Man")	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Daniel

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) How did Daniel and his friends show courage? (2) What did the video say about God's kingdom?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Lions' Den Sneak*, see Games #4.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Lion Paper-Plate Masks*, see Activities #4. Coloring Page 4: "Daniel in the Lions' Den."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **D-A-N-I-E-L**. Say all 5 Major Prophets in order with motions, and the whole memory verse. Begin oral check-offs (see End-of-Phase Review).

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, help us to be brave like Daniel and his friends. Thank You for being with us in hard and scary times. Thank You that Jesus is King forever! Amen.

Week 5 (optional): "Messenger Mania Review Sunday"

Use the End-of-Phase Review & Celebration plan below. Run the *Major Prophet Mega-Relay* (Games #5), finish oral check-offs, stamp Bible Passports, and award the 📯 "God's Big Messenger" badge.

Book Memory Song & Motions

🎵 "The Library Song: Major Prophets Verse" (tune: "Ten Little Fingers")

The tune is the familiar counting song "One little, two little, three little fingers..." Each verse = one section of the Bible library. Sing all the verses every week; it's cumulative! The new verse this month is Verse 4.

Verse 1: LAW (5)

> Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, the books of the Law! Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, FIVE!

Verse 2: HISTORY (12)

> Joshua, Judges, Ruth, and First and Second Samuel, First and Second Kings, then First and Second Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, and Esther: History! Twelve books of HIS-TO-RY!

Verse 3: POETRY / WISDOM (5)

> Job and Psalms and Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs, they're Poetry and Wisdom! Job and Psalms and Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs, that's FIVE!

Verse 4: MAJOR PROPHETS (5), NEW!

> I-sai-ah, Jer-e-mi-ah, Lam-en-ta-tions, E-ze-kiel and Dan-iel, the Ma-jor Pro-phets! I-sai-ah, Jer-e-mi-ah, Lam-en-ta-tions, E-ze-kiel, Dan-iel: FIVE!

Tag (shout it!)

> Five plus twelve plus five plus five… TWENTY-SEVEN BOOKS, we're ALIVE!

(Teacher tip: Little Lambs can just shout "FIVE!" and do the motions; they don't have to sing every word.)

Hand motions for the new books

Book	Motion
Isaiah	Touch two fingers to your lips (the hot coal), then shoot your hand up: "Send me!"
Jeremiah	Cup hands and roll them in a circle like shaping clay on a potter's wheel.
Lamentations	Trace "tears" down your cheeks, then sweep arms up and out like a sunrise.
Ezekiel	Go floppy like loose bones, then snap up straight and tall.
Daniel	Open hands like a lion's jaws ("Roar!"), then clap them shut.

Review motions for books learned earlier (1–22). These match the motions used in earlier phases and the Books of the Bible Memory System:

Section	Book → motion
Law	Genesis: palms together like a book, open, sweep arms up (sunrise) · Exodus: walk two fingers across your palm and out the "door" · Leviticus: fold hands in prayer, then raise them high · Numbers: count 1-2-3-4 on fingers, then zig-zag your hand · Deuteronomy: two fingers up, tap your head, hand on heart
History	Joshua: march with a fist-trumpet · Judges: pound a gavel on your palm, then draw a circle · Ruth: scoop grain, then hug yourself · 1 & 2 Samuel: hold up 1 or 2 fingers, then cup your ear (listening) · 1 & 2 Kings: 1 or 2 fingers, then crown on head · 1 & 2 Chronicles: 1 or 2 fingers, then unroll a scroll · Ezra: stack fists like bricks · Nehemiah: hammer + shield · Esther: crown, then "speak up" hands at mouth
Poetry / Wisdom	Job: hands open up, then fold over heart · Psalms: strum a harp · Proverbs: tap your head with one finger · Ecclesiastes: blow a puff into your hand, then point up · Song of Songs: heart hands

📣 Section Shout

> **Teacher:** "Who are God's big messengers?" **Kids:** "FIVE MAJOR PROPHETS!" **Teacher:** "Name them!" **Kids (with motions):** "Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, DANIEL!" **Teacher:** "What is a prophet?" **Kids:** "GOD'S MESSENGER!"

Cumulative recall drill (5 minutes)

1. **Section Stand-Up:** Call out a section ("Law!"). Kids stand and say the books in that section. Go in order: Law → History → Poetry/Wisdom → Major Prophets.
2. **Before & After:** "What comes after Song of Songs?" (Isaiah) "What comes before Ezekiel?" (Lamentations) "What's the last book of History?" (Esther)
3. **Count-Up:** Kids hold up fingers as they say each Major Prophet (5 fingers = one hand!). Then they "stack" it on the previous sections: 5 + 12 + 5 + 5 = 27.
4. **Speed Round (Explorers+):** Time how fast the class can say all 27 books in order. Write the time on the board and try to beat it each week.
5. **Missing Book:** Say the 5 Major Prophets but skip one. Kids shout which one is missing.

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on the section name "Major Prophets," the motions, and being able to say "Isaiah" and "Daniel." Celebrate any attempt!
- **Explorers:** Goal: say and spell all 5 new books and sing all four verses.
- **Trailblazers:** Goal: say all 27 books in order without the song, and give a one-word summary for each Major Prophet.
- **Ambassadors:** Goal: say all 27 books in order, lead the song for a younger class one week, and explain why they're called "Major."

Spelling & Reading

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letter recognition & first sounds)

Book	First letter	Sound it out	Picture clue
Isaiah	**I**	"eye"	🔥 coal
Jeremiah	**J**	"j-j-j"	🏺 pot
Lamentations	**L**	"l-l-l"	😢 tear
Ezekiel	**E**	"ee"	🦴 bone
Daniel	**D**	"d-d-d"	🦁 lion

Activity: hold up a big letter card; kids shout the book and do its motion. "D is for... DANIEL!" (roar and snap).

Explorers (book names)

1. Isaiah
2. Jeremiah
3. Lamentations
4. Ezekiel
5. Daniel
6. *Review:* Psalms, Proverbs, Esther, Nehemiah, Genesis

Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocabulary words)

- Book names: Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel
- Vocab: **prophet**, **exile**, **Babylon**, **covenant**, **Messiah**

Ambassadors (book names + harder vocabulary with definitions)

Word	Definition
Prophet	A person who speaks God's message to people.
Exile	Being forced to live away from your homeland (Judah's exile to Babylon, 586–538 B.C.).
Lament	A song or prayer that pours out grief or complaint to God.
Acrostic	A poem in which each line or stanza begins with the next letter of the alphabet (Lamentations 1–4).
Covenant	A binding, promise-based relationship (God's covenant with Israel; the new covenant in Jesus).
Seraphim	Heavenly beings around God's throne (Isaiah 6); the name relates to "burning ones."
Messiah	"Anointed one": the promised King from David's line (Greek: *Christos*, Christ).
Sovereign	Having supreme power and authority; God rules over all kings and nations.

Word	Definition
Apocalyptic	A type of writing with symbolic visions about God's victory at the end of history (Daniel 7–12, Revelation).

👏 Syllable-clap method

Say each name slowly and clap once per syllable, then spell it in the rhythm of the claps:

- **I-sai-ah** (3 claps) → I · S-A-I · A-H
- **Jer-e-mi-ah** (4 claps) → J-E-R · E · M-I · A-H
- **Lam-en-ta-tions** (4 claps) → L-A-M · E-N · T-A · T-I-O-N-S
- **E-ze-ki-el** (4 claps) → E · Z-E · K-I · E-L
- **Dan-iel** (2 claps) → D-A-N · I-E-L

🏃 "Spell It Out" relay

1. Make two or more teams. Write each letter of a book name on a separate index card (one set per team) and scatter the cards at the far end of the room.
2. Call out a book ("JEREMIAH!").
3. One runner at a time runs, grabs ONE letter card in the right order, and brings it back. The team lines up the cards on the floor.
4. First team to spell the word correctly and shout its motion wins the round.
5. *Little Lambs:* Run to grab the first letter only. *Ambassadors:* Spell two books back-to-back without looking at a list.

🐝 Mini spelling bee word list (with sentences)

Word	Use it in a sentence
Isaiah	**Isaiah** said, "Here am I. Send me!"
Jeremiah	**Jeremiah** watched the potter shape the clay.
Lamentations	**Lamentations** says God's love is new every morning.
Ezekiel	**Ezekiel** saw dry bones come to life.
Daniel	**Daniel** prayed three times a day.
prophet	A **prophet** tells God's message.
Babylon	**Babylon** was a big city far from Jerusalem.
furnace	The king made the **furnace** seven times hotter.
lions	God shut the mouths of the **lions**.
potter	The **potter** made a new pot from the clay.
Messiah (Ambassadors)	The prophets said the **Messiah** would come from David's family.
covenant (Ambassadors)	Jeremiah promised a new **covenant**.

📖 Read-aloud practice passage

Have Explorers and older read this aloud, one sentence each. Little Lambs can repeat the bold words.

> God sent **prophets** to His people. A prophet is God's **messenger**. **Isaiah** saw God on His throne and said, "Send me!" **Jeremiah** watched a **potter** make a pot. He cried when Jerusalem fell, and he wrote sad songs called **Lamentations**. **Ezekiel** saw dry **bones** come alive! **Daniel** prayed to God, and God shut the **lions'** mouths. All the prophets pointed to **Jesus**, the King who would come. God's **word** lasts **forever**!

Word Trivia

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. What is a prophet? (Multiple choice: a) a farmer b) God's messenger c) a king)
2. Who said, "Here am I. Send me!"?
3. True or False: Daniel was thrown into a den of hungry lions.
4. How many men did the king see walking in the fire?
5. What did the potter make out of clay?
6. Fill in the blank: "The word of our God endures _____." (Isaiah 40:8)
7. What did God do to the lions' mouths?
8. What came to life in Ezekiel's valley?
9. True or False: Daniel stopped praying when the king made a law against it.
10. What did Daniel and his friends eat instead of the king's food?
11. Which book has "Lament" (a sad song) in its name?
12. Fill in the blank: God's love is new every _____.

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

13. Who said, "I am too young"? (Who said it?)
14. Which book tells about the valley of dry bones? (Which book?)
15. What touched Isaiah's lips?
16. How many wings did each seraph have?
17. What were the names of Daniel's three friends (Babylonian names)?
18. Which king made a giant golden statue?
19. Who rescued Jeremiah from the muddy cistern?
20. Fill in the blank: "For to us a _____ is born, to us a son is given." (Isaiah 9:6)
21. Which book has the verse "For I know the plans I have for you"? (Which book?)
22. True or False: Lamentations comes right after Isaiah.
23. Who saw handwriting on the wall? (King Nebuchadnezzar or King Belshazzar?)
24. Where did Ezekiel live when he saw his visions?

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

25. Who said, "But even if he does not... we will not serve your gods"? (Who said it?)
26. Which king burned Jeremiah's scroll piece by piece?
27. Which Persian king did Isaiah name about 150 years before he was born?
28. In what year (B.C.) did Babylon destroy Jerusalem and the temple?
29. In Jeremiah 31, what new thing did God promise to make with His people?
30. Which chapter of Isaiah describes the Suffering Servant who was "pierced for our transgressions"?
31. Fill in the blank: Jesus called Himself the "Son of _____," a title from Daniel 7.
32. What was Daniel's Babylonian name?
33. True or False: Four of the five chapters of Lamentations are acrostic (alphabet) poems.
34. What are the last words of the book of Ezekiel (the new name of the city)?
35. Which New Testament passage shows Jesus reading from Isaiah 61 and saying it was fulfilled?
36. Why are these five books called "Major" Prophets?

🔑 Answer Key

1. b) God's messenger
2. Isaiah (Isaiah 6:8)
3. True (Daniel 6)
4. Four (Daniel 3:25)
5. A pot (Jeremiah 18)
6. forever
7. He shut them (Daniel 6:22)
8. Dry bones (Ezekiel 37)
9. False, he kept praying three times a day (Daniel 6:10)
10. Vegetables and water (Daniel 1:12)
11. Lamentations
12. morning (Lamentations 3:23)
13. Jeremiah (Jeremiah 1:6)
14. Ezekiel
15. A live (burning) coal from the altar (Isaiah 6:6–7)
16. Six (Isaiah 6:2)
17. Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego
18. King Nebuchadnezzar (Daniel 3)
19. Ebed-Melek (the Cushite official), with the king's permission (Jeremiah 38:7–13)
20. child
21. Jeremiah (29:11)
22. False, Jeremiah comes right after Isaiah; Lamentations comes after Jeremiah.
23. King Belshazzar (Daniel 5)
24. In Babylon, by the Kebar River (Ezekiel 1:1)
25. Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego (Daniel 3:18)
26. King Jehoiakim (Jeremiah 36:23)
27. Cyrus (Isaiah 44:28; 45:1)
28. 586 B.C. (some scholars say 587)

29. A new covenant (Jeremiah 31:31–34)
30. Isaiah 53 (beginning at 52:13)
31. Man
32. Belteshazzar (Daniel 1:7)
33. True (chapters 1–4; chapter 5 has 22 verses but is not alphabetical)
34. "THE LORD IS THERE" (Ezekiel 48:35)
35. Luke 4:16–21
36. Because they are long books, not because they are more important.

Games

🎮 Game #1: Prophet Says (Messenger Relay)

- **Best for:** All ages (great for Little Lambs & Explorers)
- **Supplies:** A paper or plastic megaphone, a list of short "messages" (e.g., "Send me!", "Hop like a lion!", "Spell DANIEL!", "Say the 5 Major Prophets!")
- **Setup:** Kids line up at one end of the room. One "prophet" (start with the teacher) stands at the other end with the megaphone.
- **How to play:** Like "Simon Says," but kids only obey when the leader begins with **"The prophet says..."** ("The prophet says: shout 'Here am I, send me!'"). If the leader gives a command without "The prophet says," anyone who obeys takes one step back. Mix in book-name commands: "The prophet says: say the book that comes after Isaiah!" Correct answer = one step forward.
- **How to win:** First player to reach the prophet becomes the next prophet.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* No "out," just giggle and keep playing; use motion commands. *Older:* Add "Before & After" book questions and verse fill-ins; whoever answers first moves two steps.
- **Learning goal:** A prophet speaks God's message, and God's people listen and obey. Reinforces book order.

🎮 Game #2: Potter's Shape-Up

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers (Little Lambs with help)
- **Supplies:** None (or picture cards of shapes: pot, lion, bones, crown, scroll, megaphone)
- **Setup:** Groups of 3–5. One player is the "Potter"; the others are "clay."
- **How to play:** The teacher calls out a shape from this month's stories ("A LION!", "A FURNACE!", "A POT!", "DRY BONES!"). The Potter has 15 seconds to gently "mold" the clay kids into that shape (clay kids can move themselves as directed; no pulling or pushing). When time is up, the teacher calls "Freeze!" and checks shapes. Then the Potter must name the **book** where that shape belongs (Lion → Daniel). Rotate Potters.
- **How to win:** Teams earn 1 point for a recognizable shape and 1 point for naming the correct book. Highest score wins.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Teacher is the Potter; kids just freeze in shapes. *Older:* Add hard shapes ("wheels within wheels," "Isaiah's seraph with six wings").
- **Learning goal:** God is the Potter; we're the clay (Jeremiah 18:6). Connects symbols to books.

🎮 Game #3: Dry Bones Freeze Tag

- **Best for:** All ages (very active)
- **Supplies:** Cones for boundaries; 1–2 "Breath" pinnies or scarves
- **Setup:** Choose 2 taggers ("Dry Wind") and 1–2 "Prophets" holding the Breath scarf.
- **How to play:** When a Dry Wind tags you, you become "dry bones": you flop down on the floor (sitting is fine). To come back to life, a Prophet must run to you and say, "Dry bones, hear the word of the LORD!" plus ask you a quick question ("Spell Ezekiel!" or "Name a Major Prophet!"). Answer it and you're "alive" again. Switch roles every 2 minutes.
- **How to win:** If the Dry Wind turns everyone into bones, they win; if the time ends with players still "alive," the Prophets win.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* The Prophet just touches you and says "LIVE!" *Older:* Questions get harder (book order, verse fill-ins, trivia).
- **Learning goal:** God's Word brings life (Ezekiel 37). Practices book names under pressure.

🎮 Game #4: Lions' Den Sneak

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers (Trailblazers as leaders)
- **Supplies:** A chair ("Daniel's prayer spot"), a blindfold (optional), a small "prayer" object such as a bean bag
- **Setup:** One child is "Daniel," kneeling at the chair. Everyone else is a lion, starting at the far wall.
- **How to play:** Similar to "Red Light, Green Light." When Daniel faces away, lions sneak forward (silently!). When Daniel turns around and says "My God shut the lions' mouths!", lions freeze with their mouths shut. Anyone caught moving or roaring goes back to the start. The first lion to tap Daniel's shoulder must say one Major Prophet (or the memory verse) and then becomes Daniel.
- **How to win:** Become the next Daniel by reaching the chair and answering correctly.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Lions crawl on all fours; any answer like "Daniel!" counts. *Older:* Lions must say all five Major Prophets in order to win.
- **Learning goal:** Daniel's faithfulness and God's protection; book-name recall.

🎮 Game #5: Major Prophet Mega-Relay

- **Best for:** All ages (review Sunday)
- **Supplies:** 5 stations with signs (Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel), a passport card per team, stickers or markers
- **Setup:** Mixed-age teams of 4–6 (Ambassadors lead teams). Each station has one task.
- **How to play:** Teams rotate through the stations in Bible order:
  - **Isaiah station:** Each person says "Here am I, send me!" and the team recites Isaiah 40:8.
  - **Jeremiah station:** Build a "pot" from play-dough together in 60 seconds and spell JEREMIAH.
  - **Lamentations station:** Do the tears-to-sunrise motion and say "New every morning!" Older kids say Lamentations 3:22–23.
  - **Ezekiel station:** Assemble a cut-up paper skeleton (the bone puzzle from Activities #3) in under 90 seconds.
  - **Daniel station:** Toss 3 bean bags into a "lions' den" box; for each miss, answer one trivia question instead.

- **How to win:** First team to collect all 5 station stamps and then sing the full Library Song (all 4 verses) wins. All teams that finish get a prize.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Little Lambs get a buddy and do motions instead of reciting. *Older:* Add a timer and hard trivia at each station.
- **Learning goal:** Review all five books in order with the key story for each.

🎮 Game #6 (bonus): Handwriting on the Wall

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors
- **Supplies:** Whiteboard or large paper
- **How to play:** Hangman style. A volunteer "writes on the wall" blanks for a book name, person or word from this phase ("NEBUCHADNEZZAR"). Teams guess letters. Each wrong guess adds a part to a drawing of a "hand" instead of a stick figure (5 fingers + palm = 6 misses).
- **How to win:** Guess the word before the hand is complete.
- **Learning goal:** Spelling the harder names; recalling Daniel 5.

Coloring Pages

> 🖍️ Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-07-printables.html`.

Page 1: "Isaiah's Vision" (Week 1)

- **Scene:** A great throne high up with a long royal robe flowing down like a waterfall to fill the bottom of the page. Two seraphim with six wings each (two covering faces, two covering feet, two spread out to fly). In the lower corner, Isaiah kneels with his hand raised. A small seraph holds tongs with a glowing coal near his lips. Smoke swirls along the edges.
- **Caption:** "Here am I. Send me!" (Isaiah 6:8)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "What color do you think God's glory looks like?" "Why did Isaiah need his sins forgiven?" "Where could God send *you* this week?"

Page 2: "Jeremiah at the Potter's House" (Week 2)

- **Scene:** A potter sitting at a spinning wheel, shaping a tall pot with wet hands. Jeremiah watches in the doorway. Shelves of finished pots line the walls. A sunrise peeks through a window (for "new every morning").
- **Caption:** "Like clay in the hand of the potter, so are you in my hand." (Jeremiah 18:6)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "What would you like God to shape in your life?" "What happens when the clay gets messed up?" "How is God's love new every morning?"

Page 3: "The Valley of Dry Bones" (Week 3)

- **Scene:** Split page. Left side: a valley full of scattered bones and dry, cracked ground. Right side: the same valley with people standing up tall, cheering, with wind swirls (God's breath) blowing through. Ezekiel stands in the middle with arms raised.
- **Caption:** "I will put my Spirit in you and you will live." (Ezekiel 37:14)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "What color should the 'before' side be? The 'after' side?" "What does God's breath do?" "How does Jesus give us new life?"

Page 4: "Daniel in the Lions' Den" (Week 4)

- **Scene:** Daniel kneeling peacefully in the center, hands folded. Lions lying around him, one yawning with its mouth closed, one resting its head on its paws. A bright angel stands behind Daniel. Above, a stone opening with a sliver of morning light and the worried king peeking in.
- **Caption:** "My God sent his angel, and he shut the mouths of the lions." (Daniel 6:22)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "How do you think Daniel felt?" "When are you scared? How can you pray then?" "Who is always with you?"

Page 5: "The Fourth Man in the Fire" (bonus)

- **Scene:** A big brick furnace with tall flames. Inside, four figures walk freely, ropes falling off. Outside, King Nebuchadnezzar leans forward with wide eyes, pointing.
- **Caption:** "Our God is able!" (from Daniel 3:17)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "Why wouldn't the friends bow to the statue?" "What does 'even if he does not' mean?"

Page 6: "God's Big Messengers" book-name page

- **Scene:** Five big megaphones arranged like a fan, each labeled with a book: ISAIAH (with coal), JEREMIAH (with pot), LAMENTATIONS (with teardrop and sun), EZEKIEL (with bone), DANIEL (with lion). Banner across the top: "MAJOR PROPHETS: 5 BOOKS." Bottom: a purple crown with "Jesus is the King they pointed to!"
- **Caption:** "The word of our God endures forever." (Isaiah 40:8)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** Say each book as you color its megaphone. "Which story is your favorite?"

Activities & Crafts

✂️ Activity #1: Megaphone Messenger Craft (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Purple cardstock or construction paper (1 sheet per child), tape, stickers, markers, the printed message "GOD'S WORD LASTS FOREVER!" and optional ribbon.
- **Steps:**
    1. Decorate the flat paper with stars, crowns and the word "PROPHET."
    2. Write (or glue) Isaiah 40:8 along one edge.

3. Roll into a cone (narrow at one end), tape it shut and trim the wide end evenly.
4. Practice: shout "Here am I, send me!" and the five Major Prophets through the megaphone.

- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-roll cones; they add stickers. *Explorers:* Write all five book names around the cone. *Trailblazers:* Write one key verse from each Major Prophet. *Ambassadors:* Help younger kids; write their own "send me" commitment inside.
- **What it teaches:** Prophets were God's messengers. We share God's message too.

🏺 Activity #2: Clay Pots with a Promise (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Air-dry clay or play-dough, toothpicks for writing, paper plates, small slips of paper with Lamentations 3:22–23 or Jeremiah 18:6 printed on them.
- **Steps:**
  1. Roll a ball of clay and press your thumb in the middle to make a "pinch pot."
  2. Use a toothpick to carve your initials and a small sun ("new every morning").
  3. If it gets lopsided, squish and start again! (Talk about God reshaping us.)
  4. Fold the verse slip and tuck it inside the pot to take home.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Play-dough only; just squish and reshape. *Explorers:* Pinch pot plus verse. *Trailblazers/Ambassadors:* Make a coil pot and carve "NEW COVENANT" or "Jer. 31:33."
- **What it teaches:** God is our Potter. He doesn't throw us away when we mess up; He reshapes us.

🦴 Activity #3: Q-tip Skeleton / Paper Bone Puzzle (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Black construction paper, cotton swabs (Q-tips), glue, white crayon or chalk, scissors. For Little Lambs: a pre-cut paper skeleton (head, body, 2 arms, 2 legs) and paper fasteners (brads).
- **Steps (Q-tip):**
  1. Draw a skull shape with white crayon at the top of the black paper.
  2. Glue cotton swabs (cut some in half) to make a spine, ribs, arms and legs.
  3. Write "Dry bones, hear the word of the LORD!" (Ezekiel 37:4) at the bottom.
  4. Add a "breath" swirl in bright color next to the skeleton.
- **Steps (paper puzzle):** Kids connect the skeleton with brads so it can "dance," then make it stand up as they say "LIVE!"
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Paper puzzle. *Explorers:* Q-tip skeleton. *Trailblazers:* Add labels for 5 real bones (skull, ribs, spine, femur, pelvis) for fun. *Ambassadors:* Write Ezekiel 36:26 and explain "new heart" to a younger buddy.
- **What it teaches:** God gives life to what was dead, a picture of new life in Jesus.

🦁 Activity #4: Lion Paper-Plate Masks (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Paper plates, yellow and orange paint or crayons, yarn or strips of orange/brown paper for the mane, craft sticks, glue, markers, scissors.
- **Steps:**
  1. Color the plate yellow.
  2. Glue strips of paper or yarn around the edge for a mane.
  3. Draw a lion face with a **closed, smiling mouth** (God shut its mouth!).

4. Cut out eye holes (teacher helps) and tape a craft stick to the bottom for a handle.
5. On the back write: "My God shut the mouths of the lions." (Daniel 6:22)

- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-cut eye holes and manes. *Explorers:* Full craft. *Trailblazers:* Write the three times Daniel prayed (morning, noon, evening idea) on the mane strips with prayer requests. *Ambassadors:* Lead the younger kids in acting out the lions' den with masks.
- **What it teaches:** God is with us and protects us when we stay faithful.

⏳ Activity #5: Prophet Timeline Wall

- **Supplies:** A long strip of butcher paper, markers, the coloring pages or printed symbols, tape.
- **Steps:**
  1. Draw a long line labeled "740 B.C." at the left and "538 B.C." at the right, with "Jesus is born" far off the right end of the paper (with an arrow).
  2. Mark: Isaiah's call (740), Assyria attacks (701), Jeremiah's call (627), Daniel taken to Babylon (605), Ezekiel taken (597), Jerusalem falls (586), Daniel in the lions' den (about 539), the Jews go home (538).
  3. Kids tape the matching symbol (coal, pot, tear, bone, lion) at each prophet's spot.
  4. Draw arrows from each prophet's "Jesus promise" pointing to the far right: "JESUS!"
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Just place the pictures where the teacher points. *Explorers:* Place pictures and say the book name. *Trailblazers:* Add the kings (Hezekiah, Josiah, Zedekiah, Nebuchadnezzar, Cyrus). *Ambassadors:* Research and add the prophecies' New Testament fulfillments.
- **What it teaches:** The prophets lived in real history, and their messages all pointed forward to Jesus.

🎭 Activity #6: "Brave in Babylon" Skit

- **Supplies:** Simple costumes (crowns, towels as robes), a cardboard "statue," a sheet as the lions' den, stuffed lions.
- **Steps:** Ambassadors direct; Trailblazers and Explorers act; Little Lambs are "lions" and the "music" (shakers). Act out Daniel 3 and Daniel 6 in two short scenes. Perform for parents at pickup or on Review Sunday.
- **What it teaches:** Courage, prayer and God's faithfulness.

Word Puzzles

🔀 Word Scramble

Unscramble these words from Phase 7.

#	Scrambled	Hint
1	HAISAI	Said "Send me!"
2	REMJIEHA	Watched a potter

#	Scrambled	Hint
3	ATIONSLAMENT	Sad songs
4	KIEELEZ	Saw dry bones
5	NIDALE	Lions' den
6	HETPORP	God's messenger
7	LYNOBAB	Big city far from home
8	ROTTEP	Works with clay
9	ENOSB	Came to life in a valley
10	CANERFU	Very hot fire
11	NSOIL	Their mouths were shut
12	VENCOTAN	A new promise

Answer key: 1. ISAIAH 2. JEREMIAH 3. LAMENTATIONS 4. EZEKIEL 5. DANIEL 6. PROPHET 7. BABYLON 8. POTTER 9. BONES 10. FURNACE 11. LIONS 12. COVENANT

✏️ Fill-in-the-Blank Story

Word bank: Daniel, coal, potter, forever, lions, Isaiah, bones, Jesus, morning, prophets, Ezekiel, Jeremiah

> God sent big messengers called _____ to His people. _____ saw God on His throne, and an angel touched his lips with a hot _____. Young _____ went to the house of a _____ and watched him shape clay. Even when Jerusalem fell, God's love was new every _____. _____ saw a valley full of dry _____ that came to life! _____ prayed even when it was against the law, and God shut the mouths of the _____. All these prophets pointed to _____. The word of our God endures _____!

Answer key: prophets, Isaiah, coal, Jeremiah, potter, morning, Ezekiel, bones, Daniel, lions, Jesus, forever

🔗 Match the Book to Its Picture / Summary

Book		Picture / Summary
1. Isaiah		A. 🦁 Brave young men in Babylon; lions' den and fiery furnace
2. Jeremiah		B. 🦴 Visions of God's glory; dry bones live
3. Lamentations		C. 🔥 "Here am I, send me!"; "For to us a child is born"
4. Ezekiel		D. ☹️ Five sad poems; "new every morning"
5. Daniel		E. 🏺 The weeping prophet; potter and clay; a new covenant

Answer key: 1–C, 2–E, 3–D, 4–B, 5–A

Questions for Every Age

Little Lambs (4–6)

1. What does a prophet do? (Tells God's message.)
2. Who did Isaiah say was coming? (Jesus, a special baby!)
3. What can you do when you feel sad? (Talk to God; He loves me every morning.)
4. Who was with Daniel in the lions' den? (God and His angel.)
5. Who can you tell about Jesus this week?

Explorers (7–10)

1. Isaiah said "Send me!" What is one way you can serve God this week?
2. Jeremiah thought he was too young. Are you too young to obey God? Why not?
3. When you mess up, what does God do? (Forgives and reshapes us when we turn to Him.)
4. Daniel prayed three times a day. When could you pray every day?
5. What is something kids are pressured to "bow down" to instead of God?

Trailblazers (11–13)

1. Why do you think God kept sending prophets when people kept ignoring them?
2. What's the difference between a fortune-teller and a biblical prophet?
3. Which promise about Jesus from these books amazes you most, and why?
4. Daniel served a pagan king well but refused to worship his gods. Where is that line for you at school?
5. How can Lamentations help someone who is grieving?

Ambassadors (14–17)

1. How does fulfilled prophecy (like Isaiah 53 or Micah 5:2) strengthen confidence in the Bible?
2. Jeremiah obeyed for 40 years with very little "success." How do you define success as a Christian?
3. How do you lament honestly to God without losing faith? (See Lamentations 3.)
4. What does "even if he does not" faith look like in real life?
5. How can you be a "watchman" (Ezekiel 33) for your friends without being preachy?

🧠 Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics / worldview)

1. "Wasn't Isaiah 53 just written after Jesus to make Him fit?" *Suggested answer:* No. The Great Isaiah Scroll found among the Dead Sea Scrolls (at Qumran, discovered in 1947) contains the whole book of Isaiah, including chapter 53, and dates to roughly 125 B.C. That's more than a hundred years before Jesus was born. The prophecy was there first.

2. "If God is loving, why would He let Jerusalem be destroyed?" *Suggested answer:* God was patient for centuries, sending prophet after prophet (2 Chronicles 36:15–16). The exile was discipline meant to restore, not to destroy forever (Jeremiah 29:10–14). A loving parent doesn't ignore destructive behavior. God's judgment and His love work together, and both meet at the cross, where Jesus took judgment for us.

3. "Some people say Daniel was written much later, after the events it 'predicts.' How should we think about that?" *Suggested answer:* Some scholars date Daniel to the 160s B.C. because its prophecies are so accurate; they assume predictive prophecy is impossible. That's a starting assumption, not a proof. Many evangelical scholars hold to a 6th-century B.C. date based on the book's own claims, Jesus' reference to "the prophet Daniel" (Matthew 24:15), and features of its language and historical detail. Also, Daniel 7 and 9 look forward to a Messiah and a kingdom that extend beyond the 160s B.C., pointing to Jesus. If God knows the future, accurate prophecy is exactly what we'd expect.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration

Review game plan (last Sunday)

1. **Welcome (10 min):** Sing all four verses of the Library Song with motions. Do the Section Shout.
2. **Speed Chant Challenge (5 min):** Each class tries to beat its best time saying the 27 books.
3. **Major Prophet Mega-Relay (25 min):** Games #5, mixed-age teams led by Ambassadors.
4. **Trivia Showdown (10 min):** Use the Word Trivia questions. Little Lambs answer ⭐ questions with a buddy.
5. **Oral check-offs (15 min):** Use the checklists below; Ambassadors and teachers listen.
6. **Passport & badge ceremony (10 min):** Stamp passports, award badges and certificates, then close in prayer.

✅ Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs (4–6)

- ☐ Says the section name: "Major Prophets"
- ☐ Says at least 3 of the 5 books (with or without motions)
- ☐ Says the Little Lambs verse: "The word of our God endures forever."
- ☐ Tells one story in a sentence (e.g., "God shut the lions' mouths.")

Explorers (7–10)

- ☐ Says all 5 Major Prophets in order
- ☐ Spells all 5 books correctly (oral or written)
- ☐ Says Isaiah 40:8 from memory
- ☐ Sings the Library Song (all 4 verses)

Trailblazers (11–13)

- [ ] Says all 27 books so far in order (no song)
- [ ] Gives a one-sentence summary of each Major Prophet
- [ ] Says Isaiah 40:8 from memory
- [ ] Names one way each Major Prophet points to Jesus

Ambassadors (14–17)

- [ ] Says all 27 books so far in order
- [ ] Says Isaiah 40:8 and explains it
- [ ] Teaches one Major Prophet (story + motion + spelling) to a younger child
- [ ] Explains why they're called "Major" and what a prophet's three-part message was

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp the **Major Prophets** page with a purple megaphone stamp (or sticker). Kids write or trace: "I know 27 of 66 books!"

🏅 Badge: "God's Big Messenger"

A round purple badge with a golden megaphone in the center, five small icons around the edge (coal, pot, teardrop-sun, bone, lion), and the words "MAJOR PROPHETS · 5 BOOKS." Make it with cardstock and a safety pin, a sticker, or an iron-on patch for a class sash.

📜 Certificate wording

> **Purpose Church Sunday School God's Big Messenger Certificate**
>
> This certifies that _____ has completed **Phase 7: God's Big Messengers** and has learned the five Major Prophets: **Isaiah · Jeremiah · Lamentations · Ezekiel · Daniel**
>
> "The grass withers and the flowers fall, but the word of our God endures forever." (Isaiah 40:8)
>
> **Books learned: 27 of 66** Teacher: _____ Date: _____

Take-Home Family Page

> ✂️ *Copy or print this section and send it home.*

Dear Families,

This month at Purpose Church, our kids are meeting **God's Big Messengers**, the Major Prophets: **Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel and Daniel**. A prophet is a messenger who speaks God's words. These prophets warned God's people to turn back to Him, comforted them in hard times, and

promised that a Rescuer-King was coming: **Jesus!** Your child now knows **27 of the 66 books** of the Bible. Please help them practice at home!

📖 **Memory Verse:**

> "The grass withers and the flowers fall, but the word of our God endures forever." (Isaiah 40:8, NIV)
>
> *Little Lambs:* "The word of our God endures forever."

🎵 **This month's song verse (tune: "Ten Little Fingers"):**

> I-sai-ah, Jer-e-mi-ah, Lam-en-ta-tions, E-ze-kiel and Dan-iel, the Ma-jor Pro-phets! I-sai-ah, Jer-e-mi-ah, Lam-en-ta-tions, E-ze-kiel, Dan-iel: FIVE!

(Ask your child to show you the hand motions: coal on lips, shaping clay, tears to sunrise, floppy bones, lion jaws!)

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions:**

1. What is a prophet? Which prophet's story did you like best?
2. Daniel prayed three times a day, even when it was hard. When could our family pray together?
3. Isaiah said a baby would be born who would be called "Prince of Peace." Who was he talking about?

👨‍👩‍👧 **Family activity: "New Every Morning" breakfast** One morning this week, have breakfast together and read Lamentations 3:22–23 aloud. Each person shares one thing they're thankful God gave them "new" today. For extra fun, stick a sticky note on the bathroom mirror: "God's love is new every morning!"

📺 **Videos to watch at home** (search these on YouTube; parents, please preview):

- **Sharefaith Kids:** "Daniel and the Lions' Den," "Isaiah," "Ezekiel Dry Bones": https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Daniel
- **Bible Journey:** "Jeremiah," "Daniel": https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Daniel
- **BibleProject (for older kids and parents):** "Overview: Isaiah 1-39," "Overview: Isaiah 40-66," "Overview: Jeremiah," "Overview: Lamentations," "Overview: Ezekiel 1-33," "Overview: Ezekiel 34-48," "Overview: Daniel": https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Isaiah

Next month: *Twelve Mighty Messengers*, the 12 Minor Prophets, including Jonah and the big fish, and the "400 Silent Years" before Jesus was born!

Phase 8: Twelve Mighty Messengers

The 12 Minor Prophets, Hosea through Malachi: short books with BIG messages, finishing the Old Testament. Plus the "400 Silent Years" bridge that leads us to Jesus.

At a Glance

Month	Month 8
Books covered	Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi (**12 books**)
Bible section(s)	Minor Prophets (Old Testament), which **completes the Old Testament (39 books)**, plus the bridge between the Testaments
Big Idea	God's twelve "short-book" messengers said: God loves you, God is fair, turn back to Him, and the King and His messenger are coming!
Memory Verse (all ages)	"He has shown you, O mortal, what is good. And what does the LORD require of you? To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God." (Micah 6:8, NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"Walk humbly with your God." (Micah 6:8)
Theme color	Ocean Blue (for Jonah's sea and the "bridge" waters we cross to the New Testament)
Phase symbol / badge	🐋 The Big Fish + 🌉 the Bridge, "Mighty Twelve" badge
Running total of books learned	**39 of 66: the WHOLE Old Testament!** (Law 5 + History 12 + Poetry/Wisdom 5 + Major Prophets 5 + Minor Prophets 12)

> Cross-links: Program Overview · Teacher Training Guide · Books of the Bible Memory System · Game Library · YouTube Video Guide · Phase 8 Printables

The Big Idea (in kid words)

The Minor Prophets are **twelve** messengers with **short** books. "Minor" means *small book*, not *small message*! Some of them warned, "Turn back to God!" Some said, "God loves you even when you run away," just like Jonah found out inside a big fish. Then, after Malachi, God was quiet for about **400 years**. But God wasn't gone. He was getting the world ready for **Jesus**!

How this points to Jesus: These little books are packed with big clues about Jesus. **Micah** said the King would be born in **Bethlehem**. **Zechariah** said the King would ride into Jerusalem on a **donkey**. **Jonah** spent three days in the fish, and Jesus said that was a picture of His three days in the tomb. **Malachi**, the very last book of the Old Testament, said, "I will send my messenger, who will prepare the way." That messenger was John the Baptist, who got people ready for Jesus. The Old Testament ends by pointing straight ahead to Jesus!

The Books in Easy Words

> **Teacher tip:** In the Hebrew Bible, these twelve were copied together on **one scroll** called "The Book of the Twelve." A good way to remember them is in **three groups of four**:
>
> - **Group 1:** Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah ("**H-J-A-O**": "**H**appy **J**ellyfish **A**te **O**ranges")
> - **Group 2:** Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk ("**J-M-N-H**": "**J**onah **M**et **N**ine **H**ungry fish")
> - **Group 3:** Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi ("**Z-H-Z-M**": "**Z**ebras **H**op, **Z**ebras **M**arch")

1. Hosea ❤️

How to say it	ho-ZAY-uh
How to spell it	Ho-se-a — **H-O-S-E-A**
Section	Minor Prophets (1 of 12)
Traditional author	Hosea son of Beeri, prophet to the northern kingdom (Israel), about 755–715 B.C.
One-sentence kid summary	God told Hosea to keep loving his wife even when she ran away, to show how God keeps loving His people even when they run from Him.
In one word	**Faithful love**
Key people	Hosea, his wife Gomer, their children Jezreel, Lo-Ruhamah ("not loved") and Lo-Ammi ("not my people"), whose names God later turns around: "loved" and "my people" (2:23)
Key stories	Hosea marries Gomer (ch. 1); God's promise to win back His people (ch. 2); Hosea buys Gomer back (ch. 3); "I desire mercy, not sacrifice" (6:6); "out of Egypt I called my son" (11:1); "Return, Israel, to the LORD your God" (ch. 14)
Where Jesus shows up	Matthew 2:15 says Jesus coming back from Egypt fulfilled Hosea 11:1. Jesus quoted Hosea 6:6 twice (Matthew 9:13; 12:7). Like Hosea paying to buy back Gomer, Jesus paid to buy us back (redeem us).
Hand motion / symbol	❤️ **"Come home!"**: stretch both arms out wide, then pull them back in to your chest like you're bringing someone home: "God's love won't quit!"

2. Joel 🦗

How to say it	JOE-ul
How to spell it	Jo-el — **J-O-E-L**
Section	Minor Prophets (2 of 12)
Traditional author	Joel son of Pethuel (Joel 1:1); his date is uncertain (suggestions range from the 800s to the 400s B.C.).
One-sentence kid summary	After a giant swarm of locusts ate up all the crops, Joel told the people to turn back to God and promised that one day God would pour out His Spirit on everyone.

In one word	**Spirit**
Key people	Joel, the people of Judah, the priests
Key stories	A huge locust plague (ch. 1); the "Day of the LORD" (ch. 2); "Rend your heart and not your garments" (2:13); "I will repay you for the years the locusts have eaten" (2:25); "I will pour out my Spirit on all people" (2:28–32)
Where Jesus shows up	On the day of Pentecost, after Jesus went back to heaven, Peter stood up and said, "This is what was spoken by the prophet Joel" (Acts 2:16–21) as the Holy Spirit came. Joel 2:32, "Everyone who calls on the name of the LORD will be saved," is quoted in Romans 10:13 about Jesus.
Hand motion / symbol	🦗 **Locust swarm**: wiggle all ten fingers in the air and buzz!

3. Amos 📏

How to say it	AY-mus
How to spell it	A-mos — **A-M-O-S**
Section	Minor Prophets (3 of 12)
Traditional author	Amos, a shepherd and fig-tree farmer from Tekoa in Judah (Amos 1:1; 7:14), who preached to the northern kingdom about 760–750 B.C.
One-sentence kid summary	God sent a shepherd named Amos to tell rich people to stop being unfair to the poor, because God wants justice to flow like a river.
In one word	**Justice** (fairness)
Key people	Amos, King Jeroboam II, Amaziah the priest of Bethel
Key stories	God's roar against the nations, then Israel (ch. 1–2); the "cows of Bashan" (rich, greedy women, 4:1); "Let justice roll on like a river" (5:24); the plumb line vision (7:7–8); Amaziah tells Amos to go home (7:10–17); the basket of ripe fruit (ch. 8); God will rebuild David's fallen shelter (9:11)
Where Jesus shows up	James quoted Amos 9:11–12 in Acts 15:16–17 to show that Jesus' kingdom welcomes all nations. Jesus is the King from David's family who rebuilds the "fallen tent." Jesus also cared deeply for the poor (Luke 4:18).
Hand motion / symbol	📏 **Plumb line**: hold one fist up high and let a pretend string drop straight down: "Is it straight?"

4. Obadiah ☝️

How to say it	oh-buh-DIE-uh
How to spell it	O-ba-di-ah — **O-B-A-D-I-A-H**
Section	Minor Prophets (4 of 12)
Traditional author	Obadiah (his name means "servant of the LORD"), probably soon after Jerusalem fell in 586 B.C.

One-sentence kid summary	Obadiah, the shortest book in the Old Testament (just 21 verses), warned the nation of Edom that it would be punished for cheering when Jerusalem was hurt.
In one word	**Pride**
Key people	Obadiah, the nation of Edom (descendants of Esau, Jacob's twin brother)
Key stories	Proud Edom lives high in the rocky cliffs (v. 3–4); Edom stood by and gloated when Jerusalem fell (v. 10–14); "As you have done, it will be done to you" (v. 15); "the kingdom will be the LORD's" (v. 21)
Where Jesus shows up	Obadiah ends with "the kingdom will be the LORD's" (v. 21). Jesus came preaching "the kingdom of God has come near" (Mark 1:15). Jesus teaches us to love even our enemies instead of cheering when they fall.
Hand motion / symbol	☝️ **One finger**: hold up one finger: "Obadiah: one chapter!"

5. Jonah 🐋

How to say it	JOE-nuh
How to spell it	Jo-nah — **J-O-N-A-H**
Section	Minor Prophets (5 of 12)
Traditional author	About Jonah son of Amittai, a prophet in the days of King Jeroboam II (2 Kings 14:25), around 780–750 B.C.
One-sentence kid summary	Jonah ran away from God, got swallowed by a big fish, and finally preached to Nineveh, where everyone said sorry to God, showing that God loves even enemies.
In one word	**Second chance**
Key people	Jonah, the sailors, the king and people of Nineveh (capital of Assyria)
Key stories	Jonah runs the opposite way on a ship to Tarshish (ch. 1); the storm; thrown overboard; swallowed by a great fish for three days and three nights (1:17); Jonah prays inside the fish: "Salvation comes from the LORD" (ch. 2); Nineveh repents (ch. 3); Jonah pouts under a plant, and God teaches him about mercy (ch. 4)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus said, "For as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of a huge fish, so the Son of Man will be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth" (Matthew 12:40), a picture of His death and resurrection. Jesus is "greater than Jonah" (Matthew 12:41).
Hand motion / symbol	🐋 **Fish gulp**: put your hands together like a fish's mouth, open wide and "GULP!"

6. Micah 🏘️

How to say it	MY-kuh
How to spell it	Mi-cah — **M-I-C-A-H**
Section	Minor Prophets (6 of 12)

Traditional author	Micah of Moresheth, a small-town prophet in Judah, about 735–700 B.C., at the same time as Isaiah
One-sentence kid summary	Micah told God's people to be fair, kind and humble, and he said the great King would be born in little Bethlehem.
In one word	**Bethlehem**
Key people	Micah, Kings Jotham, Ahaz and Hezekiah (1:1)
Key stories	Swords will be turned into plowshares (4:3); "But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah… out of you will come for me one who will be ruler over Israel" (5:2); "act justly… love mercy… walk humbly" (6:8); God hurls our sins into the depths of the sea (7:19)
Where Jesus shows up	When the wise men asked where the King would be born, the chief priests quoted Micah 5:2: Bethlehem! (Matthew 2:1–6). Micah also said this Ruler's "origins are from of old, from ancient times." Jesus existed before He was born.
Hand motion / symbol	🏘️ **Little town**: make a tiny roof with your fingertips: "Little Bethlehem!"

7. Nahum 🏰

How to say it	NAY-hum
How to spell it	Na-hum — **N-A-H-U-M**
Section	Minor Prophets (7 of 12)
Traditional author	Nahum the Elkoshite (1:1), between 663 and 612 B.C. (his name means "comfort")
One-sentence kid summary	About 100+ years after Jonah, Nineveh went back to being cruel, so Nahum announced that God would stop Nineveh, which was comforting news for everyone they had hurt.
In one word	**Comfort** (God stops bullies)
Key people	Nahum, the city of Nineveh (Assyria)
Key stories	"The LORD is slow to anger but great in power" (1:3); "The LORD is good, a refuge in times of trouble" (1:7); "Look, there on the mountains, the feet of one who brings good news" (1:15); the fall of Nineveh (ch. 2–3), which happened in 612 B.C.
Where Jesus shows up	"The feet of one who brings good news, who proclaims peace!" (1:15; see Isaiah 52:7 and Romans 10:15). Jesus brings the best good news. Jesus will one day end all evil and cruelty forever.
Hand motion / symbol	🏰 **Tower tumbles**: stack fists on top of each other high, then let them crumble down.

8. Habakkuk ❓

How to say it	huh-BAK-uk
How to spell it	Ha-bak-kuk — **H-A-B-A-K-K-U-K** (tip: double K in the middle! "Ha-BAK-KUK," like a chicken: "bak-kuk!")

Section	Minor Prophets (8 of 12)
Traditional author	Habakkuk, in Judah about 610–600 B.C., just before Babylon invaded
One-sentence kid summary	Habakkuk asked God hard "Why?" questions, waited for God's answer, and decided to trust and rejoice in God even when everything went wrong.
In one word	**Trust**
Key people	Habakkuk, the Babylonians
Key stories	"How long, LORD, must I call for help?" (1:2); God's surprising answer: He will use Babylon (1:5–11); Habakkuk climbs his watchtower to wait (2:1); "The righteous person will live by his faithfulness" (2:4); "The earth will be filled with the knowledge of the glory of the LORD as the waters cover the sea" (2:14); "Though the fig tree does not bud… yet I will rejoice in the LORD" (3:17–18)
Where Jesus shows up	Habakkuk 2:4 is quoted three times in the New Testament (Romans 1:17; Galatians 3:11; Hebrews 10:38) to explain that we are made right with God by faith in Jesus.
Hand motion / symbol	👀 **Watchtower**: hand over your eyes like you're looking far away: "Watch and wait!"

9. Zephaniah 🎶

How to say it	zef-uh-NIE-uh
How to spell it	Zeph-a-ni-ah — **Z-E-P-H-A-N-I-A-H** (tip: "PH" makes the "F" sound.)
Section	Minor Prophets (9 of 12)
Traditional author	Zephaniah, a great-great-grandson of King Hezekiah (1:1), in the days of King Josiah (about 640–609 B.C.)
One-sentence kid summary	Zephaniah warned about the "Day of the LORD," but ended with a happy promise that God will rejoice over His people with singing.
In one word	**Singing**
Key people	Zephaniah, King Josiah
Key stories	The Day of the LORD is near (ch. 1); "Seek the LORD, all you humble of the land" (2:3); judgment on the nations (ch. 2); "The LORD your God is with you, the Mighty Warrior who saves. He will take great delight in you… but will rejoice over you with singing" (3:17)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus is the "Mighty Warrior who saves" who is "with you" (Immanuel). Jesus said heaven throws a party when one sinner repents (Luke 15:7, 10).
Hand motion / symbol	🎶 **Song from the heart**: hands start at your heart and float outward like music notes.

10. Haggai 🔨

How to say it	HAG-eye
How to spell it	Hag-gai — **H-A-G-G-A-I** (tip: double G! "HAG-GAI," and it ends in "A-I.")

Section	Minor Prophets (10 of 12)
Traditional author	Haggai, after the people came home from Babylon; all four of his messages are dated to 520 B.C.
One-sentence kid summary	Haggai told the people who had come home from exile to stop working only on their own houses and finish building God's temple.
In one word	**Build**
Key people	Haggai, Zerubbabel the governor, Joshua the high priest (see Ezra 5:1)
Key stories	"Is it a time for you yourselves to be living in your paneled houses, while this house remains a ruin?" (1:4); "Give careful thought to your ways" (1:5, 7); the people obey and start building (1:12–15); "The glory of this present house will be greater than the glory of the former house" (2:9); Zerubbabel like a signet ring (2:23)
Where Jesus shows up	Zerubbabel is in Jesus' family line (Matthew 1:12). Jesus Himself came to the rebuilt temple, which made its glory "greater." Jesus called His body the true temple (John 2:19–21).
Hand motion / symbol	🔨 **Hammer + roof**: pound one fist on the other palm twice, then make a roof over your head with both hands: "Build God's house!"

11. Zechariah 🫏

How to say it	zek-uh-RYE-uh
How to spell it	Zech-a-ri-ah — **Z-E-C-H-A-R-I-A-H** (tip: "CH" sounds like "K" here.)
Section	Minor Prophets (11 of 12)
Traditional author	Zechariah son of Berekiah, son of Iddo (1:1), a priest-prophet who started in 520 B.C., at the same time as Haggai
One-sentence kid summary	Zechariah encouraged the people with eight night visions and many promises about the coming King, including that He would ride into Jerusalem on a donkey.
In one word	**King** (on a donkey)
Key people	Zechariah, Zerubbabel, Joshua the high priest, angels
Key stories	Eight night visions (ch. 1–6), including horses, a measuring line, Joshua the high priest getting clean clothes, and a golden lampstand: "'Not by might nor by power, but by my Spirit,' says the LORD Almighty" (4:6); the King on a donkey (9:9); thirty pieces of silver (11:12–13); "They will look on me, the one they have pierced" (12:10); "Strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered" (13:7); the LORD stands on the Mount of Olives (14:4)
Where Jesus shows up	Everywhere! Jesus rode into Jerusalem on a donkey on Palm Sunday (Matthew 21:4–5; John 12:14–15). Judas was paid thirty pieces of silver (Matthew 26:15; 27:9–10). Jesus quoted "strike the shepherd" (Matthew 26:31). John 19:37 says Jesus' pierced side fulfilled 12:10.
Hand motion / symbol	🫏 **Donkey ride**: hold pretend reins and bounce gently: "Here comes the King!"

12. Malachi 📣

How to say it	MAL-uh-kie
How to spell it	Mal-a-chi — **M-A-L-A-C-H-I** (tip: ends in "CHI," which sounds like "KYE.")
Section	Minor Prophets (12 of 12), the **last book of the Old Testament**
Traditional author	Malachi (the name means "my messenger"), about 450–430 B.C., around the time of Nehemiah
One-sentence kid summary	Malachi told the people to stop giving God their leftovers and promised that God would send a messenger to get everyone ready for the Lord.
In one word	**Messenger**
Key people	Malachi, the priests, the people of Judah; "Elijah" (the coming messenger)
Key stories	"I have loved you," says the LORD (1:2); priests offering blind, lame and sick animals (1:6–14); "Will a mere mortal rob God?" Bring the whole tithe (3:8–10); "I the LORD do not change" (3:6); "I will send my messenger, who will prepare the way before me" (3:1); "the sun of righteousness will rise with healing in its rays" (4:2); "I will send the prophet Elijah to you before that great and dreadful day of the LORD comes" (4:5–6)
Where Jesus shows up	The messenger "preparing the way" is John the Baptist (Mark 1:2; Matthew 11:10). Jesus said John was the "Elijah who was to come" (Matthew 11:14; see Luke 1:17). Then the Lord Himself, Jesus, came to His temple!
Hand motion / symbol	📣 **Point ahead**: cup one hand by your mouth and point far forward with the other: "He's coming!"

Section summary: The Minor Prophets (12)

#	Book	One word	Motion
1	Hosea	Faithful love	Arms out, pull back in ("Come home!")
2	Joel	Spirit	Locust fingers
3	Amos	Justice	Plumb line
4	Obadiah	Pride	One finger
5	Jonah	Second chance	Fish gulp
6	Micah	Bethlehem	Tiny roof
7	Nahum	Comfort	Tower tumbles
8	Habakkuk	Trust	Watchtower
9	Zephaniah	Singing	Song from the heart
10	Haggai	Build	Hammer, then roof over head
11	Zechariah	King on a donkey	Donkey ride
12	Malachi	Messenger	Point ahead

🌉 Bonus: The Bridge, "The 400 Silent Years"

What it is	Not a book! It's the time *between* Malachi (the last Old Testament book, about 430 B.C.) and the first events in the New Testament (about 6–5 B.C.).
How to say it	"The Four Hundred Silent Years" (also called the "intertestamental period," IN-ter-tes-ta-MEN-tal, meaning "between the Testaments")
One-sentence kid summary	For about 400 years God didn't send any new prophets or Bible books, but He was busy getting the whole world ready for Jesus.
In one word	**Waiting** (and **Getting Ready**)
Key people & empires	The Persians; Alexander the Great (Greece); Judas Maccabeus ("the Hammer"); the Romans; Herod the Great
Key events	Greek becomes the common language; the Old Testament is translated into Greek (the Septuagint); a wicked king (Antiochus IV) messes up the temple; the Maccabees take it back and rededicate it (that's where Hanukkah comes from, see John 10:22); Rome takes over; roads are built; people long for the Messiah
Where Jesus shows up	"But when the set time had fully come, God sent his Son" (Galatians 4:4). The silence is broken when the angel Gabriel (the same angel from Daniel!) visits a priest named Zechariah in the temple to announce John the Baptist (Luke 1).
Hand motion / symbol	🌉 **Bridge**: make an arch with one arm from left to right while you whisper "shhh" (silent), then shout "JESUS!" at the end

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher

Why "Minor"? "Minor" means *shorter*, not *less important*. Their combined length is about the size of Isaiah. In the Hebrew Bible they were copied onto a single scroll called "The Twelve."

Order isn't strictly chronological. The twelve are arranged roughly by time, with the earlier (Assyrian-era) prophets first and the post-exile prophets last, but not perfectly. Here's a simple timeline to keep in your head:

Era	Approx. date (B.C.)	Prophets	Main audience
Assyrian era (before the North fell in 722)	780–700	Jonah, Amos, Hosea, Micah (Joel's date uncertain)	Jonah → Nineveh; Amos & Hosea → Israel (North); Micah → Judah (South)
Before Babylon (Judah alone)	663–600	Nahum, Zephaniah, Habakkuk	Nahum → Nineveh's fall; Zephaniah & Habakkuk → Judah
After Jerusalem falls	after 586	Obadiah	Edom
After the return home	520–430	Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi	The returned exiles in Jerusalem

Connections to earlier phases:

- Jonah and Amos ministered under **Jeroboam II** (2 Kings 14:23–25), from Phase 4.
- Micah ministered under **Hezekiah**, alongside **Isaiah** (Phase 7). Jeremiah 26:18 quotes Micah!
- Zephaniah ministered under **Josiah**, the boy king who found the Book of the Law (Phase 4).
- Haggai and Zechariah are named in **Ezra 5:1 and 6:14** (Phase 5); they encouraged the rebuilding of the temple, finished in 516 B.C.
- Malachi likely ministered around the time of **Nehemiah** (Phase 5); both deal with careless worship, tithing and marriage problems.

Recurring themes in the Twelve:

1. **The Day of the LORD:** a coming day when God sets everything right, bad news for the proud and wicked, good news for the humble (Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Zephaniah, Malachi).
2. **God's covenant love (hesed):** God's loyal, never-quitting love (Hosea, Micah 7:18–20, Jonah 4:2).
3. **Justice for the poor:** God hates religious show without kindness and fairness (Amos, Micah).
4. **God over all nations:** God cares about Nineveh, judges Edom and Assyria, and plans to bless all nations (Jonah, Nahum, Obadiah, Zechariah 8:20–23).
5. **The coming King and His messenger** (Micah 5, Zechariah 9–14, Malachi 3–4).

🌉 Bridge background: the 400 "Silent" Years (teacher notes)

"Silent" means **no new inspired prophet or Scripture** between Malachi and John the Baptist. It does **not** mean God was absent. Daniel had already predicted some of these empires (Daniel 2, 7, 8, 11). Here is a simple timeline:

Approx. date	What happened	Why it matters for the Gospels
~430 B.C.	Malachi's ministry; Nehemiah's governorship; Persia rules	The Old Testament closes.
333–332 B.C.	**Alexander the Great** (Greece) conquers the Persian Empire, including Judea	**Greek** becomes the common language of the Mediterranean world; the New Testament will be written in everyday (Koine) Greek.
323 B.C.	Alexander dies; his generals split his empire. The **Ptolemies** (Egypt) control Judea for about a century.	
~250 B.C. (3rd century)	Jewish scholars in Alexandria, Egypt, begin translating the Hebrew Scriptures into Greek: the **Septuagint** (often abbreviated LXX).	Non-Jews could now read God's Word; the apostles often quoted it.
198 B.C.	The **Seleucids** (Syria) take control of Judea.	
167 B.C.	Seleucid king **Antiochus IV Epiphanes** outlaws Jewish worship and defiles the temple with a pagan altar and sacrifice.	Compare Daniel 11:31.

Approx. date	What happened	Why it matters for the Gospels
167–164 B.C.	The **Maccabean revolt**: a priest named Mattathias and his sons, led by **Judas Maccabeus** ("the Hammer"), fight back. In 164 B.C. they cleanse and rededicate the temple.	This is the origin of **Hanukkah**, the "Festival of Dedication," which Jesus attended (John 10:22–23).
164–63 B.C.	Jewish self-rule under the Hasmonean family. Groups like the **Pharisees** and **Sadducees** form; **synagogues** spread.	These groups and synagogues appear all through the Gospels.
63 B.C.	Roman general **Pompey** captures Jerusalem; **Rome** takes over.	Roman roads, Roman peace (Pax Romana), Roman soldiers, taxes and crosses appear in the Gospels.
37 B.C.	**Herod the Great**, appointed by Rome, becomes king of Judea (ruling until 4 B.C.); about 20/19 B.C. he begins a massive rebuilding of the temple.	The Herod of Matthew 2; the temple of the Gospels (John 2:20, "forty-six years to build").
27 B.C.	**Caesar Augustus** becomes the first Roman emperor.	His census brings Mary and Joseph to Bethlehem (Luke 2:1).
~6–5 B.C.	Gabriel appears to **Zechariah the priest** in the temple (Luke 1).	**The silence is broken!**
~6–4 B.C.	**Jesus is born** in Bethlehem (Herod died in 4 B.C., so Jesus was born a little before that).	"When the set time had fully come, God sent his Son" (Galatians 4:4).

Three ways God "prepared the stage": (1) **One language** (Greek) for spreading the gospel; (2) **Roads and peace** (Rome) for travel; (3) **A hungry heart**: synagogues full of Scripture and people longing for the Messiah (Luke 2:25, 38).

A note on the Apocrypha. Catholic and Orthodox Bibles include some books written during this period (such as 1 and 2 Maccabees), called the Apocrypha or Deuterocanonical books. Protestant Christians value some of them as helpful history (1 Maccabees is a key source for the Hanukkah story), but don't count them as Scripture, in line with the Hebrew Bible Jesus used. If a kid asks, keep it simple and respectful: "Some Bibles include extra history books from this time. In our church we read them as history, not as God's Word."

Key truths to emphasize

- **God's love doesn't quit** (Hosea, Jonah).
- **God cares how we treat others**: fairness, kindness, humility (Amos, Micah 6:8).
- **We can bring God our hard questions** and still trust Him (Habakkuk).
- **God gives second chances**, to Jonah and to Nineveh.
- **Put God first** (Haggai, Malachi).
- **God keeps His promises on His schedule**: 400 years of waiting ended with Jesus right on time.

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
Hosea's unfaithful wife (Gomer)	"Hosea's wife ran away and stopped loving him back, but Hosea kept loving her and brought her home."	Same; "She loved other things more than her husband."	"She was unfaithful to her marriage." Explain that it pictures Israel worshiping idols.	Discuss the marriage metaphor for covenant and idolatry plainly but modestly. Skip the explicit language in ch. 2.
Nineveh's cruelty / Nahum's destruction	"Nineveh was a mean city that hurt people."	Assyria was cruel to many nations; God stopped them.	Discuss God's patience (Jonah, ~150 years earlier) and justice (Nahum).	Discuss justice, wrath and mercy; why God's judgment is good news for victims.
Jonah thrown overboard	Focus on the fish as God's rescue.	Tell the full story.	Discuss Jonah's choice and the sailors' fear of God.	Discuss Jonah's racism/nationalism; he wanted his enemies destroyed.
Day of the LORD / judgment language	"One day God will make everything right."	God will judge evil; people who trust Him have nothing to fear.	Explore both sides: dark for the proud, bright for the humble (Malachi 4:1–2).	Connect to the second coming and final judgment.
Antiochus defiling the temple	Skip details: "A bad king messed up God's temple."	Same, plus the Maccabees cleaning it.	Mention the pagan altar and sacrifice.	Discuss persecution and faithfulness, and Daniel 11 connections.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

1. **"Could a person really live inside a fish?"** God made the fish and sent it to save Jonah (Jonah 1:17). It was a miracle. Jesus talked about Jonah as a real event (Matthew 12:40–41), so we believe it too. The Bible says "a huge fish," not specifically a whale.
2. **"Why did Jonah run away?"** Nineveh was the capital of Assyria, an enemy nation that was very cruel. Jonah didn't want God to forgive them (Jonah 4:2). God wanted to show that His love is for everyone.
3. **"What does 'walk humbly' mean?"** It means living close to God, knowing He is the boss, and not acting like we're better than other people.
4. **"Why was God quiet for 400 years?"** God was waiting for exactly the right time (Galatians 4:4). He had already said everything the people needed until the Messiah came. He was quietly getting the world ready.
5. **"Is God quiet now?"** No! God has spoken to us through His Son, Jesus (Hebrews 1:1–2), and through the Bible, and the Holy Spirit lives in everyone who trusts Jesus.
6. **"What's a tithe?"** A tithe means "a tenth." God's people gave a tenth of their crops and animals to God. Malachi said bringing it showed they trusted God to provide.

7. **"Who is the Elijah Malachi talks about?"** Jesus said it was John the Baptist, who came "in the spirit and power of Elijah" (Luke 1:17; Matthew 11:14). He wasn't Elijah come back to life, but a prophet like him.
8. **"Why do Zechariah and Malachi seem confusing?"** They have visions and symbols, kind of like a picture puzzle. We focus on the clear parts, especially the promises about Jesus.

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
1	Hosea 3:1–5; 11:1–4; Joel 2:12–13, 28; Amos 5:24; 7:7–8; Obadiah 15	"Love That Won't Quit" (Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah)	God loves us faithfully and wants us to be fair and humble.	BibleProject "Overview: Hosea," "Joel," "Amos," "Obadiah"; Sharefaith Kids "Hosea"; Bible Journey "Amos"	Minor Prophet Line-Up Race	Heart Chain / Plumb Line Craft
2	Jonah 1–4; Micah 5:2; 6:8; Nahum 1:7	"Jonah Runs, God Rescues" (Jonah, Micah, Nahum)	God gives second chances and loves everyone, even enemies.	BibleProject "Overview: Jonah," "Micah," "Nahum"; Sharefaith Kids "Jonah"; Bible Journey "Jonah"	Jonah Overboard!	Paper-Bag Big Fish
3	Habakkuk 1:2; 2:1–4; 3:17–19; Zephaniah 3:17; Haggai 1:2–8, 12–14; Zechariah 4:6; 9:9	"Watch, Build & Trust" (Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah)	Trust God when life is hard, put Him first, and look for the King.	BibleProject "Overview: Habakkuk," "Zephaniah," "Haggai," "Zechariah"; Sharefaith Kids "Haggai Rebuild"; Bible Journey "Zechariah"	Temple Builders Relay	Palm-Branch Donkey Parade
4	Malachi 3:1, 6; 4:2, 5–6; Galatians 4:4; Luke 1:5–17	"The Messenger Is Coming" (Malachi + 🌉 the 400 Silent Years)	God was quiet but not gone; He got the world ready for Jesus right on time.	BibleProject "Overview: Malachi" & theme video "Messiah"; Sharefaith Kids "Zechariah and Elizabeth"; Bible Journey "Between the Testaments" / "Malachi"	Cross the Silent Bridge	Bridge Timeline Walk

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🧨 Activity
5 *(optional)*	Review: all 39 OT books	"Old Testament Graduation Sunday"	We know the whole Old Testament, and it all points to Jesus!	Favorite clips + BibleProject "The Covenants"	Old Testament Library Sort	Passport Stamp, Badge & OT Graduation

Weekly Lessons

Week 1: "Love That Won't Quit" (Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah)

Scripture: Hosea 3:1–5; 11:1–4; Joel 2:12–13, 28; Amos 5:24; 7:7–8; Obadiah 15

Lesson goal: Kids will learn the first four Minor Prophets, that God's love for His people never quits (Hosea), that God wants our hearts to turn back to Him (Joel), and that God cares about fairness (Amos) and humility (Obadiah).

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Rubber Band Love"

- *Supplies:* A sturdy rubber band, a toy heart or red paper heart, a string with a weight tied on (a washer or key) to be a "plumb line," a ruler.
- *Do:* Stretch the rubber band far: "No matter how far it stretches, it pulls back to where it belongs." Say: "God's love is like that. When His people ran far away, His love pulled them back. Today we meet a prophet whose own family showed God's never-quitting love." Then hold up the plumb line: "Builders use this to see if a wall is straight. God used it to show a prophet named Amos something too!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Once there was a prophet named Hosea. God told him to do something very hard. "Hosea, marry a woman named Gomer, and keep loving her, even though she won't always love you back."
>
> Hosea obeyed. He married Gomer, and they had three children. But Gomer stopped loving Hosea. She ran away and chased after other things she thought would make her happy. That broke Hosea's heart.
>
> Then God said something surprising: "Go, show your love to your wife again." Hosea found Gomer. She was in a lot of trouble and had become like a slave. So Hosea paid fifteen pieces of silver and some barley to buy her back! He brought her home and said, "You are mine, and I am yours."
>
> Why did God ask Hosea to do this? Because it was a picture of God's own love! God's people kept running away from Him and loving fake gods. But God said, "When Israel was a child, I loved him... I led them with cords of human kindness, with ties of love." God would not give up on them.

> God sent other messengers too. A prophet named **Joel** saw a giant swarm of locusts, grasshopper-like bugs, eat every plant in the land. Joel said, "Return to the LORD your God, for he is gracious and compassionate!" And God made a wonderful promise through Joel: "I will pour out my Spirit on all people."
>
> Next, God chose a shepherd and farmer named **Amos**. Amos was not a fancy preacher. He took care of sheep and fig trees! But God sent him to the rich people of Israel, who were being unfair to the poor. God showed Amos a plumb line, a string with a weight that hangs perfectly straight. God said, "I'm measuring my people. Are they straight or crooked?" Amos shouted, "Let justice roll on like a river!"
>
> Finally, the prophet **Obadiah** wrote the shortest book in the Old Testament, just one chapter! He warned the proud nation of Edom, "You cheered when Jerusalem was hurt. As you have done, it will be done to you."
>
> Hosea, Joel, Amos and Obadiah all said: Come back to God. Be fair. Be humble. And God's love will not quit. Years later, Jesus came to buy us back, not with silver, but with His own life on the cross. That's love that never quits!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Keep it to the main idea: *God loves me even when I run away.* Play "run and come back": kids "run" (walk) to the wall, then you call "Come back, I love you!" and they run back for a hug (high five).
- **Explorers:** Learn Group 1 with the sentence "Happy Jellyfish Ate Oranges" (Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah). Make a real plumb line with string and a washer and check the classroom door.
- **Trailblazers:** Read Hosea 3 and 1 Peter 1:18–19 (redeemed "not with perishable things such as silver or gold... but with the precious blood of Christ"). Read Acts 2:16–21 and see Joel quoted at Pentecost.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Amos 5:21–24: God rejected worship that came with injustice. What would Amos say to churches today? Discuss Obadiah's warning about gloating over enemies (compare Proverbs 24:17).

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Did Hosea keep loving his wife? (Yes!) (2) Does God keep loving you? (Yes!) (3) What bugs did Joel see? (Locusts / grasshoppers!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What did Hosea pay to bring Gomer home? (Fifteen silver pieces and barley.) (2) What was Amos's job before he was a prophet? (Shepherd and fig farmer.) (3) Which book is only one chapter long? (Obadiah.)
- *Trailblazers:* (1) How is Hosea's story like the gospel? (2) What does a plumb line show, and what was God "measuring"? (3) Where is Joel 2:28 quoted in the New Testament?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Why do you think God used a marriage to picture His covenant? (2) What injustices would Amos speak against today? (3) How do you respond when someone you don't like gets in trouble?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Hosea" (or "Minor Prophets")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Hosea
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Amos" / "Hosea"	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Amos
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Hosea," "Overview: Joel," "Overview: Amos," "Overview: Obadiah" (each about 6–8 min; pick one or two)	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Hosea

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) What did the video show about God's love for His people? (2) What did God want His people to change?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Minor Prophet Line-Up Race*, see Games #1.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Never-Quitting Heart Chain* and *Plumb Line Craft*, see Activities #1. Coloring Page 1: "Hosea Brings Gomer Home."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Introduce Micah 6:8 (all ages) and "Walk humbly with your God" (Little Lambs). Spell **H-O-S-E-A**, **J-O-E-L**, **A-M-O-S**, **O-B-A-D-I-A-H**. Learn Group 1: "Happy Jellyfish Ate Oranges."

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, thank You that Your love never quits, even when we run away. Help us to be fair and kind and humble. Thank You for Jesus, who brought us back to You. Amen.

Week 2: "Jonah Runs, God Rescues" (Jonah, Micah, Nahum)

Scripture: Jonah 1–4 (key verses 1:1–3, 17; 2:9–10; 3:10; 4:2, 11); Micah 5:2; 6:8; Nahum 1:7

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that God gives second chances, that God loves all people (even enemies), that Micah said Jesus would be born in Bethlehem, and that God is a safe place in trouble (Nahum).

Opening hook / object lesson: "Which Way?"

- *Supplies:* Two signs: "NINEVEH →" and "← TARSHISH," a toy boat or paper boat, a spray bottle of water (for "storm" mist, optional), a blue sheet.
- *Do:* Put the signs on opposite walls. "God told someone to go THIS way (point to Nineveh). Which way do you think he went?" Have a volunteer walk toward Tarshish with the boat. "Uh oh. Let's find out what happens when we run from God!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> God spoke to a prophet named Jonah. "Go to the great city of Nineveh and preach against it, because the people there are doing very wicked things."
>
> But Jonah did NOT want to go to Nineveh. The people there were enemies of Israel, and they were mean and cruel. So Jonah ran away! He went down to the port city of Joppa and got on a ship going to Tarshish, the opposite direction, as far away as he could go!
>
> But you can't run away from God. God sent a great wind, and a huge storm crashed over the sea. *Whoosh! Crash!* The ship was about to break apart! The sailors were terrified. They threw their cargo overboard. They prayed to their gods. But Jonah was asleep down below!
>
> The captain woke him up. "How can you sleep? Get up and call on your God!"
>
> The sailors figured out that the storm was because of Jonah. Jonah said, "I worship the LORD, the God who made the sea and the dry land. I'm running from Him. Throw me into the sea, and it will become calm."
>
> The sailors didn't want to, but finally they did. *SPLASH!* And immediately the sea became calm.
>
> But God wasn't done with Jonah. God sent a huge fish to swallow him up! *GULP!* Jonah was inside the fish for three days and three nights. Inside that dark, smelly fish, Jonah prayed. "In my distress I called to the LORD, and he answered me... Salvation comes from the LORD!"
>
> Then God commanded the fish, and it spit Jonah out onto dry land. *BLEH!*
>
> God said again, "Go to Nineveh." This time Jonah went! He walked through the city shouting, "Forty more days and Nineveh will be overthrown!" And guess what? The people of Nineveh believed God! From the king all the way down to the poorest person, they said sorry to God and stopped doing evil. Even the king got off his throne and sat in the dust! So God had mercy and didn't destroy them.
>
> But Jonah was grumpy! "I knew you were gracious and compassionate, slow to anger and full of love," he complained. Jonah wanted his enemies punished. God gently taught Jonah: "Shouldn't I care about this great city with so many people?"
>
> God loves everyone, even people we don't like. Jesus said that Jonah's three days in the fish were a picture of His own three days in the tomb. Then Jesus came back to life, so that people from every city and nation could be saved!

Add-on (1 minute): "Two more prophets this week! **Micah** told us something amazing: the King would be born in little **Bethlehem**, and that's exactly where Jesus was born! And Micah gave us our memory verse: act justly, love mercy, walk humbly with your God. **Nahum** said that, years later, Nineveh went back to being cruel, so God finally stopped them. But Nahum also said, 'The LORD is good, a refuge in times of trouble.'"

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Act it out on a blue sheet "sea": rock the boat, splash, then everyone hides under the sheet (inside the fish) and counts "1, 2, 3 days!", then "BLEH!" and they pop out. Main idea: *God gives second chances.*
- **Explorers:** Use the "Which Way?" signs to retell the story with kids walking the route. Learn Group 2: "Jonah Met Nine Hungry fish" (Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk).
- **Trailblazers:** Read Matthew 12:38–41 and Matthew 2:1–6. Find Nineveh, Joppa and Tarshish (likely in Spain) on a map; notice how far opposite Jonah ran.
- **Ambassadors:** The book ends with a question (4:11) and no answer from Jonah. Why? Who is the "Nineveh" in your life, the person you'd rather God not bless? Discuss Nahum as the "sequel" to Jonah: God's patience has limits.

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What swallowed Jonah? (A big fish!) (2) Did God give Jonah another chance? (Yes!) (3) Where was Jesus born? (Bethlehem!)
- *Explorers:* (1) Why did Jonah run away? (2) What did Jonah do inside the fish? (He prayed.) (3) What did the people of Nineveh do when they heard God's message?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why was Jonah angry when God forgave Nineveh? (2) How is Jonah's "three days" like Jesus? (3) What are the three things Micah 6:8 says God requires?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Who were more obedient to God in Jonah 1, the pagan sailors or the prophet? What does that show? (2) How do Jonah and Nahum together show both God's mercy and His justice? (3) Is there a group of people you struggle to want God to love?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Jonah" (or "Jonah and the Big Fish")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Jonah
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Jonah"	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Jonah
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Jonah," "Overview: Micah," "Overview: Nahum"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Jonah

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) What surprised you about how Jonah acted at the end? (2) What does this story teach us about God's heart for people?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Jonah Overboard!*, see Games #2.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Paper-Bag Big Fish*, see Activities #2. Coloring Page 2: "Jonah and the Big Fish."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **J-O-N-A-H**, **M-I-C-A-H**, **N-A-H-U-M**. Learn Group 2. Practice Micah 6:8 with motions: "act justly" (balance hands like scales), "love mercy" (hug), "walk humbly" (walk in place, head bowed).

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, You never stop giving second chances. Help us to obey You the first time, and help us love everyone, even people who are hard to love. Thank You for sending Jesus to Bethlehem. Amen.

Week 3: "Watch, Build & Trust" (Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah)

Scripture: Habakkuk 1:2; 2:1–4; 3:17–19; Zephaniah 3:17; Haggai 1:2–8, 12–14; Zechariah 4:6; 9:9

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that we can bring God our hard questions and still trust Him (Habakkuk), that God sings over His people (Zephaniah), that we should put God first (Haggai), and that the King would come riding on a donkey (Zechariah).

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Unfinished Tower"

- *Supplies:* A tower of blocks (or cups) only half-built, labeled "GOD'S HOUSE"; next to it, a fancy fully-built tower labeled "MY HOUSE"; a pair of binoculars (or toilet-paper-tube binoculars).
- *Do:* "Look at these two houses. One is finished and fancy. The other one, God's house, is only half done. Why do you think that is?" Let kids guess. "God's people had come home from Babylon, but they got so busy with their own houses that they stopped building God's house! God sent prophets to say, 'Put Me first!'" Hold up the binoculars: "And one prophet climbed a tower to watch for God's answer."

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Before Babylon came, a prophet named **Habakkuk** looked around and saw lots of wrong things. People were fighting and being unfair. So Habakkuk prayed a brave, honest prayer: "How long, LORD, must I call for help, but you do not listen?"
>
> God answered, but it was a surprising answer. "I'm going to use the Babylonians to discipline my people."
>
> Habakkuk was confused. "But God, the Babylonians are even worse!" So Habakkuk said, "I will climb up my watchtower and wait to see what God will say."
>
> God answered: "Write it down. The answer will come, so wait for it." And God told Habakkuk, "The righteous person will live by his faithfulness." That means: people who belong to God keep trusting Him, even when they don't understand.
>
> And Habakkuk decided to trust. He sang, "Though the fig tree does not bud and there are no grapes on the vines... yet I will rejoice in the LORD, I will be joyful in God my Savior!" Even if

everything goes wrong, God is still good.

Around the same time, a prophet named **Zephaniah** warned about the "Day of the LORD." But he also shared one of the sweetest promises in the Bible: "The LORD your God is with you... He will take great delight in you... he will rejoice over you with singing." Imagine God singing a happy song about you!

Many years later, after God's people came home from Babylon, they started rebuilding God's temple. But then they stopped. They got busy making their own houses nice and fancy with wooden walls, while God's house stayed a pile of rubble.

So God sent a prophet named **Haggai**. Haggai said, "Is it a time for you to be living in your fancy houses while God's house is a ruin? Give careful thought to your ways!" The people listened! Zerubbabel the governor, Joshua the high priest, and all the people got to work. *Bang! Bang! Bang!*

God also sent a prophet named **Zechariah** to cheer them on. Zechariah had amazing visions at night. In one, he saw a golden lampstand and two olive trees. God said, "Not by might nor by power, but by my Spirit." The people didn't have to be strong; God's Spirit would help them finish! And they did. The temple was finished in 516 B.C.

Zechariah also saw far into the future. He said, "Rejoice greatly! See, your king comes to you... lowly and riding on a donkey." About 500 years later, Jesus rode into Jerusalem on a donkey while the people waved palm branches and shouted "Hosanna!" The King had come!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Build a block "temple" together while you say "Bang! Bang! Build God's house!" End with a donkey ride around the room (pretend reins). Main idea: *God loves me and sings over me.*
- **Explorers:** Learn Group 3: "Zebras Hop, Zebras March" (Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi). Have kids whisper prayers of "Why?" to God and then say "Yet I will rejoice!"
- **Trailblazers:** Compare Zechariah 9:9 with Matthew 21:1–11. Read Ezra 5:1–2 to see Haggai and Zechariah in the history books. Discuss Romans 1:17 and its use of Habakkuk 2:4.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Habakkuk as a model of honest doubt that ends in worship. Discuss Haggai's "paneled houses": what "houses" do we prioritize over God's kingdom (Matthew 6:33)?

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What did the people stop building? (God's house!) (2) What does God do over you? (Sings!) (3) What animal did the King ride? (A donkey!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What question did Habakkuk ask God? (2) What did Haggai tell the people to do? (3) Which prophet said the King would ride a donkey?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Is it okay to ask God "why?" How did Habakkuk do it well? (2) What does "Not by might nor by power, but by my Spirit" mean for us? (3) What do Haggai and Zechariah have in common?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) How does Habakkuk 3:17–18 apply when life falls apart? (2) What would it look like to "give careful thought to your ways" with your time and money? (3) Why did Jesus choose a donkey instead of a war horse?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Rebuilding the Temple" / "Palm Sunday"	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Rebuilding+the+Temple
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Haggai" / "Zechariah"	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Zechariah
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Habakkuk," "Overview: Zephaniah," "Overview: Haggai," "Overview: Zechariah"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Habakkuk

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) Why did God want the people to finish the temple? (2) What did you learn about trusting God when things are hard?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Temple Builders Relay*, see Games #3.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Palm-Branch Donkey Parade*, see Activities #3. Coloring Page 3: "Build God's House!"

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **H-A-B-A-K-K-U-K** (double K!), **Z-E-P-H-A-N-I-A-H**, **H-A-G-G-A-I** (double G!), **Z-E-C-H-A-R-I-A-H**. Practice all 11 so far with Groups 1–3.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, even when we don't understand, we will trust You. Help us put You first. Thank You for singing over us with joy, and for sending Jesus our King. Amen.

Week 4: "The Messenger Is Coming" (Malachi + 🌉 The 400 Silent Years Bridge Lesson)

Scripture: Malachi 1:2; 3:1, 6; 4:2, 5–6; Galatians 4:4; Luke 1:5–17

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Malachi is the last book of the Old Testament, that Malachi promised a messenger would come to get people ready for the Lord, that God was "quiet" for about 400 years but was getting the world ready, and that the silence ended when God announced John the Baptist and Jesus. Kids will celebrate knowing all 39 Old Testament books!

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Long Wait"

- *Supplies:* A wrapped gift box labeled "PROMISE," an hourglass or timer, a roll of blue painter's tape, 4 big signs ("PERSIA," "GREECE," "ROME," "JESUS!"), a "Shhh!" sign.
- *Do:* Hold up the gift. "I have a present for you, but you have to wait for it." Set a 60-second timer and have everyone sit **completely silent**. (Ask: "Was that hard?") "Imagine waiting not one minute, but **four hundred years**! After Malachi, God's people waited and waited for God's promise. Today we'll cross the 'Silent Bridge' and see what God was doing while they waited." Before class, tape a long "bridge" line on the floor from one side of the room to the other, with the signs spaced along it.

📖 **Story script, Part 1: Malachi (read aloud):**

> The people of Jerusalem had come home and rebuilt the temple. But after a while, they got lazy about loving God. When they brought animals to sacrifice to God, they brought the sick ones, the blind ones, the ones that limped! They kept the best for themselves. And they stopped bringing their tithe, their gift of one-tenth to God.
>
> So God sent one last Old Testament messenger. His name was **Malachi**, which means "my messenger." Malachi began with these words from God: "I have loved you."
>
> Then Malachi said, "Would you give your governor a sick, limping animal as a present? Of course not! So why would you give one to God?" He said, "Bring the whole tithe... and see if I will not throw open the floodgates of heaven."
>
> Malachi reminded them, "I the LORD do not change." God was still faithful. And then Malachi gave a promise about the future: "I will send my messenger, who will prepare the way before me. Then suddenly the Lord you are seeking will come to his temple." And at the very end of his book, Malachi said, "I will send the prophet Elijah to you..." Someone like Elijah would come first, and then the Lord Himself would come!
>
> And that is the end of the Old Testament.

📖 **Story script, Part 2: 🌉 The 400 Silent Years (walk the bridge as you tell it):**

> *(Walk to the start of the tape line with the kids. Hold up the "Shhh!" sign.)*
>
> After Malachi, something strange happened. God didn't send any more prophets. No new Bible books were written. For about **four hundred years**, it was quiet. People called it the "silent years." But God was not asleep, and God was not gone. He was busy getting the world ready for the biggest event ever!
>
> *(Walk to "PERSIA.")* First, the Persian kings ruled. God's people were back home, waiting.
>
> *(Walk to "GREECE.")* Then a young king named **Alexander the Great** marched out of Greece and conquered almost the whole world! Soon, people everywhere were speaking the same language: **Greek**. And God's Word, the Old Testament, was translated into Greek, so people from many nations could read it! (Later, the New Testament would be written in Greek too!)

> Then a wicked king named Antiochus tried to stop God's people from worshiping God. He messed up God's temple with a fake god's altar. But a brave family called the **Maccabees**, led by Judas "the Hammer," fought back. They cleaned up the temple and gave it back to God. Jewish families still remember this every winter at **Hanukkah**, and Jesus Himself went to the temple during this festival (John 10:22)!
>
> *(Walk to "ROME.")* Then the mighty **Roman Empire** took over. The Romans built long, straight roads everywhere, and kept the peace so people could travel safely. A king named **Herod** made the temple huge and beautiful. Everywhere, God's people gathered in synagogues to read the Scriptures and pray. And they were waiting. "When will the Messiah come? When will God speak again?"
>
> *(Walk to the end of the line, "JESUS!" Pause. Whisper:)* And then one day, an old priest named **Zechariah** was working in the temple. Suddenly an angel appeared! It was **Gabriel**, the same angel who had visited Daniel hundreds of years before! Gabriel said, "Your wife Elizabeth will have a son, and you are to call him John... He will go on before the Lord, in the spirit and power of Elijah... to make ready a people prepared for the Lord."
>
> *(Shout:)* The silence was over! Malachi's messenger was coming: John the Baptist! And just a few months later, Gabriel visited a young woman named Mary and told her she would have a baby named **JESUS**!
>
> The Bible says, "When the set time had fully come, God sent his Son." God was never late. He was getting everything ready, right on time. And now we're ready to cross the bridge into the New Testament and **meet Jesus**!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Keep the bridge walk simple: "Shhh, quiet... quiet... quiet... JESUS IS COMING!" Let them jump at the end. Main idea: *God keeps His promises. Jesus came right on time.*
- **Explorers:** Let kids carry the signs and stand at each spot. Learn to say: "39 books in the Old Testament!" Celebrate finishing the Old Testament.
- **Trailblazers:** Read Daniel 2:36–45 and match the metals to empires (gold = Babylon, silver = Medo-Persia, bronze = Greece, iron = Rome) in the traditional evangelical reading. Then read Mark 1:1–4, which quotes Malachi 3:1 and Isaiah 40:3 together.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss "the fullness of time" (Galatians 4:4): language, roads, peace, the Septuagint, synagogues and longing. Ambassadors can lead the bridge walk for Little Lambs.

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Who is the last Old Testament book? (Malachi!) (2) Was God asleep during the quiet years? (No! He was getting ready!) (3) Who came at the end of the bridge? (Jesus!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What does the name Malachi mean? ("My messenger.") (2) What language did lots of people speak because of Alexander the Great? (Greek.) (3) Who was the messenger who got people ready for Jesus? (John the Baptist.)
- *Trailblazers:* (1) What were the people doing wrong in Malachi's day? (2) Name three ways God got the world ready for Jesus during the 400 years. (3) Which angel broke the silence, and where

else does he appear in the Bible?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Why might God have waited 400 years? (2) How does Malachi 3:1 connect the two Testaments? (3) What does it mean for your life that God is never late, even when He seems silent?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Zechariah and Elizabeth" (the angel's visit; the start of the New Testament story)	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Zechariah+and+Elizabeth
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Between the Testaments" (if available) or "Malachi"	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Between+the+Testaments
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Malachi"; theme video "Messiah"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Malachi

Preview every video before class. (If no "between the testaments" video is available on Bible Journey, use "Malachi" and teach the bridge with the timeline walk.) Follow-up questions: (1) What promise did Malachi leave the people waiting for? (2) How did God get the world ready for Jesus?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Cross the Silent Bridge*, see Games #4.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Bridge Timeline Walk / Bridge Craft*, see Activities #4. Coloring Page 4: "The Silent Bridge to Jesus."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **M-A-L-A-C-H-I**. Say all 12 Minor Prophets, then try ALL 39 Old Testament books! Begin oral check-offs. Optional bonus word for Trailblazers/Ambassadors: **intertestamental**.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear God, thank You that You always keep Your promises. Even when You seem quiet, You are working. Thank You for sending Jesus right on time. We can't wait to meet Him in the New Testament! Amen.

Week 5 (optional): "Old Testament Graduation Sunday"

Use the End-of-Phase Review & Celebration plan below. Run the *Old Testament Library Sort* (Games #5), finish oral check-offs, stamp Bible Passports, award the 🐋🌉 "Mighty Twelve" badge, and hold a mini "Old Testament Graduation" (paper graduation caps optional!).

Book Memory Song & Motions

🎵 "The Library Song," now with the Minor Prophets!

Sing Verses 1–4 to **"Ten Little Fingers"** (as in Phase 7), then switch to **"Yankee Doodle"** for the NEW Verse 5. Changing tunes helps kids feel that the Minor Prophets are a new "shelf" in the library. Every verse is written out below; it's cumulative!

Verse 1: LAW (5) *(tune: Ten Little Fingers)*

> Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, the books of the Law! Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, FIVE!

Verse 2: HISTORY (12)

> Joshua, Judges, Ruth, and First and Second Samuel, First and Second Kings, then First and Second Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, and Esther: History! Twelve books of HIS-TO-RY!

Verse 3: POETRY / WISDOM (5)

> Job and Psalms and Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs, they're Poetry and Wisdom! Job and Psalms and Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs, that's FIVE!

Verse 4: MAJOR PROPHETS (5)

> I-sai-ah, Jer-e-mi-ah, Lam-en-ta-tions, E-ze-kiel and Dan-iel, the Ma-jor Pro-phets! I-sai-ah, Jer-e-mi-ah, Lam-en-ta-tions, E-ze-kiel, Dan-iel: FIVE!

Verse 5: MINOR PROPHETS (12), NEW! *(tune: Yankee Doodle)*

> *(Yankee Doodle went to town, a-riding on a pony…)* **Ho-se-a, Jo-el, A-mos, O-ba-di-ah, Jo-nah,** *(…stuck a feather in his cap and called it macaroni)* **Mi-cah, Na-hum, Ha-bak-kuk, Zeph-a-ni-ah, Hag-gai!**
>
> *(Chorus: Yankee Doodle, keep it up, Yankee Doodle dandy…)* **Zech-a-ri-ah, Mal-a-chi, the twelve Mi-nor Pro-phets!** *(…mind the music and the step, and with the girls be handy)* **Short books with a might-y word: the Old Tes-ta-ment's done!**

Tag (shout it!)

> Law and History, Poetry, Major, Minor, ONE-TWO-THREE! THIRTY-NINE! The Old Testament's DONE! *(Whisper:)* Shhh... 400 years... *(Shout:)* JESUS IS COMING!

(Teacher tip: The Yankee Doodle lines are a bit crowded. Practice Verse 5 slowly first, clapping each syllable, then speed up. Little Lambs can just shout "TWELVE!" and do the fish gulp.)

Hand motions for the 12 new books

Book	Motion
Hosea	Stretch arms out wide, then pull them back in to your chest: "Come home! Love that won't quit!"
Joel	Wiggle all ten fingers overhead like a locust swarm.
Amos	Hold a fist high and drop a pretend plumb line straight down.
Obadiah	Hold up ONE finger (one chapter!).
Jonah	Hands together like a fish mouth: open... GULP!
Micah	Fingertips together to make a tiny roof (little Bethlehem).
Nahum	Stack fists high like a tower, then let them tumble down.
Habakkuk	Hand over eyes like looking out from a watchtower.
Zephaniah	Hands start at your heart and float outward like a song.
Haggai	Pound fist on palm twice like a hammer, then make a roof over your head with both hands (God's house).
Zechariah	Hold pretend reins and bounce (donkey ride).
Malachi	Cup a hand by your mouth and point far ahead: "He's coming!"

Review motions for books learned earlier (1–27). These match the motions used in earlier phases and the Books of the Bible Memory System:

Section	Book → motion
Law	Genesis: palms together like a book, open, sweep arms up (sunrise) · Exodus: walk two fingers across your palm and out the "door" · Leviticus: fold hands in prayer, then raise them high · Numbers: count 1-2-3-4 on fingers, then zig-zag your hand · Deuteronomy: two fingers up, tap your head, hand on heart
History	Joshua: march with a fist-trumpet · Judges: pound a gavel on your palm, then draw a circle · Ruth: scoop grain, then hug yourself · 1 & 2 Samuel: hold up 1 or 2 fingers, then cup your ear (listening) · 1 & 2 Kings: 1 or 2 fingers, then crown on head · 1 & 2 Chronicles: 1 or 2 fingers, then unroll a scroll · Ezra: stack fists like bricks · Nehemiah: hammer + shield · Esther: crown, then "speak up" hands at mouth
Poetry / Wisdom	Job: hands open up, then fold over heart · Psalms: strum a harp · Proverbs: tap your head with one finger · Ecclesiastes: blow a puff into your hand, then point up · Song of Songs: heart hands

Section	Book → motion
Major Prophets	Isaiah: two fingers to lips, then hand up ("Send me!") · Jeremiah: shape clay in a circle · Lamentations: tears down cheeks, then arms up like a sunrise · Ezekiel: go floppy, then stand tall · Daniel: lion jaws snap shut

📣 Section Shout

> **Teacher:** "How many Minor Prophets?" **Kids:** "TWELVE MIGHTY MESSENGERS!" **Teacher:** "Are they small?" **Kids:** "SMALL BOOKS, BIG MESSAGE!" **Teacher:** "How many books in the Old Testament?" **Kids:** "THIRTY-NINE!" **Teacher:** "Who comes next?" **Kids:** "JESUS!"

Cumulative recall drill (5 minutes)

1. **Three Groups of Four:** Split the room into three teams. Team 1 shouts Hosea–Obadiah, Team 2 shouts Jonah–Habakkuk, Team 3 shouts Zephaniah–Malachi. Rotate.
2. **Silly Sentences:** "Happy Jellyfish Ate Oranges / Jonah Met Nine Hungry fish / Zebras Hop, Zebras March." Teacher says the sentence word, kids say the book.
3. **Section Stand-Up:** Teacher calls a section (Law, History, Poetry, Major, Minor); kids stand and say that section's books.
4. **Before & After (39 books):** "What's after Daniel?" (Hosea) "What's before Malachi?" (Zechariah) "What's after Obadiah?" (Jonah) "What's the last book of the Old Testament?" (Malachi)
5. **39-Book Countdown (Trailblazers+):** Say all 39 books while holding up fingers in groups of ten (four hands = 40, minus one!). Time it and beat your record.

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on "Minor Prophets," "Jonah," "Malachi = last," and the motions. Celebrate "39!" as a big number.
- **Explorers:** Goal: say all 12 in order (using the three groups) and spell at least 8.
- **Trailblazers:** Goal: say all 39 Old Testament books in order without the song; one-word summary for each Minor Prophet.
- **Ambassadors:** Goal: say all 39; teach the three-groups trick to a younger class; explain the 400 Silent Years in 1 minute.

Spelling & Reading

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letter recognition & first sounds)

Book	First letter	Sound it out	Picture clue
Hosea	**H**	"h-h-h"	❤️ heart

Book	First letter	Sound it out	Picture clue
Joel	**J**	"j-j-j"	🦗 bug
Amos	**A**	"ay"	📏 string
Jonah	**J**	"j-j-j"	🐋 fish
Micah	**M**	"m-m-m"	🏘️ little town
Haggai	**H**	"h-h-h"	🔨 hammer
Zechariah	**Z**	"z-z-z"	🫏 donkey
Malachi	**M**	"m-m-m"	📣 messenger

Game: "Two J's!" Which two Minor Prophets start with J? (Joel and Jonah!) Which start with Z? (Zephaniah and Zechariah!) Which start with H? (Hosea, Habakkuk, Haggai!) Which start with M? (Micah, Malachi!)

Explorers (book names)

1. Hosea
2. Joel
3. Amos
4. Obadiah
5. Jonah
6. Micah
7. Nahum
8. Habakkuk
9. Zephaniah
10. Haggai
11. Zechariah
12. Malachi

Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocabulary words)

- Book names: all 12 above
- Vocab: **justice**, **mercy**, **humble**, **Nineveh**, **temple**

Ambassadors (book names + harder vocabulary with definitions)

Word	Definition
Repent	To turn around: change your mind and direction, away from sin and toward God (Jonah 3).
Redeem	To buy back or set free by paying a price (Hosea buying back Gomer; Jesus redeeming us).
Justice	Doing what is right and fair, especially for the poor and powerless (Amos 5:24).
Mercy / hesed	God's loyal, faithful, covenant love; kindness that keeps its promises (Micah 6:8; 7:18).
Day of the LORD	The coming time when God judges evil and rescues His people (Joel, Amos, Zephaniah, Malachi).

Word	Definition
Tithe	A tenth of one's income or produce given to God (Malachi 3:10).
Intertestamental	"Between the Testaments": the roughly 400 years from Malachi to the New Testament.
Septuagint	The ancient Greek translation of the Hebrew Scriptures (begun about 250 B.C. in Alexandria; abbreviated LXX).
Messiah	"Anointed One," the promised King; in Greek, *Christos* (Christ).

👏 Syllable-clap method

Book	Claps	Spell in rhythm
Ho-se-a	3	H-O · S-E · A
Jo-el	2	J-O · E-L
A-mos	2	A · M-O-S
O-ba-di-ah	4	O · B-A · D-I · A-H
Jo-nah	2	J-O · N-A-H
Mi-cah	2	M-I · C-A-H
Na-hum	2	N-A · H-U-M
Ha-bak-kuk	3	H-A · B-A-K · K-U-K
Zeph-a-ni-ah	4	Z-E-P-H · A · N-I · A-H
Hag-gai	2	H-A-G · G-A-I
Zech-a-ri-ah	4	Z-E-C-H · A · R-I · A-H
Mal-a-chi	3	M-A-L · A · C-H-I

Tricky-spot alerts: Habak**KK**uk (double K), Ha**GG**ai (double G), Ze**PH**aniah (PH = F), Ze**CH**ariah and Mala**CH**i (CH = K). Many of these end in "-IAH" (Obadiah, Zephaniah, Zechariah). "-IAH" (Hebrew "Yah") is a short form of God's name: Zechariah = "the LORD remembers," Obadiah = "servant of the LORD."

🏃 "Spell It Out" relay

1. Make teams of 4–6. Each team gets an envelope of letter cards for a book (Explorers: shorter books; Trailblazers/Ambassadors: Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Zechariah).
2. Letters are scattered across the room (face down). Runners take turns grabbing ONE letter at a time.
3. When the word is complete and in order, the whole team does that book's motion and shouts the book's "one word" (e.g., "HAGGAI: BUILD!").
4. *Bonus round:* The teacher calls "Next book!" and teams must spell the book that comes *after* the one they just spelled.
5. *Little Lambs:* Find the first letter only, then do the motion.

🐝 Mini spelling bee word list (with sentences)

Word	Use it in a sentence
Hosea	**Hosea** kept loving his wife.
Joel	**Joel** saw a swarm of locusts.
Amos	**Amos** was a shepherd who spoke for the poor.
Obadiah	**Obadiah** is the shortest book in the Old Testament.
Jonah	**Jonah** prayed inside the big fish.
Micah	**Micah** said the King would be born in Bethlehem.
Nahum	**Nahum** said the LORD is a refuge in trouble.
Habakkuk	**Habakkuk** waited on his watchtower.
Zephaniah	**Zephaniah** said God rejoices over us with singing.
Haggai	**Haggai** told the people to build God's house.
Zechariah	**Zechariah** said the King would ride a donkey.
Malachi	**Malachi** is the last book of the Old Testament.
Nineveh	Jonah finally preached in **Nineveh**.
humbly	Walk **humbly** with your God.
messenger	God promised to send a **messenger**.

📖 Read-aloud practice passage

> God sent **twelve** messengers with short books. **Hosea** showed God's love never quits. **Joel** saw locusts. **Amos** said, "Be fair!" **Obadiah** wrote just one chapter. **Jonah** ran away, but God sent a **big fish** to give him a second chance. **Micah** said Jesus would be born in **Bethlehem**. **Nahum** said God is good. **Habakkuk** trusted God when things were hard. **Zephaniah** said God sings over us. **Haggai** said, "Build God's house!" **Zechariah** said the King would ride a **donkey**. **Malachi** said a messenger was coming. Then God was quiet for **400 years**, getting the world ready for **Jesus**!

Word Trivia

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. What swallowed Jonah?
2. True or False: The Minor Prophets are called "minor" because their books are short.
3. How many Minor Prophets are there?
4. Which city did God tell Jonah to go to?
5. Fill in the blank: "Walk humbly with your _____." (Micah 6:8)

6. What animal did Zechariah say the King would ride?
7. What is the last book of the Old Testament?
8. In which town did Micah say the King would be born?
9. True or False: Jonah obeyed God right away the first time.
10. How many days and nights was Jonah inside the fish?
11. What kind of bugs did Joel see eating all the crops?
12. How many books are in the Old Testament?

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

13. Who said, "Salvation comes from the LORD"? (Who said it? Hint: from inside a fish)
14. Which book is the shortest in the Old Testament? (Which book?)
15. What was Amos's job before he became a prophet?
16. What did God show Amos to measure His people? (A plumb line / a sword / a scale)
17. Which prophet told the people to finish building the temple instead of their fancy houses?
18. Fill in the blank: "'Not by might nor by _____, but by my Spirit,' says the LORD Almighty." (Zechariah 4:6)
19. Which book says, "He will rejoice over you with singing"? (Which book?)
20. What does the name Malachi mean?
21. True or False: Nahum is about God judging Nineveh, the same city Jonah preached to.
22. Which prophet climbed a watchtower to wait for God's answer?
23. Fill in the blank: Jonah ran to a ship going to _____.
24. Which nation (descendants of Esau) did Obadiah warn?

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

25. Who said, "I knew that you are a gracious and compassionate God, slow to anger and abounding in love," and was upset about it? (Who said it?)
26. Which Minor Prophet's verse did Peter quote on the day of Pentecost?
27. Which verse from Habakkuk is quoted in Romans, Galatians and Hebrews? (Fill in: "The righteous person will live by his _____.")
28. Which Minor Prophet predicted thirty pieces of silver?
29. Which Old Testament verse did the chief priests quote to tell Herod where the Messiah would be born?
30. What was the name of Hosea's wife?
31. Who was the governor encouraged by Haggai and Zechariah to rebuild the temple?
32. Who did Jesus say was the "Elijah" Malachi promised?
33. Which conqueror spread the Greek language during the silent years?
34. What festival comes from the Maccabees rededicating the temple, and where is it mentioned in the New Testament?
35. Which angel broke the 400 years of silence by appearing to Zechariah the priest?
36. Which empire controlled Judea when Jesus was born?
37. True or False: In the Hebrew Bible, the twelve Minor Prophets were copied together on one scroll.
38. Fill in the blank: "But when the set _____ had fully come, God sent his Son." (Galatians 4:4)

🔑 Answer Key

1. A huge fish (Jonah 1:17)
2. True
3. Twelve
4. Nineveh
5. God
6. A donkey (Zechariah 9:9)
7. Malachi
8. Bethlehem (Micah 5:2)
9. False, he ran away first.
10. Three days and three nights
11. Locusts
12. 39
13. Jonah (Jonah 2:9)
14. Obadiah (21 verses)
15. A shepherd and a farmer of sycamore-fig trees (Amos 1:1; 7:14)
16. A plumb line (Amos 7:7–8)
17. Haggai
18. power
19. Zephaniah (3:17)
20. "My messenger"
21. True
22. Habakkuk (2:1)
23. Tarshish
24. Edom
25. Jonah (Jonah 4:2)
26. Joel (Joel 2:28–32 in Acts 2:16–21)
27. faithfulness (Habakkuk 2:4)
28. Zechariah (11:12–13)
29. Micah 5:2 (Matthew 2:5–6)
30. Gomer
31. Zerubbabel (with Joshua the high priest)
32. John the Baptist (Matthew 11:13–14; 17:12–13)
33. Alexander the Great
34. Hanukkah, the Festival (Feast) of Dedication (John 10:22)
35. Gabriel (Luke 1:19)
36. The Roman Empire (Caesar Augustus; Herod was a local king under Rome)
37. True ("The Book of the Twelve")
38. time

Games

🎮 Game #1: Minor Prophet Line-Up Race

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors (Little Lambs with buddies)
- **Supplies:** Two sets of 12 cards, each with a Minor Prophet name (and picture symbol for younger kids)
- **Setup:** Two teams. Shuffle each set and give one card to each player (if a team has fewer than 12 players, some get two).
- **How to play:** On "GO!", each team must line up in correct Bible order, holding their cards at chest level, and then shout the books in order with motions.
- **How to win:** First team in correct order wins the round. Play best of 3, reshuffling each time.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Use only Group 1 (4 cards) or Group 2. *Older:* Add the 5 Major Prophets (17 cards) or do it silently (no talking!).
- **Learning goal:** Book order for all 12 Minor Prophets.

🎮 Game #2: Jonah Overboard!

- **Best for:** All ages (very active)
- **Supplies:** A big blue sheet or tarp (the sea), a hula hoop or taped square (the boat), a beach ball (the big fish)
- **Setup:** Lay the blue sheet on the floor around the "boat." Everyone starts in the boat.
- **How to play:** The teacher is the "Storm." Call out commands: "Wind blows: rock left!" "Waves crash: crouch down!" "Throw cargo: toss pretend boxes!" "Sailors pray: fold hands!" Then the teacher asks a trivia question to one player. A wrong answer means "Jonah overboard!": that player jumps into the "sea." Players in the sea can get back in the boat when the "big fish" (beach ball) is rolled to them and they answer a question correctly ("GULP... BLEH!").
- **How to win:** Players still in the boat at the end, or the whole class "gets to Nineveh" if everyone ends in the boat.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* No one stays out; just do the motions and splash. *Older:* Use harder trivia and "Before & After" book questions.
- **Learning goal:** Jonah's story; God's second chances; trivia review.

🎮 Game #3: Temple Builders Relay

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Cardboard boxes, cups or large blocks (about 12 per team), each labeled with a Minor Prophet (or all 39 OT books for older kids)
- **Setup:** Blocks are piled at the far end of the room. Teams line up at the start.
- **How to play:** One runner at a time runs to the pile, finds the next book in order, and brings it back. The team stacks them in order to build a "temple wall" (Hosea at the bottom, Malachi at the top). If a block is out of order, Haggai (the teacher) calls "Give careful thought to your ways!" and the team must fix it.
- **How to win:** First team to build a 12-block tower in correct order that stands for 5 seconds wins.

- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Blocks have pictures; just stack them, and the teacher helps with order. *Older:* Build all 39 OT books in order, sorted by section.
- **Learning goal:** Book order; Haggai's message to put God first.

🎮 Game #4: Cross the Silent Bridge

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Painter's tape "bridge" (two parallel lines about 2 feet apart across the room), signs: MALACHI (start), PERSIA, GREECE, ROME, JESUS! (finish)
- **Setup:** Kids line up at MALACHI. Teacher stands at JESUS!
- **How to play:** It's a silent game! Kids must cross the bridge without making a sound (no talking, no giggling!). At each sign, the teacher holds up a card with a question (shown, not said aloud, or acted out); kids answer by doing a motion or pointing (e.g., "Show me the Jonah motion!" "Hold up fingers: how many Minor Prophets?"). Anyone who makes a sound goes back one sign. At the end, everyone who reaches "JESUS!" can finally shout as loud as they want: "JESUS IS COMING!"
- **How to win:** Everyone who crosses wins. The class wins together when everyone reaches the end.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Allow whispers; teacher helps. *Older:* Questions are about the 400 years ("Show me with fingers about how many years," "Point to the empire that spread Greek").
- **Learning goal:** The 400 Silent Years; the waiting and the joy of Jesus' coming.

🎮 Game #5: Old Testament Library Sort

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors (review Sunday)
- **Supplies:** 39 cards (one per OT book) per team; 5 colored "shelf" mats or baskets labeled Law, History, Poetry/Wisdom, Major Prophets, Minor Prophets
- **Setup:** Shuffle the cards and place them in a pile in the center for each team.
- **How to play:** Teams race to sort all 39 books onto the correct shelves, *and in correct order* on each shelf.
- **How to win:** First team with all 39 correctly sorted and ordered. (Ambassadors can be the "librarians" who check.)
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Little Lambs sort only the Minor Prophets with picture cards, or match pictures to "Jonah" and "Malachi." *Older:* No section labels; they must name the sections themselves.
- **Learning goal:** Mastery of all 39 Old Testament books and their sections.

🎮 Game #6 (bonus): Locust Swarm Tag

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers
- **Supplies:** Green scarves or pinnies for "locusts"; paper "crops" (green paper leaves) scattered on the floor
- **How to play:** Locusts (2–3 kids) try to tag the "farmers." Farmers protect the crops by standing on them. When tagged, a farmer must "rend your heart" (put a hand on their heart) and say "Return to the LORD!", then they're free again. After 2 minutes, count how many crops are left.

- **Learning goal:** Joel's message to turn back to God; God restores "what the locusts have eaten" (Joel 2:25).

Coloring Pages

> 🖍️ Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-08-printables.html`.

Page 1: "Hosea Brings Gomer Home" (Week 1)

- **Scene:** A dusty road leading to a little house with a warm, glowing window. Hosea walks hand-in-hand with his wife, both smiling. Three children run out of the house to greet them. A big heart shape is drawn in the clouds above.
- **Caption:** "I led them with cords of human kindness, with ties of love." (Hosea 11:4)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "How do you think Hosea felt bringing his wife home?" "How does God feel when we come back to Him?" "Who can you show never-quitting love to?"

Page 2: "Jonah and the Big Fish" (Week 2)

- **Scene:** Underwater: a huge fish with its mouth open, and Jonah (on his knees, praying) visible inside a cut-away "window" in the fish's belly, with seaweed wrapped around his head (Jonah 2:5). Above the water, a small ship sails away under clearing storm clouds. In the corner, a tiny picture of the city of Nineveh on the shore.
- **Caption:** "Salvation comes from the LORD." (Jonah 2:9)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "What did Jonah do inside the fish?" "Have you ever run away from doing the right thing?" "How did God give Jonah a second chance?"

Page 3: "Build God's House!" (Week 3)

- **Scene:** Workers on scaffolding stacking big stones for the temple; Zerubbabel holding a building plan; Haggai pointing up and cheering. A golden lampstand with two olive trees in a small "dream bubble" in the corner (Zechariah's vision). Fancy houses with wooden walls in the background, with a sign "My House" crossed out and "God's House First!" written above.
- **Caption:** "Not by might nor by power, but by my Spirit." (Zechariah 4:6)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "What does it mean to put God first?" "What would you build for God?" "How does God's Spirit help us?"

Page 4: "The Silent Bridge to Jesus" (Week 4)

- **Scene:** A long stone bridge stretching across the page. On the left bank: an old scroll labeled "MALACHI" and a messenger pointing across. Along the bridge: small pictures of a Persian crown, a Greek helmet (Alexander), a menorah/lampstand (Hanukkah), and a Roman road sign.

On the right bank: a bright star over a stable in Bethlehem, and the angel Gabriel. The bridge's railing says "SHHH... 400 YEARS..." and the right end bursts with "JESUS!"
- **Caption:** "When the set time had fully come, God sent his Son." (Galatians 4:4)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "Have you ever had to wait a really long time for something?" "What was God doing during the quiet years?" "Who did God send at the right time?"

Page 5: "Your King Comes on a Donkey" (bonus)

- **Scene:** Jesus riding a young donkey through a city gate; children waving palm branches; coats laid on the road.
- **Caption:** "See, your king comes to you... riding on a donkey." (Zechariah 9:9)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "Zechariah said this 500 years early! How did he know?" "Why do you think the King came on a donkey instead of a big war horse?"

Page 6: "Twelve Mighty Messengers" book-name page

- **Scene:** Twelve fish swimming in a big ocean wave, each fish labeled with a Minor Prophet in order, with its small symbol (heart, locust, plumb line, "1," fish, little house, tower, watchtower, music note, hammer, donkey, megaphone). At the bottom, a bridge leading to a sign: "NEW TESTAMENT →."
- **Caption:** "Walk humbly with your God." (Micah 6:8)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** Say each name as you color its fish. "Which prophet is your favorite? Why?"

Activities & Crafts

❤️ Activity #1: Never-Quitting Heart Chain & Plumb Line (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Red and pink paper strips (1" × 8"), glue sticks or tape, markers; string, metal washers, craft sticks.
- **Steps (Heart Chain):**
  1. On each strip write one way God shows love (or one way kids can show love to others).
  2. Loop and glue the strips into a paper chain. Talk about how a chain holds on, like God's love.
  3. Add a heart tag that says "God's love won't quit!" (Hosea).
- **Steps (Plumb Line):** Tie a washer to a 12" string, then tie the other end to a craft stick labeled "AMOS: Let justice roll!" Let kids test whether things in the room are straight.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-cut and pre-written strips; they glue. *Explorers:* Write their own. *Trailblazers:* Write a different Minor Prophet's name on each link (in order!). *Ambassadors:* Write "justice" action ideas (help a classmate, give to a food drive) on the plumb line tag.
- **What it teaches:** God's faithful love (Hosea) and His care for fairness (Amos).

🐋 Activity #2: Paper-Bag Big Fish (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Brown or white paper lunch bags, newspaper or tissue for stuffing, blue/gray paint or crayons, googly eyes, rubber bands, a small paper "Jonah" figure (print or draw).
- **Steps:**
  1. Color or paint the bag like a big fish (scales, fins).
  2. Stuff it lightly with newspaper, but first slip the paper Jonah inside!
  3. Twist the open end and wrap it with a rubber band to make a tail.
  4. Add googly eyes and a big smile.
  5. Write "Salvation comes from the LORD! (Jonah 2:9)" on the side.
  6. At home, kids can "BLEH!" Jonah out by opening the tail and retelling the story.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-stuffed bags; just decorate. *Explorers:* Full craft. *Trailblazers:* Write Jonah's 4 chapters on the 4 fins (Runs, Prays, Preaches, Pouts). *Ambassadors:* Lead the craft and retell the story to Little Lambs using the fish.
- **What it teaches:** Second chances and God's mercy for all.

🌿 Activity #3: Palm-Branch Donkey Parade (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Green construction paper, child-size handprint tracing, tape, paper towel tubes or craft sticks; for the "donkey": a gray paper plate, paper ears, yarn.
- **Steps:**
  1. Trace both hands on green paper and cut them out (teacher helps).
  2. Tape the hands to a paper towel tube in a fan shape to make a palm branch.
  3. Write "Zechariah 9:9" on the tube.
  4. Make a donkey face mask from the gray paper plate (optional).
  5. Parade around the room (or into the main service!) waving branches and shouting "Hosanna! The King is coming!"
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-cut hands. *Explorers:* Write the 4 Week 3 book names on the fingers. *Trailblazers:* Add the Matthew 21:5 reference and compare it to Zechariah 9:9. *Ambassadors:* Organize and lead the parade; read Zechariah 9:9 aloud as it begins.
- **What it teaches:** Old Testament promises came true in Jesus, our humble King.

🌉 Activity #4: The Bridge Timeline Walk & Bridge Craft (Week 4 Bridge Lesson)

- **Supplies:** Long butcher paper or painter's tape on the floor; cardstock strips (for a bridge craft); markers; stickers or printed symbols (scroll, crown, Greek helmet, menorah, Roman road, star).
- **Steps (Timeline Walk):**
  1. Lay out the floor bridge with 6 "stops": Malachi (~430 B.C.) → Persia → Alexander & the Greek language (333 B.C.) → the Septuagint (~250 B.C.) → the Maccabees & Hanukkah (164 B.C.) → Rome takes over (63 B.C.) → Herod & the temple → Gabriel & Zechariah → JESUS!
  2. At each stop, a kid (or Ambassador) reads a one-sentence card explaining it.
  3. Everyone walks silently between stops and cheers at the end.
- **Steps (Bridge Craft):**
  1. Fold a cardstock strip into an arch and glue its ends to a base strip.
  2. Write "MALACHI" on the left end and "MATTHEW" on the right end.

3. Along the arch write "400 Silent Years: God was getting ready!"
4. Add symbol stickers along the arch in order.

- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Walk the bridge; decorate a pre-folded arch with a star sticker at the end. *Explorers:* Full craft with 4 symbols. *Trailblazers:* Add dates. *Ambassadors:* Prepare and read the stop cards; explain "the fullness of time."
- **What it teaches:** God was working during the quiet years and brought Jesus at exactly the right time. This links the Old and New Testaments.

✅ Activity #5: Micah 6:8 Challenge Cards

- **Supplies:** Index cards in three colors (one each for "Act Justly," "Love Mercy," "Walk Humbly"), markers, a small envelope per child.
- **Steps:**
  1. Brainstorm one action for each phrase (Act justly: "Take turns fairly." Love mercy: "Forgive my brother." Walk humbly: "Pray before school.").
  2. Write or draw one action on each colored card.
  3. Put them in an envelope labeled "Micah 6:8 Challenge."
  4. Next week, kids report which ones they did; give a sticker for each.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Draw pictures; teacher writes. *Explorers/Trailblazers:* Write their own. *Ambassadors:* Make a 7-day challenge chart and share it in a group chat or with family.
- **What it teaches:** Living out the memory verse in everyday life.

📚 Activity #6: The Old Testament Bookshelf

- **Supplies:** A 39-slot "bookshelf" poster (5 shelves, color-coded by section) and 39 "book spine" strips (1" wide) in matching colors, glue, markers.
- **Steps:**
  1. Kids write a book name on each spine (or get pre-printed spines).
  2. Glue the spines onto the correct shelf, in order.
  3. Decorate the top: "I know the WHOLE Old Testament! 39 of 66."
  4. Leave room for a new "New Testament" bookshelf next month.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Glue only the 12 Minor Prophet spines (pre-printed). *Explorers+:* All 39. *Ambassadors:* Add a one-word summary to each spine.
- **What it teaches:** The structure of the Old Testament library; celebrates completing it.

Word Puzzles

🔀 Word Scramble

Unscramble these words from Phase 8.

#	Scrambled	Hint
1	NOHAJ	Swallowed by a fish
2	ESOHA	Love that won't quit

#	Scrambled	Hint
3	SOMA	Shepherd prophet
4	LOJE	Saw locusts
5	CHAMI	Bethlehem prophet
6	IAHCLAM	Last book of the OT
7	AGIGAH	"Build God's house!"
8	KUKBAKAH	Watchtower prophet
9	HEVENIN	Big city that said sorry
10	YEKDON	The King rode one
11	MEHLEBETH	Little town where Jesus was born
12	GERSSEMEN	Malachi's name means "my ___"
13	TENLIS	The 400 ____ years

Answer key: 1. JONAH 2. HOSEA 3. AMOS 4. JOEL 5. MICAH 6. MALACHI 7. HAGGAI 8. HABAKKUK 9. NINEVEH 10. DONKEY 11. BETHLEHEM 12. MESSENGER 13. SILENT

✏️ Fill-in-the-Blank Story

Word bank: Malachi, fish, Bethlehem, Jesus, Hosea, donkey, Nineveh, 400, temple, Jonah, twelve, Greek

> God sent _____ Minor Prophets. _____ kept loving his wife, showing God's love. _____ ran away from God, but a big _____ swallowed him. Finally he preached in _____, and the people said sorry to God. Micah said the King would be born in _____. Haggai told the people to finish God's _____. Zechariah said the King would ride a _____. _____ was the last book of the Old Testament. Then God was quiet for about _____ years. During that time many people learned to speak _____. Then, right on time, God sent _____!

Answer key: twelve, Hosea, Jonah, fish, Nineveh, Bethlehem, temple, donkey, Malachi, 400, Greek, Jesus

🔗 Match the Book to Its Picture / Summary

Book		Picture / Summary
1. Hosea		A. 🦗 Locusts; "I will pour out my Spirit"
2. Joel		B. 🔨 Finish building the temple!
3. Amos		C. ❤️ A husband's love that never quits
4. Obadiah		D. 🫏 Night visions; the King on a donkey
5. Jonah		E. 📏 A plumb line; "Let justice roll!"

Book		Picture / Summary
6. Micah		F. 👀 Asked God "Why?"; "Yet I will rejoice"
7. Nahum		G. ☝️ One chapter against proud Edom
8. Habakkuk		H. 📣 "I will send my messenger"; last OT book
9. Zephaniah		I. 🐋 Ran from God; big fish; Nineveh repents
10. Haggai		J. 🏰 Nineveh falls; "The LORD is good, a refuge"
11. Zechariah		K. 🏘️ Bethlehem; "act justly, love mercy, walk humbly"
12. Malachi		L. 🎶 God rejoices over you with singing

Answer key: 1–C, 2–A, 3–E, 4–G, 5–I, 6–K, 7–J, 8–F, 9–L, 10–B, 11–D, 12–H

Questions for Every Age

Little Lambs (4–6)

1. Does God still love you when you do something wrong? (Yes!)
2. What did Jonah do inside the fish? (He prayed!)
3. How can you be kind to someone this week?
4. What town was Jesus born in? (Bethlehem!)
5. Is it hard to wait? Who did God's people wait for? (Jesus!)

Explorers (7–10)

1. Jonah didn't want to go to Nineveh. Is there something God wants you to do that feels hard?
2. What is one way you can "act justly" (be fair) at school or home?
3. Haggai said "Put God first." What is one way you can put God first this week?
4. How can you trust God when something bad happens, like Habakkuk did?
5. What was God doing during the 400 quiet years?

Trailblazers (11–13)

1. Why do you think God cared so much about the people of Nineveh?
2. Amos and Micah talk a lot about the poor. What does that show about God's heart?
3. Which prophecy about Jesus from these books is your favorite? Why?
4. Have you ever felt like God was "silent"? What does the 400-year bridge teach about those times?
5. What's the difference between giving God your "leftovers" and your best (Malachi 1)?

Ambassadors (14–17)

1. Jonah knew God was merciful and resented it. Where might you resent God's mercy to others?
2. How do Jonah and Nahum together show that God is both merciful and just?

3. Habakkuk wrestled with God honestly. How do you handle doubts or hard questions?
4. Micah 6:8: which part (justice, mercy, humility) is hardest for you? Why?
5. How did the events of the 400 Silent Years make the spread of the gospel easier in Acts?

🧠 Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics / worldview)

1. "Isn't Jonah just a fish tale, a myth?" *Suggested answer:* Jonah son of Amittai is a historical prophet mentioned in 2 Kings 14:25. Nineveh was a real, very large city (its ruins are near modern Mosul, Iraq). Jesus spoke of Jonah's experience and Nineveh's repentance as real events, setting them beside His own resurrection and the coming judgment (Matthew 12:39–41). If God can raise Jesus from the dead, He can certainly preserve Jonah in a fish. The question really comes down to whether miracles are possible, and the resurrection is the test case.

2. "If God is loving, why does Nahum celebrate the destruction of a city?" *Suggested answer:* Assyria was infamous for brutal cruelty to conquered peoples. God had shown mercy to Nineveh through Jonah about a century earlier, and they returned to violence. For the many nations Assyria had terrorized, Nineveh's fall was a rescue. Nahum 1:3 holds both truths: "The LORD is slow to anger but great in power; the LORD will not leave the guilty unpunished." A God who never judged evil would not be good. At the cross, God's justice and mercy meet: Jesus takes the judgment so the guilty who repent can be forgiven.

3. "Why should we trust that the Old Testament ended with Malachi? What about the books from the 400 years?" *Suggested answer:* Jewish tradition itself recognized that prophecy had ceased after the prophets of the Persian period (for example, 1 Maccabees 9:27 speaks of a time when prophets had ceased to appear, and the historian Josephus wrote similarly). Jesus referred to the Scriptures as "the Law of Moses, the Prophets and the Psalms" (Luke 24:44), matching the Hebrew Bible's three-part arrangement, which contains the same content as the Protestant 39-book Old Testament. The Apocrypha can be valuable history, but it doesn't claim the prophetic authority of "Thus says the LORD." The next prophet, John the Baptist, was announced by an angel, exactly as Malachi promised.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration

Review game plan (last Sunday): "Old Testament Graduation"

1. **Welcome (10 min):** Sing all five verses of the Library Song. Do the Section Shout and the whisper-to-shout Tag ("Shhh... 400 years... JESUS IS COMING!").
2. **39-Book Speed Challenge (5 min):** Classes try to beat their best time.
3. **Old Testament Library Sort (15 min):** Games #5.
4. **Cross the Silent Bridge (10 min):** Games #4, with everyone crossing to the "New Testament" side of the room.
5. **Oral check-offs (15 min):** Use the checklists below; Ambassadors help.
6. **Graduation & Passport ceremony (15 min):** Paper graduation caps (optional), passport stamps, badges, certificates. Close by having the whole group say together, "We know all 39 books of the Old Testament! Next stop: Jesus!"

✅ Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs (4–6)

- [ ] Says the section name: "Minor Prophets"
- [ ] Says at least 3 Minor Prophets (e.g., Jonah, Micah, Malachi)
- [ ] Knows "Malachi is the last book of the Old Testament"
- [ ] Says the Little Lambs verse: "Walk humbly with your God."

Explorers (7–10)

- [ ] Says all 12 Minor Prophets in order
- [ ] Spells all 12 (oral or written; Habakkuk/Zephaniah/Zechariah may be done with a buddy)
- [ ] Says Micah 6:8 from memory
- [ ] Sings the Library Song (all 5 verses)

Trailblazers (11–13)

- [ ] Says all 39 Old Testament books in order (no song)
- [ ] Gives a one-word summary for each Minor Prophet
- [ ] Says Micah 6:8 from memory
- [ ] Explains three ways God prepared the world during the 400 Silent Years

Ambassadors (14–17)

- [ ] Says all 39 Old Testament books in order
- [ ] Says Micah 6:8 and explains each of its three parts
- [ ] Teaches one Minor Prophet (story + motion + spelling) to a younger child
- [ ] Gives a 1-minute explanation of the 400 Silent Years and how Malachi 3:1 links to Mark 1:2

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp the **Minor Prophets** page with a blue fish stamp, AND stamp a special **"Old Testament Complete!"** page with a gold star. Kids write or trace: "I know 39 of 66 books, the whole Old Testament!"

🏅 Badge: "Mighty Twelve"

An ocean-blue shield with a cartoon big fish curving around twelve small gold stars. Beneath the fish, a small stone bridge with the words "400 YEARS → JESUS." Banner: "MINOR PROPHETS · 12 BOOKS · OLD TESTAMENT COMPLETE." (Cardstock badge, sticker, or iron-on patch.)

📜 Certificate wording

> **Purpose Church Sunday School Old Testament Graduate & Mighty Twelve Certificate**

> This certifies that _____ has completed **Phase 8: Twelve Mighty Messengers** and has learned the twelve Minor Prophets: **Hosea · Joel · Amos · Obadiah · Jonah · Micah · Nahum · Habakkuk · Zephaniah · Haggai · Zechariah · Malachi** and has learned **all 39 books of the Old Testament!**
>
> "He has shown you, O mortal, what is good. And what does the LORD require of you? To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God." (Micah 6:8)
>
> **Books learned: 39 of 66** Teacher: _____ Date: _____

Take-Home Family Page

> ✂️ *Copy or print this section and send it home.*

Dear Families,

This month your child learned the **Twelve Minor Prophets**: **Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah and Malachi**. They are "minor" because their books are short, but their messages are mighty: God's love never quits, God cares about justice and kindness, God gives second chances (just ask Jonah!), and a King is coming. Malachi, the last book of the Old Testament, promised a messenger would come to prepare the way. We also learned about the **"400 Silent Years"** between the Testaments, when God was quietly preparing the world for Jesus. **Your child now knows all 39 books of the Old Testament!** Next month we meet Jesus in the Gospels.

📖 **Memory Verse:**

> "He has shown you, O mortal, what is good. And what does the LORD require of you? To act justly and to love mercy and to walk humbly with your God." (Micah 6:8, NIV)
>
> *Little Lambs:* "Walk humbly with your God."

🎵 **This month's song verse (tune: "Yankee Doodle"):**

> Ho-se-a, Jo-el, A-mos, O-ba-di-ah, Jo-nah, Mi-cah, Na-hum, Ha-bak-kuk, Zeph-a-ni-ah, Hag-gai! Zech-a-ri-ah, Mal-a-chi, the twelve Mi-nor Pro-phets! Short books with a might-y word: the Old Tes-ta-ment's done!

(Ask your child to teach you the three silly sentences: "Happy Jellyfish Ate Oranges / Jonah Met Nine Hungry fish / Zebras Hop, Zebras March.")

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions:**

1. Why did Jonah run away from God? What did God do?
2. Micah 6:8 says to act justly, love mercy and walk humbly. Which one can our family practice this week?
3. God was quiet for 400 years but was getting the world ready for Jesus. Have you ever had to wait for something good?

👨‍👩‍👧 **Family activity: "Micah 6:8 Week"** Make three columns on the fridge: **Act Justly**, **Love Mercy**, **Walk Humbly**. Every time someone in the family does one (sharing fairly, forgiving, praying, serving), add a sticker or tally mark. At the end of the week, celebrate with a "Jonah" treat: Swedish Fish or goldfish crackers!

📺 **Videos to watch at home** (search on YouTube; parents, please preview):

- **Sharefaith Kids:** "Jonah," "Hosea," "Zechariah and Elizabeth": https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Jonah
- **Bible Journey:** "Jonah," "Amos," "Zechariah": https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Jonah
- **BibleProject (older kids & parents):** "Overview: Jonah," "Overview: Micah," "Overview: Habakkuk," "Overview: Malachi," and the theme video "Messiah": https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Jonah

Next month: *Meet Jesus!* Matthew, Mark, Luke and John, the four Gospels!

Phase 9: Meet Jesus!

The four Gospels, Matthew, Mark, Luke and John: four true books, one amazing Jesus. The King the whole Old Testament was waiting for has come!

At a Glance

Month	Month 9
Books covered	Matthew, Mark, Luke, John (**4 books**)
Bible section(s)	Gospels (the first section of the New Testament)
Big Idea	Jesus is the promised King, the Servant who came to help and to save, the Savior for everyone, and God's own Son. He died for our sins and rose again!
Memory Verse (all ages)	"For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life." (John 3:16, NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"For God so loved the world." (John 3:16)
Theme color	Sunrise Gold (for the Light of the World and the first Easter morning)
Phase symbol / badge	✝️ The Empty Cross with a sunrise, "I Met Jesus!" badge with four corner icons (crown, running sandals, open arms, heart)
Running total of books learned	**43 of 66** (all 39 Old Testament books + 4 Gospels)

> Cross-links: Program Overview · Teacher Training Guide · Books of the Bible Memory System · Game Library · YouTube Video Guide · Phase 9 Printables

The Big Idea (in kid words)

Remember the long, quiet bridge of 400 years? Now we've crossed it, and **Jesus is here!** The word **Gospel** means **"Good News."** Four writers, Matthew, Mark, Luke and John, each wrote a true book about Jesus' life. Jesus taught about God, healed sick people, calmed a storm, loved people nobody else loved, died on the cross for our sins, and came back to life on the third day!

How this points to Jesus: These books don't just point to Jesus. They show Him to us face to face! Everything the Old Testament promised comes true here: born in Bethlehem (Micah), the messenger John the Baptist (Malachi), the King on a donkey (Zechariah), the Servant pierced for our sins (Isaiah), three days like Jonah, and the Son of Man (Daniel). John tells us why the Gospels were written: "that you may believe that Jesus is the Messiah, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name" (John 20:31).

The Books in Easy Words

> **Four Gospels, one Jesus.** Imagine four people watching the same soccer game from four different seats. One notices the coach, one notices the fast plays, one notices the fans, and one notices the star player's heart. They tell the same true game in four ways. That's like the four Gospels! Each one shows Jesus from a different "seat."
>
> **Teacher note:** Matthew, Mark and Luke are called the **Synoptic Gospels** ("seeing together") because they share many of the same stories in a similar order. John is different: about 90% of John's material is not found in the other three.

1. Matthew 👑

How to say it	MATH-yoo
How to spell it	Mat-thew — **M-A-T-T-H-E-W** (tip: double T, then "HEW." "MAT-THEW." Say "mat" + "thew.")
Section	Gospels (1 of 4), the first book of the New Testament
Traditional author	Matthew (also called Levi), a tax collector who became one of Jesus' twelve disciples (Matthew 9:9; Mark 2:14)
One-sentence kid summary	Matthew shows that Jesus is the promised King from David's family, the one all the Old Testament promises were about.
In one word	**King**
Key people	Jesus, Mary, Joseph, the wise men (Magi), King Herod, John the Baptist, Peter and the twelve disciples
Key stories	Jesus' family tree from Abraham and David (ch. 1); the wise men follow the star (ch. 2); the Sermon on the Mount, with the Beatitudes, "You are the light of the world," the Lord's Prayer, and the wise and foolish builders (ch. 5–7); Peter walks on water (ch. 14); Palm Sunday (ch. 21); the cross and the empty tomb (ch. 27–28); the Great Commission: "Go and make disciples of all nations" (28:18–20)
Where Jesus shows up	Everywhere! Matthew says over and over, "This happened to fulfill what the Lord had said through the prophet..." Matthew begins with Jesus as **Immanuel, "God with us"** (1:23), and ends with Jesus saying, **"I am with you always"** (28:20).
Hand motion / symbol	👑 **Bow to the King**: kneel on one knee and bow your head like the wise men: "Jesus is KING!"

2. Mark 🏃

How to say it	MARK
How to spell it	Mark — **M-A-R-K** (tip: the same as a marker! "On your MARK, get set, GO!")
Section	Gospels (2 of 4)

Traditional author	John Mark, a helper of Peter (1 Peter 5:13) and Paul (2 Timothy 4:11), cousin of Barnabas (Colossians 4:10). Early Christians said Mark wrote down Peter's eyewitness preaching.
One-sentence kid summary	Mark is the shortest, fastest Gospel, full of action, showing Jesus as the powerful Servant who came to help people and give His life for us.
In one word	**Servant** (in action!)
Key people	Jesus, John the Baptist, Peter, James and John, the paralyzed man and his four friends, the Roman centurion
Key stories	Starts fast with John the Baptist and Jesus' baptism (ch. 1); four friends lower a man through a roof (ch. 2); Jesus calms the storm: "Quiet! Be still!" (ch. 4); Jesus heals a girl and a sick woman (ch. 5); feeding the 5,000 (ch. 6); "Let the little children come to me" (ch. 10); the cross: "Surely this man was the Son of God!" (ch. 15); the empty tomb (ch. 16)
Where Jesus shows up	The key verse: "For even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many" (Mark 10:45). Mark opens by quoting Malachi 3:1 and Isaiah 40:3 about the messenger (1:2–3), which links the two Testaments!
Hand motion / symbol	🏃 **Run in place**: pump your arms and shout "IMMEDIATELY!" (Mark uses the word "immediately" or "at once" again and again.)

3. Luke 🩺

How to say it	LUKE (rhymes with "duke" and "nuke," not with "book")
How to spell it	Luke — **L-U-K-E** (tip: a silent E at the end, just like "cute")
Section	Gospels (3 of 4)
Traditional author	Luke, "the doctor" (Colossians 4:14), a traveling partner of Paul. He also wrote **Acts**! He carefully interviewed eyewitnesses (Luke 1:1–4) and wrote to a man named Theophilus.
One-sentence kid summary	Doctor Luke carefully wrote down the true story of Jesus, the Savior who came for everyone, especially the lost, the poor, the sick and the left-out.
In one word	**Savior** (for everyone!)
Key people	Jesus, Mary, Zechariah and Elizabeth, John the Baptist, the shepherds, Simeon and Anna, Mary and Martha, Zacchaeus, the thief on the cross, two travelers to Emmaus
Key stories	Angel Gabriel visits Zechariah and Mary (ch. 1); Jesus born in Bethlehem, with angels and shepherds (ch. 2); 12-year-old Jesus in the temple (ch. 2); the Good Samaritan (ch. 10); the lost sheep, lost coin and lost son (ch. 15); ten lepers healed, one says thank you (ch. 17); Zacchaeus climbs a tree (ch. 19); the cross and the thief: "Today you will be with me in paradise" (ch. 23); the walk to Emmaus (ch. 24)
Where Jesus shows up	Luke's key verse: "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost" (Luke 19:10). The angel announces: "Today in the town of David a Savior has been born to you; he is the Messiah, the Lord" (2:11). On the Emmaus road, Jesus explained how all the Old Testament was about Him (24:27, 44).
Hand motion / symbol	🤗 **Open arms wide**: "Jesus came for EVERYONE!" (or pretend to listen with a doctor's stethoscope).

4. John ❤️

How to say it	JON
How to spell it	John — **J-O-H-N** (tip: the H is silent! J-O-**H**-N. "Jo-(shh)-n.")
Section	Gospels (4 of 4)
Traditional author	John, son of Zebedee, a fisherman, brother of James, and one of Jesus' closest friends. He calls himself "the disciple whom Jesus loved" (John 21:20–24). Traditionally he also wrote 1, 2 and 3 John and Revelation.
One-sentence kid summary	John shows us that Jesus is God's own Son, who came from heaven so that everyone who believes in Him can have life forever.
In one word	**Believe** (Jesus is God's Son)
Key people	Jesus, John the Baptist, Nicodemus, the woman at the well, Mary, Martha and Lazarus, Thomas, Peter, Mary Magdalene
Key stories	"In the beginning was the Word" (ch. 1); water into wine at a wedding (ch. 2); Nicodemus at night and John 3:16 (ch. 3); the woman at the well (ch. 4); feeding the 5,000 and "I am the bread of life" (ch. 6); the man born blind (ch. 9); the Good Shepherd (ch. 10); Lazarus raised from the dead (ch. 11); Jesus washes His disciples' feet (ch. 13); the cross: "It is finished" (ch. 19); Mary Magdalene and Thomas see the risen Jesus (ch. 20); breakfast on the beach (ch. 21)
Where Jesus shows up	John is built around **7 signs** (miracles) and **7 "I AM" sayings**: "I am the bread of life," "the light of the world," "the gate," "the good shepherd," "the resurrection and the life," "the way and the truth and the life," and "the true vine." Thomas's words say it all: "My Lord and my God!" (20:28)
Hand motion / symbol	🌍 **World hug**: draw a big circle in the air (the world), then cross your arms over your heart: "For God so LOVED the world!"

Section summary: The Gospels (4)

#	Book	One word	Shows Jesus as…	Motion
1	Matthew	King	The promised King	Kneel and bow like the wise men
2	Mark	Servant	The Servant in action	Run in place, "Immediately!"
3	Luke	Savior	The Savior for everyone	Open arms wide
4	John	Believe	God's Son	Draw a big world, cross arms over heart

> **Fun teacher fact:** Since the early church, Christians have matched the Gospels with the four living creatures of Ezekiel 1 and Revelation 4 (human, lion, ox, eagle). The most common pairing (from Jerome) is Matthew = human, Mark = lion, Luke = ox, John = eagle. You'll see these symbols in old church art and stained glass. They're tradition, not Scripture, but they can be a fun "spot the symbol" activity!

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher

What is a Gospel? "Gospel" (Greek *euangelion*) means "good news." Each Gospel is a theological biography: a true account of Jesus' life, death and resurrection, shaped to show who Jesus is and why it matters. They aren't a complete diary (John 21:25 says the world couldn't hold all the books!); each writer selected stories for his readers.

Gospel	Likely first readers	Emphasis	Length	Unique highlights
Matthew	Jewish Christians	Jesus the promised Messiah-King; fulfillment of the Old Testament; Jesus' teaching (five big teaching sections)	28 ch.	Wise men, flight to Egypt, Sermon on the Mount (full), Peter walks on water, Great Commission
Mark	Roman / Gentile Christians	Jesus the powerful, suffering Servant; fast-paced action; discipleship includes the cross	16 ch. (shortest)	Fast pace ("immediately"), Jesus' emotions, the centurion's confession
Luke	Theophilus and Gentile readers	Jesus the Savior of all; careful history; outsiders, women, the poor, prayer, the Holy Spirit	24 ch. (longest book in the NT)	Birth of John, shepherds, boy Jesus, Good Samaritan, Lost Son, Zacchaeus, Emmaus
John	Christians and seekers everywhere	Jesus the eternal Son of God; believing in Him brings eternal life	21 ch.	Seven signs, seven "I AM" sayings, Nicodemus, the woman at the well, Lazarus, foot-washing, Thomas

Timeline & map notes.

- Jesus was born **about 6–4 B.C.** (before Herod the Great died in 4 B.C.; our calendar's "year 1" was miscalculated in the 500s A.D.). He grew up in **Nazareth** in Galilee, began His public ministry around age 30 (Luke 3:23), and ministered for about three years. He was crucified under **Pontius Pilate** around **A.D. 30 or 33**, and rose on the third day.
- Draw a simple map of Israel: **Galilee** (north, with the Sea of Galilee, Nazareth, Capernaum, Cana), **Samaria** (middle, where the woman at the well lived), and **Judea** (south, with Jerusalem, Bethlehem, Bethany and Jericho, Zacchaeus's town). The **Jordan River** connects the Sea of Galilee to the Dead Sea (Jesus was baptized there).
- The Gospels were likely written between about A.D. 50 and 95, within the lifetime of eyewitnesses (compare 1 Corinthians 15:3–8, which Paul wrote around A.D. 55 and which includes an even earlier creed).

Connections to Phase 8 (the bridge). Start Week 1 with a quick recap: Malachi promised a messenger → 400 quiet years → Gabriel visits Zechariah (Luke 1) → John the Baptist "prepares the way" (Mark 1:2–4) → Jesus! Point out that the empires from the bridge show up now: Caesar Augustus (Luke 2:1), Herod (Matthew 2), Roman soldiers and Pilate, Pharisees and Sadducees, synagogues, and the Greek language the Gospels were written in.

Key truths to emphasize

- **Jesus is fully God and fully human.** He got tired and wept (John 4:6; 11:35), and He calmed storms and forgave sins (Mark 2:5–12; 4:39).
- **Jesus fulfilled the Old Testament promises.**
- **Jesus loves everyone**, including children, outsiders, sinners and the sick.
- **Jesus died on the cross for our sins** and **rose again on the third day.** This is the center of the gospel (1 Corinthians 15:3–4).
- **We are saved by believing in Jesus** (John 3:16; 20:31), not by being good enough.
- **Jesus calls us to follow Him** and tell others (Matthew 28:19–20).

🙏 Sharing the gospel and responding (important for this phase)

This phase naturally invites kids to trust Jesus. Be ready, warm and **never pressuring**. A simple "ABC" outline:

- **A**dmit: "I have sinned and need God's forgiveness" (Romans 3:23).
- **B**elieve: "Jesus is God's Son, He died for my sins, and He rose again" (John 3:16; Romans 10:9).
- **C**hoose to follow: "I want Jesus to be my Lord and Savior and to follow Him" (John 1:12).

If a child wants to talk or pray, do so in a visible, open space (follow your church's child-safety policy) with another adult nearby. Pray simply together, celebrate, and **tell the parents** (and your pastor/children's director) so they can follow up. Avoid group "raise your hand" pressure with young children; offer individual conversations instead.

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
The crucifixion	"Bad men hurt Jesus and He died on a cross. But He let it happen because He loves us, and three days later He came alive again!" Always tell the resurrection in the same breath.	Tell the story plainly (soldiers, the cross, "It is finished"), without graphic description; emphasize love and the resurrection.	Explain why Jesus died (our sins; Isaiah 53:5; Mark 10:45). Discuss Peter's denial and restoration.	Discuss substitutionary atonement, the historical evidence for the crucifixion and resurrection, and why it matters.
Herod killing Bethlehem's baby boys (Matt. 2:16)	Skip. "An angel warned Joseph to take Jesus to Egypt to keep Him safe."	Mention briefly: "Jealous King Herod wanted to hurt baby Jesus."	Briefly mention; Herod's known cruelty fits history.	Discuss evil, suffering and God's protection of His plan (and Jeremiah 31:15 in Matt. 2:18).

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers (11–13)	Ambassadors (14–17)
Death (Lazarus, Jairus's daughter)	"Jesus is stronger than death!"	Talk honestly; Jesus wept with His friends.	Discuss grief and hope (1 Thess. 4:13).	Discuss resurrection hope and the problem of suffering.
Demons / evil spirits (e.g., Mark 5)	Skip or say "Jesus made a very sick man well."	"Jesus is more powerful than anything evil."	Read Mark 5 with discussion.	Discuss spiritual reality with balance: Jesus has all authority (Col. 2:15).
John the Baptist's death (Mark 6)	Skip.	Skip or "A bad king put John in jail."	Optional, brief.	Optional discussion of faithfulness and cost.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

1. **"Was Jesus a real person?"** Yes! Four Gospels written within one lifetime of Jesus tell about Him, and even non-Christian historians from the first and early second centuries (such as the Jewish historian Josephus and the Roman historian Tacitus) mention Him.
2. **"Is Jesus God or God's Son?"** Both! Christians believe in one God in three persons: the Father, the Son and the Holy Spirit. Jesus is God the Son, who became a human baby (John 1:1, 14).
3. **"Why are there four Gospels instead of one?"** Each writer shows a different side of Jesus, like four photos of the same person from different angles. Having four witnesses also makes the story even more trustworthy (Deuteronomy 19:15).
4. **"Why did Jesus have to die?"** Sin separates us from God and deserves punishment. Jesus, who never sinned, took our punishment in our place so we could be forgiven (Isaiah 53:5; 1 Peter 3:18).
5. **"How did Jesus come back to life?"** God the Father raised Him by His power (Acts 2:24). Many people saw Him alive: the women, the disciples, Thomas, and over 500 people at once (1 Corinthians 15:6).
6. **"Where is Jesus now?"** He went back up to heaven (Luke 24:51; Acts 1:9). He is alive, He hears our prayers, and He promised to come back.
7. **"Did Jesus have brothers and sisters?"** The Gospels mention brothers, including James and Jude, and sisters (Mark 6:3). (Teachers: some Christian traditions understand these as cousins or step-siblings; keep it simple.)
8. **"Can I be Jesus' friend even though I'm a kid?"** Yes! Jesus said, "Let the little children come to me, and do not hinder them" (Mark 10:14).

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	📺 Video	🎮 Game	🖍️ Activity
1	Matthew 2:1–12; 5:14–16; 7:24–27; 28:18–20	"Jesus Is the King!" (Matthew)	Jesus is the promised King, and He is with us always.	BibleProject "Overview: Matthew 1-13" & "Matthew 14-28"; Sharefaith Kids "Wise Men"; Bible Journey "Matthew"	Gospel Four Corners	King Jesus Crown
2	Mark 2:1–12; 4:35–41; 10:45	"Jesus the Mighty Servant" (Mark)	Jesus has power over sickness, sin and storms, and He came to serve.	BibleProject "Overview: Mark"; Sharefaith Kids "Jesus Calms the Storm"; Bible Journey "Mark"	Through the Roof Relay	Through-the-Roof House
3	Luke 2:8–20; 19:1–10	"A Savior for Everyone!" (Luke)	Jesus came to seek and save the lost, including me!	BibleProject "Overview: Luke 1-9" & "Luke 10-24"; Sharefaith Kids "Zacchaeus"; Bible Journey "Luke"	Zacchaeus, Come Down!	Pop-Up Zacchaeus Tree
4	John 11:25; 19:16–30; 20:1–29; 20:31	"He Is Alive!" (John)	Jesus is God's Son. He died for us and rose again, so believe!	BibleProject "Overview: John 1-12" & "John 13-21"; Sharefaith Kids "Easter / He Is Risen"; Bible Journey "John"	Empty Tomb Treasure Hunt	Rolling-Stone Tomb
5 *(optional)*	Review all 4 Gospels	"Good News Party Sunday"	Four Gospels, one Jesus, and the good news is for you!	Favorite clip review + BibleProject "Gospel of the Kingdom"	Fishers of People Net Tag	Passport Stamp, Badge & Gospel Bracelets

Weekly Lessons

Week 1: "Jesus Is the King!" (Matthew)

Scripture: Matthew 1:21–23; 2:1–12; 5:14–16; 7:24–27; 28:18–20

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that the New Testament begins with Matthew, that Matthew shows Jesus is the promised King (born in Bethlehem, worshiped by the wise men), that Jesus taught people how to live in His kingdom, and that King Jesus promises to be with us always.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Across the Bridge"

- *Supplies:* The floor "bridge" from Phase 8 (painter's tape), a gold paper crown, a flashlight (for the star), a small gift box with three small items (something gold, a small candle or spice for "frankincense," and a small jar for "myrrh").
- *Do:* Have kids walk silently across the bridge one more time: "Shhh... 400 years... Malachi said a messenger and the King would come..." At the far end, turn on the flashlight like a star and set the crown on a chair: "THE KING IS HERE! Welcome to the **New Testament**! The first book is Matthew, and Matthew wants you to know: Jesus is the KING!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Matthew had a job that most people didn't like. He was a tax collector, and many tax collectors cheated people. But one day Jesus walked by Matthew's tax booth and said two words: "Follow me." And Matthew got up, left everything and followed Jesus! Later, Matthew wrote a book to show everyone who Jesus really is: **the King!**
>
> Matthew starts with Jesus' family tree, going all the way back to King David and to Abraham. Jesus was from the royal family, just like God promised!
>
> Then Matthew tells how an angel told Joseph, "Mary will give birth to a son, and you are to give him the name Jesus, because he will save his people from their sins." Matthew says this happened to make Isaiah's promise come true: "They will call him Immanuel," which means "God with us."
>
> When Jesus was born in Bethlehem, wise men from far away in the east saw a special star. They traveled a long way to Jerusalem and asked, "Where is the one who has been born king of the Jews? We saw his star and have come to worship him."
>
> King Herod was not happy! He didn't want another king. He asked the priests, "Where will the Messiah be born?" They said, "In Bethlehem! The prophet Micah wrote it."
>
> The star led the wise men right to the house where Jesus was. They bowed down and worshiped Him, and they gave Him treasures: gold, frankincense and myrrh, gifts fit for a king! Then God warned them in a dream not to go back to Herod, so they went home another way.
>
> When Jesus grew up, He taught people about His kingdom. He sat on a mountainside and said, "You are the light of the world... let your light shine before others." He taught them to pray, "Our Father in heaven, hallowed be your name..." And He said, "Everyone who hears these words of mine and puts them into practice is like a wise man who built his house on the rock." When the storm came, the house on the rock stood strong!
>
> At the very end of Matthew, after Jesus died and rose again, He gathered His disciples on a mountain and said, "All authority in heaven and on earth has been given to me. Therefore go and make disciples of all nations... And surely I am with you always, to the very end of the age."
>
> Jesus is the King. He is God with us. And He is with you, always!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Give each child a turn wearing the crown and saying "Jesus is KING!" Act out the wise men following the flashlight star. Sing "The Wise Man Built His House upon the Rock" (traditional) with motions. Main idea: *Jesus is the King, and He's with me.*
- **Explorers:** Have kids find Matthew 1:1, the first page of the New Testament, and notice how many books come before it (39!). Read the Lord's Prayer together (Matthew 6:9–13).
- **Trailblazers:** Hunt for "fulfilled" verses in Matthew 1–2 (1:22–23 Isaiah; 2:5–6 Micah; 2:15 Hosea; 2:17–18 Jeremiah). Connect each one to the Phase 7 and Phase 8 prophets.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss the Great Commission (28:18–20): what does "make disciples" mean in daily life? Compare Matthew's first and last chapters ("God with us," 1:23, and "I am with you always," 28:20).

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) What did the wise men follow? (A star!) (2) What did they give Jesus? (Presents: gold!) (3) Who is the King? (Jesus!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What was Matthew's job before he followed Jesus? (Tax collector.) (2) What does "Immanuel" mean? ("God with us.") (3) What happened to the house built on the rock?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why do you think Matthew began with a family tree? (2) Which Old Testament prophet said Jesus would be born in Bethlehem? (Micah.) (3) What does it mean to be "the light of the world"?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Why was King Herod threatened by baby Jesus? Are people still threatened by Jesus' kingship today? (2) What does it look like to build your life "on the rock"? (3) Who is one person you could help "become a disciple"?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Wise Men" (or "Sermon on the Mount" / "Wise and Foolish Builders")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Wise+Men
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Matthew" (or "Birth of Jesus")	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Matthew
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Matthew 1-13" and "Overview: Matthew 14-28"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Matthew

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) How does Matthew show that Jesus is the King? (2) What did Jesus teach about how to live in His kingdom?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Gospel Four Corners*, see Games #1.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *King Jesus Crown*, see Activities #1. Coloring Page 1: "The Wise Men Worship the King."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Introduce John 3:16 (all ages) and "For God so loved the world" (Little Lambs). Spell **M-A-T-T-H-E-W** (double T!). Learn the new section shout: "FOUR GOSPELS!"

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear Jesus, You are the King! Thank You for being "God with us." Help us build our lives on You like a house on the rock. Thank You for being with us always. Amen.

Week 2: "Jesus the Mighty Servant" (Mark)

Scripture: Mark 1:1–3; 2:1–12; 4:35–41; 10:45

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Mark is the shortest, action-packed Gospel, that Jesus has power over sickness, sin and storms, and that Jesus, the mighty one, came to serve and to give His life for us.

Opening hook / object lesson: "On Your Mark!"

- *Supplies:* A stopwatch, a "START" line on the floor, a small blanket or towel (the mat), a spray bottle (storm), a fan (optional).
- *Do:* Line kids up: "On your MARK... get set... GO!" Have them race to the wall and back. "That was fast! Today's book is like that race: it's called **Mark**, and it's the fastest Gospel. Mark keeps saying 'immediately!' Jesus did this, and immediately He did that! Let's see what Jesus did in Mark."

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> Mark's book starts fast. There's no baby Jesus, no shepherds or wise men. Mark jumps right in: "The beginning of the good news about Jesus the Messiah, the Son of God!" John the Baptist is preaching by the river, Jesus is baptized, and *immediately* Jesus starts teaching, healing and helping people!
>
> One day Jesus was teaching in a house in the town of Capernaum. So many people came that the house was packed. People were squished inside and crowded outside the door. Nobody else could get in!
>
> Four friends came carrying a man on a mat. Their friend was paralyzed: he couldn't walk at all. "We have to get him to Jesus!" they said. But they couldn't get through the crowd.
>
> So what did they do? They climbed up onto the flat roof! They dug a big hole right through the roof, *scrape, scrape, scrape*, and they lowered their friend on his mat, right down in front of Jesus!
>
> Jesus saw their faith. He looked at the man and said, "Son, your sins are forgiven."
>
> Some teachers of the law thought, "What? Only God can forgive sins!" Jesus knew what they were thinking. He said, "So that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins..." He turned to the man: "Get up, take your mat and go home." And immediately the man stood

> up, picked up his mat and walked out in front of everyone! The people were amazed and praised God: "We have never seen anything like this!"
>
> Another day, Jesus and His disciples got into a boat to cross the Sea of Galilee. Jesus was tired, so He lay down in the back of the boat on a cushion and fell asleep. Suddenly a furious storm came up! The waves crashed over the boat, and it was filling up with water!
>
> The disciples woke Jesus. "Teacher, don't you care if we drown?"
>
> Jesus got up. He spoke to the wind and the waves: "Quiet! Be still!" And immediately, the wind stopped and everything became completely calm.
>
> The disciples were amazed. "Who is this? Even the wind and the waves obey him!"
>
> Jesus is the mighty Son of God. He can heal, forgive and calm storms. But listen to what Jesus said about why He came: "For even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many." The mightiest person ever came to be a servant and to give His life for us on the cross!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Act out the roof story with a towel "mat" and a teddy bear: four kids hold the corners and "lower" the bear onto a table. Then make a "storm" (wiggle, blow, sway) until you say "Quiet! Be still!" and everyone freezes. Main idea: *Jesus is strong and He helps me.*
- **Explorers:** Count how many times Mark 1 says "immediately," "at once" or "just as" (the exact number varies by translation; NIV uses several of these). Discuss: "Who are friends you could bring to Jesus?"
- **Trailblazers:** Read Mark 2:7–12. Why did Jesus forgive sins *before* healing? (He was showing He is God.) Read Mark 1:2–3 and find the Malachi and Isaiah quotes from the last two phases.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Mark 10:42–45: how is greatness in Jesus' kingdom different from the world's idea? Optional: discuss why many Bibles note that Mark 16:9–20 isn't in the earliest manuscripts, and how this is handled honestly by evangelical scholars (no Christian doctrine depends on those verses).

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) How did the friends get their friend to Jesus? (Through the roof!) (2) What did Jesus say to the storm? ("Quiet! Be still!") (3) Is Jesus strong? (Yes!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What did Jesus say to the paralyzed man first? ("Your sins are forgiven.") (2) What was Jesus doing when the storm started? (Sleeping!) (3) What did the disciples ask after the storm stopped?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why were the teachers of the law upset? (2) What do the friends teach us about bringing others to Jesus? (3) What does it mean that Jesus came "to serve"?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Which storms in your life do you need to trust Jesus with? (2) How does the forgiving-then-healing order show Jesus' identity? (3) What does serving like Jesus look like at school, at home or on a team?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Jesus Calms the Storm" (or "Through the Roof")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Jesus+Calms+the+Storm
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Mark" (or "Jesus Heals Paralyzed Man")	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Mark
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Mark"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Mark

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) What did Jesus' miracles show about who He is? (2) How did Jesus show He came to serve?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Through the Roof Relay*, see Games #2 (plus *Quiet! Be Still! Freeze*, Games #4).

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Through-the-Roof House*, see Activities #2. Coloring Page 2: "Through the Roof!"

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **M-A-R-K**. Say "Matthew, Mark" with motions. Practice John 3:16 in two halves.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear Jesus, You are mighty! You can calm any storm. Thank You for coming to serve us and to give Your life for us. Help us bring our friends to You. Amen.

Week 3: "A Savior for Everyone!" (Luke)

Scripture: Luke 1:1–4; 2:8–20; 19:1–10

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that Doctor Luke carefully wrote the true story of Jesus, that the angels announced Jesus as a Savior for all people, and that Jesus came "to seek and to save the lost," even people like Zacchaeus whom others didn't like.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Lost and Found"

- *Supplies:* A small toy sheep (or a coin) hidden somewhere in the room before class, a toy stethoscope or doctor's bag, a "step stool" or chair.
- *Do:* Put on the stethoscope: "Today's book was written by a doctor! His name is Luke. But first: oh no, I've lost my little sheep! Can you help me find it?" Let kids search. When it's found, celebrate wildly! "That's how Jesus feels about people who are lost from God. Doctor Luke tells us Jesus came to find the lost!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

Luke was a doctor and a careful writer. He said, "I have carefully investigated everything from the beginning," and he talked to people who had seen Jesus with their own eyes. Then he wrote it all down so we could know it's true.

Luke tells us that on the night Jesus was born, some shepherds were out in the fields near Bethlehem, watching their sheep. Shepherds were poor, smelly and often ignored by important people. But God sent His angel to *them* first!

Suddenly an angel appeared, and the glory of the Lord shone all around. The shepherds were terrified! But the angel said, "Do not be afraid. I bring you good news that will cause great joy for **all** the people. Today in the town of David a Savior has been born to you; he is the Messiah, the Lord." Then a huge army of angels appeared, praising God: "Glory to God in the highest heaven, and on earth peace!"

The shepherds hurried to Bethlehem and found Mary, Joseph and baby Jesus, lying in a manger, just as the angel said. They told everyone what they had seen!

Years later, when Jesus was grown up, He walked through the city of Jericho. A huge crowd was there. In that city lived a man named **Zacchaeus**. He was a chief tax collector, and he was very rich, because he had cheated people. Nobody liked Zacchaeus.

Zacchaeus wanted to see Jesus, but he had a problem: he was short! He couldn't see over the crowd. So he ran ahead and climbed up into a sycamore-fig tree.

When Jesus came to that spot, He stopped, looked up into the tree and said, "Zacchaeus, come down immediately. I must stay at your house today."

Zacchaeus scrambled down and welcomed Jesus with joy! But the people grumbled, "Jesus is going to be the guest of a sinner!"

But Zacchaeus's heart had changed. He stood up and said, "Look, Lord! Here and now I give half of my possessions to the poor, and if I have cheated anybody out of anything, I will pay back four times the amount."

Jesus smiled and said, "Today salvation has come to this house... For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost."

Shepherds or rich men, little kids or grown-ups, people everyone likes or people nobody likes: Jesus came to be the Savior for everyone. That includes you!

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Have kids "climb a tree" (stand on tiptoes, reach up), then call each child by name: "____, come down! I want to be your friend!" Main idea: *Jesus knows my name and loves me.*
- **Explorers:** Sing the traditional "Zacchaeus Was a Wee Little Man" song with motions. Find Luke 2:11 and Luke 19:10 in the Bible.

- **Trailblazers:** Read Luke 1:1–4 and discuss what makes Luke a careful historian. Compare Luke 15 (lost sheep, coin, son) with the Zacchaeus story: what's the common theme?
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Zacchaeus's repentance: what does real change look like (making things right, generosity)? Discuss who the "Zacchaeuses" are in your school, the people others avoid.

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Who did the angels visit? (Shepherds!) (2) Where did Zacchaeus climb? (A tree!) (3) Does Jesus love everyone? (Yes!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What was Luke's job? (Doctor.) (2) What did the angel say the good news was? (3) What did Zacchaeus promise to do after he met Jesus?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why do you think God told shepherds first? (2) Why did people grumble about Jesus visiting Zacchaeus? (3) What does Luke 19:10 tell us about why Jesus came?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) How does Luke show special care for the poor and outsiders? (2) What does real repentance look like in Zacchaeus? (3) How can you "seek the lost" the way Jesus did?

📺 **Video for the week:**

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Zacchaeus" (or "Shepherds and Angels")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Zacchaeus
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"Luke" (or "Zacchaeus")	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Luke
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: Luke 1-9" and "Overview: Luke 10-24"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Luke

Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: (1) Who did Jesus reach out to that others ignored? (2) What changed in Zacchaeus after he met Jesus?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Zacchaeus, Come Down!*, see Games #3.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Pop-Up Zacchaeus Tree*, see Activities #3. Coloring Page 3: "Zacchaeus in the Tree."

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **L-U-K-E** (silent E). Say "Matthew, Mark, Luke" with motions. Say John 3:16 all the way through.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear Jesus, thank You for coming to find the lost. Thank You that You know our names and love everyone. Help us to be kind to people others leave out. Amen.

Week 4: "He Is Alive!" (John)

Scripture: John 3:16; 11:25; 19:16–30; 20:1–29; 20:31

Lesson goal: Kids will learn that John shows Jesus is God's Son, that Jesus died on the cross for our sins ("It is finished!") and rose again on the third day, and that John wrote so that we would **believe** and have life in Jesus' name.

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Empty Box"

- *Supplies:* A box or plastic egg decorated like a tomb with a "stone" lid, empty inside except for a folded strip of white cloth; a small cross; a flashlight.
- *Do:* "This box is like a tomb, a place where people were buried. What do you think is inside?" Let kids guess. Slowly open it: only a folded cloth! "It's EMPTY! Today we find out why the most important tomb in history is empty!"

📖 **Story script (read aloud):**

> John was one of Jesus' closest friends. He was a fisherman who left his nets to follow Jesus. He called himself "the disciple whom Jesus loved." Many years later, John wrote down what he had seen so that we would believe that Jesus is God's Son.
>
> John saw Jesus do amazing signs: turn water into wine, feed 5,000 people with one boy's lunch, walk on water, and open the eyes of a man born blind. John heard Jesus say, "I am the light of the world," "I am the good shepherd," and "I am the way and the truth and the life."
>
> Once, Jesus' friend Lazarus died. When Jesus arrived, Lazarus had been in the tomb for four days. Jesus told Lazarus's sister Martha, "I am the resurrection and the life." Jesus cried with His friends. Then He called out in a loud voice, "Lazarus, come out!" And Lazarus walked out of the tomb, alive!
>
> But some leaders hated Jesus. They had Him arrested. Roman soldiers made fun of Him and put a crown of thorns on His head. Then they nailed Him to a wooden cross. John was there, standing near the cross with Jesus' mother, Mary. Even while He was suffering, Jesus cared for His mom and asked John to take care of her.
>
> Then Jesus said, "It is finished." He bowed His head and died. Jesus had finished the job He came to do: paying for our sins, taking the punishment we deserved, because He loves us. His friends gently laid His body in a tomb, a cave in a garden, and a big stone was rolled in front.
>
> Everyone was so sad. But that's not the end of the story!
>
> Early on Sunday morning, while it was still dark, Mary Magdalene went to the tomb. The stone had been rolled away! She ran to tell Peter and John. They ran to the tomb. John ran faster and got there first! Inside, they saw the strips of linen cloth lying there, and the cloth that had been around Jesus' head folded up by itself. The tomb was **empty**!
>
> Mary stayed outside, crying. Then she turned around and saw a man. She thought he was the gardener. Then He said her name: "Mary." She knew that voice. It was **Jesus! He was ALIVE!**

> Later Jesus appeared to His disciples. But Thomas wasn't there, and he said, "Unless I see the nail marks in his hands... I will not believe." A week later, Jesus came again and said, "Thomas, put your finger here; see my hands... Stop doubting and believe." Thomas fell down and said, "My Lord and my God!"
>
> John wrote: "These are written that you may believe that Jesus is the Messiah, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name." Because "God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life." **Jesus is alive!**

Age-group teaching tips:

- **Little Lambs:** Use the box: "Jesus died... (close box) ...but on Sunday... (open box) ...He's ALIVE!" Repeat several times, and have kids shout "He's ALIVE!" Main idea: *Jesus loves me so much He died for me, and He's alive!*
- **Explorers:** List the 7 "I AM" sayings on the board and let kids draw a symbol for each. Practice John 3:16 with motions (heart, world/circle, "gave" with open hands, "believe" pointing to the head and heart, "eternal life" hands circling forever).
- **Trailblazers:** Read John 20:30–31 and discuss John's purpose. Read the Thomas story: is it okay to have questions? How did Jesus respond to Thomas's doubt (with evidence and invitation, not anger)?
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss evidence for the resurrection: the empty tomb, the many eyewitnesses (1 Cor. 15:3–8), women as the first witnesses (unlikely to be invented in that culture), and the transformed disciples who were willing to suffer. Ambassadors can lead a younger group in the "Empty Tomb Treasure Hunt."

Discussion questions:

- *Little Lambs:* (1) Where did Jesus die? (On a cross.) (2) What did Mary find at the tomb? (It was empty!) (3) Is Jesus alive today? (YES!)
- *Explorers:* (1) What did Jesus say before Lazarus came out? ("I am the resurrection and the life.") (2) What did Jesus mean by "It is finished"? (3) What did Thomas say when he saw Jesus?
- *Trailblazers:* (1) Why did Jesus have to die? (2) Who were the first people to see the empty tomb and the risen Jesus? (3) Why did John write his book (John 20:31)?
- *Ambassadors:* (1) Which evidence for the resurrection do you find strongest? (2) How would you explain John 3:16 to a friend who's never been to church? (3) What difference does the resurrection make for how you face death, fear or failure?

📺 Video for the week:

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@SharefaithKids	Little Lambs & Explorers	"Easter" / "He Is Risen" (or "Lazarus")	https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Easter
@BibleJourneyTV	Explorers & Trailblazers	"John" (or "Resurrection")	https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Resurrection

Channel	Best for	Search term	Link
@bibleproject	Trailblazers & Ambassadors	"Overview: John 1-12" and "Overview: John 13-21"	https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+John

Preview every video before class, especially crucifixion scenes, for Little Lambs. Follow-up questions: (1) What did the video show about why Jesus died? (2) How did Jesus' friends react when they saw He was alive?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Empty Tomb Treasure Hunt*, see Games #5.

🖍️ **Activity of the week:** *Rolling-Stone Tomb*, see Activities #4. Coloring Page 4: "He Is Risen!"

🔤 **Memory / spelling focus:** Spell **J-O-H-N** (silent H). Say all 4 Gospels, then all 43 books! Begin oral check-offs.

🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> Dear Jesus, thank You for loving us so much that You died on the cross for our sins. Thank You that You are ALIVE! Help us believe in You and follow You forever. Amen.

(Teacher: After the prayer, gently let kids know that anyone who has questions about following Jesus can talk with you or their parents. See "Sharing the gospel and responding" above.)

Week 5 (optional): "Good News Party Sunday"

Use the End-of-Phase Review & Celebration plan below. Play *Fishers of People Net Tag* (Games #6), make Gospel Bracelets (Activities #5), finish oral check-offs, stamp Bible Passports, and award the ✝️ "I Met Jesus!" badge.

Book Memory Song & Motions

🎵 "The Library Song": the Old Testament plus the Gospels!

Verses 1–4 use **"Ten Little Fingers,"** Verse 5 uses **"Yankee Doodle,"** and the NEW Verse 6 uses **"Frère Jacques" ("Are You Sleeping?")**. Before Verse 6, everyone whispers the **Bridge**: "Shhh... 400 years..." and then shouts "JESUS IS HERE!" All lyrics are written out below; sing them every week.

Verse 1: LAW (5) *(tune: Ten Little Fingers)*

> Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, the books of the Law! Genesis, Exodus,

> Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy, FIVE!

Verse 2: HISTORY (12)

> Joshua, Judges, Ruth, and First and Second Samuel, First and Second Kings, then First and Second Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, and Esther: History! Twelve books of HIS-TO-RY!

Verse 3: POETRY / WISDOM (5)

> Job and Psalms and Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs, they're Poetry and Wisdom! Job and Psalms and Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs, that's FIVE!

Verse 4: MAJOR PROPHETS (5)

> I-sai-ah, Jer-e-mi-ah, Lam-en-ta-tions, E-ze-kiel and Dan-iel, the Ma-jor Pro-phets! I-sai-ah, Jer-e-mi-ah, Lam-en-ta-tions, E-ze-kiel, Dan-iel: FIVE!

Verse 5: MINOR PROPHETS (12) *(tune: Yankee Doodle)*

> Ho-se-a, Jo-el, A-mos, O-ba-di-ah, Jo-nah, Mi-cah, Na-hum, Ha-bak-kuk, Zeph-a-ni-ah, Hag-gai! Zech-a-ri-ah, Mal-a-chi, the twelve Mi-nor Pro-phets! Short books with a might-y word: the Old Tes-ta-ment's done!

🌉 **The Bridge (spoken)**

> *(whisper)* Shhh... four hundred years... God was getting ready... *(shout)* JESUS IS HERE!

Verse 6: THE GOSPELS (4), NEW! *(tune: Frère Jacques; each line is sung twice)*

> **Mat-thew, Mark, Luke,** *(Mat-thew, Mark, Luke,)* **Then comes John!** *(Then comes John!)* **Tell-ing us of Je-sus,** *(Tell-ing us of Je-sus,)* **Good News: FOUR!** *(Good News: FOUR!)*

Tag (shout it!)

> Thirty-nine and FOUR makes... FORTY-THREE! JESUS DIED AND ROSE FOR ME!

Bonus round (sing it as a round!): Because "Frère Jacques" is a round, split the class into 2–4 groups and sing Verse 6 as a round. Group 2 starts when Group 1 reaches "Then comes John!" It sounds amazing, and it drills the four names over and over.

Hand motions for the 4 new books

Book	Motion
Matthew	Kneel on one knee and bow your head like the wise men: "King!"
Mark	Run in place, pumping your arms: "Immediately!"
Luke	Open your arms wide: "For everyone!"
John	Draw a big circle in the air (the world), then cross your arms over your heart: "God so loved the world!"

Review motions for books learned earlier (1–39). These match the motions used in earlier phases and the Books of the Bible Memory System:

Section	Book → motion
Law	Genesis: palms together like a book, open, sweep arms up (sunrise) · Exodus: walk two fingers across your palm and out the "door" · Leviticus: fold hands in prayer, then raise them high · Numbers: count 1-2-3-4 on fingers, then zig-zag your hand · Deuteronomy: two fingers up, tap your head, hand on heart
History	Joshua: march with a fist-trumpet · Judges: pound a gavel on your palm, then draw a circle · Ruth: scoop grain, then hug yourself · 1 & 2 Samuel: hold up 1 or 2 fingers, then cup your ear (listening) · 1 & 2 Kings: 1 or 2 fingers, then crown on head · 1 & 2 Chronicles: 1 or 2 fingers, then unroll a scroll · Ezra: stack fists like bricks · Nehemiah: hammer + shield · Esther: crown, then "speak up" hands at mouth
Poetry / Wisdom	Job: hands open up, then fold over heart · Psalms: strum a harp · Proverbs: tap your head with one finger · Ecclesiastes: blow a puff into your hand, then point up · Song of Songs: heart hands
Major Prophets	Isaiah: two fingers to lips, then hand up ("Send me!") · Jeremiah: shape clay in a circle · Lamentations: tears down cheeks, then arms up like a sunrise · Ezekiel: go floppy, then stand tall · Daniel: lion jaws snap shut
Minor Prophets	Hosea: arms out, pull back in ("Come home!") · Joel: locust fingers · Amos: drop a plumb line · Obadiah: one finger · Jonah: fish-mouth gulp · Micah: tiny roof · Nahum: fist tower tumbles · Habakkuk: hand over eyes (watchtower) · Zephaniah: song floats from heart · Haggai: hammer, then roof over head · Zechariah: donkey ride · Malachi: hand at mouth, point ahead

📣 Section Shout

> **Teacher:** "What does Gospel mean?" **Kids:** "GOOD NEWS!" **Teacher:** "How many Gospels?" **Kids:** "FOUR GOSPELS, ONE JESUS!" **Teacher:** "Name them!" **Kids (with motions):** "MATTHEW, MARK, LUKE AND JOHN!" **Teacher:** "Where is Jesus now?" **Kids:** "HE'S ALIVE!"

Cumulative recall drill (5 minutes)

1. **Testament Toss:** Toss a soft ball to a child and call "Old" or "New." The child names any book from that Testament. (So far, the only New Testament books are the 4 Gospels!)
2. **Section Stand-Up:** Law → History → Poetry/Wisdom → Major → Minor → Gospels. Each group stands and says its books.
3. **Before & After across the bridge:** "What's the last book of the Old Testament?" (Malachi) "What's the first book of the New Testament?" (Matthew) "What's after Luke?" (John)
4. **Gospel Stories Match:** Teacher says a story; kids shout and do the motion of the Gospel it's (most famously) from: "Zacchaeus!" (Luke) "Wise men!" (Matthew) "Thomas sees Jesus!" (John) "Friends through the roof!" (Mark, also in Matthew and Luke!)
5. **43-Book Marathon (Trailblazers+):** Say all 43 books in order. Time it.

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on "Matthew, Mark, Luke and John," the motions, and "Gospel means Good News." The Frère Jacques verse is very easy for them!
- **Explorers:** Goal: say and spell all four Gospels; sing all six verses.
- **Trailblazers:** Goal: say all 43 books in order without the song; give each Gospel's "one word" and one key story.
- **Ambassadors:** Goal: say all 43 books; lead the round; explain why there are four Gospels.

Spelling & Reading

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letter recognition & first sounds)

Book	First letter	Sound it out	Picture clue
Matthew	**M**	"m-m-m"	👑 crown
Mark	**M**	"m-m-m"	🏃 runner
Luke	**L**	"l-l-l"	🤗 open arms
John	**J**	"j-j-j"	❤️ heart
Jesus	**J**	"j-j-j"	✝️ cross

Bonus: "Two M's, then L, then J!" (M-M-L-J). Clap it: "M! M! L! J!"

Explorers (book names)

1. Matthew
2. Mark
3. Luke
4. John

5. Gospel
6. Jesus
7. *Review:* Malachi, Micah, Isaiah, Genesis, Psalms

Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocabulary words)

- Book names: Matthew, Mark, Luke, John
- Vocab: **gospel**, **disciple**, **miracle**, **parable**, **resurrection**

Ambassadors (book names + harder vocabulary with definitions)

Word	Definition
Gospel	"Good news": the message that Jesus died for our sins and rose again; also the name for the four books about His life.
Disciple	A follower and learner who lives the way the teacher lives.
Parable	A short story Jesus told, using everyday things to teach a spiritual truth (e.g., the Lost Son).
Synoptic	"Seeing together": Matthew, Mark and Luke, which share many of the same stories.
Incarnation	God the Son becoming a human being ("The Word became flesh," John 1:14).
Atonement	Jesus' death making us "at one" with God by paying for our sin.
Resurrection	Rising from the dead to a new, never-dying body, as Jesus did on the third day.
Messiah / Christ	"Anointed One," the promised King. "Christ" is the Greek word, not Jesus' last name!
Repentance	Turning away from sin and toward God (like Zacchaeus).

👏 Syllable-clap method

Book	Claps	Spell in rhythm
Mat-thew	2	M-A-T · T-H-E-W
Mark	1	M-A-R-K
Luke	1	L-U-K-E
John	1	J-O-H-N
Gos-pel	2	G-O-S · P-E-L
Je-sus	2	J-E · S-U-S

Tricky-spot alerts: Ma**TT**hew (double T, and "TH" sounds like "T" here, not like "the"), Luk**E** (silent E), Jo**H**n (silent H).

🏃 "Spell It Out" relay

1. Teams line up. At the far end, each team has a basket of letter cards for M-A-T-T-H-E-W, M-A-R-K, L-U-K-E and J-O-H-N, all mixed together.

2. Call "MATTHEW!" One runner at a time brings back a letter in order.
3. When a team finishes a word, they do its motion and shout its "one word" ("MATTHEW: KING!").
4. Then call the next Gospel, using the same basket (so kids must hunt for the right letters).
5. *Little Lambs:* Grab the first letter and run back shouting the name. *Ambassadors:* Spell all four Gospels and "RESURRECTION" in one run.

🐝 Mini spelling bee word list (with sentences)

Word	Use it in a sentence
Matthew	**Matthew** shows that Jesus is the King.
Mark	**Mark** is the shortest Gospel.
Luke	Doctor **Luke** wrote about Zacchaeus.
John	**John** wrote, "For God so loved the world."
Gospel	**Gospel** means "good news."
Jesus	**Jesus** died and rose again.
disciple	Peter was a **disciple** of Jesus.
miracle	Calming the storm was a **miracle**.
shepherds	The angels told the **shepherds** about Jesus.
Zacchaeus	**Zacchaeus** climbed a tree to see Jesus.
resurrection (Ambassadors)	The **resurrection** happened on the third day.
Bethlehem	Jesus was born in **Bethlehem**.

📖 Read-aloud practice passage

> The New Testament starts with four **Gospels**. Gospel means **good news**! **Matthew** shows Jesus is the **King**. Wise men brought Him gifts. **Mark** shows Jesus is a mighty **Servant**. He calmed a **storm** and healed a man who came through the **roof**. **Luke** shows Jesus is the **Savior** for everyone. He called **Zacchaeus** down from a tree. **John** shows Jesus is God's **Son**. Jesus died on the **cross** for our sins, and on the third day He rose again. The tomb was **empty**! "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son."

Word Trivia

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. What does the word "Gospel" mean?
2. Name the four Gospels.
3. True or False: Jesus was born in Bethlehem.

4. What did the wise men follow to find Jesus?
5. Who climbed a tree to see Jesus?
6. What did Jesus say to the storm? ("Quiet! Be _____!")
7. Fill in the blank: "For God so _____ the world." (John 3:16)
8. Who did the angels visit on the night Jesus was born?
9. True or False: The tomb was empty on Sunday morning because Jesus rose from the dead.
10. How did the four friends get the man to Jesus?
11. What is the first book of the New Testament?
12. Was Jesus asleep or awake when the storm began?

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

13. Who said, "Zacchaeus, come down immediately"? (Who said it?)
14. Which Gospel was written by a doctor? (Which book?)
15. What was Matthew's job before he followed Jesus?
16. What three gifts did the wise men bring?
17. Fill in the blank: "You are the _____ of the world." (Matthew 5:14)
18. Which Gospel is the shortest?
19. Who said, "My Lord and my God!"? (Who said it?)
20. What did Jesus say right before He died on the cross in John's Gospel?
21. True or False: Zacchaeus promised to pay back four times what he had cheated.
22. Which friend of Jesus did He raise after four days in the tomb?
23. Who was the first person to see the risen Jesus in John 20?
24. Which Gospel ends with "Go and make disciples of all nations"? (Which book?)

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

25. Who said, "Surely this man was the Son of God!" at the cross in Mark? (Who said it?)
26. Fill in the blank: "For even the Son of Man did not come to be served, but to _____." (Mark 10:45)
27. Which three Gospels are called the "Synoptic" Gospels?
28. Name three of Jesus' seven "I AM" sayings in John.
29. To whom did Luke address his Gospel?
30. Which Old Testament prophet is quoted at the very start of Mark, along with Isaiah?
31. What other New Testament book did Luke write?
32. What is the purpose of John's Gospel, according to John 20:31?
33. Fill in the blank: Luke 19:10: "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the _____."
34. What does "Immanuel" mean, and which Gospel uses it in chapter 1?
35. True or False: Matthew's family tree of Jesus starts with Abraham.
36. Which Roman governor sentenced Jesus to be crucified?
37. What was the first sign (miracle) Jesus did in John's Gospel?
38. Which Gospel tells the parables of the Lost Sheep, the Lost Coin and the Lost Son?

🔑 Answer Key

1. Good news
2. Matthew, Mark, Luke, John

3. True (Matthew 2:1; Luke 2:4–7)
4. A star
5. Zacchaeus (Luke 19:4)
6. still (Mark 4:39)
7. loved
8. Shepherds (Luke 2:8–14)
9. True
10. They lowered him through a hole in the roof (Mark 2:4).
11. Matthew
12. Asleep (Mark 4:38)
13. Jesus (Luke 19:5)
14. Luke (Colossians 4:14)
15. Tax collector (Matthew 9:9)
16. Gold, frankincense and myrrh (Matthew 2:11)
17. light
18. Mark
19. Thomas (John 20:28)
20. "It is finished." (John 19:30)
21. True (Luke 19:8)
22. Lazarus (John 11)
23. Mary Magdalene (John 20:14–18)
24. Matthew (28:19)
25. The Roman centurion (Mark 15:39)
26. serve (and to give his life as a ransom for many)
27. Matthew, Mark and Luke
28. Any three: bread of life (6:35), light of the world (8:12), the gate (10:7, 9), the good shepherd (10:11), the resurrection and the life (11:25), the way and the truth and the life (14:6), the true vine (15:1)
29. Theophilus (Luke 1:3)
30. Malachi (Malachi 3:1 in Mark 1:2; Isaiah 40:3 in Mark 1:3)
31. Acts (Acts 1:1)
32. "That you may believe that Jesus is the Messiah, the Son of God, and that by believing you may have life in his name."
33. lost
34. "God with us," in Matthew 1:23
35. True (Matthew 1:1–2; Luke's family tree goes back to Adam, Luke 3:38)
36. Pontius Pilate
37. Turning water into wine at a wedding in Cana (John 2:1–11)
38. Luke (chapter 15)

Games

🎮 Game #1: Gospel Four Corners

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Four signs for the four corners of the room: MATTHEW 👑, MARK 🏃, LUKE 🤗, JOHN ❤️
- **Setup:** One child (or the teacher) is "It" and stands in the middle with eyes closed.
- **How to play:** "It" counts down from 10 while everyone runs to a corner, doing that corner's motion. At "0," "It" (eyes still closed) calls out a Gospel. Everyone in that corner must answer a question together ("Name a story from this Gospel!" or "Spell your Gospel!"). If they answer correctly, they stay in; if not, they sit out one round (or join "It" as helpers).
- **How to win:** Last players standing win. Or, for no-elimination, every correct answer earns that corner a point.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* No one sits out; they just shout the corner's name and do the motion. *Older:* Questions require a specific story unique to that Gospel ("Name a story ONLY in Luke").
- **Learning goal:** The four Gospel names, their symbols and key stories.

🎮 Game #2: Through the Roof Relay

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors (Little Lambs with a stuffed animal)
- **Supplies:** One beach towel or small blanket per team (the mat), one stuffed animal per team (the paralyzed man), cones; optional: a table to represent the "roof"
- **Setup:** Teams of 4 (the four friends!). A finish line at the far end represents Jesus.
- **How to play:** Each team carries its "friend" on the towel (each kid holding a corner) to the far end without dropping it. At the "roof" (a table or a hula hoop on the floor), they must gently "lower" the friend down and say together, "Jesus, help our friend!" Then the friend "gets up and walks" (one teammate grabs the stuffed animal and runs it back). Then the next group of four goes.
- **How to win:** First team to have all members carry the mat wins, or the team with the fewest "drops."
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Teacher holds one corner; walk, no running. *Older:* Add a trivia question at the roof; a wrong answer means you must "dig through the roof" (10 jumping jacks) first.
- **Learning goal:** Teamwork in bringing friends to Jesus (Mark 2); Jesus' power to forgive and heal.

🎮 Game #3: Zacchaeus, Come Down!

- **Best for:** Little Lambs, Explorers
- **Supplies:** Chairs, low benches or carpet squares ("trees"), one fewer than the number of players (like musical chairs); music
- **Setup:** Arrange the "trees" in a circle.
- **How to play:** While the music plays, kids walk around the trees. When the music stops, everyone "climbs a tree" (stands on/at a carpet square). The child without a tree becomes "Jesus." They walk up to any tree, point and say, "_____, come down! I want to come to your house today!" That child comes down, and the two link arms and help call the next round. *No one is out*: the "found" kids join Jesus' crowd, cheering. Remove a tree each round.

- **How to win:** Everyone wins when everyone has been "found"! Celebrate: "The Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost!"
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Teacher plays Jesus each round. *Older (Trailblazers):* Whoever is called down must answer a trivia question to join the crowd.
- **Learning goal:** Jesus seeks and saves the lost (Luke 19:10) and knows each of us by name.

🎮 Game #4: "Quiet! Be Still!" Storm Freeze

- **Best for:** All ages (great energy burner)
- **Supplies:** A blue sheet or parachute (optional), music or a rain stick
- **Setup:** Kids spread out (or hold the parachute edges).
- **How to play:** The teacher calls out storm actions: "Wind is blowing!" (sway), "Waves are crashing!" (jump), "Rain is pouring!" (wiggle fingers down), "Boat is rocking!" (rock side to side). Then, at a random moment, the teacher (as Jesus) stands up and says, "QUIET! BE STILL!" Everyone must freeze immediately and silently. Anyone who moves or giggles must answer a question ("Which Gospel are we learning?" "Spell MARK!") to rejoin.
- **How to win:** Players who freeze perfectly earn a point; the most points at the end wins (or everyone wins a "calm sea" sticker).
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Use the parachute and no questions. *Older:* Let an Ambassador be "Jesus"; add longer "freeze" times.
- **Learning goal:** Jesus' power over nature (Mark 4:35–41).

🎮 Game #5: Empty Tomb Treasure Hunt

- **Best for:** All ages (Ambassadors lead teams of younger kids)
- **Supplies:** 12 plastic eggs (or small boxes), each with a small item and a Scripture slip; one empty egg (the 12th); a "tomb" (cardboard box with a round "stone")
- **Setup:** Hide the eggs around the room or building. Suggested contents (in order):
    1. Tiny crown: Matthew 2:2 (wise men worship the King)
    2. Small cloth or bandage: Mark 2:11 (the man on the mat walks)
    3. Seashell or blue paper: Mark 4:39 ("Quiet! Be still!")
    4. Leaf: Luke 19:4–5 (Zacchaeus)
    5. Bread piece (cracker): John 6:35 ("I am the bread of life")
    6. Palm leaf (green paper): John 12:13 ("Hosanna!")
    7. Cup: Luke 22:20 ("the new covenant in my blood")
    8. Three coins or silver paper: Matthew 26:15 (thirty silver coins)
    9. Small cross: John 19:30 ("It is finished")
    10. Cloth strip: John 19:40 (linen strips)
    11. Small stone: John 20:1 (stone rolled away)
    12. **EMPTY!**: Matthew 28:6 ("He is not here; he has risen, just as he said.")
- **How to play:** Teams search for eggs (each team finds one color, or teams find all and then share). Then everyone sits in a circle and opens the eggs in order (numbered), reading the verse and retelling the story together. The empty egg is opened last, and everyone shouts "HE IS RISEN!"
- **How to win:** Every team that finds its eggs wins; the true "prize" is the empty egg!

- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Hide in easy places; teacher reads verses. *Older:* Give riddle clues to each hiding place; teams must find the verse in their own Bibles.
- **Learning goal:** The story of Jesus' life, death and resurrection in order.

🎮 Game #6: Fishers of People Net Tag

- **Best for:** All ages (review Sunday)
- **Supplies:** Open space; cones for boundaries
- **Setup:** Start with two "fishermen" (Peter and Andrew!) holding hands to form a "net."
- **How to play:** Jesus said, "Come, follow me, and I will send you out to fish for people" (Mark 1:17). The fishermen chase the "fish." When they tag someone, that person joins the net by holding hands. The net keeps growing! Only the kids at the ends of the net can tag. When the net reaches 6, it can split into two nets of 3. Before joining the net, a caught fish must say one Gospel name (or the memory verse) to get "on board."
- **How to win:** The last fish caught becomes the first fisherman next round.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* Walk, don't run; teacher is part of the net. *Older:* Caught fish must say all 43 books before joining (or a section of them).
- **Learning goal:** Jesus calls us to follow Him and bring others; review of the Gospels.

Coloring Pages

> 🖍️ Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-09-printables.html`.

Page 1: "The Wise Men Worship the King" (Week 1)

- **Scene:** A simple house in Bethlehem with a large shining star above it. Inside the doorway, Mary holds toddler Jesus on her lap. Three wise men in rich robes kneel before Him, holding out a treasure chest (gold), an incense jar (frankincense) and a small bottle (myrrh). Camels rest outside.
- **Caption:** "They bowed down and worshiped him." (Matthew 2:11)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "What gift would you give King Jesus?" "Why did the wise men travel so far?" "How can we worship Jesus today?"

Page 2: "Through the Roof!" (Week 2)

- **Scene:** A cut-away view of a crowded house with a flat roof. On the roof, four friends hold ropes and lower a man on a mat through a big hole. Below, Jesus reaches up with a smile while the crowd looks up in surprise. Bits of roof are falling. (Optional second panel: the man walking out carrying his mat, with his arms raised.)
- **Caption:** "Get up, take your mat and go home." (Mark 2:11)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "Which friend would you be?" "Who could you bring to Jesus?" "What did Jesus forgive first?"

Page 3: "Zacchaeus in the Tree" (Week 3)

- **Scene:** A big sycamore-fig tree with wide branches. A short man (Zacchaeus) peeks out from the leaves. Below, Jesus looks up and points, with a smile; a crowd behind Him shows surprised faces. Add a little sheep near Jesus' feet for "the lost."
- **Caption:** "For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost." (Luke 19:10)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "How do you think Zacchaeus felt when Jesus said his name?" "Who is someone others leave out that you could include?"

Page 4: "He Is Risen!" (Week 4)

- **Scene:** A garden at sunrise. A tomb carved in rock with a big round stone rolled to the side; inside, folded linen cloths. Outside, Mary Magdalene turns in joyful surprise toward Jesus, who stands in bright light with His arms open (nail marks gently visible). Flowers bloom everywhere. Three empty crosses stand on a distant hill.
- **Caption:** "He is not here; he has risen!" (Matthew 28:6) / "I am the resurrection and the life." (John 11:25)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "What colors show happiness?" "What did Mary feel when she heard Jesus say her name?" "Why is the empty tomb the best news ever?"

Page 5: "Jesus Calms the Storm" (bonus)

- **Scene:** A small fishing boat on huge waves; dark clouds on one side and clear sky breaking through on the other. Jesus stands at the front of the boat with one hand raised. The disciples hold on in shock.
- **Caption:** "Even the wind and the waves obey him!" (Mark 4:41)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** "What 'storms' (scary things) do you face?" "How can you pray when you're scared?"

Page 6: "Four Gospels, One Jesus" book-name page

- **Scene:** A big cross in the center with a sunrise behind it. In the four corners, four open books labeled MATTHEW (with a crown), MARK (with running sandals), LUKE (with open arms / a little sheep) and JOHN (with a heart). A banner across the top: "GOSPEL = GOOD NEWS!" Banner across the bottom: "43 of 66 books!"
- **Caption:** "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son." (John 3:16)
- **Coloring conversation prompts:** Say each Gospel as you color it. "Which Gospel story is your favorite?"

Activities & Crafts

👑 Activity #1: King Jesus Crown (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Gold or yellow cardstock strips (crown-shaped, pre-cut points), plastic "jewels" or stickers, glue, markers, stapler.

- **Steps:**
    1. Write "JESUS IS KING!" across the front of the crown.
    2. Decorate with jewels and stars (for the wise men's star).
    3. On the inside write "Matthew 2:2" or "Immanuel = God with us."
    4. Size to the child's head and staple.
    5. **Twist:** Explain we are not the kings; Jesus is. Kids can wear it, then take it off and "lay it down" before a cross to show "Jesus is King of my life."
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-written crowns; stickers only. *Explorers:* Write the four Gospels on four points. *Trailblazers:* Write four Old Testament prophecies Jesus fulfilled on the points. *Ambassadors:* Write Matthew 28:18–20 inside and lead the "lay it down" moment.
- **What it teaches:** Jesus is the promised King (Matthew).

🏠 Activity #2: Through-the-Roof House (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Small boxes (tissue or cereal box cut down) or folded cardstock "houses," a square hole cut in the top, yarn, a craft stick or clothespin person, a small fabric or paper "mat," tape, markers.
- **Steps:**
    1. Decorate the box as a house; draw Jesus and people inside (on the inner back wall).
    2. Tape the craft-stick man to a paper mat.
    3. Tie yarn to each corner of the mat (or two strings).
    4. Lower the man through the roof hole into the house, and pull him back out "walking"!
    5. Write "Mark 2:11, Get up and walk!" on the side.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-made house; they color and lower the man. *Explorers:* Full craft. *Trailblazers:* Add four friend figures on the roof with names of friends they're praying for. *Ambassadors:* Help younger kids and explain the forgive-then-heal point.
- **What it teaches:** Bringing friends to Jesus; Jesus' power and forgiveness.

🌳 Activity #3: Pop-Up Zacchaeus Tree (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Paper cups (one per child), green tissue or construction paper, a craft stick per child, a small paper Zacchaeus figure, tape, scissors, markers.
- **Steps:**
    1. Turn the cup upside down and poke a slit in the bottom (teacher).
    2. Color the cup brown like a tree trunk; glue green paper "leaves" around the top edge.
    3. Tape Zacchaeus to the top of a craft stick.
    4. Push the stick up through the slit from inside the cup, so Zacchaeus can "climb up" and "come down" as you push and pull the stick.
    5. Write "Luke 19:10" on the trunk.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-cut and pre-slit. *Explorers:* Full craft; retell the story to a partner. *Trailblazers:* Write on the leaves the four ways Zacchaeus changed. *Ambassadors:* Write names of "lost" friends they'll pray for on the leaves (privately).
- **What it teaches:** Jesus seeks and saves the lost; real life change.

🪨 Activity #4: Rolling-Stone Tomb (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Paper plates (one and a half per child), gray paint or crayons, a paper fastener (brad), a strip of white cloth or paper, markers, a small cross sticker.
- **Steps:**
    1. Cut a paper plate in half; staple or glue the half-plate onto a whole plate to make a "pocket" tomb, with an opening (door) drawn on it.
    2. Color the tomb gray and the background as a garden sunrise.
    3. Cut a gray circle ("stone") and attach it with a brad so it can roll aside to reveal the doorway.
    4. Behind the door, glue a folded white cloth strip and write "HE IS RISEN!"
    5. Write John 11:25 around the edge.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Pre-assembled; they color and roll the stone. *Explorers:* Full craft. *Trailblazers:* Write John 3:16 on the back. *Ambassadors:* Write out the ABC gospel outline on the back to use when sharing with a friend.
- **What it teaches:** Jesus died and rose again; the empty tomb.

📿 Activity #5: Gospel Bracelet (review / Week 5)

- **Supplies:** Elastic cord or yarn; pony beads in gold, dark gray, red, white and green.
- **Steps (string the beads and say what each means):**
    1. **Gold:** God loves you and made you to know Him (John 3:16).
    2. **Dark gray:** Sin, the wrong things we do, separates us from God (Romans 3:23).
    3. **Red:** Jesus died on the cross to pay for our sin (John 19:30).
    4. **White:** When we trust Jesus, He forgives us and makes us clean (1 John 1:9). And He rose again!
    5. **Green:** We grow by following Jesus, reading the Bible and praying (2 Peter 3:18).
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs:* Larger beads and pipe cleaners; teacher says the meaning. *Explorers:* Make two, one to keep and one to give away. *Trailblazers:* Memorize a verse for each bead. *Ambassadors:* Use the bracelet to explain the gospel to a younger child.
- **What it teaches:** The gospel message in a simple, memorable, shareable way.

💡 Activity #6: "I AM" Lightbulb Chart (Trailblazers & Ambassadors) / "I AM" Picture Cards (younger)

- **Supplies:** Poster board, seven lightbulb (or lamp) shapes, markers, Bibles.
- **Steps:**
    1. Look up each "I AM" saying in John (6:35; 8:12; 10:9; 10:11; 11:25; 14:6; 15:5).
    2. Write the reference and saying on each lightbulb, plus a picture (bread, light, gate, shepherd, empty tomb, road, vine).
    3. Add a line: "What this means for me..."
    4. Hang the chart in the classroom for the rest of the year.
- **Age adaptations:** *Little Lambs/Explorers:* Color 7 picture cards and play a matching game ("Jesus said, 'I am the... ' [show bread] ...BREAD of life!"). *Ambassadors:* Connect "I AM" to God's name in Exodus 3:14 (and John 8:58).
- **What it teaches:** Who Jesus is, in His own words.

Word Puzzles

🔀 Word Scramble

Unscramble these words from Phase 9.

#	Scrambled	Hint
1	WEHTTAM	Shows Jesus is King
2	KRAM	Shortest Gospel
3	EKUL	Written by a doctor
4	NHOJ	"God so loved the world"
5	SPLEOG	Means "good news"
6	SUSEJ	God's Son
7	CEUAZSHAC	Climbed a tree
8	DREHSPHES	Heard the angels first
9	MOTB	It was empty!
10	MORST	Jesus calmed it
11	SORCS	Jesus died on it for us
12	VELIEBE	John wrote so we would ___
13	RUSLAZA	Came out of the tomb alive

Answer key: 1. MATTHEW 2. MARK 3. LUKE 4. JOHN 5. GOSPEL 6. JESUS 7. ZACCHAEUS 8. SHEPHERDS 9. TOMB 10. STORM 11. CROSS 12. BELIEVE 13. LAZARUS

✏️ Fill-in-the-Blank Story

Word bank: Luke, roof, King, John, alive, shepherds, Mark, tree, Matthew, Gospel, star, storm, cross

> The word _____ means good news. _____ shows that Jesus is the _____. Wise men followed a _____ to worship Him. _____ shows Jesus in action. Four friends lowered a man through a _____, and Jesus calmed a _____ on the sea. Doctor _____ tells how angels visited _____ and how Zacchaeus climbed a _____. _____ tells us that Jesus died on the _____ for our sins, but on the third day He was _____ again!

Answer key: Gospel, Matthew, King, star, Mark, roof, storm, Luke, shepherds, tree, John, cross, alive

🔗 Match the Book to Its Picture / Summary

Book		Picture / Summary
1. Matthew		A. 🤗 Doctor's careful account; shepherds, Zacchaeus, the Lost Son; "seek and save the lost"
2. Mark		B. ❤️ Seven signs and seven "I AM"s; John 3:16; Thomas: "My Lord and my God!"
3. Luke		C. 👑 Wise men; Sermon on the Mount; "Go and make disciples"
4. John		D. 🏃 Shortest and fastest; "Immediately!"; "Quiet! Be still!"; came to serve

Answer key: 1–C, 2–D, 3–A, 4–B

Bonus match: Prophecy → Fulfillment (Trailblazers & Ambassadors)

Old Testament promise		Fulfilled in…
1. Micah 5:2 (Bethlehem)		A. Mark 1:2–4 (John the Baptist)
2. Malachi 3:1 (the messenger)		B. Matthew 21:1–9 (Palm Sunday)
3. Zechariah 9:9 (King on a donkey)		C. Matthew 2:1–6 (born in Bethlehem)
4. Isaiah 53:5 (pierced for our sins)		D. Matthew 12:40 & 28:6 (three days, then risen)
5. Jonah 1:17 (three days in the fish)		E. John 19:34–37 (the cross)

Answer key: 1–C, 2–A, 3–B, 4–E, 5–D

Questions for Every Age

Little Lambs (4–6)

1. Who is Jesus? (God's Son, the King, my Savior!)
2. How does Jesus feel about you? (He loves me!)
3. Who could you tell about Jesus?
4. What can you do when you're scared, like in a storm? (Pray to Jesus!)
5. Is Jesus alive today? (Yes!)

Explorers (7–10)

1. Which Gospel story is your favorite? Why?
2. The four friends helped their friend get to Jesus. How can you help a friend know Jesus?
3. Zacchaeus changed after he met Jesus. How does knowing Jesus change how we act?
4. Why do you think Jesus was willing to die on the cross?
5. What does it mean to "believe" in Jesus?

Trailblazers (11–13)

1. Why do you think God gave us four Gospels instead of one?

2. Which Old Testament promise fulfilled by Jesus amazes you the most?
3. Thomas had doubts. What questions do you have about Jesus, and who can you ask?
4. What does it look like to be a disciple (follower) of Jesus in middle school?
5. Jesus came to serve (Mark 10:45). Where could you serve this week?

Ambassadors (14–17)

1. If a friend asked, "Who is Jesus to you?", what would you say?
2. How do the four Gospels' different emphases (King, Servant, Savior, Son) help you understand Jesus more fully?
3. What part of Jesus' teaching (e.g., the Sermon on the Mount) is hardest for you to live out?
4. How does the resurrection change how you think about the future, death or failure?
5. What would it look like for you to obey the Great Commission this year?

🧠 Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics / worldview)

1. "How do we know the Gospels are reliable and not legends?" *Suggested answer:* (a) **Early:** The Gospels were most likely written within 20–65 years of Jesus' death, while eyewitnesses and opponents were still alive; Paul's letters (some from the A.D. 50s) quote even earlier creeds about Jesus' death and resurrection (1 Corinthians 15:3–8). (b) **Eyewitness-based:** Luke says he investigated eyewitness testimony (Luke 1:1–4); John claims to be an eyewitness (John 21:24). (c) **Well-preserved:** We have thousands of Greek New Testament manuscripts, some fragments within about a century of writing, far more than for any other ancient work. (d) **Historically accurate details:** Places, rulers and customs (e.g., Pilate, Caiaphas, the Pool of Bethesda) have been confirmed by archaeology. (e) **Embarrassing details:** The disciples look slow and fearful, and women are the first witnesses. Inventors of a legend wouldn't have written it that way.

2. "Didn't the Gospels contradict each other?" *Suggested answer:* The Gospels have differences in detail and emphasis (like how many angels were at the tomb: Matthew mentions one, Luke two). Different eyewitness accounts typically vary this way. If one mentions two angels, there was certainly at least one! Courts expect independent witnesses to agree on the core and differ on details; identical accounts would suggest copying or collusion. All four agree on the central facts: Jesus' ministry, crucifixion under Pilate, burial, empty tomb and resurrection appearances.

3. "Did Jesus really rise from the dead, or is there another explanation?" *Suggested answer:* Historians, including many skeptical ones, widely accept several facts: Jesus died by crucifixion; His followers sincerely believed they saw Him alive; the persecutor Paul and the skeptic James (Jesus' brother) were converted by what they believed were appearances; and the tomb was found empty. Alternative theories struggle: hallucinations don't happen to groups of 500 at once (1 Cor. 15:6); a stolen body doesn't explain the disciples' willingness to suffer for their claim; "swoon theory" ignores Roman execution expertise. The resurrection best explains the evidence, and it is the foundation of Christian faith (1 Corinthians 15:14, 17, 20).

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration

Review game plan (last Sunday): "Good News Party"

1. **Welcome (10 min):** Sing all six verses of the Library Song (including the whispered Bridge), then sing Verse 6 as a round.
2. **43-Book Challenge (5 min):** Classes try to beat their best time.
3. **Gospel Four Corners (10 min):** Games #1.
4. **Fishers of People Net Tag (10 min):** Games #6.
5. **Gospel Bracelets (10 min):** Activities #5. Ambassadors help Little Lambs.
6. **Oral check-offs (15 min):** Use the checklists below.
7. **Passport & badge ceremony (15 min):** Stamp passports, award badges and certificates. Close with a resurrection celebration (a sunrise-yellow cupcake or donut "empty tomb," a donut hole!) and prayer.

✅ Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs (4–6)

- [ ] Says "Gospel means Good News"
- [ ] Says the four Gospels (Matthew, Mark, Luke, John) with motions; at least 3 counts!
- [ ] Says the Little Lambs verse: "For God so loved the world."
- [ ] Tells one Jesus story in a sentence (e.g., "Jesus calmed the storm" or "Jesus is alive!")

Explorers (7–10)

- [ ] Says all 4 Gospels in order
- [ ] Spells all 4 correctly (MATTHEW, MARK, LUKE, JOHN)
- [ ] Says John 3:16 from memory
- [ ] Sings the Library Song (all 6 verses)

Trailblazers (11–13)

- [ ] Says all 43 books so far in order (no song)
- [ ] Gives each Gospel's "one word" and one key story
- [ ] Says John 3:16 from memory
- [ ] Names three Old Testament prophecies Jesus fulfilled

Ambassadors (14–17)

- [ ] Says all 43 books so far in order
- [ ] Says John 3:16 and explains it in their own words
- [ ] Teaches one Gospel (story + motion + spelling) to a younger child
- [ ] Explains the gospel using the ABC outline or the Gospel Bracelet

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Open the **New Testament** section of the passport for the first time! Stamp the **Gospels** page with a gold cross-and-sunrise stamp. Kids write or trace: "I know 43 of 66 books! I met Jesus!"

🏅 Badge: "I Met Jesus!"

A round sunrise-gold badge with an empty cross in front of a rising sun. In the four "corners" around the circle: a crown (Matthew), running sandals (Mark), open arms (Luke) and a heart (John). Banner: "GOSPELS · 4 BOOKS · GOOD NEWS!"

📜 Certificate wording

> **Purpose Church Sunday School "I Met Jesus!" Gospel Certificate**
>
> This certifies that _____ has completed **Phase 9: Meet Jesus!** and has learned the four Gospels: **Matthew · Mark · Luke · John**
>
> "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life." (John 3:16)
>
> **Books learned: 43 of 66** Teacher: _____ Date: _____

Take-Home Family Page

> ✂️ *Copy or print this section and send it home.*

Dear Families,

This month we crossed the bridge into the **New Testament** and met **Jesus** in the four Gospels: **Matthew, Mark, Luke and John**. "Gospel" means "Good News"! Matthew shows Jesus as the promised **King**, Mark as the mighty **Servant**, Luke as the **Savior for everyone**, and John as **God's Son** who gives eternal life to all who believe. We learned about the wise men, the friends who lowered a man through a roof, Jesus calming the storm, Zacchaeus in the tree, and most importantly that Jesus died on the cross for our sins and **rose again**! Your child now knows **43 of the 66 books** of the Bible.

Your child may have questions about following Jesus. That's wonderful! If they do, we'd love to help. Please feel free to talk with your child's teacher or our children's ministry leader.

📖 **Memory Verse:**

> "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life." (John 3:16, NIV)

> *Little Lambs:* "For God so loved the world."

🎵 **This month's song verse (tune: "Frère Jacques," each line twice):**

> Mat-thew, Mark, Luke, *(Mat-thew, Mark, Luke,)* Then comes John! *(Then comes John!)* Tell-ing us of Je-sus, *(Tell-ing us of Je-sus,)* Good News: FOUR! *(Good News: FOUR!)*

(Try singing it as a round at dinner!)

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions:**

1. Which Jesus story did you learn this month? What did Jesus do?
2. Zacchaeus changed after meeting Jesus. How does Jesus change people today?
3. What does John 3:16 tell us about how much God loves us?

👨‍👩‍👧 **Family activity: "Four Gospels, Four Nights"** Pick four nights this week. Each night, read one short story from a different Gospel together:

- **Night 1, Matthew 2:1–12:** The wise men (put a flashlight "star" on the ceiling!)
- **Night 2, Mark 4:35–41:** Jesus calms the storm (read it in the bathtub or by a bowl of water!)
- **Night 3, Luke 19:1–10:** Zacchaeus (eat dinner "at Zacchaeus's house," with a picnic under a tree or houseplant)
- **Night 4, John 20:1–18:** The empty tomb (open an empty box or plastic egg together and say "He is risen!")

📺 **Videos to watch at home** (search on YouTube; parents, please preview):

- **Sharefaith Kids:** "Wise Men," "Jesus Calms the Storm," "Zacchaeus," "Easter": https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Jesus
- **Bible Journey:** "Matthew," "Luke," "Resurrection": https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Jesus
- **BibleProject (older kids & parents):** "Overview: Matthew 1-13," "Overview: Matthew 14-28," "Overview: Mark," "Overview: Luke 1-9," "Overview: Luke 10-24," "Overview: John 1-12," "Overview: John 13-21," and the theme video "Gospel of the Kingdom": https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Matthew

Next month: *The Church Is Born!* The book of Acts, with the Holy Spirit, Peter, and Paul's amazing journeys!

Phase 10: The Church Is Born

Jesus goes back to heaven, the Holy Spirit comes like fire, and the good news spreads from Jerusalem to the ends of the earth.

At a Glance	
Month	Month 10
Books covered	Acts (1 book)
Bible section(s)	History–Acts (1)
Big Idea	The Holy Spirit gives God's people power to tell everyone about Jesus.
Memory Verse (all ages)	"But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit comes on you; and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth." — Acts 1:8 (NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"You will be my witnesses." — Acts 1:8
Theme color	Flame Red (with a touch of orange)
Phase symbol / badge	🔥 The Spirit Flame badge (a red-orange flame with a small globe inside it)
Running total of books learned	**44 of 66**

> Cross-links: Program Overview · Teacher Training Guide · Books of the Bible Memory System · Game Library · YouTube Video Guide · Phase 10 Printables

The Big Idea (in kid words)

Jesus came back to life, and then He went back up to heaven. But He did not leave His friends alone. He sent the Holy Spirit — God Himself — to live inside everyone who trusts Jesus. The Holy Spirit made scared people brave and gave them power to tell everyone the good news. That group of Jesus-followers is called **the church** — and if you love Jesus, you are part of it too!

How this points to Jesus: The book of Acts is really "Part 2" of what Jesus did. Luke wrote that his first book (the Gospel of Luke) told what Jesus *began* to do and teach (Acts 1:1). Acts shows Jesus *still* working — from heaven, through His Spirit, through His people. Every healing in Acts happens "in the name of Jesus," every sermon is about Jesus dying and rising, and the whole book ends with Paul "proclaiming the kingdom of God and teaching about the Lord Jesus Christ" (Acts 28:31).

The Books in Easy Words

Acts (The Acts of the Apostles)

How to say it	AKTS (rhymes with "facts")
How to spell it	Acts — A-C-T-S (one syllable, one clap!)
Full title	The Acts of the Apostles ("a-POS-uls" = "sent-out ones")
Section	History–Acts (the only book in this section) — the New Testament's history book
Traditional author	Luke, a doctor and Paul's travel friend (he also wrote the Gospel of Luke). Both books are written to a man named Theophilus (thee-OFF-ih-lus).
When	The events cover about 30 years (around AD 30–62).
One-sentence kid summary	After Jesus goes back to heaven, the Holy Spirit fills His followers with power, and they tell the good news about Jesus everywhere — from Jerusalem all the way to Rome.
In one word	**GO!** (or "Spread!")
Key people	Peter, John, Stephen, Philip, Saul/Paul, Barnabas, Silas, Timothy, Lydia, Cornelius, Priscilla & Aquila, Luke
Key stories	Jesus goes up to heaven (ch. 1) · Pentecost: wind and fire (ch. 2) · Peter and John heal a man who could not walk (ch. 3) · Stephen, the first Christian to die for Jesus (ch. 6–7) · Philip and the Ethiopian official (ch. 8) · Saul meets Jesus on the road to Damascus (ch. 9) · Peter and Cornelius (ch. 10) · An angel breaks Peter out of jail (ch. 12) · Paul's missionary journeys (ch. 13–21) · Paul and Silas sing in jail (ch. 16) · Shipwreck and a snake bite (ch. 27–28)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus speaks and ascends (1:1–11); Peter preaches that Jesus is "Lord and Messiah" (2:36); Stephen sees Jesus standing at God's right hand (7:55–56); Jesus speaks to Saul from heaven: "I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting" (9:5); Jesus encourages Paul at night: "Take courage!" (23:11)
Hand motion / picture symbol	🔥 **Flame & Go:** Wiggle your fingers above your head like a flame (the Spirit), then throw both hands forward like you're tossing seeds to the world (spreading the good news). Say "ACTS!" as you throw.

Acts in four "rings" (Acts 1:8 is the map of the whole book):

1. **Jerusalem** — chapters 1–7
2. **Judea & Samaria** — chapters 8–12
3. **The ends of the earth** — chapters 13–28 (Paul's journeys to Turkey, Greece, and finally Rome)

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher

Acts is the bridge between the Gospels and the Letters. Without it, we would not know how Paul became an apostle, who the churches in Corinth, Philippi, and Ephesus were, or how a small Jewish movement in Jerusalem became a worldwide family including Gentiles (non-Jews). Luke was a careful historian (Luke 1:1–4), and he was an eyewitness for parts of the story — notice the "we" sections starting in Acts 16:10, where Luke travels with Paul.

The book has two main human "heroes": **Peter** (chapters 1–12, mostly among Jewish people) and **Paul** (chapters 13–28, mostly among Gentiles). But the true main character is the **Holy Spirit**, who is mentioned over 50 times. The Spirit is not a "force" or an "it"; He is God, the third person of the Trinity, who comforts, guides, and empowers believers.

Key truths to emphasize

1. **Jesus is alive and reigning.** The ascension is not Jesus "leaving"; it's Jesus taking His throne.
2. **The Holy Spirit lives in every believer** (Acts 2:38–39). Kids who trust Jesus have the Spirit too — this isn't just for grown-ups or "super Christians."
3. **The church is people, not a building.** The first church met in homes (Acts 2:46).
4. **The gospel is for everyone** — every nation, language, and background (Acts 10:34–35).
5. **God's plan can't be stopped.** Jail, threats, storms, and shipwrecks could not stop the message (Acts 28:31 ends with "without hindrance").

Timeline & map notes

- **AD 30/33** — Jesus' death, resurrection, ascension, and Pentecost (Pentecost = 50 days after Passover; Jesus ascended 40 days after rising, Acts 1:3).
- **~AD 34–36** — Stephen martyred; Saul's conversion.
- **~AD 46–48** — Paul's 1st journey (Cyprus and southern Turkey: Antioch in Pisidia, Iconium, Lystra, Derbe).
- **~AD 49** — Jerusalem Council (Acts 15).
- **~AD 49–52** — 2nd journey (Philippi, Thessalonica, Berea, Athens, Corinth).
- **~AD 53–57** — 3rd journey (long stay in Ephesus).
- **~AD 57–62** — Arrest in Jerusalem, prison in Caesarea, voyage and shipwreck, house arrest in Rome.

Map tip: Draw three loops on a big map of the Mediterranean (blue = 1st journey, green = 2nd, orange = 3rd) and a red dotted line for the trip to Rome. Trailblazers love tracing these.

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers & Ambassadors (11–17)
Stephen's death (Acts 7)	"Some angry people hurt Stephen very badly, and he died. But Jesus was right there, and Stephen went to be with Jesus." No details of stoning.	"They threw stones at him." Focus on Stephen forgiving them like Jesus did.	Discuss persecution then and now; Stephen's prayer mirrors Jesus' on the cross (Luke 23:34).
Ananias & Sapphira (Acts 5)	Skip.	Optional; emphasize "God cares about honesty."	Discuss God's holiness and why lying to the Holy Spirit was so serious in the newborn church.
Saul hurting Christians (Acts 8–9)	"Saul was mean to Jesus' friends."	"He put Christians in jail."	Discuss real forgiveness: God can change anyone.
Beatings, jail, shipwreck	Keep calm and hopeful: "God took care of them."	Fine to tell plainly; highlight courage and joy.	Discuss suffering for faith and why it doesn't mean God has abandoned us.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

- **"Where did Jesus go?"** — Up to heaven, to be with God the Father. He is alive right now, and He is coming back one day (Acts 1:11).
- **"Is the Holy Spirit a ghost?"** — No. The old word "Holy Ghost" just meant "Holy Spirit." He is God, and He is kind, good, and with us.
- **"Can I see the Holy Spirit?"** — Not with our eyes, like we can't see wind. But we can see what He does — like how wind moves the trees, the Spirit changes people's hearts.
- **"Will I get fire on my head?"** — The flames on Pentecost were a special sign for that day. The Spirit doesn't usually come with flames, but He comes to everyone who trusts Jesus.
- **"Why did God let Stephen die?"** — We don't know every reason. But God was with Stephen, Stephen went to be with Jesus, and God used what happened to spread the good news to new places (Acts 8:4).
- **"Can God change a really mean person?"** — Yes! Saul was one of the meanest enemies of Christians, and God changed him into Paul, one of the greatest missionaries ever.
- **"Am I in the church?"** — If you trust Jesus, yes! The church is God's family, and you belong.

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	Video	Game	Activity
1	Acts 1–2	Wind, Fire & Power!	Jesus went up; the Holy Spirit came down.	📺 Pentecost (Sharefaith Kids, Bible Journey); "Overview: Acts 1–12" (BibleProject)	🎮 Wind Relay	Pentecost Flame Headbands
2	Acts 3–4; 6–7	Brave in Jesus' Name	The Spirit makes us brave to speak about Jesus.	📺 Peter & John heal the lame man; Stephen	🎮 Silver & Gold Freeze	"In Jesus' Name" Walking Feet Craft
3	Acts 8:26–40; 9:1–31; 10	From Enemy to Friend	God can change anyone, and the good news is for everyone.	📺 Saul's conversion; Peter's vision	🎮 Road to Damascus Blindfold Walk	Scales-Falling Paper Glasses
4	Acts 13–14; 16; 27–28	To the Ends of the Earth	Nothing can stop God's good news.	📺 Paul & Silas in prison; the shipwreck; "Overview: Acts 13–28" (BibleProject)	🎮 Shipwreck!	Missionary Journey Map & Passport
5 (optional)	Review all of Acts	Review & Fun Sunday	44 books and counting!	Favorite clip replay	🎮 Acts Trivia Ship Race	Spirit Flame Badge ceremony

Weekly Lessons

Week 1 — Wind, Fire & Power! (Acts 1–2)

Scripture: Acts 1:1–11; 2:1–41 **Lesson goal:** Kids will know that Jesus went back to heaven and sent the Holy Spirit to give His followers power to tell others about Him.

Opening hook / object lesson — "The Invisible Helper" *Supplies:* a small handheld fan (or a sheet of cardboard), a pinwheel, a few tissues or feathers, an uninflated balloon.

1. Ask, "Can you see wind?" (No.) Turn on the fan and point it at the pinwheel. "Can you see what the wind DOES?" (Yes!)
2. Blow up the balloon a little: "Air inside makes it big and strong." Let it go and watch it zoom.
3. Say: "Today we'll learn about Someone we can't see with our eyes — the Holy Spirit. Like wind, we see what He does. He fills people and gives them power!"

Story script (read aloud):

After Jesus came back to life, He spent forty days with His friends. He ate with them, talked with them, and taught them about God's kingdom. Then one day, on a hill called the Mount of Olives, Jesus gave them a big job.

"Wait in Jerusalem," Jesus said. "Soon the Holy Spirit will come on you, and you will get power. Then you will be My witnesses — in Jerusalem, in Judea and Samaria, and all the way to the ends of the earth!" A witness is someone who tells what they have seen.

And then — whoosh! — Jesus went up, up, up into the sky until a cloud hid Him. His friends stood there staring. Suddenly two men dressed in white stood beside them. "Why are you looking at the sky?" they said. "This same Jesus will come back the same way you saw Him go!"

So the friends went back to Jerusalem and prayed together and waited. Ten days later, it was a big holiday called Pentecost. Jerusalem was crowded with people from many countries. Jesus' friends were all together in one place.

Suddenly, a sound like a mighty, rushing wind filled the whole house! Then something that looked like little flames of fire came and rested on each person. They were all filled with the Holy Spirit — and they began to speak in other languages they had never learned!

People outside heard the noise and came running. "How can this be?" they said. "These men are from Galilee, but we hear them telling about God's wonders in our own languages!"

Then Peter stood up. Remember Peter? Not long before, he had been so scared that he said three times he didn't even know Jesus. But now, filled with the Holy Spirit, Peter was brave! He shouted, "Jesus, the One you put on a cross, God raised back to life! We have all seen Him! God has made Him both Lord and Messiah!"

The people's hearts hurt. "What should we do?" they asked. Peter said, "Turn away from your sins and be baptized in the name of Jesus. God will forgive you, and you will receive the Holy Spirit too!"

That day, about three thousand people believed in Jesus and were baptized. The church was born — and it was just getting started!

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Make sound effects together: rub hands for wind, wiggle fingers for flames. Repeat: "Jesus went UP (point up), the Spirit came DOWN (wiggle fingers down)."
- **Explorers:** Have them count to 40 (days with Jesus) and then 10 more (waiting) = 50 = Pentecost ("Pente" means fifty). Practice spelling A-C-T-S with claps.
- **Trailblazers:** Compare Babel (Genesis 11 — languages confused, people scattered) and Pentecost (languages understood, people united in Jesus). Look up Acts 2:9–11 and find the countries on a map.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Peter's transformation (Luke 22:54–62 vs. Acts 2:14). What changed him? Read Acts 2:42–47 and compare that church to ours today. Have one Ambassador lead the Little Lambs' sound-effect retelling.

Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Where did Jesus go? (Up to heaven.) 2) Who did Jesus send to help His friends? (The Holy Spirit.) 3) What did it sound like? (Wind!)
- *Explorers:* 1) What job did Jesus give His friends? 2) What did the people from other countries hear? 3) How was Peter different from the night Jesus was arrested?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why do you think God let people hear the message in their own languages? 2) Acts 1:8 lists four places — what does that tell us about God's plan? 3) What does a "witness" do, and how can you be one at school?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Peter said, "God has made this Jesus... both Lord and Messiah" (2:36). Why are those two titles so important? 2) What do Acts 2:42–47's four habits (teaching, fellowship, breaking bread, prayer) look like in a teenager's life? 3) Why does it matter that the Holy Spirit is a Person and not just a power?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Pentecost" / "Holy Spirit comes" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Pentecost | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Pentecost" / "Ascension" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Pentecost | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors (Explorers with pauses) | "Overview: Acts 1–12" (also the theme video "Holy Spirit") | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Acts |

Teacher: Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: 1) What surprised you in the video? 2) What did the people do after Peter preached?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Wind Relay* (see Games). ✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Pentecost Flame Headbands* (see Activities & Crafts). 🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Say the full memory verse with motions. Spell A-C-T-S. Add "Acts" to the end of the Gospels chant: "Matthew, Mark, Luke, John — ACTS!" 🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> "Dear God, thank You that Jesus is alive in heaven. Thank You for sending the Holy Spirit. Please make me brave to tell others about Jesus. Amen."

Week 2 — Brave in Jesus' Name (Acts 3–4; 6–7)

Scripture: Acts 3:1–10; 4:1–31; 6:8–15; 7:54–60 **Lesson goal:** Kids will learn that the Holy Spirit gives courage to speak about Jesus, even when it's hard.

Opening hook / object lesson — "What Do I Have?" *Supplies:* an empty wallet or purse, a few play coins, a small wrapped "gift" box with a paper heart inside labeled "JESUS."

1. Open the wallet and dump out the coins. "Is money a good gift? Sure! But today we'll meet two men who had *no* money."
2. Hold up the box: "They had something better to give." Open it and show the heart.
3. Say: "Peter said, 'Silver or gold I do not have, but what I do have I give you.' Let's find out what he gave!"

Story script:

> One afternoon, Peter and John walked to the temple to pray. By the gate called Beautiful sat a man who had never been able to walk — not even once since the day he was born. He was over forty years old! Every day, friends carried him to the gate so he could beg for money.
>
> "Please, give me some money!" the man called. Peter and John stopped and looked right at him. "Look at us!" Peter said. The man looked up, hoping for coins.
>
> But Peter said, "Silver or gold I do not have, but what I do have I give you. In the name of Jesus Christ of Nazareth, walk!" Peter took his hand and helped him up — and instantly the man's feet and ankles became strong! He jumped up, stood, and walked. Then he went into the temple walking and jumping and praising God!
>
> Everyone stared. "Isn't that the man who used to sit by the gate?" Peter told them, "Why are you surprised? We didn't do this by our own power. Jesus did it! The same Jesus you killed — God raised Him from the dead!"
>
> The leaders were angry. They put Peter and John in jail overnight. The next day they said, "Stop talking about Jesus!" But Peter and John answered, "We cannot help speaking about what we have seen and heard." Then they went back to their friends, and everyone prayed, "Lord, help us speak Your word with great boldness." The place where they were shook, and they were all filled with the Holy Spirit again!
>
> More and more people believed. One of the church's helpers was a man named Stephen. He was full of God's grace and power. Some people hated what Stephen said about Jesus, so they dragged him in front of the leaders. Stephen bravely told them the whole story of God's people — and how they had rejected Jesus.
>
> The leaders grew furious. But Stephen looked up to heaven and said, "Look! I see heaven open and Jesus standing at the right hand of God!" They dragged him outside the city and threw stones at him. As he was dying, Stephen prayed, "Lord Jesus, receive my spirit... Lord, do not hold this sin against them." Just like Jesus, Stephen forgave the people who hurt him. And then he went to be with Jesus forever.

(Little Lambs version of the ending: "Some angry people hurt Stephen very badly. But Stephen saw Jesus in heaven, and he forgave them, and he went to be with Jesus.")

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Act out the lame man: sit on the floor, then on "In the name of Jesus — walk!" everyone jumps up and hops around praising God. Repeat three times; they will beg for more.
- **Explorers:** Hold a "Brave Meter" (thermometer drawn on poster). Ask: "When is it hard to talk about Jesus?" Color up the meter as they share ideas for being brave.
- **Trailblazers:** Compare Stephen's last words (7:59–60) to Jesus' on the cross (Luke 23:34, 46). Why would Luke include these similarities?

- **Ambassadors:** Read Acts 4:13 — the leaders saw that Peter and John were "unschooled, ordinary men" and "took note that these men had been with Jesus." Discuss: courage comes from time with Jesus, not from being impressive. Note that Saul (later Paul) watched Stephen die (7:58; 8:1) — foreshadowing next week.

Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) What did the man do after Jesus healed him? (Walked and jumped!) 2) Whose name did Peter use? (Jesus.) 3) Who did Stephen see in heaven? (Jesus.)
- *Explorers:* 1) Why didn't Peter give the man money? 2) What did Peter and John say when they were told to stop talking about Jesus? 3) How was Stephen like Jesus?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why did the healing make the leaders angry instead of happy? 2) What did the believers pray for in Acts 4:29 — and what didn't they pray for? 3) What's one hard place where you need courage to follow Jesus?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) The believers prayed for boldness, not safety. What does that teach us about prayer? 2) How can you forgive someone who mistreats you for your faith? 3) Stephen's death led to the gospel spreading (8:1–4). How has God brought good out of hard things in history or in your life?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Peter and John heal" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Peter+and+John | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Stephen" / "lame man healed" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Stephen | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | "Overview: Acts 1–12" (rewatch the Jerusalem section) or "Gospel of the Kingdom" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Gospel+of+the+Kingdom |

Teacher: Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: 1) How did the man show he was thankful? 2) Where did Peter say the power came from?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Silver & Gold Freeze* (see Games). ✂️ **Activity of the week:** *"In Jesus' Name" Walking Feet Craft* (see Activities & Crafts). 🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Memory verse through "...and you will be my witnesses." Spell A-C-T-S and A-P-O-S-T-L-E-S (Explorers and up). Recite all four Gospels + Acts. 🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> "Jesus, You are powerful! Please give me courage to talk about You. Help me forgive people, like Stephen did. Amen."

Week 3 — From Enemy to Friend (Acts 8:26–40; 9:1–31; 10)

Scripture: Acts 8:26–40; 9:1–31; 10:1–48 **Lesson goal:** Kids will learn that God can change anyone's heart and that the good news is for every person, everywhere.

Opening hook / object lesson — "Dirty to Clean" *Supplies:* a clear glass of water, a few drops of food coloring (dark blue), a small bottle of bleach-free stain remover or a few drops of household iodine +

vitamin C tablet (adult-handled; the classic "disappearing color" trick), OR simply a dirty T-shirt and a clean T-shirt.

- Simple version: Show a muddy shirt. "Could this ever be clean again?" Then hold up the same style shirt, clean. "God can make a brand-new person out of someone who was really, really wrong."
- Say: "Today you'll meet a man named Saul who hated Jesus' friends. Could God ever change *him*?"

Story script:

> After Stephen died, a young man named Saul got angrier and angrier at the people who followed Jesus. He went from house to house, dragging Christians to jail. Then he asked for letters so he could arrest Jesus-followers in the city of Damascus too.
>
> Saul and his men were on the road, almost to Damascus, when suddenly — FLASH! — a light from heaven, brighter than the noon sun, blazed all around him. Saul fell to the ground. A voice said, "Saul, Saul, why do you persecute Me?"
>
> "Who are You, Lord?" Saul asked, trembling.
>
> "I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting," the voice answered. "Now get up and go into the city, and you will be told what to do."
>
> Saul stood up and opened his eyes — but he couldn't see anything! He was blind. His men had to lead him by the hand into Damascus. For three days Saul couldn't see, and he didn't eat or drink. He just prayed.
>
> In Damascus there was a believer named Ananias. Jesus told him in a vision, "Go to Saul and pray for him." Ananias gulped. "Lord, this man has done terrible things to Your people!" But Jesus said, "Go! I have chosen him to tell the nations about Me."
>
> So Ananias went. He put his hands on Saul and said, "Brother Saul" — brother! — "Jesus sent me so you can see again and be filled with the Holy Spirit." Right away, something like scales fell from Saul's eyes. He could see! He got up and was baptized.
>
> Saul began telling everyone, "Jesus is the Son of God!" Now people wanted to hurt *him*. One night his friends put him in a big basket and lowered him through an opening in the city wall so he could escape. Later, Saul became known by his other name — Paul — and he became one of the greatest missionaries who ever lived.
>
> Meanwhile, God was teaching Peter something new too. A Roman soldier named Cornelius loved God, and an angel told him to send for Peter. At the same time, Peter had a vision of a big sheet full of animals, and God said, "Do not call anything impure that God has made clean." When Peter met Cornelius and his family, he understood: "God does not show favoritism!" The good news of Jesus is for everybody — every nation, every color, every language. And the Holy Spirit came on Cornelius's whole household too!

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Turn the lights off for "blind" and on when the "scales fall off." Say together: "Jesus can change ANYONE!" Hold up a heart that flips from a frowny face to a smiley face.
- **Explorers:** Point out Saul = Paul: same man, two names (Saul was his Hebrew name; Paul his Roman name — Acts 13:9). Let them spell both.
- **Trailblazers:** Look up Acts 9:15 and Galatians 1:13–16 — Paul's own description of his change. Map Jerusalem → Damascus (about 135 miles / 220 km).
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss why Cornelius's story was such a big deal: the first church was mostly Jewish, and including Gentiles without them becoming Jewish first was a major step (Acts 10–11; 15). Discuss Ananias's courage — would you visit someone who was known to hurt Christians?

Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Who talked to Saul from heaven? (Jesus.) 2) What happened to Saul's eyes? (He couldn't see, then he could!) 3) Can Jesus change anybody? (Yes!)
- *Explorers:* 1) Why was Ananias afraid to visit Saul? 2) How did Saul escape from Damascus? 3) What did Peter learn from Cornelius?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Jesus said Saul was persecuting *Me*. What does that tell us about how Jesus feels about His people? 2) Why do you think Ananias called him "Brother Saul"? 3) Who is someone you think could "never" change? Pray for them this week.
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Paul later called himself "the worst of sinners" (1 Timothy 1:15–16). How does his story give hope to others? 2) What does "God does not show favoritism" (10:34) mean for racism or cliques today? 3) What does true conversion look like — a feeling, a decision, a changed life, or all of these?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Saul conversion" / "Road to Damascus" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Saul | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Paul conversion" / "Philip and the Ethiopian" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Paul | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | "Overview: Acts 1–12" (Samaria to Cornelius part) | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Acts |

Teacher: Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: 1) How did Saul change after meeting Jesus? 2) Who helped Saul after he was blinded?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Road to Damascus Blindfold Walk* (see Games). ✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Scales-Falling Paper Glasses* (see Activities & Crafts). 🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Full memory verse; spell S-A-U-L and P-A-U-L. Recite all 44 books with the cumulative chant (big kids) or the Gospels + Acts (little kids). 🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> "Jesus, thank You that You can change anyone — even me! Help me love everyone, because Your good news is for everybody. Amen."

Week 4 — To the Ends of the Earth (Acts 13–14; 16; 27–28)

Scripture: Acts 13:1–3; 16:6–40; 27:1–28:31 **Lesson goal:** Kids will learn that God sent Paul around the world with the good news, and nothing — not jail, storms, or snakes — could stop it.

Opening hook / object lesson — "Can't Stop It!" *Supplies:* a roll of masking tape, a small ball, a paper "message" taped to the ball reading "JESUS IS ALIVE!"

1. Lay tape lines on the floor as "walls." Roll the ball; let kids try to block it with their hands, but have a teacher keep finding new ways around.
2. Say: "Some people tried to stop the message about Jesus. They tried jail. They tried chains. Even a giant storm tried! But God's message kept rolling."

Story script:

> In the city of Antioch, the church was praying when the Holy Spirit said, "Set apart Barnabas and Saul for the work I have called them to." So the church prayed for them and sent them off. That was the first missionary journey! A missionary is someone sent to tell others about Jesus.
>
> Paul went on three big journeys, walking and sailing thousands of miles. On his second trip, he took his friend Silas. They went to a city called Philippi. There a woman named Lydia, who sold fancy purple cloth, believed in Jesus. But some men got angry at Paul and Silas, and they had them beaten and thrown into the deepest part of the jail with their feet locked in wooden blocks.
>
> Do you know what Paul and Silas did at midnight? They prayed and sang songs to God! The other prisoners were listening. Suddenly — RUMBLE! — a huge earthquake shook the jail. All the doors flew open, and everyone's chains came loose!
>
> The jailer woke up and thought all the prisoners had escaped. He was terrified. But Paul shouted, "Don't harm yourself! We are all here!" The jailer rushed in, shaking, and fell down before them. "Sirs, what must I do to be saved?"
>
> They answered, "Believe in the Lord Jesus, and you will be saved — you and your household." That very night, the jailer and his whole family believed and were baptized, and he was filled with joy!
>
> Years later, Paul was arrested in Jerusalem. He asked to have his case heard by Caesar, the emperor in Rome. So soldiers put Paul on a ship. But a terrible storm blew for two weeks. The sailors threw cargo overboard. Everyone thought they would die. Then Paul stood up and said, "Keep up your courage! An angel of God told me that not one of you will be lost — only the ship."
>
> The ship crashed on the island of Malta and broke apart. But all 276 people made it safely to shore! While Paul was building a fire, a poisonous snake bit his hand. Everyone waited for him to fall over — but Paul just shook it off into the fire and was fine!
>
> Finally Paul reached Rome. He was under guard in a house for two years, but people came to visit him every day. And the book of Acts ends with Paul telling everyone about Jesus "with all boldness

> and without hindrance." The good news was unstoppable — and it still is! Now it has reached all the way to us.

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Play "jail": sit with "chained" hands (crossed wrists). Sing "Jesus Loves Me" softly, then stomp feet for the earthquake and throw hands apart — "Free!" Then rock side to side for the storm.
- **Explorers:** Let them shout the sound effects: RUMBLE! CRASH! HISS (snake)! Give each child a "ticket" for each city visited and stamp it.
- **Trailblazers:** Trace the three journeys on the map. Find Philippi, Ephesus, Corinth, and Rome — and connect: "Paul later wrote letters to these very churches!" (Next month's books.)
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Acts 17:16–34 (Paul in Athens with philosophers). How did Paul start with what they knew ("an unknown god") to point them to Jesus? Practice explaining the gospel in 60 seconds to a friend who doesn't go to church.

Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) What did Paul and Silas do in jail? (Sang and prayed!) 2) What shook the jail? (An earthquake.) 3) What bit Paul? (A snake — and he was okay!)
- *Explorers:* 1) What question did the jailer ask? 2) How many people were on Paul's ship, and how many were saved? 3) Why do you think Paul and Silas could sing in a dark jail?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why do you think God let Paul go through so many hard things? 2) How did Paul encourage others during the storm? 3) Acts ends without telling us what happened to Paul at his trial. Why might Luke end it there?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Acts ends "without hindrance" while Paul is literally in chains. What's the point? 2) Where are "the ends of the earth" for you — who near you hasn't heard about Jesus? 3) How do you answer someone who says, "If God loved Paul, why did he suffer so much?"

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Paul and Silas" / "Paul shipwreck" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Paul+and+Silas | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Paul shipwreck" / "Paul missionary journey" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Paul+shipwreck | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | "Overview: Acts 13–28" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Acts+13-28 |

Teacher: Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: 1) What did the jailer do after he believed? 2) How did God protect Paul on the way to Rome?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Shipwreck!* (see Games). ✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Missionary Journey Map & Passport* (see Activities & Crafts). 🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Say the full verse for the class; Little Lambs say "You will be my witnesses." Big kids: all 44 books in order, with section shouts. 🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> "God, nothing can stop Your good news! Thank You that it reached me. Help me share it with my friends and family. Amen."

Week 5 (optional) — Review & Fun Sunday

Use the End-of-Phase Review plan below: trivia ship race, oral check-offs, Bible Passport stamps, and the Spirit Flame badge.

Book Memory Song & Motions

🎵 New verse for Acts — tune: *"The Farmer in the Dell"*

> 🎵 *The church is on the move, The church is on the move, Matthew, Mark, and Luke and John, And then comes ACTS — let's go!*
>
> *The Spirit came like fire, The Spirit came like fire, Jerusalem to all the world — That's the book of ACTS!*

🎵 The Cumulative Book Chant (Books 1–44)

Chant it with a steady clap-clap-slap (clap, clap, slap knees) rhythm. Each section ends with a "Section Shout." (Classes may also sing each section to the tune they learned in that phase — see the Memory System.)

> **OLD TESTAMENT!** *(arms wide like an open book)*
>
> Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy — **"FIVE books of LAW!"** *(hold up 5 fingers)*
>
> Joshua, Judges, Ruth, First and Second Samuel, First and Second Kings, First and Second Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther — **"TWELVE books of HISTORY!"** *(flash 10 + 2 fingers)*
>
> Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs — **"FIVE books of POETRY!"** *(strum an air harp)*
>
> Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel — **"FIVE MAJOR PROPHETS!"** *(big muscle arms)*
>
> Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi — **"TWELVE MINOR PROPHETS!"** *(small muscle with one pinky)*
>
> **"THIRTY-NINE in the OLD!"** *(stomp, stomp)*
>
> **NEW TESTAMENT!** *(arms wide again)*

> Matthew, Mark, Luke, John — **"FOUR GOSPELS — JESUS' STORY!"** *(make a cross with fingers)*
>
> ACTS! — **"ONE book of HISTORY — THE CHURCH IS BORN!"** *(flame fingers, then throw hands out)*
>
> **"FORTY-FOUR and COUNTING!"** *(jump!)*

Hand motions (New Testament so far)

For Matthew, Mark, Luke and John, use the motions your class learned in Phase 9. For Genesis through Malachi, use the motions from Phases 1–8 (see the Memory System). This month adds one:

Book	Motion
Acts	Flame fingers over your head, then throw both hands forward ("GO!").

Section Shout

Teacher: "How many books of New Testament History?" **Kids:** "ONE BOOK — ACTS! THE CHURCH IS BORN!"

Cumulative recall drill (5 minutes)

1. **Echo round:** Teacher says each section; kids echo.
2. **Section sprint:** Teacher calls a section name ("Major Prophets!"), kids chant only those books.
3. **What comes next?:** Teacher says a book ("John!"), kids shout the next ("ACTS!"). Mix from all 44.
4. **Silent motions:** Do only the hand motions for the New Testament; kids name the book.
5. **Beat the clock:** Can the class chant all 44 in under 60 seconds?

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on the New Testament five (Matthew, Mark, Luke, John, Acts) with motions; join in the Section Shouts for the Old Testament.
- **Explorers:** Aim for all 44 with the chant; use colored section cards to help.
- **Trailblazers:** Say all 44 without help, and name where each section starts.
- **Ambassadors:** Lead the chant for younger groups; try it backward from Acts to Genesis!

Spelling & Reading

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letter recognition & sound it out)

- Find the first letter: **A** for Acts, **F** for Fire, **W** for Wind, **J** for Jesus, **P** for Peter and Paul.

- Sound it out: A-C-T-S ("a... k... t... s" — Acts!).
- Trace the word **ACTS** in large dotted letters on the printable.

Explorers (book names & story words)

- Acts, Matthew, Mark, Luke, John (review), Peter, Paul, Spirit, church, apostle

Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocab words)

- All New Testament books so far: Matthew, Mark, Luke, John, Acts
- Vocab: **Pentecost** (Jewish festival 50 days after Passover, when the Spirit came), **apostle** (one sent out by Jesus), **witness** (someone who tells what they saw), **missionary** (one sent to share the gospel), **ascension** (Jesus going up to heaven)

Ambassadors (book names + harder vocab with definitions)

- All 44 books so far, including Ecclesiastes, Lamentations, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Deuteronomy
- **persecution** — mistreating people because of what they believe
- **Gentile** — a person who is not Jewish
- **conversion** — turning from sin to follow Jesus; a changed life
- **martyr** — a person who dies because of their faith (from Greek *martys*, "witness")
- **Theophilus** — the person Luke wrote to; the name means "friend of God"

The syllable-clap method

1. Say the word slowly.
2. Clap once for each syllable: *Acts* (1 clap) · *A-pos-tle* (3 claps) · *Pen-te-cost* (3 claps) · *Mis-sion-ar-y* (4 claps) · *Per-se-cu-tion* (4 claps).
3. Spell each syllable, then put it together.

"Spell It Out" relay

Supplies: Large letter cards (one letter per card) for several words, two baskets, masking tape start line.

1. Divide into two teams. Put the scrambled letters for one word in each team's basket across the room.
2. Teacher calls a word (e.g., "APOSTLE"). One player at a time runs, grabs one correct letter, and runs back.
3. The team lines up their letters in order on the floor. First team to spell it correctly and read it aloud wins a point.
4. Little Lambs pair with an older buddy; Ambassadors spell harder words ("PERSECUTION").

Mini spelling bee word list

Word	Use it in a sentence
Acts	"Acts tells how the church began."
Spirit	"The Holy Spirit came on Pentecost."

Word	Use it in a sentence
Peter	"Peter preached and three thousand people believed."
Paul	"Paul traveled to many cities to tell about Jesus."
church	"The church is God's family, not just a building."
apostle	"An apostle is someone sent out by Jesus."
witness	"Jesus said, 'You will be my witnesses.'"
Pentecost	"The Spirit came with wind and fire at Pentecost."
missionary	"Paul was a missionary who sailed across the sea."
Damascus	"Saul met Jesus on the road to Damascus."
Jerusalem	"The church started in Jerusalem."
shipwreck	"Everyone survived the shipwreck on Malta."
persecution	"Persecution made the believers scatter, and they shared Jesus everywhere."
Gentile	"Cornelius was a Gentile who believed in Jesus."

Read-aloud practice passage

(Explorers and older read aloud; Little Lambs repeat key phrases.)

> **Acts 2:42–47 (simplified):** The believers listened to the apostles' teaching. They spent time together, ate meals together, and prayed together. Everyone was amazed at the wonders God did. They shared what they had with anyone who needed it. Every day they met together and praised God with glad and sincere hearts. And every day the Lord added more people who were being saved.

Word Trivia

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. Where did Jesus go in Acts chapter 1?
2. Who did Jesus send to help His friends?
3. What did the sound at Pentecost sound like?
4. What did the flames look like they were resting on?
5. True or False: Peter and John gave the man at the gate lots of money.
6. What did the man who couldn't walk do after he was healed?
7. What did Paul and Silas do in jail at midnight?
8. What shook the jail?
9. What animal bit Paul on the island?
10. Fill in the blank: "You will be my _____." (Acts 1:8)

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

11. Who wrote the book of Acts?
12. How many days did Jesus spend with His friends after He rose, before going to heaven?
13. About how many people believed and were baptized at Pentecost?
14. Who said it? "Silver or gold I do not have, but what I do have I give you."
15. What was the name of the gate where the lame man sat?
16. Who was the first Christian to die for Jesus?
17. Which book? The church is born and the good news spreads to Rome.
18. What was Saul's other name?
19. Who did God send to pray for Saul so he could see again?
20. How did Saul escape from Damascus?
21. Who said it? "Sirs, what must I do to be saved?"
22. What did Lydia sell?
23. True or False: Everyone on Paul's ship survived the shipwreck.
24. On what island did Paul's ship crash?

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

25. Who was chosen to replace Judas as one of the Twelve? (Acts 1)
26. To whom did Luke write both his Gospel and Acts?
27. Fill in the blank: "We cannot help speaking about what we have _____ and _____." (Acts 4:20)
28. Who said it? "Look, I see heaven open and the Son of Man standing at the right hand of God."
29. What book was the Ethiopian official reading when Philip met him?
30. In what city were the disciples first called "Christians"?
31. What was the name of the Roman centurion Peter visited in Acts 10?
32. Who answered the door when Peter knocked after escaping prison — and forgot to open it?
33. In which city were the people praised for examining the Scriptures every day? (Acts 17:11)
34. What did the altar in Athens say that Paul used to start his message?
35. How many people were on Paul's ship? (Acts 27:37)
36. Who fell asleep during Paul's long sermon and fell out of a window? (Acts 20)
37. True or False: Acts ends with Paul's death.
38. What were the three "rings" of Acts 1:8?

Answer key

1. Up to heaven. 2. The Holy Spirit. 3. A violent/rushing wind. 4. On each of them (their heads). 5. False — they had no money; they healed him in Jesus' name. 6. Walked, jumped, and praised God. 7. Prayed and sang hymns to God. 8. An earthquake. 9. A snake (viper). 10. witnesses.
2. Luke. 12. Forty days (Acts 1:3). 13. About 3,000 (Acts 2:41). 14. Peter (Acts 3:6). 15. Beautiful (Acts 3:2). 16. Stephen. 17. Acts. 18. Paul. 19. Ananias. 20. Lowered in a basket through an opening in the wall. 21. The Philippian jailer (Acts 16:30). 22. Purple cloth (Acts 16:14). 23. True (Acts 27:44). 24. Malta.
3. Matthias (Acts 1:26). 26. Theophilus. 27. seen; heard. 28. Stephen (Acts 7:56). 29. Isaiah (Acts 8:28–32, Isaiah 53). 30. Antioch (Acts 11:26). 31. Cornelius. 32. Rhoda (Acts 12:13–14). 33. Berea (Bereans). 34. "To an unknown god" (Acts 17:23). 35. 276. 36. Eutychus (Acts 20:9–12) — Paul

brought him back to life. 37. False — it ends with Paul preaching in Rome under house arrest. 38. Jerusalem; Judea and Samaria; the ends of the earth.

Games

🎮 1. Wind Relay

- **Best for:** All ages (great for Little Lambs & Explorers)
- **Supplies:** Cotton balls or feather pieces, straws (one per child), masking tape, two paper "flame" targets
- **Setup:** Tape a start line and a finish line about 10–15 feet apart. Put a paper flame at the finish for each team.
- **How to play:** Teams line up. Each player blows a cotton ball through a straw from start to finish (no hands!), then runs back and tags the next player. While waiting, the team chants the New Testament books.
- **How to win:** First team to have every player finish wins. Bonus point if the team can say Acts 1:8.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* blow with mouths (no straws) and shorten the distance. *Older:* blow the cotton ball around obstacles (cones = "the ends of the earth").
- **Learning goal:** We can't see wind, but we see what it does — like the Holy Spirit.

🎮 2. Silver & Gold Freeze

- **Best for:** Little Lambs & Explorers
- **Supplies:** Music player, worship song
- **Setup:** Kids sit on the floor as the "man who couldn't walk."
- **How to play:** Teacher (as Peter) says, "Silver or gold I do not have..." Kids stay seated. When the teacher says "...In the name of Jesus — WALK!" everyone jumps up and walks/leaps/dances while music plays. When the music stops, freeze! Teacher calls out a book name; frozen kids must shout the book that comes after it (or before it for older kids).
- **How to win:** Everyone who answers stays in; last few standing are "Brave Witnesses."
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* just freeze and say "Thank You, Jesus!" *Older:* name the section of the called book too.
- **Learning goal:** Healing came through Jesus' name; book-order recall.

🎮 3. Road to Damascus Blindfold Walk

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors
- **Supplies:** Blindfolds (or kids close eyes), cones/chairs for an obstacle path, a "Damascus" sign
- **Setup:** Make a winding path from "Jerusalem" to "Damascus."
- **How to play:** Pairs: one is "Saul" (blindfolded), one is a guide who leads only with words (or by holding a hand for younger kids). At each cone, Saul must say one book of the Bible in order (starting from Genesis) before taking the next step. At Damascus, the guide (as "Ananias") says "Brother Saul, receive your sight!" and removes the blindfold. Switch roles.
- **How to win:** Time each pair; fastest correct run wins — but no skipping books!

- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* hold hands; just say "Jesus loves me" at each cone. *Older:* say the books backward from Acts.
- **Learning goal:** Saul's blindness and healing; trusting a guide; recall of book order.

🎮 4. Shipwreck!

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Open space, four signs on walls: "BOW" (front), "STERN" (back), "PORT" (left), "STARBOARD" (right)
- **How to play:** Teacher is "Captain." Commands: "Bow!" "Stern!" "Port!" "Starboard!" (run to that wall). "STORM!" (everyone spins in place). "Throw the cargo!" (pretend to toss boxes). "Snake!" (shake your hand off like Paul). "SHIPWRECK!" — everyone must find a group of exactly the number the captain calls ("Shipwreck — groups of 4!") and sit down in a "lifeboat." Each lifeboat must then shout one book from the New Testament.
- **How to win:** Kids left out of a group or too slow help the Captain give the next command (no one is ever really "out" — Acts 27: everyone was saved!).
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* fewer commands; just Storm, Snake, and Shipwreck. *Older:* lifeboats must recite the whole Gospels + Acts or a section of the Old Testament.
- **Learning goal:** Paul's shipwreck story; God kept all 276 people safe.

🎮 5. Spread the Good News (Tag)

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers
- **Supplies:** Red pinnies or red bandanas (flames), open area
- **How to play:** Start with one "Witness" holding a red bandana (the Spirit's flame). When the Witness tags someone, they must say a book of the Bible (in order — the class keeps track), and then that person gets a bandana and becomes a Witness too. Keep going until everyone is a Witness. Like the church in Acts, the good news spreads person to person!
- **How to win:** Last person tagged gets to start the next round. Challenge: get through all 44 books before everyone is tagged.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* walk instead of run; say "Jesus loves you!" when tagging. *Older:* add "zones" (Jerusalem, Judea/Samaria, the ends of the earth) that must be reached in order.
- **Learning goal:** Acts 1:8 — the message spreads outward; book-order recall.

🎮 6. Acts Trivia Ship Race (Review Sunday)

- **Best for:** All ages, in mixed teams
- **Supplies:** Map of the Mediterranean drawn on poster board with a path of 10 spaces from Jerusalem to Rome, paper boat markers for each team, trivia questions from above
- **How to play:** Teams take turns answering trivia. Easy = move 1 space, Medium = 2, Hard = 3. "Storm" cards (wrong answers) don't send you back — instead the team must say Acts 1:8 together to "stay afloat."
- **How to win:** First team to reach Rome!
- **Learning goal:** Review the whole book of Acts.

Coloring Pages

🖍️ **Coloring page 1 — Jesus Goes Up (Week 1)** *Scene:* Jesus rising into a soft cloud above a grassy hill (Mount of Olives); 11 disciples looking up with hands shading their eyes; two men in white standing nearby. *Caption:* "This same Jesus… will come back." — Acts 1:11 *Coloring conversation:* Where is Jesus now? What did the two men in white say? Is Jesus coming back?

🖍️ **Coloring page 2 — Wind & Fire (Week 1)** *Scene:* A room full of happy people with small flames above their heads; swirly lines for wind; a window showing a crowd outside from many lands. *Caption:* "All of them were filled with the Holy Spirit." — Acts 2:4 *Coloring conversation:* What color will you make the flames? Who lives in the hearts of people who trust Jesus?

🖍️ **Coloring page 3 — Walking & Jumping (Week 2)** *Scene:* A man leaping in the air with arms raised; Peter and John smiling; a big, decorated temple gate behind them. *Caption:* "In the name of Jesus Christ… walk." — Acts 3:6 *Coloring conversation:* How do you think he felt? What's something you can thank Jesus for today?

🖍️ **Coloring page 4 — The Light on the Road (Week 3)** *Scene:* Saul on the ground shielding his eyes from a bright beam from heaven; his traveling companions startled; the city of Damascus in the distance. *Caption:* "I am Jesus." — Acts 9:5 *Coloring conversation:* What was Saul like before? After? Who can Jesus change?

🖍️ **Coloring page 5 — Singing in Jail (Week 4)** *Scene:* Paul and Silas sitting in a stone jail with music notes floating up; chains falling open; cracks in the wall from an earthquake. *Caption:* "About midnight Paul and Silas were praying and singing." — Acts 16:25 *Coloring conversation:* What song would you sing if you were scared? How can we praise God when things are hard?

🖍️ **Coloring page 6 — Book Name Page: ACTS** *Design:* Big bubble letters **A-C-T-S** filled with small pictures: a flame (A), a church (C), a ship (T), and a snake being shaken off (S). Border with "Matthew · Mark · Luke · John · ACTS." *Caption:* "Acts — The Church Is Born! Book 44 of 66."

> **Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-10-printables.html`**

Activities & Crafts

✂️ 1. Pentecost Flame Headbands (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Sentence strips or paper strips (for headbands), red/orange/yellow tissue paper or construction paper, glue sticks, stapler, markers
- **Steps:** 1) Cut flame shapes from colored paper. 2) Write "ACTS 1:8" or "I can be a witness!" on the headband. 3) Glue flames to the front. 4) Staple to fit each child's head.
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* use pre-cut flames and stickers. *Explorers:* write the verse reference. *Trailblazers/Ambassadors:* write the names of the four "rings" (Jerusalem, Judea, Samaria, ends

of the earth) on four flames.
- **What it teaches:** The Holy Spirit came on every believer; we are witnesses.

✂️ 2. "In Jesus' Name" Walking Feet Craft (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Construction paper, crayons, scissors, glue, a long paper strip
- **Steps:** 1) Trace each child's feet on paper and cut out. 2) On one foot write "Walking," on the other "Jumping." 3) Glue to a strip that says "and praising God!" (Acts 3:8).
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* teachers trace and cut; kids color. *Explorers:* add Acts 3:6. *Older:* write one place their feet will go this week where they can be brave for Jesus.
- **What it teaches:** Jesus' power healed the man; we can walk in Jesus' name.

✂️ 3. Scales-Falling Paper Glasses (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Paper glasses template (or pipe cleaners shaped as glasses), wax paper or cellophane, tape, sequins or paper "scales"
- **Steps:** 1) Make simple glasses frames. 2) Lightly tape paper "scales" over the lenses. 3) Retell the story; on "Brother Saul, receive your sight!" kids peel the scales off and look through clear lenses.
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* pre-made frames. *Older:* write "Before" and "After" words for Saul on each arm of the glasses.
- **What it teaches:** Jesus changed Saul; God opens our eyes to the truth.

✂️ 4. Missionary Journey Map & Passport (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Printed outline map of the Mediterranean (or hand-drawn), colored yarn or markers, small booklet (folded paper), stamps or stickers
- **Steps:** 1) Mark Jerusalem, Antioch, Philippi, Athens, Corinth, Ephesus, Malta, Rome. 2) Glue yarn along Paul's route. 3) In a mini "passport," kids draw something that happened in each city (Philippi = jail, Malta = snake, Rome = house arrest). Stamp each page.
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* place stickers on a pre-drawn route. *Explorers:* label cities. *Trailblazers:* color-code the three journeys. *Ambassadors:* add the letters Paul later wrote to each city (Philippians, Corinthians, Ephesians, Thessalonians).
- **What it teaches:** The gospel spread "to the ends of the earth"; Acts connects to Paul's letters.

✂️ 5. "Unstoppable" Prayer Chain

- **Supplies:** Strips of paper, markers, tape or glue
- **Steps:** Each child writes or draws the name of someone they want to tell about Jesus, then links their strip to the class chain. Add to it every week. On Review Sunday, hang it around the room and pray over it.
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* draw a face. *Older:* write a name and one way to show them Jesus' love.
- **What it teaches:** We are witnesses; the church grows one person at a time.

✂️ 6. Shipwreck Snack (bonus)

- **Supplies:** Blue gelatin or blue frosting on graham crackers ("sea"), pretzel sticks (broken ship planks), gummy snakes, goldfish crackers. *(Check for allergies.)*
- **Steps:** Kids build the shipwreck scene and retell Acts 27–28 as they eat.
- **What it teaches:** God kept everyone safe; the snake couldn't hurt Paul.

Word Puzzles

Word scramble

Unscramble these Acts words:

1. TSAC
2. RTEEP
3. LUPA
4. TIRSIP
5. HCURHC
6. SWESSITNE
7. CTSOPEENT
8. LTEOPAS
9. SCUSAMAD
10. KRCEWHSIP
11. ALAMT
12. YLAID
13. NGIISGN
14. LTEIENG

Answer key: 1. ACTS 2. PETER 3. PAUL 4. SPIRIT 5. CHURCH 6. WITNESSES 7. PENTECOST 8. APOSTLE 9. DAMASCUS 10. SHIPWRECK 11. MALTA 12. LYDIA 13. SINGING 14. GENTILE

Fill-in-the-blank story

Word bank: heaven, Spirit, fire, Peter, three thousand, walk, Saul, blind, Paul, sang, earthquake, Rome

> After Jesus rose again, He went up to _____. Then the Holy _____ came with wind and tongues of _____. _____ preached, and about _____ _____ people believed. Peter and John told a man to _____ in Jesus' name. A man named _____ hated Christians, but Jesus met him on the road and he was _____ for three days. Later he was called _____. He and Silas _____ in jail, and an _____ shook the doors open! At the end of Acts, Paul was in _____ telling everyone about Jesus.

Answers: heaven, Spirit, fire, Peter, three thousand, walk, Saul, blind, Paul, sang, earthquake, Rome

Match the story to its picture

Draw a line from each story to its picture symbol. | Story | Picture | |---|---| | 1. Jesus goes up to heaven | A. 🐍 Snake shaken into a fire | | 2. Pentecost | B. 🧺 Basket over a wall | | 3. The lame man healed | C. ☁️ A cloud | | 4. Saul escapes Damascus | D. 🔥 Flames and wind | | 5. Paul and Silas in jail | E. 🦶 Jumping feet | | 6. Malta | F. 🎵 Music notes and chains | | 7. Peter's vision | G. 🧺 A big sheet full of animals |

Answers: 1-C, 2-D, 3-E, 4-B, 5-F, 6-A, 7-G

Bonus — Match the book to its summary (review): | Book | Summary | |---|---| | Matthew | a. A doctor's careful account of Jesus' life | | Mark | b. Jesus is the promised King from David's line | | Luke | c. Jesus is God's Son — believe and have life | | John | d. The church is born and the good news spreads | | Acts | e. The fast-moving story of Jesus the Servant |

Answers: Matthew-b, Mark-e, Luke-a, John-c, Acts-d

Questions for Every Age

Little Lambs (ages 4–6)

1. Who lives in the hearts of people who love Jesus?
2. What is the church? (God's family!)
3. Who can you tell about Jesus this week?
4. What makes you brave?
5. How can you help someone like Peter and John helped the man?

Explorers (ages 7–10)

1. How would you explain the Holy Spirit to a friend?
2. When is it hard for you to talk about Jesus?
3. Which person in Acts would you most like to meet, and why?
4. What do you think the first church was like? Would you like it?
5. Paul and Silas sang when things were bad. What can you do when you're having a bad day?

Trailblazers (ages 11–13)

1. What does it mean to "be filled with the Spirit" in everyday life?
2. How did persecution actually help the church grow?
3. Why did God choose someone like Saul to be His messenger?
4. How do you know if you're part of God's church?
5. What's one "Jerusalem" (home), "Judea" (town), and "ends of the earth" (world) where you can be a witness?

Ambassadors (ages 14–17)

1. How does the church in Acts 2:42–47 challenge the way we "do church" today?

2. What makes a person bold for Jesus — personality, or something else?
3. How do you share your faith with someone who has a different religion, like Paul did in Athens?
4. Christians are still persecuted in many countries. How should we respond and pray?
5. How can you use your gifts in your church right now, not "someday"?

🧠 Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics & worldview)

1. **"How do we know the resurrection really happened — wasn't it just made up later?"** *Suggested answer:* Acts shows the apostles preaching the resurrection in Jerusalem within weeks — the very city where Jesus' tomb was. If the body were still there, opponents could have produced it. The disciples went from hiding to boldly risking prison and death; people don't usually die for something they know is a lie. Paul, a former enemy, became a believer after meeting the risen Jesus. Early sources (like 1 Corinthians 15:3–8) list many eyewitnesses.
2. **"Is Acts real history, or just a religious story?"** *Suggested answer:* Luke names real rulers (Herod Agrippa, Gallio, Felix, Festus, King Agrippa II), cities, and local titles that historians and archaeologists have confirmed (for example, the Gallio inscription at Delphi helps date Paul's time in Corinth). Luke says he carefully investigated (Luke 1:1–4) and was present for parts of the journey ("we" passages). That doesn't prove every miracle by itself, but it shows Luke was a careful, trustworthy historian.
3. **"Isn't it arrogant to say everyone needs Jesus?"** *Suggested answer:* Peter said salvation is found in no one else (Acts 4:12), but the message was offered humbly and freely to everyone — Jews, Samaritans, Ethiopians, Romans, Greeks. The gospel isn't "we're better than you"; it's "we were all lost, and Jesus rescues anyone who trusts Him." Sharing good news you believe is true is an act of love, not arrogance.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration

Review game plan (last Sunday)

Time	Activity
10 min	Welcome + full Cumulative Book Chant (all 44) with motions
15 min	🎮 Acts Trivia Ship Race (mixed-age teams)
10 min	Replay a favorite video clip; kids vote
15 min	Oral check-offs (rotating stations with helpers; Ambassadors assist)
15 min	Shipwreck Snack + finish passports & prayer chain
10 min	Badge ceremony, Bible Passport stamps, prayer

Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs

- [ ] Says the Little Lambs verse: "You will be my witnesses."

- [ ] Says the section name: "Acts — the church is born!"
- [ ] Names 3 New Testament books (e.g., Matthew, Mark, Acts) with motions
- [ ] Tells one thing from Acts (wind and fire, walking man, singing in jail, snake...)

Explorers

- [ ] Says Acts 1:8 (with help allowed on the place names)
- [ ] Says and spells A-C-T-S
- [ ] Says all 5 New Testament books so far in order and spells each
- [ ] Says the Old Testament section names in order

Trailblazers

- [ ] Says Acts 1:8 from memory
- [ ] Says all 44 books in order (two "helps" allowed)
- [ ] Gives a one-sentence summary for each New Testament book so far
- [ ] Names Paul's three missionary journeys' main cities on a map (at least 4)

Ambassadors

- [ ] Says Acts 1:8 and explains how it outlines the book
- [ ] Says all 44 books in order with no help
- [ ] Teaches the story of Acts (in 2–3 minutes) to a younger kid, using the Flame & Go motion
- [ ] Explains one Big Question in their own words

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp: a **red flame over a small globe** with the words "ACTS — BOOK 44."

🏅 Badge description — The Spirit Flame

A round red-and-orange badge with a flame in the center. Inside the flame is a small globe showing the Mediterranean. Around the edge: "THE CHURCH IS BORN · ACTS 1:8 · 44 of 66."

📜 Certificate wording

> **Purpose Church Sunday School Bible Explorer Certificate — Phase 10: The Church Is Born**
>
> This certifies that _____ has learned the book of **ACTS** and can say the books of the Bible from **Genesis to Acts — 44 of 66!**
>
> "You will receive power when the Holy Spirit comes on you; and you will be my witnesses... to the ends of the earth." — Acts 1:8
>
> Awarded the **Spirit Flame Badge** on _____ (date).
>
> Teacher: _____

Take-Home Family Page

Dear Parents and Families,

This month your child learned about the book of **Acts** — how Jesus went back to heaven, sent the Holy Spirit at Pentecost, and how the first Christians (like Peter and Paul) bravely shared the good news from Jerusalem to Rome. Your child can now say **44 of the 66 books** of the Bible! Please ask them to teach you the chant and motions.

This month's verse: "But you will receive power when the Holy Spirit comes on you; and you will be my witnesses in Jerusalem, and in all Judea and Samaria, and to the ends of the earth." — Acts 1:8
Little Lambs: "You will be my witnesses."

🎵 **This month's song** (tune: *The Farmer in the Dell*):

> The church is on the move, the church is on the move, Matthew, Mark, and Luke and John, and then comes ACTS — let's go!

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions**

1. What happened on the day of Pentecost?
2. How did Jesus change Saul? Can Jesus change anyone?
3. Who is one person our family could tell about Jesus, or show His love to, this week?

🏠 **Family activity — "Our Family's Acts 1:8 Map"** Draw four circles inside each other. In the center write "Our Home," then "Our Neighborhood," then "Our City," then "The World." Together, write one way your family can share Jesus' love in each circle (e.g., pray at dinner, bake cookies for a neighbor, help at a food pantry, pray for or support a missionary). Put it on the fridge!

📺 **Videos to watch at home** (search on YouTube; parents, please preview):

- **@SharefaithKids** — search "Pentecost" or "Paul and Silas": https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=Pentecost
- **@BibleJourneyTV** — search "Paul shipwreck": https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Paul+shipwreck
- **@bibleproject** — "Overview: Acts 1–12" and "Overview: Acts 13–28" (best for ages 11+): https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Acts

Next month: "Letters from Paul" — 13 letters Paul wrote to churches and friends!

Phase 11: Letters from Paul

Thirteen letters written by Paul to churches and friends — full of grace, joy, love, and how to live for Jesus.

At a Glance	
Month	Month 11
Books covered	Romans, 1 Corinthians, 2 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, 1 Thessalonians, 2 Thessalonians, 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, Titus, Philemon (13 books)
Bible section(s)	Paul's Letters (13)
Big Idea	We are saved by God's grace through faith in Jesus — and that grace changes how we live.
Memory Verse (all ages)	"For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith—and this is not from yourselves, it is the gift of God." — Ephesians 2:8 (NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"It is the gift of God." — Ephesians 2:8
Theme color	Royal Blue (like ink on a letter)
Phase symbol / badge	✉️ The Sealed Scroll badge (a rolled letter tied with a red ribbon and a quill pen)
Running total of books learned	**57 of 66**

> Cross-links: Program Overview · Teacher Training Guide · Books of the Bible Memory System · Game Library · YouTube Video Guide · Phase 11 Printables

The Big Idea (in kid words)

Remember Paul from the book of Acts? He started lots of churches in lots of cities. When he couldn't visit them, he wrote them letters! God's Holy Spirit guided Paul's words, so these letters are part of the Bible. Paul's biggest message is this: we can't earn God's love by being good enough — it is a **free gift** called **grace**. When we trust Jesus, God forgives us, makes us part of His family, and helps us live with love, joy, and kindness.

How this points to Jesus: Every one of Paul's letters is about Jesus — who He is (God's Son, over everything, Colossians 1:15–20), what He did (died for our sins and rose again, 1 Corinthians 15:3–4), and how He lives in us (Galatians 2:20). Paul said, "For to me, to live is Christ" (Philippians 1:21).

The Books in Easy Words

> **Big tip for remembering:** Paul's letters are named after **who they were sent to**. Nine are to **churches** (Romans → 2 Thessalonians) and four are to **friends/pastors** (1 Timothy → Philemon). And the middle four have a famous memory trick: **G-E-P-C = "General Electric Power Company"** (Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians).

1. Romans

How to say it	ROH-munz
How to spell it	Ro-mans — R-O-M-A-N-S
Section	Paul's Letters (to a church)
Author	Paul (written down by his helper Tertius, Romans 16:22), from Corinth, about AD 57
Kid summary	Everyone has sinned, but God gives forgiveness and new life as a free gift to everyone who trusts Jesus.
In one word	**Gift**
Key people	Paul, Phoebe (who carried the letter, 16:1–2), Priscilla & Aquila, Abraham (an example of faith, ch. 4)
Key passages	"All have sinned" (3:23); "The wages of sin is death, but the gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord" (6:23); "God demonstrates his own love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us" (5:8); "In all things God works for the good of those who love him" (8:28); nothing can separate us from God's love (8:38–39); "Be transformed by the renewing of your mind" (12:2)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus is the One who takes our sin and gives us His righteousness (3:22–26).
Hand motion	🛣️ Walk two fingers along your other arm like a road — the "Romans Road" to salvation.

2. 1 Corinthians

How to say it	FIRST kor-IN-thee-unz
How to spell it	Co-rin-thi-ans — C-O-R-I-N-T-H-I-A-N-S
Section	Paul's Letters (to a church)
Author	Paul, from Ephesus, about AD 55
Kid summary	Paul helps a church that is arguing and messing up, and shows them how to love each other and work together like one body.

In one word	**Love**
Key people	Paul, Apollos, Cephas (Peter), Chloe's household
Key passages	One body with many parts (ch. 12); the love chapter — "Love is patient, love is kind" (13:4–7); Jesus rose and appeared to over 500 people (15:3–8)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus is the foundation of the church (3:11) and the first to rise from the dead (15:20).
Hand motion	❤️ Hold up 1 finger, then make a heart with your hands.

3. 2 Corinthians

How to say it	SEK-und kor-IN-thee-unz
How to spell it	Co-rin-thi-ans — C-O-R-I-N-T-H-I-A-N-S
Section	Paul's Letters (to a church)
Author	Paul, from Macedonia (northern Greece), about AD 56
Kid summary	Paul shares his hard times and shows that God's power is strongest when we feel weak.
In one word	**Strength-in-weakness** (or simply **Weak**)
Key people	Paul, Titus, Timothy
Key passages	"If anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come" (5:17); "God loves a cheerful giver" (9:7); Paul's list of hardships — shipwrecked three times, lowered in a basket (11:23–33); "My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness" (12:9)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus "who had no sin" became sin for us so we could be made right with God (5:21).
Hand motion	💪 Hold up 2 fingers, then make a wobbly weak arm that turns into a strong muscle.

4. Galatians

How to say it	guh-LAY-shunz
How to spell it	Ga-la-tians — G-A-L-A-T-I-A-N-S
Section	Paul's Letters (to churches in the region of Galatia, modern-day Turkey)
Author	Paul, around AD 48–55
Kid summary	We are made right with God by trusting Jesus, not by keeping rules — and the Holy Spirit grows good fruit in our lives.
In one word	**Free**
Key people	Paul, Peter, Barnabas, Titus, Abraham
Key passages	"I have been crucified with Christ and I no longer live, but Christ lives in me" (2:20); "You are all one in Christ Jesus" (3:28); "It is for freedom that Christ has set us free" (5:1); the fruit of the Spirit: love, joy, peace, forbearance, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness and self-control (5:22–23)

Where Jesus shows up	Jesus "loved me and gave himself for me" (2:20).
Hand motion	🍎 Pretend to pick fruit off a tree and take a bite.

5. Ephesians

How to say it	ee-FEE-zhunz
How to spell it	E-phe-sians — E-P-H-E-S-I-A-N-S
Section	Paul's Letters (to a church; written from prison)
Author	Paul, from prison (probably Rome), about AD 60–62
Kid summary	God saved us by grace and made us one big family in Jesus — so put on God's armor and stand strong.
In one word	**Armor**
Key people	Paul, Tychicus (who delivered the letter, 6:21)
Key passages	"By grace you have been saved, through faith" (2:8–9); we are God's handiwork (2:10); "Be kind and compassionate to one another, forgiving each other" (4:32); "Children, obey your parents in the Lord" (6:1); the armor of God — belt of truth, breastplate of righteousness, feet ready with the gospel of peace, shield of faith, helmet of salvation, sword of the Spirit (the word of God) (6:10–18)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus is the head of the church, and He brings people together (1:22; 2:14).
Hand motion	⛑️ Pretend to put on a helmet, then hold up a shield.

6. Philippians

How to say it	fih-LIP-ee-unz
How to spell it	Phi-lip-pi-ans — P-H-I-L-I-P-P-I-A-N-S (two P's in the middle!)
Section	Paul's Letters (to a church; written from prison)
Author	Paul, from prison (probably Rome), about AD 61–62
Kid summary	Even in jail, Paul is full of joy because Jesus is with him — and he tells us to rejoice too.
In one word	**Joy**
Key people	Paul, Timothy, Epaphroditus, Euodia & Syntyche (two women asked to get along, 4:2)
Key passages	"For to me, to live is Christ and to die is gain" (1:21); Jesus humbled Himself and became a servant (2:5–11); "Rejoice in the Lord always. I will say it again: Rejoice!" (4:4); "Do not be anxious about anything" (4:6); "I can do all this through him who gives me strength" (4:13)

Where Jesus shows up	"At the name of Jesus every knee should bow" (2:10).
Hand motion	😀 Frame your big smile with both hands and bounce.

7. Colossians

How to say it	kuh-LOSH-unz
How to spell it	Co-los-sians — C-O-L-O-S-S-I-A-N-S (two S's in the middle!)
Section	Paul's Letters (to a church; written from prison)
Author	Paul (with Timothy), from prison, about AD 60–62
Kid summary	Jesus is over everything — He made everything and holds it all together — so we don't need anything else to be close to God.
In one word	**Supreme** (or **Over-all**)
Key people	Paul, Timothy, Epaphras (who started the church), Onesimus, Tychicus
Key passages	"The Son is the image of the invisible God… in him all things hold together" (1:15–17); "Set your hearts on things above" (3:1); "Whatever you do, work at it with all your heart, as working for the Lord" (3:23)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus is Creator, Head of the church, and the One who made peace through His cross (1:15–20).
Hand motion	👑 Point up high, then put a crown on your head — Jesus is King over all.

8. 1 Thessalonians

How to say it	FIRST thess-uh-LOH-nee-unz
How to spell it	Thes-sa-lo-ni-ans — T-H-E-S-S-A-L-O-N-I-A-N-S
Section	Paul's Letters (to a church)
Author	Paul (with Silas and Timothy), from Corinth, about AD 50–51 — one of Paul's earliest letters
Kid summary	Jesus is coming back one day, so keep loving, keep praying, and don't lose hope.
In one word	**Return** (or **Coming**)
Key people	Paul, Silas, Timothy
Key passages	Jesus will come down from heaven with a loud command and the trumpet call of God (4:16–17); "Rejoice always, pray continually, give thanks in all circumstances" (5:16–18)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus died and rose again, and He is coming back for His people (4:14).
Hand motion	☁️ Hold up 1 finger, then look up and point at the clouds.

9. 2 Thessalonians

How to say it	SEK-und thess-uh-LOH-nee-unz
How to spell it	Thes-sa-lo-ni-ans — T-H-E-S-S-A-L-O-N-I-A-N-S
Section	Paul's Letters (to a church)
Author	Paul (with Silas and Timothy), from Corinth, about AD 51
Kid summary	While we wait for Jesus to come back, we keep working hard and doing good.
In one word	**Wait-and-work** (or **Work**)
Key people	Paul, Silas, Timothy
Key passages	"The Lord is faithful, and he will strengthen you and protect you" (3:3); "Never tire of doing what is good" (3:13)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus will return in glory and make everything right (1:7–10).
Hand motion	🔨 Hold up 2 fingers, then hammer one fist on the other — keep working!

10. 1 Timothy

How to say it	FIRST TIM-uh-thee
How to spell it	Tim-o-thy — T-I-M-O-T-H-Y
Section	Paul's Letters (to a friend — a young pastor)
Author	Paul, about AD 62–64, to Timothy in Ephesus
Kid summary	Paul coaches his young friend Timothy on how to lead a church and be a good example, even though he is young.
In one word	**Example**
Key people	Paul, Timothy
Key passages	"Christ Jesus came into the world to save sinners" (1:15); "Don't let anyone look down on you because you are young, but set an example for the believers in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith and in purity" (4:12)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus is the one "mediator between God and mankind" (2:5).
Hand motion	👍 Hold up 1 finger, then point to yourself and give a thumbs-up — "I can be an example!"

11. 2 Timothy

How to say it	SEK-und TIM-uh-thee
How to spell it	Tim-o-thy — T-I-M-O-T-H-Y
Section	Paul's Letters (to a friend)
Author	Paul, from prison in Rome, about AD 64–67 — his last letter before he died

Kid summary	In his final letter, Paul tells Timothy to stay strong, keep teaching God's Word, and finish the race.
In one word	**Finish**
Key people	Paul, Timothy, Lois (Timothy's grandmother) and Eunice (his mother) (1:5), Luke ("Only Luke is with me," 4:11), Mark
Key passages	"All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness" (3:16); "I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith" (4:7)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus "has destroyed death and has brought life and immortality to light" (1:10).
Hand motion	📖 Hold up 2 fingers, then open your hands like a Bible and blow gently into it — "God-breathed!"

12. Titus

How to say it	TY-tus
How to spell it	Ti-tus — T-I-T-U-S
Section	Paul's Letters (to a friend — a pastor on the island of Crete)
Author	Paul, about AD 62–64
Kid summary	Paul tells Titus to choose good leaders and teach God's people to do what is good because God has been so good to us.
In one word	**Good** (doing good)
Key people	Paul, Titus
Key passages	God's grace teaches us to say "No" to wrong and live upright lives (2:11–12); "He saved us, not because of righteous things we had done, but because of his mercy" (3:5)
Where Jesus shows up	"Our great God and Savior, Jesus Christ" (2:13).
Hand motion	🧱 Stack your fists one on top of the other, like building something good and orderly (Paul left Titus to "put in order" the churches, 1:5).

13. Philemon

How to say it	fy-LEE-mun
How to spell it	Phi-le-mon — P-H-I-L-E-M-O-N
Section	Paul's Letters (to a friend)
Author	Paul, from prison, about AD 60–62 — only 1 chapter (25 verses)
Kid summary	Paul asks his friend Philemon to forgive Onesimus, a runaway slave who became a Christian, and welcome him back as a brother.
In one word	**Forgive**

Key people	Paul, Philemon, Onesimus (o-NESS-ih-mus, means "useful"), Apphia, Archippus
Key passages	"Formerly he was useless to you, but now he has become useful" (v. 11); "no longer as a slave, but better than a slave, as a dear brother" (v. 16); "If he has done you any wrong… charge it to me" (v. 18)
Where Jesus shows up	Paul's offer to pay Onesimus's debt is a picture of what Jesus does for us — He takes our debt on Himself.
Hand motion	🤝 Shake hands with a neighbor and say "Welcome back, brother!"

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher

Paul (born Saul in Tarsus) was a highly trained Jewish Pharisee who persecuted Christians until Jesus met him on the road to Damascus (Acts 9). He then spent about 30 years starting churches across the Roman Empire. His 13 letters (called **epistles**) were written to real people facing real problems — arguments, false teaching, fear, suffering, and confusion about Jesus' return. They are arranged in the Bible **roughly from longest to shortest**, first the church letters, then the personal letters — not in the order Paul wrote them. (1 Thessalonians and Galatians are probably the earliest; 2 Timothy is the last.)

Groupings that help:

- **Church letters (9):** Romans, 1 & 2 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, 1 & 2 Thessalonians
- **Prison letters (4):** Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, Philemon (+ 2 Timothy, written from a later imprisonment)
- **Pastoral letters (3):** 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, Titus — instructions for church leaders

Many of these cities appeared in Acts last month: Philippi (Lydia and the jailer, Acts 16), Thessalonica (Acts 17), Corinth (Acts 18), and Ephesus (Acts 19). Connect the dots for the kids — "Remember the jailer? This letter went to his church!"

Key truths to emphasize

1. **Grace:** salvation is a free gift, received by faith, not earned by works (Ephesians 2:8–9; Romans 6:23).
2. **Grace changes us:** good works don't save us, but they are the result of being saved (Ephesians 2:10; Titus 2:11–14).
3. **Jesus is supreme:** He is God, Creator, and Lord over all (Colossians 1:15–20; Philippians 2:5–11).
4. **The church is one body:** every person matters, every gift is needed (1 Corinthians 12).
5. **Love is the greatest:** (1 Corinthians 13:13).
6. **Hope:** Jesus is coming back, and death is not the end (1 Thessalonians 4:13–18; 1 Corinthians 15).

Map notes

Use the same Mediterranean map from Phase 10. Place an envelope icon on each city: **Rome, Corinth, Galatia (region), Ephesus, Philippi, Colossae, Thessalonica, Crete (Titus)**. Timothy was in Ephesus (1 Timothy 1:3); Philemon lived in Colossae (compare Colossians 4:9).

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs	Explorers	Trailblazers & Ambassadors
Sin and death (Romans 6:23)	"Sin means doing wrong things. Sin separates us from God. But Jesus came to fix it!"	Explain "wages" as what we earn. Emphasize the gift side.	Discuss justice and mercy — God doesn't ignore sin; Jesus pays for it.
Slavery (Philemon)	"Onesimus was a worker who ran away."	"In those days, some people were owned by others as slaves. That was wrong and hurtful. Paul asked Philemon to treat Onesimus as a brother."	Discuss honestly: Roman slavery was common and cruel. Paul condemned slave-trading (1 Timothy 1:10) and taught that in Christ "there is neither slave nor free" (Galatians 3:28). These truths later fueled Christians who fought to end slavery. (See Big Question #3.)
Believers who died (1 Thessalonians 4)	"When people who love Jesus die, they go to be with Jesus, and one day He will make everything new."	Reassure; let kids share about grandparents or pets gently.	Discuss grief "with hope" (4:13) — Christians still feel sad, but not without hope.
Paul's sufferings (2 Corinthians 11)	"Paul had lots of hard days, but God helped him."	Fine to list them — kids love the adventure.	Connect to "power made perfect in weakness."

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

- **"Why did Paul write letters instead of texting?"** — There were no phones! Letters were carried by friends who walked or sailed for weeks. A letter from Paul was a big deal — the whole church would gather to hear it read.
- **"How are letters to other people God's Word for me?"** — The Holy Spirit guided Paul (2 Timothy 3:16). The same truths that helped those churches help us, because people still need Jesus, still argue, still get scared, and still need hope.
- **"What is grace?"** — Grace is getting a good gift you didn't earn. God gives us forgiveness and His love even though we don't deserve it.
- **"If grace is free, can I just do bad stuff?"** — Paul answered that exact question: "By no means!" (Romans 6:1–2). When you love someone who gave you a huge gift, you want to please them.
- **"Did Paul go to jail because he was bad?"** — No. He was arrested for telling people about Jesus. Some people didn't like his message.

- **"What happened to Paul?"** — The Bible doesn't describe his death, but early Christian writers say he was killed in Rome for his faith, around AD 64–67. Before that, he wrote, "I have finished the race" (2 Timothy 4:7). He is with Jesus now.

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	Video	Game	Activity
1	Romans 3:23; 5:8; 6:23; 10:9; Galatians 5:22–23	The Best Gift Ever	Salvation is a free gift — grace!	📺 "Overview: Romans" (BibleProject); Sharefaith Kids "grace"; Bible Journey "Paul"	🎮 Romans Road Race	Gift Box Verse Craft
2	1 Corinthians 12–13; Ephesians 6:10–18	One Body, Big Love, Strong Armor	Every person matters; love is the greatest; God makes us strong.	📺 "Overview: 1 Corinthians," "Overview: Ephesians"	🎮 Body Parts Scramble / Armor Up Relay	Armor of God Paper Suit
3	Philippians 1; 4; Colossians 1:15–20; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18	Joy in Chains	Joy comes from Jesus, not from easy days — and He's coming back.	📺 "Overview: Philippians," "Overview: Colossians," "Overview: 1 Thessalonians"	🎮 Joy Jump	Joy Jar
4	1 Timothy 4:12; 2 Timothy 3:14–4:8; Titus 3:4–7; Philemon	Letters to Friends	God uses young people, and forgiveness makes enemies into family.	📺 "Overview: 1 Timothy," "Overview: 2 Timothy," "Overview: Philemon"	🎮 Mail Carrier Dash	Write-a-Letter Station
5 (optional)	All 13 letters	Review & Fun Sunday	57 books — almost there!	Favorite clip replay	🎮 Letter Sort Showdown	Sealed Scroll Badge ceremony

---

Weekly Lessons

Week 1 — The Best Gift Ever (Romans & Galatians)

Scripture: Romans 3:23; 5:8; 6:23; 8:38–39; 10:9; 16:1–2, 22; Galatians 5:22–23 **Lesson goal:** Kids will understand that salvation is a free gift from God (grace), received by trusting Jesus.

Opening hook / object lesson — "Earn It or Receive It?" *Supplies:* a beautifully wrapped gift box (inside: a card that reads "GRACE — a gift you can't earn"), a few "chores" cards (sweep, jump 10 times, recite ABCs).

1. Show the gift. "Who wants it?" Offer it to a volunteer — but first say, "You have to earn it! Do these 3 chores." Let them start, then stop them.
2. "Wait — if you earn it, is it still a gift? No! It's a paycheck." Hand them the gift for free.
3. Say: "God's love is like this. We can't earn it. Paul called it **grace** — a gift we receive by trusting Jesus."

Story script:

> Paul was staying in the city of Corinth. He had never been to Rome, the biggest and most important city in the whole world. But there were Christians in Rome, and Paul loved them. He wanted to send them the clearest explanation he could of the good news about Jesus.
>
> So Paul sat down with a friend named Tertius. Paul talked, and Tertius wrote every word with a pen and ink on a long scroll. It was a very long letter — sixteen chapters!
>
> Here is some of what Paul said. "Everyone has sinned." Sin means doing what's wrong and going our own way instead of God's way. Paul said, "All have sinned and fall short of the glory of God." That means nobody is good enough on their own — not kings, not teachers, not even Paul!
>
> "Sin is like a job that pays a terrible paycheck," Paul explained. "The wages of sin is death." That's bad news. But then comes the best news ever: "...but the GIFT of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord!"
>
> How did God give us this gift? Paul wrote, "God showed His love for us like this: while we were still sinners, Christ died for us." Jesus didn't wait for us to get good. He came for us while we were still messing up!
>
> And how do we receive the gift? "If you declare with your mouth, 'Jesus is Lord,' and believe in your heart that God raised Him from the dead, you will be saved."
>
> Paul wanted the Romans to know that once you belong to Jesus, nothing can take you away from His love. "Not death, not life, not angels, not anything in all creation can separate us from the love of God that is in Christ Jesus our Lord!"
>
> When the letter was done, a brave woman named Phoebe carried it all the way to Rome — over land and sea. Imagine the church gathering to hear it read out loud for the first time!
>
> In another letter, to the churches in Galatia, Paul explained what happens after we receive God's gift: the Holy Spirit grows "fruit" in our lives — love, joy, peace, patience, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, and self-control. We don't grow good fruit to earn God's love. We grow it because God's love is already living in us!

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Pass the gift box around while singing; whoever holds it when the music stops says, "Jesus is a gift!" Focus phrase: "It is the gift of God."
- **Explorers:** Teach the **Romans Road** with 4 signposts on the wall: 3:23 (everyone sinned), 6:23 (sin pays death, God gives a gift), 5:8 (Jesus died for us), 10:9 (believe and say "Jesus is Lord"). Walk the road together.
- **Trailblazers:** Look up Galatians 5:22–23 and list the nine fruits. Which one is easiest for you? Hardest? Compare with "acts of the flesh" (5:19–21).
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss "justified by faith" (Romans 5:1). What does "justified" mean (declared right/not guilty)? Why couldn't the law save us (Romans 3:20; Galatians 2:16)? Practice walking a younger child through the Romans Road.

Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) What is a gift? 2) What gift does God give us? (Jesus / forever life with Him.) 3) Can anything stop God from loving you? (No!)
- *Explorers:* 1) What does "all have sinned" mean? 2) Why is God's gift better than a paycheck? 3) Who carried Paul's letter to Rome?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why do people try to earn God's love? 2) What's the difference between doing good to *get* God's love and doing good *because* we have it? 3) Which fruit of the Spirit do you want God to grow in you this month?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Romans 8:28 is often quoted — what does it promise, and what doesn't it promise? 2) Why does Paul say "while we were *still* sinners"? Why does that matter? 3) How would you explain grace to a friend who thinks God grades on a curve?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "grace" / "fruit of the Spirit" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=fruit+of+the+Spirit | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Paul" / "Romans" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Paul | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | "Overview: Romans 1–4" and "Overview: Romans 5–16"; "Overview: Galatians" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Romans |

Teacher: Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: 1) What is the "gift of God"? 2) What do we have to do to receive a gift?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Romans Road Race* (see Games). ✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Gift Box Verse Craft* (see Activities & Crafts). 🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Learn the memory verse (Ephesians 2:8) with motions. Learn "Romans, First and Second Corinthians." Spell R-O-M-A-N-S. 🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> "Thank You, God, for the gift of Jesus. I can't earn Your love, but You give it to me free! Please grow good fruit in my life. Amen."

Week 2 — One Body, Big Love, Strong Armor (1 & 2 Corinthians, Ephesians)

Scripture: 1 Corinthians 12:12–27; 13:1–13; 2 Corinthians 12:9; Ephesians 6:10–18 **Lesson goal:** Kids will learn that every believer is an important part of Christ's body, that love is the greatest, and that God gives us armor to stand strong.

Opening hook / object lesson — "The Silly Body" *Supplies:* a large paper cut-out of a person, extra paper "ears" (lots of them), tape.

1. Tape ten ears all over the paper body. "What if the whole body was an EAR? How would it see? Smell? Walk?"
2. Kids laugh. Say: "Paul wrote to a church where people were saying, 'I'm more important than you!' Paul said, 'You're like a body — every part is needed!'"

Story script:

> In the city of Corinth there was a church Paul had started. Paul stayed there a year and a half, teaching about Jesus. But after he left, the church started having problems. People were arguing. Some said, "I follow Paul!" Others said, "I follow Apollos!" Some thought they were more important because they had flashy gifts. Others felt left out.
>
> So Paul wrote them a letter. He said, "You are like a body. A body has many parts — eyes, ears, hands, feet. What if the foot said, 'I'm not a hand, so I don't belong'? It would still be part of the body! What if the whole body were one big eye? How would it hear? God put each part where He wanted it. You are the body of Christ, and each one of you is a part of it."
>
> Then Paul wrote something so beautiful that people still read it at weddings today. "If I can speak every language, even like angels, but don't have love, I'm just a noisy gong! Love is patient. Love is kind. It does not envy. It does not boast. It is not proud. It keeps no record of wrongs. Love never fails!" And Paul ended, "Faith, hope, and love — but the greatest of these is love."
>
> Later, Paul wrote them another letter. He told them about his hard times: he'd been beaten, shipwrecked three times, gone hungry, and even lowered in a basket through a wall to escape. Paul also had something painful he called a "thorn in my flesh." Three times he asked God to take it away. But God said, "My grace is enough for you. My power is made perfect in weakness." Paul learned that when he felt weak, God's strength showed up even more!
>
> Years later, while he was chained to a Roman soldier, Paul wrote to the church in Ephesus. Maybe he looked at that soldier's armor and got an idea. "Put on the full armor of God," he wrote, "so you can stand strong!" There's the **belt of truth**, the **breastplate of righteousness**, **shoes** ready to share the **gospel of peace**, the **shield of faith**, the **helmet of salvation**, and the **sword of the Spirit**, which is the **Word of God**. And don't forget — pray at all times!

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Point to body parts: "Eyes! Ears! Hands! Feet! Every part is important — and YOU are important in God's family!" Put on pretend armor piece by piece with big motions.

- **Explorers:** Read 1 Corinthians 13:4–7, replacing "love" with "Jesus." Then replace it with your own name — "Sam is patient, Sam is kind..." Is it true? Pray for God's help.
- **Trailblazers:** Match each piece of Roman armor to its spiritual meaning; discuss why the sword (God's Word) is the only "attack" piece.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss spiritual gifts (1 Corinthians 12:4–11; Romans 12:6–8). What gifts do you see in each other? Discuss why Paul put the love chapter right in the middle of a discussion about gifts.

Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Is every part of your body important? 2) Are you important in God's family? (Yes!) 3) What is the greatest thing? (Love!)
- *Explorers:* 1) Why was the church in Corinth arguing? 2) What are three things love does or doesn't do? 3) Name three pieces of God's armor.
- *Trailblazers:* 1) What does it mean that the church is "the body of Christ"? 2) Which part of "love is..." is hardest for you? 3) What did God mean by "My power is made perfect in weakness"?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) How can cliques in a youth group be like the problems in Corinth? 2) What "battles" are teens facing, and which armor piece helps most? 3) How can weakness actually be a gift?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "armor of God" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=armor+of+God | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Paul Corinth" / "armor of God" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=armor+of+God | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | "Overview: 1 Corinthians," "Overview: 2 Corinthians," "Overview: Ephesians" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Ephesians |

Teacher: Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: 1) Which piece of armor would you want most, and why? 2) How can you show love this week?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Armor Up Relay* and *Body Parts Scramble* (see Games). ✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Armor of God Paper Suit* (see Activities & Crafts). 🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Add "Galatians, Ephesians" (G-E of "General Electric"). Spell C-O-R-I-N-T-H-I-A-N-S (Explorers+), E-P-H-E-S-I-A-N-S. 🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> "Dear God, thank You that I'm an important part of Your family. Help me to be patient and kind. Help me put on Your armor and stand strong. Amen."

Week 3 — Joy in Chains (Philippians, Colossians, 1 & 2 Thessalonians)

Scripture: Philippians 1:12–14, 21; 2:25–30; 4:4–13; Colossians 1:15–20; 1 Thessalonians 4:13–18; 5:16–18
Lesson goal: Kids will learn that real joy comes from Jesus, who is over everything, and that we have hope because He is coming back.

Opening hook / object lesson — "Joy on the Inside" *Supplies:* a can of soda (or bottle of sparkling water), a clear cup, a bag of sugar cubes or a lemon; OR a glow stick.

- Glow stick version: Show an un-cracked glow stick. "It's kind of boring." Turn off the lights and crack it — it glows! "The darker it gets, the brighter it shines. Paul was in a dark place — chained up in prison — but his joy in Jesus shone bright!"

Story script:

> Paul was under arrest in Rome. He lived in a house, but a Roman soldier guarded him all day, and Paul was chained. He couldn't travel. He couldn't visit his churches. Some people would be grumpy, sad, or angry. But Paul did something surprising — he wrote a letter about JOY!
>
> The letter was to his friends in Philippi. Remember them? That's where Lydia believed, and where Paul and Silas sang in jail and the jailer's family got saved! The Philippian church loved Paul. They sent a man named Epaphroditus with gifts to help him. But Epaphroditus got so sick he almost died! God had mercy and healed him, and Paul sent him home carrying the letter.
>
> Paul wrote, "Don't worry about me! Because I'm in chains, the whole palace guard has heard about Jesus! And other Christians are getting braver." Paul said, "For me, to live is Christ, and to die is gain." In other words, "If I live, I get to serve Jesus. If I die, I get to be with Jesus. Either way, I win!"
>
> Then Paul wrote, "Rejoice in the Lord always! I'll say it again: Rejoice!" and "Don't worry about anything; instead, pray about everything." And, "I have learned to be content whether I have a lot or a little. I can do all this through Him who gives me strength."
>
> About the same time, Paul wrote to the church in Colossae. Some people there were saying Jesus wasn't enough. Paul wrote, "Jesus is the image of the invisible God! Everything was made through Him and for Him. He holds all things together!" If Jesus holds the whole universe together, He can hold *us* together too.
>
> Years earlier, Paul had written to the church in Thessalonica. Those believers were sad because some of their Christian friends had died. They wondered, "Will we ever see them again?" Paul comforted them: "We don't grieve like people who have no hope. Jesus died and rose again, and one day the Lord Himself will come down from heaven with a loud command and the trumpet call of God. Those who died believing in Jesus will rise, and we will all be with the Lord forever! So encourage each other with these words."
>
> No wonder Paul could write, "Rejoice always, pray continually, give thanks in all circumstances!"

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Sing "I've Got the Joy, Joy, Joy, Joy Down in My Heart." Practice "Rejoice!" as a jump-and-cheer. Short truth: "Jesus makes me happy inside, even on sad days."
- **Explorers:** Play "Glad / Sad / Still Glad": Teacher names a bad situation ("Your ice cream fell!"). Kids say one reason they can still have joy in Jesus.

- **Trailblazers:** Read Philippians 4:6–7 and practice turning worries into prayers. Write a worry on one side of a card and a prayer on the other.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss "content" (Philippians 4:11–13). Is Philippians 4:13 about winning sports games? (In context it's about being content in need or plenty.) Discuss Colossians 1:15–20 as one of the earliest Christian statements that Jesus is God.

Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Where was Paul when he wrote about joy? (In chains!) 2) Who gives us joy? (Jesus.) 3) Who is coming back one day? (Jesus!)
- *Explorers:* 1) How did Paul's chains actually help spread the gospel? 2) What does Philippians 4:6 tell us to do instead of worrying? 3) Why were the Thessalonians sad, and what did Paul tell them?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) What's the difference between happiness and joy? 2) What does "He holds all things together" mean for your life? 3) How can you "give thanks in all circumstances" — even bad ones?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) What does Philippians 4:13 really mean in context? 2) How does hope in Jesus' return change the way Christians handle grief? 3) Paul says "to die is gain." How can that be true without being morbid?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "joy" / "Paul in prison" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=joy | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Paul in Rome" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Paul+Rome | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | "Overview: Philippians," "Overview: Colossians," "Overview: 1 Thessalonians," "Overview: 2 Thessalonians" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Philippians |

Teacher: Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: 1) How can you rejoice when you're having a hard day? 2) What will happen when Jesus comes back?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Joy Jump* (see Games). ✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Joy Jar* (see Activities & Crafts). 🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Add "Philippians, Colossians, First and Second Thessalonians." Spell P-H-I-L-I-P-P-I-A-N-S (two P's!) and C-O-L-O-S-S-I-A-N-S (two S's!). Little Lambs: "Rejoice!" 🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> "Jesus, You hold everything together. Thank You for giving me joy, even on hard days. Thank You that You are coming back! Amen."

Week 4 — Letters to Friends (1 & 2 Timothy, Titus, Philemon)

Scripture: 1 Timothy 4:12; 2 Timothy 1:5; 3:14–17; 4:6–8; Titus 3:4–7; Philemon 1–25 **Lesson goal:** Kids will learn that God uses young people and that forgiveness turns enemies into family.

Opening hook / object lesson — "The Debt Note" *Supplies:* a paper "bill" that reads "OWES: $1,000,000," a red marker, an envelope.

1. Hand a volunteer the bill. "Oh no — you owe a million dollars! Can you pay it?" (No!)
2. Take the red marker and write across it: "CHARGE IT TO ME. — Paul." "Today we'll read a letter where Paul says, 'If he owes you anything, charge it to me.' That's what Jesus does for us!"

Story script:

> Paul had a lot of friends, and some of his letters were written just to them.
>
> One friend was **Timothy**. Timothy grew up in a town called Lystra. His grandmother Lois and his mother Eunice taught him the Scriptures from the time he was a little boy. When Paul visited, Timothy believed in Jesus and began traveling with Paul. Paul called him "my true son in the faith."
>
> When Timothy became a pastor in Ephesus, he was pretty young. Maybe some people said, "You're just a kid! What do you know?" So Paul wrote, "Don't let anyone look down on you because you are young, but set an example for the believers in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, and in purity." God uses young people!
>
> Later, Paul was in prison again, and this time he knew he would probably die soon. He wrote one last letter to Timothy: "Keep going in what you learned. All Scripture is God-breathed. Preach the Word! I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith. Now there is a crown waiting for me." Paul also wrote, "Come see me soon. Bring my coat and my scrolls. Only Luke is with me."
>
> Another friend was **Titus**, who was helping churches on the island of Crete. Paul told him, "Remind people to be kind and ready to do good — because God our Savior was kind to us. He saved us, not because of the good things we did, but because of His mercy."
>
> And then there's the shortest letter: **Philemon**. Philemon was a rich Christian who had a church meeting in his house. He also had a slave named Onesimus. One day, Onesimus ran away — and he may have taken something too. He ran all the way to the big city of Rome.
>
> Guess who Onesimus met there? Paul! Paul told him about Jesus, and Onesimus became a Christian. His name meant "useful," and now he really was useful — he helped Paul a lot.
>
> But Onesimus needed to make things right. So Paul sent him back home with a letter for Philemon: "I'm sending him back to you — not as a slave anymore, but as a dear brother. Welcome him like you would welcome me. If he owes you anything, charge it to me. I'll pay it back!"
>
> Can you imagine Philemon reading that letter with Onesimus standing right in front of him? That's the power of the gospel: Jesus forgives us and makes us brothers and sisters — and He paid what we owed.

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Act out the Philemon story with two puppets: running away, saying sorry, getting a hug. "God forgives us, and we forgive others."

- **Explorers:** Brainstorm ways kids can "set an example" in each area: speech, conduct (actions), love, faith, purity. Write them on a hand outline (five fingers = five areas).
- **Trailblazers:** Read all of Philemon (it's short — 25 verses). Find where Paul is gentle, where he is persuasive, and where he offers to pay. Compare Philemon 18 with 2 Corinthians 5:21.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss 2 Timothy 3:16–17 — what does "God-breathed" mean for how we treat the Bible? Write a "Paul-style" letter of encouragement to a younger kid in the class.

Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Who taught Timothy about God when he was little? (His grandma and mom.) 2) Can God use kids? (Yes!) 3) What did Paul ask Philemon to do? (Forgive / welcome Onesimus.)
- *Explorers:* 1) What five ways did Paul say Timothy could be an example? 2) Why did Onesimus have to go back? 3) How is Paul saying "charge it to me" like what Jesus did?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why do you think Paul's last letter talks so much about God's Word? 2) What does it mean to "finish the race"? 3) Who is someone you need to forgive or ask forgiveness from?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) How can a teenager be a leader in church now? 2) What would it have cost Philemon to obey Paul? 3) How should the gospel change the way we treat people with less power or status?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "Timothy" / "forgiveness" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=forgiveness | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Onesimus" / "Philemon" / "Timothy" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Philemon | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | "Overview: 1 Timothy," "Overview: 2 Timothy," "Overview: Titus," "Overview: Philemon" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Philemon |

Teacher: Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: 1) How did Paul help Onesimus and Philemon become friends? 2) How can you be an example this week?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Mail Carrier Dash* (see Games). ✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Write-a-Letter Station* (see Activities & Crafts). 🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Add "First and Second Timothy, Titus, Philemon." All 13 letters with motions! Spell T-I-M-O-T-H-Y, T-I-T-U-S, P-H-I-L-E-M-O-N. 🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> "Dear God, thank You that You can use me even though I'm young. Thank You that Jesus paid what I owed. Help me forgive others like You forgave me. Amen."

Week 5 (optional) — Review & Fun Sunday

Use the End-of-Phase Review plan below: Letter Sort Showdown, oral check-offs, Bible Passport stamps, and the Sealed Scroll badge.

Book Memory Song & Motions

🎵 Paul's Letters Song — tune: *"Old MacDonald Had a Farm"*

> 🎵 **Verse 1: Letters to Churches** *Paul wrote letters to the church, Thirteen letters — WHOA! Romans, First and Second Corinthians, Thirteen letters — WHOA! Galatians here, Ephesians there, Philippians, Colossians — everywhere! First and Second Thessalonians, Thirteen letters — WHOA!*
>
> **Verse 2: Letters to Friends** *Paul wrote letters to his friends, Thirteen letters — WHOA! First and Second Timothy, Thirteen letters — WHOA! With a Titus here and a Philemon there, Here a letter, there a letter, everywhere a letter, letter! Paul wrote letters to his friends, Thirteen letters — WHOA!*
>
> *(Shout:)* **"THIRTEEN LETTERS FROM PAUL!"**

Tip: Sing "Romans, First and Second Corinthians" fast, to fit the line "And on that farm he had a cow." "Galatians here, Ephesians there" fits "With a moo-moo here and a moo-moo there." Practice slowly first, then faster! Throw your arms wide on every "WHOA!"

Bonus chant for the middle four — "General Electric Power Company":

> *G — Galatians! E — Ephesians! P — Philippians! C — Colossians! General Electric Power Company — G, E, P, C!*

🎵 The Cumulative Book Chant (Books 1–57)

Clap-clap-slap rhythm. (Classes may also sing each section to the tune they learned in that phase — see the Memory System.)

> **OLD TESTAMENT!** *(arms wide like an open book)*
>
> Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy — **"FIVE books of LAW!"** *(5 fingers)*
>
> Joshua, Judges, Ruth, First and Second Samuel, First and Second Kings, First and Second Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther — **"TWELVE books of HISTORY!"**
>
> Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs — **"FIVE books of POETRY!"** *(air harp)*
>
> Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel — **"FIVE MAJOR PROPHETS!"** *(big muscles)*
>
> Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi — **"TWELVE MINOR PROPHETS!"** *(pinky muscle)*
>
> **"THIRTY-NINE in the OLD!"**
>
> **NEW TESTAMENT!**

> Matthew, Mark, Luke, John — **"FOUR GOSPELS!"** *(cross)*
>
> Acts — **"ONE book of HISTORY — THE CHURCH IS BORN!"** *(flame and go)*
>
> Romans, First and Second Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, First and Second Thessalonians, First and Second Timothy, Titus, Philemon — **"THIRTEEN LETTERS FROM PAUL!"** *(pretend to write with a quill, then fold a letter)*
>
> **"FIFTY-SEVEN — ALMOST THERE!"** *(jump!)*

Hand motions for each letter

#	Book	Motion
1	Romans	Walk fingers along your arm (Romans Road)
2	1 Corinthians	1 finger, then a heart (love chapter)
3	2 Corinthians	2 fingers, then a wobbly arm becoming a strong muscle
4	Galatians	Pick fruit and take a bite
5	Ephesians	Put on a helmet, hold up a shield
6	Philippians	Frame a big smile and bounce (joy)
7	Colossians	Point up, then put on a crown (Jesus over all)
8	1 Thessalonians	1 finger, look up and point to clouds
9	2 Thessalonians	2 fingers, hammer fists (keep working)
10	1 Timothy	1 finger, point to self + thumbs-up (be an example)
11	2 Timothy	2 fingers, open-book hands + blow ("God-breathed")
12	Titus	Stack fists (put things in order, do good)
13	Philemon	Shake hands ("Welcome back, brother!")

Section Shout

Teacher: "How many letters did Paul write?" **Kids:** "THIRTEEN! NINE to CHURCHES and FOUR to FRIENDS!"

Cumulative recall drill (5 minutes)

1. **Echo round** for Paul's letters, then the whole chant.
2. **Churches or Friends?** Teacher calls a letter; kids point to the "Churches" wall or "Friends" wall.
3. **Number line-up:** Hand 13 kids a letter card each (shuffled). Class arranges them in order in under 60 seconds.
4. **What's missing?** Teacher says the 13 letters but skips one; first to name the missing one wins.
5. **Full chant challenge:** All 57 in under 75 seconds.

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Learn "Romans" and "Philemon" (first and last) plus the "Thirteen letters from Paul!" shout. Do the motions with older buddies.
- **Explorers:** Learn all 13 with the song; master the two tricky spellings (Philippians, Colossians).
- **Trailblazers:** Know all 57 in order and which letters were written from prison.
- **Ambassadors:** Lead the chant; quiz younger kids; explain the GEPC trick to them.

Spelling & Reading

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letter recognition & sound it out)

- First letters: **R** for Romans, **G** for Galatians (and Gift!), **J** for Joy, **L** for Love and Letter, **T** for Timothy and Titus.
- Sound it out: T-I-T-U-S ("Ti... tus") and J-O-Y.
- Trace **PAUL** and **LOVE** on the printable.

Explorers (book names)

- Romans, Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, Thessalonians, Timothy, Titus, Philemon

Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocab words)

- All 13 letters (with "First" and "Second" written as numbers: 1 Corinthians, 2 Corinthians...)
- Vocab: **grace** (a gift we don't earn), **faith** (trusting God), **epistle** (a letter in the Bible), **armor** (protection for battle), **rejoice** (to be full of joy and praise)

Ambassadors (book names + harder vocab with definitions)

- All 57 books so far
- **justification** — being declared "not guilty" and right with God through faith in Jesus
- **redemption** — being bought back / set free by a payment (Jesus' death)
- **reconciliation** — making peace between two who were enemies (us and God; Philemon and Onesimus)
- **sanctification** — the process of being made more like Jesus
- **contentment** — being satisfied in Christ whether you have a lot or a little

Syllable-clap method

Word	Claps
Ro-mans	2
Co-rin-thi-ans	4

Word	Claps
Ga-la-tians	3
E-phe-sians	3
Phi-lip-pi-ans	4
Co-los-sians	3
Thes-sa-lo-ni-ans	5 (the champion!)
Tim-o-thy	3
Ti-tus	2
Phi-le-mon	3

"Spell It Out" relay

Supplies: Letter cards in two colors (one set per team), two "mailbag" baskets, tape line.

1. Each team's mailbag holds the scrambled letters of a book name.
2. Teacher calls the book ("PHILIPPIANS!"). Runners take turns grabbing one letter at a time and building the word on the floor.
3. When finished, the whole team spells it aloud and does that book's motion.
4. Little Lambs: hunt for just the first letter. Ambassadors: build "THESSALONIANS" or "SANCTIFICATION."

Mini spelling bee word list

Word	Use it in a sentence
Paul	"Paul wrote thirteen letters in the Bible."
grace	"Grace is a gift we don't earn."
love	"Love is patient and kind."
joy	"Paul had joy even in prison."
Romans	"Romans says the gift of God is eternal life."
Titus	"Titus helped churches on the island of Crete."
Timothy	"Timothy learned the Scriptures from his grandmother and mother."
armor	"Put on the full armor of God."
Galatians	"Galatians tells about the fruit of the Spirit."
Ephesians	"Ephesians says we are saved by grace through faith."
Philippians	"Philippians tells us to rejoice in the Lord always."
Colossians	"Colossians says Jesus holds all things together."
Philemon	"Philemon was asked to welcome Onesimus as a brother."
Thessalonians	"Thessalonians teaches that Jesus is coming back."

Word	Use it in a sentence
justification	"Justification means God declares us right with Him through faith."

Read-aloud practice passage

> **1 Corinthians 13:4–8a (NIV):** "Love is patient, love is kind. It does not envy, it does not boast, it is not proud. It does not dishonor others, it is not self-seeking, it is not easily angered, it keeps no record of wrongs. Love does not delight in evil but rejoices with the truth. It always protects, always trusts, always hopes, always perseveres. Love never fails."
>
> *Little Lambs:* echo "Love is patient, love is kind" with hand motions (hands folded for patient; hug yourself for kind).

Word Trivia

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. Who wrote 13 letters in the Bible?
2. Fill in the blank: "It is the _____ of God." (Ephesians 2:8)
3. What is the "greatest" of faith, hope, and love?
4. True or False: Paul wrote some letters while he was in prison.
5. What did Paul tell the Philippians to do "always"? (Rejoice!)
6. What do we put on to stand strong: the armor of _____?
7. Fill in the blank: "Love is patient, love is _____."
8. True or False: We can earn God's love by being really, really good.
9. Who is coming back one day, according to Thessalonians?
10. What was the first letter of Paul's in the Bible?

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

11. What is the last of Paul's letters in the Bible order?
12. Which book? It talks about the "fruit of the Spirit."
13. Name three fruits of the Spirit.
14. Which book has the "love chapter"?
15. Who carried the letter of Romans to Rome?
16. Which book? "I can do all this through him who gives me strength."
17. Who were Timothy's grandmother and mother?
18. Fill in the blank: "The wages of sin is death, but the gift of God is _____ _____ in Christ Jesus our Lord." (Romans 6:23)
19. What is the "sword of the Spirit"?
20. Who ran away from Philemon?
21. Which book? "Don't let anyone look down on you because you are young."
22. What do the letters G-E-P-C stand for?

23. True or False: Paul's letters are in the Bible in the order he wrote them.
24. How many chapters does Philemon have?

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

25. Who said it? "I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith."
26. Who actually wrote down the words of Romans as Paul spoke them?
27. What did God tell Paul when he asked three times for his "thorn" to be removed?
28. Name all six pieces of the armor of God.
29. Which four letters are often called the "Prison Letters"?
30. Which three letters are called the "Pastoral Letters"?
31. Which book? "The Son is the image of the invisible God."
32. What does the name "Onesimus" mean?
33. Fill in the blank: "All Scripture is **-**." (2 Timothy 3:16)
34. Which book? "If anyone is in Christ, the new creation has come."
35. On what island was Titus serving?
36. Who brought gifts from Philippi to Paul and then got very sick?
37. In 1 Corinthians 15, how many people at one time did Jesus appear to after He rose?
38. True or False: Paul offered to pay whatever Onesimus owed.
39. Which letter did Paul write last, shortly before he died?
40. Which book? "Rejoice always, pray continually, give thanks in all circumstances."

Answer key

1. Paul. 2. gift. 3. Love (1 Corinthians 13:13). 4. True. 5. Rejoice in the Lord (Philippians 4:4). 6. God. 7. kind. 8. False — it's a free gift (Ephesians 2:8–9). 9. Jesus. 10. Romans.
2. Philemon. 12. Galatians (5:22–23). 13. Any three: love, joy, peace, forbearance (patience), kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control. 14. 1 Corinthians (ch. 13). 15. Phoebe (Romans 16:1–2). 16. Philippians (4:13). 17. Lois and Eunice (2 Timothy 1:5). 18. eternal life. 19. The word of God (Ephesians 6:17). 20. Onesimus. 21. 1 Timothy (4:12). 22. Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians ("General Electric Power Company"). 23. False — church letters are first, roughly longest to shortest, then letters to individuals. 24. One.
3. Paul (2 Timothy 4:7). 26. Tertius (Romans 16:22). 27. "My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness" (2 Corinthians 12:9). 28. Belt of truth, breastplate of righteousness, feet fitted with the readiness of the gospel of peace, shield of faith, helmet of salvation, sword of the Spirit. 29. Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, Philemon. 30. 1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, Titus. 31. Colossians (1:15). 32. "Useful." 33. God-breathed. 34. 2 Corinthians (5:17). 35. Crete (Titus 1:5). 36. Epaphroditus (Philippians 2:25–30). 37. More than 500 (15:6). 38. True (Philemon 18–19). 39. 2 Timothy. 40. 1 Thessalonians (5:16–18).

Games

🎮 1. Romans Road Race

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers (Little Lambs with buddies)

- **Supplies:** Four large "road signs" (3:23, 6:23, 5:8, 10:9) posted around the room, tape "road" lines, paper "cars" or just running feet
- **Setup:** Place signs in a loop. At each sign, a card says what the verse means in kid words.
- **How to play:** Teams race from sign to sign. At each sign, they must say the meaning ("Everyone sinned!") before running on. At the finish, they shout the memory verse.
- **How to win:** First team to complete the road and say Ephesians 2:8 together.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* just shout one word at each sign (Sin! Gift! Jesus! Believe!). *Older:* must quote each verse from memory.
- **Learning goal:** The gospel in four steps; grace.

🎮 2. Armor Up Relay

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Two sets of "armor": a belt (rope or old belt), a breastplate (paper grocery bag with arm holes), shoes (big adult slippers), a shield (paper plate or cardboard), a helmet (plastic bowl or hat), a sword (rolled-up newspaper or Bible). Labels on each.
- **Setup:** Armor piles at the far end of the room for each team.
- **How to play:** Runner 1 runs to the pile, puts on the belt, says "Belt of truth!" and runs back. Runner 2 grabs the breastplate, and so on, until one teammate is fully dressed. That "soldier" must then say Ephesians 6:11 ("Put on the full armor of God...") or just "I'm ready!"
- **How to win:** First fully armored soldier wins.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* teacher helps put armor on. *Older:* each runner must also name a real-life way to use that piece.
- **Learning goal:** The six pieces of God's armor (Ephesians 6).

🎮 3. Body Parts Scramble

- **Best for:** Little Lambs & Explorers
- **Supplies:** None (or cards with body parts drawn on them)
- **How to play:** Teacher calls out two body parts: "Elbow to knee!" Kids find a partner and touch those parts together. When the teacher shouts "ONE BODY!" everyone joins in one giant group hug/huddle and shouts, "We are the body of Christ!" Then the teacher calls a Paul letter, and kids shout the next one.
- **How to win:** Everyone wins when the whole class is one body!
- **Adaptations:** *Older:* add "Name a spiritual gift!" challenges.
- **Learning goal:** 1 Corinthians 12 — we need each other.

🎮 4. Joy Jump

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Open space, a list of situations
- **How to play:** Teacher reads a situation. If it's a *happy* situation, kids jump and shout "Rejoice!" If it's a *hard* situation, kids crouch — then the teacher says "But Jesus is still with me!" and everyone springs up and shouts "Rejoice ANYWAY!" Between rounds, call a Paul letter; kids answer "Church!" or "Friend!"
- **How to win:** This is a cooperative game; the goal is for everyone to jump together.

- **Adaptations:** *Older:* kids must say a verse from Philippians after each "Rejoice anyway!"
- **Learning goal:** Joy in every circumstance (Philippians 4:4; 1 Thessalonians 5:16–18).

🎮 5. Mail Carrier Dash

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors
- **Supplies:** 13 envelopes, each labeled with one letter of Paul (Romans → Philemon), 9 "church" mailboxes (shoeboxes labeled Rome, Corinth, Corinth, Galatia, Ephesus, Philippi, Colossae, Thessalonica, Thessalonica) and 4 "friend" mailboxes (Timothy, Timothy, Titus, Philemon)
- **Setup:** Spread mailboxes around the room. Put envelopes in a central "post office."
- **How to play:** Teams of mail carriers race to deliver each envelope to the correct mailbox. Then they must line up all 13 envelopes in Bible order.
- **How to win:** Fastest correct delivery + correct order.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* only deliver 4 (Romans, Ephesians, Philippians, Philemon) with picture clues. *Older:* add a third step — say one key verse from each letter.
- **Learning goal:** Who each letter was written to; order of the books.

🎮 6. Letter Sort Showdown (Review Sunday)

- **Best for:** Mixed-age teams
- **Supplies:** Two sets of all 57 book cards, color-coded by section
- **How to play:** Teams race to put all 57 books (or just the New Testament 18 for younger teams) in order. Midway, the teacher shouts "Section Shout!" and teams must stop and do the Section Shout for a section they've completed.
- **How to win:** First complete and correct line wins; bonus points for each correct "In one word" given for a Paul letter.
- **Learning goal:** Cumulative review.

Coloring Pages

🖍️ **Coloring page 1 — Paul Writes a Letter (Week 1)** *Scene:* Paul sitting by an oil lamp speaking, while his helper Tertius writes on a long scroll with a feather pen; Phoebe standing in the doorway with a traveling bag, ready to carry it. *Caption:* "The gift of God is eternal life in Christ Jesus our Lord." — Romans 6:23 *Coloring conversation:* What gift has God given you? Who could you send a kind letter to?

🖍️ **Coloring page 2 — Fruit of the Spirit Tree (Week 1)** *Scene:* A big tree with nine fruits, each labeled: love, joy, peace, forbearance, kindness, goodness, faithfulness, gentleness, self-control. *Caption:* "The fruit of the Spirit is love, joy, peace..." — Galatians 5:22 *Coloring conversation:* Which fruit do you want God to grow in you this week?

🖍️ **Coloring page 3 — The Armor of God (Week 2)** *Scene:* A kid dressed in Roman armor, each piece labeled (belt of truth, breastplate of righteousness, shoes of peace, shield of faith, helmet of salvation, sword of the Spirit). *Caption:* "Put on the full armor of God." — Ephesians 6:11 *Coloring conversation:* Which piece do you need most today?

🖍️ **Coloring page 4 — Joy in Chains (Week 3)** *Scene:* Paul smiling as he writes, with a chain on his wrist connected to a Roman guard; big letters "REJOICE!" floating above. *Caption:* "Rejoice in the Lord always." — Philippians 4:4 *Coloring conversation:* Why was Paul happy even in chains? What makes you joyful?

🖍️ **Coloring page 5 — Welcome Home, Brother (Week 4)** *Scene:* Philemon hugging Onesimus at the door of his house, a letter in Philemon's hand; church members smiling in the background. *Caption:* "... no longer as a slave, but... as a dear brother." — Philemon 16 *Coloring conversation:* Is there anyone you need to forgive? How does Jesus forgive us?

🖍️ **Coloring page 6 — Book Name Page: 13 Envelopes** *Design:* Thirteen envelopes arranged like a staircase, each with a book name in bubble letters (Romans → Philemon) and a tiny symbol (road, heart, muscle, fruit, helmet, smile, crown, cloud, hammer, thumbs-up, open book, blocks, handshake). *Caption:* "Thirteen Letters from Paul — Books 45–57!"

> **Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-11-printables.html`**

Activities & Crafts

✂️ 1. Gift Box Verse Craft (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Small square cards, wrapping paper scraps, ribbon, glue, markers; a folded "box" template (cube net) for older kids
- **Steps:** 1) Fold or glue a paper "present" with a flap that opens. 2) Under the flap write "It is the gift of God" (Ephesians 2:8) or "Jesus." 3) Decorate with ribbon.
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* flap card with a cross sticker inside. *Explorers:* write the verse. *Older:* write the four Romans Road verses on the four sides of a cube.
- **What it teaches:** Grace is a free gift.

✂️ 2. Armor of God Paper Suit (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Large paper grocery bags (breastplate), paper plates (shields), sentence strips (belts and helmets), aluminum foil, markers, tape
- **Steps:** Make each piece, label it, and "suit up." Take a class photo of your "army of God."
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* make just the shield and helmet. *Explorers:* all six pieces. *Older:* write a matching verse or real-life use on the back of each piece.
- **What it teaches:** Ephesians 6:10–18.

✂️ 3. Joy Jar (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Small plastic jars or cups, colored paper strips, stickers, markers
- **Steps:** 1) Decorate the jar with "Rejoice!" 2) Write or draw things that give you joy, plus one hard thing where you can still trust Jesus. 3) Take it home and add a strip each day.

- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* draw pictures. *Older:* add a Bible verse strip each day from Philippians.
- **What it teaches:** Philippians 4:4; 1 Thessalonians 5:16–18.

✂️ 4. Write-a-Letter Station (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Stationery, envelopes, stickers, pens, wax-seal stickers (red)
- **Steps:** Kids write a "Paul-style" letter: 1) Greeting ("Grace and peace to you..."), 2) Thanks ("I thank God for you because..."), 3) Encouragement (a verse), 4) Goodbye ("The grace of the Lord Jesus be with you"). Send to a missionary, a shut-in church member, a grandparent, or a friend.
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* draw a picture and dictate one sentence to a helper. *Ambassadors:* write to a younger kid in the class.
- **What it teaches:** Paul's letter format; encouraging others.

✂️ 5. Fruit of the Spirit Bracelet

- **Supplies:** Pipe cleaners or elastic cord, beads in 9 colors (one per fruit), color key card
- **Steps:** String nine beads; as each is added, name the fruit and a way to show it.
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* big beads, 3 fruits (love, joy, peace). *Older:* all nine with a memory challenge.
- **What it teaches:** Galatians 5:22–23.

✂️ 6. Paul's Letter Map

- **Supplies:** Map from Phase 10, 13 tiny envelope stickers, string
- **Steps:** Stick an envelope on each city that got a letter; draw a line from Rome (where Paul was in prison) to the cities that got prison letters.
- **What it teaches:** Real letters to real places; connects Acts and the letters.

Word Puzzles

Word scramble

1. SAMNOR
2. CEGAR
3. YJO
4. ALPU
5. RRAOM
6. TFHIA
7. MHTOTYI
8. TSITU
9. RTTLEE
10. OMNIESSU
11. VLOE
12. TIRFU
13. CEJOIER
14. NAESPHIES

15. MLEOPHNI

Answer key: 1. ROMANS 2. GRACE 3. JOY 4. PAUL 5. ARMOR 6. FAITH 7. TIMOTHY 8. TITUS 9. LETTER 10. ONESIMUS 11. LOVE 12. FRUIT 13. REJOICE 14. EPHESIANS 15. PHILEMON

Fill-in-the-blank story

Word bank: letters, grace, gift, love, armor, joy, chains, coming back, Timothy, young, Onesimus, brother

> Paul wrote thirteen _____ in the Bible. He said we are saved by _____, which is a free _____ from God. To the church in Corinth, he wrote that the greatest thing is _____. To the Ephesians, he said to put on the _____ of God. Even in _____, Paul was full of _____. He told the Thessalonians that Jesus is _____ _____. He told his friend _____ not to let anyone look down on him because he was _____. And he asked Philemon to welcome _____ back as a dear _____.

Answers: letters, grace, gift, love, armor, chains, joy, coming back, Timothy, young, Onesimus, brother

Match the book to its picture / summary

Book	Picture / Summary
1. Romans	A. 🍎 The fruit of the Spirit
2. 1 Corinthians	B. 🤝 A runaway welcomed home
3. Galatians	C. 🛣️ The road to salvation — God's free gift
4. Ephesians	D. 👑 Jesus is over everything
5. Philippians	E. ❤️ "Love is patient, love is kind"
6. Colossians	F. ⛑️ The armor of God
7. 1 Thessalonians	G. 😄 Rejoice, even in chains
8. 1 Timothy	H. ☁️ Jesus is coming back
9. 2 Timothy	I. 👍 Be an example even when young
10. Philemon	J. 📖 "All Scripture is God-breathed"

Answers: 1-C, 2-E, 3-A, 4-F, 5-G, 6-D, 7-H, 8-I, 9-J, 10-B

Questions for Every Age

Little Lambs (ages 4–6)

1. What is the best gift God ever gave? (Jesus!)

2. How can you be kind this week?
3. What makes you joyful?
4. Who can you say "I forgive you" or "I'm sorry" to?
5. Who can you draw a picture or "letter" for to show God's love?

Explorers (ages 7–10)

1. How would you explain "grace" in your own words?
2. Which fruit of the Spirit do you see in your mom, dad, or a friend?
3. Which piece of God's armor would help you at school?
4. How can you have joy on a bad day?
5. How can you set an example for younger kids?

Trailblazers (ages 11–13)

1. Why is it hard to accept a gift we didn't earn?
2. Where do you see "Corinth problems" (arguing, pride, cliques) in your world?
3. What worries can you turn into prayers this week (Philippians 4:6)?
4. How does knowing Jesus "holds all things together" help when life feels like it's falling apart?
5. What would it look like to "finish the race" of faith well?

Ambassadors (ages 14–17)

1. If salvation is by grace, why does the way we live still matter?
2. How should 1 Corinthians 12 shape the way you see people with different gifts or personalities?
3. Where do you find your contentment — and is it in Christ or in circumstances?
4. Who is an "Onesimus" in your life — someone you need to welcome or forgive?
5. Who is your "Timothy" (someone younger you can mentor) and who is your "Paul" (someone older who mentors you)?

🧠 Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics & worldview)

1. **"Didn't Paul invent Christianity and change Jesus' simple message?"** *Suggested answer:* Paul consistently points back to what he *received* from others (1 Corinthians 15:3 — "what I received I passed on to you"), including the early creed about Jesus' death, burial, resurrection, and appearances. Paul met with Peter and James (Galatians 1:18–19; 2:9), who agreed with his message. Jesus Himself taught grace (Luke 18:9–14), His death as a ransom (Mark 10:45), and the inclusion of the nations (Matthew 28:19). Paul explains Jesus — he doesn't replace Him.
2. **"If we're saved by grace and not by works, doesn't that let people do whatever they want?"** *Suggested answer:* Paul anticipated this objection: "Shall we go on sinning so that grace may increase? By no means!" (Romans 6:1–2). Grace doesn't just forgive; it transforms (Titus 2:11–12). A person who truly receives grace is given a new heart and the Holy Spirit (Ephesians 2:10; Galatians 5:22–25). Good works are the fruit of salvation, not the root.
3. **"Why didn't Paul just say slavery was wrong?"** *Suggested answer:* Paul wrote to small, powerless house churches inside an empire where slavery was everywhere, and a call to violent revolt would likely have ended in mass executions. But Paul planted truths that undermine slavery: he condemned "slave traders" (1 Timothy 1:10), taught that in Christ "there is neither

slave nor free" (Galatians 3:28), encouraged slaves to gain freedom if they could (1 Corinthians 7:21), told masters they too have a Master in heaven and must treat slaves justly (Colossians 4:1), and asked Philemon to receive Onesimus "no longer as a slave... but as a dear brother" (Philemon 16). Those seeds grew — many Christian abolitionists like William Wilberforce and Frederick Douglass appealed to the Bible's teaching that every person bears God's image. It's honest to admit that some people have twisted the Bible to defend slavery; the Bible's own story points toward freedom and dignity.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration

Review game plan (last Sunday)

Time	Activity
10 min	Welcome + Paul's Letters Song + full Cumulative Chant (57 books)
15 min	🎮 Letter Sort Showdown (mixed-age teams)
10 min	Favorite video replay + "Which letter was it from?" quiz
15 min	Oral check-off stations (Ambassadors help)
15 min	Write-a-Letter Station finish + "Mail Call" (deliver letters to each other)
10 min	Sealed Scroll badge ceremony, Bible Passport stamps, prayer

Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs

- [ ] Says "It is the gift of God."
- [ ] Says the section name: "Paul's Letters!" and "Thirteen letters from Paul!"
- [ ] Names 3 of Paul's letters (e.g., Romans, Titus, Philemon) with motions
- [ ] Tells one thing Paul wrote (love, joy, armor, forgive...)

Explorers

- [ ] Says Ephesians 2:8
- [ ] Says all 13 of Paul's letters in order
- [ ] Spells all 13 (Philippians and Colossians count double!)
- [ ] Sorts them into "churches" and "friends"

Trailblazers

- [ ] Says Ephesians 2:8–9 from memory
- [ ] Says all 57 books in order (two "helps" allowed)
- [ ] Gives the "one word" for each of Paul's letters
- [ ] Names the prison letters and pastoral letters

Ambassadors

- [ ] Says Ephesians 2:8–10 and explains grace vs. works
- [ ] Says all 57 books in order with no help
- [ ] Teaches one Paul letter (summary, key verse, motion) to a younger kid
- [ ] Explains the Romans Road in their own words

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp: a **blue envelope with a red wax seal** and the words "PAUL'S LETTERS — 13 — BOOKS 45–57."

🏅 Badge description — The Sealed Scroll

A royal-blue badge showing a rolled scroll tied with a red ribbon and a white quill pen crossing it. Around the edge: "LETTERS FROM PAUL · SAVED BY GRACE · 57 of 66."

📜 Certificate wording

> **Purpose Church Sunday School Bible Explorer Certificate — Phase 11: Letters from Paul**
>
> This certifies that _____ has learned the **thirteen letters of Paul** — Romans through Philemon — and can say the books of the Bible from **Genesis to Philemon — 57 of 66!**
>
> "For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith—and this is not from yourselves, it is the gift of God." — Ephesians 2:8
>
> Awarded the **Sealed Scroll Badge** on _____ (date).
>
> Teacher: _____

Take-Home Family Page

Dear Parents and Families,

This month your child learned the **13 letters Paul wrote** to churches and friends — Romans through Philemon. We talked about grace (God's free gift), love (1 Corinthians 13), the armor of God (Ephesians 6), joy even in hard times (Philippians), Jesus' return (Thessalonians), and forgiveness (Philemon). Your child now knows **57 of the 66 books** of the Bible — only 9 to go!

This month's verse: "For it is by grace you have been saved, through faith—and this is not from yourselves, it is the gift of God." — Ephesians 2:8 **Little Lambs:** "It is the gift of God."

🎵 **This month's song** (tune: *"Old MacDonald Had a Farm"*):

> Paul wrote letters to the church, thirteen letters — WHOA! Romans, First and Second Corinthians, thirteen letters — WHOA! Galatians here, Ephesians there, Philippians, Colossians — everywhere! First and Second Thessalonians, thirteen letters — WHOA! *(Verse 2: Paul wrote letters to his friends… First and Second Timothy… Titus here and Philemon there!)*

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions**

1. What is grace? Can you think of a time someone gave you something you didn't earn?
2. Which piece of the armor of God do you need most this week?
3. How can our family "rejoice always," even on hard days?

🏠 **Family activity — "A Letter Like Paul's"** As a family, write a letter of encouragement to someone — a grandparent, missionary, teacher, neighbor, or someone who's sick. Use Paul's pattern: greeting ("Grace and peace to you!"), thanks, a Bible verse, and a blessing. Mail it or deliver it together!

📺 **Videos to watch at home** (search on YouTube; parents, please preview):

- **@SharefaithKids** — search "armor of God" or "fruit of the Spirit": https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=armor+of+God
- **@BibleJourneyTV** — search "Paul": https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Paul
- **@bibleproject** — "Overview: Romans," "Overview: Ephesians," "Overview: Philippians" (best for ages 11+): https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Philippians

Next month: "Faith, Hope & Forever" — the last 9 books, a whole-Bible review, the Bible Bowl, and Graduation Sunday!

Phase 12: Faith, Hope & Forever

The last nine books, then a celebration: we review all 66 books, hold the Bible Bowl, and finish the year with Graduation Sunday. Jesus wins, and God's story goes on forever!

At a Glance	
Month	Month 12
Books covered	Hebrews, James, 1 Peter, 2 Peter, 1 John, 2 John, 3 John, Jude, Revelation (9 books)
Bible section(s)	General Letters (8) and Prophecy–Revelation (1)
Big Idea	Jesus is better than everything. Real faith shows in how we live, and one day Jesus will make everything new.
Memory Verse (all ages)	"Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever." — Hebrews 13:8 (NIV)
Little Lambs verse	"Jesus Christ is the same… forever." — Hebrews 13:8
Year verse (optional, for the whole-Bible review)	"All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness." — 2 Timothy 3:16 (NIV)
Theme color	Crown Gold (with a sky-blue accent for the "new heaven and new earth")
Phase symbol / badge	👑 The Forever Crown badge, plus the year-end **Whole Bible Champion** medal
Running total of books learned	**66 of 66. The whole Bible!**

Cross-links: Program Overview · Teacher Training Guide · Books of the Bible Memory System · Game Library · YouTube Video Guide · Phase 12 Printables

Planning note: This month has more in it than usual. Weeks 1–4 teach the last nine books. The **Whole-Bible Review Plan** runs alongside them, in the 10-minute Welcome & Book Chant slot every week. The **Bible Bowl** and **Graduation Sunday** happen on Week 5, or on a special Sunday you choose. Everything for the review, the Bowl and Graduation is in the section **End-of-Phase Review & Celebration**.

The Big Idea (in kid words)

We made it to the end of the Bible! The last letters were written by Jesus' friends and family: Peter, John, James, Jude, and the writer of Hebrews. They say: **Jesus is the best**, so keep trusting Him. **Real faith shows** in how we act and talk. **God is love**, so love one another. Then the very last book,

Revelation, shows us the ending of God's big story. **Jesus wins!** He will wipe away every tear and make everything new, and His people will live with Him forever.

How this points to Jesus: Hebrews says Jesus is better than angels, better than Moses, and better than every priest and sacrifice (Hebrews 1–10). Revelation shows Jesus as the Lamb who was slain and the Lion who has won (Revelation 5:5–6). The Bible starts in a garden with the tree of life (Genesis 2), and it ends in a garden-city with the tree of life (Revelation 22). Jesus brings us back home. He is "the Alpha and the Omega, the First and the Last, the Beginning and the End" (Revelation 22:13).

The Books in Easy Words

> **Big tip for remembering:** The **General Letters** are mostly named after **who wrote them** (James, Peter, John, Jude). Paul's letters were named after **who received them**. The one exception is **Hebrews**, which is named after its readers (Hebrew/Jewish Christians). Count them on your fingers: **1** Hebrews, **2** James, **3–4** Peter, **5–7** John, **8** Jude. Then comes **Revelation**, the grand finale!

58. Hebrews

How to say it	HEE-brooz
How to spell it	He-brews — H-E-B-R-E-W-S
Section	General Letters
Author	Unknown! The letter doesn't say. People have guessed Paul, Barnabas, Apollos, and others. God knows, and that's enough. Probably written before AD 70.
Kid summary	Jesus is better than everything and everyone, so don't give up. Keep trusting Him like the heroes of faith did.
In one word	**Better**
Key people	Jesus (our great High Priest), Melchizedek, Moses, and the "Faith Hall of Fame" (ch. 11): Abel, Enoch, Noah, Abraham, Sarah, Isaac, Jacob, Joseph, Moses, Rahab, Gideon, Samson, David, Samuel, and more
Key passages	Jesus is "the radiance of God's glory" (1:3); "the word of God is alive and active" (4:12); we can "approach God's throne of grace with confidence" (4:16); "faith is confidence in what we hope for and assurance about what we do not see" (11:1); "without faith it is impossible to please God" (11:6); "let us run with perseverance the race marked out for us, fixing our eyes on Jesus" (12:1–2); "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever" (13:8)
Where Jesus shows up	Everywhere! Jesus is the Son over God's house, the perfect High Priest, and the once-for-all sacrifice (7:27; 10:10–14).

Hand motion	🏆 Thumbs up, then move it higher, and higher again: "Good, better, BEST — Jesus!"

59. James

How to say it	JAYMZ
How to spell it	James — J-A-M-E-S
Section	General Letters
Author	James, the brother of Jesus. He didn't believe in Jesus at first (John 7:5). Then he met the risen Jesus (1 Corinthians 15:7) and became a leader of the Jerusalem church (Acts 15; Galatians 1:19). Probably one of the earliest New Testament books (about AD 45–49).
Kid summary	If you really trust Jesus, it will show in what you do and how you talk.
In one word	**Do** (faith that works!)
Key people	James. He also mentions Abraham, Rahab, Job and Elijah as examples.
Key passages	"If any of you lacks wisdom, you should ask God" (1:5); "Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak and slow to become angry" (1:19); "Do not merely listen to the word... Do what it says" (1:22); "faith by itself, if it is not accompanied by action, is dead" (2:17); the tongue is like a small rudder that steers a big ship, or a small spark that sets a forest on fire (3:3–6); "Come near to God and he will come near to you" (4:8)
Where Jesus shows up	James calls himself "a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ" (1:1). He echoes Jesus' Sermon on the Mount many times, and he waits for "the Lord's coming" (5:7–8).
Hand motion	🛠️ Zip your lips (careful words), then roll up your sleeves (faith that works).

60. 1 Peter

How to say it	FIRST PEE-ter
How to spell it	Pe-ter — P-E-T-E-R
Section	General Letters
Author	The apostle Peter, written with help from Silas (5:12). Probably from Rome, which he calls "Babylon" (5:13), about AD 62–64.
Kid summary	When life is hard because you follow Jesus, keep your hope in Him. He cares for you.
In one word	**Hope**
Key people	Peter, Silas, Mark (5:13)

Key passages	God gave us "new birth into a living hope through the resurrection of Jesus Christ" (1:3); "you also, like living stones, are being built into a spiritual house" (2:5); "Always be prepared to give an answer... for the hope that you have" (3:15); "Cast all your anxiety on him because he cares for you" (5:7); the devil prowls "like a roaring lion" (5:8)
Where Jesus shows up	"He himself bore our sins in his body on the cross... by his wounds you have been healed" (2:24, quoting Isaiah 53).
Hand motion	🪨 Hold up 1 finger, make a fist ("rock," since Peter's name means rock), then toss your worries up to God with both hands.

61. 2 Peter

How to say it	SEK-und PEE-ter
How to spell it	Pe-ter — P-E-T-E-R
Section	General Letters
Author	The apostle Peter, near the end of his life (1:14), about AD 64–68
Kid summary	Keep growing in Jesus, don't believe false teachers, and remember that God always keeps His promises. He is patient because He wants everyone to come to Him.
In one word	**Grow**
Key people	Peter. He mentions Paul ("our dear brother," 3:15), Noah and Lot.
Key passages	Peter was an eyewitness of Jesus' glory on the mountain (1:16–18); "With the Lord a day is like a thousand years" (3:8); "He is patient with you, not wanting anyone to perish, but everyone to come to repentance" (3:9); "grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ" (3:18)
Where Jesus shows up	Peter heard God say, "This is my Son, whom I love" (1:17). Jesus is coming back as He promised (3:10–13).
Hand motion	🌱 Hold up 2 fingers, then crouch and "grow" up tall like a plant.

62. 1 John

How to say it	FIRST JAHN
How to spell it	John — J-O-H-N (silent **H**!)
Section	General Letters
Author	The apostle John, "the disciple whom Jesus loved." He wrote it as an older man, about AD 85–95.
Kid summary	God is love. When we trust Jesus, God forgives us, we become His children, and we love one another.
In one word	**Love**
Key people	John, who calls his readers "dear children"

Key passages	"If we confess our sins, he is faithful and just and will forgive us our sins" (1:9); "See what great love the Father has lavished on us, that we should be called children of God!" (3:1); "God is love" (4:8); "We love because he first loved us" (4:19); "I write these things to you... so that you may know that you have eternal life" (5:13)
Where Jesus shows up	John touched and saw Jesus, "the Word of life" (1:1). Jesus is "the atoning sacrifice for our sins" (2:2).
Hand motion	🤗 Hold up 1 finger, then give yourself a big hug: "God is love!"

63. 2 John

How to say it	SEK-und JAHN
How to spell it	John — J-O-H-N
Section	General Letters
Author	John, who calls himself "the elder." It has 13 verses, the fewest verses of any book in the Bible.
Kid summary	A short note to a church family (called "the lady chosen by God and her children"): keep walking in truth and love, and watch out for false teachers.
In one word	**Truth**
Key people	John, "the lady chosen by God," and her children
Key passages	"This is love: that we walk in obedience to his commands" (v. 6)
Where Jesus shows up	John warns about people who deny that "Jesus Christ [came] in the flesh" (v. 7). Jesus really became human.
Hand motion	🚶 Hold up 2 fingers, then march in place: "Walk in truth!"

64. 3 John

How to say it	THURD JAHN
How to spell it	John — J-O-H-N
Section	General Letters
Author	John, "the elder." In the original Greek it is the shortest book in the Bible by word count.
Kid summary	John thanks his friend Gaius for welcoming and helping Christian travelers, warns about a bossy man named Diotrephes, and praises a good man named Demetrius.
In one word	**Welcome**
Key people	Gaius (good host), Diotrephes (wanted to be first), Demetrius (good example)
Key passages	"I have no greater joy than to hear that my children are walking in the truth" (v. 4); "Do not imitate what is evil but what is good" (v. 11)
Where Jesus shows up	The travelers went out "for the sake of the Name," meaning Jesus' name (v. 7).
Hand motion	👋 Hold up 3 fingers, then wave a big "Welcome!"

65. Jude

How to say it	JOOD
How to spell it	Jude — J-U-D-E
Section	General Letters
Author	Jude, "a brother of James" (v. 1), which makes him another brother of Jesus. About AD 65–80. Only 25 verses.
Kid summary	Stand strong for the true message about Jesus, and remember that God is able to keep you from falling.
In one word	**Stand** (or **Keep**)
Key people	Jude. He mentions Michael the archangel, Enoch, Cain, Balaam and Korah as examples.
Key passages	"Contend for the faith that was once for all entrusted to God's holy people" (v. 3); "To him who is able to keep you from stumbling and to present you before his glorious presence without fault and with great joy" (v. 24)
Where Jesus shows up	"Our only Sovereign and Lord, Jesus Christ" (v. 4). Jesus keeps us (v. 1) and brings us to eternal life (v. 21).
Hand motion	🛡️ Pretend to trip, then catch yourself with both arms out: "God keeps me from falling!"

66. Revelation

How to say it	rev-uh-LAY-shun (it's **Revelation**, with no "s" on the end!)
How to spell it	Rev-e-la-tion — R-E-V-E-L-A-T-I-O-N
Section	Prophecy–Revelation (the only book in this section)
Author	The apostle John, while he was exiled on the island of Patmos (1:9), about AD 95
Kid summary	Jesus shows John amazing visions: Jesus is alive and in charge, evil will be defeated, and God will make a new heaven and a new earth where His people live with Him forever.
In one word	**Wins!** (or **New**)
Key people	Jesus (the Lamb, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the King of kings), John, angels, the seven churches
Key passages	Jesus: "I am the First and the Last. I am the Living One; I was dead, and now look, I am alive for ever and ever!" (1:17–18); letters to seven churches: Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum, Thyatira, Sardis, Philadelphia, Laodicea (ch. 2–3); "Here I am! I stand at the door and knock" (3:20); the throne room and the Lamb (ch. 4–5); "He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain" (21:4); "I am making everything new!" (21:5); the river of life and the tree of life (22:1–2); "Come, Lord Jesus" (22:20)
Where Jesus shows up	Jesus is the main character of Revelation. The first verse calls it "The revelation from Jesus Christ." He is "KING OF KINGS AND LORD OF LORDS" (19:16).

Hand motion	🎺 Blow a trumpet, then throw both arms up in victory: "JESUS WINS!"

Teacher Preparation

Background for the teacher

The **General Letters** (also called the "Catholic" Epistles, where *catholic* simply means "universal") were written to wider audiences than Paul's letters. They come from Jesus' inner circle: two of His brothers (James and Jude), and two of the Twelve (Peter and John). Hebrews stands at the front because it is the longest, and it's a sermon-like letter to Jewish Christians who were tempted to give up following Jesus and go back to the old system of temple and sacrifices. Its message is "Don't go back. Jesus is better."

Revelation belongs to a type of writing called *apocalyptic*. The Greek word *apokalypsis* means "unveiling" or "revealing." It is full of symbols (lampstands, beasts, numbers, colors). Its first readers were persecuted churches under the Roman Empire, so it was meant to **encourage**, not to frighten. The big message is clear even when the details are hard: Jesus has already won through His death and resurrection, evil will be completely defeated, and God will live with His people in a renewed creation. Christians who love the Bible hold different views on the timing and details of the end times. In kids' ministry, focus on what all Christians agree on: **Jesus is coming back, Jesus wins, and God makes all things new.**

Key truths to emphasize

1. **Jesus is better and enough.** We don't need anything else to be right with God (Hebrews 10:10–14).
2. **Real faith shows itself** in obedience, kindness, and careful words (James 2:17; 3:1–12).
3. **Suffering is not the end.** We have a living hope (1 Peter 1:3–7).
4. **God is love,** and His love makes us His children (1 John 3:1; 4:8–19).
5. **God keeps His people** and keeps His promises (2 Peter 3:9; Jude 24).
6. **Jesus wins and makes everything new** (Revelation 21:1–5).
7. **The whole Bible is one story** that leads to Jesus (Luke 24:27).

Timeline notes

- **~AD 45–49:** James (possibly the earliest NT book)
- **~AD 62–68:** 1 & 2 Peter; Hebrews (before the temple was destroyed in AD 70)
- **~AD 65–80:** Jude
- **~AD 85–95:** 1, 2, 3 John
- **~AD 95:** Revelation, written on Patmos (a small island off the coast of modern Turkey)

Map tip: The seven churches of Revelation 2–3 are all in the Roman province of Asia (western Turkey), arranged roughly in a loop, like a mail route. Ephesus is the first one, the same city where Paul spent three years (Acts 19–20).

Handling sensitive content by age

Topic	Little Lambs (4–6)	Explorers (7–10)	Trailblazers & Ambassadors (11–17)
Revelation's beasts, dragon, plagues	Skip the scary pictures. Focus on Jesus on His throne, the rainbow, the new home, and "no more tears."	"Revelation uses picture-language, like a dream full of symbols. Some pictures show how bad evil is, but the dragon *loses* and Jesus *wins*."	Teach the apocalyptic genre and its symbols (7 = completeness; the Lamb = Jesus). Mention that Christians hold different views on the details, and say so respectfully.
Death and heaven	"People who love Jesus go to be with Him. One day God will make a new world with no more ouchies or crying."	Let kids share about people they miss. Point them to Revelation 21:4.	Talk about grief and hope. The final hope is not just "floating in heaven" but resurrection and a new creation (1 Corinthians 15; Revelation 21).
Judgment / hell	Not a focus. "God will make everything right."	"God is fair. He will stop all evil. Anyone who trusts Jesus is safe."	Discuss honestly: God's justice is good news for victims of evil, and His patience gives everyone time to turn to Him (2 Peter 3:9).
Persecution (1 Peter, Hebrews 11:35–38)	"Some people were mean to Christians, but God was with them."	Tell plainly; highlight courage.	Discuss Christians persecuted today and how to pray for them.

Common kid questions (with simple answers)

- **"When is Jesus coming back?"** We don't know! Jesus said no one knows the day or hour (Matthew 24:36). So we live ready, loving God and others every day.
- **"Will heaven be boring?"** No! Revelation shows worship, celebration, a city full of light, a river, the tree of life, and God's people serving Him and reigning with Him (Revelation 22:3–5). Everything good we enjoy here comes from God. The new creation will be even better.
- **"Will my pet be in heaven?"** The Bible doesn't tell us directly. We do know God loves His creation. His new creation will be full of good things, and we can trust Him to make it perfect.
- **"Is Revelation scary?"** Some parts use scary pictures to show how bad evil is. But the ending is the happiest ending ever: Jesus wins, and there are no more tears.
- **"Does James say we're saved by being good?"** No. James says real faith *shows* by what we do, the way a living tree shows it's alive by growing fruit. We're saved by grace through faith (Ephesians 2:8). Good works are the *evidence* of that faith.
- **"Who wrote Hebrews?"** Nobody knows for sure, and that's okay! The church has always recognized it as God's Word because it teaches the truth about Jesus.
- **"Are we done with the Bible now?"** We've learned the names of all 66 books, but there's a lifetime of treasure to discover in them. Keep reading!

Month at a Glance

Week	Passage	Lesson Title	Key Point	Video	Game	Activity
1	Hebrews 1:1–4; 4:14–16; 11; 12:1–2; 13:8	Jesus Is Better & the Faith Hall of Fame	Jesus is better than everything, so keep running your race of faith.	📺 "Overview: Hebrews" (BibleProject); Sharefaith Kids "faith"; Bible Journey "heroes of faith"	🎮 Faith Hall of Fame Relay	Hall of Fame Trophy Craft
2	James 1:19–22; 2:14–26; 3:3–12; 1 Peter 5:7; 2 Peter 3:8–9, 18	Faith That Works, Hope That Holds	Real faith shows in actions and words, and God cares for us when life is hard.	📺 "Overview: James," "Overview: 1 Peter," "Overview: 2 Peter"	🎮 Tongue Twister Tag / Spark Pass	Ship & Rudder Craft
3	1 John 1:9; 3:1; 4:7–19; 2 John 6; 3 John 4, 11; Jude 24–25	God Is Love, Walk in Truth	God loves us like His own children, and He keeps us from falling.	📺 "Overview: 1–3 John," "Overview: Jude"	🎮 Love Chain Tag	"Children of God" Family Portrait
4	Revelation 1:9–18; 4–5; 21:1–5; 22:1–5, 20	Jesus Wins!	Jesus is King. One day He will make everything new.	📺 "Overview: Revelation 1–11," "Overview: Revelation 12–22"	🎮 Seven Churches Mail Route	New Creation Window
5	All 66 books	Bible Bowl & Graduation Sunday	We learned the whole Bible, and the story leads to Jesus!	Highlight reel of the year's favorite clips	🎮 The Bible Bowl	Graduation, certificates & celebration

Weekly Lessons

Week 1: Jesus Is Better & the Faith Hall of Fame (Hebrews)

Scripture: Hebrews 1:1–4; 4:14–16; 11:1–40; 12:1–2; 13:8 **Lesson goal:** Kids will learn that Jesus is better than anyone or anything, and that God's people have always lived by faith, trusting Him even before they could see His promises come true.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Good, Better, Best" *Supplies:* three items that get "better," for example a candle (or flashlight), a lamp, and a photo of the sun. Or a paper airplane, a toy plane, and a picture of a real jet.

1. Show the candle: "This gives light. Good!" Show the lamp: "Better!" Show the picture of the sun: "BEST!"
2. Say: "God gave His people good things: prophets, angels, Moses, priests. But then God sent the BEST: His Son, Jesus! Hebrews says Jesus is better than all of them."

Story script (read aloud):

Long ago, a group of Christians had a hard choice. They were Jewish people who believed in Jesus, but life was getting tough. Some of their neighbors were mean to them. Some of them had lost their homes and belongings. A few started thinking, "Maybe we should stop following Jesus and go back to the old ways."

So someone wrote them a letter. We don't even know who wrote it! But the message was clear: **"Don't give up. Jesus is better!"**

"Long ago, God spoke through prophets," the letter said. "But now He has spoken to us through His Son. Jesus is the shining brightness of God's glory. He made the whole universe, and He holds it all together by His powerful word!"

"Jesus is better than the angels, because angels worship Him. Jesus is better than Moses, because Moses was a servant in God's house, but Jesus is the Son. Jesus is better than the priests, because they had to offer sacrifices again and again, but Jesus offered Himself once, and that was enough, forever!"

Then the letter said, "Do you need courage? Remember the heroes of faith!" And it told about them, one after another, like walking through a Hall of Fame.

"By faith, Noah built an ark before there was even a cloud of rain. By faith, Abraham left home without knowing where he was going. By faith, Sarah had a baby when she was very old, because she believed God keeps His promises. By faith, Moses chose to suffer with God's people instead of living like a prince in Egypt. By faith, the walls of Jericho fell down. By faith, Rahab helped God's people." There were so many more: Gideon, Samson, David, Samuel...

"What is faith?" the writer asked. "Faith is being sure of what we hope for and certain of what we don't see yet."

And then the best part: "All these heroes are like a huge crowd cheering us on! So let's throw off everything that slows us down, and run our race with perseverance, fixing our eyes on Jesus!"

The letter ended with a promise we can hold on to every single day: "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever." He never changes. He's always better. And He'll always be there.

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Make a "Hall of Fame" walk. Post pictures of Noah (ark), Abraham (stars), Moses (staff), and David (sling) on the wall. Walk past each one and say, "He trusted God!" At the end, put up a mirror: "And YOU can trust God too!"
- **Explorers:** Hand out hero cards from Hebrews 11. Each child reads their hero's line and acts it out, and the class guesses who it is.
- **Trailblazers:** Make a "better than" chart: Jesus vs. angels (ch. 1), Moses (ch. 3), the priests (ch. 7), and animal sacrifices (ch. 9–10). Why would this matter so much to Jewish Christians?
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss Hebrews 11:13 and 11:39–40: many heroes died "not having received" what was promised. What does it mean to trust God when you don't see results? Ask each Ambassador to share a "faith moment" from their own life with a younger group.

Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Who is the best? (Jesus!) 2) What did Noah build? (An ark.) 3) Does Jesus ever change? (No, He's always the same!)
- *Explorers:* 1) Why were the people who got this letter thinking about giving up? 2) Name two heroes of faith and what they did. 3) What is faith?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why is Jesus a better priest than the priests in the temple? 2) What things "slow you down" in your race of faith (Hebrews 12:1)? 3) Which hero in Hebrews 11 would you want to talk to, and what would you ask?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Hebrews says Jesus' sacrifice was "once for all." Why does that matter for how we feel about our sins? 2) How does "a great cloud of witnesses" encourage you? 3) What's the difference between faith and wishful thinking?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "faith" / "heroes of faith" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=faith | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Hebrews" / "heroes of faith" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Hebrews | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors (Explorers with pauses) | "Overview: Hebrews" (also the theme video "Sacrifice and Atonement") | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Hebrews |

Teacher: Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: 1) What makes Jesus better than anyone else? 2) Which hero of faith do you remember from the video?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Faith Hall of Fame Relay* (see Games). ✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Hall of Fame Trophy Craft* (see Activities & Crafts). 🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Learn Hebrews 13:8 with motions (point back for "yesterday," down for "today," far forward for "forever"). Spell H-E-B-R-E-W-S. **Whole-Bible Review:** Law and History (see the review plan). 🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> "Jesus, You are better than anything! You are the same yesterday, today and forever. Help me trust You and never give up. Amen."

Week 2: Faith That Works, Hope That Holds (James, 1 & 2 Peter)

Scripture: James 1:19–22; 2:14–26; 3:3–12; 1 Peter 1:3; 3:15; 5:7–8; 2 Peter 1:16–18; 3:8–9, 18 **Lesson goal:** Kids will learn that real faith shows in our actions and our words, and that God cares for us and keeps His promises when life is hard.

Opening hook / object lesson: "The Tiny Rudder" *Supplies:* a toy boat in a tub of water (or a picture of a big ship), a small piece of cardboard as a "rudder," a match/lighter **(teacher-only; you can use a picture of a spark instead)**, and a toothpaste tube with a paper plate.

1. Squeeze some toothpaste onto the plate. "Can you put it back in the tube?" (Kids try. It's nearly impossible!)
2. Say: "Words are like toothpaste. Once they're out, you can't put them back! James says our tongue is small, like the little rudder that steers a huge ship, or a tiny spark that can set a whole

forest on fire."

Story script:

> Jesus had brothers who grew up with Him in Nazareth. One of them was named James. At first, James didn't believe his big brother was the Messiah. But after Jesus rose from the dead, He appeared to James. Everything changed! James became a leader of the church in Jerusalem, and he wrote a letter.
>
> James's letter is very practical. He wrote, "Don't just listen to God's Word. DO what it says! If you only listen, you're like someone who looks in a mirror, walks away, and forgets what he looks like."
>
> "Imagine someone who has no food and no warm clothes," James said. "If you say, 'Have a nice day! Stay warm and eat well!' but you don't give them anything, what good is that? Faith that doesn't do anything is dead." Real faith is alive, and living things grow! It shows in how we act.
>
> Then James talked about our words. "Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak, and slow to get angry. The tongue is small, but it's powerful. A tiny rudder steers a huge ship. A tiny spark can burn a whole forest. With the same mouth we praise God and then say mean things to people. That shouldn't happen!"
>
> Another of Jesus' friends wrote letters too: Peter, the fisherman. Remember how Peter was once so scared that he said he didn't know Jesus? Now Peter was an old man and a brave leader. Christians all over were being treated badly. Some were laughed at. Some lost their jobs. Some were even hurt.
>
> Peter wrote to them, "Praise God! Because Jesus rose from the dead, we have a *living hope*, and nothing can ruin it! When you're worried, throw all your worries on God, because He cares for you. And always be ready to tell people why you have hope."
>
> In his second letter, Peter wrote near the end of his life. Some people were saying, "Jesus isn't really coming back!" Peter said, "I was there on the mountain when I saw Jesus shine with God's glory, and I heard God's voice! God keeps His promises. If it seems like a long time, remember: to the Lord, a day is like a thousand years. He is being patient, because He wants everyone to come to Him." And Peter's very last words in the Bible are these: "Grow in the grace and knowledge of our Lord and Savior Jesus Christ!"

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Play "Kind Words, Unkind Words." Teacher says a phrase; kids give a thumbs up for kind words or cover their mouth for unkind ones. Practice: "Thank you!" "I'm sorry!" "You can play with me!"
- **Explorers:** Act out James 2:15–16 as a skit. One person is cold and hungry. First the "faith without works" person just says "Have a nice day!" Then a second person brings a blanket and food. Ask: which one shows real faith?
- **Trailblazers:** Read James 2:14–26 next to Ephesians 2:8–10. Do they disagree? (No. Paul says we're saved by faith, not works. James says real faith produces works. Ephesians 2:10 says

we're saved *for* good works.)
- **Ambassadors:** Practice 1 Peter 3:15. Each Ambassador writes a 30-second answer to "Why do you believe in Jesus?" and shares it "with gentleness and respect."

Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Who can we give our worries to? (God!) 2) Are kind words good? (Yes!) 3) How can you help someone this week?
- *Explorers:* 1) What does "faith without deeds is dead" mean? 2) How is the tongue like a rudder or a spark? 3) Why did Peter say God seems "slow" to come back?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) How do James and Paul fit together on faith and works? 2) What are you worried about that you can "cast" on God this week? 3) What's one way to be "quick to listen and slow to speak" at home?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) How does the way Christians talk online show (or hide) their faith? 2) Why might suffering actually make faith stronger (1 Peter 1:6–7)? 3) How would you answer someone who says, "If God is real, why hasn't Jesus come back yet?"

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "kind words" / "James" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=kind+words | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Peter" / "James" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Peter | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | "Overview: James," "Overview: 1 Peter," "Overview: 2 Peter" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+James |

Teacher: Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: 1) What's one way you can "do" what God's Word says this week? 2) What does God want us to do with our worries?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Spark Pass* and *Tongue Twister Tag* (see Games). ✂️ **Activity of the week:** *Ship & Rudder Craft* (see Activities & Crafts). 🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Hebrews 13:8. Add "James, First and Second Peter." Spell J-A-M-E-S and P-E-T-E-R. **Whole-Bible Review:** Poetry and the Prophets (see the review plan). 🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> "Dear God, help my faith show in what I do. Help my words be kind. Thank You that I can give You my worries, because You care for me. Amen."

Week 3: God Is Love, Walk in Truth (1, 2, 3 John & Jude)

Scripture: 1 John 1:1–9; 3:1; 4:7–19; 5:13; 2 John 4–6; 3 John 1–11; Jude 3, 24–25 **Lesson goal:** Kids will learn that God loves us so much that He makes us His children, that we show His love by loving others and living in truth, and that God keeps us from falling.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Lavished!" *Supplies:* a small cup, a large pitcher of water, a tray or tub underneath, and paper hearts.

1. Hold the small cup over the tray and pour water from the pitcher. Keep pouring until the cup overflows all over the tray.

2. Say: "John says God's love is *lavished* on us. That means He pours and pours, way more than we could ever hold! It overflows. When God's love fills us up, it spills out onto other people."

Story script:

> Remember John? He was one of Jesus' twelve disciples, a fisherman with his brother James. Jesus called them the "Sons of Thunder," maybe because they had big tempers! John was there when Jesus walked on water, when Jesus died on the cross, and when Jesus rose again. John even outran Peter to the empty tomb!
>
> Now John was an old man, probably the last of the twelve still alive. He took care of churches, and he loved them like a grandpa. He called them "my dear children."
>
> John wrote, "We saw Jesus with our own eyes. We heard Him. We even touched Him! And we're telling you about Him so you can be part of God's family with us."
>
> "Look how much the Father loves us!" John wrote. "He calls us His children, and that's what we are! God is love. This is what love is: not that we loved God first, but that He loved us and sent His Son to take away our sins. So, dear friends, since God loved us so much, we should love one another. We love because He first loved us."
>
> John also wanted his friends to be sure. "If we confess our sins, God is faithful and fair, and He will forgive us. I write these things so you can KNOW you have eternal life."
>
> John wrote two tiny letters too. One went to a church family he called "the chosen lady and her children." He told them, "Keep walking in truth and love." The other went to a good friend named Gaius, who always welcomed traveling missionaries into his home. John said, "Nothing makes me happier than hearing that my children are walking in the truth! Keep doing what is good." But there was a bossy man named Diotrephes who wanted to be first and wouldn't welcome anyone. John said, "Don't copy what is evil. Copy what is good."
>
> Jesus' brother Jude also wrote a short letter. Some people were teaching lies about Jesus, and Jude said, "Stand strong for the true faith!" Then he ended with one of the most beautiful blessings in the Bible: "To Him who is able to keep you from stumbling and to bring you into His glorious presence without fault and with great joy, to the only God our Savior, be glory forever! Amen."

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Hug-and-say: "God loves ME! I'm God's child!" Pass a heart around the circle; each child says, "God loves you, [name]!"
- **Explorers:** Have kids count how many times the word "love" appears in 1 John 4:7–12 (NIV: love/loved/loves appears many times; let them discover it). Then write "We love because He first loved us" on a heart.
- **Trailblazers:** List the "tests" John gives to know you belong to God: believing in Jesus (5:1), obeying Him (2:3), and loving others (3:14). Talk about assurance: can we *know* we have eternal life (5:13)?

- **Ambassadors:** Discuss truth and love together (2 John 3–6). Why do Christians sometimes have truth without love, or love without truth? How did Jesus show both?

Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Who loves you more than anyone? (God!) 2) What does God call us? (His children.) 3) Who can you love this week?
- *Explorers:* 1) What does "lavished" mean? 2) What happens when we confess our sins? 3) Why was John happy with Gaius but not with Diotrephes?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) John says "God is love." Does that mean "love is God"? Why does the order matter? 2) How can you "walk in the truth" at school? 3) What does it mean that God can keep you from stumbling?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) What does it mean to "contend for the faith" without being mean? 2) Why does it matter that John *touched* Jesus (1 John 1:1)? 3) How can you be sure you have eternal life without being proud about it?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "God is love" / "love one another" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=God+is+love | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "John" / "apostle John" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=apostle+John | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | "Overview: 1–3 John," "Overview: Jude" | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+John |

Teacher: Preview every video before class. Follow-up questions: 1) How does God show that He loves us? 2) How can we show God's love to others?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Love Chain Tag* (see Games). ✂️ **Activity of the week:** *"Children of God" Family Portrait* (see Activities & Crafts). 🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Hebrews 13:8. Add "First, Second, Third John, Jude." Spell J-O-H-N (silent H!) and J-U-D-E. **Whole-Bible Review:** Gospels, Acts and Paul's Letters (see the review plan). 🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> "Father God, thank You for pouring Your love on me and calling me Your child. Help me love others the way You love me. Thank You for keeping me from falling. Amen."

Week 4: Jesus Wins! (Revelation)

Scripture: Revelation 1:9–18; 4:1–11; 5:1–14; 21:1–5; 22:1–5, 13, 20 **Lesson goal:** Kids will learn that Jesus is alive and in charge, that He has defeated evil, and that one day He will make everything new and live with His people forever.

Opening hook / object lesson: "Peek at the Last Page" *Supplies:* a picture book with a happy ending, and a puzzle box (with the box cover showing the finished picture) plus a few loose pieces.

1. Show a few puzzle pieces: "Can you tell what the picture is?" (Hard!) Then show the box cover: "NOW you know how it turns out."

2. Say: "Sometimes life feels like a bunch of mixed-up puzzle pieces. But God gave us the last book of the Bible, Revelation, to show us the box cover: how the story ends. Spoiler alert: JESUS WINS!"

Story script:

> John was an old man now, and he was in trouble for telling people about Jesus. The Romans sent him away to a small, rocky island called Patmos. He was far from his friends and his churches. But on the Lord's Day, something amazing happened.
>
> John heard a loud voice behind him, like a trumpet. He turned around and saw Jesus! But Jesus looked different from how John remembered Him. His face was shining like the sun at its brightest. His eyes were like flames of fire. His voice sounded like rushing waters. John fell down at His feet like he was dead.
>
> But Jesus put His right hand on John and said, "Don't be afraid. I am the First and the Last. I am the Living One. I was dead, and look, I am alive forever and ever!"
>
> Jesus told John, "Write down what you see and send it to seven churches." Then John saw a door open in heaven. He saw God's throne, with a rainbow around it shining like an emerald. Angels and creatures were worshiping day and night: "Holy, holy, holy is the Lord God Almighty!"
>
> In God's hand was a scroll sealed with seven seals. An angel asked, "Who is worthy to open the scroll?" No one in heaven or on earth could open it, and John began to cry. But an elder said, "Don't cry! Look! The Lion of the tribe of Judah has won! He can open the scroll!"
>
> John looked for a lion, but he saw a Lamb that looked as if it had been slain. It was Jesus, who died for us and rose again! Then millions and millions of angels sang, "Worthy is the Lamb who was slain!" and every creature everywhere joined in.
>
> John saw many more visions. Some of them showed how terrible evil is, and how God will stop it once and for all. And at the very end, John saw the best thing of all: a new heaven and a new earth! A beautiful city came down from God, shining like a jewel. A loud voice said, "Now God's home is with His people! He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death, or crying, or pain!"
>
> Jesus, sitting on the throne, said, "Look! I am making everything new!" There was a river, clear as crystal, flowing from God's throne, and on each side grew the tree of life. God's people will see His face, and they will live with Him forever.
>
> Almost the very last words of the Bible are a promise and a prayer. Jesus says, "Yes, I am coming soon." And John answers, "Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!"

Age-group teaching tips

- **Little Lambs:** Focus on three pictures: Jesus shining bright, the rainbow throne, and the new home with no tears. Pretend to wipe tears from each other's cheeks: "No more crying!" Then

cheer: "JESUS WINS!"

- **Explorers:** Point out connections. The tree of life was in Genesis 2 and appears again in Revelation 22. The Bible's first and last pages match! Ask them: "What else from Genesis comes back?" (A garden, a river, God living with people, and no more curse, Revelation 22:3.)
- **Trailblazers:** Explore the symbols: the Lion and the Lamb (power through sacrifice), seven (completeness), and the throne (God is in charge). Read the letter to one church (for example, Laodicea, 3:14–22) and ask what Jesus would say to our church.
- **Ambassadors:** Discuss how Revelation encouraged persecuted Christians: the Roman Empire looked unstoppable, but the Lamb is on the throne. Read Revelation 7:9–10 (every nation, tribe, people and language) and talk about God's worldwide family. Mention respectfully that Christians hold different views on the end-times details, but all agree on the ending.

Discussion questions

- *Little Lambs:* 1) Who did John see? (Jesus!) 2) Will there be crying in God's new home? (No!) 3) Who wins? (JESUS!)
- *Explorers:* 1) Why was John on the island of Patmos? 2) Why did John cry, and who made him stop? 3) What will be in God's new heaven and new earth?
- *Trailblazers:* 1) Why is Jesus called both a Lion and a Lamb? 2) How does the end of the Bible connect to the beginning? 3) How does knowing the ending help you when life is hard?
- *Ambassadors:* 1) Revelation was written to suffering churches. What does it tell persecuted Christians today? 2) Why is "new creation" a bigger hope than just "going to heaven when you die"? 3) If Jesus said, "I am coming soon," how should that change the way you live this week?

📺 **Video for the week** | Channel | Who watches | Search term | Link | |---|---|---|---| | @SharefaithKids | Little Lambs & Explorers | "heaven" / "Revelation" | https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=heaven | | @BibleJourneyTV | Explorers & Trailblazers | "Revelation" / "John on Patmos" | https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Revelation | | @bibleproject | Trailblazers & Ambassadors | "Overview: Revelation 1–11," "Overview: Revelation 12–22" (also "Heaven and Earth" or "The Day of the Lord" theme videos) | https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Revelation |

Teacher: Preview every video before class. Revelation videos may show some intense images; choose clips carefully for younger groups. Follow-up questions: 1) What's your favorite thing about God's new creation? 2) How did John's vision show that Jesus is in charge?

🎮 **Game of the week:** *Seven Churches Mail Route* (see Games). ✂️ **Activity of the week:** *New Creation Window* (see Activities & Crafts). 🔤 **Memory / Spelling focus:** Hebrews 13:8 for everyone. Add "Revelation" and sing the full 66-book song! Spell R-E-V-E-L-A-T-I-O-N (no S!). **Whole-Bible Review:** General Letters, Revelation, and the full run of all 66 (see the review plan). 🙏 **Closing prayer:**

> "Jesus, You are the First and the Last, and You win! Thank You that one day there will be no more tears. Come, Lord Jesus! Amen."

Week 5: Bible Bowl & Graduation Sunday

See **End-of-Phase Review & Celebration** below for the full Bible Bowl format, the 40 questions and answers, and the Graduation Sunday program with certificate wording.

Book Memory Song & Motions

🎵 New verse for the last nine books (tune: *"Row, Row, Row Your Boat"*)

> 🎵 *Hebrews, James, and Peter, Peter, John and John and John and Jude! Revelation, Revelation, Jesus wins! Jesus wins! Sixty-six — we're through!*
>
> *(Verse 2, sung slower and softer, then building up): Faith and hope and love, Jesus wins the day! Genesis to Revelation, Sixty-six books — HOORAY!*

Tip: "Hebrews, James, and Peter, Peter" fits "Row, row, row your boat." Hold up 1, then 2 fingers on the two Peters, and 1, 2, 3 fingers on the three Johns. "Revelation, Revelation, Jesus wins! Jesus wins!" fits the fast "merrily, merrily..." line. Sing it as a round once kids know it!

🎵 The Grand Finale: Cumulative Book Chant (all 66 books)

Use a clap-clap-slap rhythm. (Classes may also sing each section to the tune they learned in that phase. See the Memory System.)

> **OLD TESTAMENT!** *(arms wide like an open book)*
>
> Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy — **"FIVE books of LAW!"** *(5 fingers)*
>
> Joshua, Judges, Ruth, First and Second Samuel, First and Second Kings, First and Second Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther — **"TWELVE books of HISTORY!"** *(10 + 2 fingers)*
>
> Job, Psalms, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, Song of Songs — **"FIVE books of POETRY!"** *(air harp)*
>
> Isaiah, Jeremiah, Lamentations, Ezekiel, Daniel — **"FIVE MAJOR PROPHETS!"** *(big muscles)*
>
> Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi — **"TWELVE MINOR PROPHETS!"** *(pinky muscle)*
>
> **"THIRTY-NINE in the OLD!"** *(stomp, stomp)*
>
> **NEW TESTAMENT!** *(arms wide again)*
>
> Matthew, Mark, Luke, John — **"FOUR GOSPELS!"** *(make a cross)*
>
> Acts — **"ONE book of HISTORY: THE CHURCH IS BORN!"** *(flame and go)*

> Romans, First and Second Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, First and Second Thessalonians, First and Second Timothy, Titus, Philemon — **"THIRTEEN LETTERS FROM PAUL!"** *(write with a quill)*
>
> Hebrews, James, First and Second Peter, First, Second, Third John, Jude — **"EIGHT GENERAL LETTERS!"** *(8 fingers)*
>
> Revelation — **"ONE book of PROPHECY: JESUS WINS!"** *(trumpet, then arms up)*
>
> **"TWENTY-SEVEN in the NEW!"** *(stomp, stomp)*
>
> **"SIXTY-SIX BOOKS: THE WHOLE BIBLE — GOD'S WORD IS TRUE!"** *(everyone jumps and cheers!)*

Hand motions for the last nine books

#	Book	Motion
58	Hebrews	A thumbs up that moves higher and higher: "Good, better, BEST!"
59	James	Zip your lips, then roll up your sleeves
60	1 Peter	1 finger, a fist ("rock"), then toss your worries up
61	2 Peter	2 fingers, then crouch and grow tall
62	1 John	1 finger, then hug yourself
63	2 John	2 fingers, then march in place
64	3 John	3 fingers, then a big welcome wave
65	Jude	Trip, then catch yourself
66	Revelation	Blow a trumpet, then arms up: "JESUS WINS!"

Section Shouts (the last two)

Teacher: "How many General Letters?" **Kids:** "EIGHT! Hebrews, James, Peter, Peter, John, John, John, Jude!" **Teacher:** "How many books of Prophecy at the end?" **Kids:** "ONE: REVELATION! JESUS WINS!" **Teacher:** "How many books in the whole Bible?" **Kids:** "SIXTY-SIX!"

Cumulative recall drill (5 minutes)

1. **Section Sprint:** Call any of the 10 library sections. Kids chant that section only.
2. **Bookends:** Teacher says a section, and kids name its *first* and *last* book (for example, Paul's Letters: Romans and Philemon).
3. **What's next? / What's before?:** The teacher names any of the 66 books, and kids shout the next one (older kids also give the one before).
4. **Silent Bible:** Teacher does only the motions, and kids name the books.
5. **66 in 66:** Can the class (or an individual Ambassador) chant all 66 books in 66 seconds or less? Track the class record on the board all month.

Tips for each age group

- **Little Lambs:** Know the 10 Section Shouts and do all the shouts with the big kids. Know the first book (Genesis) and the last book (Revelation). Say at least one book from each Testament.
- **Explorers:** Chant all 66 with the song, using section color cards as helps.
- **Trailblazers:** Say all 66 alone, and name the section each book is in.
- **Ambassadors:** Say all 66 fast, backward from Revelation to Genesis, and lead the chant on Graduation Sunday.

Spelling & Reading

Spelling lists by age group

Little Lambs (letter recognition & sound it out)

- First letters: **H** for Hebrews (and Hope!), **J** for James, John, Jude (and Jesus!), **P** for Peter, **R** for Revelation.
- Sound it out: J-U-D-E ("J... oo... d"), J-A-M-E-S.
- Bookend words: trace **GENESIS** (first) and **REVELATION** (last).

Explorers (book names)

- Hebrews, James, Peter, John, Jude, Revelation. Review: Genesis, Exodus, Psalms, Isaiah, Matthew, Acts, Romans.

Trailblazers (book names + 5 vocab words)

- All nine new books, written correctly as 1 Peter, 2 Peter, 1 John, 2 John, 3 John
- Vocab: **faith** (trusting God about what we can't see yet), **hope** (being sure God will keep His promises), **priest** (someone who brings people to God; Jesus is our High Priest), **revelation** (something shown or uncovered), **eternal** (lasting forever)

Ambassadors (book names + harder vocab with definitions)

- All 66 books. Watch for the tricky ones: Deuteronomy, Ecclesiastes, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Philippians, Colossians, Thessalonians, Revelation.
- **perseverance**: keeping on and not giving up when it's hard (Hebrews 12:1)
- **atonement**: the work of Jesus that makes us "at one" with God by paying for sin
- **apocalyptic**: a type of writing that uses symbols and visions to reveal God's plan (from *apokalypsis*, "unveiling")
- **covenant**: a binding promise-relationship God makes with His people (the "new covenant," Hebrews 8)
- **Alpha and Omega**: the first and last letters of the Greek alphabet, meaning "the Beginning and the End" (Revelation 22:13)

The syllable-clap method

Word	Claps
He-brews	2
James	1
Pe-ter	2
John	1
Jude	1
Rev-e-la-tion	4
per-se-ver-ance	4
a-poc-a-lyp-tic	5

"Spell It Out" relay (Graduation Edition)

Supplies: Letter cards for **REVELATION**, **HEBREWS**, **GENESIS**, and **BIBLE**; two baskets; a tape line.

1. Teams race to build the word, one letter per runner.
2. When they finish, the whole team spells it aloud and gives the book's "In one word."
3. **Final round:** Both teams build **G-E-N-E-S-I-S** and **R-E-V-E-L-A-T-I-O-N** at the same time, then lay them at opposite ends of the room as "bookends." Everyone lines up between them and chants all 66!
4. Little Lambs find the first letter only. Ambassadors spell **PERSEVERANCE** or **APOCALYPTIC**.

Mini spelling bee word list

Word	Use it in a sentence
Jude	"Jude is a short letter with only 25 verses."
James	"James says faith shows in what we do."
John	"John wrote that God is love."
Peter	"Peter told us to cast our worries on God."
hope	"We have a living hope because Jesus rose."
faith	"By faith, Noah built an ark."
Hebrews	"Hebrews says Jesus is better than everything."
eternal	"God gives eternal life to all who trust Jesus."
forever	"Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever."
Revelation	"Revelation shows that Jesus wins."
Genesis	"Genesis is the first book and Revelation is the last."
perseverance	"Run with perseverance the race marked out for us."

Word	Use it in a sentence
Deuteronomy	"Deuteronomy is the fifth book of Law."
Ecclesiastes	"Ecclesiastes says to remember your Creator."
Thessalonians	"Thessalonians teaches that Jesus is coming back."

Read-aloud practice passage

> **Revelation 21:3–5 (NIV):** "And I heard a loud voice from the throne saying, 'Look! God's dwelling place is now among the people, and he will dwell with them. They will be his people, and God himself will be with them and be their God. He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the old order of things has passed away.' He who was seated on the throne said, 'I am making everything new!'"
>
> *Little Lambs:* echo "No more crying!" and "I am making everything new!"

Word Trivia

⭐ Easy (Little Lambs / Explorers)

1. What is the last book of the Bible?
2. How many books are in the whole Bible?
3. Fill in the blank: "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and _____."
4. True or False: In God's new creation, there will be no more crying.
5. Who wins at the end of the Bible?
6. What gentle, woolly animal starting with L is Jesus called in Revelation?
7. What other animal starting with L, one that roars, is Jesus called?
8. Fill in the blank: "God is _____." (1 John 4:8)
9. What did Noah build by faith?
10. True or False: Peter said we should keep our worries all to ourselves.

⭐⭐ Medium (Explorers / Trailblazers)

11. Which book has the "Faith Hall of Fame"?
12. Who wrote the book of James? (Hint: he grew up with Jesus!)
13. Which book? "Faith by itself, if it is not accompanied by action, is dead."
14. James says the tongue is like what two small things?
15. Fill in the blank: "Cast all your _____ on him because he cares for you." (1 Peter 5:7)
16. On what island was John when he wrote Revelation?
17. Which three books in a row have the same name?
18. Who said it? "I am the First and the Last. I am the Living One; I was dead, and now look, I am alive for ever and ever!"

19. Which book? "See what great love the Father has lavished on us, that we should be called children of God!"
20. How many churches got letters in Revelation 2–3?
21. Which book has only 25 verses and was written by a brother of James?
22. True or False: Hebrews tells us exactly who wrote it.
23. What tree is in both Genesis and Revelation?
24. What three-word prayer comes near the very end of the Bible?

⭐⭐⭐ Hard (Trailblazers / Ambassadors)

25. Fill in the blank: "Now faith is confidence in what we _____ _____ and assurance about what we do not see." (Hebrews 11:1)
26. Which mysterious king-priest does Hebrews compare Jesus to?
27. Which book? "Everyone should be quick to listen, slow to speak and slow to become angry."
28. Who said it? "Always be prepared to give an answer to everyone who asks you to give the reason for the hope that you have."
29. In 2 Peter, what event did Peter say he saw as an eyewitness?
30. Fill in the blank: "With the Lord a day is like a _____ _____." (2 Peter 3:8)
31. Which book has the fewest verses in the Bible?
32. In 3 John, who was the bossy man who "loves to be first"?
33. In 3 John, who was the friend that John praised for welcoming travelers?
34. Name four of the seven churches in Revelation 2–3.
35. What did the elder tell John when he was weeping in Revelation 5?
36. What does "Alpha and Omega" mean?
37. Which book? "To him who is able to keep you from stumbling..."
38. True or False: James and Paul disagree about faith and works.
39. Which book? "Here I am! I stand at the door and knock."
40. Name the 8 General Letters in order.

Answer key

1. Revelation. 2. 66. 3. forever. 4. True (Revelation 21:4). 5. Jesus! 6. Lamb. 7. Lion (of the tribe of Judah, Revelation 5:5). 8. love. 9. An ark (Hebrews 11:7). 10. False: cast them on God (1 Peter 5:7).
2. Hebrews (ch. 11). 12. James, the brother of Jesus. 13. James (2:17). 14. A rudder on a ship and a spark that starts a forest fire (James 3:4–6). 15. anxiety. 16. Patmos (Revelation 1:9). 17. 1, 2 and 3 John. 18. Jesus (Revelation 1:17–18). 19. 1 John (3:1). 20. Seven. 21. Jude. 22. False: the author is unknown. 23. The tree of life (Genesis 2:9; Revelation 22:2). 24. "Come, Lord Jesus" (Revelation 22:20).
3. hope for. 26. Melchizedek (Hebrews 5–7; Genesis 14:18). 27. James (1:19). 28. Peter (1 Peter 3:15). 29. The Transfiguration: Jesus shining with glory on the mountain, and God's voice saying "This is my Son" (2 Peter 1:16–18). 30. thousand years. 31. 2 John (13 verses). 32. Diotrephes (3 John 9). 33. Gaius (3 John 1, 5–8). 34. Any four: Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum, Thyatira, Sardis, Philadelphia, Laodicea. 35. "Do not weep! See, the Lion of the tribe of Judah... has triumphed" (Revelation 5:5). 36. The First and the Last, the Beginning and the End (the first and last letters of the Greek alphabet). 37. Jude (v. 24). 38. False: they agree. We are saved by faith, and real faith

shows in works (Ephesians 2:8–10; James 2:18). 39. Revelation (3:20). 40. Hebrews, James, 1 Peter, 2 Peter, 1 John, 2 John, 3 John, Jude.

Games

🎮 1. Faith Hall of Fame Relay

- **Best for:** All ages
- **Supplies:** Hero picture cards (Noah = ark, Abraham = stars, Sarah = baby, Moses = staff, Rahab = red cord, Gideon = trumpet & jar, David = sling); tape; a finish-line "trophy" (a cup covered in foil)
- **Setup:** Spread the hero cards face-down at the far end of the room.
- **How to play:** Runners race to flip one card, shout "By faith, [hero]...!" and finish the sentence (for example, "By faith, Noah built an ark!"), then run back and tag the next teammate. When all the cards are flipped, the team runs together to the trophy and says Hebrews 13:8.
- **How to win:** First team to finish all their heroes and say the verse wins.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* pair up with a buddy, and say just the hero's name and "trusted God!" *Older:* must also name the Old Testament book where that hero's story is found (Noah: Genesis, Moses: Exodus, Rahab: Joshua, Gideon: Judges, David: 1 Samuel).
- **Learning goal:** Hebrews 11 and connecting it to the Old Testament books.

🎮 2. Spark Pass

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers
- **Supplies:** A red or orange ball (the "spark"), music
- **How to play:** Kids sit in a circle and pass the "spark" while music plays. When the music stops, the person holding it must say something **kind** about the person to their right (taming the tongue!) **or** name the next book in the 66-book order (the class keeps the count). If they can't, the spark "spreads." They stand up, and the round continues until everyone has had a turn.
- **How to win:** The whole class wins if you get through all 66 books in one game.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* say "God loves you!" to the next person. *Older:* say a verse from James or 1 Peter.
- **Learning goal:** James 3: words are powerful. Book order.

🎮 3. Tongue Twister Tag

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors
- **Supplies:** Open space, a list of tongue twisters
- **How to play:** It's freeze tag. To get unfrozen, a teammate must come and say a Bible tongue twister to you three times fast: "Peter's pen penned powerful promises," "Jude judged jumpy jesters," "Hebrews has heroes of hope," "Seven churches' cheerful chairs." Funny mistakes are part of it. Remind kids: "If we can't even control our tongue in a tongue twister, we need God's help with our words!"
- **How to win:** Taggers try to freeze everyone in 2 minutes. Then switch.

- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* freeze dance with "kind words" to unfreeze. *Older:* to unfreeze, you must name the 8 General Letters.
- **Learning goal:** James 3 (taming the tongue) and remembering the new book names.

🎮 4. Love Chain Tag

- **Best for:** All ages (great for Little Lambs with walking instead of running)
- **Supplies:** Open space
- **How to play:** One "It" starts. When It tags someone, they link arms and say together, "We love because He first loved us!" The chain grows as it tags more players. Only the two ends of the chain can tag.
- **How to win:** Keep going until everyone is part of the chain, God's whole family!
- **Adaptations:** *Older:* each new link must name a book of the Bible in order, starting from Genesis.
- **Learning goal:** 1 John 4:19. Love spreads, and we're all one family.

🎮 5. Seven Churches Mail Route

- **Best for:** Explorers, Trailblazers, Ambassadors
- **Supplies:** Seven boxes or hoops labeled Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum, Thyatira, Sardis, Philadelphia and Laodicea, set in a loop around the room (the real route was roughly a circle); seven envelopes with a short message from Revelation 2–3 in each
- **How to play:** Teams of "messengers" from Patmos must deliver the envelopes **in the correct route order**. At each stop they read the one-line message aloud (for example, Ephesus: "Return to your first love," 2:4–5; Smyrna: "Be faithful, even to the point of death," 2:10; Laodicea: "I stand at the door and knock," 3:20).
- **How to win:** Fastest correct route.
- **Adaptations:** *Younger:* only 3 stops, with picture clues. *Older:* after delivering, say what Jesus might say to our church today.
- **Learning goal:** Revelation 2–3 and Jesus' care for real churches.

🎮 6. Bookend Dash (66-book review game)

- **Best for:** All ages, in mixed teams
- **Supplies:** Two complete sets of 66 book cards, color-coded by the 10 library sections; two long tables or floor space; a "GENESIS" sign and a "REVELATION" sign for each team
- **How to play:** Teams race to place all 66 books in order between their Genesis and Revelation signs. Little Lambs place the 10 section header cards. Explorers place the New Testament books. Trailblazers and Ambassadors place the Old Testament books. When done, the team chants all 66 while pointing to each card.
- **How to win:** First correct shelf wins. The teacher checks with the answer list.
- **Learning goal:** The whole Bible library, in order and by section.

🎮 7. The Bible Bowl

The year-end championship. Full format and 40 questions are in **End-of-Phase Review & Celebration** below.

Coloring Pages

🖍️ **Coloring page 1: The Faith Hall of Fame (Week 1)** *Scene:* A grand hallway with framed portraits: Noah with the ark, Abraham looking at the stars, Moses with his staff at the Red Sea, Rahab with a red cord in a window, and David with his sling. At the end of the hall is a big empty frame labeled "YOU!" for the child to draw themselves. *Caption:* "Fixing our eyes on Jesus." (Hebrews 12:2) *Coloring conversation:* Which hero is your favorite? How can you trust God like they did?

🖍️ **Coloring page 2: The Tiny Rudder (Week 2)** *Scene:* A big sailing ship on the ocean, with a close-up circle showing its small rudder. A smiling kid at the bottom has a speech bubble that says "Kind words!" *Caption:* "Quick to listen, slow to speak." (James 1:19) *Coloring conversation:* What kind words can you say this week? Who needs to hear them?

🖍️ **Coloring page 3: Children of God (Week 3)** *Scene:* A huge heart with many kids of every kind inside it, holding hands. A big hand from heaven is pouring love (drawn as water or light) over them. *Caption:* "See what great love the Father has lavished on us!" (1 John 3:1) *Coloring conversation:* How does it feel to be God's child? Who can you show His love to?

🖍️ **Coloring page 4: The Lion and the Lamb (Week 4)** *Scene:* A shining throne with a rainbow around it. In front of it stand a lion and a lamb side by side, and angels sing above them. *Caption:* "Worthy is the Lamb!" (Revelation 5:12) *Coloring conversation:* Why is Jesus called both a Lion and a Lamb? What will you sing to Jesus?

🖍️ **Coloring page 5: Everything New! (Week 4)** *Scene:* A beautiful garden-city with a crystal river flowing from a throne, the tree of life on both banks covered in fruit, and happy people of every nation with no tears. Sunlight is everywhere. *Caption:* "I am making everything new!" (Revelation 21:5) *Coloring conversation:* What do you think the new creation will be like? What are you most excited about?

🖍️ **Coloring page 6: Book Name Page: The Whole Library** *Design:* A big bookshelf with 66 book spines in 10 labeled sections (Law, History, Poetry/Wisdom, Major Prophets, Minor Prophets, Gospels, Acts, Paul's Letters, General Letters, Revelation). Each spine has a book name for kids to color by section. A banner across the top says "I KNOW ALL 66!" *Caption:* "All Scripture is God-breathed." (2 Timothy 3:16)

> **Printable book-name coloring sheet and word search: see `../printables/phase-12-printables.html`**

Activities & Crafts

✂️ 1. Hall of Fame Trophy Craft (Week 1)

- **Supplies:** Paper cups, aluminum foil, pipe cleaners (handles), gold stickers, paper labels, markers
- **Steps:** 1) Turn a cup upside down and stack a second cup on top. Cover them with foil to make a trophy. 2) Add pipe-cleaner handles. 3) Write the label "By faith..." and the name of a Hebrews 11 hero, or "By faith, [your name] will..."
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* pre-wrapped trophies, with a sticker label "I trust God!" *Explorers:* write a hero's name. *Older:* write one area of life where you need faith right now.
- **What it teaches:** Hebrews 11 and living by faith.

✂️ 2. Ship & Rudder Craft (Week 2)

- **Supplies:** Foam or paper plates (hulls), craft sticks (masts), paper sails, small cardboard rudders, brads (paper fasteners), markers
- **Steps:** 1) Build a little ship. 2) Attach a rudder with a brad so it can turn. 3) Write "My words steer my life" on the sail and "James 3:4" on the rudder.
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* glue paper boats onto a blue page and add the sticker "Kind words!" *Older:* write 3 kind words they'll use this week on the sail.
- **What it teaches:** James 3: our words are small but powerful.

✂️ 3. "Children of God" Family Portrait (Week 3)

- **Supplies:** Paper frames, crayons, mirror stickers or photos, heart stickers
- **Steps:** Kids draw themselves inside a frame along with their church "family." Write across the top: "We are God's children!" (1 John 3:1).
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* draw self + heart. *Older:* add 1 John 4:19 and draw someone they'll show love to this week.
- **What it teaches:** God's love makes us His family.

✂️ 4. New Creation Window (Week 4)

- **Supplies:** Black construction paper frames, colored tissue paper or cellophane, clear contact paper, scissors
- **Steps:** 1) Cut a window shape from black paper. 2) Fill it with tissue-paper pieces on contact paper, including a river (blue), the tree of life (green), and a throne with a rainbow. 3) Hang it in a sunny window so the light shines through, the way God's glory lights the city (Revelation 21:23).
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* free-form colors. *Older:* plan the design with the details from Revelation 21–22.
- **What it teaches:** God will make everything new.

✂️ 5. My Whole-Bible Bookshelf (all month)

- **Supplies:** A printed bookshelf with 66 empty spines (or 10 section shelves), colored markers in 10 colors, a section color key
- **Steps:** Each week, color in the books reviewed that week (see the Whole-Bible Review Plan) and write a tiny symbol on each spine. By Graduation Sunday the shelf is full!
- **Ages:** *Little Lambs:* color the 10 sections with stickers. *Older:* write each book's "in one word" on its spine.
- **What it teaches:** The whole Bible library, in order.

✂️ 6. Bible Passport Finale Page

- **Supplies:** The class's Bible Passports, gold star stickers, a photo of each child (optional)
- **Steps:** Kids add a final page: "My favorite Bible story this year was ___ because ___." Then they add their photo and the final gold "Forever Crown" stamp.
- **What it teaches:** Reflection and celebration of the whole year.

✂️ 7. Graduation Crown (for Graduation Sunday)

- **Supplies:** Gold cardstock crowns (template), jewels/stickers, markers
- **Steps:** Decorate a crown and write "66 of 66!" on the front. Wear it during the Graduation processional.
- **What it teaches:** "The crown of righteousness" (2 Timothy 4:8) and celebrating finishing the race.

Word Puzzles

Word scramble

1. WSERBEH
2. MSEAJ
3. TPERE
4. NHJO
5. EDJU
6. NOELTAVIRE
7. IATFH
8. EPHO
9. VLEO
10. BALM
11. NILO
12. SOPATM
13. TRONEH
14. RREFEOV
15. YTXSI-XSI

Answer key: 1. HEBREWS 2. JAMES 3. PETER 4. JOHN 5. JUDE 6. REVELATION 7. FAITH 8. HOPE 9. LOVE 10. LAMB 11. LION 12. PATMOS 13. THRONE 14. FOREVER 15. SIXTY-SIX

Fill-in-the-blank story

Word bank: better, faith, Noah, James, words, worries, love, children, Patmos, Lamb, tears, new, sixty-six

> Hebrews says Jesus is _____ than everyone, and it tells about heroes of _____, like _____ who built an ark. Jesus' brother _____ said real faith shows in what we do, and that our _____ are powerful. Peter said to give all our _____ to God. John wrote that God is _____ and that we are His _____. John saw visions on the island of _____. He saw Jesus as a _____ on the throne. In God's new home there will be no more _____, and Jesus will make everything _____. Now we know all _____ books of the Bible!

Answers: better, faith, Noah, James, words, worries, love, children, Patmos, Lamb, tears, new, sixty-six

Match the book to its picture / summary

Book	Picture / Summary
1. Hebrews	A. 🎺 Jesus wins and makes everything new
2. James	B. 🤗 God is love; we are His children
3. 1 Peter	C. 🚶 Walk in truth and love (only 13 verses!)
4. 2 Peter	D. 🏆 Jesus is better; the Faith Hall of Fame
5. 1 John	E. 🛡️ God keeps you from stumbling
6. 2 John	F. 🛠️ Faith that works; tame your tongue
7. 3 John	G. 🌱 Grow in grace; God is patient
8. Jude	H. 👋 Welcome travelers; copy what is good
9. Revelation	I. 🪨 Living hope; cast your worries on God

Answers: 1-D, 2-F, 3-I, 4-G, 5-B, 6-C, 7-H, 8-E, 9-A

Bonus: Bookends Match. Match each "first" to its "last." | First book of the section | Last book of the section | |---|---| | Genesis (Law) | a. Esther | | Joshua (History) | b. Philemon | | Job (Poetry) | c. Deuteronomy | | Isaiah (Major Prophets) | d. Malachi | | Hosea (Minor Prophets) | e. Song of Songs | | Matthew (Gospels) | f. Daniel | | Romans (Paul's Letters) | g. John | | Hebrews (General Letters) | h. Jude |

Answers: Genesis-c, Joshua-a, Job-e, Isaiah-f, Hosea-d, Matthew-g, Romans-b, Hebrews-h

Questions for Every Age

Little Lambs (ages 4–6)

1. What was your favorite Bible story this year?
2. Who is the Bible all about? (Jesus!)
3. How does God show He loves you?
4. What will God's new home be like?
5. Who can you tell a Bible story to this week?

Explorers (ages 7–10)

1. Which hero of faith are you most like?
2. How can your faith show in what you do this week?
3. When do you need to be "slow to speak"?
4. What's one thing you learned about the Bible this year that surprised you?
5. Now that you know the 66 books, which one do you want to read next?

Trailblazers (ages 11–13)

1. What does it mean that Jesus is "the same yesterday, today and forever" when everything else changes?
2. How do your words show what's in your heart (James 3)?
3. When life is hard, what helps you keep hope?
4. How does knowing the end of the story (Revelation) change how you live now?
5. How does the Bible fit together as one story? Can you tell it in one minute?

Ambassadors (ages 14–17)

1. What is one thing you're tempted to "go back to" instead of following Jesus (Hebrews' warning)?
2. Is your faith visible in your actions, or only in your words?
3. How would you explain the hope of the new creation to a friend who is grieving?
4. What is your plan to keep reading the Bible after this year?
5. Who will you invest in, the way Paul invested in Timothy, as you help lead younger kids?

🧠 Big Questions for Ambassadors (apologetics & worldview)

1. **"How can 66 books by around 40 authors over about 1,500 years tell one story?"** *Suggested answer:* The Bible's authors include kings, shepherds, fishermen, a doctor, a tax collector and prophets. They wrote in three languages (Hebrew, Aramaic and Greek) on three continents. Yet the story holds together: creation, the fall, God's promise, Israel, the coming King, Jesus' death and resurrection, the church, and the new creation. Genesis 3:15 promises a Rescuer who will crush the serpent. Revelation 12 and 20 show the ancient serpent defeated. The tree of life is lost in Genesis 3 and restored in Revelation 22. Jesus Himself said the Scriptures are about Him (Luke 24:27; John 5:39). Christians believe this unity comes from one divine Author working through many human authors (2 Peter 1:20–21).

2. **"Doesn't James contradict Paul about faith and works?"** *Suggested answer:* They're answering different problems. Paul (Romans 3–4; Ephesians 2:8–9) is answering people who thought they could earn salvation by keeping rules, and he says no, it's by faith alone. James (2:14–26) is answering people who claimed to have faith but lived as though they didn't, and he says that kind of "faith" is dead. Both use Abraham as an example: his faith was credited as righteousness (Genesis 15:6), and his faith was shown in his obedience (Genesis 22). Paul himself says we are saved "for good works" (Ephesians 2:10). The Reformers summed it up this way: "We are saved by faith alone, but the faith that saves is never alone."
3. **"Isn't heaven just wishful thinking, something people made up to feel better about death?"** *Suggested answer:* Christian hope isn't based on wishing. It's based on a historical event, the resurrection of Jesus (1 Peter 1:3; 1 Corinthians 15:14–20). If Jesus rose, then death has already been defeated once, and His promise to raise us is believable. The Bible's picture is also more solid than clouds and harps. It is a renewed, physical creation with justice, beauty, work, worship and relationships (Revelation 21–22). Also, wishful thinking would probably invent a heaven without judgment, but the Bible honestly includes God's justice. A hope that comes with a real event, real eyewitnesses and real moral seriousness isn't what wishful thinking looks like.

End-of-Phase Review & Celebration

This month's celebration has four parts:

1. **The Whole-Bible Review Plan.** It runs all month and reviews all 66 books.
2. **Phase 12 Review & Oral Check-off.** This is the final check-off, covering the whole Bible.
3. **The Bible Bowl.** The year-end competition, with 40 questions and answers.
4. **Graduation Sunday.** The program, the awards and the certificate wording.

Part 1: The Whole-Bible Review Plan (All 66 Books)

Goal

By the end of the month every child can (at their own level) **say, spell, and place** the books of the Bible, and tell **God's Big Story** from Genesis to Revelation.

God's Big Story in 9 Scenes (teach with motions)

#	Scene	Books	Kid sentence	Motion
1	**Creation**	Genesis 1–2	God made everything, and it was very good.	Make a big circle (the world)
2	**Fall**	Genesis 3	People disobeyed God, and sin broke everything.	Drop your hands, then make a sad face
3	**Promise**	Genesis 12–50	God chose Abraham's family to bless the whole world.	Point up to the stars

#	Scene	Books	Kid sentence	Motion
4	**Rescue**	Exodus–Deuteronomy	God freed His people from Egypt and gave them His good rules.	Part the "sea" with both arms
5	**Kingdom**	Joshua–2 Chronicles	God gave them a land and kings, and promised a forever King from David's family.	Put on a crown
6	**Exile & Return**	Kings, Ezra–Esther, the Prophets	God's people turned away and were sent far from home. God brought them back, and the prophets promised a Messiah.	Walk away, then walk back
7	**Jesus**	Matthew–John	The King came! Jesus lived, died for our sins, and rose again.	Make a cross, then arms up
8	**Church**	Acts–Jude	The Holy Spirit came, and the good news spread everywhere.	Flame fingers, then throw your hands out
9	**New Creation**	Revelation	Jesus will come back and make everything new forever.	Big circle again, then jump!

Practice: Kids say all nine scenes with motions in under a minute. Ambassadors tell the whole Big Story to younger kids in their own words.

Four-week review schedule (uses the 10-minute Welcome & Book Chant slot)

Week	Sections reviewed	Books	Running review	10-minute plan
1	Law + History	Genesis → Esther (17)	17 of 66	2 min full chant · 3 min "Section Spotlight" (read the kid summaries below for these 17) · 3 min Bookend Dash (OT history shelf only) · 2 min Big Story scenes 1–6
2	Poetry + Major Prophets + Minor Prophets	Job → Malachi (22)	39 of 66	2 min full chant · 3 min Spotlight · 3 min "What's Next?" drill · 2 min "400 silent years" reminder (between Malachi and Matthew)
3	Gospels + Acts + Paul's Letters	Matthew → Philemon (18)	57 of 66	2 min full chant · 3 min Spotlight · 3 min Mail Carrier Dash (from Phase 11) · 2 min Big Story scenes 7–8
4	General Letters + Revelation, then all 66	Hebrews → Revelation (9) + all	66 of 66	2 min full chant · 3 min Spotlight · 3 min "66 in 66" challenge · 2 min Big Story, all 9 scenes
5	Everything	All 66	🎉	Bible Bowl + Graduation

The Whole-Bible Review Table (all 66 books)

Use this table for Section Spotlights, flashcards, and the Bookend Dash. Each book has a kid summary and a picture symbol. The symbol is a flashcard cue, not a hand motion.

Hand motions for the review: use the same motions kids learned all year, so the whole program stays consistent.

- **Law, History & Poetry (Phases 1–6):** Genesis: sunrise hands (palms together like a book, open, sweep arms up) · Exodus: walk two fingers across your palm and out the "door" · Leviticus: fold hands in prayer, then raise them high · Numbers: count 1-2-3-4 on your fingers, then zig-zag your hand · Deuteronomy: two fingers up, tap your head, hand on heart · Joshua: march with a fist-trumpet · Judges: pound a gavel on your palm, then draw a circle · Ruth: scoop grain, then hug yourself · 1 & 2 Samuel: 1 or 2 fingers, then cup your ear · 1 & 2 Kings: 1 or 2 fingers, then a crown on your head · 1 & 2 Chronicles: 1 or 2 fingers, then unroll a scroll · Ezra: stack your fists like bricks · Nehemiah: hammer + shield · Esther: crown, then "speak up" hands · Job: open your hands up, then fold them over your heart · Psalms: strum a harp · Proverbs: tap your head · Ecclesiastes: puff into your hand, then point up · Song of Songs: heart hands.
- **Isaiah through John (Phases 7–9):** use the motions from Phase 7, Phase 8 and Phase 9.
- **Acts through Revelation (Phases 10–12):** see Phase 10, Phase 11 and the motion table in this file's Book Memory Song section.

📜 **LAW (5)** | # | Book | Kid summary | Symbol | |---|---|---|---| | 1 | Genesis | God makes everything good, people sin, and God promises a Rescuer through Abraham's family. | 🌍 | | 2 | Exodus | God frees His people from slavery in Egypt and gives them the Ten Commandments. | 🌊 | | 3 | Leviticus | God shows His people how to be holy and come near Him through sacrifices. | 🐑 | | 4 | Numbers | Israel grumbles and wanders 40 years in the wilderness, but God stays faithful. | 🔢 | | 5 | Deuteronomy | Moses reminds the new generation: "Love the Lord your God with all your heart." | 📜 |

🏰 **HISTORY (12)** | # | Book | Kid summary | Symbol | |---|---|---|---| | 6 | Joshua | God helps Joshua lead Israel into the Promised Land, and Jericho's walls fall. | 🎺 | | 7 | Judges | Israel keeps forgetting God, and He sends judges like Deborah, Gideon and Samson to rescue them. | 🔄 | | 8 | Ruth | Loyal Ruth trusts God, marries Boaz, and becomes the great-grandmother of King David. | 🌾 | | 9 | 1 Samuel | Samuel anoints Israel's first kings, Saul and then David, who defeats Goliath. | 🪨 | | 10 | 2 Samuel | David rules as king, and God promises a forever King from his family. | 👑 | | 11 | 1 Kings | Solomon builds the temple, the kingdom splits in two, and Elijah stands up for God. | 🔥 | | 12 | 2 Kings | Elisha does miracles, but many kings turn from God, and the people are taken into exile. | ⛓️ | | 13 | 1 Chronicles | David's story is told again, with family trees, focused on worship and God's promise. | 🌳 | | 14 | 2 Chronicles | Judah's kings from Solomon to the exile, and God's invitation to return to Him. | 🏛️ | | 15 | Ezra | God's people come home, rebuild the temple, and Ezra teaches God's law. | 🔨 | | 16 | Nehemiah | Nehemiah leads the people to rebuild Jerusalem's walls in 52 days. | 🧱 | | 17 | Esther | Brave Queen Esther saves her people, and God works behind the scenes. | 👸 |

🎵 **POETRY / WISDOM (5)** | # | Book | Kid summary | Symbol | |---|---|---|---| | 18 | Job | Job loses almost everything but learns to trust God even when he doesn't understand. | 🙏 | | 19 | Psalms | 150 songs and prayers for every feeling: happy, sad, scared and thankful. | 🎵 | | 20 | Proverbs | Wise sayings that teach us how to live God's way. | 💡 | | 21 | Ecclesiastes | Life without God is empty, like chasing the wind, so remember your Creator. | 💨 | | 22 | Song of Songs | A love poem celebrating the love between a husband and wife, a gift from God. | 💕 |

📣 **MAJOR PROPHETS (5)** | # | Book | Kid summary | Symbol | |---|---|---|---| | 23 | Isaiah | God is holy, and He promises a Servant-King who will suffer for our sins. | 🕊️ | | 24 | Jeremiah | The "weeping

prophet" warns Judah and promises a new covenant written on hearts. | 🏺 | | 25 | Lamentations | Sad poems about fallen Jerusalem, and yet God's mercies are new every morning. | 🌅 | | 26 | Ezekiel | Visions of God's glory, dry bones coming to life, and God giving new hearts. | 🦴 | | 27 | Daniel | Daniel and his friends stay faithful in Babylon, and God rescues them from fire and lions. | 🦁 |

📯 **MINOR PROPHETS (12)** | # | Book | Kid summary | Symbol | |---|---|---|---| | 28 | Hosea | God's love stays faithful even when His people are unfaithful. | 💍 | | 29 | Joel | A locust plague warns of the Day of the Lord, and God promises to pour out His Spirit. | 🦗 | | 30 | Amos | A shepherd prophet says: "Let justice roll on like a river!" | ⚖️ | | 31 | Obadiah | The shortest Old Testament book: God judges proud Edom. | ⛰️ | | 32 | Jonah | Jonah runs from God, is swallowed by a big fish, and learns that God loves even his enemies. | 🐋 | | 33 | Micah | Act justly, love mercy, and walk humbly with God. A ruler will come from Bethlehem. | ⭐ | | 34 | Nahum | God judges cruel Nineveh, and He is a refuge for those who trust Him. | 🏰 | | 35 | Habakkuk | A prophet asks God hard questions and learns to trust and rejoice anyway. | ❓ | | 36 | Zephaniah | The Day of the Lord is coming, but God rejoices over His people with singing. | 🎶 | | 37 | Haggai | Put God first, and rebuild His temple! | 🏗️ | | 38 | Zechariah | Visions of hope and a King coming, riding on a donkey. | 🫏 | | 39 | Malachi | Return to God. A messenger will come to prepare the way. (Then come 400 "silent years.") | ☀️ |

✝️ **GOSPELS (4)** | # | Book | Kid summary | Symbol | |---|---|---|---| | 40 | Matthew | Jesus is the promised King, the Son of David, who fulfills the Old Testament. | 💰 | | 41 | Mark | The fast-moving story of Jesus, the Servant who came to give His life. | 🏃 | | 42 | Luke | A doctor carefully tells about Jesus, the Savior who seeks and saves the lost. | 🩺 | | 43 | John | Jesus is God's Son. Believe in Him and have life! | ❤️ |

🔥 **HISTORY: ACTS (1)** | # | Book | Kid summary | Symbol | |---|---|---|---| | 44 | Acts | The Holy Spirit comes, and the church spreads the good news from Jerusalem to Rome. | 🔥 |

✉️ **PAUL'S LETTERS (13)** | # | Book | Kid summary | Symbol | |---|---|---|---| | 45 | Romans | Everyone has sinned, but God's gift is eternal life through Jesus. | 🛣️ | | 46 | 1 Corinthians | We are one body, and love is the greatest. | ❤️ | | 47 | 2 Corinthians | God's power is made perfect in our weakness. | 💪 | | 48 | Galatians | Freedom in Christ and the fruit of the Spirit. | 🍎 | | 49 | Ephesians | Saved by grace, so put on the armor of God. | ⛑️ | | 50 | Philippians | Rejoice in the Lord always, even in chains! | 😀 | | 51 | Colossians | Jesus is over everything and holds it all together. | 👑 | | 52 | 1 Thessalonians | Jesus is coming back, so keep hoping! | ☁️ | | 53 | 2 Thessalonians | Keep working and doing good while you wait. | 🔨 | | 54 | 1 Timothy | Be an example, even if you're young. | 👍 | | 55 | 2 Timothy | All Scripture is God-breathed, so finish the race. | 📖 | | 56 | Titus | God was kind to us, so be ready to do good. | 🧱 | | 57 | Philemon | Forgive, and welcome each other back like family. | 🤝 |

📬 **GENERAL LETTERS (8)** | # | Book | Kid summary | Symbol | |---|---|---|---| | 58 | Hebrews | Jesus is better than everything, so keep the faith. | 🏆 | | 59 | James | Real faith shows in what you do and say. | 🛠️ | | 60 | 1 Peter | Living hope when life is hard: cast your worries on God. | 🪨 | | 61 | 2 Peter | Grow in grace. God is patient and keeps His promises. | 🌱 | | 62 | 1 John | God is love, and we can know we have eternal life. | 🤗 | | 63 | 2 John | Walk in truth and love. | 🚶 | | 64 | 3 John | Welcome and help those who serve God, and copy what is good. | 👋 | | 65 | Jude | Stand strong for the faith. God can keep you from falling. | 🛡️ |

🎺 **PROPHECY: REVELATION (1)** | # | Book | Kid summary | Symbol | |---|---|---|---| | 66 | Revelation | Jesus wins and makes everything new! | 🎺 |

Optional extended review Sunday: "Bible Journey Stations"

If you have an extra Sunday (or a long Saturday event), set up **10 stations**, one for each library section, with Ambassadors as station leaders. Groups rotate every 6 minutes.

Station	Section	Activity
1	Law	"Creation Countdown": put the 7 days of creation cards in order, then chant the 5 books.
2	History	"Jericho Walls": stack 12 cups labeled with the History books in order, then knock them down with a "trumpet" shout.
3	Poetry	"Psalm Karaoke": sing Psalm 23 or a psalm song, then name the 5 Poetry books.
4	Major Prophets	"Lion's Den Freeze": everyone freezes like lions while a child names the 5 books.
5	Minor Prophets	"Big Fish Toss": toss a beanbag fish into buckets labeled with the 12 books in order.
6	Gospels	"Four Friends": do the four Gospel motions from Phase 9, then match each Gospel to a picture of its story.
7	Acts	"Wind Relay" (from Phase 10).
8	Paul's Letters	"Mail Carrier Dash" (from Phase 11).
9	General Letters	"Count on Your Fingers": say the 8 letters while counting on your fingers.
10	Revelation	"No More Tears": each child writes or draws one thing they're excited about in God's new creation and pins it on a "New Jerusalem" poster.

Give each child a **Journey Card** with 10 boxes and stamp it at each station.

Part 2: Phase 12 Review & Oral Check-off (Final Whole-Bible Check-off)

Review game plan (Week 4 or a dedicated review Sunday)

Time	Activity
10 min	Welcome, the full 66-book chant, and the Big Story in 9 scenes
15 min	🎮 Bookend Dash (all 66)
10 min	Favorite video replay, then a "Which book was it from?" quiz
20 min	Oral check-off stations (Ambassadors help with the younger groups)
15 min	Finish your Whole-Bible Bookshelf and Bible Passport finale page

Time	Activity
5 min	Prayer of thanks for the year

Oral check-off checklist

Little Lambs

- ☐ Says "Jesus Christ is the same… forever."
- ☐ Says the first book (Genesis) and the last book (Revelation)
- ☐ Says all 10 Section Shouts with the class (Law, History, Poetry, Major Prophets, Minor Prophets, Gospels, Acts, Paul's Letters, General Letters, Revelation)
- ☐ Names at least 3 books from each Testament
- ☐ Tells one favorite Bible story from the year

Explorers

- ☐ Says Hebrews 13:8
- ☐ Says and spells all 9 books from this phase
- ☐ Says all 66 books in order (section cards allowed as helps)
- ☐ Puts the 10 sections in order and tells how many books are in each

Trailblazers

- ☐ Says Hebrews 13:8 and 2 Timothy 3:16
- ☐ Says all 66 books in order without help
- ☐ Gives a one-sentence summary of any book the teacher picks (5 random picks)
- ☐ Tells the Big Story in 9 scenes

Ambassadors

- ☐ Says all 66 books in order, then backward from Revelation to Genesis
- ☐ Teaches one book of their choice to a younger child (summary, motion, and where Jesus shows up)
- ☐ Explains how the Bible is one story that points to Jesus (2–3 minutes)
- ☐ Answers one Big Question from this phase in their own words

🛂 Bible Passport stamp

Stamp: a **golden crown above an open book**, with the words "REVELATION — 66 of 66 — JESUS WINS!" On Graduation Sunday, add the final full-page stamp: **"WHOLE BIBLE EXPLORER: GENESIS TO REVELATION."**

🏅 Badge description: The Forever Crown

A gold badge shaped like a crown, with a sky-blue gem in the center. Inside the gem is a tiny tree of life. Around the edge: "FAITH · HOPE · FOREVER · HEBREWS 13:8 · 66 of 66."

🏅 Year-end medal: Whole Bible Champion

A gold medal on a ribbon striped in the colors of all 12 phases. The front reads "66 BOOKS · ONE STORY · JESUS." The back reads "Purpose Church Sunday School · Whole Bible Explorer · [Year]." Give it to every child who completes their age group's final check-off. (Give every child a participation ribbon too, so no one leaves empty-handed.)

Part 3: The Bible Bowl 🏆

A fun, high-energy, year-end competition. It is mixed-age by design: older kids help younger ones shine.

Format overview

- **Length:** About 45 minutes (fits Week 5 before Graduation, or a Saturday event)
- **Teams:** 4–6 teams of 4–6 players. **Every team should have at least one player from each age group** (Little Lamb, Explorer, Trailblazer, Ambassador) when possible. Teams pick names from the Bible library sections (Team Law, Team Prophets, Team Gospels, Team Letters…) and wear matching colors.
- **Rounds:** 4 rounds of 10 questions, plus tiebreakers
- **Volunteers needed:** Quizmaster (reads questions), Scorekeeper (large whiteboard), Timekeeper (10-second timer), Judges (1–2, to settle answers), Runner (carries answer slates)

Supplies

- A buzzer or bell for each team (or have teams raise a colored flag)
- Small whiteboards and markers (one per team) for written-answer rounds
- A scoreboard (whiteboard or poster)
- A timer, the question cards (below), prizes, the trophy (a decorated "golden Bible" or a cup)
- A "Lamb Card" for each team (see the rules)

Rules

1. **Rounds 1 & 3 (Slate Rounds):** Every team writes its answer on a whiteboard within 15 seconds. All teams with the correct answer score points.
2. **Rounds 2 & 4 (Buzzer Rounds):** The first team to buzz answers within 5 seconds. If they're wrong, the next team may steal for half points (round down).
3. 🐑 **Lamb Questions:** Questions marked 🐑 must be answered by the team's youngest player (teammates may not whisper!). A correct Lamb answer earns **double points.**
4. **Help Card:** Once per game, each team may use its "Ask a Friend" card to let the whole team huddle for 20 seconds on a buzzer question.
5. **Kindness rule:** Teams lose 1 point for unkind words or arguing with the judges, and gain 1 bonus point when a judge sees great teamwork or encouragement (James 1:19!).
6. **Judges' decision is final.** Accept reasonable spellings and equivalent wording.

Scoring

Round	Name	Points per correct answer
1	The Library (books & order)	1 (Lamb = 2)
2	Old Testament Adventures	2 (Lamb = 4)
3	New Testament Adventures	2 (Lamb = 4)
4	Which Book? Lightning Round	3 (Lamb = 6)

🎤 The 40 Bible Bowl Questions

Round 1: The Library (slate round, 1 point each)

1. 🐑 How many books are in the whole Bible?
2. 🐑 What is the first book of the Bible?
3. 🐑 What is the last book of the Bible?
4. How many books are in the Old Testament, and how many in the New Testament?
5. Name the four Gospels.
6. What book comes right after Malachi?
7. What book comes between John and Romans?
8. Name the five books of the Law, in order.
9. Which book has the most chapters?
10. In which section of the Bible library do you find the book of Jonah?

Round 2: Old Testament Adventures (buzzer round, 2 points each) 11. 🐑 What did God create on the very first day? 12. 🐑 Who built a giant boat called an ark? 13. 🐑 What did God put in the sky as a promise after the flood? 14. Who was sold by his brothers, then became a leader in Egypt? 15. Who led God's people out of Egypt and through the Red Sea? 16. Which city's walls fell down after Israel marched around it for seven days? 17. Who said, "Where you go I will go... Your people will be my people and your God my God"? 18. What did young David use to defeat the giant Goliath? 19. Which queen risked her life to save her people, saying, "If I perish, I perish"? 20. Which man was thrown into a den of lions because he kept praying to God?

Round 3: New Testament Adventures (slate round, 2 points each) 21. 🐑 In what town was Jesus born? 22. Who baptized Jesus in the Jordan River? 23. 🐑 How many apostles (special disciples) did Jesus choose? 24. When Jesus fed a huge crowd with 5 loaves and 2 fish, about how many men were there? 25. Finish the verse: "For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever..." 26. On what day after He died did Jesus rise from the dead? 27. Who came on the disciples on the day of Pentecost, with wind and tongues of fire? 28. Who met Jesus in a blinding light on the road to Damascus? 29. What were Paul and Silas doing at midnight in the Philippian jail? 30. 🐑 In God's new creation, what will God wipe from every eye?

Round 4: "Which Book?" Lightning Round (buzzer round, 3 points each) *Quizmaster reads a quote or description, and teams name the book.* 31. "In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth." 32. "The Lord is my shepherd, I lack nothing." 33. "Trust in the Lord with all your heart and lean not on your own understanding." 34. "For to us a child is born... And he will be called Wonderful Counselor,

Mighty God, Everlasting Father, Prince of Peace." 35. A prophet runs from God, is swallowed by a great fish, and then preaches to the city of Nineveh. 36. "But you, Bethlehem Ephrathah... out of you will come for me one who will be ruler over Israel." 37. "Love is patient, love is kind." 38. "Faith by itself, if it is not accompanied by action, is dead." 39. "Rejoice in the Lord always. I will say it again: Rejoice!" 40. "He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain."

✅ Bible Bowl Answer Key

#	Answer	Reference
1	66	—
2	Genesis	—
3	Revelation	—
4	39 Old Testament, 27 New Testament	—
5	Matthew, Mark, Luke, John	—
6	Matthew	—
7	Acts	—
8	Genesis, Exodus, Leviticus, Numbers, Deuteronomy	—
9	Psalms (150 chapters/psalms)	—
10	Minor Prophets	—
11	Light	Genesis 1:3–5
12	Noah	Genesis 6–9
13	A rainbow	Genesis 9:12–16
14	Joseph	Genesis 37–50
15	Moses	Exodus 14
16	Jericho	Joshua 6
17	Ruth (speaking to Naomi)	Ruth 1:16
18	A sling and a stone	1 Samuel 17:49–50
19	Esther	Esther 4:16
20	Daniel	Daniel 6
21	Bethlehem	Luke 2:4–7; Matthew 2:1
22	John the Baptist	Matthew 3:13–17
23	Twelve	Mark 3:14–19
24	About 5,000 men (besides women and children)	Matthew 14:21
25	"...believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life."	John 3:16
26	The third day (the first day of the week, Sunday)	Luke 24:1–7; 1 Corinthians 15:4
27	The Holy Spirit	Acts 2:1–4

#	Answer	Reference
28	Saul (later called Paul)	Acts 9:1–6
29	Praying and singing hymns to God	Acts 16:25
30	Every tear	Revelation 21:4
31	Genesis	Genesis 1:1
32	Psalms	Psalm 23:1
33	Proverbs	Proverbs 3:5
34	Isaiah	Isaiah 9:6
35	Jonah	Jonah 1–3
36	Micah	Micah 5:2
37	1 Corinthians	1 Corinthians 13:4
38	James	James 2:17
39	Philippians	Philippians 4:4
40	Revelation	Revelation 21:4

Tiebreakers (use in order until the tie is broken)

- **T1:** How many psalms are in the book of Psalms? *(150)*
- **T2:** Who lived longer than anyone else in the Bible, and how old was he? *(Methuselah, 969 years — Genesis 5:27)*
- **T3:** What is the shortest verse in most English Bibles? *("Jesus wept." — John 11:35)*
- **T4:** Who was the first king of Israel? *(Saul — 1 Samuel 10)*
- **T5 (Sudden-Death Chant):** One player from each tied team says the 66 books in order. The fastest without a mistake wins (a judge listens to each player).

Bible Bowl awards

- 🏆 **Bible Bowl Champions:** the trophy and a champions certificate for each member
- 🥈 **Runner-up:** ribbons
- 🐑 **Lamb of the Bowl:** the young player with the most correct Lamb answers
- 💛 **Team Spirit Award** (James 1:19): the team that showed the most kindness and encouragement
- 🎖️ **Every player:** a participation ribbon that reads "I played in the Bible Bowl!"

Part 4: Graduation Sunday 🎓

A joyful celebration of the whole year. Invite families, grandparents and the whole church! Choose **Option A** (a full kids' program during Sunday school time) and/or **Option B** (a short recognition in the main worship service).

Before the day (2–3 weeks out)

- [ ] Send the family invitation (it's on the Take-Home Family Page)
- [ ] Print certificates (wording below) and sign them (lead teacher + pastor)
- [ ] Order or make Whole Bible Champion medals, participation ribbons and the Bible Bowl trophy
- [ ] Prepare a slideshow of photos from all 12 phases
- [ ] Decorate: a "66 Books" bookshelf wall, the 12 phase badges on banners, gold and sky-blue balloons
- [ ] Ask the pastor to give a blessing and present the certificates
- [ ] Choose kid readers for the Big Story readings and rehearse them
- [ ] Arrange a reception (cake decorated as an open Bible, or 66 cupcakes, each topped with a book name). *Check for allergies.*
- [ ] Ambassadors rehearse leading the 66-book chant

Option A: Kids' Graduation Celebration (75 minutes)

Time	Program item	Who	Notes
0:00	**Processional**	All kids, wearing their Graduation Crowns	Kids enter by age group to a joyful worship song. Families stand and clap.
0:04	**Welcome & opening prayer**	Lead teacher	Script below
0:07	**Opening song: the 66-Book Grand Finale Chant**	All kids, led by Ambassadors	All 10 Section Shouts and motions. Families are invited to join the last shout!
0:12	**God's Big Story in 9 Scenes**	9 kid readers (mixed ages), with the whole class doing the motions	Each reader says one scene's sentence from the review table.
0:20	**Phase-by-phase slideshow**	AV volunteer	12 phases, 1–2 slides each, with the phase badge
0:28	**Little Lambs performance**	Little Lambs	"Jesus Christ is the same… forever!" plus a favorite song from the year
0:32	**Explorers performance**	Explorers	Spell 5 hard book names on the "big stage" (Deuteronomy, Ecclesiastes, Habakkuk, Philippians, Revelation)
0:36	**Trailblazers performance**	Trailblazers	Say all 66 books, then each says one book summary
0:42	**Ambassador testimonies**	2–3 Ambassadors	1–2 minutes each: "What God taught me this year"
0:50	**Bible Bowl Champions recognized**	Bible Bowl Quizmaster	Trophy presentation and the champions certificates
0:54	**Certificate & medal presentation**	Pastor + lead teacher	Call each child by name, give the certificate and medal, and stamp the final Bible Passport page

Time	Program item	Who	Notes
1:05	**Commissioning of Ambassadors** as Junior Leaders	Pastor	Script below. Ambassadors who will help lead next year stand at the front.
1:09	**Blessing over the children**	Pastor (families lay a hand on their child's shoulder)	Numbers 6:24–26
1:12	**Closing song & recessional**	All	Kids walk out to their families
1:15	**Reception**	Hospitality team	Cake, photos at the "66 Books" wall

Scripts

Welcome (lead teacher):

> "Welcome, families and friends! Twelve months ago, these children opened the first page of the Bible: 'In the beginning…' Since then they've walked with Abraham, crossed the Red Sea with Moses, marched around Jericho, sung psalms with David, listened to the prophets, met Jesus in the Gospels, watched the church be born, read Paul's letters, and just finished the very last page, where Jesus says, 'I am making everything new!' Today we celebrate that these kids know all 66 books of God's Word. More importantly, they know the One the whole Bible is about: Jesus. Let's pray."

Opening prayer:

> "Father, thank You for Your Word, all 66 books of it. Thank You for every child here, and for every teacher and family who helped them learn. Today we celebrate what You have done. Jesus, You are the same yesterday and today and forever. Be honored in this celebration. Amen."

Big Story readers (one line each, with the class doing the motions):

> 1. "In the beginning, God made everything, and it was very good." (Creation)
> 2. "But people disobeyed God, and sin broke everything." (Fall)
> 3. "God promised Abraham that his family would bless the whole world." (Promise)
> 4. "God rescued His people from Egypt and gave them His good rules." (Rescue)
> 5. "God gave them a land and kings, and promised a forever King from David's family." (Kingdom)
> 6. "God's people turned away and were sent far from home, but God brought them back and promised a Messiah." (Exile & Return)
> 7. "Then Jesus came! He lived, died for our sins, and rose again!" (Jesus)
> 8. "The Holy Spirit came, and the good news spread all over the world, all the way to us!" (Church)

> 9. "One day Jesus will come back and make everything new, forever!" (New Creation) **All:** "Sixty-six books, ONE story — JESUS!"

Commissioning of Ambassadors (pastor):

> "Ambassadors, Paul told Timothy, 'Don't let anyone look down on you because you are young, but set an example' (1 Timothy 4:12). You have learned God's Word this year, and you have helped younger kids learn it too. Will you keep reading God's Word, keep following Jesus, and keep helping the younger ones learn about Him?" **Ambassadors:** "We will, with God's help!" "Church family, will you pray for these young leaders and encourage them?" **Congregation:** "We will!" *(The pastor prays for them.)*

Blessing (pastor; families place a hand on their child's shoulder):

> "The Lord bless you and keep you; the Lord make his face shine on you and be gracious to you; the Lord turn his face toward you and give you peace." (Numbers 6:24–26)

Option B: Main-Service Recognition (10–15 minutes)

1. Kids process to the front during the last worship song (2 min).
2. The pastor introduces them: "These kids learned all 66 books this year!" (1 min).
3. The kids chant the 66 books with motions, led by Ambassadors (2 min).
4. One Ambassador gives a 1-minute testimony.
5. The Bible Bowl champions are recognized (1 min).
6. Certificates are presented. For large groups, call the names by age group and hand out certificates in the classroom afterward (3–5 min).
7. The pastor blesses the children (Numbers 6:24–26) and the congregation applauds (1 min).

Awards list (optional extra recognitions)

Award	Given to
🏅 **Whole Bible Champion** medal	Everyone who completed their age-group final check-off
📖 **All 66 Award**	Kids who can say all 66 books alone
🐝 **Super Speller**	The top speller in each age group (from the year's spelling bees)
🛂 **Full Passport**	Kids with all 12 phase stamps
⏰ **Faithful Attender**	Kids who missed 4 Sundays or fewer
🤝 **Servant Heart**	Ambassadors and helpers who served the younger groups
🏆 **Bible Bowl Champions**	The winning team
🎖️ **Participation ribbon**	**Every child** ("I'm part of God's big story!")

📜 Certificate wording

1. Phase 12 Certificate (Forever Crown)

> **Purpose Church Sunday School Bible Explorer Certificate — Phase 12: Faith, Hope & Forever**
>
> This certifies that _____ has learned the books of **Hebrews, James, 1 & 2 Peter, 1, 2 & 3 John, Jude, and Revelation**, and can say the books of the Bible from **Genesis to Revelation: 66 of 66!**
>
> "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever." (Hebrews 13:8)
>
> Awarded the **Forever Crown Badge** on _____ (date).
>
> Teacher: _____

2. Whole Bible Graduation Certificate (main certificate for Graduation Sunday)

> **PURPOSE CHURCH SUNDAY SCHOOL Certificate of Completion WHOLE BIBLE EXPLORER**
> *Genesis to Revelation*
>
> This is to certify that _____ has faithfully completed all twelve phases of the Purpose Church Sunday School Bible curriculum, learning the names, order and message of all **66 BOOKS OF THE BIBLE** from the Law to the Prophets, from the Gospels to the Letters, all the way to Revelation, and has discovered that the whole Bible tells one story pointing to **Jesus**.
>
> Age group: ☐ Little Lambs ☐ Explorers ☐ Trailblazers ☐ Ambassadors
>
> "All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness." (2 Timothy 3:16)
>
> Presented on _____ (date), in the year _____.
>
> _____ Lead Teacher _____ Pastor

3. Bible Bowl Champion Certificate

> **Purpose Church Sunday School 🏆 BIBLE BOWL CHAMPION 🏆**
>
> Congratulations to _____, a member of **Team** _____, champions of the year-end Bible Bowl!
>
> "Do your best to present yourself to God as one approved... who correctly handles the word of truth." (2 Timothy 2:15)

> Date: _____ Quizmaster: _____

4. Ambassador Junior Leader Commissioning Certificate

> **Purpose Church Sunday School Junior Leader Commission**
>
> _____ has served as an **Ambassador** this year, learning all 66 books of the Bible and helping younger children learn God's Word. Today they are commissioned as a **Junior Leader** for the coming year.
>
> "Don't let anyone look down on you because you are young, but set an example for the believers in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith and in purity." (1 Timothy 4:12)
>
> Commissioned on _____ (date).
>
> _____ Pastor _____ Children's Ministry Leader

5. Participation Certificate (for every child who attended any part of the year)

> **Purpose Church Sunday School I'm Part of God's Big Story!**
>
> _____ joined us on the journey through God's Word this year. We are so glad you were here! Keep reading, keep learning, and keep following Jesus.
>
> "Your word is a lamp for my feet, a light on my path." (Psalm 119:105)
>
> Date: _____ Teacher: _____

Take-Home Family Page

Dear Parents and Families,

We did it! This month your child learned the last nine books of the Bible: **Hebrews, James, 1 & 2 Peter, 1, 2 & 3 John, Jude, and Revelation.** Your child now knows **all 66 books of the Bible**, Genesis to Revelation! We learned that Jesus is better than everything (Hebrews), that real faith shows in what we do and say (James), that we have a living hope (1 & 2 Peter), that God is love (1–3 John), that God keeps us from falling (Jude), and that Jesus wins and makes everything new (Revelation).

🎓 **You're invited to Graduation Sunday!** Date: _____ Time: _____ Place: _____ Come celebrate with your child! There will be songs, the Bible Bowl champions, certificates and medals, a blessing for every child, and cake. Grandparents and friends are welcome!

This month's verse: "Jesus Christ is the same yesterday and today and forever." (Hebrews 13:8) **Little Lambs:** "Jesus Christ is the same... forever."

🎵 **This month's song** (tune: *"Row, Row, Row Your Boat"*):

> Hebrews, James, and Peter, Peter, John and John and John and Jude! Revelation, Revelation, Jesus wins! Jesus wins! Sixty-six — we're through!

Ask your child to teach you the full 66-book chant with the motions. See if your family can say all 66 in 66 seconds!

🍽️ **Dinner-table questions**

1. What was your favorite Bible story from this whole year, and why?
2. How can our family show "faith that works" (James 2) this week?
3. What are you most excited about in God's new creation (Revelation 21–22)?

🏠 **Family activity: "Keep the Story Going"** Now that your child knows the names of all 66 books, help them start *reading* them! Choose a family Bible reading plan for the new year. For example, read one chapter of Mark a night (16 nights), then John (21 nights), or use a children's story Bible together. Make a family "bookshelf" chart and color in each book as you read it. Celebrate every finished book!

📺 **Videos to watch at home** (search on YouTube. Parents, please preview them first.)

- **@SharefaithKids**: search "heaven" or "faith": https://www.youtube.com/@SharefaithKids/search?query=heaven
- **@BibleJourneyTV**: search "Revelation" or "Peter": https://www.youtube.com/@BibleJourneyTV/search?query=Revelation
- **@bibleproject**: "Overview: Hebrews," "Overview: James," and "Overview: Revelation 12–22" (best for ages 11+). A great follow-up for the whole family is BibleProject's "Overview" series, which has a video for every book of the Bible: https://www.youtube.com/@bibleproject/search?query=Overview+Revelation

Thank you for partnering with us this year. Your child has learned the whole Bible library. Now let's help them spend a lifetime reading it, loving it, and following the Jesus it's all about!